Let's do this one more time

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/80065306.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Swift Wind, Razz (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Slow Burn, POV Adora (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), POV of other people rarely, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), catra is healing, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, author is awkward as hell, How Do I Tag, Other Additional Tags to Be Added, minor mentions of suicidal thoughts, other background relationships, no beta reader we die like Shadow Weaver, Catra joins the rebellion, Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Mentioned trauma, Catra Joins Best Friend Squad (She-Ra), Yearning, It gets better before it gets worse again before it gets better again, Shadow Weaver Is Her Own Warning, everyone knows catradora is a thing, except catradora themselves, post-season 3, Angst, Comfort eventually

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by MessTrudi

Summary

After the portal, Adora and Catra wake up in the past. As the only people remembering the future, they decide to change it. Well, Adora decides that and chooses to kidnap her former best friend. Surely, their relationship can only get better from here.

Canon divergence that I'm sure has been done before, but I wrote it anyway.

Notes

Hello!
Just wanted to say a few things. For one, I am not natively english, so please excuse any mistakes that I have surely made <33

And then, just a warning, this will be long. It wasn't supposed to, but over the last few months, fueled by the fact that She-Ra would be taken off of Netflix, I have written about 170k words for this. I am in the process of editing and will update whenever I can.

And another very important disclaimer, because sadly this is the time we live in right now: I have never and will never use AI. All of this was written with sleep deprivation and a slight amount of insanity, combined with my love for em dashes. You will see them, but I promise you, no AI would have placed them as lovingly and obsessively as I have.

I do hope you enjoy reading <33

Chapter 1: A New Reality

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Queen Angella was gone.

Adora stood in the silence for a moment, staring into the void her world had become. How was she supposed to tell Glimmer what happened? How was she supposed to face her friends and allies? What was she supposed to do now?

She was supposed to fix things, but she hadn't done anything. Angella did. And Adora let her.

Forcing herself to breathe, she gripped her sword tighter. No matter how much she may have wanted to, she couldn't deal with all that right now. Reality was still collapsing and that was more important than whatever existential crisis she had going on.

Not that she knew what exactly she was supposed to do to stop the portal's effects — it seemed that was the theme for today. She had the sword, what now?

For a lack of better ideas, she decided it was time for She-Ra. She raised her sword into the air and called out the words like she had so many times, just that this time, there was truly no one around to hear her.

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

It seemed to do the trick. The void turned white and the vortex that Angella had vanished into disappeared.

When she opened her eyes, she was greeted with a familiar sight. Just not the one, she was expecting. She thought she would end up in Hordak's sanctum again, with everyone, but while she was in the Fright Zone alright, she was once again alone. Though, that

wasn't entirely true. All around her were the sleeping faces of her old squad.

Adora sat up, confused. What was going on? Was this still the portal? Had she failed that too?

She took a deep breath and tried to remember. When she had woken up in the portal before, she had been teleported into a time after the invasion of Thaymor, which is why she had been in her Force Captain barrack. So unless the illusion had changed, this was not the portal all over.

Besides, the fact that she remembered that at all meant she couldn't be stuck in the portal because back then, she had thought all of this was her normal life for a while.

So, what was going on?

Adora quietly got up and looked around, but everyone seemed to be sleeping soundly, as usual. The only person to ever have a light enough sleep to notice her slip away had been Catra. Who was nowhere to be seen.

There were a lot of conflicting emotions welling up inside her at the thought. For one, worry for her former friend, but also worry for herself. If Adora remembered everything, did everyone else too? If that was the case, she was not safe here.

She needed more information, so she went to look around, though she didn't make it far. Barely out of the room in fact, where she found Catra standing in front of a window, touching the right part of her face. The part that had been corrupted by the portal.

Despite her earlier worries, Adora's anger came back quickly. Without a warning, she grabbed the girl and dragged her off into what appeared to be a supply closet. Catra naturally complained, but Adora wasn't hearing it.

"Do you remember?" She got straight to be point.

Catra didn't answer for a while, only rubbed her wrist and avoided eye contact.

Adora sighed and tried to stay reasonably calm, which was hard because their fight in the portal was still fresh in her mind and she was still incredibly angry. "I take that as a yes", she grumbled, seeing as Catra still didn't respond, making her feel like she was going to lose her last thread of sanity. "Are you seriously gonna pretend I'm not here? That's so childish!"

Catra scoffed, losing some of her hesitation. "What's the point? You seem to know all the answers."

If she had one, Adora would have screamed into a pillow. Had Catra always been that frustrating or was it because they were enemies now? "I don't", she snapped. "Case in point, I don't even know why I'm talking to you! I also don't know why you hate me! I don't know why I ever thought we were friends! I don't know what's going on! I just don't know anything and it's driving me nuts!"

She couldn't have said what kind of reaction she was expecting, but any reaction at all would have been great, but Catra did not really look impressed.

"We're in the past", she then mumbled.

"What?" Did Adora get that correctly? It sounded so absurd.

Catra shrugged. "Most people are asleep, so I can't be for sure, but it looks like it", she apparently decided to elaborate. "Shadow Weaver is still here for one. The picture on your bed is still there and I checked the schedule for tomorrow. Our entire squad is in for training."

Adora had several questions, but she focused on the important stuff for now. "How long have you been awake?" Okay, maybe not the *most* important stuff.

"About an hour."

She had several more follow up questions, like how it was possible that the feline woke up before her, but she needed to reminded herself to focus.

So, they were in the past, probably. There were still some questions that remained. For one, how many people remember the … future? The other was, how far in the past were they? And then there was the question whether they could change something.

Catra's groan ripped her from her thoughts. "Don't even think about it", she warned. "We're keeping everything the way it was."

Adora scoffed. "That's impossible, we know too much to do everything the same."

"Whatever. I'll stick with my decision. I'm never joining the rebellion", her former friend growled and Adora really shouldn't be surprised.

"Of course not", she grumbled. "Would be a shame if you ever let go of anything." She was aware that she was quoting Light Hope with all her letting go talk, but she didn't care. She just wanted to leave, which Catra blocked.

"What's that supposed to mean?" She looked angry, but Adora knew her too well. If she was truly angry, she would have already lashed out. No, the girl was hurt.

She refused to feel guilty for it, but she felt herself failing. "It means that you love to hold grudges", she explained shortly. "Maybe that's why you can't leave. You're too desperate to prove to everyone that they need you", she realized. And somehow, she understood the feeling.

"Like it's that different from the rebellion", Catra laughed. "You love to act like the good guys, but you do just as much damage as the Horde. But, I'm sure they expect nothing from you but an upbeat attitude", she mocked.

Adora couldn't do this anymore. Getting into fights with Catra. Discussing this. "Do whatever you want", she relented. "In the end, you always do. You never listen to anyone, even if you know they're right." This time, no one stopped her from stepping out of the door. "I'm leaving."

"Fine!", Catra yelled behind her because she was petty like that. "I don't need you! I never did!"

Her voice had cracked towards the end and Adora almost turned back around to try and convince her again, but she quickly remembered all the times she had tried before and how useless that had been. Maybe she should simply follow her own advice and let it go.

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Catra was fuming. She usually was. But this was different. This was because Adora really left her for good, it seemed.

It wasn't often that Adora, little miss sunshine, was angry, but now she was. Angry at Catra. That was new and it was all her fault, wasn't it? She had pushed the other for months, hoping to finally sever every last connection they shared. Now she had done it. So why didn't she feel good about it?

If she only thought hard enough, she might figure it out. Deep down, she probably knew, but she hadn't spend years avoiding her feelings to start unleashing them now.

Instead, she was wandering, looking for a wall to demolish or a balcony to jump off of — whatever she found first, she guessed, would have to do.

The problem was only that she barely paid attention to any of her surroundings, which made it hard to find either.

At some point she found herself close to the Force Captain barracks, probably out of habit by now, and immediately turned around. Not only did she not want to get into the embarrassment of being caught around here, she also didn't want to think about how she had lost her room. She could get it back, she supposed, but Adora was already changing the story, so she better not hope.

Stupid Adora and her stupid hero complex ruining her life once again.

She couldn't hold it in anymore. Why find a specific wall to destroy when no one will probably care about some scratches no matter where? So she went at it, slicing through the metal until she felt the tears sting at her eyes and she broke down.

The wall before her was barely holding up anymore and she cut deep enough that she could see the moon through the slashes.

"Wow", she heard behind her and jumped, ready to fight whoever dared be in her space right now. But she stopped when she saw Scorpia. "You got some sharp claws, huh?", the woman asked with a smile. Cheery, as usual. Like she could never have a bad day, it was pissing Catra off.

"What do you want?", she snapped, ignoring the fact that right now, Scorpia technically outranked her. Still, she knew her and the smiling face in front of her would not reprimand her like other Force Captains might. Besides, with any luck, everyone might remember the events of the portal and before, so Scorpia would still think of her as a friend. She hoped.

"Just heard some odd sounds and thought I'd check", she explained without hesitation. "I don't think I've seen you before. What are you doing here? Do you need help?"

"I don't need help! And certainly not yours!", Catra snapped immediately, only barely catching that Scorpia did in fact not remember. Adora and her might really be the only people with their memories still intact. Odd.

The other woman lifted her pincers in surrender and took a reluctant step back. "Lots of anger, I get it. Do you wanna talk about it?"

Catra groaned. Loudly, but she didn't care about waking people. Also, the Fright Zone makes enough weird noises on its own, she doubted anyone would notice a few more.

She stared at Scorpia. From the very moment they had met, she had tried her best to hate the woman. Especially after the disaster with Adora, she really didn't feel like getting close to anyone. But that princess was just too stubborn for her own good. And sometimes, Catra kind of liked having someone around she could count on. But that still didn't make them friends.

"No", she finally grumbled as Scorpia still looked at her, unable to get a hint, as usual. "There's nothing to talk about." Nothing, she *wanted* to talk about.

Scorpia nodded thoughtfully and somehow Catra knew that she wasn't getting rid of the woman anymore. "You know, in my personal experience, people usually say that when they really should air some stuff out."

"What experience? You don't have any friends", she replied with a laugh and saw Scorpia's face fall.

This was exactly why Catra didn't have any friends either. She was terrible at this. Even when she wasn't trying to be.

At this point, she could only leave, which she did. Walking away, reevaluating and searching for a new plan, that's what she was good at. She was used to failing, but she has gotten good at finding ways to work around that.

Catra stopped in a random empty corridor and took a deep breath while smoothing her hair back. So, the portal failed too. But now, she had knowledge. She wouldn't fall for Shadow Weaver again, she would know how to get to Hordak's good side, she can still win this war. The only thing she'll have to look out for will be

Adora, who will do things differently too. That would make it harder, but she could do it.

One thing at a time, though. Adora was already gone and people, mostly Shadow Weaver, would have questions. That old hag would want the other girl back, no matter what or how, and just like last time, Catra would have to sabotage that. She could tell the sorceress outright, that her golden child defected, but where would that leave her? In a ditch somewhere, probably.

No, playing dumb might be better. That way, Shadow Weaver couldn't dispose of her right away, needing Adora's best friend to convince her to come back. And while that was happening, Catra could figure out how to get rid of the sorceress without Entrapta because there was no way she was letting a princess get close to Hordak again.

By the time, she got all her anger out and a plan ready, it was already morning and despite the lack of sleep, she dragged herself to training, though she hardly did anything, just enough to pass the session.

She was asked by everyone on her squad where Adora was, but she shrugged every time. Until Shadow Weaver visited them after training and dragged her into the Black Garnet Chamber.

"Adora has missed training today", she said and Catra rolled her eyes behind her back. "Where is she?"

"How am I supposed to know?", she replied, trying to sound as bored as she could. She would never admit it out loud, but the old woman still scared her.

Shadow Weaver was not happy with that answer. "Don't play dumb with me, child. You two are close. She would never depart without telling you", she pointed out, the shadows around her growing darker. "You have been spotted wandering around all night. Are you going to tell me, you didn't notice anything?"

As much as she was in tunnel vision for most of it? She could have walked past Adora on a stolen skiff and still wouldn't remember it. "Exactly, I wasn't around to see Adora sneak out", she said instead, as it was the only plausible thing.

The older woman sighed. "As always, you are a disappointment", she grumbled and glared at her. "Have it your way, but your insolence will not protect her. Or you. If Adora is not back by tonight, you will receive her punishment. Now get out!"

Catra didn't need to be told twice. She was out of the room and three corridors down before the mechanical door could even close.

Was she surprised by the outcome? Not really, but that didn't mean she liked it. It made sense, too. The only reason why she hadn't been punished last time, was because she was needed to get Adora back at Thaymor, but that was still … who knew how long away.

How was she supposed to get out of this one?

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Adora's plan to run away was sabotaged the moment she noticed that she needed to steal a skiff. With a frustrated groan, she was forced to sneak back inside and somehow manage to get a key when she hadn't been promoted to Force Captain yet.

She thought about maybe playing along to get that promotion first, but that was a terrible idea for so many reason. Most importantly, she can't act to save her life, and also not insignificantly, she would have to deal with Catra, who stubbornly refused to see reason.

Eventually she hid out in a corner somewhere to put together a plan and process what happened.

They were in the past. She had no clue if anyone apart from her and Catra remembered the time before the portal. Angella was hopefully still alive if they were truly in the past which meant she could fix things. The portal could be avoided, a lot of things could be avoided. And yet, the one thing she cannot fix was Catra.

She would admit that Catra had a point, that both the Horde and the princesses fought their fights and sometimes they couldn't take care of every single town, person or piece of nature in order to protect their territories, but at least they were nice. They didn't threaten anyone or torture them or sent them to die on Beast Island over a single mistake. Even their prison was literally a guest room!

Why didn't Catra see that? Why couldn't she just listen? Why did she want to stay at this terrible place?

As long as they were friends, she always thought she knew Catra, but that turned out to be wrong. She didn't know anything and she didn't understand why the girl wanted to stay in the Horde so desperately. All she knew was that Catra did that because she was mad at Adora, but why?

She thought about Entrapta, who hadn't been indoctrinated since she was a baby and still seemed to want to stay in the Fright Zone. To be fair, the Fright Zone did have better opportunities to be an eccentric scientist, but apart from that? Was there another reason?

With a groan, she slid down the wall. She'd bet Catra knew the reason. Catra, despite being a lot less socially outgoing, was always better at figuring out people's motives.

She missed her. Had the entire time and it broke her heart having to fight her. Adora was still angry at her because of the portal, and she probably would be for a while, but as much as she wants

to say that she finally doesn't care anymore, she can't. Because she does care. A lot more than she could ever tell any of her friends or they might start doubting her. They couldn't doubt She-Ra.

Adora tried to figure out what to do. She didn't want to leave Catra here again, even if it seemed to be what the feline wanted. Did she want it? All the pain that she knew this place had inflicted on both of them… she could not imagine that Catra really wanted to stay, but then what was the problem?

That Adora joined the rebellion? She had asked the girl to come with her, she hadn't left her behind without a second thought, she had wanted her friend by her side. She still does.

With a sigh, she made a decision. One that she already knew would backfire so badly. Kidnapping Catra had already been a terrible idea in the portal, and she doubted the girl would be happy that she tried it again, but Adora was determined to not leave the feline in this place.

It was already creeping close to morning by the time she snuck back out into the corridors. How was she supposed to go about this? She still needed a skiff, and something to knock Catra out. She also would need to find her. Didn't she say something about training in the morning?

Her time in the rebellion really made her too comfortable with improvising. Why didn't she think a bit more about this before running out of her hiding place?

As it usually does, though, things worked themselves out as she saw the tail of someone who hopefully would be able to help. "Scorpia!", she called before realizing that maybe she shouldn't draw too much attention to herself.

Well, too late. The woman stopped and turned around in confusion. "Oh, hi… do I know you?"

"Uh… no?", she mumbled. It didn't seem like the other remembered. Okay, that would make this a bit more difficult, but they already had worked together in the portal, despite not really knowing each other. This would be fine. "Listen, I need your help."

Scorpia seemed to be even more confused now. "You need my help? *My* help?"

"Yes." She nodded. "This might sound a little insane, or really dumb", she then started to explain. "But I kinda need you to knock someone out."

"I'm not sure I'm comfortable with that", the other mumbled and took a tiny step back.

"It's for her own good. She's not going to come with me voluntarily, but if she doesn't she'll get hurt, and I mean, she already hates me, so whatever. I just... I can't leave her behind again!" She was only vaguely aware of how little sense this would make to an outsider.

"You were not kidding. Definitely getting some insane vibes", Scorpia said, taking another step back.

This did not go as smoothly as she had hoped. Then again, she was doing a terrible job at explaining this. "Okay, it's not as insane as it sounds, I promise. I just… I have this friend and she's really stubborn and I just want her to be safe, so please knock her out for me?" She tried to make her best puppy eyes and by the way Scorpia suddenly tried to look away, she suspected it might be working.

Eventually the woman sighed. "Who's your friend?", she then asked defeated.

"Her name is Catra, she's a bit shorter than me, claws, tail, one blue eye, one yellow", she tried to describe as many defining features as she could.

Something like recognition crossed the other's face. "Oh, I know her!"

"You do?" Did Scorpia remember something after all?

"Yeah, she wandered around last night, woke me up when she destroyed a wall and started crying", she said a bit too cheerful for the topic. Her own words seemed to catch up to her, though. "Yeah, she really did not seem to be happy", she mumbled to herself. "Okay, I can help, but then what?"

That was a good question. "Then, we'll get out of here", she said, even though she should probably not tell anyone that she planned on defecting.

"We?", Scorpia then asked, sounding a bit surprised before deflating. "You mean, you and Catra…"

Adora felt very uncomfortable, but … honestly, the woman never struck her as a bad person. "I mean… you can come too. If you want." And she did appear a bit hopeful just now when she thought Adora had referred to her.

"Really?" The woman lit up again and then suddenly Adora found herself in a crushing hug, that was still kind of nice? Even if she would like to breathe a bit more. Luckily she was put down again quickly. "I've never been included in anything, so this is a first. Wow, this is like… wow. Does that mean we're friends now?"

"Uh… I don't know. I guess?" She really wasn't sure. Then again Bow and Glimmer had also made quick friends with her, so maybe sometimes that stuff happens fast. "But first, you need to find Catra."

"Yeah, about that", Scorpia then said when Adora already wanted to turn around. "Do I *have* to knock her out? I don't like doing that and she seemed really angry and-"

"I know. But don't worry, she can direct that at me", she tried to calm the other down. "And, I'm afraid you can't convince her to

come. I tried."

"Okay, then", the woman mumbled, though she still didn't seem happy about it. "So, I knock her out and then…?"

"We'll meet at the skiff bay. We need one anyway if we want to get out of here."

A nod. "And what do you do?"

"I'll get a key for a skiff", she answered easily because while it would be easier for Scorpia to get a key, seeing as she was a Force Captain, Adora didn't want to make the woman do all the work.

They nodded at each other one more time and then they were off into different directions.

Adore still knew where to go. After all, she had spend her entire life here, apart from a few months. The bigger problem was avoiding the people. Doing this during the daytime had been a bad idea, but they couldn't change that now.

She knew there was a room that held all the important stuff for Force Captains. Reaching it was one thing, but it was coincidentally also something of a break room, which meant someone was always in there. Back when she had just gotten promoted, it may have been awkward, but nobody had batted an eye at her being there. Now, though?

There were only a handful of Force Captains, which meant that there had to be windows of time in which she could sneak in. But, hiding behind the corner and watching the door carefully, every time one left, just a few seconds later another one went in. Didn't these people have something better to do? Then again, they might also be working in there, looking through files or something.

Speaking of, if she does eventually get in there, it might not be the worst idea to take some files, too. Get some knowledge. Catra

and Scorpia both must have information about the inner workings of the Horde, but she couldn't trust Catra to actually spill and Scorpia never appeared particularly in the loop.

The Force Captain who had occupied the room for the last ten minutes finally left. Adora waited a few seconds, then a minute, but no one else came down the hall. She decided to take the opportunity and slip in.

Finding a key was the easiest part, but if she really wanted to take some files, she had to check which ones. Did she have the time for that, though?

In the end, in her panic, she grabbed a bunch at random. Then she saw a separate cabinet and went to check in there too. Those were definitely private — Shadow Weaver's by the looks of it. That was obviosuly her handwriting scribbled over everything. Adora grabbed a few of those as well, and then decided to make a break for it.

When she got out, she noticed the next Force Captain coming down the hall, but before he could fully realize what she was doing here, she bolted.

She heard a few screams behind her, but didn't turn around and ran straight to the docks. During her run, she tried to read the number on the key, so she could quickly find the right skiff, but it was harder to decipher than she thought. Eventually she managed, though right before running straight into a door.

That slowed her down for a moment, as she rubbed the spot on her head that had collided with metal, but it wouldn't be the first time she had received a head injury. She would be fine, and once she had her sword back, she could easily heal herself. Hopefully — after all, she had only done it once before.

So, she stumbled on, somebody still yelled behind her, but she reached the bay, and Scorpia was there too, with a limb Catra in one arm and some box balanced on the other.

"Go go go!", she yelled over to the woman, who once again looked confused before she noticed whoever was running after Adora and started to make a break for it.

At this point, Adora was already next to her and guided them to the skiff that they needed. She didn't waste any time on making sure everyone was secure before she turned the thing on and speed through the gate. Only then did she allow herself to take a breath.

"We're really doing this", she heard Scorpia mumble.

"Yeah", Adora repeated. "Don't worry, the rebellion is nice." She hoped. They were not exactly friendly to Horde soldiers, but hopefully She-Ra could convince them.

Then they were quiet. She noticed that Scorpia made sure Catra could sleep in a more comfortable position, and Adora kept glancing over to make sure the feline was still out. In the portal they had barely made it to the edge of the woods before she had woken up, but that had been a sting baton, so maybe Scorpia's poison was stronger.

It must be because when they had reached the Whispering Woods and Adora turned off the skiff, the girl was still out. "We need to walk to rest of the way", she told the woman, knowing that the woods wouldn't let a skiff get far.

The other only nodded and carefully picked Catra up, and Adora collected her loot, as well as Scorpia's box.

Now the only thing they still needed was the sword. Scorpia didn't question her searching glance or why she stopped occasionally when she thought she saw something. The woman seemed to trust her judgment, though she did keep making confused faces.

After an hour or so, Adora felt frustration rise in her. It really shouldn't surprise her that these stupid trees just wouldn't let her find her way. Even if she wasn't able to find the sword right now, Brightmoon would be great at least. Though, without She-Ra that

would be a useless destination anyway, so the sword was kind of her priority.

By the time it was noon, she allowed a break. Catra was still out. "Just how strong is that poison?", she couldn't help asking.

"Oh, it depends. But… I don't know, it could still take a while, maybe not, I really don't know", Scorpia answered. "What exactly are you looking for?", she then asked. "You seem to be searching for something."

She sighed. "Yeah… there's this sword, I … had a dream and I'm sure it's here somewhere." That wasn't a complete lie. Not exactly her motivation right now, but a dream had been what led her here last time.

"Oh, like destiny? That's so cool", the woman cooed and Adora winced. "No?"

"I don't know", she simply mumbled. After everything that had happened with Light Hope, she didn't think of it as a good thing anymore. At the beginning she liked having a purpose, a destiny, but learning that she had been deliberately taken from her family because someone had to be She-Ra… that wasn't destiny, it was random and she had to suffer the consequences now.

"Okay, but it does sound important. I'm good, we can keep going", Scorpia offered and while Adora wanted to refuse, because they did need to rest a little, she just couldn't.

With a nod, she got up and they kept walking. Somehow she remembered it having been a lot easier, but a lot had happened that day — a giant bug, the ruin, Thaymor — so she was possibly throwing it out of proportion.

And the woods were huge, but they had to run into the sword at some point, right? That's how that went? Then she swore that they had walked past that stone three times already, that tree five and Scorpia had stumbled twice now and she was pretty sure that was the same root both times.

"Come on!", Adora yelled then at no one in particular. The daymoon was starting to vanish behind the tree line and she was sincerely getting desperate. "What do I have to do to get my sword?!"

Adora had never quite understood just how sentient these woods were, just that they were. Kind of. They certainly kept the Horde away, to some extent, and she had never experienced any problem traveling through it with any princess, so they must have some awareness of who is and isn't an intruder. So why was she having such a problem?! She was a princess too!

Scorpia patted her on the back and looked a bit unsure. "Maybe we should find shelter, for now. The woods evidently don't want you to find the sword right now, and it is getting dark, so…" She shrugged, like she didn't know how to finish that sentence.

She only nodded. At this point, she was about to give up, lie on the ground and ready to let nature take her. But she couldn't do that, not with the Horde still threatening the planet and Scorpia around to depend on her and Catra to still deal with.

Weirdly enough, just as the woman was about to suggest ideas for shelter, a bright light shone through the trees.

Adora stumbled forward immediately, running towards it, hoping that it wasn't an optical illusion but actually her sword.

When she came into the clearing, she sighed with relief. "Thank you!", she cried out to the woods. Then she went to grab it. This time, there was no Glimmer or Bow around — she was probably early.

What was there, though, was the vision she had received the first time too, with Light Hope asking her to fight for the honor of Grayskull. If that sequence had been disturbing the first time around, it was downright terrifying now. Back then it had been weird, but there had been enough going on to distract her from it.

This time she was fully aware of it, which just made it worse somehow.

But it didn't matter, because she was willing to fight. If not for Grayskull, whatever that was, then for Etheria and her friends. Even if the only friend she had ever known before the rebellion decided to leave her after all.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you liked it!

Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 2: Thaymor

Chapter Summary

pretty sure the chapter title gives it away...

Chapter Notes

I've rewritten this chapter too many times to count - both during the initial writing and the last few days editing. It never felt enough. It still doesn't if I'm being honest...

Still, I do hope every decision makes at least somewhat sense and that you'll enjoy <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra felt numb, which was an odd thing for her. Usually she was in some kind of misery. Was she dead? Did she throw herself out of a window, after all?

No, she didn't. The memories only came back slowly, but they came back.

She had been pacing through the halls, growing more and more nervous, knowing Adora wasn't coming back and trying to find a way to avoid punishment, preferably without minimizing her chances to seize control eventually.

Okay, maybe she had been working herself up into a mental breakdown, seeing as her chances weren't great. And maybe she had been willing and ready to destroy another wall, tear someone's throat out or cry — she wasn't picky.

Instead of doing any of that, she ran into Scorpia again, though. "Oh, hi kitty", she cooed awkwardly.

Catra absolutely did not have the nerves for this and she could feel how her eye twitched. She had too much to do and figure

out, she didn't have time for Scorpia's delusions. So, she just kept walking.

Sadly, it didn't deter the other. "Wait!", she called out and ran after her.

She really tried not to let it annoy her, but with her as on edge as she was, she failed. She just wanted to be left alone, so she could think and find a solution. "Could you stop following me?", she snapped, making Scorpia flinch.

Still, she shook her head. "No can do. I'm just…"

"Just what? Spit it out." She didn't have time for this.

The woman took a breath. "So, I need you to know that I'm really, very sorry about this", she then said and before Catra could ask what that even meant, she was starting to lose her consciousness.

As the memories came back, she noticed that Scorpia must have stung her. But why? It wasn't like her.

She had a headache. That was the first feeling that came back before she could even open her eyes. There were voices around her, but she couldn't make out anything they said. One thing she did know for sure, though, was that she was not in the Fright Zone anymore. She didn't need to open her eyes when she could feel the wind ruffle her fur and the distinct smell of metal was missing.

When she did manage to open her eyes, she saw trees. Why was she in the woods? She tried to sit up and take in more of her surroundings, but her arms weren't cooperating. Or any other part of her body.

At the very least she managed to turn her head to see Scorpia who talked with someone. Someone, she couldn't see from this angle.

"It'll be fine", she then made out. It sounded familiar.

"Are you sure?", Scorpia asked. "What you said just now doesn't really make it sound like it will be fine."

A sigh. "But that's only a very small possibility. Most likely it'll be fine." Adora.

Somehow that realization was enough to force her body to work. She was still slightly out of it, and the world around her spun when she sat up, but she wasn't going to let that stop her. "Are you kidding me?!", she screamed, making Scorpia flinch next to her.

"Hey Catra", the blonde idiot said nervously and waved awkwardly.

She let out a frustrated yell and tried to get on her feet. There were pincers helping her, but she weakly pushed them away, making herself stumble in the process and running straight into Adora, who gave her some support as Catra whirled around, ignoring her worsening headache. "You stung me", she accused, trying and failing to point an angry finger at Scorpia. "You traitor!"

The situation only slowly started to make sense to her and she still had a lot of questions, but one thing was very clear to her. Scorpia was working with Adora. Who was still holding her upright.

"Don't be mad at her", the blonde told her, her voice way too close for comfort. "That was my idea."

Catra pushed herself off of the girl and stumbled vaguely towards a tree that she hoped she wasn't imagining. "Of course, it was", she then said with a roll of her eyes that she regretted just a second later. "Scorpia's way too soft to just sting people for no reason. I just can't believe you kidnapped me again!"

"I knew you wouldn't come if I asked you", the blonde scoffed.

"And that didn't give you a hint?!", she spat.

"Are you taking the hint that I don't want to leave you behind?!", the other asked, throwing her arms into the air like she was about ready to give up.

"I didn't want to leave, you stupid idiot!"

Adora honestly dared to laugh. "Oh? Because last I checked, you were mad because I left you", she grumbled condescendingly. "Could you please make up your mind, you stubborn brat?!"

Catra leaned against the tree and tried not to throw up. Somehow she managed to force out a mocking laugh of her own. "Well, last *I* checked, you told me to live with my choices."

"Well…" The blonde seemed to be at a loss for words for a moment, as she was reminded of their not-so-long-ago past in the portal. "Maybe… you don't have to… anymore", she mumbled awkwardly.

With that, some quiet settled in and Catra took the chance to ground herself a little, as she willed the poison to leave her body.

She had a bit of experience with this, seeing as Scorpia had knocked her out once before in an attempt to hit Sparkles. It had been as terrible then as it was now, but at least Entrapta wasn't trying to experiment on her, and Scorpia didn't try to feed her soup, so that was some improvement.

Then she started to process a few things. Like the fact that Adora came back for her. To kidnap her, but she actually came back.

"Why?", she mumbled out eventually. This didn't make any sense. Adora was evidently angry at her.

"What do you mean, why?", the idiot asked, though.

She was really not in the right mental state to deal with this right now. "I know you hate me, so why do you care?"

Adora looked taken aback. "I don't hate you."

"Oh, please spare me the goody two shoes act", she grumbled, flexing her claws a little as she slowly regained control.

"It's not an act", the blonde protested. "I know I probably should, but I just cannot hate you. I'm angry at you and I am far from forgiving you, but … I still care about you. You're my friend."

She scoffed. "We haven't been friends in a long time, princess."

There was a sigh. "I know. You made that very clear."

"I did. I told in no uncertain terms that I did not want to leave and yet, here we are", she grumbled. The world started to stabilize. That was good at least.

"Do you really hate the thought of coming with me and starting again so much that you want to go back to Shadow Weaver?", Adora then asked. The hurt in her voice made Catra uncomfortable.

The easy answer was no, but she couldn't tell Adora that.

She didn't necessarily want to go back. If she was being honest with herself, she knew that no matter how much she would look for solutions, some plan that would end with her on top, all her efforts wouldn't matter. Shadow Weaver didn't care about her, Hordak would never trust her and staying in the Horde would only end in pain, and from her experience an early grave.

But did that mean, she wanted to join the rebellion? Also no. The thought made her want to jump off of something, in fact. Being back in Adora's space and helping the princesses sounded just as terrible as Shadow Weaver's torture did.

"Catra, all these things that happened", Adora said after a few long seconds of silence. She was vague in her phrasing, possibly because Scorpia was still listening in. "That can't be what you wanted."

"Like you care about what I want", she responded bitterly.

"I do."

"Oh, yeah?", she challenged, tilting her head — she happily discovered that the world didn't start to spin again. "If I asked you to instead run to the waste with me, would you?"

She already knew the answer, but the pained sigh the girl let out still hurt. "That's not fair."

Catra managed to get up without stumbling. "So, I'm supposed to follow you wherever, and you won't do the same for me. But my hypothetical question is unfair?" She walked up to the girl for the proper effect. "I don't owe you anything, Adora. You stopped looking out for me, so why should I do you any favors now?"

The girl winced at the mention of their broken promise. Sure, Catra hadn't exactly held up her end of the bargain lately, but Adora had broken it first, so that hardly counted.

"I'm sorry", the blonde then said, and it shocked Catra enough to take a step back. "I didn't realize I was doing that, and I never wanted to hurt you. I'm not asking you for any favors, but I just… couldn't let you stay there knowing how much it would hurt you. I can't fight against you again."

It would be easy to convince herself that it was a lie if anyone else had said it. But this was Adora, the worst liar on the planet. Which meant she meant all that.

Catra was experiencing a lot of conflicting emotions. Hope for their friendship, but also anger because of the audacity. A bit of guilt maybe because she received another chance even though she certainly didn't deserve it. And somewhere in there was spite and the urge to say no and run, just to hurt the girl.

Adora came back to kidnap her because she didn't want her to get hurt. She didn't want to fight. But she was still angry.

"What exactly do you want from me?", she asked carefully because if the girl didn't want to be enemies, but also didn't

forgive her, then what was even happening?

Somehow this entire situation got more awkward. "It doesn't matter what I want."

"Adora, I am this close to slapping you", she warned, pressing her fingers tightly together and watching the blonde stare with a bit of fear, now taking her own step back. "Give me a proper answer or I'm out of here."

"I want you back", came the immediate response.

Catra had to process that before she gave any commitment.

The problem was that, clearly, wanting her back didn't outweigh Adora's perceived duties to the planet or whatever. Neither did it erase all the hurt and hate that Catra had accumulated over the past months. Or Adora's own anger.

But it did open the door for Catra to easily accept without giving away just how much she wanted that too.

She had to really think about this because once she made a decision there would be no going back. One way or the other. Being in the past was an opportunity she wouldn't get again and she had to be careful about this.

The Fright Zone was terrible. According to Adora, the rebellion was better or at least nicer, or whatever, and Catra didn't even doubt that, considering her short experience of being Sparkles' prisoner. Sure, the princess was ready to kill her, but some goodness insider her had always held her back from even so much as hurting her. And Catra *had* pushed her, to be completely fair.

But that was also kind of a problem. Catra didn't fit in with the princesses. She wasn't nice or kind or good. In the end, she would be as much of an outsider as in the Horde.

One thing she knew for sure, though, was how ungrateful the Horde was. Hordak clearly had no clue how most things in the Horde worked, and Shadow Weaver didn't care enough about the war to really push them forward. And yet, no matter how much better the Horde had been under Catra, nobody cared.

She had no way of knowing how different that would be in the rebellion, but she had seen them celebrate openly whenever they had defeated the Horde, so… maybe. Catra had to admit, the idea of getting a bit of recognition wasn't a bad one.

Another thing to be taken into account was a short happy moment in the Crimson Waste.

Scorpia had been right, she had never been happier than in these few days away from the Fright Zone — she really hated that junk heap of metal and fear with a burning passion. Why had she gone back? Because Adora told her that Shadow Weaver was in Brightmoon. Shadow Weaver… now that she thought about it, if nothing else did it for her, the chance for a bit of revenge was tempting.

Enough to stay with the princesses? Debatable, but joining the rebellion — as much as she wanted to throw up — did have a lot of pros.

The most notable con? Adora. Well, and the fact that it would be weird fighting alongside the people who have been her enemies for months.

Catra looked over to the blonde, who less than patiently waited for the verdict. The girl was nervous, even if she tried to hide it. Adora had always been terrible at waiting, and having nothing to do.

With things already changed, thanks to Adora, the one question that had kept Catra at the edge of a panic attack was whether she would have any chance at all to seize control like last time.

The blonde had not yet been promoted, Thaymor was still who knew how long away, and even if she managed not to die in the next few weeks, things would start to look really bad for her at around Princess Prom.

Apart from the fact, that Adora would not fall for her distraction again, making it impossible to kidnap Sparkles and getting them to leave Entrapta behind, she also didn't want Entrapta in the Horde and without her… there were a lot of things she couldn't do.

Entrapta, most notably, had been a huge part in taking out Shadow Weaver, as their meddling with the Black Garnet has led to a confrontation, but without that… Hordak would probably kill her himself if she got rid of his current second in command.

Catra had worse odds than the first time around.

Going through the same few bits of misery was one thing, but with things as they were, it would possibly mean more misery than she was willing to bear.

The rebellion, on the other hand, was currently small and losing. They desperately needed skilled people and if they would come close enough to winning, and to, maybe, invade the Fright Zone, she could possibly 'accidentally' kill Shadow Weaver in 'self defense'.

It was a risk, but compared to what she *knew* would await her back in the Horde, it still felt like the better option. "Okay", she heard herself say before she fully processed it.

Adora lit up in surprise. "Really? You're coming with me?", she asked with too much hope to be healthy.

"I'm not doing this because I like you. I just hate Shadow Weaver more than I hate you", she grumbled and despite the fact that she could see the blondes' face fall a second, she did not miss the fact that Catra had admitted to liking the girl better than some other

people. It was a small win, but it seemed like Adora gladly took it anyway.

"Yay", Scorpia suddenly cheered beside them, startling them both. "I feel like I'm missing some context, but I'm really happy you're coming too. I am still worried about the pitchforks and torches thing, Adora mentioned, though."

Catra raised an eyebrow and turned to Adora, who awkwardly cleared her throat. "I already told you, it's a very unlikely scenario. I'll transform into She-Ra again, which should calm everyone enough to listen and give us a chance."

She had a very hard time trusting that statement. She-Ra could not hide the two Horde soldiers with her, not to mention that Adora was one, too, a fact that she would have to reveal sooner or later.

There was, however, a better way at getting the princesses to trust them — at least enough to avoid execution on sight. "Hey, when's the attack on Thaymor?", she asked Scorpia, the only person who hopefully knew what day it actually was.

Scorpia looked slightly taken aback. "In three days, why?", she asked before a realization seemed to hit her. "Wait, you're not a Force Captain, you shouldn't know about that. How do you know about that?"

"I can see the future", she replied sarcastically and started to form a plan.

So, Adora had defected a few days before she was supposed to, which only made her feel more sure in her decision. With so much time to kill, it would be more likely that Catra would end up 'disposed off' — as Shadow Weaver liked to call it — than climbing the ranks. It would also give them enough time to reach the town.

"You can?", Scorpia then asked in wonder, ripping her from her thoughts.

Catra had to think back to what she had said for a moment. Then she scoffed. "No", she told her with a face that hopefully said "Did you seriously believe that?"

"What about Thaymor?", Adora chimed in then, a bit awkwardly, getting them back on topic.

"If we save the town, they might be more inclined to trust us", she told her.

Adora snorted. "More inclined?"

Catra responded with a growl. "Your plan was just to 'be She-Ra' and hope for the best, at least I got a real plan. Those princesses won't trust us, no matter how much you sparkle. We're Horde. I don't even know how you-" She cut herself off, remembering Scorpia was still here. "If we wanna prove to them that we are on their side, we need to do something more than be She-Ra."

"I know you're not a fan, but it has worked las-" The blonde, too, had to stop. "In my head", she corrected.

She couldn't help, but laugh at the terrible save.

Adora rolled her eyes in response. "How do you wanna save Thaymor anyway? We're just three people."

Catra rolled her eyes. "You always were terrible at planning", she grumbled and reveled in the sputtering face the other was making. "Of course we can't fight the army that's coming just on our own. I don't think that's wise anyway, considering that Shadow Weaver will most likely be watching. But we can save the people. Evacuate."

Adora nodded slowly as the idea churned in her big empty head. "Okay, yeah, that's… a good idea", the girl mumbled eventually.

"Are you honestly surprised?", Catra questioned, a bit offended.

The other shook her head. "I just didn't expect you to actually help so quickly." That was not really less offensive if she would have asked Catra, even though it was also fair.

But if she was going to do this — selfish motives or not — she was not going to risk getting attacked and imprisoned, potentially killed, the second they step foot in Brightmoon. This was pure self preservation, a skill that Adora obviously never developed.

"So, where is that stupid town?", she asked instead of responding to that, and followed Adora through the woods.

The thought of bolting crossed her mind a few times, but for some unexplainable reason she didn't. Though she was tempted more and more, each time she thought about it.

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Adora had somehow managed to convince Catra to come with her without getting into a fight with the girl. At least not a physical one.

Obviously, she wasn't delusional enough to think that Catra only did this because Adora had asked her to, or out of the goodness of her heart. She had practically seen the gears turn inside the feline's head and, somehow, she was sure the other was planning something. It was surely not Adora making her stay.

Whatever Catra was planning, she just hoped it wouldn't be anything too bad. Like sabotaging the rebellion from the inside.

She sighed. Just because they had … reached an agreement, didn't mean there was friendship, or trust or even tolerance. Adora kept awaiting the inevitable attack or the result of whatever the other was planning, and Catra kept looking around like she wanted to run.

With everything still unspoken between them, and everything that had happened, they would probably be hostile for a while, she suspected. But she hadn't lied. She did want Catra back in her life, as her friend. As usual, though, she had not thought this through because how were they supposed to be friends after all the hurt they had inflicted on each other? Sure, none of that had theoretically happened yet, but they still remembered, so it kind of did happen… Time travel was confusing.

They walked in silence, mostly because Catra was stubborn and Adora was unwilling to always having to initiate conversation. Only Scorpia tried to make a bit of small talk here and there, which was incredibly awkward and short lived.

The next difficulty was reached when they were forced to take a break, because of the nightfall. Scorpia had no problem lying down in the grass and sleeping. Catra apparently did, though, because she chose the biggest nearest tree and made her way up there.

Adora was not about to judge if she wanted a bit of privacy, but it felt more like she just didn't want to be here at all. Or like she was hiding, neither of which calmed her down at all.

In fact, it made her anxious to sleep. It was probably unreasonable — she knew Catra liked to be alone if she had something to think about or stuff to work through — but she could swear she saw the feline's eyes through the leaves staring at her and Adora felt very much like prey.

Another part of her was also a bit worried that the other would be gone in the morning and she wouldn't notice, but considering she couldn't see the girl in the dark and that high up, that might come true regardless of whether or not she slept. So, she tried, she really did. She was pretty sure, she must have drifted off a few times but it could not have been long and by the time, light started to shine through the woods, she gave up.

Her body was riddled with anxiety that only let up a little when Catra jumped down and landed in front of her. Though, it did not look like she had slept much either.

She was about to reach out and ask, but the feline noticed the hand slowly creeping towards her shoulder and hissed. Well, she made an effort.

Adora made herself useful and picked some berries that she knew were edible thanks to Razz. She really tried not to take it personally — Catra was not a morning person and has hissed at several people who tried to talk to her too early in their time together.

At least she was more calm when Adora offered her food. Scorpia was awake now too. They ate in the same awkward silence that they also walked in. She noticed the tall woman looking in between the two former friends like she expected another fight to break out, but they managed to pull themselves together.

"We should get going", Catra said when the berries were all gone. "We don't have that much time left and I didn't see any signs of a town from up there."

Adora agreed. Two days was not a lot of time. And then they still had to convince the people to listen to them and evacuate. They should be there sooner rather than later.

Scorpia raised a pincer then. "Uh, how exactly are we going to convince the villagers to listen to us anyway?", she asked.

The feline rolled her eyes. "We got a brightly glowing and unnecessarily tall alter ego with us, I'm sure they'll listen to that."

"You want me to use She-Ra to convince them?", she asked to clarify. "I'm not sure that will actually help. People usually just freak out and don't listen to me."

"I definitely freaked out", Scorpia said, nodding.

"Besides, didn't you say that being She-Ra would not be enough?"

Catra groaned. Or maybe growled, she wasn't sure. "It's not enough to convince the queen. Right now we're talking about some townspeople. Chances are, they listen to She-Ra before they listen to any of us", Catra pointed out and was admittedly right. Even if it wasn't downright obvious that they were from the Horde, who would listen to three random strangers?

"Fine", she sighed and they kept walking.

Same boring silence. The only difference this time was that Catra occasionally made them stop to climb a tree. It seemed that the feline didn't have any trust in Adora to know which way to go.

In all fairness, she didn't know the woods extremely well, and they seemed to conspire against her sometimes, but she was confident that she could find Thaymor.

To keep busy — and herself distracted from the hurt and disappointment of what their friendship had become — she loosened her sword from its place as a bracelet, where she had decided to keep it considering how many times she had lost the damn thing before, and wanted to train a bit. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Scorpia once again looked very much in awe, while Catra unsurprisingly rolled her eyes.

She spend the rest of the day testing her abilities a little. Technically she had already been through a good bit of training and has used the sword for a while in the future, but that didn't exactly mean that it would still work in the past.

Though, with how easily she could transform it into whatever she could think of at the moment, it seemed that her knowledge and memory was enough to make the sword work properly.

By the time, she was satisfied, the daymoon was starting to set again and Catra jumped back down from another tree. "I saw

some smoke. Thaymor can't be far", she then said, which was good news.

"We should make camp for today, though. It's getting dark", Adora pointed out and didn't earn much more than a nod.

They went through the same motions as the night before and Scorpia tried to fill the silences once again. It was a futile endeavor.

Adora had no more faith in Catra not to run or kill her in her sleep than before and once again lay awake. She wondered the entire night if this was how they would be from now on. Not only that they didn't trust each other, but also thought the worst of each other. How were they supposed to work together like this?

And how was she supposed to fix it?

No matter what way she thought about it, she couldn't find a solution. In the end, even if Adora was willing to completely forgive the feline and put everything behind them, it would still come down to whether Catra was willing to do the same, and with the way it looked now, she had doubts. The girl was hardly thrilled about the prospect of staying with Adora, and she refused to talk to her and whenever they had to talk to each other, she would be extra grumpy about it.

There was no way there would be any cooperation from Catra, and Adora had to admit, it worried her. What would happen when they eventually reached Brightmoon and Catra stubbornly refused to even appear somewhat trustworthy?

This thought kept her awake until morning.

She forced herself through the motions. At least there was no conversation that she should have taken part in. Just the usual silence that she sadly started to become used to.

They kept walking, Catra kept climbing trees, Scorpia eventually talked again — what about, Adora couldn't have said, possibly

some little facts and anecdotes. On another day, she would have loved to listen, but as it was, she was too busy keeping her eyes on the feline to make sure nothing bad would happen.

When the smoke from the chimneys started to be visible from the ground, Catra stopped climbing trees, but she did keep a rather large distance to them.

She had to come closer to them, though, when they reached the edge of the town. "What are you looking at me for? Transform and go talk to them", she snapped at Adora's questioning glance.

For some reason, she had hoped for a few more pointers, but she wasn't in the mood for a lengthy and probably passive-aggressive discussion with the girl, so she just did what she was told and turned into She-Ra.

Before she could take a step forward, though, she became a bit unsure again. "Alone?", she asked. Not that she couldn't do it alone, but the thought of letting Catra out of her sight didn't sit right with her.

The feline just blinked, her face tense — probably due to frustration. "Do you want to start a mass panic? We don't exactly scream 'friendly woodland creatures'", she hissed.

Right. They could hardly do anything about their clothes right now, and the Horde symbol would definitely not be received friendly.

Adora took a deep breath to ground herself and finally stepped out of the woods. She made her way through the preparations for the party she remembered.

Barely five steps into the town, she noticed the whispers and stares. She tried to get somewhere in the middle of the crowd, thinking about what to say all the while.

"Hello." Great start. "I'm here to warn you."

There was a child at her leg, tugging at her skirt. "Who are you?", they asked with stars in their eyes.

The answer came from all around them, people staring in awe and whispering her name like it was a prayer.

She looked over to where Catra and Scorpia were still hiding, somehow hoping that, for one they were still there, but also that they might be able to help. The feline covered her face with a hand and shook her head, while the other nodded encouragingly.

"Uh", she tried to get people's attention again. "Yes, I am She-Ra", she confirmed, which might have not been a good idea seeing as everyone now was cheering. "You are in danger!" That made them calm down again. "The Horde is planning an attack on your village, but me and my friends will help you evacuate to … Brightmoon, so you all will be safe."

She looked over again, Catra peeked out from under her hand. So Adora hasn't messed up completely, that was good.

"Okay, I need you to stay calm", she said again, quieting the murmurs once again. "We still have time. And I promise, you will all be safe."

They still looked scared and largely unconvinced. "We can't just leave!", someone piped in.

"Yeah, what of our town?", another one asked then.

"Why is the Horde attacking us?"

"I…" She didn't have a good answer to that. "You know what the Horde is capable of. You have to keep yourself safe first. I know that the queen will take care of you and make sure you are all safe", she said instead.

Now, at least, they thought about it and she could already see a few nodding heads. "So what do we do?", then was asked and Adora felt herself get a bit hopeful.

She cleared her throat and wondered about how to best phrase this. "Me and my friends will help you pack what's necessary and evacuate the town", she told them, receiving a few more nods in return. Then it seemed to slowly sink in that they would need to abandon their home and they started to look slightly panicked again. "So, my friends…", she started, trying to get them to not think about their uncertain future. "Uh… they might be wearing something that might scare you, but I promise they're here to help."

Maybe not the best way to phrase that and out of the corner of her eye, she saw Catra facepalm again.

The crowd around her was mostly just confused, which was at least better than panicked. "Just trust me", she quickly breathed out — she was not made for public speaking.

She looked over to the other two, who slowly crawled out of the bushes. Catra carried herself with confidence — whether or not she was actually feeling confident was anyone's guess. But Scorpia radiated with anxiety as she nervously waved to the crowd.

Adora was just relieved that someone else was here now.

"You are terrible at this!", she was hissed at the second Catra was near enough. Adora wanted to reply that she thought she had done rather well, considering the lack of prior thought that went into this, but now the crowd definitely was growing panicked, and loud, with two Horde soldiers in their midst. "Relax, people, the last thing we need is a mass panic, unless you have a death wish", Catra growled.

Now it was Adora's turn to wanting to facepalm, but surprisingly the harsh words did get the people to quiet down. So, she kept standing to the side as the feline kept going, barking orders with an air of authority that the crowd responded to with obedient focus.

"I want you all to pack necessities. As a reminder, that includes trinkets of emotional value, food, clothes, a tooth brush for all I care. Kids stay with your parents or whoever else takes care of you. Anyone who needs help, ask. You have an hour."

People scrambled away. It wasn't exactly orderly, but it was surprisingly calm. Maybe because Catra looked like she had it together. Maybe the confidence she emanated somehow translated to them. Or they were more afraid of the girl than the thought of abandoning their home. Who knew?

There were still some hushed panicked conversations and some people who looked clearly overwhelmed, but for the most part, everyone did what they were told.

"We need to get some means of transport", she then said towards Adora and Scorpia.

"Transport?", Adora helpfully asked.

"We can't have a bunch of old people slow us down, so yeah, transport", Catra explained with practiced calm, despite the fact that Adora saw her eye twitch a little.

In order to not annoy her more — and destroy their fragile peace — she just nodded and ran off. She knew they had at least one horse that could pull a cart.

It wasn't hard to find Swift Wind, or to convince him to follow her — he had always been rather friendly, even when he couldn't talk. She also found a few carts along the way. In the background she could listen to Catra yelling at some people trying to take unnecessary stuff. Maybe she misheard, but did someone seriously try to drag along their sofa?

When Adora came back, she helped out wherever she could, just like Scorpia did. And Catra, sometimes. Mostly the girl seemed to be busy explaining the word 'necessary' to people.

She busied herself helping the sick and disabled get their stuff together and then hauling them into the cart. Whenever necessary, she also tried calming the children. Being a myth come to life helped a lot.

All in all, it took a little longer than an hour, though it was still early in the afternoon when they were done.

Catra quickly ordered everyone to be quiet as the panic started to grow again. The way her ears twitched, Adora guessed she also wanted to listen to her surroundings. When she was satisfied, she gave them the order to go.

Adora and Scorpia quickly got their own stuff from out from the bushes and then they were off.

Swift Wind pulled one cart, and Adora another because it turned out that a lot more people than expected needed some help.

Scorpia walked in the back, making sure they were safe — though what exactly she planned to do in case of an attack was unclear since she was kind of immobilized due to the box in her arms.

Catra walked in the front, a whole crowd of people away from Adora, clutching the files that had been stolen from the Fright Zone.

She would have to admit, though, that it was impressive how well the feline had made sure things happened somewhat orderly. Truth be told, despite knowing that her friend was promoted to Force Captain, she had never seen her actually act like it. Until now.

Had Catra been like that in the Fright Zone? If she could manage order in this town of panicked people, it was no wonder the Horde had gotten so much harder to defeat after she had gotten promoted.

And it didn't seem like the girl had any plans to sabotage anything. Maybe that was still coming, but Adora gained a lot

more faith in the girl after seeing her take responsibility so easily. If Catra truly wanted to, she would be a huge gain for the rebellion.

Chapter End Notes

I really hope this made sense. If not, you're free to leave constructive criticism <33

Next time, we're going to Brightmoon!

Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 3: Brightmoon

Chapter Summary

We're joining the rebellion!

Chapter Notes

Just a quick note:
I'm not going to be super realistic with how Angella handles her rebellion and guards. For one because I don't know anything about military, but mostly because I think it's funnier to stick with the canon xD
If Scorpia can sneak into a room full of princesses at the height of war, I'm not going to make Brightmoon super strict. So, there won't be extreme surveillance because canon Brightmoon has terrible security.

I hope you enjoy <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was paranoid on a good day and today was anything but. She couldn't believe she actually was about to join the princesses. If she wouldn't be so sure that Adora would simply kidnap her again if she tried to run off to live in the woods, she would have done that instead.

To make matters worse, she could feel Adora watching her. Had the entire time, even during the night. Like the blonde expected her to tear her throat out at any given moment.

Not that she could blame her. She had her own hesitations about her so called best friend.

And she most certainly started to regret this decision. But there was no going back. It has been days since they left the Fright Zone and there was no way they weren't all noted as defectors by now. She had no choice but to see this through.

She still hated it. With every step closer to Brightmoon she wanted to leave more desperately. Adora might be delusional enough to believe that this would work itself out, but Catra sincerely doubted that. However Adora convinced these people last time to trust her was beyond her understanding. Then again, the blonde was always loved by everyone.

Maybe the girl was right even, and her sunshiny attitude would save them. Yeah, as if.

They could only hope that the queen would at least hear them out.

It was already close to nightfall when the castle came into view, and Catra involuntarily slowed down at the sight, letting herself fall back into the crowd. She didn't fight the urge because considering what she was wearing, she did not want to be the first person to be spotted.

It wasn't until she bumped into someone and flinched that she realized she was possibly a bit scared. Not of the princesses, of course, but everything this meant for her. She wasn't a good person, no matter what Adora might believe. This was a terrible idea. But this was her thing, right? Making bad decisions. All she could do now was wait for the consequences of this one.

"Are we there already?", Adora asked somewhere behind her. Close, too close.

Catra took a deep breath and smoothed over her hair to calm down. "Yeah, Brightmoon in all its pastel glory", she grumbled.

She looked over into the woods again. If she entered that castle, she could still run theoretically, but it would be harder for her to convince herself to do it.

"Please stay." It was quiet, but she heard it regardless. Only her, and no one else because even after all this time, Adora still knew the perfect cadence that went undetected by everyone but her. And of course the girl knew what Catra was thinking too.

She sighed. "That's low", she responded to her own words being used against her.

The girl had the guts to smile. She glowed brighter too. "You know nothing's too low for me."

"I'm starting to believe that", she mumbled, holding onto the files, she had taken over carrying, tighter. She felt incredibly uncomfortable. This was weird. After days of distant silence and carefully watching each other's moves, Adora suddenly wanted to be soft?

"I should probably go in first… Explain, calm people down", the blonde said awkwardly then, before she carefully let go of the cart to rush to the beginning of the crowd. Thank goodness — Catra felt much better with a sea of people between them.

Scorpia took over pulling duty silently, handing her box of belongings to some elderly woman with her usually cheery smile. Well, she was silent until they started walking again. "Sorry again. Because of the stinging", the woman muttered.

"Whatever", Catra said. She had better things to worry about than this tiny bit of betrayal that can't even be called that considering that Scorpia did not know her anymore. They weren't close. Not like they ever were.

"You seemed really angry the other day", Scorpia pointed out.

She sighed. This woman just couldn't let things be. "Maybe a little. It's fine, though", she lied.

There was a sigh of relief next to her. "Well I'm glad you can forgive me. And you do seem to be a lot more calm than in the Fright Zone, so that's good, too."

Catra didn't exactly feel calm, but she wasn't pacing or tearing walls down, so she supposed she appeared very calm to the woman who has yet to learn how wrong that assumption was.

"So, are you nervous? I'm nervous", Scorpia then rambled. "It's just… My family never fit in with the princesses, you know? Adora said they would be nice, but I guess I'm still a little worried. Aren't you?"

Scorpia was an idiot, but soft and too kind for the Horde. "You'll fit right in, they'll love you", she said, but the woman didn't look like she believed it.

"I don't know", the other mumbled, but didn't notice that Catra had avoided her question.

She was very worried, though not much about the question of belonging. Catra knew that where Scorpia would fit like a missing puzzle piece, she would clash with everything and everyone there. She would never belong with the princesses.

As they got closer to Brightmoon again, Scorpia quieted down — probably the nervousness.

Catra could see some guards guiding the people somewhere, so it seemed like Adora had at least already informed them about what happened and why all these people were here, but she could not see the girl in question anywhere.

That would be her best opportunity if she wanted to run. But where to? Even if she had thought about it earlier, she could hardly live in the woods. And as fun as it had been, she didn't want to be all alone in the waste. She was a defector, so even if she wanted to, she couldn't go back to the Fright Zone either.

With a sigh, she resigned herself to her fate.

Closer to the entrance, she finally spotted the queen, Sparkles and Arrow Boy, who all tensely glanced between the refugees and Adora — well, She-Ra — as the blonde probably tried to explain what had happened. From all the confused looks, she seemed to be doing an awful job.

Catra took a deep breath and made sure to stand tall, then signaled to Scorpia that they would need to make their way over. The woman got her box back and followed.

The little crowd of three soon turned to the two and their obvious connection to the Horde.

Scorpia waved awkwardly as Adora kept rambling on about the fact that they had helped evacuate and to please not arrest them.

The queen eventually just held up a hand, making the girl go quiet. "We will take care of these people", she then said towards the villagers. "As for all of you…

"I can explain", Adora interrupted, which raised a lot of eyebrows. "If you let me, I can explain everything and I promise we're here to help." If the blonde was willing to interrupt an authority figure, her anxiety must be intense.

"We'll discuss this in the throne room", the queen said, but didn't look like she had a lot of trust in this.

Neither did Sparkles, who glared at them with suspicion. At least Arrow Boy seemed a bit hopeful. That guy was always weirdly positive, the exact attitude that had made him so easily usable the last time Catra had spend longer time with them.

They walked behind them on the way to the throne room, to guard them probably.

And it was a long walk, but it did give her an opportunity to see the castle from the inside. Scorpia was certainly fascinated by the pretty colors and decor. Catra was only disgusted by all the brightness.

When they made it to the brightest room, a big hall that led to a hovering throne at the end, that the queen took a seat in, she regretted her decision of coming here more than ever.

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This could have gone better, Adora decided as they walked to the throne room. Not only had she been so overwhelmed when the queen suddenly stood next to her — she really was alive, thank goodness — she also had no real idea how to actually explain any of this.

Trying to ground herself now, she stared mostly at Angella, who was still alive. She had another chance to make sure Glimmer's family wouldn't be ripped apart even more than it already was. Speaking of, the princess glared at her and her companions like she was ready to go for the kill if she had to. Knowing her that was probably even accurate.

She glanced back at Catra, who looked grumpier than usual and etched slight claw marks into the files in her hands, which did nothing for Adora's nerves.

Eventually, though, they entered the throne room and under the gaze of everyone there, she tried to look a bit more confident. Being taller than everyone helped a lot. She had to get a grip if she wanted to convince Angella to let them stay, considering that she didn't have Glimmer and Bow on her side this time.

"I know the legend of the warrior the First Ones called She-Ra", the queen then said, starting this possibly very difficult conversation. "They said she would return to us in the hour of our greatest need to bring balance to Etheria. I never thought she was anything more than a myth and yet you're here now. With two Horde soldiers and a claim that you have evacuated a village to safe them from the Horde." She looked at them all individually for a few seconds. "Do you understand why I have a hard time trusting this?"

"I do", she answered honestly and didn't really know what else to say.

The queen sighed. "You are not the first people to defect from the Horde. However, you are the first to come here. With a mythological princess. You said you can explain. Please do", she prompted.

Well, here goes. "Your majesty", she started off well enough. "My name is Adora and I was… chosen to carry the sword of She-Ra." Let's start with that, though she hated using Light Hope's words here, but that's what it was, right? No choice of her own, but one made by others. "Those are Catra and *princess* Scorpia." She felt the need to make that clear — they were two princesses. "We …" She glanced back at Catra in particular, making sure she didn't mess up again. When the girl shrugged subtly, she hoped she read that correctly. "We have come to pledge ourselves to the rebellion."

While surely not the most surprising thing the queen must have heard today, she still looked slightly shocked.

"All of us have seen what the Horde is capable of and it's not right. They told us that we were doing good. That we would bring order to Etheria. That the princesses were dangerous. But that's not true. The Horde has lied to us and hurt us and the planet." She wasn't all too sure about her decision to disclose all that, but if nothing else, Angella looked a bit more sympathetic. "We were also told that Thaymor was a rebel fortress. We… might not be able to save the town, but we wanted to safe the people. They are innocent and shouldn't be hurt by the Horde's manipulation."

The queen looked conflicted. "We", she then said and Adora blinked in confusion. "That's what you said. Like you were part of the Horde, too."

"Well…", she mumbled and let She-Ra fall away, earning some loud gasps. "I was. I… was getting these dreams of the sword. I went and searched for it and… saw all the destruction. I hadn't realized before… well, I had, but not to this extend", she stumbled her way through the words. She would be lying if she said that she had never seen the atrocities of the Horde — she did grow up

with Catra, after all — but she had still believed in the big scheme of things.

Adora risked a glance over to said feline and saw the last bit of an eye roll. This was going terribly on every front.

"Your majesty", she started again because she just couldn't be quiet. "I know that we can help you defeat the Horde. I mean, I'm She-Ra, so that's… something. We also have knowledge. And Catra is an amazing strategist and Scorpia is really strong and I promise we don't have any reason to go back or betray you. Please… give us a chance."

She was vaguely aware of her growing panic and desperation, and the fact that she had no way of knowing if Catra really would not betray them or even want to help. But.. she supposed she did believe it.

Since the queen seemed to mull it over, she risked a glance back to the feline who pointedly avoided her gaze. She did not know whether that was good or bad.

"Alright", Angella eventually said carefully. "You will have to earn my trust, but I am willing to give you a chance. *If* you are truly willing to stand against those you once served."

"Yes." There was no hesitation. She was determined to make things right this time.

Angella's gaze shifted behind her and Adora couldn't help but turn around too.

"Yeah, I mean… I was never really attached to the Horde", Scorpia said awkwardly, maybe a little bit unsure, but she looked determined enough to believable.

Catra, though, was a different question. It was one thing for Adora to say they'd all join, and another for the girl to make that admission herself.

She didn't stare at her spot on the wall anymore and directly at the queen, but she was clearly hostile — her claws were out and her tail was way too still. Her eyes seemed to look through Angella's act, though she doubted there was one, then she shifted her gaze towards Adora, and she was sure she must look very pleading.

They stared at each other for a long time. She couldn't say if it had been seconds or minutes. Eventually, the feline's eyes seemed to soften a little — she might just be imagining things, though.

"Sure", was the eventual answer as she looked back at the queen, and while Adora let out a sigh of relief, she also knew that it wasn't a particularly strong answer. "I have no reason to go back. Other than to hurt someone", she added towards Angella specifically, who looked very skeptical.

Now Adora focused her pleading look on the queen.

"I do appreciate what you have done for my people today", the woman said then. It was a careful statement, like it was more for show than an actual truth. "The rebellion accepts your allegiance", she called out, loud enough for the farthest person in the room to hear it. "If you give me a reason to believe you are still a threat to us, I will deal with you accordingly", she added more quietly.

"That is fair, your majesty", she said and nodded because it was. Very fair, considering the circumstances. "We won't disappoint you."

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All in all, that went better than Catra had expected. Sure, nobody here trusted them and judging by the queen's reaction throughout, She-Ra didn't sway her as much as Adora's evident

desperation. And the woman's own probably did a good deal as well. She could use any help she could get and she knew it.

That didn't mean they were trusted, however.

Some guards led them through the halls and s has felt the eyes of everyone on her all the way to the door, though the stares didn't exactly stop out on the hallway.

Catra was used to feeling watched, especially after being stuck with Adora for the last couple days, but something about being in this place made it worse.

Obviously the Evil Horde would be fine with mass surveillance and she has not exactly known privacy her entire life, but to be watched like this on the supposed good side did rub her the wrong way.

She also couldn't help but feel like they were watching her specifically. Her response to the queen's question hadn't been as immediate or enthusiastic as the other two's, but did that seriously warrant all the whispers and stares?

They probably thought she wouldn't notice, but she did. And she had very good hearing. Enough to hear what they had to say about them. Some talked about She-Ra — a mix of awe, doubts and confusion— but some also about Catra — being worried about her commitment more specifically.

"Should I take that back?", Adora chose the worst time to ask.

Catra was sure she just meant well since the files were technically hers, but she only growled in response and clutched her lifeline harder. She just had to hold onto something.

"No, then", the blonde mumbled.

Soon enough they were shown a bedroom that was thrice the size of their barracks. And unnecessarily decorated. Was that a waterfall?

The guard mumbled something about more mattresses or whatever since the room currently only had one very fluffy bed. Catra was honestly scared to touch it because she was sure her claws would make that thing explode in an instant.

"Wow", Scorpia chuckled — at least one of them was having fun. "This looks… wow. Is that for showering?", she asked, pointing at the waterfall.

"No", Adora told her. "Though, I don't know what it is for. The bathroom's over there", she pointed to a door that the woman immediately opened and went to explore, without questioning how the blonde possibly knew any of that without any prior exploration.

Adora then looked over to her and Catra already dreaded whatever was going to come out of the girl's mouth, but luckily two more people materialized in the room before a word could be spoken. She has never been so happy to see Sparkles in her life.

"Hi", Arrow Boy said with a smile and wave. At the new voice Scorpia peaked back out of the bathroom. "I'm Bow, that's Glimmer", he then introduced, carefully like he was looking at a startled animal. "We're just checking in."

"Checking you can be trusted", Sparkles said, glaring all the while.

To her surprise Adora spoke up. "Not everyone in the Horde is evil", she defended with a sigh — like it wasn't the first time she has had this discussion.

"Exhibit A and B", Catra mumbled, pointing at both the blonde and Scorpia.

Sparkles scoffed. "You're literally called the 'Evil Horde'."

"Yes, because the Horde is evil. But a lot of people who live there aren't", Adora tried to explain. "A lot of us have been there since we were babies. It's manipulation, that doesn't make them bad."

"Wait, what? Since babies?", Arrow Boy asked. "That's so sad." Even the princess looked a bit taken aback.

Catra rolled her eyes. "You haven't even heard half of it", she grumbled.

"You saved the people of Thaymor", Sparkles quickly gathered herself. "Though, we have yet to see if *that* was just manipulation." She glared at them some more before changing her face into a look of confusion. "But, assuming you haven't lied… why Thaymor? It's just a civilian town. Why would the Horde want to attack that?"

"I don't know", Adora mumbled. "For territory, probably?"

"Probably?", the princess mocked and crossed her arms.

"We aren't told these things, okay? I can only guess what the big plan is", Adora responded surprisingly aggressive. And here Catra thought, these people were the smiles-and-rainbows type of friends.

"We're also conditioned not to care", Catra added again and earned a frustrated groan from the princess.

"Then why do *you* care?", she snapped.

"Who said I do?", she replied with a smirk. "Don't get it twisted, Sparkles, I'm only here because I have nowhere else to be."

"Okay, first of all, my name is Glimmer", the girl told her sternly. It might have more effect if she didn't lose glitter with every movement. "And secondly, that is a terrible reason to change sides."

"Oh, well, if you don't want any help, I can go back…", she offered — there was no way she could actually do that, but it was always fun to get a rise out of the princess.

"Catra!", Adora yelled at the same time that Sparkles let out a panicked "No!"

Maybe this would be more fun than she had expected.

The princess took a deep breath. "You are seriously here to help?", she then asked, with another suspicious glare.

"Yes", Adora quickly jumped in. "We are."

Sparkles hummed, but didn't give any other answer to the statement. Arrow Boy stepped in for her. "So, we're also here to tell you that most other rooms have been out of use for so long, they need some cleaning before they're inhabitable again, so you'll have to share for a few days… sorry", he changed the topic.

"I don't think that'll be a problem", Adora responded, which made sense. Despite the fact that all of them have spend a good while sleeping on their own, they were still used to sharing, given the fact that, until promoted, they all slept in barracks of twelve people.

Arrow Boy seemed a bit confused, but nodded anyway. "We'll get you mattresses, blankets and pillows so you at least have some space to yourself. After dinner, though. Are you hungry? We can show around and then get food", he offered.

Catra started to have a lot of questions. After the queen told them that she didn't trust them at all, she had expected that they would be something like prisoners for a while. If this was how they treated the people they did not trust, it was no wonder that the rebellion was losing.

"Oh!", Scorpia then chimed in. "What's the schedule like?", she asked and was stared at with more confusion. She chuckled awkwardly. "You know, what are the times for eating, training… that stuff."

"Oh…", Sparkles exclaimed. "There isn't any. I mean, most people will eat at around nine, one and six, but you can get food at any

other time too. There isn't really a set time for training either, it's just whenever you feel like it. There might be meetings, but you'll be notified of that. *If* mom allows you to come."

Seriously? If they just did everything *whenever they felt like it*, how did they get anything done?

"Well, I could eat", Adora then said, looking somewhat excited and Catra swallowed down a remark that the girl was always up for eating. Even the disgusting ration bars have been hurled down like it was the most delicious thing on the planet.

Arrow Boy chuckled. "Then let's go. We'll give you a little tour on the way. So down the hall is Glimmer's room, if you need anything, and a bit further is my room. Seriously, whatever you need, just ask", he rambled on as he moved to the door.

"Bow!", Sparkles complained. "We don't know these people, don't tell them where I sleep", she hissed.

"Well, we can't treat them like enemies. That's no way to behave", he hissed back.

The princess groaned, but didn't argue. "Just to be clear, you're just in here because it was the only free room. And this way, we can keep an eye on you. The guards too since they're mostly stationed around here", she clarified then, as they all filed out of the room.

Catra slowly fell behind and stayed in the room just before the door closed. She just wasn't in the mood for having dinner with the princesses. She wasn't really feeling hungry, either. And she wanted to be alone.

She walked over to the window and looked outside. There was a garden right under her. Leaning her head outside, she saw a few windows, but none that looked like there was life behind it. Good.

It wasn't that far down, so she jumped, landing gracefully on her feet. For the simple fact that anyone could spot her out here at

any time, she quickly ducked behind a few bushes and, by doing that, found a little house that was full of flowers. She had no idea what it was, but it smelled nice and was the best hiding spot she could find.

So, she sat there, staring into nothing.

What now? Being here, she had to admit, wasn't as bad as she had imagined it to be, but it didn't stop her from feeling weird about it. She had honestly joined the rebellion. Maybe she had lost her mind in that portal.

But what use would it have been to stay in the Fright Zone? Why try again to be Hordak's second in command when she was so easily disposable to the Crimson Waste?

In the end, she didn't *have* to pledge herself to the rebellion, but she did because… well, she hadn't lied, she had nowhere else to go. And maybe she had been just the tiniest bit swayed by Adora's casual praise of her abilities.

And who knows? If Catra hadn't agreed as well, maybe the queen would have rejected them all and then what?

Adora … didn't seem to fully hate her. The girl didn't trust her and analyzed her every move, but she did *not* hate her. Somehow she believed that.

If she had ruined this for her, though, she surely would have hated her forever.

This wasn't a bad place to be, she guessed. But she would be damned if she slept in the same room as Adora.

Not that she would sleep, but that was exactly the problem. Neither of the two could know or they would only worry and bother her about it and she didn't want that.

This place was nice, safe from the wind too. She would just stay here with the files, maybe do some reading. She would see where

the night took her.

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She was ashamed to admit that she didn't notice Catra was missing until they all arrived at the dining hall.

While receiving a tour — that she already knew, but she still enjoyed hanging out with Bow and Glimmer — and then getting to the awesomely smelling dining hall, she had been a bit distracted. But when they made it to the last stop (the food), she wanted to see Catra's reaction, but the girl wasn't there. She wasn't anywhere.

"Where are we supposed to sit?", Scorpia asked while Adora was panicking a bit.

"Anywhere, really", Bow answered. "We usually sit over there. Looks like Spinnerella and Netossa are already there, but don't worry, they're super nice. Even if we don't know what they do exactly."

Since there was no better option, Scorpia started to walk over there, but seemed to notice Adora not following, which was then she noticed the absence of a certain feline, too.

"Where's Catra?", the woman asked, quickly starting to look as panicked as Adora felt.

"She already betrayed us?", Glimmer mumbled, her arms crossed and looking like she had expected it.

Adora felt the need to defend the girl. "No, she didn't", she said sternly, even if she might be worried about the same thing. There was a tiny voice in her head that asked her what she had expected. If she was really stupid enough to believe nothing

would happen. "I'll look for her", she announced and turned to leave again, no matter how hungry she was. She just had to know.

But something stopped her. Well, someone. Bow. "Are you sure? She appeared rather… uh, grumpy earlier. Maybe she just wants to be alone", he pointed out and send a look to Glimmer, who rolled her eyes.

That was a possibility. "I guess", she admitted. "But I… I just want to check on her. Maybe something's wrong. She wouldn't just do this, there had to be a reason." She ignored the little voice telling her that she was probably the last person Catra wanted to see.

"Okay, if you think that's best", Bow said and send her an encouraging smile. He was always so open and nice, she really hoped they could rebuild the friendship they once had. That he didn't remember.

It felt a bit like back in the portal, just that, back then, she only had to trigger the others' memories, but this time they really had to put in the work again. And who knows if it will ever be the same.

"I don't trust it", Glimmer chimed in. "Maybe the reason is that she's evil. She did not really convince me with her 'Sure, I guess I'll join' attitude. I'm with Adora, we should find her and make sure she isn't up to anything."

Now, it was starting to get a bit offensive. "She won't be up to anything", she defended again. "It's not like she has anything to be up to. Not like she knows anything to relay to the Horde, which she has no way of doing", she pointed out.

"Maybe", the girl grumbled. "But… come on! You and Scorpia I believed, I mean, I believed you *enough*, but her? I don't trust her."

She sighed. "I'm sure she's just processing. This is a lot for her. I'll find her."

"I'm coming with you", Glimmer then said, falling into step with her. "I can hardly leave you alone when you're only here on a chance. Who knows? Maybe you and her have some plan."

"We don't", she replied. "We barely even talked to each other at all since we left the Fright Zone and the one time we did, we yelled."

Glimmer stared at her, making her slightly uncomfortable. "I thought you were friends. With the little looks between you two... You give off vibes."

"Vibes?", she repeated confused. What was that supposed to mean?

The girl shrugged. "Yeah, like you've known each other for a long time."

"We have", she admitted. "We have been friends. We just… I don't know, it's complicated."

Glimmer only hummed in response and didn't have any more time to respond anyway, since they have reached the room.

"Catra?", Adora called out, but didn't receive an answer.

Catra wasn't the person for hiding. She was stubborn and angry and she would fight against anything that came her way. Only on very few occasions did she hide and that usually didn't mean anything good.

Whenever she did resort to hiding, though, Adora could usually at least see her tail somewhere, or the glow of her eyes. Some sign of where the other was, but now there was nothing.

Then she noticed the open window and looked outside. It lead to the garden.

It wasn't a great clue, but it was something. She let Glimmer know of her destination and then let herself get teleported down.

Catra might have just jumped out, but unlike her, Adora couldn't do that without at least breaking her legs, if she would even land on them. Honestly, how did Catra do that?

"Catra!", she called out again. She really hoped the girl didn't leave Brightmoon completely. Catra had looked back into the woods a lot earlier, and she had been very hesitant to agree to stay, it wasn't impossible. And there was still no sign of her. A fact that made Glimmer look downright smug.

Alright, she had to think. If she were Catra, where would she hide? A tree probably.

Checking all the trees, she found no trace of anyone having been there lately, though she did see the garden house behind a few overgrown bushes. It was very well hidden, perfect for a girl who didn't want to be seen.

She went over and peaked around the corner. "Catra?", she called out, but didn't necessarily expect an answer. Not that she needed one. The tail was always the hardest part for her to hide.

"I don't want to see you, piss off", Catra grumbled when Adora was about to sit down next to her. "Both of you", she added with a glare in Glimmer's direction, that was eagerly reciprocated.

Adora naturally ignored her. "Could you give us a bit of privacy?", she asked towards the princess and sat down.

Glimmer now eyed them both skeptically, but went to wait outside. They were still visible to each other, since the house was made of glass, and the girl could surely still hear them, too. Adora therefore tried to whisper as quietly as she possibly could — Catra's super hearing was very practical.

"What's going on?", she asked.

Catra took a deep breath and probably tried to keep her frustration at bay. "Like I'd wanna talk about it with you", she

spat, barely bothering to whisper, but Adora didn't take it personally.

She probably should, but she never could whenever Catra was like this. On the battle field it was different because it *was* personal. This was just defense. "It always helped", she tried again.

"Yeah, well, a lot has changed. Our talk the other day didn't magically fix us, Adora."

"I know", Adora easily agreed. "But I thought we could at least try. I told you, I want you back. And I really want to forgive you."

"You're an idiot, then", the other said with a scoff.

Honestly, what did she expect? "And you're an ass", Adora responded. She let a bit of silence settle between them while she debated what she was supposed to say next.

Having known Catra for almost two decades didn't particularly mean that she knew her well. She knew a lot about her, but a lot of times, what went on in that girl's head evaded her. Which was probably the reason, they ended up enemies in the first place.

There were a lot of things she could say, clearing the air a bit, making misunderstandings disappear. They've hadn't had a chance to really talk in … a while. Or she could ask questions that the other probably wouldn't answer anyway. None of it felt appropriate at the moment, though. Especially with Glimmer still outside.

Still, she didn't feel comfortable leaving the other girl like this. Maybe they should start small? But what qualified as small? When had it become so difficult to talk to the other girl? She supposed somewhere between being dropped off a cliff at the Crystal Castle and being kidnapped in the Crimson Waste.

"Catra?", she tried getting the other's attention even if she had no clue how to continue from there.

"We should talk about what we do now", Catra interrupted her, a proper whisper this time.

"What?" Adora was caught a bit off guard.

"You want me to help the rebellion, so we should discuss it. We need a plan if you want to win this", she explained a bit more, getting even more quiet — so much so, that Adora really had to strain herself to still hear it.

"Oh", she mumbled. It shouldn't surprise her that Catra would think about winning before their broken relationship, though by the bitterness in the girl's voice, she suspected that Catra might use the topic as a distraction instead of having actual ambitions about it. "Well… with the lack of trust we have, I don't know how much we can plan", she pointed out.

"It's better to have something in case we need it, don't you think?", the girl asked with just a little bit of a growl.

Adora thought for a moment. Catra did have a point. "I'm sure Glimmer will push her idea of actually fighting the Horde and rebuilding the Princess Alliance. The queen is against direct confrontation, but maybe we can support the recruitment missions. Might also be a good way to earn her trust", she offered.

"Good." Catra nodded. She didn't seem to have anything more to say to that.

"Okay", she mumbled into the silence. She really wanted to keep their conversation going, but she shouldn't push the other. And Glimmer was still there, too, probably bored out of her mind. Speaking of Glimmer… "Are you coming inside?"

A few seconds passed, then Catra got up. Adora thought that would be the answer, but the girl stopped by the door to talk to Glimmer. "Can I stay out here a bit?", she asked. "Or will you freak out?"

The princess glared again. "Are you still gonna be here in the morning?", she responded with a question of her own.

"I'll be here."

Glimmer groaned. "I'll have to tell a guard to keep an eye on you", she said and rolled her eyes for good measure.

Catra looked a bit startled for a second, like she hadn't expected that. To be fair, Adora hadn't either.

The two nodded at each other once and then the feline went back to her spot. With that, the matter seemed to be settled.

Adora watched with mild confusion. She wanted to ask for some clarification, when Glimmer already started to leave. She was still rooted to her spot, frozen with all her questions.

"Adora", Catra called out, a bit of annoyance evident in her voice. "I'll still be here. Promise."

That did not get her out of her frozen state. In fact, it might have worsened it. They didn't make a lot of promises over their time, but whenever they did they were holy. Their very first had been broken several times over the past months. Being enemies had done a lot of damage, but that's why this meant more than any other thing either of them could have said.

Eventually, she turned to follow Glimmer back inside, but she felt this inexplicable urge to say something before she did. The problem was, that she didn't know how to put the feeling inside her into words. "I missed you", was what left her. Then she turned to the garden.

Glimmer waited next to a guard, who would watch the greenhouse from a respectable distance. "That was more convincing than whatever happened earlier", the princess mumbled before she grabbed Adora and teleported them back to the dining hall.

Adora had to agree. It had been more convincing. She wholeheartedly believed that Catra would not leave and it filled her with a calm she hadn't felt in months.

Chapter End Notes

As alway, I hope you liked it <33

until next time, stay hydrated <33

Chapter 4: First Day

Chapter Notes

> I think this can be considered a filler... Like, there's something happening, but I have a hard time coming up with a summary. It's the first day, some shenanigans, some tension. Hopefully fun?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wasn't a fan of sleeping. Never really has been — she couldn't remember a time in her life in which she didn't regularly wake up screaming after a nightmare.

Lately, though, it had been getting worse. With Shadow Weaver's betrayal and her death sentence, directly followed by the events of the portal … she hadn't slept at all anymore. She had let herself rest, making sure that she was still able to function, but she couldn't allow herself to sleep.

She spent the better part of the night turning in the sheets that Adora had brought her later in the evening and tried to stay awake while also not thinking about her decision too hard.

The other nights she had been able to keep herself busy. In the woods, she had her thoughts and doubts to occupy herself with and before that…

Technically, she had lied to Adora that first night back in the past. She had been up for far more than an hour by the time the blonde had confronted her.

Catra didn't know why she had woken up so much earlier, but she had, and she had spent her time running around, trying to figure out the situation, noticing the difference in organization, the schedules, the wall that Emily had destroyed completely intact. She had even snuck onto the transport for Beast Island, checking if Entrapta was there, but she wasn't.

She also didn't know why she had felt the need to lie to Adora. After all, she had just checked a few things, nothing noteworthy to lie about. Well, except the thing about Entrapta. She couldn't confess that to anyone, least of all Adora.

It didn't happen anymore, anyway. There was no reason for anyone to know.

And thinking about it only made her feel terrible. So, after a few close calls with sleep, she dragged herself out of the little shed and started to wander through the castle.

The guard that had been left in charge of her had startled when she had walked out, but dutifully followed her. It was annoying, but not as annoying as all the other guards around that kept sending her odd looks. Catra would hiss at them occasionally, which made them mind their own business again.

She didn't really know what she was doing here, other than walking. By now, she was a bit hungry, but despite what Sparkles had said about being able to get food whenever, she doubted that would work when the cooks were asleep. Discovering the place also wasn't an option — she didn't think it wise to wake people in her endeavors.

So, she just … paced. It wasn't much different from what she did in the Fright Zone and the familiarity of the motions did calm her a bit. And her guard could clearly use the cardio.

Catra only stopped once. In front of a mural of a man. He must have been important to get an entire wall dedicated to him.

"My husband." The voice startled her and she instinctively got into a fighting stance, her claws out and ready to pounce. But then she saw the queen and forced herself to relax. The woman didn't seem to mind her hostile reaction, at least. More like she had expected it even. "King Micah. He built the rebellion with me and he was one of the first casualties of the Horde", she explained, shooting her a glare.

Catra ignored it. "What happened?", she asked instead of offering a reaction. She didn't care what the queen thought of her, but she was curious.

"I wasn't present at the scene", the woman said, surprisingly. With the obvious distrust between them, she had not actually expected an answer. "He had been captured." The queen looked away, clearly trying to keep it together.

"He has been sent to Beast Island, probably", she mumbled, not knowing what else to do. Or say. She wasn't good with feelings and stuff.

The queen looked at her again with furrowed brows. "Beast Island?"

"Yeah, it's…" The place she had been almost sent to die, too. The place she had send Entrapta to… She cleared her throat. "It's a deadly place where the Horde sends traitors and sometimes captures", she said then, sounding more put together than she felt.

"How deadly is it exactly?", she queen hesitantly asked.

"I don't know. I haven't been there. But the stories we heard weren't great." They were terrifying in fact. But she was sure that was not what the woman wanted to hear.

"What is your name again?" That was unexpected.

"Catra", she told her because why not. The woman would learn it anyway over time. Since she was stuck here now.

For a moment, it looked like the queen was about to ask or say something else. Or maybe she was just trying to figure Catra out. It was hard to tell. Eventually, though, she seemed to decide not to say whatever she was thinking, which was a bit relieving.

"I'll leave you to it", Catra mumbled when she was sure the conversation was over. She wasn't very eager to hang out with the

winged lady much longer either, so she turned to leave.

"Catra?", the woman called out however. The girl in question turned back around to stare at the queen questioningly. "I know that Glimmer has allowed you some … leeway. I want to disallow you from making camp in hiding, but I do trust my daughter."

She waited a few seconds for something more — a threat, an insult, anything — but it seemed that the queen had just wanted to let her know. "I just don't want to share a room with Adora. Or Scorpia", she replied because the woman still looked at her expectantly.

Now she looked surprised. "I see", she said, though Catra highly doubted that.

Since nothing else followed, Catra slowly walked away from this odd conversation. The queen didn't stop her, so she assumed that this moment really was over. And thank goodness for that.

She sincerely didn't understand these people.

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Adora's morning was like any other had been in the last few months. Apart from Scorpia, of course, and the guards that followed them down to the dining hall.

What did remain the same, though, was the lack of Catra, who did not just spend a bit longer outside, but had decided to sleep there, too. Anything to get away from Adora, it seemed.

It was way too early for that, though, and she wanted to think about food now. She loved Brightmoon's food, and she loved the dining hall — possibly because it felt comfortingly familiar to the Fright Zone where everyone would eat in the same place, too.

She knew that the royal family technically had their own private rooms to dine, but as far as she knew they barely ever used it. Probably because Glimmer liked to sit with everyone, and … did Angella even need to eat? That was probably an inappropriate thought.

With a slight shake of her head, she decided to distract herself with Scorpia, who was unusually silent and kept looking around like she was searching for something.

Before she could ask, however, they reached the dining hall and her unasked questioned answered itself.

Adora barely managed to process the picture in front of her before Scorpia ran over to Catra, who sat alone at a table, munching on a piece of bread.

It seemed that even Catra, with her quick reflexes, couldn't process fast enough to avoid the crushing hug that Scorpia engulfed her in immediately. "Oh, I was so worried! I am so glad to see you", she said all while Catra struggled to get out of the woman's tight grip.

"Let me go!", she screeched, but wasn't really heard. Her one advantage was her flexibility, though, which was how she managed to wriggle free eventually and reinstated a rather big distance. "You seriously need to learn something about personal space!"

Once again, Scorpia all but ignored the girl's complains and kept gushing about her, even if from a distance. "When you were suddenly gone, I was worried something had happened or you needed help. I hope you're okay now. Did you sleep well? Did you sleep?", she rambled on and Catra didn't respond to a single thing.

She didn't need to when the rings under her eyes were dark enough to answer for her.

“Scorpia”, the girl growled in warning after a minute of this. It was impressive she held up this long. Not that the woman seemed to get the hint.

Adora decided to intervene then — it wouldn't do anyone any good if Catra decided to get violent. "Scorpia! I wanna show you something, it's delicious", she said and all but dragged the other with her.

She had no clue what she was going to show her, but she was sure she could find something. At least Catra looked … well, she still looked pissed, but not close to committing murder anymore. And Scorpia looked sufficiently distracted.

“You should try the bread, it’s great and really soft”, she told the woman. “Put something on it, though.”

“Like what?”, she asked, a plate already in hand, but looking slightly overwhelmed.

She let her gaze wander over the spread. “Try this”, she pointed at the marmalade. “It’s sweet and a bit sticky, but I think you’ll love it. If you don’t want it sweet, there’s also that.” She now pointed to what she thinks was called salami. “It’s meat.”

Scorpia carefully put something on her plate. Since yesterday's food didn't kill her, it should be clear to assume that this wouldn't be a threat either and yet the woman treated it like one.

Adora shook her head a little. "Oh, and you really should try the pudding", she just kept going. "It looks absolutely disgusting, but it's one of the best things I've ever eaten", she declared. The dish was certainly up in her top three.

She loaded her own plate and packed one for Catra as well. Of course, she couldn’t be sure how much the girl had already eaten, but it didn’t look like a lot and she had also skipped dinner.

Back at the table, Adora put one plate in front of Catra and sat down next to her. Scorpia naturally took the other side.

“What’s this?”, the feline asked, poking the tiny block of cheese with a claw.

“It’s called breakfast”, Adora replied unhelpfully and earned a glare. “It’s just a few things for you to try. Some meat, cheese. I know you don’t like sweets, so I skipped the marmalade.”

Catra stared at her. “I have no idea what you just said.”

Adora sighed. “Just eat it.”

They ate in silence, the same awkward one they have sat through while wandering in the woods, but at least she could enjoy the show of the two trying more of the goods Etheria had to offer. Scorpia still looked skeptical and inspected everything she put in her mouth, but once she did, her frown melted away completely and was replaced with awe.

While that was great, Catra certainly was the funnier one to watch because she tried to hide her reactions, putting up a front of disinterest and shrugging like she's had better.

Adora could only roll her eyes. Sure, the feline had tried a few things before — she had always loved to sneak some contraband for the two to eat. Adora, obviously, had been rule abiding and never touched any of it, but Catra has had not such hesitations.

Still, she has never tasted what Brightmoon’s kitchens had to offer.

“Stop staring at me”, the girl mumbled eventually, shooting Adora another glare. “You too”, she growled at Scorpia who tried hiding behind her pincers.

“You're no fun”, Adora said.

“I'm not here to be fun”, the other responded.

“Don't worry, you can not have fun later”, a new voice said. Glimmer, who rubbed the sleep from her eyes and looked like she

hadn't slept all night. Different than Catra, though, that probably wasn't true.

“Why?”, Scorpia asked who currently smeared a worrying amount of jelly on her bread.

“Meeting.” Glimmer groaned and let herself plop down at the table, making herself comfortable like she was going to take a nap here.

Adora didn't think much of it and scanned the crowd for Bow, who stood at the buffet. Then she remembered their current situation. “Is everyone coming?”, she asked because she wasn't sure if their given chance included being able to partake in meetings.

Glimmer didn't even look up. "Yup. Everyone's coming for some brainstorming or whatever. Mom wanted you there for some reason, I didn't ask", she mumbled. "I just don't know why we need to do this so early in the morning."

That was an exaggeration. Sure, it wasn't as late as Glimmer liked to get up, but as she had announced, breakfast was at nine. Hardly the earliest morning.

Now Bow joined them, too, putting a plate in front of Glimmer before sitting down with his own. "Well, I for one am excited", he said and happily spread butter on his bread.

“You're always excited”, Glimmer groaned, still head down on the table.

“Not always. I'm also terrified a lot”, he corrected. "But how could I not be excited today? We have new people in the rebellion and we get to hang out with them. And the meeting is also not *that* early. It's still a good while away."

Now, the princess did look up. "Oh, you're right! We wanted to give you guys makeovers!", she squealed with newfound excitement that rivaled Bow's.

"Absolutely not", Catra said immediately and it was exactly what Adora had expected. The girl loved to mock her for the jacket she had found and never stopped wearing, but the feline herself was no bit better.

Glimmer scoffed. "You're not allowed to say no. You can't keep walking around looking like Horde soldiers."

"Oh, so what you're saying is that to be a true part of the rebellion I have to develop a terrible fashion sense?", Catra mocked with the most innocent voice that Adora has ever heard.

The princess was fuming. Spinnerella and Netossa walked by then, and, noticing the tense atmosphere, decided to eat at a different table. Adora wanted to join them. "Listen here, Horde scum, if you think that just because you're allegedly here to help, I won't punch you in the face, you're wrong", Glimmer threatened.

Catra didn't look impressed. She just looked the other up and down and smirked. "Flirting already, Sparkles? And here I thought you were taken by Arrow Boy."

Adora couldn't look anymore. But before she could rest her head in her hands, she did see both Glimmer and Bow get redder than any tomato she had ever seen. Though Glimmer was probably more angry than flustered.

"How are you so infuriating to talk to?!", she seethed.

Adora peaked from under her hands a little and saw that Catra was the picture of relaxation. Judging from the smirk, she was enjoying this even. "Years of practice", she purred. *Purred*.

"You know what? Do whatever you want! Run around in Horde clothes. If we're lucky, you'll get killed by some vengeful townspeople!", the princess hissed.

Catra still didn't look impressed. "Does that mean I can leave?", she asked and earned something akin to a growl from Glimmer. So, she got up with a shrug and left, a guard in tow.

They all sat a bit in silence after, as they waited for Glimmer to calm down a bit, which she did. Slowly. And by brutally tearing apart her bread instead of using a knife. Then again, Adora wasn't sure she liked the idea of a knife in Glimmer's hand at the moment.

Somehow, if that was at all believable, the rest of breakfast got even more tense than before Glimmer and Bow had showed up.

"So… she's…", the boy tried to start a conversation and immediately deflated.

"She's the worst", Glimmer happily jumped in. "How did you manage to be friends with her?", she asked towards Adora.

"I … uh", she stammered, not expecting to be thrown into this conversation, though she really should have. "She used to be…" What? Catra had never been exactly nice. "Less angry?", she settled on.

Bow looked at her with a bit of pity and Glimmer just raised an eyebrow. "Seriously, what do you see in her? You didn't have anyone better in the Horde?"

"No." Her response was almost immediate. There was nothing to think about, she had wanted Catra to be her friend and she has never regretted that decision. Until they ended on opposites sides, at least. "She can be a really great friend. If she's not mad at you", she added quietly.

"What happened?", Bow then asked carefully. "I mean… maybe we can help?"

"I doubt it", she mumbled. "Catra won't put her grudges aside or even talk unless she wants to. You can't force that. Trust me, I tried." She took a deep breath. "It's fine. We'll be fine. How about we don't think about Catra and just… go look for clothes", she said maybe a bit too enthusiastically.

Glimmer and Bow exchanged a look, but apparently decided to let it be for now. They certainly weren't close enough to discuss this, which was a fact that made Adora feel sad and grateful at the same time.

They quietly finished up breakfast and made their way to the 'clothes room'.

"You know… maybe if we take her on a mission, show her that she can trust us, she might warm up to us", Bow said on the way.

"We can try", she replied, though she didn't have much faith in it.

"Glimmer and I wanted to rebuild the Princess Alliance for months now. She hopes that, with She-Ra, the queen will finally allow her a mission and if she does, we could take you all. I'm sure Catra has her good sides. It will be fun", he told her.

"Bow", Glimmer hissed. "Valuable information!"

The boy rolled his eyes. "Come on. They're invited to the meeting, they would have known soon anyway."

"Ugh, whatever", the girl grumbled. "But I doubt we'll take Catra anywhere. Who wants that? I don't."

"Well, I do", Bow responded easily. "I think, we just need to get to know her. Right Adora?"

"Huh? Oh, yeah… she can be really fun", she mumbled, but she had to admit, she wasn't quite sure if this idea with Catra would work out. That girl was so unbelievably stubborn, it was hard to imagine her being friends with anyone here.

Scorpia awkwardly cleared her throat and raised a pincer. "I would love to go on a mission", she said. "Nobody ever gave me a mission. I always wanted to know what the hype is about."

"We'll see", Glimmer sighed. "First, mom would have to agree. And then we can talk missions and whether you can be trusted to

come."

Bow shook his head. "Don't listen to her. The recruitment missions would be perfect for you to prove yourselves!"

The princess groaned with frustration. "Let's deal with clothes first", she changed the topic and lead them into the room that was full of piles of clothes that came from… somewhere. Adora didn't think she she ever asked.

For her, it was a relatively simple affair — she looked for the clothes that most resembled her current ones, as she was quite comfortable in her style, and already knew in which corner to look.

Scorpia was a bit more difficult, since they had to find something that fit over her exoskeleton. Everything that did, were pretty simple garments that didn't need much work to match them together to look good. So even that had been over and done with within an hour or so, much to Glimmer disappointment.

It was clear that she had wanted to dress them up like dolls a little, and she thought their choices in clothing were extremely boring. In the end, though, the Horde symbol was gone and she had to accept the situation.

Though, if the princess could ever be bothered to trust them enough, she could probably convince Scorpia to come on a shopping trip with her.

But for now, they had no time to stay much longer anyway, because the meeting was about to start.

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Catra had no idea what she was supposed to be doing, but she knew that she was not going to submit herself to Sparkles' clutches and taste in fashion.

So, she had taken to some more pacing, walking all around the borders of Brightmoon's castle. It was completely surrounded by the Whispering Woods and the ocean, which wasn't exactly new information to her.

She didn't dare going into town, so she went back inside the castle, wandering around the huge garden instead. When she was bored of that, she went to exploring a little — this time opening rooms.

Catra found the kitchen, the library, the barracks that were so much nicer than in the Fright Zone, another kitchen, eventually she made her way to the throne room again, there were several studies, and a ballroom.

What she had yet to find, was a meeting room.

Honestly, she had no idea when that dumb meeting was about to start, and the longer she walked around, the less she wanted to go. There was something about this place… it was too calm and it made her stand more on edge than normal.

The guards pissed her off, and with every minute she heard her personal shadow's steps behind her, the more she wanted to make sure he could never walk again.

She couldn't do that, though. And so, when she felt like she couldn't control her anger much longer, she locked herself into the next best room that she could find, which turned out to be Adora's. Just her luck, but at least the blonde wasn't here.

It was less calm in here. After just one night, the room felt lived in. Not chaotic — Adora was always the one that kept everything tidy for the both of them — but lively somehow.

Catra sat down one the clearly unused mattress on the ground and tried to soothe her rage a little.

Carefully, she combed her fingers through her hair, trying to get the knots out — it was a relaxing motion. Adora used to do that back in the day. The girl always loved Catra’s poofy hair and said she hated how her own was so thin.

A small fragile smile snuck into her face and she allowed it. For now, while no one was here to see.

It didn't matter how much she denied it, to everyone and herself, but she had not been feeling too unpleasant when she realized that Adora had come back for her, that the girl wanted her in her life, that it didn't matter how much she had tried to push her away. That she had never succeeded in that anyway.

She had thought they were finally done completely, after the portal, but it turned out that she was not getting rid of Adora that easily — not that almost destroying time and space should count as easy.

Nothing she had done had been easy. It had never been fun to hurt the other, even if she couldn't say she regretted it. After all, with the golden girl gone, Catra could finally climb the ranks in the Horde and gain recognition, which she had always wanted. Or at least that's what she had thought she wanted.

She remembered that Adora kept bringing it up since the portal — the question of what she wanted, that it can't be all of the things that have happened, but the truth was that she had wanted it. Still does.

Alright, maybe she didn't want to destroy the world anymore, but she still wanted to destroy. She still wanted to hurt people, still didn't want to live in Adora's shadow.

Did it suddenly make her a better person, just because she did it all on the side of the rebellion?

She didn't think so. Authority figures still hated her, the guards were afraid of her, just like the cadets in the Fright Zone had been. It didn't really make a difference to her where she was, just like she had expected it to be.

The only difference was that she now had much more free time that she spent driving herself crazy. She didn't have anything to do here and she could not keep thinking about this. Catra was here now, she was part fo the rebellion and there was hardly anything she could do about it now. And if she didn't stop thinking about it, she would just come back around to Adora or her other regrets eventually, and she was not ready for that.

Catra got up again, determined to go to that meeting, if only to have something to do.

When she opened the door, her assigned guard and everyone around him flinched. She ignored it. “There’s supposed to be a meeting. You know where?”, she asked and it might have come out just a little bit aggressive.

The guard swallowed, but didn’t answer, just pointed down the hall. Very helpful.

She rolled her eyes and went into that direction, occasionally looking back at him for more directions and otherwise randomly opening doors in hopes of finding the right one. It took her a lot longer than she had anticipated, but at some point she did manage to open the right one.

The meeting seemed to be in session already, but Catra didn’t care, simply sitting down on the nearest empty chair, which was right in-between Sparkles and Arrow Boy to her dismay.

“Catra”, the queen called to her. “How nice of you to join us.” She was obviously not thrilled that Catra was late.

“I got lost”, she gave an explanation. “Your guards are very unhelpful”, she added, earning a few gasps, most likely because she didn’t address the older woman properly and she wasn't

about to. She hadn’t even transcended the bare minimum of respect with Hordak and the guy was a lot scarier than the queen in front of her.

“They might be more helpful if they weren’t scared”, the older woman pointed out, looking at her with disappointment.

Catra scoffed. “If they can’t even answer a question because of a little terror, how are they supposed to fight a war?”, she shot back, earning more gasps.

The queen looked at her, clearly surprised by the directness, but eventually nodded. "Point taken", she mumbled.

Now it was Catra's turn to be surprised — she was not getting reprimanded?

“As I was saying”, the woman then got back on topic. “We have received word this morning that Horde forces have destroyed Thaymor", she told them sadly, then sternly looked at her three newcomers. Catra guessed that meant that their proven truthfulness was the reason they were even invited.

Some guard stood up then. "They have retreated for now, but we do not know what they are planning to do with the territory or if we stand a chance at rebuilding", they told the queen.

"You do not happen to know anything about that, do you?", the woman asked towards them.

"I'm afraid not, your majesty", Adora answered carefully.

The queen sighed. "Then we will have to see how the situation unfolds."

"Or, maybe we could-", Sparkles started to say, but was interrupted quickly.

"No, Glimmer", the older woman almost yelled out. "We will not put ourselves in danger. *You* will not put yourself in danger. Do not

think I have forgotten how you took unnecessary risks on your last mission."

The princess scoffed and took a breath to defend herself, but was quieted by the angry look of her mother. If Catra wouldn't be so sure that she would be thrown out by the girl herself, she would have laughed.

The queen cleared her throat. "I also have received a distress call from princess Perfuma. The Horde is laying siege to her kingdom and she's asking Brightmoon for assistance. General?" She sounded tired. Almost hopeless.

"Plumeria is located near the front lines. The Horde has set up camp in their territory, cutting off their main supply route", they explained. So that random guard wasn't so random after all. Good to know.

"Brightmoon will provide food and humanitarian aid", the queen decided, and Catra once again wondered how the rebellion ever expected to win.

Not to be one to agree with Sparkles, but if they never fought back, then of course they would lose. It's not like she could point that out, though, considering she was still the not-to-be-trusted Horde soldier.

"So", Sparkles said very awkwardly in her stead. "Speaking of…"

"Glimmer", the queen warned.

"Just hear me out! I've been thinking, Bow and Adora too", the princess started again and one look at Adora told Catra that the girl had apparently not been present at that conversation. "That we could recruit the other princesses, rebuild the Princess Alliance!"

"Glimmer", the queen sighed. They must have had this talk before.

“Nothing dangerous!”, Sparkles interrupted. “Just a few diplomatic missions.”

“Your majesty”, Adora now spoke up, though she did so with more hesitance than the princess. “I do think it’s a good idea, we can always use more allies”, she said before stopping shortly to look at Catra.

Did she want her to say something? Or was that the hint that the blonde wanted Catra as an ally? She furrowed her brows in response, but that just seemed to confuse the other.

The queen was done thinking about it anyway. “And how do you propose we go about this?”, she asked no one in particular.

"Well, we could go bring the supplies to Plumeria and maybe mention to Perfuma that she could join the rebellion", Glimmer suggested, standing up for better effect or something. "And then there are princess Mermista, Frosta and Entrapta, of course. We'll just go on a few, totally chill, diplomatic missions. Though, reaching the Kingdom of Snows might be a bit of a waste of time, considering the prom is right around the corner, but we could at least try to convince the other three for now."

A sigh left the older woman. "As much as I appreciate the idea to strengthen our defenses, I'm afraid the princesses withdrew from the last alliance. They have chosen to focus on protecting their own lands and have shown no signs of wanting to join forces."

"You see", Sparkles kept going, in no way discouraged — it was honestly a little admirable. "That's the good thing about a diplomatic mission. There's no risk. We just go and ask and the worst they can do is say no. Which they won't."

"Glimmer…"

"Besides! That was the old princesses. Their kids have all taken over now, which makes now the ideal time to take our chances", the princess added.

Another sigh. "I'm not sure. We do not have enough people available and you can hardly go alone."

"Your majesty", Arrow Boy said, standing up too now. And Catra was in the middle of these two maniacs. "A few diplomatic missions would be the ideal chance to take our newcomers to. See how they do, you know?", he suggested.

Adora had mentioned that this would probably be the next course of action, but Catra really didn't want to go anywhere near the other princesses.

The queen raised her eyebrows. "Are you sure that's a good idea?", she asked rather vaguely, probably to spare their feelings.

"I think they can be trusted", the boy said with a conviction that just felt wrong. "And it's not like Glimmer and I can't defend ourselves."

The woman did not look like she had much faith in that. She sighed again. "It's still dangerous. Plumeria is under siege and Salineas is a treacherous journey away."

"Don't worry. We have She-Ra now! We can conquer anything", Sparkles said again now. She too, with way too much confidence. And also, first Adora, now Sparkles — was She-Ra their answer to everything?

Catra risked another glance to Adora, who once again didn't look very comfortable with being thrown into this conversation as an argument.

"You will not *conquer* anything, Glimmer", the queen reprimanded. "I will allow you to go on diplomatic missions only. No engaging the Horde and no unnecessary dangers. No violence and no collateral damage."

Sparkles looked downright ecstatic. "Really?! Thanks, mom! You won't regret it."

"I really hope I don't", she mumbled in response and looked at the three former Horde soldiers once more with varying degrees of worry. But she kept her calm. "You will deliver food and supplies to Plumeria tomorrow. You can discuss how you want to arrange that later. Until then, we have other things to discuss. Glimmer, sit down."

The princess did so, but it didn't take away from her enthusiasm.

After that was done, they talked about other things, mostly the queen with the guards — border control, security, surveillance of Horde activity. If anyone had asked her, Catra would have had a lot to say and improve about it, but no one did, so she kept quiet.

She tried to listen though — any information could be useful, after all — but she was too hyper aware of the people around her.

Sitting between Sparkles and Arrow Boy, she was the subject of several quiet comments that apparently had to go somewhere. Scorpia was nervous and her constant stirring distracted her paranoid mind that saw danger in every movement in the corner of her eyes. Worst was Adora, though, who kept watching her like she expected Catra to run amok any second.

The blonde should really relax. Yes, she was annoyed, but mostly bored. No one was in any danger.

When the meeting was over after an hour or two — it was hard to tell — she wanted nothing more than to leave and hide out somewhere again. But she remembered that they had things left to discuss.

"Okay", Sparkles took the word again once it was only them left. "We have three missions, what's the plan?"

"Five people is too much", she said something for the first time in at least an hour. She still sat in-between the two most annoying people on the planet, who both shot her a look now.

"I think, the more the merrier", Arrow Boy told her.

"No, she has a point", Scorpia came to her rescue, surprisingly — the woman loved to be around people. "We don't wanna ambush people."

Sparkles sighed. "I guess", she reluctantly agreed. "But we can't exactly split up. Five is such a weird number."

"Why not?", Catra asked with a shrug. "You go in teams of two and two, and I go alone. Problem solved." She knew she couldn't do that, but it was worth a shot in her opinion.

"Yeah, no", the princess scoffed.

"We usually do things as a team", Arrow Boy chimed in and leaned in. She couldn't hold back the growl that build in her throat. He leaned a bit away from her.

"Bow is right", Sparkles said again. "Unfortunately, we are a team, even if we spit up. I say you always have to be at least in teams of two."

"Oh, that means we could do two missions at once", the boy exclaimed happily. "So, one team Glimmer and one team Bow!"

Did Catra still have the option to throw herself out of the window? Did this room even have one?

Alright, since that wasn't a possibility, she had to make a decision before these idiots made one for her. She certainly wasn't going sailing and she was not a fan of the flower people. She also wasn't eager to see Entrapta again.

Salineas was definitely out, but did she want to go to the hippies or her top three regret?

"I take Entrapta", she blurted out then. Before she spend time with more overly positive people, she preferred her nightmares.

A short silence of shock settled in. "That's… why?"

"Would you rather I don't go anywhere?", she asked with barely restrained annoyance.

"No… I mean, yes, kinda", Sparkles mumbled. "But that's not- I just want to know why Entrapta."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Why not Entrapta?", she replied with a question again, but only earned herself a glare. She sighed. "I don't want to go anywhere else." She was not about to tell them about her water aversion.

The princess sighed. "You know what, fine", she grumbled. "Bow, you go with her."

"Yay!", the guy cheered. "Entrapta's a genius, I've always wanted to meet her. I'm a bit of a tinkerer myself." He leaned back into her, earning him another growl.

She pushed him away. "Why him?"

"Because I don't want you", Sparkles replied with a smile. "So, that means Adora and Scorpia are going to Plumeria with me."

This was the worst. Not only would she have to face Entrapta, she had to do it with the most annoying person. They did know that Dryl was full of cliffs, right? Did they want her to push him down one?

"Whatever", she grumbled and got up. She couldn't stick around here anymore.

Catra was vaguely aware of someone calling after her, but she did not care. Unless someone wanted to loose a limb in the next few minutes, she had to get out of there.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter we'll get into a bit more plot (no mission yet, but we will be meeting people :))

I hope you liked it <333 until next time, stay hydrated <33

Chapter 5: Razz

Chapter Notes

> Of course I'm going to have Adora meet Razz again hehe xD There's also a good bit of foreshadowing in this one, and some progress
>
> Hope you have fun <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was out of her seat before the door could close. She had no idea what she was supposed to do, but she knew that Catra was angry — again — and she wanted to do something. They could not keep going like this.

The feline noticed her immediately, of course, and began to growl. "Leave me alone!" She started to walk faster.

Adora kept up with her. “I really don’t think you should be alone.”

“I don’t care what you think! I don’t even know why *you* care.”

“I just do”, Adora said because that was really all there was. They had this talk before, hadn't they? Why didn't Catra just get it?

“Stop it! Just leave me alone!”

“Why do you wanna be alone so badly?”

Catra’s answer was a simple groan. They were close to running at this point.

“Whatever is going on with you surely won’t be solved all alone”, she pointed out.

“Nothing is going on with me! I just don’t want to deal with you people!”

Now it was Adora's turn to groan in frustration. "Why are you even here if you hate us all so much?", she asked and didn't expect an answer. She grabbed the other's arm and forced them to a stop.

Catra wrangled herself free immediately, but at least didn't run again.

"I know I asked you to stay, but … I didn't want to force you into something you don't want", she said.

The other girl scoffed. "Could have convinced me", she mumbled.

"Stop it! I am trying. At least I'm doing that much, I can't say the same about you!", she yelled. "I don't expect miracles, but the least you could do is talk to me or at least not be an asshole to everyone. I know you couldn't care less about any of this, but then why don't you just make everyone's lives easier and leave?!"

Catra once again didn't answer. She didn't do anything. Just stared.

"You can leave, you know?", she said into the silence. "You don't have to see me or anyone else you've hurt ever again. I hope it'll make you feel better. But I doubt it."

She turned around quickly. She didn’t want to see Catra’s reaction. It would probably be an insult again anyway. Why should she stick around for that? Especially since she was very aware of how sad her she had sounded — it was too easy of an opening to give to the girl. She regretted saying anything at all, honestly. This certainly didn't help their relationship. It might have ruined it forever.

Not that any of that mattered right now. She still had a meeting to get back to.

On the way back, she ran into a guard that apparently had a hard time catching up with them — to be fair, they had run quite a bit.

The guy looked at her shortly and then kept running, probably searching for Catra. Somehow she doubted he would find anyone.

She noticed just how much way they had run when she finally spotted the door to the war room. It still shouldn't be enough to leave a guard completely out of breath. Brightmoon's security could really use some better training.

Back in the room, the first thing she saw were the pitiful stares.

"Is everything okay?", Bow asked carefully.

She sat back down. "Not really", she mumbled. "Did you make any decisions?" She didn't want to talk about it, though.

The others seemed to be accepting of that, at least. "Yes", Glimmer told her. "Since we are now apparently splitting into two teams, Bow and Catra will go to Dryl while we go to Plumeria. But if Catra doesn't show up, we just all go to Plumeria. I don't care that we're too many people — that's a ridiculous argument anyway", she explained, her disdain for the feline evident in her voice and the eye roll she performed.

"Then there's still Mermista", Bow kept going and eyed Adora shortly. "Do you think we could get Catra onboard for that? Literally."

"She doesn't like water", Adora told them. The girl also wouldn't like Sea Hawk, but she could hardly say that. And it was still up for debate if she would even be around for that, at all.

The princess didn't seem to unhappy about that. "Okay, so no Catra. Perfect!"

"Uh, not really", Bow said then. "It wouldn't be fair to leave Catra behind."

Glimmer groaned. "We don't leave her behind. *She* doesn't want to come", she pointed out. "Don't worry, I'm sure we can get Netossa and Spinnerella to babysit her. She'll be fine."

He just sighed and rolled his eyes, but didn't argue any further. Neither did Adora, despite thinking that — if Catra was even still here — leaving the girl with two strangers was not the best idea.

"Good. Since there are no more complaints, I decide that we'll all go to Salineas. Well, all without Catra", Glimmer announced to make it official. "Now, does anyone have any questions?"

Scorpia did. Several in fact, and the rest of the meeting consisted of answering them. All of them were about how missions were supposed to look like and what to do and how to behave. Bow answered all of it with the patience of a saint.

Adora has had her doubts, but maybe he was the perfect person to go on a mission with Catra, after all.

If the girl would still be here. After everything Adora had said to her earlier, she might have actually just left for good.

With the meeting over, she could probably check, but she didn't want to. She couldn't get disappointed again just yet. What she really wanted, was to spend some time with someone who wouldn't ask her questions and wouldn't bring up anything surrounding Catra.

Adora was about to sneak away from their little group, when she remembered the guard in her back and the still distrustful look that Glimmer had on both her and Scorpia. At least she wasn't glaring at them with hate anymore.

She cleared her throat. "Hey, uh… would it be okay if hung out with Swi- the horse from Thaymor a bit? I think I need to clear my head", she asked awkwardly. It was weird to ask for permission here. These were her friends, after all — though right now, they were as much her friends as Catra was.

The pitiful looks returned. "I guess that's okay", Glimmer mumbled. She still didn't fully trust her, but at least she was allowed some respite.

"Thanks", she said and started to walk off towards the pasture.

A guard naturally followed her, but it was a different one than the one that had run after Catra earlier. She wondered if he was still searching for the feline.

She found Swift Wind without any problem, munching of grass a bit away from the other horses that he wasn't familiar with. He looked up when she came close, but didn't seem to mind her presence.

"Hey, Swifty", she called out. The guard stood a few paces away, so she felt comfortable talking freely.

It wasn't enough to completely forget that he's there, but enough to feel like she could breathe and that he wouldn't listen in.

Adora sat down next to the horse. "Do you have a best friend?", she asked — her plan to distract herself from Catra completely forgotten. Swift Wind didn't even look at her. "I had one. She's not dead or anything, but she's… She's always been grumpy. Aggressive even, but since Thaymor… well, the first Thaymor, things have gotten so terrible. I … I still don't really understand it. Why did she choose the Horde?"

The horse neighed, which wasn't really an answer, but it encouraged her to keep talking.

She tried to be quiet — this was a private conversation, after all, that the guard had no business being a part of. "I never wanted to leave her behind, that was her choice and yet she acts like I'm to blame for everything", she grumbled and crossed her arms. "I just wish she would talk to me."

Swift Wind nuzzled her a bit, probably to tell her to move so he could reach more grass.

Instead she petted him. "I also wish you could talk", she said then. "You were a really good friend. Sometimes it felt like I didn't

even have to tell you anything, you just knew. Maybe you did. We did have this weird bond thing, after all."

He looked at her curiously.

"It was an accident. I shouldn't do that to you again. You seem pretty happy as a normal horse", she told him. "Not that you were unhappy being part of the rebellion. It just feels wrong to do it on purpose. You were pretty freaked out last time."

He blinked.

She sighed. "It would just be nice to have a proper friend again, you know? Glimmer and Bow don't remember me and Catra hates me. And Scorpia is nice and all, but I wouldn't exactly call us friends. Not yet anyway." She let herself fall back in the grass. "Not that we would be friends either… because you don't remember. Just like everyone else. Except Catra."

Swift Wind lay down next to her. Maybe she was a bit delusional, but maybe they were friends, after all.

"I don't know what to do", she mumbled, both referring to Catra and her still pending decision to transform the horse. But also the war. Obviously, Catra not being on the Horde's side would be a huge advantage, but that didn't mean she actually knew how to win this. "Don't tell anyone", she told Swift Wind, who neighed again.

Adora was She-Ra, she couldn't afford to let anyone know how clueless she was. She had to fix what she had done wrong the last time, and she also had to earn these people's trust somehow. She couldn't allow herself to make any mistakes.

How was she going to do that?

Briefly, she wondered if that was what made Mara go nuts. If she ever did. After seeing the message in the waste, and the talk with Light Hope, she wasn't so sure anymore that anything that

hologram had told her was to be trusted. But who else could she ask for advice when it came to She-Ra?

Suddenly, she sat up again. Swift Wind didn't bat an eye at the motion, but the guard looked over to make sure she didn't try anything.

"Hey, Swifty…", she said and carefully pet him again. "Do you think you would mind if I… well…" She sighed. "I need your help. Well, your panic, more accurately."

He looked confused.

This was very wrong, and she was aware of it, but she really needed a good distraction and she needed Swift Wind to lead her to Razz. "I'm sorry", she told him and then got up.

She didn't think she would need to transform, since it hadn't been necessary last time. But she did need a good excuse to use her sword because the guard looked ready to intervene when she had loosened it from its place as a bracelet.

"A bit of training helps me relax", she said with an awkward laugh. It was not a lie, but the situation made her nervous enough that the guard still didn't look convinced.

To make him calm down a bit, she started to turn her sword into several non-lethal things — a cup, a broom, a flute. After watching her to that for a while, he seemed to lose interest, which was good. Because with him watching her, she could not have transformed Swift Wind, at least not convincingly accidental.

This way, he would hopefully not notice that she did it on purpose.

Adora reminded herself to take a few deep breaths to calm her anxiety. She didn't want to blast the hose into pieces.

With as much concealment as she could manage by turning away from the guard, she focused on what she wanted to happen.

"Please work", she whispered to the sword before sending a blast towards Swift Wind.

She let out a sigh of relief when she saw him transform and not explode. Then she quickly went ahead to try and calm him down, to really sell it. At least she was truly worried for her friend, and very sorry for doing this to him again, otherwise she was sure the guard would have caught on to the fake accident.

This way, he still yelled at her and asked what she had done, but it didn't look like he thought she had done it on purpose. He even tried to help her calm the newly transformed horse.

It didn't work, and Swift Wind quickly discovered how to fly. They both ran after him, but with the guards lacking training, Adora quickly lost him in the town.

"I'll get him back, don't worry!", she yelled quickly, when she noticed him falling behind.

By the time, she got to the woods, she had lost sight of Swift Wind as well. So much for him guiding her. She just hoped she managed to find Razz on her own.

As usual, the woods were impossible to navigate and yet she didn't feel like giving up. For one, she still had to find her friend that she had purposefully added more limbs to, but she also knew that the woods always led her somewhere. Mostly to Razz or Light Hope. She really hoped for Razz.

Still, as the minutes ticked past and she didn't catch even a hint of the woman, she started to freak out a little.

"Hello?", she started to yell into the woods at some point. "Madame Razz? Swift Wind? Is anyone here?"

There was no answer because of course there wasn't.

Adora had no idea how long she kept walking, but at some point she smelled… something. It did not belong in the woods, but she

couldn't place it. It was a nice smell, though.

She kept thinking about it as she followed it, which miraculously led her to the small hut that Razz lived in. By then, she had managed to recognize the smell. It was pie. And where there was pie, there was Madame Razz.

"Razz?", she called out again, not much caring for the use of a name she could not yet know. The woman couldn't keep past and present straight anyway, so Adora doubted she would be confused. Or point it out.

"Who's there?", a voice responded and soon the woman in question came out the door, her broom at the ready. Adora had to smile.

"Hi, sorry, I didn't mean to intrude", she tried to calm the old lady down.

"Oh Mara, dearie, is that you?", Razz asked with a smile of her own. "What are you doing here? We weren't supposed to do anything today", she then said before smiling even brighter. "What a surprise! Come in, come in, the pie is almost done!"

Adora had no time to answer, she was simply dragged along.

The little house was as chaotic as usual and she didn't see any chairs around, so she kept standing around. And she still had to find Swift Wind. "Did you happen to see a horse run or fly by?"

Madame Razz turned to look at her, really look at her, then. The pie seemed to be forgotten. "Adora", she said, surprisingly. "This is wrong… you're not supposed to meet Madame Razz yet. You did something."

Adora was absolutely shocked. "How do you… Do you remember?" Were Catra and her not the only people with their memory intact?

"Remember?", the woman repeated with confusion. "I remember that you promised to go berry picking with me tomorrow", she said like it was a reminder for Adora.

This was just confusing. Yes, she supposed she was one day early, but if Razz didn't actually remember then how did she know any of this?

"Always asking the wrong questions", the old woman said to herself as she took care of the pie again. "Just like my Mara."

Mara again. "How do you know her? She's been dead for a thousand years"

“You are silly, I made plans with her last week!”, the woman replied.

“Then where is she?”, she asked. “See? It doesn’t make sense- Ow!” She got hit with a broom.

And Madame Razz looked at her like a disappointed parent. “You’re here, aren’t you?”

“But I’m not-” This time she saw the broom coming and dodged.

“You cannot understand yet, dearie. You always want to understand. So curious and good. It will be your downfall if you’re not careful. You have a lot to learn, but not today. Today we pick berries!”

Adora stuttered for a few seconds, trying to process all of that. "Didn't you say tomorrow?", she then asked, which she felt was the least of her problems, but nothing else but that part made much sense to her.

“You’re here now.” A basket was shoved into her hands and then she had to scramble after Razz to keep up.

"What about the pie?", she asked, once again, the most useless question and she didn't even get an answer to it.

Razz was probably too busy on focusing where she stepped considering how fast she was running.

Adora really wished, the woman would answer anything at all, though, because she honestly felt more confused than the first time around. Why did she think she was getting any kind of advice here, again?

Did Razz remember the events before the portal? Or was that just her usual weirdness? And how did she know Mara? How did she know Adora when they have not met before?

She refused to think the woman was crazy — she said too many true things for that, ominous, but true — and yet she could not make any sense of her either.

Razz stopped here and there to pick some berries and because Adora didn't know what else to do, and she needed to keep busy, she helped.

Her mind kept coming up with more and more question, but apart from the fact that she would probably get no answers, she also had a hard time putting them into actual words.

The woman didn't seem to mind the silence, contently filling it with her hums and occasional self talk, that was just as helpful as anything else she said.

She only quieted down once they came past the Crystal Castle, a place that made Adora's thoughts slow down for a second to remember the last time she had been here.

She had asked Light Hope about her past and where she came from. The revelation that she was a First One. She still had so many questions about that, too, but she would probably never get answers to them, either.

Adora already dreaded having to go back in there. Did she have to? She had done the training already and apart from that, Light Hope had never been particularly helpful. And after that hologram

had told her that she had no choice in anything, it would be cathartic to *choose* to not go back there.

Right now she should focus on Razz, though, who had gone unnaturally still.

"Razz?", she asked because it was worrying her a little. Last time, the woman had climbed the tower and now she was frozen in place?

"We used to come here to look at the stars. Do you remember, Mara?", she then said, seemingly lost in memory. "They're all gone now."

She didn't ask how, but Adora knew the answer anyway. "A portal", she mumbled. She didn't know why Mara had done it, but she had used a portal to get them into this starless dimension. And this time around she would make sure they would stay here. No more portals on her watch.

“Oh Mara, you always had crazy ideas”, Razz laughed at her.

Adora scoffed. "It's true", she defended. "Mara used a portal and destroyed the planetary balance in the process."

Razz still laughed. "Sounds like my Mara. Always so brave." She sighed. "Well, stop gawking, silly. We still have more berries to pick." And just like that, the woman was off again.

"Wait!", Adora yelled after her. "There are berries all around the place."

"I don't want them. They have bad juju", was all the explanation. Which didn't make any sense, but Adora wasn't about to question it if it meant getting away from the Crystal Castle.

So, she followed the woman. And seriously, how could someone this old be this fast? She stumbled over several roots and ran into more branches and yet, somehow, Razz didn't face a single obstacle despite her speed.

Well, she always had a feeling that the woods hated her.

She was so distracted by trying not to get impaled by a tree, that she didn't notice when Razz came to a stop. After almost running into the other, she recognized why they weren't walking anymore.

Right, she remembered. It wasn’t a pretty sight, the destruction and weapons. The Horde camp somehow looked worse than in her memory.

“It’s the same old story, dearie”, Razz told her sadly. “Wicked people destroying what they cannot understand.”

“Is that what happened to Mara?”, she couldn’t help but asking.

“You’re so very like her, you know”, Razz answered her question for once… somewhat. “She did the brave thing even when she was afraid."

It reminded her more of Angella than herself, if she had to be honest. Back in the portal, it was the queen who did the brave thing despite being afraid, not Adora.

It reminded her of something else, too. Something Madame Razz told her in the portal. “Mara saved us”, she repeated it. "But from what? Why did she open a portal? Why did she hide us here?"

“It wasn’t easy, but for you it never is.” They were being ominous again.

Adora was starting to get frustrated. "What wasn't easy? What happened? How can I do better? What can I do to help Mara?", she asked, but didn't receive an answer.

Razz just smiled at her, a soft almost motherly smile. “Mara would be proud of you, dearie.”

She was either about to cry or tear something apart because while it felt so oddly meaningful to hear that, she still didn't know what it meant.

Luckily, she was quickly distracted by the distraught sounds of a horse. “Swift Wind!” She didn’t need more to throw herself into a fight. “For the honor of Grayskull!”

She spotted him quickly surrounded by Horde soldiers and trapped in a net. That was the first thing she destroyed, freeing her friend before going after the weapons and any soldiers that got in her way.

Last time, this fight hadn't ended very well for her, but this time, she would make sure to get rid of the Horde. Whatever this place had been once, she would make sure it could regrow.

Madame Razz was helping, too, which was worrying, but Swift Wind came to help the woman, which Adora was glad for because otherwise she might have been too distracted to do what she needed to. And she really needed to focus because the soldiers went at her with the intention to really hurt her.

For her part, she did not want to inflict permanent damage on her opponents. She majorly pushed them out of her way, so she could destroy the cannons, though she saw some of them humping away from her anyway. When she managed to cut the last of the cannons in half, she made eye contact with the commanding officer who slowly inched back.

She shot him a glare and he called for the retreat.

When they were all gone, she turned back to her normal self and joined Razz and Swift Wind. “Are you alright?”, she asked.

“That was some cardio”, the woman said and held her back. Adora tried not to laugh, but failed.

Despite her grievances with the woman, she offered to carry Razz, which she enthusiastically agreed to. Swift Wind was walking next to them and occasionally looked at his wings, but otherwise he seemed fine.

“I’m supposed to tell you that he thanks you for coming to his rescue”, Razz then said. “And that he loves his name.”

“I’m glad”, Adora said, certainly relieved that he was not mad at her. “But why can’t he tell me that himself?”

She got another hit with the broom. “He is very self conscious about his new ability, don’t be rude Mara”, she got chastised.

“Sorry”, she mumbled. “Take as long as you need, Swifty.” He neighed in response. It made sense, in their old time he hadn’t started talking until about a week after the transformation.

It was a short walk back to Razz’s house. Oddly so. She was sure that they had walked a lot longer earlier, but maybe with Adora carrying the woman, the woods were a bit nicer to her. Maybe, who knew?

She gently sat the woman down. “Thank you, dearie.”

“Of course.”

“I’m gonna lie down. Next time, we just go berry picking, Mara. You always work, there's no balance”, Razz told her.

Adora swallowed a response that she didn’t chose to go to the Horde camp and that it was just a coincidence, but it would fall on deaf ears anyway. “Yes, next time, we’ll just pick berries. No work and no fighting for justice.”

“That’s the spirit, dearie! Swift Wind can also visit me again.” Another neigh, which made Razz laugh. Can she understand that?

The woman disappeared inside her hut, so Adora turned to Swift Wind. “Well then, let’s go back to Brightmoon”, she said and started walking. Last time she had been in a bit of a rush and asked him to fly her, but now they had time. And with the way he kept skeptically looking at his wings, she was sure he preferred walking, too.

Back at Brightmoon, the guards were visibly relieved to see both of them again. One of them took over the duty of following her around again as she gave Swift Wind some food, water and enough space before she went to dinner herself.

She had skipped lunch in favor of Swift Wind and Razz, so she made her way straight to the buffet and loaded her plate with all the stuff she knew she enjoyed before even trying to find her friends and sitting with them.

"Adora!", Scorpia — who was unsurprisingly the first one to notice her — yelled loud enough to make the entire hall quiet down to stare at her.

It also made Glimmer conscious of her presence and she scowled at her. "There you are!", she shouted and grabbed her arm to drag her into the seat right next to her. "You can't just disappear like that! I could already hear my mom's voice saying 'I told you so'. You can't do that to me!"

"Sorry, I…" She didn't really know what to say. Now sitting at the table, she also noticed Catra's absence. She was a little surprised, but not much. And she had told her that she could leave, didn’t she?

"Yeah, yeah, I know", the girl waved her off. "You did something weird to the horse and chased after it. We already know. The guard was convinced you did it on purpose to run off, by the way."

Adora couldn't really deny that. Not believably at least. "I was just training, testing my abilities", she mumbled awkwardly. "And then it… happened." Not a lie.

"What exactly did happen?", Bow then asked, intrigued. "The guard couldn't really describe it, something about you transforming the horse? Into what?"

"He has wings now. And a horn. And a different … color. And *he* ran off, I just spend all day searching for him.”

“You can do that?”, Scorpia asked, her eyes wide and her mouth open. Adora wasn’t sure if she was terrified or in awe.

“Apparently”, she said and used the time of everyone processing this information to stuff some food in her mouth.

Glimmer didn't seem to want to let her eat, though. "And what exactly did you say to Catra?", she asked and Adora almost choked. She did not want to explain how it was her fault that the feline was gone.

"What do you mean?", she managed to get out after Scorpia hit her back a few times, hard enough that she couldn't tell if the woman broke any bones. She did send the woman a thankful smile, though.

"I mean that during the meeting you both ran out. You said it didn't go great and had to take a break with the horses. And she's an even greater nightmare to deal with", the princess explained.

"Catra's still here?", she asked in shock. She had not expected that. "Where is she?", she couldn't help but asking. Just like she couldn’t stop the hope rising inside her.

Glimmer scoffed. “Hiding in a tree last I saw her”, the girl muttered, stabbing into a pudding with a certain viciousness that told her that encounter had not been great either.

“She threw pine cones at us”, Bow added and shuddered. Had it been that terrible?

"Which is weird because I didn't even see any pine trees around", Scorpia added thoughtfully.

“I’m sure she switched to a more comfortable place by now, but we haven't checked. We don’t really want to go near her right now, and I don't really care either”, Glimmer finished.

Adora processed that one second and then proceeded to eat as fast as she could without inflicting any damage on herself. She

could feel the others staring at her, but she didn't care — she wanted to talk to Catra and make things right.

When she was sufficiently stuffed, she got up and turned to the door before remembering that Catra once again hadn't been present for dinner.

So, she went back to the buffet, stacked another plate with food and then left.

She went straight to the garden and the greenhouse, barely noticing the guard following her, or the one guarding the glasshouse.

Before she entered, though, she stood there unsure. She wanted to avoid another fight, but she didn't know if she could. On top of that, Catra probably already knew Adora was here, which put a bit of pressure on her.

Eventually, she approached the door and decided to knock, despite the fact that any type of announcement was technically unnecessary. It still felt right.

Catra turned her head only slightly and at least didn’t outright scream at her to get out. “I brought a peace offering”, she tried to be funny and at least she got the other girl to fully look at her.

Since the yelling still didn’t come, she made her way towards the feline and sat down a small distance away from her. “I thought you might be hungry”, she then said and put the plate down between them.

Catra looked at it for a while and Adora got worried that she might reject it, but then the girl reached out to one of the filled buns.

Adora let her eat in silence. Baby steps, she reminded herself.

It wasn't comfortable by any means, but Catra let her stay and she was happy about that.

She managed to stay quiet until the plate was almost empty. "I'm sorry", she then said into the silence. "I didn't mean it… Not really. I do mean it that you don't have to stay if you don't want to, but I don't want you to leave. I don't think it would be easier. And I know that you are trying. I can only imagine how much it really means that you're here."

Catra didn't respond, didn't even look at her, but her ear twitched a little — a clear signal, that she was listening.

"We've hurt each other a lot", she kept going. "I don't want to hurt you anymore, but somehow I still do and I… I don't know what to do." She paused, hoping that the other would say something, but she didn't. "I *never* wanted to hurt you", Adora said because it needed to be said.

It didn't fix anything, but she still felt like it was important. That it was never her intention.

"I did", Catra said then, her voice raspier than usual. Probably because she hadn't used it in hours. Or because she had yelled at Glimmer earlier. "I really wanted to hurt you. I couldn't stand seeing you happy." Catra took the last bun from the plate and bit into it. Adora waited, hoping there was more. "I don't think I want to anymore. I don't want you to hate me." It was quiet but she heard it regardless.

"I never hated you, Catra", she told her, again and she would tell her as many times as it needed to sink in. "I never could. Even now, no matter how frustrated I get… I don't understand it, but I just can't stop caring about you."

"You're an idiot", Catra laughed.

"I know", she chuckled. "Am I an idiot for hoping we can fix this? Us?" She was maybe setting herself up to be hurt again, but she just had to know if they were on the same page.

To her surprise the other shook her head. "Then I'm an idiot, too." Now Catra looked up, looked at her. "Truce?"

Adora smiled. “Allies.”

Chapter End Notes

I'll be honest, at least half of the foreshadowing that I have Razz throw around has been completely accidental. I have been flabberghasted, rereading this because... I don't remember writing most of that xD

Anyway, next time, we'll finally get so see the start of the missions!
Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 6: Entrapta

Chapter Summary

We're starting the princess recruitment missions!

Chapter Notes

This is, as of right now, the longest chapter of this entire thing. I don't know how this became 8k words, but apparently, that's how much I wrote.
Anyway, we finally get some story progress!

Hope you enjoy <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra saw herself, pupils thin and full of panic. "This time *I* am going to win! I don't care what it takes, we are opening that portal! Now!"

Opposite to her was Entrapta. "No!", she defied her. "I won't. I need to tell Hordak, he'll understand!" She had barely turned around when Catra rammed a sting baton into the woman's back. Electricity was shooting everywhere.

Entrapta fell to the ground and everything turned red.

Oh, Catra knew what this was and she was powerless to do something against it.

She stared at her hands, the baton, Entrapta. What had she done? "Get her out of here!" Her voice started to echo in the emptiness of the room that the scientist no longer filled with her chatter. She was lying on the floor, even her hair limb.

What had she done?

“What did you do to me?”, she heard Entrapta ask her in her always so curious voice.

Suddenly the picture changed and she saw Adora and the portal. Adora was angry because of Catra because she had pushed and pushed the girl until the only possible thing left was anger.

The portal activated and Catra felt like it was trying to suck her in.

“Why did you do it?”, Adora asked, though now she seemed sad. Disappointed almost. Nothing from the anger remained. “Why couldn’t you come with me?”

Catra wanted to run, but the portal wouldn’t let her, pulling her in closer and closer and she did not want to go back inside. She tried to claw at something to hold on to, but there was nothing. She was falling into the portal as she saw Adora reach out for her. She couldn’t be saved.

Catra woke up with a scream and startled a bunch of birds by the sound of it. She touched her face just to be sure she wasn’t back in that portal, but her fur was smooth.

She couldn't even remember how she fell asleep. Adora talked to her and yes, she had lied down after, but she had managed to avoid sleep for so long, why did she have to slip up today of all days?

It wasn't all that surprising that she would be having this nightmare since she would be seeing Entrapta again today. Of course, the woman wouldn’t remember anything, but Catra did and she wasn’t sure if she could look the scientist in the eyes without succumbing to her own mind.

Maybe Sparkles and the flower people would have been better, after all, but she couldn't change that now. At least not without the princess being nosy again, and Catra was not going to explain herself.

She had to pull herself together — she has been through worse. She could face Entrapta.

Catra took a few … dozen … deep breaths, hoping she could calm herself down enough to face anyone at all without arousing suspicion.

“Catra?”, a voice called out. Scorpia. Now Catra scrambled to make herself look less scared. “Are you okay?”, she asked when she rounded around to the entrance.

“I’m fine”, she tried to growl but it barely came out as a whisper. Obviously, her efforts hadn't worked.

Scorpia came closer and sat down next to her. “I have nightmares too, sometimes. It helps me to talk about it.”

“I have nothing to talk about and I didn’t have a nightmare”, she mumbled and got up to get ready. To do something because otherwise she might cry.

Sadly she had not much to do because it had been a bit cold and she had decided to sleep with her clothes still fully on. Then again, she was also grateful for that because she did not want the other to see her in her underwear. For several reasons.

Scorpia hesitated. “You look terrified”, she then said quietly, but Catra picked up on it anyway.

“So what?”, she snapped and splashed some water in her face.

“Is that why you’re not sleeping? And why you’re out here alone?”, the woman then asked, once again not understanding when to stop. “Does Adora know?”

Catra turned around halfway through drying off the water with a piece of cloth that lay around. She quickly finished so she wouldn’t look ridiculous while answering. “No”, she said. “And if you tell her, I’ll scratch your face off.”

“I won’t”, the woman replied easily. “I can keep a secret, I’m a good friend.”

There it was. Scorpia was always quick to label her relationships. Last time Catra had snapped several times telling the other they weren’t friends and that remained true. They weren’t. But she didn't want to deal with this right now. Not today. She just ran her fingers through her hair in a lazy attempt at combing. “Why are you here anyway?”, she then asked, hoping to change the topic.

“You weren’t at breakfast and we're supposed to leave in half an hour, so I thought I’d check on you”, the woman answered. “Adora wanted to go actually, but we all thought that would be a bad idea, so I came instead."

And where did some random strangers get the audacity from to chose what was best for her? She almost yelled that question out loud, but she kept it together.

Catra was done doing whatever to appear busy anyway, so she just walked out.

"You know", Scorpia said as she stumbled after her. "I mean it, if you ever wanna talk about it, I'm here for you."

"Yeah, thanks", she sighed because she knew that silence just encouraged the other more. She didn’t need to look back to know the woman was beaming with joy.

She just kept walking. Her guard looked at her weird, no doubt having heard her earlier scream. It made her want to go back inside her hideout and stay there, alone. But that wasn't a possibility.

They went straight to the dining hall and found the group at their usual table. She stopped in the door for a second, debating whether she wanted to quickly stuff herself with food, but considering the day she would have in front of her, she’d rather not risk throwing up.

“Over here!”, Arrow Boy called out to them as if they hadn’t spotted the group already.

Sparkles snorted. “Did you seriously oversleep on an important day like this?”, she asked and Catra hissed at her. “Not a morning person, I feel you”, was the odd response and she couldn’t help but frown at it. The princess looked to be still half asleep, which might explain her nicer attitude.

“You should eat something, it will be a long day”, Arrow Boy called out and started buttering another piece of bread. They’ve already been here a while, how much did they eat?

“Not hungry”, she grumbled.

“You can also pack some for later”, Adora told her, also stuffing her face with a heavily packed sandwich.

“I’ll think about it.” Though whatever remained of her appetite quickly vanished watching the others. She sincerely considered going hungry for the day.

“Don't worry, I’ll pack something for us in a sec”, Arrow Boy ensured her with a smile.

"I'll do too", Sparkles said and already went over to the buffet, as she was already done eating apparently.

Since Catra refused to eat, she could only sit and be bored, which she hated because it made her mind go to places, she really didn’t want to think about. Like Entrapta.

The princess was a whirlwind that she had avoided most of the time and even when they had interacted, Catra barely understood a word she had said. And from what she had gathered, the alliance hadn’t been much better in that regard. And that meant that she would have to do something to hold Entrapta here in the rebellion, otherwise she would probably run off somewhere and possibly befriend Hordak again.

Which, now that she thought about it, might not be the worst of ideas.

Catra, despite all her faults and paranoia, wasn't an idiot. She had noticed Hordak going soft around the princess and most importantly, the woman had posed a threat to Catra's own position as second in command, a title currently still held by Shadow Weaver.

Would it work again, though? With no Scorpia or Catra around to look out for the scientist and to give her a chance, would she even get close enough to Hordak to cause some damage?

"What are you thinking about?" Adora lightly bumped into her, effectively distracting her.

"Nothing", she mumbled, scooting away just a little. While not a terrible idea, it was a terrible plan. There were just too many risks.

The girl snorted. "I know that face. You're scheming something", she pointed out with a smug grin that made Catra think of something mean to say.

But she held herself back. They just got on somewhat good terms, she should not ruin that. Again. "I was just considering some possibilities", she told the annoying blonde.

Adora hummed, intrigued. "Mind to fill me in?"

"There's nothing to fill you in on, it's a dead end", she mumbled and wished she had some food, just so she could distractedly stab into it.

"Maybe later", Adora said, ever the optimist.

She couldn't argue that further because suddenly Arrow Boy was next to her, asking her about her preferences before he packed something, and when he was out of her space again, she had practically forgotten what she had been thinking about before.

And shortly after that, they started to travel towards the other kingdoms with the only addition of a random horse from the Brightmoon stables to pull the supplies for Plumeria.

Despite Sparkles' reservations about them, their group was extremely talkative. It seemed that everyone but Catra easily fit in with the princess and her boyfriend — or whatever, she still didn't know what was going on there. It wasn't much of a surprise if she had to be honest.

They chattered away about nothing in particular, nothing of interest, so Catra walked behind them and tried not to get annoyed too much.

Since Plumeria and Brightmoon shared their spot right next to the Whispering Woods, it was luckily not an overly long walk together, and their two groups made their goodbyes while it was still morning.

Sparkles and Arrow Boy were friendly and professional, mostly. Scorpia was behaving like they would never see each other again. And then there was Adora, who slowly crept closer to her.

"Hey", she said when she was finally close enough.

“What? Gonna give me a heartfelt goodbye too?”, Catra asked sarcastically, making the other laugh.

“No”, she said. “I know you can do this and that you’ll be fine.”

“Then what do you want?”

The girl took a deep breath, talking low and quiet again, so only Catra’s ears would pick up on it. “I barely remembered what has happened back there, but Entrapta had this virus that's really dangerous. I know you can handle it. You’ve dealt with worse, but still… be safe.” Adora looked at her with something in her eyes. Catra wasn’t sure what it was or if she liked it.

“I will be”, she mumbled, avoiding eye contact. “You too.” She looked back shortly to see the other girl smile and before it could get any more awkward, she had to keep talking. "You know you have to disregard the queen's orders, right? And make sure Shadow Weaver doesn't pick up on you and She-Ra being the same person or she'll stalk you again."

"I'll just go into battle as She-Ra straight away", the girl responded easily. "Think that'll do it?"

Catra wasn't sure. If anyone called Adora's name or the sorceress noticed how similar the two personas look, it might not matter at all. "Yeah, it should", she said, though. No need to worry the blonde about hypotheticals. They should all try to focus on the mission.

Then she had to wait for Arrow Boy giving out weirdly motherly instructions to the other team — this would be a long day.

When he finally came over, she just turned and started walking without looking back. The boy, however, waved until he couldn't see the others anymore.

Catra expected something then, but he let them walk in silence, surprisingly. It made her suspicious. So much so, that it was her to break the silence not even half an hour in.

"Don't you have something to say?", she hissed because she couldn't take the suspense anymore.

The guy looked confused. "Do you want me to?"

What kind of a response was that? "No", she answered honestly.

Now he looked even more confused. "Then why did you-"

"We can walk in silence, it's fine!", she interrupted him and smoothed out her hair to calm down.

He awkwardly cleared his throat. "Just for our safety, we should probably not yell. These cliff can be really instable and we don't wanna be crushed", he told her, which was weird.

She understood, of course, but the information wasn't the odd part. It was the fact that he was so… distant? Catra had expected an attempt at friendship or something similarly nice. That would have been terrible, but she didn't feel very comfortable with this either. "Got it", she mumbled in acknowledgement.

And just like she had asked him to, he kept quiet.

It was a rather long walk to Dryl and he didn't say a word on the whole way. After another half an hour, she started to get used to it. There really didn't seem to be a trick here, he just accepted that she didn't want to talk, or him to talk.

After a while, it got weirdly comfortable even.

At some point, he decided to take a look at his arrows. They all looked the same to her, but she knew that they all did something different. "How do you keep them apart?", she heard herself ask and they both looked shocked at that.

Then he smiled. "They have little differences", he happily explained. "The net ones are heavier, and the one for the goo has a slightly greener shade to it. Also, I make them all myself, so it's easier to tell them apart. I also have a few prototypes that I haven't refined quite yet. They'll stand out, like my sonic arrow."

"A sonic arrow?", she asked. What could he possibly need that for?

"Might be a good distraction some day. Or it could work like a signal flare, just with sound. You never know what might be useful", he told her with a shrug.

Sure, whatever. "So, you just have random arrows for potential situations?" She honestly didn't know why she kept asking, but … she had always been curious about it.

"I like to be prepared for everything", he said simply, putting his arrows back. "Well, to be fair, I am not prepared for everything, but I'm prepared for a lot of things."

"I get it", she mumbled because she did. She liked to be prepared, too.

He hummed. "I thought so. Adora said you were a good strategist. That's kind of the perfect job for people wanting to be prepared." He chuckled and she already feared the story from his life that was surely about to come. "I think that's what makes Glimmer and me such good friends. She likes to throw herself into every fight and I always have to hold her back and remind her to think things through."

There was so much she could say now. "Sounds nice", is what she settled on because she did not want to go any deeper on the topic of friendship.

"How is it with you and Adora?"

She groaned. Of course he would bring it up anyway.

Arrow Boy furrowed his brows. "I know things are… tense between you right now, but you're still friends, right?"

"No", she told him. "We *have been* friend. Right now… we're just on the same side. We're coworkers at best." She took a breath and noticed the boy to do the same. "I don't wanna talk about it", she added then, hoping he could accept it like earlier.

"Okay." He did, but evidently wasn't ready to be quiet again. "Can I ask you something? Might be personal."

She sighed. "I might not answer."

"Fair", he laughed. "Do you miss the Fright Zone?", he then asked and she was mostly confused. "It's just … Adora and Scorpia seem to feel fairly at home in Brightmoon. I think Scorpia might be a bit

homesick, but… You're always distant and … well, you don't exactly look like you want to be here", he explained.

He's right. She did not want to be in Brightmoon, but that didn't mean she missed the Horde. She missed what she used to have. First with Adora, then without her. In the end, she thinks she misses her connection to the other girl and her power more than the place itself, though.

"I don't think Scorpia ever really agreed with the Horde. They kept her mostly away from everything. She's just happy to help and be included. And Adora has the most annoying personality — she just can't help but save everyone", she said eventually. "I was never sold on the war. I don't care. But no… I certainly don't miss the Fright Zone."

"Is it so bad that Adora wants to save people?", he asked.

Catra felt a familiar anger rise in her again. Of course it wasn't a bad thing to want to save people. But it was terrible that Adora never even considering leaving for Catra, but suddenly a bunch of random strangers are in danger and the girl runs off to play the hero.

Yeah, she was still angry about that. It was really hard to imagine that they would ever be friends again.

"Let's just focus on the mission", she grumbled. She didn't want to deal with this today.

They turned around a corner and Dryl finally came into view. It looked just like Catra remembered it.

"The distress beacon is on", Arrow Boy noticed then, luckily killing any possible further conversation. "But there wasn't supposed to be any Horde around here."

"Doesn't look like there is", she said because she couldn't outright tell him what she knew. It was probably the virus that Adora had mentioned.

"Whatever is going on, we'll have to be careful", he told her. "Oh, and Entrapta is known for building traps all around her castle, so we should generally watch our steps."

She nodded and they walked closer. Catra remembered how terrible this place was. And now, without the business of taking over the place, it was eerily quiet.

It really shouldn't surprise her — Entrapta lived alone, after all.

They slowly made their way around the traps in the courtyard, but still didn't spot anything at all.

"Maybe your right", Arrow Boy whispered eventually. "I don't think it's the Horde. It's probably coming from the inside."

She nodded. "We should try to stick together then", she said, and even though it came out like she was about to throw up at the thought of spending more time with him, he nodded dutifully.

They carefully made their way into the fortress by means of a window since every entrance seemed to be a trap, and Catra remembered that this place was a maze. And they didn't have a map, or a tracker pad. This would be interesting.

The inside looked just as uninhabitable as the outside and reminded her of the Fright Zone, just in purple — a lot of confusing corridors, only little decor and all the noise was robotic and metal … even though the walls seemed to be made of stone.

Weird.

They agreed to try and find Entrapta and very quietly made their way around.

Neither of them had any idea where they were going or where the princess could be hiding. Even if she was in the most obvious place — her lab — they had no way of knowing where that was. Catra remembered what Entrapta had told her back in the Fright

Zone, to always keep a tracker pad handy, otherwise they would get lost.

This was going to be a long day.

And the weird metallic noises were extremely grating on her sensitive ears.

"You okay?", Arrow Boy asked after a while. It probably showed on her face that something was bothering her.

She nodded. "This place makes noises", she whispered back. "It's not nice."

He was alert right away. "Something to worry about?"

"Can't tell. It's too far away. But I don't wanna find out either", she mumbled. This place gave her the creeps.

The boy nodded in agreement and they kept going, silently and keeping careful watch on their surroundings.

She had to admit, it was nice working with someone competent again. He kept a watchful eye, was prepared for an attack, and was able to walk around quietly. Somehow, she found herself enjoying this, even if she had be cautious.

After an hour or so, Catra added the new emotion of frustration into the mix, because she was pretty sure they were walking in circles. It was hard to tell with all the identical walls, but there was a bit of grease on the floor that she swore she had seen before.

“I hate this place”, she groaned and stopped because continuing to walk felt pointless.

Arrow Boy send her a sympathetic look. "We gotta find a better tactic. Running around aimlessly clearly won't get us anywhere."

"Without a map, I don't think we'll have much of a choice", she mumbled and leaned against a wall to think, or hope for the boy to come up with something.

Suddenly, though, she fell backwards and Bow was gone.

Slightly panicked, she pressed and punched the wall that had somehow brought her to a different corridor, to get back to where she had been just now, but that stupid thing wouldn’t budge. She could probably cut through it, but depending on how thick it was, she would not reach the other side so easily — she would have to tear it away layer by layer — she would be exhausted by the time she made it through, and then she wouldn't be able to fight well anymore.

At the same time, how was she supposed to find Arrow Boy again? What if she didn't find Entrapta, either? Why could nothing just be easy for once?

Catra sunk down on the floor and wanted to scream, but she was still very aware of the noise that came from somewhere. And it was closer now than before. She had to calm herself.

She couldn't get back the way she came from and she was just as lost as before, just that now she had two people to find. It wasn't the worst of odds. And really, she only had to find Entrapta because she hopefully had a map. That way, they might find Arrow Boy, too.

Positive thinking really wasn't for her. Let's be real, she was lucky if she managed to get out of here at all.

And as if the world liked to prove her right, she noticed the noise getting unsettlingly close now.

She pulled herself up from the ground and got ready to fight whatever was coming. At the very least, it might be a nice distraction.

It didn't take long for a rather big group of robots to round the corner and Catra didn't waste a second to pounce on them, cutting into them with her claws, ripping out anything that she could grip. For most of them, a few missing cables already deactivated them, but some were more stubborn. She jumped on them and teared them apart top to bottom with the help of the claws on her feet.

By the time the robots stopped coming, a rather big part of the hallway was littered with them and she had gotten slightly out of breath.

She listened and couldn’t hear another robot near her. What she did hear however was something behind her that did not sound like the robots just now.

Then something crawled out of a vent and Catra tensed even more.

“A visitor! I’m saved!”, the princess called out as she crawled down to the ground. That was creepy, even for Entrapta's standards. The woman took off her mask and stared at the carnage in front of her. Then she pulled out her recorder. “I have an angry looking feline person, who seems to have destroyed about two dozen of my robots. Further investigation required.”

Catra was momentarily frozen in place. The nightmare fresh in her mind, and hearing her so excited and lively made her feel distressed.

“Welcome to Dryl!”, Entrapta then called out and came closer to look at Catra, making her natural defenses come to life, and effectively getting her out of her frozen state to get out of the woman's range. The princess didn't seem to mind. “I’m very sorry. Things are usually really fun around here, but it’s gotten a teensy bit deadly”, she explained.

Catra took a deep breath, grounding herself again — Adora was right, she has been through worse and she could face this too.

First, she swallowed a comment about how they probably had very different definitions of fun. Then she willed her voice to work and her mind to focus. "Well, I'm here to help, I guess. But I came with someone else, we got separated by a wall and I couldn't get back."

"Yes, all the mechanisms I've installed are sort of evil right now, but don't worry, we can find your friend", the princess assured her and pulled out a pad. Her smile got quickly replaced by a frown. "Right. Evil. We'll have to find your friend the old fashioned way, then."

Catra sighed, frustrations overwhelming her anxieties. "Great. It will be a long walk, care to explain what's going on?", she tried to get the other to talk because Adora had been less than helpful.

"You want to hear about my experiments?!", the other squealed excitedly.

She was about to answer something when she heard the bots coming near again and groaned.

On the bright side, it was only one. It was big, though. With a roll of her eyes, she jumped up to the top of the cleaning robot.

She had figured out earlier that the power unit was usually behind the eyes, which made sense in a disturbing kind of way. So, she made quick work smashing her claws into the metal and pulling the power source out, throwing it at Entrapta's feet.

The princess didn't seem happy. "You killed bot 329", she said sadly. "For a moment it looked like it was trying to communicate."

"It was trying to kill us", she told the delusional scientist in front of her. "I want answers. Why is everything trying to kill us?"

"They're not trying to kill us, they're just confused", the other argued. "But they're fascinating to study that way. You see, they are actually designed to help me — cleaning, filing, basic hygiene. And they're sound activated too, super practical."

“Not right now”, she growled. At least that explained why the robots had shown up now when before they had kept their distance — her clawing at the wall and Entrapta's presence hadn't been exactly quiet.

“No, you’re right.” Entrapta looked over to the corpses of their attackers. “But this entire situation gives me so much data. And I’m very interested to know how you did that. You did not just punch through, did you? It’s too precise, it looks almost cut.” The woman grabbed her hands with her hair to check out her claws.

It took some struggling, but she managed to get out of the hold. That hair was strong. “Hey, focus”, she snapped at the scientist. “What happened?”

Entrapta didn’t seem mad about the loss of her discovery. “It’s really fascinating. I’ve been experimenting with a disk that was recovered from a mine in Dryl. It was a game changer.” She made a replica of it with her hair. “It had more First Ones code than anything I’d ever seen before, but it seems to have reacted with the First Ones tech that powers my bots. It infected them with some sort of virus.”

Somewhere in that speech Catra realized that Adora was an absolute idiot.

It was the same disk and virus that she had used against She-Ra in the Northern Reach. Since Adora didn’t remember anything, she had made it sound like Entrapta invented something that went nuts, not that she had found a disk. Somewhere in that blonde’s brain it had to click that those two events were connected, no?

“The angry feline appears to be more angry. Possibly because of my virus, but I’m not sure”, she heard the princess babble next to her.

“I’m not angry at you”, Catra said, slowly in an attempt to stay quiet as to not attract more bots.

"Oh, good, I got worried there for a second. People tend to get angry with me often and I really didn't want to make my savior angry", Entrapta said and Catra remembered again why she had decided to trust the princess in the first place back in the other time. Because she was a sad and lonely creature.

"Speaking of saving. Where is this disk so we can destroy it?"

"Destroy it? But the experiment isn't complete", the princess objected.

Catra glanced behind her towards the destruction she had caused. "I say it is."

"But what if it's not? There's so much data I could collect."

She sighed. "I'll probably regret asking this, but are you seriously willing to risk your life for a bit of data? You won't even be around to use it anymore."

Entrapta stared at her a long time and Catra practically saw her weighing the pros and cons. Eventually the princess sighed. "You're right. It's in my lab, we just need to find it."

"Good. Maybe we'll find Arrow Boy on the way."

***

Catra completely lost track of time in this castle. Walking through this maze didn't help either and they had to keep stopping to cut down some more robots. She felt what little patience she had leave her with every pass by the same stupid picture.

The first time they saw it, Entrapta had squealed that they were close to the lab and Catra had been mildly impressed that the princess had put up at least some landmark from time to time, but

then they had passed it five more times. If she didn’t know that it was useless, Catra would take the wall down.

At least she could take down the bots — it was quite a good outlet for her continuously growing frustrations.

“Do you have to destroy every bot?”, the princess asked behind her sadly. “I still need them and you kind of damage them. A lot.”

“I’ll try to be more careful”, she grumbled with no intentions of actually doing that.

“That would be great!” Of course the scientist didn’t understand the sarcasm. Well, Catra wasn’t going to correct her. “So, your friend, what are we looking for exactly?”, she then asked.

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Don’t you live alone?”, she asked. What did it matter what Arrow Boy looked like, any stranger would be him.

“No, I have a kitchen staff”, Entrapta told her, though. “The bots couldn’t quite figure out human food, so I had to keep them.”

“Right”, she mumbled. “Well, he's a bit taller than me and he never covers his stomach", she told her then.

Entrapta didn’t seem to be listening, though, her hair reaching out to Catra’s hand again, that she quickly snatched away from the woman, who promptly pouted.

“It’s fascinating”, she quickly regained her enthusiasm. “I’ve never seen anything like it. How does it work? Does it hurt? How strong are they? Are they natural?”, she started to ramble.

“Can we deal with this later? You know, when we’re not in mortal danger?”, Catra interrupted before the princess got loud enough to attract more bots.

“It’s a date”, Entrapta squealed, excitedly clapping her hands.

She sighed. How was she supposed to deal with this long term? Then she remembered, that she hadn’t brought up the alliance even once so far. In-between all the bots and searching for Arrow Boy and the lab, she kind of forgot. Not like the princess had ever once wondered what two strangers were doing in her castle either.

“How about this, you join the rebellion and you can collect whatever data you want. Without touching”, she offered.

“Yes!”, was the immediate response, somehow surprisingly quick and at the same time not at all a surprise. “I vaguely remember something. Didn’t the alliance fall apart?”, Entrapta then asked. “I think I overheard something at Princess Prom.”

“The prom hasn’t happened yet”, Catra pointed out.

“Oh, I meant the last one”, the other replied. "Though that has been a while ago, my information might be outdated."

She wanted to ask, but at the same time, she really didn't. Though, she thinks Scorpia had mentioned it to be some annual dance, so she supposed that made sense. “Well, they’re trying to get it rebuild”, she answered the original question. “That’s why I’m here. To recruit you.”

“How nice”, the princess cooed. “They didn’t even ask me last time, but I’m happy to help.”

This woman really didn’t care what side she was on as long as she was included. Just like Scorpia — no wonder they had become fast friends last time. “First we have to make it out of here alive.”

“Of course, right”, the princess mumbled as if she had forgotten what situation they were in. “I think it’s that way.”

Catra saw that picture again and took a long deep breath.

“Or not”, the other laughed. “Well I’m out of ideas, we tried every way already. Our only option is to burn the place to the ground.

Though it would be unfortunate for the experiment."

"And everyone still inside", Catra added only to be blinked at with no thought behind those magenta eyes. "Like your staff? Or us?"

"Oh", the princess exclaimed. "Maybe we should try going that way." And she kept walking, with Catra following even if she really didn't want to. If she was being honest, she had little to no hope that they would make it out alive. If the bots didn't take them out, they would starve before they found that stupid lab. Or the exit, at least.

Now she really regretted not eating anything.

Entrapta kept rambling on about some experiment or other while they walked, but Catra didn't really listen, rather trying to focus on the noise from the bots, so they could be prepared.

After half an hour, or possibly more, she suddenly heard a different noise. She stopped, grabbing the princess by the arm to stop her too.

"More bots?", she asked, looking around, but naturally didn't see anything.

What Catra heard were footsteps, human ones. She dragged the scientist with her into the direction of the noise, which was hard because she only had a vague direction and more often than not, she took a wrong turn because of this confusing place.

At some point, though, she noticed the steps getting louder. Which was when Entrapta heard them too.

"Oh, is that your friend? Yay!", the princess called out, but Catra ignored her.

After a few more turns, she almost ran into the boy, who came to an abrupt stop. And he was out of breath. "Catra!", he cheered happily. "Uh, bots. They're-", he started giving a vague explanation about why he had been running probably.

"I know", she cut him off.

"I'm out of arrows", he breathed out, clearly exhausted. "Well, not quite, but it seems that they get attracted by noise and I feel like my sonic arrow will just make things worse."

"You're right", she told him and could hear the bots drawing nearer. "We should go. This is Entrapta, by the way."

“Hi!”, Entrapta said before turning back to Catra. “So, the hearing thing is also very interesting”, she started.

"Later", Catra growled. "Now we run."

Arrow Boy didn't need more instructions, but Entrapta was sometimes a bit slow to process things, so Catra just dragged her along until she could run herself.

"It's nice to meet you, princess Entrapta", the boy got out between breaths. "Maybe not the best circumstances, but still."

The princess only made a noise of acknowledgement, and Catra wasn't sure if it was because she was feeling awkward or because of the running.

She decided to change the topic. "You haven't found her lab anywhere, did you?", she asked Arrow Boy.

"I didn't see any doors, actually", he responded.

That was unfortunate, but she hadn't had much hope anyway. They needed to stop and think for a moment, so she looked out for any gap that they could hide in. When she spotted one, she dragged them in there and threw a hand over Entrapta's mouth as they waited for the robots to pass them by. When they did, they waited a bit longer and then allowed themselves to catch their breaths.

Entrapta was the first to leave their hideout to look around.

Meanwhile Arrow Boy focused his attention on Catra. "Are you okay? You just disappeared and… I'll admit I was a bit worried something might happen to you."

She scoffed. "I can handle myself."

"Didn't say you couldn't", he shot back.

"I'm fine", she grumbled with a roll of her eyes. "Are you?"

He smiled and she regretted saying anything. "A bit bruised maybe, but nothing lethal."

"Oh, I think it's that way!", Entrapta then called out to them.

"Could you try to announce that a bit quieter next time?", she growled and quickly ushered her along, so they could avoid another fight.

Catra's claws might be more permanently usable, unlike Bow's arrows, but she was starting to feel a bit sore. The less they had to fight, the better.

So, she simply followed the princess in random directions because Entrapta still didn't actually know where they were. Trying to find logic in this place was absolutely impossible anyway.

At least the presence of another science geek distracted the woman from her odd fascination with Catra’s bodily functions enough that she could relax a bit.

After what must have been another hour, the scientist suddenly stopped and walked back a few steps. “Oh, we’re here!”, she then told them with relief. “I mean, of course we’re here, we were never lost”, she added as if her two visitors had not been walking into several dead ends with her.

Entrapta happily walked up to the door to put in a code and was consequently electrocuted.

Arrow Boy was at her side quickly, to make sure she was okay, but the scientist seemed to be fine. “Wow!” Excited even. “The door is infected too, it won’t let us in. That is so smart!”

Catra raised her eyebrows again, honestly starting to question that woman’s sanity.

“And awful, we’re all gonna die”, she added then and Catra couldn’t help but facepalm.

“Out of the way”, she told them and they took a step to the side each without question.

She hadn’t even thought about the possibility of also getting electrocuted before she had cut the first line into the door and was very relieved when nothing happened, so she quickly cut in three more and then proceeded to kick the rectangle she had created away to reveal the lab and some more robots.

With a groan she went inside and started to cut down these things too. When she was done, she was sure she looked absolutely feral, but Arrow Boy just nodded proudly. Entrapta for her part was focused for once, already running towards her main computer.

“How fascinating, it has completely protected itself”, she mumbled into her recorder as she stared at the disk. “The disk has physically connected itself to my mainframe.” A few dots on one screen started to blink, and move towards them — probably more bots.

“Great, how do we turn it off?”, Catra interrupted, trying to hurry things along a bit.

“The power conduit!”, the princess said, pointing at the thickest cable Catra had ever seen.

Bow and Entrapta used all their strength to tear it out. Catra would have helped, but she was too exhausted. Neither of the two seemed to care anyway.

For a moment everything shut off. Then a light started to emit from the disk, turning everything back on again.

“It’s running on its own power now!”, Entrapta cackled.

Catra knew they were running out of time and she also had no idea how they had managed to destroy it the first time. She knew it could be easily cut or snapped in half, but with all this tech attached to it, she would surely get a shock this time. Her claws were not long enough to safely touch it.

She looked around, trying to find something to smash into it, but even though there were a bunch of parts and scraps lying around, nothing looked sturdy enough to ram into the thing.

Her surely panicked eyes landed on Arrow Boy eventually, who looked around, trying to find a solution, too. Then it hit her.

"Use your arrow", she told him.

"But it'll draw more bots", he protested.

"Not if you destroy the disk with it. It's still an arrow", she reminded him, just as new bots turned the corner. "Hurry up!"

He got to work immediately, placing the arrow onto his bow. "I need more distance or the hit might not be impactful enough", he then said.

Catra looked around and saw something like a machine, or a pipe or whatever — it was tall and further back in the room, it would hopefully create enough distance. "Entrapta, can you get him up there?"

The princess had been studying the disk up until now and seemed confused for a second before the words sunk in. "Oh, yeah!"

Entrapta used her hair to lift the boy up, while Catra used her claws to climb out of the incoming bots' way. Up there, Arrow Boy finally used his arrow. "I believe in you!", he yelled as he let it fly.

It was a perfect shot and while the sound was absolutely horrible, it did shatter the disk into tiny pieces.

They all watched as every single thing in the room powered down before anyone let out a cheer.

"We did it!", Entrapta was the first to scream as she did a little dance before lifting herself back down to inspect what remained of her robots.

Catra only let out a sigh of relief and then impulsively went over to the disk to pick up the pieces and take them with her. Considering that Entrapta still has had that thing in the Northern Reach, she must have fixed it the first time to keep experimenting with it and having seen what it did to Adora, she really didn't want to know this disk in the small scientist's hands.

Luckily, Bow went over to Entrapta to make sure the princess was alright, and neither could see how she pocketed every last piece of it.

"Thank you so much for saving me!", Entrapta then said. "I would be honored to join your rebellion and when can I visit to discuss your abilities?", she turned her attention back to Catra.

"Since you're a part of the alliance now, you can technically visit whenever", Arrow Boy told her.

Catra didn't feel like spending time with the scientist anytime soon, though. "Just give it a few days, okay? This was a lot."

"Noted! I'll see you in a few days then!" After that, she turned around to keep assessing the damage and seemingly went back to work.

That was good enough of a goodbye for Catra. There was just one little problem. "How do we get back outside?"

"Oh, right", Entrapta seemed to remember. She threw the pad she had carried with her at her. "Just leave it by the door when you're

out.” The woman didn’t even turn around.

“Thanks”, Catra said, activated the thing and got going, Arrow Boy behind her.

"A map is good. I really don't want to get lost again", he said and slumped into himself a little, seemingly just as out of energy as she was. “She seems nice, though.”

“Sure”, Catra mumbled. Nice wasn’t particularly the word she would use to describe the princess. She wasn’t bad, of course, and yes, she could be nice, she supposed, but doing anything with her was also exhausting.

She wondered how the other mission went. The frustrated part of her hoped it had gone just as bad, but the part of her that wouldn’t accept a defeat, hoped it went well.

"I hope the others had an easier time", Arrow Boy said, apparently thinking about the same thing. "Are you really okay? You can tell me if you got hurt, you know."

"I'm really fine. Just tired", she answered, knowing that she would avoid sleep regardless.

He hummed. "Me too. At least, I'll be on a boat next time. I don't think I can do much walking tomorrow. I wish I could get the day off, too."

"What?", she asked, confused.

"Right, you weren't there anymore", he mumbled and chuckled a bit awkwardly. "Well, Adora said you probably wouldn't want to go to Salineas, and … I think you said that, too. So, you'll get a day off and we'll go on another mission."

Catra wasn't sure what to think about that. She didn't really like the idea of having a day off. What would she even do? She could train, she guessed, but… Arrow Boy was right, their muscles would probably be sore for a few days.

She never had a day off before. This didn't feel like she would like it. For a brief moment she considered asking the boy for some advice — he probably had a bit of experience — but she ended up not doing that. He was okay to be around, yes, but she would not discuss recreational activities with the guy.

Her lack of a response at least didn't seem to bother him. "And the other good thing is that the mission was a success!"

"Yeah", she agreed. That was good. It might mean a bit more trust. And privacy.

He smiled in that weird, soft way again. "And, if I dare say it, we were a pretty good team. You with your quick thinking, and I had my arrow. And see? It was good for something in the end. If only for the purpose of having been spared until the very end."

Catra felt a chuckle rise in her, and cleared her throat to push it back down. "I guess", she replied noncommittally. "We should almost be out", she then said, trying to change the topic a little.

"Already?", the other exclaimed in shock. “We’ve been wandering for hours when we could have made it in an out in less than 30 minutes?”

“Seems so”, she mumbled. “This place is terrible.”

“I consider agreeing.”

Then Catra heard steps again, several. For a second she had been worried that Entrapta might have noticed the disk was gone and would demand it back, but who rounded the corner were three very colorful people, who stopped dead at the sight of the duo.

“You’re the kitchen staff, I assume”, Catra called out and they nodded.

“We were checking to see if it was finally over”, the big woman told them.

“It is, no reason to worry anymore”, Arrow Boy assured them.

The three looked at each other and seemingly had some silent conversation. “Are you from the rebellion?”, the man then asked and Bow nodded. “Can we come with you?”

“We can’t do this anymore!”, the smaller woman cried out and immediately covered her mouth with a hand as if she was worried to attract any bots.

Catra shared a look with Arrow Boy, who seemed just as unsure as she was. She weighed her options, which were none really. They couldn’t really tell them no and to suck it up, no matter how much she had wanted to. That wouldn’t be a good look for the rebellion. Besides, since Brightmoon had a bunch of refugees from Thaymor already, she was sure these three could be easily placed with them or something.

“Sure, whatever”, she mumbled eventually and kept walking. Since no one protested, she assumed that either Arrow Boy came to the same conclusion, or for some reason just decided to trust her. Either way, she had no energy to care anymore.

At the door, as promised, she left the pad and then they walked all the way back to Brightmoon in the last light of the day. They really had been wandering a long time in there. If she was being honest with herself, she never wanted to step foot in that castle again.

“I still have all that food. Anyone hungry?”, Bow then asked and looked around.

Without hesitation, Catra grabbed two sandwiches at once and started to stuff her face, all the while ignoring the boy's knowing smile.

Chapter End Notes

Next, we'll go see what the other team was up to <33

Until then, stay hydrated <33

Chapter 7: Perfuma

Chapter Notes

> I feel like the pacing on this one is off... but I might have just stared at it too long because I've rewritten almost every conversation like five times because something was always bothering me... I'm tired.
>
> Anyway, I still hope you enjoy this chapter <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, you and Catra get along now?", Glimmer asked, only a few minutes after they had said their goodbyes to the duo going to Dryl.

"Yeah", Adora answered then, and couldn't help but smile. "It seems like she's ready to make an effort."

"You sound surprised", the girl said with a raised eyebrow.

"Well… I am. She's stubborn. Like, she would rather burn the world down than apologize type of stubborn", she told them, wincing a little considering how close the girl had actually come to that. "And I mean, she hasn't apologized exactly, and I also don't expect her to, but she hasn't lashed out again, even though I can tell she's annoyed, so she seems to be really trying."

"Is she?", Glimmer asked, though. "I mean, not to question your judgment, but she did growl at me and refused to eat or talk to us. I didn't notice much of a difference."

"She didn't try to start a fight with you", Scorpia pointed out, optimistically. "I say that's improvement."

"I just think that's weird", the girl said. "She seems to be most at ease when she can annoy me, so that's actually something to worry about."

She had a point, now that Adora thought about it. Catra had been very quiet today and while she had thought the girl was trying to be more considerate, maybe she should have worried instead.

"You're right", Scorpia agreed thoughtfully. "But she hasn't slept very well, so… maybe that's why she's so quiet?", she suggested.

"She slept?", Glimmer asked, seemingly shocked. Adora understood that. "And I wouldn't call her quiet exactly, she seemed more…" She waved her hands around, looking for a word. "Unsettled? I don't know, like the calm before the storm."

The woman hummed. Then she turned to Adora. "Shouldn't you know something? I mean, you grew up together, right? You know her best."

"I don't know about that", she mumbled quickly. Even if they ignored the months of separation, Catra has always had her secrets, and has always been incredibly hard to read.

"How does one grow up in the Horde anyway?", Glimmer asked then with a confused look.

For a moment, Adora was happy about the little deviation from the topic, but this question wasn't any easier to answer. "Uh, that's… not a nice story", she mumbled vaguely.

“That’s why I want to hear it”, Glimmer told them. “You… you do seem to be trustworthy and you clearly want to help. Well, with the exception of Catra, but… what I mean is, that you might have been right, saying that not everyone in the Horde is evil and I think I need to really understand if I want to fight with you", she rambled. "I… I understand if you don’t want to talk about it, of course, but I’d still like to hear about it.”

She was never good at saying no to Glimmer. “Not everyone in the Horde is good, either. Some went there voluntarily and are even fine with the destruction", she started, thinking of Shadow Weaver and some Force Captains. "But … a lot of people, like us, have been in the Horde since we were babies. Pretty much from the

moment we could walk, we were trained for battle in-between basic lessons for reading, writing and math”, she kept going, thinking of the better parts of growing up. “After we could do all that, it was just training for the next few years and a few strategy lessons here and there. Catra was always the best at those. No matter how Shadow Weaver tried to make her lose, she always got at least very close to winning”, Adora fondly remembered.

Glimmer hummed. “So she is smart?”

“If she wants to be”, Adora snorted. "She has a tendency to let other people do the work." Then a realization hit her. "But maybe that was Shadow Weaver's fault", she mumbled.

She remembered their encounter in the Crystal Castle like it was yesterday. The memories, all the things Catra had said. It wasn't like the feline never wanted more, just that she was deliberately kept from reaching it, so she stopped trying.

Adora felt a bit stupid for only figuring it out now.

"Who is that Shadow Weaver?", the princess then asked. "You mentioned her a couple times, she seems to be important", she added an explanation.

Adora took a deep breath and tried not to let too much of her resentment show. “She’s a sorceress. She’s been in charge of our squad and has basically raised us, I guess. Not very well, though. There was a lot of manipulation involved.”

"When you say manipulation…", the girl started, but let whatever the question was unnamed.

She had an idea of what she wanted to know and she was not sure if she was ready to confront that. "I don't know", she mumbled therefore. "All I know is that it really messed with our heads."

"Do you think it could explain why Catra's so … defensive?", Glimmer then asked, circling back to the original topic.

"Maybe", she mumbled.

Honestly, Adora had never thought about it that way. She had always assumed it was just how Catra was, but maybe it wasn't a personality trait and just a reaction to a life under Shadow Weaver.

Catra never talked about these things, what happened whenever the sorceress summoned her or even what happened when the girl was just suddenly in a bad mood.

"Well, I was lying, obviously!" The words rang in her head. What else had Catra lied about? How many things did she downplay just to spare Adora's feelings? And she hadn't noticed just how much the feline had been suffering, had just rolled her eyes and moved on.

“Adora?”, Glimmer called out to her and carefully touched her shoulder. “Are you okay? I didn't mean to make you sad.”

“I'm fine, why wouldn’t I be?”, she asked quickly, probably a bit too cheerfully. She was such an idiot.

"We're here for you, if you want to talk or just need a hug", Scorpia offered then. "I mean, what you just said, that's… wow, I never realized how good I had it being ignored all the time."

"Okay, no", Glimmer interrupted. "There's no way that's better. Well, maybe, but that doesn't make it good either. That was your kingdom and they took it and couldn't even bother to include you? How dare they? That's just as bad as mistreating kids for no reason. No wonder you wanted to leave."

Scorpia considered it. "You know.. they always told me that my grandfather gave the kingdom to Hordak. Like voluntarily."

"I really doubt that", the girl said with a shake of her head. "They were probably just manipulating you, too. That is so messed up."

"I never thought about that", Scorpia mumbled, clearly having to process some things.

Adora didn't know what to say now, so she awkwardly cleared her throat. "So, how much further until we get to Plumeria?"

Glimmer raised an eyebrow, surely knowing what Adora was doing, but then she sighed, letting it be. "We should be getting closer. Can't be far", she told them.

And closer they got. With every minute that ticked by, the worse the nature around them started to look. Adora remembered how everything had been dying and after having seen what Plumeria was supposed to look like, it hit different than last time.

The branches of trees started to hang downwards and the leaves looked too orange for summer, eventually even turning into a decaying brown.

"Is it just me or does this place look… dead?", Scorpia asked carefully. "I mean, I don't know much about princesses, or nature, maybe that's normal?"

"No, it's not", Glimmer said slowly, as she worriedly eyed her surroundings. "This can't just be a problem with the supply route. Something is seriously wrong here."

Just then, Adora spotted the familiar smoke that rose above the trees and pointed to it. "The Horde camp. They must be doing something to the plants", she suggested, hopefully without giving away just how much she knew it to be true.

"But that doesn't make any sense. The runestone should still keep them alive even if the Horde does something", Glimmer said, though the doubt in her voice gave away that she believed Adora's theory. "Maybe we should check it out, though."

"Didn't the queen say to not engage the Horde?", Scorpia asked, clearly nervous about the prospect of disobeying orders.

Glimmer just snorted. "Since when has that ever stopped me?", she asked with a mischievous smirk and Scorpia looked even more nervous.

Adora held back a laugh. She had hoped that Glimmer's impulsive and rebellious nature would get them where they needed to be without her having to interfere much, or act — she shuddered at the thought.

They walked a few more minutes and a clearing came into view. The people there didn't seem to notice the new arrivals, which might be due to the lack of a glowing warrior — she had decided to just be Adora this time and avoid any misunderstandings from the start.

"You're here!", the unmistakable voice of Perfuma called out, as the woman rushed over, wasting no time to create bouquets and flower crowns out of thin air and placing them on the newcomers.

"Princess Perfuma", Glimmer said, looking a bit unsure as to what to do with the extreme amount of flowers in her hands. "We brought food and supplies for you. And we want to help you with the blockade."

Perfuma smiled gratefully and looked over at the cart that had been pulled by a very bored looking horse. "Look everyone", she told her people, who started to look over to them from far away, wary of their guests. "The rebellion has sent us provisions!"

That seemed to break the ice and the people rushed over too, to take a look at what they had brought. The princess, meanwhile, led them towards the clearing.

“Our people have lived here in tranquility for thousands of years", she kept talking. "We’re known for our beautiful flowers, our majestic trees.” She moved over to a huge tree with pink leaves. “And this is the Heart-Blossom, the center of our kingdom and the source of all my magical powers.”

Glimmer took a good look at it. "At least this tree is fine", she mumbled with relief. "What happened to everything else?"

Perfuma looked uncomfortable. “We’re going through a little rough patch, but I’m sure the universe will right itself soon.”

The three of them looked at each other, doubt displayed on all their faces.

The princess seemed to pick up on it. “Look, the blight hit right after the Horde arrived. We don’t know why and nothing I do stops it”, she admitted, clearly uncomfortable. “But we don’t dwell on the negative. Look at the positive. The Heart-Blossom is still healthy and the celebration is about to begin!”

"You want to celebrate while your land is dying?", Glimmer asked then. "We should do something about this. Fight! Scare those Horde soldiers so they never come back." The girl was clearly way too excited about that prospect.

Perfuma sighed. “We’re not fighters. All I can do is grow pretty flowers”, she said and made one in her hand. “All we want to do is live peacefully in our ancestral home.”

"There is no peace as long as you let the Horde do … whatever they are doing. This is your kingdom, you have to-", Glimmer kept arguing.

"I am well aware of that", Perfuma interrupted, seemingly a bit offended. "What am I supposed to do? Gift them flowers and ask nicely?" She took a breath, centering herself again. "The universe will make sure to repay the Horde for their evil deeds. I have to believe that."

Scorpia cleared her throat then, effectively distracting the two princesses. "I hate to interrupt, but what is a … celebration?"

Perfuma relaxed visibly and giggled a little. "Come on, I'll show you", she said and grabbed the other woman by the pincers.

Adora and Glimmer were left behind, staring at the pair.

"Why won't she fight?", the princess then asked frustratedly. "What if she doesn't want to join the rebellion?"

"She will", Adora tried to calm her. She knew that Perfuma did enjoy fighting quite a bit, after she had tried it. "Maybe if we spend some time with them, they'll listen to us?" It came out like a question because it was one — how did they do this last time, again?

Glimmer sighed. "Maybe", she agreed. "Come on."

They walked over to where the celebration had started. It was the usual — eating, dancing, telling stories, some games. Don't get her wrong, Adora loved parties, no matter how small they were. It was just that Glimmer was brooding next to her and Scorpia was practically attached to Perfuma. She had too much space to think, so she did. About Catra, mostly.

Her earlier realizations still worried her. All the things she must have misunderstood about her friend. Maybe that was why Catra had such a hard time adjusting, too.

She roamed her memories, thinking about how, while she had been confused about several things, Adora had adjusted to Brightmoon rather quickly. Scorpia seemed to be the same way. And yes, they had only been here a couple of days, but considering it was a new experience for both Scorpia and Catra, it was a bit odd that one of them fit in so quickly while the other didn't.

Part of it was probably because Scorpia was a good bit more open minded about the whole thing while Catra had already decided a long time ago that she would hate the rebellion, but the other part — or so Adora wondered — might be because the feline had more negative experiences with people.

"Cookie?"

She startled to see Perfuma hold out a plate with sweets. "Oh, thanks", she mumbled as she took one.

The woman smiled and settled into a pillow next to her.

Everything had been a blur since her thoughts had been preoccupied, but somehow she had ended up in the story teller circle. Glimmer was gone, too, and Scorpia was enthralled by the story teller — that was probably why the princess decided to leave her alone to check on Adora.

The man there told stories about She-Ra, well Mara probably. Or maybe She-Ras from before her even. She wondered how true they really were. Knowing how much about herself had been exaggerated, who knew what else was a lie.

"You have a lot of negative energy surrounding you", Perfuma said when the story teller took a break. "Not like your positivity is getting blocked exactly, but like your sunshine is getting overshadowed by guilt or doubt."

Adora blinked at the woman. "I- I'm not… I mean, I guess", she stumbled over her words.

The other gave her a soft smile. "Feeling regret or doubt is very natural", she assured. "Though, we shouldn't let it take control."

She only nodded, unsure what to do with that information or what it meant exactly. Since the princess smiled brighter, though, she suspected that her confusion wasn't all that obvious.

"Your friend is similar", the woman kept going. "I can tell that she has a lot of kindness to give, but there's something … like a dark cloud surrounding her."

"We uh… grew up in the same, terrible place. It might be that", Adora offered since she didn't know what else to say.

Perfuma nodded. "Are you having fun?", she then changed the topic. "Joyful experiences can help unblock you." Or maybe not.

"Uh, yeah", she mumbled. She hadn't even noticed much of anything.

The princess gave her a pitiful look, probably looking through her lie. "Sharing experiences with a friend might help stay in the moment", she told her with an encouraging smile. "I'll be checking on Scorpia again. Make sure to enjoy yourself."

Adora sighed. Somehow, the woman was right. While it felt wrong to enjoy herself when this place was dying, she had to stay in the moment.

She got up and looked for Glimmer, who leaned bored against a tree next to the snacks and some kids.

"How's it going? Having fun?", the girl asked when she got close enough.

"Mostly feeling watched", she answered as she noticed now how everyone was looking around, glancing over to them occasionally.

Glimmer hummed. "These people clearly expect an attack or something. But they still won't fight", she grumbled.

Adora tried to, once again, remember how they convinced these people last time, but she truly had no idea. They had just shown up at the battle. "They have more fight in them than they think, we just got to… get it out of them", she said vaguely.

"Or, we go down there, kick some butt and save theirs", Glimmer suggested.

Adora chuckled a bit. "We're just three people."

"Well with She-Ra, we're four."

"That's not how that works", she mumbled, but it didn't seem to actually get through to the other.

"Maybe if they know that She-Ra is back, they'll get some hope and are more willing to fight", she voiced out the next idea.

"I don't know." Last time that didn't go well and she had disappointed them all.

"Did you say She-Ra?", Perfuma asked, suddenly next to her again. How did she do that?

Despite all of her objections, no matter how tiny they have been, Glimmer jumped right into it. "Yes!", she exclaimed, all but pushing Adora a bit forward. "She got chosen or whatever. We got a new She-Ra!"

The girl was loud enough that soon the entire village was surrounding them, asking her questions of why she doesn't look like the typical picture of She-Ra or where her sword was or if she was going to fight the Horde all on her own.

She scrambled to answer whatever she could, but the questions came so fast, she gave up eventually.

"See?", Perfuma interrupted eventually. "The universe has heard our pleas and sent us a new She-Ra to save us! Will you be healing our land?", she then asked towards Adora.

This time around, she at least knew how to heal, but knowing how the Horde would continuously poison the land, she doubted it would help much. "I mean, I can, but the Horde will keep damaging the nature here and we can only fix that together", she told the princess as much.

The woman sighed. "It's not like I don't want to save my kingdom", she told them solemnly. "But I can't fight. I make flowers."

"Perfuma, you are so strong", she told her, only regretting it a second later. How does she make this seem less weird? "I don't think that your powers are weak. You can control plants and so

many of them. You don't even have to hurt anyone, you could… I don't know, restrain them?"

Perfuma still didn't look all that convinced.

"We're here to help you", Scorpia then said. "You won't be alone. You are so nice, you deserve to keep your home. And uh… there's nothing negative about fighting back?"

The princess smiled, though it wasn't the soft one from before — somehow it felt like she was smiling just to not make Scorpia feel bad about the slightly awkward sentiment.

Glimmer took a step forward. "The Horde will keep attacking. Even if we could go down there and defeat them all on our own, they'll just come back eventually. But if you show them that they shouldn't mess with Plumerians, they'll think twice — no thrice — about attacking you again."

Perfuma sighed, still not quite convinced, but Glimmer wasn't done yet.

"You are a princess. You are strong and we're here to help. You can't give up, this is your home", the girl added a bit more pleadingly.

"You are right", Perfuma said then. "I can't let someone else fight my battles, that would be irresponsible of me."

"That's the spirit!", Glimmer cheered, somehow actually encouraging the flower princess.

Surprisingly, the woman turned to Scorpia now. "And you are right, too. I was so scared to lose my positivity that I already accepted defeat. But fighting back can be a positive thing." She faced her people, then. "Everyone! Get the war-chimes! We will save our home!"

There were cheers everywhere and people ran to prepare themselves.

"What's the plan?", she then asked towards the trio.

"Well, you will distract the forces, use whatever you can and… feel comfortable with, and we will find and destroy what is causing all this", Adora said, looking at them in question.

"I think I'll stay with Perfuma", Scorpia told them. "You know, I'm better at fighting, and being the muscle person, so I should make sure that they stand a chance", she explained and they nodded.

Perfuma looked at the woman softly. "That is so sweet", she said before focusing back on the other two. "How will you find what is causing this?"

"It's probably whatever is making this smoke", Glimmer suggested. "Hopefully, otherwise this could be difficult."

"We can do this", Adora said confidently. "What was that you said? We can conquer anything?" She pulled her sword from her wrist. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Perfuma excitedly clapped upon seeing her transform. "With the She-Ra, I am sure we can do this. The universe is on our side."

***

The plan was simple. The Plumerians and Scorpia would attack the camp at the front, while Adora and Glimmer would sneak in through the back.

She would admit that being an incredibly tall, glowing being was not very practical when it came to hiding, but she wasn't taking any chances with Shadow Weaver. Catra said that the woman had picked up on her and She-Ra being the same last time, so the best solution she had, was to stick with one.

At least they didn't have to hide long, which was probably how they got away with She-Ra crouching behind the tiniest bush they could have found.

It wasn’t hard to determine the perfect moment to make their way in when they could hear Perfuma yell all the way across the camp.

“I said the universe will repay the Horde one day and today the universe is us!”, was the first one that told them the attack had begun. When a minute later they heard “I’ve never been so alive!” they decided to walk in.

The camp was positively empty at the back, which made it easy to find the building the smoke came from and get inside. It looked as disturbing as it had last time, and Adora debated how to best destroy it.

She could just blast or cut through it, but the machinery was connected to roots and she was worried she would damage them in the process.

"Those look like the roots from the Heart Blossom", Glimmer pointed out. Another reason not to randomly blast things. "That must be why Perfuma's powers can't keep anything alive anymore."

Alright, if she couldn't blast it, what else could she do? She could try to disconnect the pipes from the roots by brute force, maybe.

Since she had nothing better, that's what she did. It was not easy, those things were tightly attached, but She-Ra was stronger than Horde machinery. Sadly — as she discovered after tearing a pipe off — disconnecting it was not enough to shut it off. And it still leaked some weird liquid. If that got into the earth, they might make the problem even worse.

"Cables", Glimmer called out, staring at the ground and walking off, following a cable she apparently found.

Adora was confused shortly, but then she ran after the girl.

She kept an eye on the surroundings, ready to fight, just in case a stray Horde soldier found them, but they were seemingly all too distracted by Perfuma and her people.

The cable lead to another tent, where they did find a power generator.

"She-Ra, do your thing", Glimmer demanded, already taking a step back.

Adora didn't need to be told twice and swung her sword to cut the thing in half. For a second nothing happened, which confused her but she took a few steps back regardless. As if the generator had been waiting for her to be out of range, it went up in flames just as she had rejoined her friend.

Glimmer vanished shortly and came back grinning. "The entire place is dark, seems like this really turned it off", she announced.

And if they needed a different sign, below them vines with flowers grew, covering everything in the Horde camp. She guessed that meant that Perfuma had her full power back.

They joined the Plumerians in time to see the first soldiers flee at the sight of the rapidly growing flowers, but a few stuck around.

Adora didn't waste time to run into battle and throw a few people around. She didn't have fun doing it, but if the Plumerians hadn't scared them off, then only a few bruised could. Glimmer too, threw herself into battle without any hesitation.

She spotted Scorpia not too far from her, who was fighting rather ruthlessly as well — though she was apologizing the entire time.

Either way, with four princesses on the field, and seeing the damage they could inflict, it was eventually enough for even the most stubborn to turn and run.

When it seemed safe enough, they calmed down again and were ambushed by Perfuma, who went in to hug them. It was very tight for someone who looked so fragile.

"Thank you so much!", she said and made new flower crowns for them. "You truly inspired us. How can we ever repay you?", she asked.

"Join the rebellion", Glimmer suggested easily.

"Didn't that go horribly wrong the first time?", Perfuma asked, once more unsure.

"We're clearly stronger together", the girl pointed out. “The alliance of the past has broken apart because they stopped believing in change, but we are not going to let that happen again."

Perfuma chuckled. “Well, if you believe in this then so will I. I do get to hit more people with flowers, right?”, she then asked, expectedly having found a bit of violence to be enjoyable.

“Absolutely!”

“Yay”, she cheered. “You have a new ally. Hey everyone!”, she turned around. “Looks at us. We’re mighty rebels now!” Everyone was seemingly happy with that. These people were odd.

Since the camp was covered in plants and the power generator has been destroyed, Adora chanced to detransform and received another hug.

"Thank you, the She-Ra", Perfuma told her again. "I wish you save travels, but you will have to excuse me. I have a celebration to prepare." She waved at them real quick and then she was off.

"At least they actually have something to celebrate now", Glimmer mumbled. "Alright, I'm beat. Mission success! Let's go home."

"Yeah, one down, two to go", Scorpia cheered as they started walking. "Do you think Catra was successful, too?"

Adora thought about how Catra probably knew Entrapta better than any of them. The chances were pretty good that she managed to convince the princess. "I think so."

Chapter End Notes

Someone has not enough awareness of Scorpia's excistence... (no, I will not explain xD)

Next time, we'll finish up the missions (and after that we'll get into some of my favorite chapters hehe)! Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 8: Salineas - Part 1

Chapter Notes

I don't have much to say for once... Have fun!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was about ready to collapse when they made it back to Brightmoon. They arrived late, very late — it was closer to midnight than it was to dinner time. She had hoped that people were already asleep by now, but then she saw Adora pace at the entrance and she considered turning around and climbing in at the back.

But she was too tired for that. "Hey Adora", she called out with what little energy she had.

"Catra!" Now Adora was running towards them, but stopped awkwardly when she got into arms reach. "And Bow. I'm glad you made it. We were worried about you." The blonde gave her a once over and Catra became very aware of how disheveled she must look.

“Really? Oh, that’s so nice”, Bow cooed because of course he did.

“We’re fine, it just took a bit longer”, Catra replied casually.

“Well, queen Angella had wanted to have a brief discussion about our missions, but seeing how late it is, I’m sure we can reschedule”, Adora then said, walking alongside them. “Also, what’s with them?”, she then asked pointed at the three figures walking behind them.

“Entrapta’s kitchen staff. After the entire thing today, they decided they didn’t want to live there anymore, so they came with us”, she explained shortly.

As if Bow suddenly remembered their existence — which might be plausible, as they had been extremely quiet the entire time — he ran over to the nearest guard. "Excuse me, could you please take care of them.” They nodded. “Thank you.” And Arrow Boy was back by her side. "We can have a meeting, I don't mind. What about you?"

Catra was a bit taken aback then, having expected him to answer for the both of them. "A meeting is fine. As long as I can finally sit down."

"Oh, yeah, sitting sounds nice", he easily agreed. "I haven't sat down since breakfast."

"I think I got to sit down for like two minutes once", Catra remember her little breakdown after the wall had swallowed her.

Adora chuckled awkwardly, eying them curiously. "Long day, huh?"

"There was a lot of running involved", Arrow Boy explained for the blonde and she nodded, but it didn't seem to clear anything up for her.

"Yeah, and a lot of walking in the wrong direction", Catra added, a bit of anger shining through her voice.

"For someone so smart, Entrapta really didn't think that design through", the boy said, and she couldn't hold back the snort that escaped her.

Adora kept giving them an odd look, but apparently didn't want to say anything. Catra wasn't sure what that meant. It wasn't that weird to complain with someone. That didn't mean they were friends.

When they arrived at the meeting room, everyone was already there waiting. The queen had even brought a book to entertain herself with in the meantime. When the door opened she looked up and put it aside while they took a seat.

When Catra sat down, she had to swallow a satisfactory sigh. Sitting, finally.

“Now, I will make this quick”, the queen said. “Glimmer?”

Sparkles looked a bit nervous as she stood. “Our mission was a success. We brought the supplies to Plumeria and convinced princess Perfuma to join the rebellion."

"And?", the woman asked with a sigh. So not only Catra had picked up on the girl's anxiety.

"The Horde was poisoning their lands. What were we supposed to do? We *had* to fight them", she defended. "And no one got hurt. No one important anyway."

The queen sighed, clearly disappointed, but probably too tired to deal with this. "Bow?"

"Well, it didn't exactly go smooth. Entrapta's castle was infected with some virus and we were attacked by killer robots. But we took care of that and Entrapta has agreed to join the rebellion", he told the queen.

"Also, she’ll be visiting shortly. Also, her kitchen staff has fled the castle with us and now needs a place to live”, Catra added and Arrow Boy nodded.

“That certainly explains why you were so late”, Sparkles mumbled.

Bow chuckled. “Oh, it was crazy. When we went inside it was barely noon and by the time we made it out, the daymoon was already setting. You really lose sense of… everything in there.”

“Alright then”, the queen said, though she appeared a bit worried about what she had heard. “The missions all turned out well in the end. Even if I do not approve of your blatant disrespect of my orders, Glimmer."

"We needed to help them!", the girl argued.

"I would very much like to ban you from your other mission to Salineas", the woman threatened, making the princess sputter in shock. "But… I know that the royal family of Salineas values etiquette, so I cannot sent a team without a proper diplomat."

"Yes!"

They queen sighed again. "And another thing before I forget. The staff was able to clear out two more rooms if you wish for more privacy", she told them. "They are right adjacent to the one you already have. Now, rest up. You are dismissed."

Everyone got up with relief, probably eager to get to bed. Not so much Catra, who followed with little enthusiasm.

"So, killer robots, huh?", Sparkles asked then as they made their way through the hallway, mostly talking to Arrow Boy, which was alright with Catra.

"Yeah, Entrapta's bots all tried to kill us to protect this disk thing that has infected them. But Catra made sure they didn't even get a chance. This girl is the most elegant fighter I have ever seen. I wish you had been there, it was beautiful", the boy answered.

"Really?", the princess asked with disbelief, while Catra tried not to get red. What was happening?

Adora bumped into her then, with a smug smile. "I always knew that", she whispered, and Catra didn't know what she was even supposed to feel at this point. It was weird, she didn't like it.

"Shut up", she grumbled and crossed her arms.

"Well, you should have seen Adora", Sparkles then said proudly. "The way she threw those Horde soldiers around like they weighed nothing? She-Ra is a machine."

The two kept going a bit like this, comparing them and telling the other how great they were — now even Adora got red, but Catra

only questioned what this was supposed to be. Some sort of battle about who had the better mission partner?

They didn't even much care about what happened with their rooming situation. When they reached Adora's room, the two just kept walking and bickering.

"Those two are weird", Catra mumbled then and rolled her eyes. If it hadn't been for Scorpia, she would have made another comment about how she didn't understand how Adora ever managed to be friends with them.

The blonde just shrugged. "Well, at least they seem to be a bit more trusting of us." Then she looked to the closed door of her room. "So…?"

Scorpia awkwardly cleared her throat then. "Yeah, not gonna lie, while it was nice sharing a room with you, I would take my own, actually… You uh… and I say this with love, you fight in your sleep and it kind of keeps me up. So. If you don't mind."

Catra snorted at the mention of Adora's seemingly persistent sleep fighting habits, but the girl seemed to be a bit embarrassed about it. "Oh, yeah, that's fine", she answered and forced a smile.

Scorpia, luckily, was too dense to notice the obvious lie, and made quick work at getting her few belongings out of the old and into her new room. By the sounds of it, the woman seemed to like it.

That left the two former best friends.

Catra had no intention to move from her shed. She had gotten quite comfortable there, but before she could leave for some alone time, she still had to do something, so she went into Adora's room and searched for an empty drawer in the dresser.

She heard the blonde follow behind her. "You're not going to stay." It wasn't much of a question, but it was obviously making the girl sad.

The truth was, though, that they weren't there yet. Maybe they never would be. "No", she answered honestly even though there wasn't technically anything to answer. “Have you seriously never realized that the two days you can’t remember were because of the same disk?”, she then asked because it was the better topic.

“What?”, Adora asked, clueless as she was.

Catra found an empty spot and fished out the remains of the disk to place them inside. “Entrapta’s virus was coming from this First Ones disk. The same one I used against you in the Northern Reach. That really hasn’t clicked for you, huh?”

Adora came closer to look at the shards. “I’ve never noticed, no”, she said and laughed a little. “Why do you have those?”

“Didn’t want Entrapta to put it back together.” She hesitated with the next part, but decided to say it. “You may not remember, but I do. You almost killed me, which I guess was my fault, but… even when you weren’t She-Ra, you were out of it. Wasn’t very nice to look at.”

Suddenly there was a hand on hers. “It’s a good thing you took it. I never want to hurt you again.”

Maybe it wasn’t the better topic, after all. “Anyway”, she said, freeing her hand and walking over to the window. “It’s late. Goodnight Adora.” Then she jumped out and bolted to her greenhouse.

Whoever arranged the rooms at least didn’t remove her stuff. They probably didn't care enough to do that. Or they had just picked up on her avoidant tendencies, which was likely since there was also a guard still stationed here.

She lay down and stared at the ceiling for a good while and rubbed the spot on her hand that Adora had touched just now. It had been a while since they had done that.

Of course, they had touched each other plenty of times during fights, though that was more punching than touching. Over the last few days, they might have accidentally touched occasionally, but not like this. Not so soft and forgiving.

That was a ridiculous thought. There was no way that Adora had honestly forgiven her. She was just trying to rebuild the bridges that were destroyed. Not that Catra had really forgiven Adora either. The girl had still left her, had prioritized strangers over her best friend. But in a way, Catra had accepted it.

Adora was just like that, always helping, always sacrificing herself, always wanting to be acknowledged. It wasn’t something that Catra liked very much, but it was something she had gotten used to.

As soon as she was starting to drift off, she stopped those thoughts and focused on something else. Her nightmare was still fresh in her mind and she tried her best to force it down. Entrapta was fine, still her brilliant, annoying, energetic self. Catra hadn't ruined that yet.

And she wouldn't, she decided then. Entrapta, and by extension Scorpia, deserved better. However, that included more than just Catra's treatment. From what she knew about the scientist in particular, she hadn't felt at ease with the rebellion before, and Catra wanted to change that. For some reason.

The problem was just that she was no expert in the field of relationships. In fact, she had been just as terrible, if not worse, than the rebellion in the past… or whatever.

On top of that, the two women unfortunately — though, Catra really wasn't too unhappy about that — didn't remember anything, so there was no possibility in which she could just apologize and be done with it.

So, she had to do something else. Adora was right, hiding from the people she hurt wouldn't make her feel better. She wasn't sure

if her new idea would, either, but… she was here now, and she could at least try to make a change.

Catra had no real ambitions to be friends or anything, but she could at least do… something.

She sighed with the realization that she was terrible at this. Her only friend ever had been Adora and even that got messed up in the end. How was anyone supposed to learn this stuff in the Horde anyway?

With renewed energy, she got up again and walked to the castle, her guard sighing behind her. She was close to yelling at him to get over it — her body was on the brink of collapsing and she managed to still walk a bit.

She remembered that she had seen a library during her explorations, and she was trying to find it again, but she had opened so many doors that day, it took her an embarrassing amount of time to find it.

When she did, she was so used to opening and closing doors that she almost didn't notice she had opened the right one.

The library was massive. They technically had one in the Fright Zone, too, but compared to this it was honestly just sad. At the same time, she would have preferred a smaller one because it would make finding something easier.

She did have the entire night, though.

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When Adora came down to breakfast she was unsurprised to find that Catra was not there. She got majorly more concerned when

Scorpia joined them and said that the feline was not in the greenhouse, either.

"Don't worry, Adora, We'll find her", Netossa tried to calm her down — she and Spinnerella have decided to sit with them today, since they had developed a bit of trust by now. It was nice of them to offer some comfort, especially since Adora had no time to go on a search, but she also knew this would keep bothering her all day.

"I mean, she has stuck around this long, she'll be around somewhere", Glimmer added, waving a tiny piece of cake at her as she gestured around.

"And Entrapta wants to visit her, she wouldn't just leave", Bow also chimed in.

"Right", she answered to all that, but wasn't convinced. At this point she should probably have more faith in Catra, but the underlying worry that the girl will run and leave her alone was very persistent.

Catra wouldn't do that, though. Sure, the feline had thrown her off a cliff and had abandoned her in the portal, but last night they seemed almost fine for a second, before Catra had pulled away and ran. That still had to mean something, right? That they could fix things. She wouldn't leave. Right?

"Adora." Glimmer snacked her arm. "Relax, she'll still be here when we get back. Now get it together, I need you focused for this mission. Unless you want to stay behind and search for Catra yourself."

"Could I?", she asked, jumping at the offer, even though she knew she was needed more in Salineas.

"No!", the girl answered and Adora pouted.

"We promise, we'll make sure she's fine", Spinnerella assured her then with a certain amusement that she wasn't sure what it

meant. "You focus on your mission."

"Yeah", Bow said then. "Just think of our mission. We'll be on a boat- Oh, and we'll be going to Seaworthy where all the cool pirates are!"

"No. No pirates", Glimmer interrupted. "We are not there to have fun."

Now the boy pouted. "But… I always wanted to see the pirates."

"Me too!", Scorpia jumped in now. "I've read a contraband book when I was a kid about pirates, they're supposed to be super cool."

Adora had to smile a bit. "I mean, a few minutes can't hurt, right?", she tried to make a point for them.

Glimmer just groaned, though. "We have a plan, people! We're not there for sightseeing!"

Now they all frowned. "What's going on?", Bow then asked. "You're not usually the uptight plan person."

The princess sighed. "You saw my mom yesterday. I need this mission to go absolutely smooth, so she won't ground me or … maybe she'll never give me another mission", she mumbled with horror.

"That won't happen", Adora said. "I'm sure the queen knows your value. And she loves you. She wouldn't do that." The others nodded in agreement.

Glimmer didn't exactly looked convinced, but she did relax a bit. "Fine, five minutes, but then we'll have to search for a sea captain. We're on a tight schedule", she compromised and the two pirate enthusiasts cheered.

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The way to Seaworthy was about as long as to Plumeria, which meant they got there rather quickly, busying themselves on the way with Glimmer and Bow asking the two newcomers random questions, like if they had found foods they particularly enjoyed, now that it's been a few days.

Adora's answer was easy. She had fallen in love with cake a long time ago, though she wasn't a picky eater. But anything sweet, she devoured with joy.

Scorpia had the surprising answer of vegetables. She blushed a bit when she received confused glances, but explained that while she thought they were a bit disgusting on the first day, Perfuma had shown her a few more during the celebration and the woman had seemingly warmed up to it.

When they got closer to their temporary destination, Glimmer started to talk about how great Seaworthy was. "You're gonna love it", she told them excitedly.

Adora knew two things, though. One, the girl certainly had not liked Seaworthy and probably never would — it was much too dubious for her liking. And two, Glimmer had never been here before, making that statement entirely nonsensical.

Bow didn't call her out on it, though, too busy voicing his excitement and infecting Scorpia with it.

A minute later, the tavern came into view and Adora already didn't want to go inside. She agreed with it being too dubious, and she would make sure they could deal with Sea Hawk quickly — she already had a plan.

First, however, they had to give Bow and Scorpia their promised five minutes.

Glimmer and her watched as the other two first stood in awe and terror as they looked around the crowd of thieves, smugglers and pirates. Then they went discovering a bit, carefully making their way through the sea of people, giggling all the while.

In the meantime, Glimmer went to the bar to ask for a sea captain. Just like last time, Sea Hawk was pointed out to them, who was currently engaged in an arm wrestling match.

Adora wondered if that was an everyday activity for him. Last time, if she remembered correctly, Glimmer did get grounded for two weeks after their mission in Plumeria, but because they had planned all the missions in advance this time, they were weeks early. And yet, Sea Hawk was here, arm wrestling for drinks.

Maybe it was good they would reunite him with Mermista and recruit him for the rebellion because he seriously needed a better hobby.

Eventually, their two tourists came back, a little out of breath — possibly because of the excessive laughing.

"This is… loud, and violent", Scorpia told them then, coincidentally at the exact moment that someone was punched to stumble into the wall right next to them. "But I've never seen so many people have fun before."

"There are so many cool people here, I wish we could talk to them", Bow added.

"We'll talk to one of them", Glimmer reminded them. "The bartender said that this guy there is a sea captain, so we'll go over and convince him to take us to Salineas."

"Uh, how do we do that?", Scorpia asked.

Adora smiled. "Leave it to me. I got a plan", she told them confidently and went over. The others followed, though they seemed a bit confused.

Sea Hawk was already on his third arm wrestling match, and they waited for him to be finished.

"Are we sure about this?", Scorpia mumbled, watching the procedure skeptically.

"We have nothing better", Glimmer sighed.

It didn't take much longer, for them to finish their match. "I win!", Sea Hawk called out. His opponent threw a little pouch of money on the table and angrily stalked away, while he made himself comfortable in his booth.

Glimmer send her an expectant look, and Adora sat down on the now empty chair. "I'll go the next round", she announced.

"Adora", the girl next to her hissed, probably not having expected this to be the plan.

"Trust me", she whispered back. And Glimmer did. The girl leaned back a bit, though eying her skeptically, and let Adora do her thing.

"Oho", Sea Hawk laughed, apparently not noticing the short tension. "I've never seen you around here before. This could be interesting", he said while readying himself.

"I'm not playing for money or drinks, though", she told him, earning her a shocked expression before he schooled it back into his laid back vibe.

"No?", he asked, trying to sound casually curious. "What do you want then?"

She smiled. "We need a ride to Salineas. If I win, you take us." She paused briefly. "For free."

He sputtered a moment. "Why would I do that?", he asked, now looking slightly offended even.

Adora leaned back a little. "Oh, I'm sorry, I didn't think this would intimidate you", she bluffed. She might be a terrible actor, but she was good at crushing this guy's ego in particular. And her confidence was anything but fake, so obviously, he still felt challenged by it.

"I'm not-" He cleared his throat. "Alright, I'll play lassie. Just know that I am undefeated in arm wrestling."

She just hummed noncommittally and placed her arm on the table. Then it was on.

Adora would admit one thing, Sea Hawk was actually good. He was certainly a strong opponent, but Adora was better. Though it did take her a bit of effort, it was not an impossible feat. She had beat him several times already, after all.

“This is so dumb”, Glimmer mumbled behind her, in between the cheers from the others.

She saw Sea Hawk about to say something, and knowing it would be some random boast that may or may not be true, she put some more strength into her arm and beat him before he could say a single word.

Adora pumped her fists in the air in victory and Scorpia and Bow cheered behind her even louder. Glimmer just shook her head.

Sea Hawk stared at his hand for a second in shock, before standing tall again, clearing his throat. “Truth be told, I let you win so as to boost your confidence.” He cleared his throat again. “I’ve been wanting to go to Salineas anyway. To visit my close personal friend, princess Mermista.” He jumped over the table. “You were just lucky enough to meet me at this very opportune moment. Now come on, forth to adventure!"

Glimmer still didn't look like she liked what just happened. "At least it was quick", she said with a shrug, though. "I have a feeling you saved us from a lot of unnecessary speeches."

The girl had no idea.

They went outside to the docks to find Sea Hawk's boat. “Let's have some proper introductions", he announced. "My name is Sea Hawk and this is the Dragon's Daughter. Three", he said with a grand gesture while they made their way aboard.

"You're name is Sea Hawk?", Bow asked, practically with stars in his eyes.

“What happened to one and two?”, Scorpia added curiously.

“Tragically, they went down in flames”, Sea Hawk answered full of sadness.

“I feel like that shouldn’t happen”, Glimmer said. “How does a boat in the middle of the ocean even catch fire?”

“I set them on fire”, he told them with a shrug before running to the front of the boat, pointing towards the open sea. “Adventure!”

"Are we sure about this?", the princess asked with a look towards Adora. "I really do not want to know what his idea of adventure looks like."

"It's gonna be fine", she replied easily. "Maybe don't let him steer, though."

"Do not worry, I will teach you everything you need to know", Sea Hawk announced and cleared his throat, probably to start singing.

Glimmer's frustrated groan cut him off. "Please tell me one of you knows how to do this", she said towards Adora and Scorpia.

"Yeah, I took a bunch of classes because, you know, I had nothing better to do", Scorpia told them excitedly.

"Great!", the girl replied with relief. "You'll get us there, I'll do the lookout. Bow, check the gear and Adora… make sure he doesn't hurt anyone." With that she teleported to the crow's nest.

Sea Hawk stared after her in confusion. "How did she…?", he mumbled looking between the spot where Glimmer just was and where she stood now. Then the commands seemed to catch up to him. "This is my boat! I know very well how to use it", he then complained.

"Uh… I'm gonna need a map", Scorpia said awkwardly.

Despite his protests, he handed it over with a sigh.

"Don't take it personally", Adora tried to cheer him up a bit. "It's just an important mission, you know?"

“Of course, a top secret mission”, he said, already cheering up again. “I shall make sure you have the most adventurous sail!” He got up, striking a pose and started to sing.

“No, that’s not-” There was no stopping him now. She could only watch the man dance around the boat while singing about how great he was.

Bow and Scorpia cheered for him of course, effortlessly stroking the man's ego and he thrived on it.

"So, new crew. Who exactly are you?", he asked then as he looked over to Scorpia steering, Glimmer in perfect lookout position and Bow retying the knots. "You are strangely overqualified."

Since Adora was the only one without a real job, she decided to take over introductions. "Well, that's Glimmer, that's Bow, over there is Scorpia and I'm Adora. We're from the rebellion."

"The rebellion?", he repeated excitedly. "So this is a top secret mission from the queen?"

"Uh… I guess?", she mumbled.

"I am honored", he said with way too much bravado. He acted like he was about to receive a medal. "Best two out of three?", he

then asked, apparently bored already.

She laughed, rolling her shoulder and preparing herself. “You bet.”

They quickly put together a makeshift table and got going. It was to no ones surprise that he lost. “Go Adora!”, Glimmer yelled down from her lookout, while Bow took Sea Hawk's side, and Scorpia cheered for them both equally — for fairness — while they went again and again because Sea Hawk wanted at least one win so badly.

"We should reach Salineas soon", Scorpia interrupted eventually to give them an update.

“Already?” Sea Hawk was shocked. “Have we reached the Straits of Serpentine yet?”

“I’ve sailed around it.”

“You what?!”

Scorpia looked confused. "It's dangerous and it wasn't really on the way anyway", she explained awkwardly.

“But- I was-”, Sea Hawk stuttered. “I was going to give you a proper adventure!”

“We don’t need adventure!”, Glimmer called down again. “We need this mission to go smooth and impress my mom! It’s a miracle she didn’t say no to this one already! Just sit down, sing another shanty for all I care and let Scorpia do her thing!”

Scorpia smiled apologetically and turned her attention back to sailing. But giving Sea Hawk explicit permission to sing probably wasn’t the best idea because that’s what he did immediately, and without a single break, with Bow as his background vocals — they didn't sound bad or anything, but it just got a bit annoying after a while.

Fortunately, the shore came into view soon, or Glimmer might have murdered Sea Hawk. Adora was for once glad that Catra wasn't here, because she was pretty sure that the girl would have enabled the princess.

She hoped the feline was doing alright back in Brightmoon.

"Again, I'm no expert at princess stuff, but is this place supposed to look like a ghost town?", Scorpia asked while steering the boat carefully to a stop.

“No”, Glimmer answered after she had teleported down from her spot. “It’s not. First Plumeria and now this. What is going on? Where is everyone?”

Adora already knew the answer, but couldn’t say anything. Sea Hawk had no such hesitations.

“It is an odd sight to behold”, he told them. “My dearest Mermista should have already come to greet me! If I know the princess, and I do, something’s amiss.”

She rolled her eyes, doubting that Mermista would do such a thing even under normal circumstances. “We should check the castle”, she said instead.

Chapter End Notes

> So... I'm going to let you in on a little secret. Most of my chapters are two-parters... The chapters are (for some reason - the writing escalated!) almost always 10k words or more, so I have decided to cut them in half.
> So far I have managed to cut them between scenes (and I like to think that it wasn't very noticable). This is the first of a few instances where I had to cut it in the middle of a scene. I'm sorry...
>
> Next chapter is coming, hopefully, soon <333 probably Monday

Chapter 9: Salineas - Part 2

Chapter Notes

Once again not sure if I like this, but I hope you do <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They have barely taken three steps when a voice called to them. "Hold! Hold I say!" A man quickly ran towards them. He was completely out of breath when he reached them. "What's your business in Salineas?", he wheezed.

"We've come to speak with princess Mermista", Glimmer told him with all the air of official business that this mission required.

"And tell her Sea Hawk is with them!", she was interrupted by the man in question who swiftly pushed himself forward. "She'll be excited to see me."

Adora couldn't stop the snort from leaving her, but nobody seemed to have noticed. Either that or they didn't think anything weird of it.

Glimmer pushed the man to the side again. "Please lead us to her. We have come on official business of the Princess Alliance", she finished and shot Sea Hawk a glare.

The merman nodded and walked off to lead them to the castle.

They had only been here once and last time Adora was too focused on this mission to really take a look around, but this time she allowed herself a little sightseeing. Luckily she blended in perfectly with Scorpia, who also looked around curiously.

Salineas was truly beautiful, though she didn't fully grasp how the architecture here worked, but she did admire the aesthetic of sea shells and corals. There were also several murals in the castle that she would have liked to look at a bit longer, and not just sneak a

single glance at them — she guessed they presented the history of the kingdom.

Then, the merman opened some big doors and they were led into the throne room where Mermista already waited for them. “Ew, who let him back in here?”, was the first thing out of her mouth.

Sea Hawk didn’t let that stop him, though. “Princess!”, he called out and went to bow in front of her. “Oh, it’s been too long. I have dreamed of you night and day since we parted”, he declared, but as always, Mermista did not look impressed.

“Uh-huh and who are you?”, she then addressed the others.

“My name is Glimmer of Brightmoon. We never met, but our parents fought in the rebellion together.” Sometimes Adora forgot that her friend could do all the regal princess stuff and most of the time just chose not to. She had a real air of authority around her.

“Oh yeah, I remember hearing about the old Princess Alliance”, Mermista responded with what looked like an eye roll. “My dad said it was a total disaster.”

The air became awkward and Glimmer looked down, clearly unsure what to say, but Sea Hawk took the opening for some more sweet-talking. “I didn’t think it was possible, but you’re beauty grows greater with each passing day.” He was promptly elbowed by the merman.

“Would you quit it? I am trying to talk to my new friend, Twinkle”, she said, pointing to Glimmer, who looked less than happy with the false name.

“My dearest, my friend here’s name is Shimmer”, Sea Hawk gently corrected.

“My name is Glimmer!”, the girl in question yelled. “Seriously, how is that so hard? Why can no one remember my name?” There were clearly some frustrations there due to Catra calling her the

wrong name constantly. At least Adora couldn't remember her explode like this last time.

Mermista still looked bored. “Okay, wow, chill. I literally just met you”, she said, but didn’t seem to be all that mad about the outburst. Then again, Mermista did not have a wide range of emotions to begin with, so who knew?

Glimmer took a deep breath. "I'm sorry. I'm a little stressed, I guess", she mumbled, seemingly a bit embarrassed.

"I get it. I'm under pressure constantly, it's totally throwing me off, too", the other princess responded nonchalantly. "Would you like some horsd’oeuvres?", she asked and waved a hand towards the merman, who promptly walked off.

Sea Hawk squealed and hopped onto the throne, now that the other man didn’t stand in the way anymore. “Ooooh, horsd’oeuvres!”

“For everyone, but Sea Hawk”, Mermista added.

Glimmer laughed awkwardly. "That is very kind", she said, probably just to avoid more tension.

"Is your guard also your butler?", Bow asked in confusion, watching after the merman.

Mermista sighs. “I’m a little understaffed right now”, she said with a wave of her hand like it was no big deal. “Everybody fled because the gate is falling apart or whatever.” She got up, probably to get away from Sea Hawk and scoffed. “It figures that I would inherit a kingdom that’s crumbling, but it’s totally fine. I’m handling it. It’s just kinda inconvenient because the Horde won’t stop attacking us.”

Glimmer perked up immediately. “Why is the gate falling apart?”, she asked possibly a bit too enthusiastically, and walked after the other princess, who shrugged.

“I mean, who knows? But it’s getting weaker every day and if the Horde tries to attack us again, we’re pretty much dead.” It didn’t seem like that possibility fazed her in the slightest, but Adora knew that she cared for her kingdom a lot. And that was how they had convinced her last time, too.

Time to speed things up a bit again.

She looked around, searching for the one mural that said something about the gate, so they can move this forward. “This is First One’s writing”, she told them, pointing to the right mural.

The sea princess gave her a look "Yeah, I know it's First One's writing. I mean, obviously." Then she turned to Glimmer. “And who is she again? What is she doing?”

Glimmer looked just as confused, though. “That’s Adora and I don’t know. What are you doing?”

She awkwardly cleared her throat, just like Sea Hawk had done many times today, and tried not lose her train of thought with everyone's attention on her. "I was reading the murals. This one says something about the Gate. The First Ones built it and it looks like it gets its power from the Salinean Runestone. The Gate is probably failing because it’s losing its connection to the power source”, she explained.

Everyone stared at her. “Hold on”, Glimmer said. "You can read that?"

"Yeah?" It wasn't supposed to sound so much like a question, but it kind of came out as one. She had forgotten that this wasn't a common thing, and that nobody knew about it yet. "I guess."

“Wow, I’m impressed”, Mermista said, but Adora wasn’t sure if the princess was being honest or sarcastic.

"I don't know why or how it works, I just … it's a thing I can do", she added for no particular reason at all, though maybe in an attempt for pull Glimmer out of her confused state.

"We can talk about your weird abilities later. Does it say how we can fix the gate?", the girl asked then, focusing on the mission at hand again.

“We’ll have to reconnect it to the runestone. I think we can use She-Ra for it.” She really hoped no one would ask for an explanation and just believe that she read that on the wall as well.

"She-Ra?", Mermista asked then, though she didn't exactly seem confused, more surprised — just like most people, she probably knew the legends.

"Oh yeah, it's pretty cool", Scorpia answered, while Glimmer mulled over the situation.

“Alright then”, the princess called out eventually, apparently accepting Adora's words without question. Then she turned to Mermista again. “Look, you need our help and we need yours. If Adora can repair your gate, will you consider joining the Alliance? Please?”

Mermista threw her head back and groaned. “I don’t know… I guess”, she said, which was as much of an affirmation as they were going to get. “But only because I want to see She-Ra. And if he sets anything of fire, I’m throwing you all out”, she then said with a look to Sea Hawk.

"Don't worry, we'll keep an eye on him", Glimmer promised.

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The gate was just as she remembered it, glowing red and full of holes. Standing in front of it on a floating rock, they all took in the damage while Adora looked out to the distance, but no Horde ship was to be seen.

"We're lucky. It's a quiet day today", Mermista told them. "Usually the Horde is here like almost every day."

So, that either meant that Shadow Weaver hadn't figured out that Adora was She-Ra yet and still had no idea where she was. Or that she should sincerely worry. Silence was never for a good reason.

She really hoped for the first one. That the sorceress didn't know and that they had coincidentally arrived on one of the few days where no attacks happened. That would be good.

“I really hope you know what you’re doing”, Mermista told her, starting to look a bit skeptical, and ripping her from her thoughts.

Adora chuckled nervously. It had been a while, but she should manage to repair it. She loosened her sword from her wrist. “Yeah, I got this. For the honor of Grayskull!”

“Wow. Okay. That’s… different”, she heard Mermista mumble somewhere to the side.

“Yeah, is that a thing she does often?”, Sea Hawk asked too.

Glimmer shrugged. “We haven’t needed it much so far, but seeing that we’re at war, I’d guess it’s going to happen a lot more often, yeah.”

Adora tried to focus despite the noise and gripped her sword tightly while bringing it up to point it at the gate. It started glowing with magical energy almost immediately and a second later that energy was shot at the gate, which started to glow too now, from the point where her sword was outwards. This was much more exhausting than she remembered.

“Oh! It’s working!”, Sea Hawk screeched and startled her enough that she lost her connection.

Mermista hit the man and shot him a glare. "Stop talking, she needs to focus", she demanded. "Keep going", she told her then,

looking just the slightest bit flustered.

Adora nodded at her in thanks and tried again. Last time it had taken very long, but this time, with no interruptions from the Horde, she was done in a matter of minutes.

Repairing an entire gate was pretty exhausting, though, and she detransformed almost instantly after lowering her sword again. She also had to lean on it a little.

“Huh, what do you know, you actually fixed it”, Mermista mumbled.

“It’s beautiful”, Scorpia said, now looking at the Gate in all its shimmering glory.

“I guess that means, your people will be safe for a while, again”, Glimmer pointed out. “From the Horde mostly, of course. Which is the reason we’re here”, she not so smoothly brought them back on topic. “None of us stand a chance on our own, but we might be able to stop them together.”

Mermista didn’t look very convinced at first, but she quickly resolved herself. “You fixed my home. I thought every kingdom would have to fight for themselves, but you helped me. Maybe you’re right.” Then she gestured at Adora. “Plus, your friend can turn into a gorgeous eight-foot tall lady with a sword who can read a dead language. I want her on my side. So sure, I’m in.”

Glimmer cheered loudly, hugging Mermista and Sea Hawk was also joining the celebration for some reason.

“This calls for a shanty!”, he exclaimed.

“No! No shanties!”, Mermista quickly shut him down. “Why are you always so annoying?”

"I still don't get the impression of close personal friend", Scorpia pointed out with a certain skepticism.

“We have a rich and complicated past”, he defended.

“If by that you mean you got us kicked out of the Dolphin Social for challenging the doorman to a duel, then sure”, Mermista grumbled, and already started to walk down and back to the beach.

“I don’t recall doing that”, Sea Hawk answered, staying close behind her.

“Or the time you set our gondola on fire in the tunnel of love?”

Sea Hawk smirked. “That I do recall.”

Mermista groaned. “Ugh, just get him out of here”, she said and brought a bit more distance between them, while Sea Hawk pouted.

“You won’t regret this!”, Glimmer enthusiastically assured her before quietly turning towards Sea Hawk. "You really like setting things on fire, huh?", she asked with a shake of her head.

Somehow, the man missed all the clues of how little it impressed the girl, immediately regaining his confidence. "It's the thrill of adventure!"

The girl rolled her eyes. “Sure, whatever, let’s just get back”, she said and they made their way back to the boat.

Bow gave the man a sympathetic pat on the back and chatted with him a bit, quickly building him up again.

Mermista, for her bored and don't-care attitude, saw them off and even waved at them.

Everyone got put back into their earlier duties, which meant that Sea Hawk still had a chance to pout in a corner as everyone else worked.

Adora did feel bad for the sea captain a bit. Last time he has had a better opportunity at proving himself, but she was sure his time would undoubtedly come. Like Glimmer said, they were in the middle of war. They all would have enough fights to prove themselves in.

It seemed that Glimmer felt bad for the man, too, because once they were on the open sea, she teleported down from the lookout to the empty space next to him, effectively startling him.

“I’d really appreciate a warning”, he said, holding a hand over his heart.

“Sorry”, she chuckled. “I’m sorry if I’ve been a bit mean to you on the way here. It’s just that I couldn’t let anything go wrong today.”

“No, it was probably for the best”, he replied a bit sadly. “I would have only gotten in your way. I’m just not used to a crew anymore, you know? Once upon a time, I had friends and everyday was an adventure”, he went for a big speech, but deflated. “The fact that I kept setting my boats on fire was considered charming. But here no one takes me seriously.”

“Yeah, I know a little about that”, Glimmer mumbled.

“You? But you’re a princess”, the man exclaimed in shock.

“Try being the daughter of an immortal queen when your powers are sparkles”, she said exaggeratedly while producing some glitter from her hand. “This is why today was so important. I don’t get many chances to prove myself and my mom is already mad at me because I threw myself into a fight again at the last mission", she told him.

"Seems like you light things on fire too", he replied with a slight smile. "Metaphorically speaking."

She chuckled. "If you put it like that", she admitted. "The rebellion can use anyone who’s willing to fight. Today might not have been

your day, but if you want, you’re free to join, too”, she offered then.

Sea Hawk went and hugged the girl. “How generous of you. Why yes, I will fight for the rebellion and my sweet Mermista!” And just like that he had regained his cheerful attitude. Adora couldn’t help but smile even when she tried to act like she didn’t eavesdrop.

She decided to leave them to it and turned to Scorpia instead. "Have fun today?", she asked.

"Oh, I mean… today was a lot less eventful than yesterday, but that had also been kind of intimidating — my first real fight and all — so yeah, I guess today was fun", she answered.

"That's good", she mumbled, not entirely sure what to say now. "I'm glad."

"Really?"

"Yeah", she told her truthfully. "I mean, you keep saying that you had nothing to do in the Fright Zone and you left with us without a second thought — I didn't get the impression you felt at home there. So, yeah, I'm glad you can be included now and have fun."

When she looked over again she saw the woman's eyes water. Adora panicked for a second, but then Scorpia started to laugh.

"That's so nice of you to say", she muttered through her tears. "I never felt like I belonged, but now… you all make sure to include me, it's so nice."

"No problem", Adora mumbled, slightly awkward. "That's what friends are for." Next thing she knew she was crushed in a hug.

As much as she had to admit that she hadn't payed the woman much attention before — or even really considered letting her join their defection too, until she had been confronted with a pout — she was glad it had worked out like this. Scorpia really didn't

belong in the Fright Zone. Neither did anyone, but that was a problem for another day.

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Catra woke up when someone opened the door to the library. She hadn't even noticed she had fallen asleep — realistically, she probably passed out, but she wasn't going to complain about a few hours of rest without any nightmares plaguing her.

She was, however, going to complain about whoever startled her into a fight response.

Peaking down from the spot she had chosen for her late night reading, she could see one of the older princesses sneaking around the shelves — the net one, she thinks, but it could also be the wind one. She hadn't fought the pair much, so she wasn't sure.

Either way, the woman clearly seemed to be looking for something, but didn't look up, so Catra was safe for now. Maybe the princess was just searching for a book. What else? This was a library after all.

But then, probably because she was leaning forward, the book in her lap slid down a little and she grabbed it with a little gasp that definitely didn't go unheard in the silence.

"Catra?", the woman called out carefully.

So the princess was not here for a book.

Catra rolled her eyes and placed her stray book next to her on top of the shelve, making sure it couldn't be seen from the ground — that would be the worst that could happen.

She had somehow ended up with a bunch of psychology books, guidebooks on relationships, and a psychological analysis on positive communication. No one had to see that.

It wasn't like she was completely clueless, anyway — spending years with a faceless witch made her a good people reader — but she wasn't all that knowledgeable about how to not immediately resort to lying and manipulation, which was something she did not need to discuss with anyone.

Grabbing the blanked, that she had stolen from one of the sofas standing around, she quickly buried the books. By the time she looked back up (or down) again, she had been spotted.

They made eye contact and the woman smiled. "Hi Catra." She waved up.

"What do you want?", she got the point. The faster she could get rid of the princess, the better.

The woman shrugged. "Just checking where you've been. You're friends have been worried about you, you know", she told her.

She scoffed. "Let me guess, they're worried I've gone rogue?", she replied sarcastically.

The princess looked a bit taken aback. "No, I think they're *just* worried about you. Your health. Your mental state."

Catra responded with a growl, which didn't seem to impress the other.

In fact, it looked like her chances to get rid of the woman just vanished, as she leaned against a shelve like she planned to stay here a while. "I know, we haven't met… like at all — I'm Netossa, by the way — but I have noticed that you don't come to eat much, and that you isolate yourself, and-"

"I'm not isolating myself", she hissed, but the other just raised an eyebrow. "I just… I don't want to hang out with them."

"Catra, I say this with respect. You haven't eaten, you don't sleep, you hide away every chance you get. You even wanted to go to Entrapta alone." Catra wanted to ask how the woman possibly knew all this, but Netossa seemed to read the question on her face. "The guards are gossips", she answered.

She rolled her eyes. "Just because I don't like you, doesn't mean I'm isolating", she said, ignoring every other point, the other had made.

The princess sighed. "I don't believe that. But you won't listen to me anyway. You also seem to be doing okay, for once, so if you want, I'll leave you alone."

"How nice", she grumbled.

Netossa shook her head, but did leave. The fact that people actually just left her alone still struck Catra as suspicious, but she was grateful for her returned privacy.

What even just happened? And what did it mean that the princess didn't believe her? Catra hadn't been really honest, sure, but she had made it clear from the start that she wasn't here to make friends. Her distance was hardly unexpected or out of character for her.

She had resolved herself to … make up for past mistakes that no one but her remembered, but that didn't mean much. It was a rather selfish thing to do, in fact, if you asked her. But that's not how these people would see it. They would probably even be encouraged in their efforts if they knew — they would think that she cared, which is why she didn't want them to know.

Catra waited a few more minutes before she got the books back out from under her blankets, but the library stayed empty. Occasionally, she heard shuffling in front of the door and prepared herself to hide, but it was probably just the guard.

Eventually, she relaxed enough to get back to reading and made good progress, too, until she heard the door open carefully and

she quickly stuffed the book in her hand back under her blanket.

It was the other one this time, who smiled at her gently. "It's lunch time", she told her. "My wife told me you were busy, so I thought I'd bring you some food. Let me know if you want something else."

Catra blinked at the woman and the plate in her hand a few times. "Uh… it's fine." It came out as a question, and it honestly was one. She wasn't sure what to think of this.

The wind princess, though, smiled a bit brighter and came over to hold the plate up for Catra to grab it, which she cautiously did.

"Thanks", she mumbled as she looked over the food. It was a few basic things that the other probably deemed safe for most possible food allergies.

"You're welcome." For a moment it looked like the woman wasn't sure whether to leave or stay. "Do you want some company?", she decided to asked then.

"Not really", Catra said honestly. She felt almost sorry for it because the woman had brought her food after all, but she really didn't want people around.

"Alright." Why did everyone so easily agree here? "Just…" She sighed. "If you need anything at all, we're in the gardens."

"Okay?" Once again a question. She was so confused.

"I just wanted to let you know that you can come talk to us if you need it. Since none of your friends are here, currently.", the princess explained. "I know we're not the same, but we'll listen, or help. Whatever you need", she added, seemingly as the thought came to her, not at all aware that it didn't actually make a difference to Catra which princess she would have to avoid. "I'll leave you to it, then."

Catra only nodded and watched the other leave. Once again, she questioned what this was supposed to mean.

It was nice of the princess, she guessed, but she didn't get the point of it. Why were they so nice?

She shook her head and went back to reading, all the while stuffing her face from time to time. Ironically, her book currently went in depth on trust issues, which was probably something she displayed, but she didn't see anything wrong with it. Why should she extend her trust to anyone if they couldn't prove that they deserved it?

It didn't matter right now anyway. She picked up another book and hoped for something better.

The shuffling in front of the door continued, and she half expected either of the two princess to show up again, but they didn't — apparently they were serious about leaving her alone.

And after a while, she did think she understood their reasoning a little.

As far as she could tell, manipulation wasn't all that far off from positive communication. It always revolved around choosing your words carefully — the only difference was that actually good people said or did things for other people regardless of their own potential gain.

And the princesses? Yeah, they probably really just checked on her because they just wanted to. To make sure Catra was okay.

She still didn't trust it, but that seemed to be it. She wondered if she would ever get used to that. And if the last hours were wasted time.

If the only difference between good and bad was how the other person felt about it, then what was the point? Sure, she could use more positive words, or whatever these books talked about, but she doubted it would really change anything.

Could she actually do good if her entire reason for it was absolutely selfish?

Maybe she should have read philosophy instead.

Eventually, some big commotion coming from somewhere outside interrupted her again. She wasn't really reading anymore, but she was still annoyed by it.

A glance at the window told her that the day was nearly over and the others probably came back from Salineas. It seemed that she had been thinking for a while, then.

She was also hungry again, so — knowing that sooner or later someone would come to bother her anyway — she decided to make things easier and came to them.

At the door to the dining hall, seeing the group already happily eating and chatting, she briefly considered turning back around, but then Scorpia spotted her and waved and now everyone knew she was here.

So she stacked her plate with whatever she could find and plopped down at a free space. The two princesses who had checked on her today were also here and smiled at her, which she ignored.

"Hey, Catra", Adora greeted her happily.

"How was your mission?", she asked — she didn't particularly care, but she didn't want them to ask about her.

The blonde scrunched up her eyebrows, telling her clearly that she knew that. "Our mission went great. Mermista is part of the Alliance now."

"Congrats", she mumbled.

"Oh, it was really great!", Scorpia chimed in now. "They let me steer a boat, can you believe it?"

"I mean, Sea Hawk is nice and all, but I did not trust him to get us there safely", Sparkles told the group, shaking her head in emphasis.

"He was cool, though", Arrow Boy came to the guy's defense.

"So he says", the princess corrected and the boy pouted. "Yes, he was cool, I'll admit it. I'm just saying, he loved to boast about himself. In shanty form."

"Sounds terrible", Catra commented.

"You have no idea. He sang for like half an hour straight", the girl told her, surprisingly. It seemed to surprise herself too. "But he's overall a good guy", she added awkwardly then and looked away.

Scorpia cleared her throat. "How was your day, Catra?", she changed the topic. "Did you have fun with Spinnerella and Netossa?"

Catra froze. And so did everyone else, weirdly enough. "How do you know that?", she asked calmly. Curiously even.

"They told us, of course", Sparkles came to the nervous woman's rescue.

She just hummed as she watched the two worst liars very closely. Scorpia was avoiding eye contact and Adora looked like she wanted to melt into the ground. And when Catra stabbed into her chicken leg they flinched.

Of course no one was just nice for no reason. She knew she had been right to be suspicious. And it also helped her decide that yes, she had been wasting her time.

"I don't need a babysitter", she hissed at them and judging by the guilty looks across from her, she was dead on.

"Catra", the wind princess — Spinnerella or something — decided to speak up now. "We just checked on you occasionally."

"I thought that's what I had a guard for", she pointed out.

"A guard who's terrified of you", Sparkles mumbled beside her.

"That's not my problem", she snapped. She wanted to say something along the lines of this didn't justify stalking her, but it kind of did. Being surveilled was part of the agreement, that they were even allowed to join the rebellion. But since the very first day here, it had rubbed her the wrong way and this did not make it better.

The princess sighed. "Look, they were in the same room with you for five minutes. It's not a big deal. And they did leave you alone after you made it clear that that's what you wanted."

"What I wanted?", she scoffed. "Clearly I never get what I want." She gets beaten, left behind and send to die. The rebellion wasn't any different in terms of pushing her boundaries.

And she finally realized why everyone watching her felt so terrible — it didn't just remind her of the Fright Zone in general, it reminded her of Hordak's little abomination spying on her and selling her out.

She swallowed hard and got up. She barely remembered to take her food with her, though her appetite was long gone anyway.

"Catra?", someone called out for her, probably Adora. She didn't care.

Somehow she made it back to her greenhouse where she spend minutes reminding herself that if the rebellion had one thing going for them, it was that they wouldn't send Catra to die over a single little mistake. Not that she had made any yet, besides being awful to everyone.

She was fine.

Chapter End Notes

Next time, we'll finally get to the chapter that is among my favorites. I really want to dare to say that next chapter things start to pick up a bit, but I also don't want to get your hopes up - I am a pessimist at heart <333

Anyway, next chapter will contain some development and I'm excited! Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 10: A New Page - Part 1

Chapter Notes

> So, this chapter was almost named "Character Development", which probably tells you more about it than the current title, but I like it better. For poetic reasons xD
>
> Also quick warning for incoming headcanons, a mental breakdown, and vague mentions of abuse (I don't know if it's bad enough to really need a trigger warning, but you get one, just in case)
>
> Have fun <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra, despite having managed to calm down, was still rattled with the anxiety of someone checking up on her. She needed something to do, but she didn't want to go back inside, didn't want to risk running into one of them.

She looked around, hoping to find something to do, even if she had to pick up gardening, but her eyes settled on the files that Adora had stolen, and that Catra had then stolen from the girl. She had wanted to read them anyway.

A lot of them were about things like supply routes or materials, which gave her a bit of satisfaction — if Catra had to run around trying to figure out how to make more armor, so could Shadow Weaver.

But others were less public. By some cruel coincidence, Adora must have grabbed their squad's file. Maybe it wasn't a coincidence, but Catra didn't know why the blonde would have wanted to have this.

All five of them had their own portfolio, some longer some shorter. Well, hers and Adora’s were very long, the other three were rather

short.

She decided to start reading Lonnie's section, but there wasn't much in there that she hadn't already known. Except for a few notes about her fighting abilities and her potential to rise the ranks, which surprised Catra a little.

Rogelio was similar. There was potential, but in his case the language barrier would probably keep him from climbing up. Kyle was essentially labeled as a lost cause and Shadow Weaver had already marked him for inventory duty for the rest of his life.

Now came the hard part.

She started with Adora. The sorceress had a lot to say about her. Untapped power, usable, too attached to her squad, keep an eye on her relationship with Catra — somehow she had hoped for a more sophisticated evaluation, but she already knew all that, since the old woman was not really subtle about it.

But then she read something that she hadn't expected to read at all. Portal. Adora came out of a portal? Hordak had tried to use it, but he was too late and instead he found Adora. Shadow Weaver had seen her potential power right away, while Hordak was a fool for ignoring it — the woman must have known Hordak would never read these files because that was bold.

So, that's why Shadow Weaver had taken such an interest in their squad only? Because she somehow knew that Adora was She-Ra? Or at least suspected something along those lines.

Catra had known that the sorceress was always obsessed with Adora because of something — some delusion she has had about what Adora could do for her, but not that she had known that the girl had a connection with magic.

And, as the report went on over the years, of course Catra posed a problem. Adora liked her, she had chosen her as a friend when she was never supposed to have a choice. And Catra was such a

terrible choice. Catra was curious and aggressive and rebellious, everything the witch had tried to beat out of Adora.

She couldn't stand it anymore, and even though she had avoided her own report, she needed to check something.

Of course there was no clue as to where she was from, she just showed up at their doorstep one day. Great. Anyway, Shadow Weaver didn't waste any time hating her because that is one of the first things in there. That she suspected a lot of defiance and therefore put Catra on a list to watch out for.

And then she and Adora became friends when they were like four. The sorceress marked it with potential, to manipulate Adora of course. Someone she cared for meant someone to threaten.

The real hate started when Catra was six. More specifically when she had scratched out Octavia's eye. The sorceress wrote that if Catra was willing to hurt a Force Captain so young, she would surely be a problem for Shadow Weaver who always wanted more power, so Catra needed to be broken.

That hag had only waited for the perfect opportunity. And then it came when Adora and her snuck into the Black Garnet chamber maybe a year later.

Shadow Weaver very obviously prided herself on that moment, two birds with one stone. Make Catra feel worthless, disposable if she didn't have Adora's favor, and — she cross referenced Adora's file — make the blonde feel overly responsible for Catra's actions. So now both of them were afraid to mess up. In both cases it would mean Catra's death. A thing, that seemingly would have been a win win situation for the sorceress, being rid of her, while breaking Adora for good, so she would never even think of rebelling again.

Catra had known for a long time, that Shadow Weaver never cared about her. She had never wanted that to be true, which had made her so easy to manipulate back when the sorceress had

been in that cell. After that incident, she had no hope left on that front, but it was still different to read it on paper. Shadow Weaver's honest thoughts.

And she was only at age seven.

She would leave it there for now. Catra couldn't stomach any more.

It already made her reevaluate a lot of things, she didn't need more to process.

Thanks to that old woman she had been forced to live in Adora's shadow, be dependent on her to even be allowed to breathe. Of course, when she left, she had felt betrayed that the girl would just disregard her life like that. And at the same time… without the blonde, she could finally explore life without anyone to be dependent on. Without being constantly overlooked. And Hordak did see her, promoted her and gave her everything she had ever wanted.

She already knew that — Shadow Weaver wasn't as mysterious as she thought — but the real question was, just how deep did the manipulation go for Catra to have such a reaction in the first place.

Had she ever really wanted any of the things she had been chasing after? Or had she been made to want it, just so she could compete with Adora? Compete for a goal she was never supposed to reach.

Adora had said it, too, didn't she? *Maybe that's why you can't leave. You're too desperate to prove to everyone that they need you.*

Oh, how she hated the blonde to be right. And she hated Shadow Weaver — as if Catra didn't already have enough reasons to want the witch dead.

Well, she would never admit it out loud, but … Adora *was* right. And maybe the rebellion wasn't all that bad, either.

Despite all her grudges against these people, she has yet to feel the same competition she had in the Horde. They were all accepted as individuals, and people did listen to her here.

Despite her outburst earlier, she had to admit that the princesses had acted according to what she had wanted — they had left her alone. Even on their mission, Arrow Boy had accepted the silence and never pushed. They could have also changed the arrangement of the missions after she had angrily stormed out of the meeting, put her somewhere else, but they didn't. Neither did they stop her from sleeping in the garden house.

Catra sighed, got back up and decided to walk. Her guard was, once again, not happy, but sitting didn't seem like an option anymore, not with all the information to process.

Every time she thought she finally saw the last of Shadow Weaver's influence over her, she realized there was more. An entire life more.

Adora's room still had light, and for a moment Catra considered climbing up. But then she would have to explain it and she didn't want to tell the girl. She didn't know how the blonde would react. Would she even care? And if she did, what would she do then? Catra decided she didn't want to find out.

She paced the garden, and only when it got too cold for her — and it was late enough to be safe and undiscovered — did she get back to venturing through the halls.

The guards all stiffened when she walked by, but she wasn't in the mood for scaring them. They seemed to notice that something was off and sent worried glances after her — that made her want to scare them after all, but she didn't have the energy. And it reminded her of Shadow Weaver.

In that cell, she had told the sorceress that she was nothing like her and while she still believed that, she noticed now that Shadow Weaver had done something way worse than just manipulate and scare her a little — she had made sure that Catra couldn’t help but become her. Out of spite.

Catra stopped in the middle of the hallway as she processed that thought. She repeated it in her mind again and again and hated that she found it to be true.

Everything she had done, since Adora had left her, was manipulate and hurt the people that needed her the most. She had stopped caring about anything else but her own win, scared to lose her power. She had pushed everyone away until even Scorpia was scared of her.

As the realization took hold of her, she couldn't move, couldn't breathe, couldn't even wipe away the tears and eventually couldn't hold herself up anymore.

She wanted to run and hide, but she couldn't do anything and she hated it. She hated everything. She hated herself.

And in the midst of all of that, she thought that she should probably be glad that Adora had gotten her to Brightmoon, and away from her chosen path of destruction. But at the same time, Catra had to question if crying on the floor in front of a bunch of guards was in any way better.

"Uh, Catra?"

She truly had no control over her body anymore, because she jumped up immediately, attacking whoever snuck up on her.

Sparkles was lucky to be able to teleport. And the princess appeared to be significantly startled, even going so far as to prepare some sparkling fists.

Catra managed to calm down a bit. It was still new to categorize the other as a non-threat, but she got the message across to

whatever department in her brain handled these responses.

As she relaxed, so did Sparkles, though she still kept an eye on her from a distance. The longer the princess looked, the more worried she became, which Catra hated even more than everything that had just happened.

Eventually, she couldn't do this anymore. "What are you doing here?", she hissed, but it came out weak and nasally.

The girl sighed tiredly. "Your guard alerted me that you were…" She didn't finish that sentence. Instead she took a step closer. "Come on. Let's go somewhere more private", she offered.

She didn’t want to follow the princess anywhere, but when she saw how the guards all looked at her with pity, she decided that anywhere was better. She already missed their frightened faces.

Sparkles led her back to what Catra assumed was her room. And it was very her — bright and pastel, lots of cushions, with a bed that hung high above the ground. When she turned back to look at the princess, a tissue box was held out to her.

For a moment she thought about refusing it, but then she felt the snot streaming down her face, and took one to blow her nose.

“Make yourself comfortable”, Sparkles then said and Catra plopped down on a chair that didn’t look like it was going to swallow her. “Do you want to talk about it?”

“No.”

“Didn’t think so”, the princess mumbled and sat down by the window. “The guard told me that you seemed odd. And then you suddenly broke down”, she kept going. “On top of the way you fled dinner today, I’ll admit I’m a bit worried.”

“I'm fine”, Catra said, crossing her arms.

“I just saw you, Catra. I don’t think you are”, Sparkles replied, ever the stubborn one. She could see why she and Adora were friends. “You’re lucky they didn’t alert my mom because I am giving you a choice. You can talk to me and we can deal with whatever is bothering you. Or I’ll wake Adora.”

“What makes you think I’ll talk to her?”, she asked with a scoff.

Sparkles shrugged. “You're right. I don't know if you will. But I know that Adora knows you better than anyone. I’m sure she knows how to make you talk.”

The princess was partly right. The blonde was always so sad and worried that Catra always felt inclined to say something. It wasn't always the truth. Mostly she succeeded by changing the topic to whatever she knew bothered Adora at the moment, but currently that was Catra. With the things as they were right now, Adora might actually wear her down.

“You’re just gonna tell Adora anyway", she pointed out, deflecting just a little.

“I won’t”, the girl replied easily. “Whatever is going on is obviously very private. If you don’t want Adora to know, I won’t tell her. I promise.”

She hissed at that. Promises were still a sore spot for her. And she didn't appreciate the illusion of a choice either — Sparkles was just as terrible to talk to as Adora.

The princess let out a sigh. “You’re restless. I know you don’t sleep, you’ve been pacing the halls a lot and you keep being tense. You surveil every room that you step into, and you are suspicious of every single person who dares to talk to you”, she told her. “The guards are gossips”, she added, explaining how the girl knew all that.

"I already heard", she grumbled, ignoring the possibility that come tomorrow morning everyone would know about her breakdown.

"Catra…", the princess sighed.

"What?", she asked defensively, interrupting the other. "Is insomnia and pacing a crime in Brightmoon?"

“Not everyone is out to get you”, the girl told her sternly and Catra looked away. “You can do whatever you want. Isolate yourself, cry in the hallway, sleep in the greenhouse. But whatever you do, you got to live with the consequences and people are worried.”

She scoffed. “Like you?”

“Like Adora, Scorpia, Bow and yes, me too”, she listed. “A lot of people care about you, whether you want that or not." Catra did in fact not want that, and it seemed to show on her face. "I know we haven't gotten along so far, and to be fair, you haven't really given me a reason to like you, but… you and the others have proven that you're trustworthy. Bow loved having you on the mission, and Adora somehow managed to like you despite growing up with you. I mean no offense, but you're a nightmare."

"Really serving up the pep talk here", she grumbled.

"What I'm trying to say is… people care. Even when you try to push them away. I'll admit, Spinnerella and Netossa were originally supposed to keep an eye on you, but after Bow came back and was basically in love with you, I told them they could relax. Only because they care, and everyone was worried, did they decide to check on you."

Catra still didn't like it and she rolled her eyes to show it.

Sparkles sighed. "Look, I might not get it, but people like you. And you keep being terrible."

"I know."

Sparkles slid a little closer then, so that they were side by side instead of face to face. "I'm not pretending to be an expert", the princess then said, a bit more softly than before. "I'm probably far

from it, but I do know that it's scary to let other people in when you don't know how to do that."

"You don't know anything about me", Catra growled. She wasn't scared.

It didn't faze Sparkles in the slightest. "I know all the things that Scorpia and Adora have said about growing up in the Horde and whatever else came up, which I'm sure applies to you as well", she told her smugly. "I also understand that the Horde has been terrible at teaching anything about relationships. I mean, I'm still trying to figure things out, I cannot imagine how bad you have it- no, actually I can. I've had first row seats the last few days."

"Are we done?" Damn, this girl can talk — nevermind what she thought earlier, she did not understand how her and Adora were ever friends.

"No", came the quick response. "Because you are part of the rebellion now and if we are supposed to fight together, you need to learn that friendships are not easy. And your behavior isn't helping them. It isn't enough to grow up together, or to hit it off or whatever. You need to constantly put in the work. Learning together, sharing experiences, trusting each other and fighting for each other — that's how you build friendships. And communication."

She groaned. "Who said I ever wanted friends?", she asked because she couldn't help herself.

"You might not want them, but you definitely need them", Sparkles easily responded.

Catra was tired. In more than just one way. And she wanted to get out of here. “Caring about people just gets you hurt”, she mumbled, bringing her knees up to her chest.

The princess somehow managed to look more worried. "That's not true", she said softly. "Friendship is something beautiful and

strong. Sometimes I wouldn't know what I'd do without Bow. He always has my back."

She scoffed. The only thing friendship has ever done for her was getting her more and more on Shadow Weaver's bad side.

Sparkles took a deep breath then, clearly too tired for this as well. "Catra", she said, and it sounded like a warning. "I understand that there are things you don't want to talk about. Especially with someone you have been annoying since day one. It's fine if you need space, no one has judged you for that. But we are rightfully worried, so if you don't talk, I am personally making sure you stay away from missions until you are better."

Catra was honestly shocked. It was such a weird thing to do. To do this out of worry. It hadn't sounded like a punishment, but she might be misinterpreting this. Sparkles was seriously about to put her on time out for health reasons?

"Fine", she growled and hated how happy the princess looked about it. The problem simply was that free time would probably do her more damage than any fight could bruise her.

"Good, well I'm just gonna ask something because I'm sure you don't want to start with *anything*", Sparkles said. "So… Adora has mentioned a few things. Not much, and I doubt I'll learn more from you, but is this in any way Shadow Weaver related?"

Catra was both surprised and not really surprised that Adora had told the girl about that witch. And it certainly wasn't a topic that she had wanted to discuss at all. "Maybe."

"Catra", the girl groaned full of desperation.

She rolled her eyes. "Yes."

Sparkles nodded. "Adora said something about her manipulating you growing up?"

It was a rather open ended question, if it could even be considered one, but Catra had to answer something anyway. "That's putting it lightly."

"I thought so", the girl mumbled. "I'm not going to ask for details. I really want to, but I won't. That's probably something you should discuss with Adora at some point, though."

"No, thank you." She hadn't avoided that topic for years only to start now.

The princess didn't react beyond an eye roll and then seemed to thing about her next words. "Is that why you…?", she asked carefully, vaguely pointing towards the door, not daring to name whatever has been going on with Catra in the hallway.

"Adora took some files", she said, unsure why. A yes or no would have been fine. Maybe because of the continued lack of sleep. Maybe because she had spend the day reading one too many of these dumb self help books. "I've decided to go through them and found, well, ours. Our squad's. Shadow Weaver had a lot to say about me", she added when the other didn't respond.

She expected the princess to display some pity, maybe some meaningless sorrys along the way, but the girl just listened attentively. The worry was still etched into her face, of course, but nothing else. Maybe that's why she kept talking.

"I knew she never liked me or cared about me much. She has also threatened to kill me a few times." She left out the part where the sorceress had actively tried to kill her. "But what's worse is that she didn't even do it because of me. She did it because of Adora."

"What do you mean?", Sparkled now asked, the worry replaced by horror.

Catra thought about how to word it. "Somehow she always knew that Adora was powerful and when we became friends it was easy to use me as a way to keep her in line", she mumbled. "Don't tell

her. Adora, I mean", she then said added quickly. "It's better if she doesn't know", she decided.

"I'm not so sure about that", the princess told her and then sighed. "You know that if you want to rebuild that friendship, you're going to have to talk to her eventually, right? But I did promise. I won't tell her."

"Thanks Sparkles." Catra wanted to throw up — thanking the princess of glitter of all people made her skin crawl, but she did actually feel a bit better after telling someone. Weird…

"Why do you keep calling me that?", the other then asked with frustration.

She shrugged. "Maybe because I don't like you", she offered.

"Right back at you, Horde scum", the princess grumbled, making Catra honestly laugh.

"Tell you what, if it makes you feel better, you can call me that", she suggested.

The other thought about it for a moment. "I think I can live with that", she then said. "Though, I think you might be alright."

It was odd, but somehow that meant a lot coming from her of all people. And somehow, she thought that she didn't actually hate her back. "You too, princess", Catra admitted.

"I'm sure there are … more things to uncover here", the girl then said diplomatically while waving her hands into Catra's direction. "But, that was probably enough for today. Feeling better at least?"

"I guess", she mumbled. She did actually feel a bit better. Awkward, extremely uncomfortable, but better.

"Good. Because I have a suggestion if you're up for it."

Catra eyed the other suspiciously. "What?"

“I think it might do you some good to not associate yourself with the Horde anymore”, she said, confusing Catra even more.

“Meaning?”

“I want to give you a makeover”, the other squealed.

“No, absolutely not!”, told her, scooting away on the limited space on the chair. She liked her clothes and there might be a few bad memories attached, but also a few good ones.

“Come on, it’ll be fun and I promise you’ll feel *a lot* better after.” The princess slid even closer on her bench. “Please. If you don’t like it, you can still wear your old stuff, just try it. Adora and Scorpia did it, too.”

“You are not group pressuring me into this!”

“What’s the harm?”, Sparkles asked with an eye roll. “You talked to me and didn't die, getting a new look is so much easier than that, and it's fun. And like I said, no one forces you to keep it. And on top of that, a new start might be just what you need.”

Catra stared at the overly excited princess in front of her with disdain. “You are not leaving me alone until I say yes, right?” Sparkles nodded. “If I don’t like what you do, I’m shredding your entire wardrobe.”

“Deal!” And then, without warning, there was a hand on her shoulder, glitter all around her and when she came out of the light, she felt sick to her stomach.

Catra didn’t even have time to see where they were, before she dropped to the ground to throw up what little food she had eaten today. After a few minutes of dry heaving, she took a few deep breaths and turned to Sparkles. “Don’t. Ever. Do that. Again!”, she yelled at the girl who stared back at her in shock.

“I didn’t know that would happen!”, she said, her voice shrill with panic. “That never happened before. Everyone was always fine.”

“I’m not!”

“I can see that!”

They both took a moment to calm down before either said anything again. “At least… warn me next time”, Catra said a lot quieter than before.

“I’m sorry, I really didn’t know that could happen”, Sparkles responded, equally awkward. “I’ll uh, call a guard to get rid of that.” She vanished out of the room for a second and came back with less than happy looking guard, who somehow had a mop with them. “We should probably test that with the others. Maybe someone else also gets travel sickness”, she then said, while they watched the guard clean.

“Good idea”, Catra responded.

The guard finished mopping the small area quickly, but kept looking at it in annoyance. When he was done, he just walked out without so much as sparing them another look. Though, they could hear him mumble “I’m not payed enough for this.”

The two of them shared a short look before they burst out laughing.

Chapter End Notes

I had to cut it in the middle again, I'm so sorry!!!

We'll pick up right where we left of next time. Until then, stay hydrated <33

Chapter 11: A New Page - Part 2

Chapter Notes

> Since this is part 2, the same warnings from last time still apply (quick copy-paste: incoming headcanons, and vague mentions of abuse)
>
> I hope you enjoy <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Anyway", Sparkles then said. "Welcome to the clothes room!"

"You have an entire room for that?", Catra questioned, looking around the room that was indeed filled to the brink with various clothes.

"Well, it's actually more of a lost and found bin. All of these are clothes that the people living here threw out, that people donated or that were found after Horde raids and nobody took ownership over. Don't worry, their all clean, though", the princess explained.

"I sure hope so", she mumbled, starting to sift through the pile that was closest to her.

"Any preferences?", Sparkles asked, also taking on a chest full of stuff.

"I like red", was the only thing that came to mind. "Oh, and pants."

The princes scoffed. "We're at war, pants are kinda a given."

Catra held up an especially sparkly pink dress that was basically made out of ruffles. "Just wanted to make sure", she said and threw that monstrosity to the side. "Also, no ruffles."

“Is that list going to grow with everything you see, now?”, Sparkles asked with a hint of amusement.

“Possibly”, she responded with a smile.

It was weird, but it was surprisingly easy to get along with the princess, now that they actually tried.

If anyone had told her a week ago that she would not only join the rebellion, but make friends with Sparkles here, she would have ripped their head off and paraded it around the Fright Zone as a warning. But being here now — while, again, extremely weird — it was all so easy, and Catra had to admit she liked it — something coming easy to her for once.

“Because you remind me of myself. You always have. Nothing was ever easy for me either. Why should it be any different for you?”

She had to take a deep breath to not break down again. Not everything had to be a challenge. Sparkles had said it, no? Not everyone was out to get her. And she couldn’t help thinking that was how it should be.

“You okay?”, the princess called out.

“Just thinking”, Catra said honestly.

“About the clothes?”, the girl asked shooting her a mockingly stern look.

“No”, she admitted. “Shadow Weaver once told me that she made things hard for me because they had been for her. That was an obvious lie considering she didn’t care enough about me to think that far, but… I just thought that talking to you might be the easiest thing I’ve done in a while.”

“Naaaawww”, the other cooed and went to hug her. “That was so cute!”

“Get off me!”, Catra yelled, pushing the other away. “It’s not cute and I don’t even know why I told you that! You’re annoying, I hate you.”

She was a second away from regretting her words, but it seemed she didn’t need to. “No you don’t”, the other chuckled. “But you should work on your urge to insult people just because you can't deal with a compliment.”

Catra growled and turned back to her search. And growing her list. No weird half skirts, no puff sleeves, no stripes or dots, no shorts, no shoulder pads, no unnecessary details with pearls or something.

“At this rate we’ll never find anything”, Sparkles let out in frustration. “Could you be a bit less picky?”

“Could you find something that isn’t ugly?”, she shot back and the girl stuck her tongue out. Catra rolled her eyes and started to sift through another pile, though it started to feel like a waste of time. This was exactly why she hadn't wanted to this in the first place.

“Aha!”, Sparkles then yelled. “How about these?” She held up a pair of dark red pants, not unlike Catra’s current ones, but without the holes and they generally appeared sturdier.

She decided to try them on, careful with the claws on her toes. The pants were fitting well, flexible and still wide enough so her claws wouldn’t accidentally rip them apart, but tight enough at the same time that they felt close enough to the pants she was used to. And she liked the color a lot better, though both were red, this one just had the nicer hue.

“They’re not bad”, she said eventually. “We’ll need to figure out something for my tail, though.”

“Come on, you like them”, Sparkles called her out. “We can make adjustments later. Now for the rest of the outfit. Here I found gloves the same color!” And she threw them over too.

“They’re different lengths”, Catra pointed out.

“Just try them!”, the other called over. “I’ll see if I can find the rest of that outfit”, she said and almost vanished halfway into the chest.

Catra did as she was told and put the gloves on. They were both fingerless, but the left barely covered her hand while the right almost covered her entire arm. It was an odd feeling, but she had to admit, she kind of liked the asymmetry.

Sparkles got back up. “Okay, I don’t see anything in there that would fit with the color. Or style”, she mumbled. “I don’t even know if there ever was a whole outfit and it’s possible someone took the top at some point already. We’ll have to find something else.”

“You do that, I’ll cut a hole in the pants before my tail goes numb from the blood loss”, she said and already went ahead to take the pants off.

“Scissors should be over there.” The princess pointed at a little vanity in the corner.

Catra made quick work of the pants. She was used to it. The Horde only had standardized clothes, which meant that if someone had more or differently formed limbs than the average person, they would have to make adjustments themselves.

Once that was done, she put them back on and since Sparkles was still busy searching, Catra got back to that too. She debated if she wanted something for her feet, but she didn't like shoes and running around in socks would leave her with holes, and at that point she could just stay barefoot.

So, she tried her luck with a top instead, which was as frustrating as expected.

She was about to sit down on the floor and take a break when suddenly Sparkles appeared in front of her, pushing something

into her face. “Yes, it looks nice!”, she told her.

“What?”, Catra asked, trying to get away from the fabric stuffed against her. When she did, she looked at what the princess had found. “Didn’t I say no weird half skirts?”

Sparkles scoffed. “It’s not a skirt, just a bit of length.”

Catra hummed, unimpressed. The top had a bit of fabric hanging from the waist, and she didn't want her clothes to get in her way and this looked like it could. At least it wasn't pink, which she had feared for because most things in this room were — it was actually a nice red, just a bit lighter than the pants. If only that pseudo skirt didn't exist.

She shot the princess a skeptical look. “I don’t know, Sparkles.”

The girl groaned. “Just try it at least.” The top was then pressed into her hands.

“Fine”, she grumbled and wondered if the others have had similar issues finding clothes. Adora probably didn't, but Scorpia? “Can you turn around?”

“A few minutes ago you had no problem showing me your ass, but now you’re a prude?”, Sparkles asked with a smirk, but turned around regardless.

“I’m not a prude”, she mumbled as she took her shirt off. She hardly could be, growing up in the Horde with literally no privacy whatsoever. No, she was more worried about something else.

The girl was already way too worried and she didn’t want to make it worse by showing her all the injuries and scars she had around her upper body, some from training, but most from Shadow Weaver. There were only few on her legs, but her torso was a sensitive area to parade around.

At least her Horde issued underwear covered a good bit.

“So?”, she asked when she was done. She looked down at herself, still unsure. It didn’t feel very her.

Sparkles turned back around and gasped dramatically. “You look gorgeous”, she said and immediately dragged her off to a mirror.

Catra looked at herself in her entire glory and, while she definitely looked good, it was odd to see herself like this. “I don’t know.”

“Do you really not like it, or is this an emotional thing?”, the princess asked.

“It’s a nice outfit”, she admitted. “I just don’t know if it’s a nice outfit on me. It’s not really my style.”

“Yes, ripped pants and whatever shapeless mess that top was looked so much better”, the girl replied sarcastically. “I know it’s different and I won’t force you to wear something that makes you uncomfortable. All I’m saying is that you look good and you don’t have to be self conscious about it.”

“I wasn't-”, she started to defend herself, but was quickly interrupted.

“Close your eyes and relax. Do you like it?”

Catra, despite how stupid it sounded, did exactly that. The clothes felt nice, comfortable and she felt like she could easily fight in them. And she had already admitted that she also liked how it looked. It was her in that outfit that she didn't like, but maybe that was a different, non-fashion related problem.

“I think I do”, she answered eventually and earned another hug. “Ugh, do you have to do that?”

“Sorry, I'll try to hold back”, was the easy response. “But we're still not done.”

“We're not?”

Sparkles laughed like the question was the most ridiculous thing she has ever heard. “No, of course not. There's still the hair to consider.”

Catra hissed and took a step back. She hated it when people touched her hair. Well, in fairness not a lot of people had — she realized that it was probably, once again, Shadow Weaver ruining things for her. Not that the sorceress had ever really done anything to it, but she loved to touch it and it had always made her feel uncomfortable.

Sparkles held up her hands in surrender. “You can do it yourself if you want, I was just *suggesting*...” She emphasized that part. “That the mask thing is a bit creepy, but I do understand that you need to hold your hair up somehow, so I suggested to do something about it.”

In theory she wasn’t all that attached to her headpiece. She had found it somewhere and decided it was good enough. Before that she had been wearing her hair open just fine. It shouldn’t be that much of a problem. “Fine, I’ll lose the 'creepy mask'”, she grumbled, taking it off and looking at it. “It’s a bunch of terrible memories anyway.”

It was. Looking in the mirror again without it, she could barely see the same girl that had almost killed everyone by opening a portal. There was nothing of the desperate Force Captain there anymore and it kind of felt nice. She even looked like she belonged in that outfit.

“So, question… you are allowed to say no”, Sparkles then said, chuckling awkwardly. “Can I do your hair?”

Catra was inclined to say no right away, but hesitated, settling on a slightly disgusted expression for now.

“I love doing other people’s hair, but I’m too old to just experiment on my mom’s, and Bow would let me but his is so

short, so please”, the princess pleaded and it was almost endearing.

She took a breath, resolving herself to the life she had kind of chosen under the influence of Scorpia's poison and should make the best of now that she was here. “Only if you’re careful, and nothing extravagant”, she said.

Sparkles literally jumped in joy and then grabbed Catra before quickly letting go again. “Right, walking. Fun”, she then said.

“That’s how normal people do it, Sparkles”, she pointed out with a smirk.

The girl groaned. “But that’s so boring.”

“What about the clothes?”, Catra then asked looking back into the mess of a room. Her old clothes were now lying among them.

“Leave them. Maybe someone else will pick them one day”, the other said with a shrug.

It felt odd to just leave them behind, like she was leaving her life behind and in a way she was. It scared her a bit. A lot. But she let it happen regardless.

The next weird thing to happen was that on the way back to Sparkles’ room, Catra swore that every guard was staring at them for some reason. No, she realized, they were looking at her specifically.

If these people thought she was less scary just because she had cried a little and changed her clothes, they had another thing coming. One hiss was enough for everyone to mind their business again.

Back in the room, the princess patted the bench by the window and Catra sat with her back to the other. Sparkles started by weaving her fingers through the chaos of her hair, untangling every knot with extreme care.

It was nice and relaxing.

“Wanna do this in silence? We can also talk if you want?”, the princess then asked and Catra thought.

Silence would make her brain go places. “Talking is fine.”

Sparkles hummed. “Since you love to talk”, she said sarcastically. “I think I should start. Let’s see. I could tell you how I met Bow?” Catra nodded — it was interesting enough. “I was, I don’t know, ten or so when I got bored of everything and decided I was going to explore the woods. I got lost of course and then I got shot at.” She chuckled. “Nothing happened, but I cried so hard, and then this little boy came through the trees and apologized and cried with me because he thought he really hurt someone.”

“Isn’t that the point of shooting arrows?”, Catra asked but was shushed.

“He was ten”, Sparkles defended her friend. “Anyway, when we both calmed down we introduced each other and played and got to know each other a bit. He was training to shoot so that he can join the rebellion when he was older and I told him I wanted to join too. We trained together then, him shooting and me teleporting to get his arrows back. I kept telling my mom and aunt about him, but they thought he was some imaginary friend I made up because, you know, I didn’t have any real friends until then.”

Catra snorted. “How did they find out?” She was actually starting to get invested.

Sparkles laughed before she had even told the story. “We mostly just met in the woods, but he came closer and closer to Brightmoon each time. And then I had the brilliant idea to sneak off into the kitchen to get some snacks because he made such a long trip, while I literally just had to teleport out of my bedroom. Let’s just say it didn’t go quite as planned.”

“Uh-huh.”

“Well, my teleportation wasn’t the best back then, so when I tried to teleport two people for the first time, we ended up less sneaking into the kitchen and more crashing into it and possibly directly into a cake, too.” Catra burst out laughing at the image. “Hey, hold still or you are not allowed to complain if it hurts”, the princess chastised. “Anyway, there was frosting everywhere and due to the chaos, our sudden appearance had caused, the bakers stumbled over each other and threw the batter, they had been mixing, around. Safe to say I got grounded after that, but my mom was still very happy that I had a real friend.”

Catra needed some time to fully calm down. Every time she thought she managed, the picture of two kids in the middle of a demolished kitchen flashed through her mind again.

“I’m glad you’re having fun”, Sparkles grumbled. “Your turn, tell me an embarrassing story”, she then demanded.

She really tried racking her brain for something, but came up with nothing. “I don’t think I have one”, she said eventually.

“Come on, you can’t tell me nothing embarrassing ever happened.”

“I don’t know.” Everything remotely embarrassing was quickly followed by punishment. Any accidents were then tried to be avoided.

Sparkles seemed to notice the gloominess threatening the good mood and changed course. “Anything else then? Something funny? Nice? Food related?”

That she had. “I can tell you how I smuggled food, does that count?”

“Yes!”, the princess replied enthusiastically.

“Well, we only had rations bars in the Horde, but everyone knew that the food that was brought back from raids was free to grab. Not officially of course. If anyone caught you, you’d be punished,

but I snuck down anyway. I only ever grabbed a little, so it wouldn’t be obvious and I also never told the others. Just Adora.”

“Wait, Adora has eaten normal food before?”, Sparkles asked confused.

“No”, Catra snorted. “I always tried to convince her, but she was so rule abiding, that I could never make her try it. Well, that’s not true. I think I made her eat bread once.”

“That’s it?”

Not really, but she couldn't tell the other about the time travel. If Adora had chosen to keep her friends in the dark, Catra could respect that. “That’s Adora. I ate a few things. Bread, buns, cookies, I think a sausage once, a bunch of sweet stuff that I cannot name”, she listed. “It was nice, though. Hiding under the sheets, whispering with her while eating all that stuff.”

“You’re really close, aren’t you?”, Sparkles asked softly, now moving on to a brush.

Catra sighed. “We were”, she mumbled. “I’m not sure if we still are.”

“You definitely look like it. I mean, you’re awkward and fight a lot, but I don't think I'd get into arguments with people I didn't care about. And I know Adora cares about you a lot”, the princess said and it still surprised Catra to hear that.

“We made a promise when we were really small. That we would look out for each other and then nothing bad could happen”, she told the other. “She… we both broke that promise. We never did that. These promises were the only thing we could depend on.”

Sparkles was quiet for a while, simply brushing her hair, but then the girl was apparently done. “Sometimes, I think, these things happen. We have to make tough choices.”

Catra chuckled, it was a sad lonely thing. “I know.” She probably knew it better than anyone. “I’m just not sure we can come back from that. A lot of trust has been broken.”

“Then you’ll rebuild”, the girl said easily. “As long as you both want it and are willing to put in the work, I’m sure you’ll be fine.”

“Speaking from experience, huh?”, she asked sarcastically, knowing that the princess has yet to face true friendship issues.

“Not really”, she admitted. “So far, Bow and I have made it through the years with only a few hitches. But now that my mom lets me maybe do more in terms of the war…” She paused. “I’m not naive. I know eventually I will make choices that Bow won’t agree with. But I do hope that our friendship is strong enough. And if you can’t fix yours for yourself, do it for me at least. Give me some hope? If you two can come back from all that hurt, maybe the future is looking bright after all.”

Catra didn’t really know what to say now. “Maybe you should become a motivational speaker”, she suggested with a smirk. Sparkles only responded with raised eyebrows, not impressed. She sighed. “I’m not good at these things”, she confessed. “I want to do better, I think. I just don’t know how.”

The princess shrugged. “I don’t know either. But, you tried talking to me and it worked, right? If you keep reading those psychology books and just put some effort into your relationship with Adora, I know you’ll do great”, she told her.

She whipped around in shock at the mention of her books.

Sparkles seemingly knew what got her in a frenzy. "I was curious what you did all day. And hiding it up on the shelves might work on the others, but I can teleport", she said with a shrug. "I didn't tell anyone if that's what you're worried about. But back to the real problem, I’ve brushed it, but what do I do with it?”

Catra had to laugh at the sudden change in tone, a little sigh of relief was maybe also in there. “I don’t know”, she then said.

“Something simple, maybe? Something I can replicate without spending hours?”

Sparkles hummed and started putting her hair up several times, then staring at it a few seconds before trying something new. “Okay, we can go ponytail or braided or… no actually that’s it.”

“Ponytail?”, Catra asked skeptically. “Like Adora’s?”

The princess snorted. “No, don’t worry, I’ll make it look cool”, she assured her. “I would also like to redo Adora’s, but I fear she might be too attached to that poof.”

“She’s had that since she was four, I doubt she’ll ever get rid of it”, Catra laughed and heard Sparkles chuckle a bit too.

“Alright, let me see”, the girl mumbled and gathered Catra’s hair again to figure out how to place it. “It’s got to be out of your face, but you have so many short strands”, she complained.

“A few strands out won’t kill me, Sparkles.”

The girl grumbled something unintelligible and kept working. “Okay, I think I got it”, she then said, looking at her work a few more times. “Go look at it.”

Catra was ushered away from her rather comfortable sitting space to go to the mirror that was hanging on the other side of the room.

“It looks nice”, she uttered in astonishment. It was like Sparkles had said, just a simple ponytail, but the girl had made it sit a bit higher than Adora’s making the floof of her hair mimic something like a crown around her head. The few short strands that still fell into her face framed it nicely without any fear of them getting in the way during a fight. “I look… different.”

“Is that good?”, the princess asked carefully. She was obviously proud of her work.

Catra wasn’t sure. She didn’t hate how she looked. “I don’t know. Just different”, she said eventually.

Sparkles smiled at her. “I think this is a good start. A change like that is like a blank piece of paper. Now you can decide how you want to fill it.”

“That does sound nice”, she admitted and then watched the other yawn. Staying up for days was second nature to her at this point, but the princess needed her sleep. “You should try to catch some more sleep.”

“What about you?”, the girl asked because of course she would.

Catra shrugged.

“I’m not accepting that”, Sparkles told her and dragged her to a different part of her room to a couch. “Here, you can sleep here.”

“I’m fine and I have a place to sleep.”

“Just that you *don’t* sleep”, the princess pointed out. “Some company might do you good. I’ll be right up there if you need me. I’ll even tell you a nice story if that helps.”

“I’m not a baby”, she growled, but the other rolled her eyes.

“You are behaving like one. Lie down. I promise I’ll redo your hair tomorrow”, she said.

Catra groaned, evaluating her chances. Sparkles could teleport and despite Catra’s allergy to it, the girl would undoubtedly still use it to get her back. And she could just stay awake regardless. She didn’t really want to go back to these files anyway.

With a groan, she sat down on the couch and took the hair tie back out. She also thought about sleeping in her underwear, but considering the audience, she wasn’t sure.

Out in the field she would have to sleep in her clothes, too, so actually this might be a good opportunity to test them. So, she kept it on and snuggled under a blanket that Sparkles had given her and listened to the promised story about the time the princess had doodled all over the war room.

Catra hadn’t planned to fall asleep, but when she opened her eyes to see the daymoon up, she noticed that she had. And without any nightmares, too.

Sparkles was still asleep, so she used the opportunity to take another look at herself in the mirror without anyone waiting for a verdict. It really wasn’t bad.

The other girl was still not waking up, so Catra tried her best to get a similar ponytail done, but evidently needed to be shown the right technique. She had no other choice than to wait for the princess.

To pass the time, she decided to take a quick trip outside.

Sparkles’ room was on the same side of the building as Adora’s and so Catra could easily jump down to the garden to tidy up the mess she had left behind. She decided to pick up the files and put their squad's at the very bottom of a pile that she placed as far out of sight as possible. Even if someone came to snoop, they hopefully wouldn’t take interest in it like that.

Then she went back to the window she had jumped out of and, thanks to a few trees and the interesting architecture of the castle, she managed to get back inside to where Sparkles was stirring. Finally.

The girl groaned and turned a few times before eventually giving it up. “Morning”, she said lazily when she spotted Catra.

She snorted. “Morning, Sparkles.”

“I can't believe you're already awake”, the girl groaned as she slowly stretched herself.

"Some people would say, we got up late", Catra replied. She didn't really know how late it was, nor had she seen a clock in this room, but she felt safe to say that it was not early morning anymore.

“Just give me a sec.” Sparkles fell back down on her bed and Catra rolled her eyes. She wasn’t a morning person either, but that was just dramatic.

She tried to wait patiently as the other crawled out of bed, almost teleported into her closet, complained about it for five whole minutes, got dressed, did her hair, and laid down on the couch to complain some more.

Sometime around the teleportation mishap, Catra picked up on some noise in the hallway. It seemed the others were already well underway for breakfast.

“Okay”, Sparkles finally appeared awake enough. “Hair time.”

“Can you explain it?”, Catra asked awkwardly. “I tried to do it earlier, but I…”

“Sure”, the other mumbled, and though tired and slightly slurred, she tried her best to make Catra understand how to make the hair stay where it was supposed to without hurting her scalp.

When that was done, they went down to the dining hall, too. Catra was a little nervous as to what the others would say about her new style, though she wouldn’t let that show. The guards, that she was sure were not the same as last night, were certainly surprised. She had to growl at all of them to get them off her case.

“Showtime”, Sparkles squealed, apparently more awake now, and turned the corner into the dining hall.

Catra followed after taking a deep breath.

At first the others didn’t seem to notice the pair approach, but when they were directly in front of the table and everyone looked up, they all started to stare at her in shock. Something clanked and she saw that Scorpia had dropped her butter knife.

And then… “You look hot- Good! You look *good*!” Adora hid her face in her palms while Catra could do nothing but stare at her, feeling a bit of heat rise to her face.

“Yeah, I- I agree”, Scorpia mumbled, and the others, meaning Arrow Boy and the two older princesses, all gave their nods of approval.

Not that she had needed that, but it was nice. She sat down next to Adora, who still couldn’t look at her, while Scorpia did nothing but. Then again, it wasn’t Scorpia who blurted it out.

“You know, I wasn’t trying to impress you, but I’m still glad you like it”, she told the girl with a smirk.

Adora responded with a groan, sinking a bit down in her seat. “Can we just forget I said anything?”

“But it means so much coming from you”, she went on, a bit sarcastically maybe, but she enjoyed watching the blonde’s cheeks get even redder.

“Catra”, she begged with a voice that sounded like fake crying.

She only laughed. “Hey, Sparkles, I think I found an embarrassing story for you.” Now someone was laughing with her and somewhere deep inside, Catra could feel a bit of hope blossoming.

Chapter End Notes

A thing I learned about myself while writing this: I can't describe outfits xD So, I'll try (I hope it works) to link the inspiration:

It's the second picture but with the hair from Adora's vision of future Catra from the series finale <333

(Also a little note I'll add here on the topic of clothing: I'm essentially using cartoon logic, so they all have just one outfit that they never have to change or wash, no matter how many days they've been wearing it xD)

Next time: We'll have a little time skip, and ... I'm not sure if this is a spoiler, but I don't think so, and I'm sure you already expect it anyway: Princess Prom!! Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 12: Princess Prom - Part 1

Chapter Notes

Long note, I'm sorry, I feel like rambling today...

Hi, so ... I'm gonna be honest, I'm not sure how smart it is to upload this in the middle of easter, and I also kinda forgot it was easter until like yesterday, but... I really don't wanna mess up my little schedule that I have made (and I already kinda messed that up anyway because I fell behind on editing (more on this later), but it's fine, it works itself out), so... I'll update it during easter.

And yes, I fell behind on editing because I ended up rewriting a lot (almost all) conversations in the last two and next two chapters (work in progress), which wasn't exactly planned, obviously. And I kinda just finished editing this one, and that is why this might have more typos than usual. I apologize.

Also, the first bit of this is like a montage of a few events I just... had to cram in there... okay, actually the entire chapter is kinda a montage.
I hope it works and isn't all too weird, I just didn't really know how the timeline in canon works for princess prom, so I gave them like a week to prepare and so we now have a bunch of small moments all crammed into one chapter.

Also, warning for incoming jealousy.

I hope you have fun!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Ugh, my aunt Casta invited us", Glimmer said when she finally showed up at lunch. The girl looked less than happy about that, which was probably to be expected. After all, Castaspella did have a tendency to baby Glimmer.

Adora had honestly wondered when, and if, a potential trip to Mystacor would come up. The last few weeks, the princess had already dragged them all around Brightmoon and several nearby villages, now that their guards had been dismissed. She has had a feeling it would only be a matter of time.

"Yes! She is the best and Mystacor is great!", Bow told them excitedly.

Catra groaned, and Adora flinched — she was still not entirely used to the other's presence. "Another trip? Really?", she mumbled.

"Well, if Catra doesn't want to go… I mean, we can't leave her behind", Glimmer said quickly, obviously happy to not having to deal with her aunt, even though she was trying to hide it.

"Hold on", Bow interjected again. "You know Castaspella is only going to get mad if you ignore her, and Mystacor is a great spot to relax. And we don't really have anything better to do", he pointed out.

And he was right. The Horde had been oddly quiet over the last few weeks — so much so that the queen had decided they could try to rebuild Thaymor, which also meant Brightmoon was a bit more quiet. Hence Glimmer's insistence to fill their time with road trips around the kingdom.

Still, Adora wasn't really sold on the idea to take a vacation, either. "I don't think we should risk it", she said. "I don't like how inactive the Horde has been. We should be ready and not distracted. Just in case." To be fair, she was also a bit worried about Shadow Weaver, and after what happened last time in Mystacor… yeah, she'd rather not repeat that.

"And that is exactly why we should relax", Bow argued, though. "If we're constantly alert, we'll be drained by the time the Horde does do something."

Scorpia carefully raised a pincher then. "Uh… hate to interrupt, but… what's an aunt?", she asked and earned some pitiful stares from anyone not Horde related.

"My dad's sister", Glimmer explained shortly. "And she's so clingy", she groaned and send a pout in Bow's direction.

"We also *do* still have something to do", Catra argued on Glimmer's behalf, though Adora suspected a slightly selfish motivation behind it, which she understood.

The princess perked up immediately. "Oh yeah! I almost forgot, and I think before we step foot on a floating rock, we should really test teleportation first. Great idea", she told them. Bow just raised a skeptical eyebrow. "Come on. Adora and Catra don't want to go and we can't just leave half the team behind. That I don't have to deal with my aunt is just a nice bonus."

The boy sighed. "Fine, but at some point, we are going to the beach."

"Maybe after the war", Catra said sarcastically.

"Why can you never be on my side?", Bow asked, pouting a little bit.

The girl just shrugged.

It was a good question, though. One that Adora had pondered for weeks, ever since Catra had suddenly become best friends with Glimmer — sometimes, she swore even Bow was jealous. Not that Adora was jealous, that would be ridiculous.

It was just weird.

After so many days of Catra antagonizing everyone and storming out angrily almost every day, things have been strangely calm now. And no one would explain it.

All Adora knew was that the feline got a pep talk and a new outfit — a thing that had been especially surprising since she hadn't wanted one in the beginning. And she had talked to Glimmer. Of all people.

Adora was happy for the girl, of course. Catra seemed to be doing a lot better and that was good — she looked comfortable and happier. Yes, she was still paranoid, but she actually came to eat, actually hung out with them and was actually nice … in her own way. She also still spent a lot of time away from them, but she was around more often than before.

Because Glimmer did … something. Something happened between them, but neither would tell anyone what happened that night. And apparently no one but Adora thought that was weird.

Of course, she had tried to find out. At first she hadn't even bothered asking Catra and went straight for Glimmer, who just hit her with a "Sorry, but that is a secret. I promised." and shrugged. She tried a few more times, even asked Bow in hopes that maybe the girl had told her best friend, but nothing.

Eventually she had tried asking Catra, awkwardly, but she also just said "That's a thing between me and Sparkles."

It was driving her mad. What did Glimmer do that Adora couldn't?

All they did reveal about that night, was an incident that showed them that Catra was apparently allergic to teleportation, which they planned to further investigate once they had time.

Well, then Glimmer had a bunch of different ideas and they still hadn't tested it. Only now, that this experiment was a convenient excuse to not having to deal with Castaspella, did the girl finally decide to do that.

And so, they found their way outside and tested everyone's teleportation tolerance.

Adora could safely say that she got dizzy after about a dozen times — a circumstance that had not naturally occurred in all their battles yet and probably wouldn't in the future either. After a quick recharge, it was Scorpia's turn, who made it to eight.

They even tested Bow, but after years of being teleported by Glimmer, he made it to the end of her powers without any issues.

But considering that realistically no one would need to be teleported eight times or more in a row, none of them should experience trouble in the future. No one but Catra, that was.

It visibly bothered the girl to be the odd one out. So much so, that she had demanded to test it herself again, claiming that maybe she had just been surprised. But even knowing what was supposed to happen, she still dropped to her knees, holding her stomach and took a few seconds to control herself enough that she at least wouldn't throw up.

That was as much of an improvement that Glimmer announced that they could possibly risk teleporting Catra in emergency situations. For every other situation they would have to find a workaround, though.

After that was done, and without the trip to Mystacor, and no Horde activity, they ended up with a lot of time on their hands that they filled either together or individually — Catra often took some space, though sometimes she *voluntarily* hung out with them.

She already hasn't had much of an idea on how to interact with the girl when she had been hostile, much less when she was somewhat friendly. Not that it really mattered anyway, because Catra usually gravitated towards Glimmer, so Adora barely had to interact with her, which she also didn't like.

Things have gotten very confusing.

In more than just one way. Even ignoring her own contradicting feelings on the matter, the reason for those feelings wasn't any

easier to make sense of. Adora might call Glimmer and Catra 'best friends' mockingly, but they didn't exactly behave like that most of the time.

Just like now. With the nice weather, they often ended up in the garden, and Glimmer liked to fill the silences with her ideas for the war, most of which were just not practical, the others plain reckless.

Eventually the girl ended in a shouting match with Catra.

"Who put you in charge? You clearly have no idea of strategy!", the feline yelled, pointing accusingly at Glimmer, who scoffed.

"And you do? All you ever did was run out of meetings!"

"More than you! If you forgot, I was literally trained since birth for this. What did you get?"

"Uh, magic?!"

"That you have to recharge."

Glimmer looked downright ready to tear Catra apart, and the feline looked ready for a fight, too. Someone *should* probably go and stop them, but Adora would admit she was not looking forward to get in between claws and magic.

Bow and Scorpia seemed equally hesitant.

Besides, these two often resolved whatever made them fight rather quickly. It didn't seem like either actually took their fights seriously. Adora was still worried it would escalate every single time.

And then, as if some mysterious force had noticed the need for a diversion, the doors to the yard opened and three guards stepped through, each with a silver plate in hand. They stopped in front of Glimmer, Adora and Scorpia.

Now that they were close enough, she recognized the invitation to Princess Prom.

Glimmer cheered up in an instant. "It's finally time!", she squealed, mostly at Bow who immediately understood what was going on.

In perfect synchrony the danced in circles while chanting. "Princess Prom! Princess Prom! Princess Prom! We are going to Princess Prom!"

"Are they okay? Should we be worried?", Scorpia asked, slightly leaning over, looking extremely confused.

Catra in the meantime came over and leaned down, so she could read Adora's invitation. "All Princess Ball, Winter Wonderland", she read out loud. "Creative."

"The ball is a meeting for the princesses of Etheria", Bow jumped in to explain, unnecessarily, but he didn't know that.

"It's a giant party! Dancing, food, fancy dresses. It only happens once a decade. I've been waiting for years for this!", Glimmer exclaimed.

"So if it's a party exclusively for princesses, why does Adora get an invite? She's only a princess sometimes, does that even count?", Catra asked innocently despite knowing the answer. Adora rolled her eyes.

"Of course! Every princess is invited. Even part-time princesses", Glimmer explained.

"Oh yeah, it's all in the invite." For demonstration purposes, Bow took Adora's invite and unraveled it to an endless scroll. "The ball has been going on for centuries. There's a lot of really old etiquette stuff you gotta do before you can party, but-"

"But once we're done with that, it's gonna be so fun!", Glimmer told them, her excitement growing by the second. "And princess

Frosta is hosting this year in the Kingdom of Snows. Her magic is incredibly powerful! She'd be a huge get for the rebellion."

"Great, a mission is gonna be so fun at a party", Catra mumbled sarcastically.

Adora scoffed. "Why are you like this? You knew all that", she mumbled low enough for only Catra to hear.

"It's fun to annoy you", the other replied with a shrug. And Adora was once again at a loss. It felt unsettlingly close to their old banter, but the fact that Catra was bantering with her at all, threw her off — they still hadn't exactly made up.

Glimmer waved a hand dismissively. "It will be a quick thing. All our other recruitments were a snap. Now more important is the question of plus ones. Every princess gets to bring one. I'll go with Bow, obviously, but what about Scorpia and Adora? One of you takes Catra, of course."

"How I love being thrown at whoever is free", the feline mumbled sarcastically, but didn't really seem offended.

Scorpia cleared her throat then and was extremely red in the face. "So uh… I actually have a date. Already", she said awkwardly.

They all stared at her in confusion. Scorpia had been practically glued to their sides, when did she get a date?

"Who are you going with?", Bow asked with a smile, trying to cover up the surprise of that statement.

"I… well, Perfuma kind of asked me", the woman mumbled awkwardly.

The confusion came back. "When?", Glimmer asked, visibly running the math in her head.

"I mean, Perfuma had been with Scorpia for practically the entire mission", Adora pointed out. Honestly, she was just kind of glad

that they accidentally avoided the weird tension between Glimmer and Bow from last time.

Scorpia smiled a little. "It was during the battle. We stumbled into each other and she asked before running off again", she explained.

"Romantic", Catra mumbled, and luckily the sarcasm didn't get through to Scorpia.

"It was sweet", the woman simply agreed.

Glimmer shrugged. "Okay then, I guess that means Catra goes with Adora." As she said that a vicious smile formed on her face. "Isn't it funny how things work out sometimes?", she asked, though Adora noticed she was mostly talking to Catra, who didn't look very happy.

"We'll all be together at the ball anyway, it doesn't really matter who goes with who", Adora tried to lighten the mood a bit.

"Of course you would think that", Glimmer laughed smugly. "I think you're forgetting the etiquette part."

"Glimmer and I have been preparing for years, but you might need a crash course", Bow added. "You need to learn all the rules. And dancing."

"Not to forget a new outfit", the princess finished.

"Sounds fun!", Scorpia said with a smile.

Adora simply shared a short look with Catra. This was not going to be fun.

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Out of all of them, Scorpia really was the only one who payed attention to Bow and Glimmer.

Adora was pretty sure that Catra was asleep, and she herself kept drifting off to figure out how to deal with this situation.

She was still right, it didn't matter much who went with who because they all ended up in the same place. And yet, last time Glimmer had still felt left behind when Bow had gone with someone else, and this time Adora felt weirdly uneasy about having to go with Catra.

Realistically, they wouldn't have to spent all that much time together — just these lessons, and maybe a few short minutes at the prom. Should be manageable. Adora couldn't help but wish it was more.

Especially because in the three days of etiquette, Catra did not talk to her at all, outside of a few sarcastic remarks.

Adora might as well could go to prom alone and it wouldn't really make a difference.

And, admittedly, it bothered her. Enough that she barely listened to any instructions and she swore that if she hadn't learned this already, she would be doomed. She just couldn't stop thinking about it.

It had already been bad before but now it was even worse because the feline was actually on friendly terms with most of them. Only Adora was avoided. And yes, she had to remind herself, Catra wasn't *friends* with anyone outside of Glimmer — and occasionally Bow because he was a package deal with Glimmer — but she at least held some polite conversations with the others. Just not Adora.

She felt like she was going mad. What was happening? Why did it bother her this much? She should just be happy that the girl made some progress, and she was. But she was also pissed for reasons she didn't fully understand.

It was fine, though. She could deal with this. It wasn't like much has changed anyway — she and Catra hadn't been friends for a while and they still weren't. Just because the feline decided to be friends with someone else, didn't change anything about her relationship with Adora.

But it did. Was she insane for thinking that? She felt insane. She hated being excluded — wait, was that what Glimmer had felt like last time? Was Adora too dramatic about this?

"Uh, Adora?", Bow's voice startled her.

"I'm here. Present, yes", she said, standing up and almost saluting. Even after a good year in the rebellion, that was somehow still ingrained into her system.

"You sure?", the boy asked. "Did you listen to a single thing, I said?"

"Of course", she answered, even though she really did not.

She wasn't sure if he believed her, but he seemed to be giving her the benefit of the doubt. He cleared his throat and then kept going. "Alright, as I was saying, with all the etiquette out of the way, the next thing you'll need to know is dances. All guests are required to at least participate in two, the traditional first dances. I think there once were more, but things have loosened up a bit and the rest can be free-styled."

"We'll need to be good at those two", Glimmer told them sternly. "Because of tradition. It's like with etiquette, we can't mess up without insulting the hostess."

That certainly didn't set the mood for some fun exercises. But they all resolved themselves to trying their best.

It was just that their best, as they found out the next day, was not exactly good.

They started by learning the steps individually, which perfectly presented everyone's level.

Adora wasn't much surprised to learn that Scorpia, or even herself, couldn't really dance — even though she hadn't been half bad last time, but that had been months ago and she had forgotten everything it seemed. But… Bow couldn't either.

He seemed to know the steps well enough, having prepared for this with Glimmer for years, but he looked rather clumsy executing them as he and the girl demonstrated.

The only people with some actual grace in them were Glimmer and Catra, which was probably why the former ended up yelling instructions while Bow partnered with Scorpia to refine his skills a bit more.

And they did end up moving steadily more fluidly. Other than Adora and Catra who spend the next hour stumbling into each other constantly because they couldn't agree on who should lead. Eventually they ended up actually talking for the first time in weeks, as they loudly argued about it until Glimmer stepped in and designated Catra as the lead because she was the better dancer.

But even a clear assignment didn't help break the ice between them. As if things hadn't been awkward enough already, now Adora felt like she had been through battle every time they took a break. Even Catra lost a bit of her elegance by how tense they both were.

In fact, they were tense enough that Catra, of all people, got reprimanded by Glimmer. Which only served to make the girl more angry at Adora. And yet, she let it out on the princess. Sort of — technically she yelled at Glimmer, but was insulting Adora.

"Could you two focus please?", Bow stepped in eventually. "Adora, relax. Catra, also relax. You have known each other your entire lives, this can't be so hard", he chastised.

Somehow, it did go a bit better. Adora tried to pretend the other didn't hate her and it helped a lot. She wasn't sure what Catra was imagining to be more calm, and she also didn't really want to know.

They were honestly not as good as she knew they could be, but good enough to pass Glimmer's scrutiny, and that was all that was important.

Looking for clothes didn't go any better either. While Glimmer had tried to sell them on the idea of matching color schemes, neither Adora nor Catra could cooperate with the other long enough to reach a conclusion. So, they ended up making their choices separately. Which also meant that Catra sorted through clothing with Glimmer.

Adora shortly debated whether she could have done something differently to be doing this with Catra instead.

She shook her head and went back to searching.

It was, once again, quite easy for her to find the dress she had worn last time, but the others didn't have that advantage, and so she had to watch the new best friend duo struggle to find something nice.

Alright, she told herself, she had to do something — she could not keep moping around, and the constant awkwardness was killing her. So, she decided to take a chance and walked up to the feline just as she threw another thing to the side.

"Who even ever wore that?", she asked in disgust and made a face as well.

"Need some help?", Adora asked and hoped she didn't sound as stressed out as she felt.

Catra didn't seem to notice, though. Or she ignored it. "I'd prefer a match, and maybe some gasoline to speed up the process", she

just grumbled, throwing more clothes away. "Why does everything need to be pastels and ruffles?"

Adora started to sift through the piles as well. "I don't know. It's the style, I guess."

"It's ugly."

"Nobody ever said it wasn't", Adora laughed. And since it seemed that the girl was too angry at the clothes to mind her presence, she offered her help again. "Anything specific you're looking for?"

Catra sighed. "I don't know. If I could, I would go back to the Fright Zone to steal the suit I had last time, but I doubt that's gonna be possible", she mumbled.

Adora remembered that suit very well. And she remembered something else. "Be right back!"

She ran over to another chest that she had looked through earlier during the hunt for her dress. She had seen something there that had looked like it might fit with Catra's style. She just had to find it again.

When she did, she got back to Catra, who hadn't stopped her own endeavors, not that Adora had expected her too. "What about this?", she asked the girl.

Catra looked up bored, but when her eyes fell on the suit, she looked intrigued. "Maybe", she mumbled and held it to her body.

It was a dark purple, a lot less edgy than the one Catra had worn last time, but it still looked nice. At least in Adora's opinion. "So?", she asked because it was still unclear what the other thought.

"It'll do, I guess", the other said. "Thanks for the help." Then she walked off to a mirror to get a better look at it. And Adora was left behind without another thought.

Glimmer walked over to talk to the girl — apparently they were discussing some ideas on how to adjust, if the hand movements were any indication.

And Adora felt this unnamed feeling, that was definitely not jealousy, creep up in her again, which led her once more to the question of why it even bothered her?

She supposed that Catra had always clung to her so much, that she never really considered what it would be like for the girl to have other friends. She didn't like it, which was a bad thought. She should be happy that Catra was making friends, getting better, growing.

She shook her head and decided to distract herself by helping Scorpia. The selection of clothes here wasn't exactly made for her figure, and whatever they did find that could fit was, as expected, ugly.

After hours and a missed lunch, they did find something. It was a black dress — Adora thinks the woman wore something black last time as well, but wasn't all that sure. It was simple, and Scorpia … well, she didn't exactly look radiant in it, but she still looked good, great even.

The woman herself was certainly impressed with her look and that was what counted. Adora had a rather simple dress, too, so at least she had someone to match with to an extent.

The day after that, it was Prom time.

Perfuma had arrived earlier that day to get ready with Scorpia. Bow and Glimmer prepared together. And Catra obviously wasn't interested in spending her time with Adora.

She got dressed the same way she had last time, and since she had no one to goof around with, she was left to brood and wait in the hallway until the first pair arrived to join her.

"The She-Ra", Perfuma called out to her and Adora tried to look friendly. "You seem… sad?", she mumbled.

Adora scoffed. "I'm not. Just bored", she lied. "You two look good."

"Thank you", Scorpia beamed. "Where's Catra? Didn't you get ready together?"

"No", she answered shortly and noticed that she made things awkward. "She likes her privacy, it's fine."

"Are you sure?, the woman asked carefully. "It's just that… you two seemed really tense lately."

She sighed. "I just… I'm confused and frustrated. I mean… I try for days to reach her, but one mysterious talk with Glimmer and suddenly they're friends and she still ignores me", she mumbled. "And it sounds so bad when I say it out loud."

Perfuma smiled gently. "I don't exactly know what's going on, but growth is rarely a linear process", she then said. "It's good that she has a friend, and eventually I'm sure she'll come around to you, too."

Scorpia nodded enthusiastically. "She's been so much friendlier lately. And she talks to you. That's progress!"

"I guess, you're right." Still didn't mean she liked it.

"You know", Perfuma said again. "I would feel blessed to guide you through some freeing meditation to improve your aura if you'd like. Maybe it will help. When you are aligned with yourself, it is much easier to connect with others", she offered.

"Uh, thanks?", she replied awkwardly and wasn't quiet sure what to do. She didn't want to outright refuse, that would be rude, but she also didn't want to agree.

Luckily, the other three joined them just a moment later and Adora felt a repeat of the hot outfit incident coming, so she pressed her lips tightly together and settled for a blush that undoubtedly rose to her face.

Catra had already looked great last time, and somehow she looked even better now. Especially with the intricate bun that her hair had turned into — courtesy of Glimmer, she assumed.

"Great! We're all here, let's go then!", Glimmer called out and luckily stopped any potential for awkward conversation — or for Adora to make a fool out of herself again — and so began the journey to the Kingdom of Snows.

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They had to wait a rather long time in front of the castle because there were a lot of people here.

That had always confused Adora. She knew there were a lot of non-elemental princesses, but that many? Unlikely. Who else was invited?

They moved through the queue silently and when they made it to the weapon check-in, Adora debated going against the rules. She still carried her sword as a bracelet and she had long learned her lesson about leaving it somewhere unattended. She knew the ball was neutral ground and weapon's were strictly forbidden, but she wasn't planning on using it — nobody had to know. It was just a matter of safety.

So, she tried to put on her best poker-face as she nervously told the guards that she had no weapons to check in. She didn't feel very confident in her ability to lie, but the guard barely even listened, and just impatiently waved them through in the middle of her sentence.

Maybe the long line was beneficial after all.

"Naughty, Adora", a raspy low voice whispered way too close to her ear. "Bringing a weapon onto neutral ground", Catra tsked.

"Like you didn't do the same", she whispered back.

Catra laughed. "Yeah, the difference is, that was me and this is you, princess."

Adora sighed. "Just focus." She definitely needed to because she had to rely mostly on things she had learned a year ago to get her through the etiquette part. At least this time she was prepared for Frosta's age.

As they approached the throne, they split into their groups of three. Glimmer and Bow at the front wasted no time curtsying and bowing respectively.

"Revered hostess, we come into your hall under the ancient rules of hospitality, bringing greetings from Brightmoon", Glimmer said the words that needed to be said, then she looked behind her and beckoned Adora and Catra to also make their entrance, which they did with the appropriate bows. "And She-Ra, the legendary warrior", she added, pointing at Adora.

The crowd behind them started to chatter, loudly. With how many people still weren't caught up on the news, it was honestly a miracle she even received an invitation.

"You are welcome in the Kingdom of Snows under the ancient rules of hospitality. Leave conflict at the door and please enjoy the ball", Frosta replied a lot less cold than last time, possibly because Adora hadn't insulted her.

"Thank you, your majesty", Glimmer said with a nod and then the four of them left the podium and quickly waited for Perfuma and Scorpia to rejoin them before they entered the big room that would later become a dance floor. "Okay, once she's done with that, she'll walk around like everyone else too. Then we can strike

and try to recruit her", the girl then made up a plan. "Now come on, let's rock this ball!"

They moved through the crowd a bit, but most people around here were strangers.

"There's Entrapta", Bow then called out and since they had nothing better to do, they went over to the woman, who currently came sliding down a column.

"The arrow one and angry one!", the scientist called out and waved. "Are you here to watch the social experiment too?"

Catra snorted. "Sure", she then said, making the other clap excitedly.

"Wait, have we never mentioned our names?", Bow then asked and Catra shrugged. Even if they had, the princess had most likely already forgotten them. "Well, I'm Bow, that's Catra and over there are Glimmer, Adora, Scorpia and Perfuma", he introduced them all.

Entrapta nodded, but Adora doubted she would remember any of that. "Why were you up there?", she asked then, so that maybe the woman would at least remember her somewhat.

"It's the perfect place to observe", the scientist explained. "It's a nice overview. There are so many groups that keep forming and breaking, it's hard to keep track of from down here. That's why you need to bring enough pockets for the tiny food, to keep yourself nourished without leaving the spot."

"That… makes sense", she mumbled.

"It's very fascinating, you're all free to join me, but it's also fine if you want to be part of the experiment instead."

"I'll stop by later, okay? We're still waiting for people", Catra told her, surprisingly.

Entrapta nodded and pulled herself back up to her vantage point. She was just as odd as Adora remembered, but Catra's niceness reminded her that being friendly and open with the woman was the most important thing. She wasn't a bad person, just a bit socially isolated.

"That just leaves Mermista", Glimmer mumbled and looked around.

She was right, everyone else was already here. Adora even spotted Netossa and Spinnerella, but they seemed to be with their own group of friends.

"Do you think she'll bring Sea Hawk?", Bow then asked excitedly, also trying to scour the crowd.

"Uh, maybe…" Glimmer didn't look happy about that and Adora recognized a bit of the discomfort from last year.

Bow shot her a confused look, seemingly having noticed as well. "Are you okay? I know you haven't exactly gotten along, but I think it would be cool for us all to be together."

"Sure", she girl replied a bit more enthusiastically.

"There seems to be distress in the group", they heard Entrapta above them.

"I'm not distressed!", Glimmer called up and earned a few disturbed glances from other party goers.

They were luckily interrupted by Mermista finding them first. "Hey, I'm here too. Don't make a big thing out of it", she said as she went to stand with them. "Who are you?" Another round of introductions followed, which really just meant introducing the princess to Catra.

"Repeated procedures. People just walking around in circles", came the whispers from above again.

That seemed to alarm Mermista a bit, a rare expression on her face. "Not gonna get into whatever is happening there", she muttered. "Look, have you seen-"

The chaos continued when Sea Hawk came through the crowd singing. "She's a beauty can't you see? She's attending this with me. She's the princess of the sea! Mermista!" By the end of it, he also stood in their little circle. "Fellow friends. And others." He bowed dramatically.

Mermista groaned. "Catra. Princess Perfuma. Princess Entrapta", she pointed at the three who were new to the man, then back at him. "Sea Hawk. My ride. Just. My. Ride", she pressed out with clear frustration.

Sea Hawk laughs. "Of course", he said before dipping into a whisper. "I'm her plus one."

"You're Sea Hawk?", Catra then asked.

"You've heard of me, of course", the man said, striking a pose. "I am famously renowned for so many things after all."

The girl snorted and just in case Adora shot her a look to make sure the other didn't say anything mean, which she was surely about to do. She rolled her eyes in response. "Yeah, sure. Bow's a big fan", she settled on.

"Whatever. Do they have a kelp bar here?", Mermista interrupted and walked off, with Sea Hawk dutifully following, but she stopped him. "You can stay."

The man pouted, but was evidently delighted enough to reunite with his number one biggest fan that he stayed regardless.

As Entrapta predicted, their group broke and reformed so that different conversations could take place. Somehow Adora ended up in a little circle with Perfuma and Scorpia, and, to her surprise, Catra.

"I have told Scorpia earlier this weird thing that happened a few days ago", Perfuma said then. "A winged horse, something I had never seen before, but nature tends to surprise us in many ways. So, a winged horse ate all the apples in Plumeria and then just flew away. My people didn't know what to do with such a majestic creature."

Adora sighed. "Swift Wind", she realized. She hoped he soon mastered his ability to talk because they needed to have a conversation. "Sorry about that."

Perfuma just laughed. "Oh don't worry, the She-Ra, we will not suffer from that loss and a child of nature could be fed."

Catra laughed and quickly covered it with a cough when the flower princess looked over. "I'm gonna check out the buffet", she then said and walked off.

"Oh! Me too", Glimmer yelled, somehow having heard this despite being in another little group with Bow and a very loud Sea Hawk. She had probably been waiting for an excuse to leave.

So, Catra and Glimmer were gone, Bow was busy with Sea Hawk and even Scorpia left her alone eventually to properly meet Entrapta.

"So, uh", Adora said awkwardly. "How are things in Plumeria, now that the runestone is back to it's former strength?"

"We were truly blessed to have received your help at the right time. The nature is healing and I try helping it whenever I can", Perfuma replied and Adora tried to look interested when she couldn't help mirror Glimmer and keeping a look out for a convenient excuse to get away.

Chapter End Notes

> You might have noticed, I have learned my lesson about describing clothes xD "purple suit" and "black dress" is the best you'll get from me. Details are up to you <33

And wow! Everyone has met each other now! Yay!!

I swear (I hope) the next chapter will be less chaotic. I also hope I can get back on schedule in terms of editing because otherwise I would have to take a week off of updating to get some headstart again, but I really don't want to do that.

Anyway, I'll shut up now... until next time when [spoiler] happens at princess prom! Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 13: Princess Prom - Part 2

Chapter Notes

Hi, the second part of princess prom (that has been edited under a lot less stressful conditions!) is here <33

Trigger warning for another mental breakdown... I swear, after this, our girl is going to be a lot more emotionally stable!

And on that topic: I know it's time for them to have a proper talk and I promise they have one, several actually, and they are coming to you over the next few chapters! I just want to gently remind you that the slow burn tag exists for a reason and we're not even halfway through.
But worry not! Patience is a virtue that I do not posess, and we'll have a lot of progress over the next few chapters. Until the next thing happens of course xD

(little side story: I just decided to check the tags again and found out that for some reason ao3 deleted a tag? I swear I didn't touch it! I know it was there and now it's gone. Added it in again, but now I'm trying to figure out if something else is missing... ao3 please don't fuel my trust issues 👀)

But the good news is that editing has been going well! Now that I'm getting to chapters that are pretty decent and don't require a lot of rewrites, I'm making good progress <333

Now!! Have fun <333 (I promise, next time I'll stop talking this much...)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was terrible at small talk. She had no idea how to give short friendly answers to nonsense topics. Removing herself from the situation was for the best.

Sparkles came with her, for some reason. She was sure the girl would tell her eventually — she always did — so she didn't bother asking.

"It's happening", the princess said then. "I mean, he likes pirates, it makes sense, but… look at him, he's so excited. Soon they'll go on adventures together. Without me. Why did I recruit Sea Hawk?"

"What are you talking about?", she asked, honestly confused.

"Everything's changing", was the melodramatic answer. "I feared this was going to happen, and now it is. He's making new friends and then he won't need me anymore."

"Oh", she mumbled, distractedly looking over the food options. Did they have anything that wasn't cake? Kelp, possibly, but that also didn't sound like something she would eat. "You're hanging out in a big group for the first time and are afraid of being left behind. He's been your only friend for years and now you're scared you'll drift apart", she interpreted — she definitely read too many psychology books lately.

"Yes!" Sparkles seemed relieved that she understood, though. "I'll never have the same connection with anyone else. What do I do?"

"Relax", she said and still couldn't decide what to eat. Maybe nothing, actually. After all, she only came here because Adora kept being nervous around the flower princess — things have been so tense already that she didn't want to embarrass the girl any further.

The girl groaned. "I sit down with you, talk to you, I help you, and you can't even listen to me", she grumbled.

Catra turned to the princess. "I am listening. You're just getting worked up over nothing. Bow is too soft to leave anyone behind, and you're too clingy to let that happen anyway. He's just chatting a bit. Calm down and maybe don't run away from him. If you feel like it, maybe take your own advice and talk to him."

"It's gonna sound like I've gone mad to him", Sparkles pointed out.

"I'm sure he's used to it", she replied and decided that she would try some cookies.

The princess scoffed and stared back at the group. "You've got it easy", she then said. "Adora is pouting whenever you don't look at her. I don't even think Bow noticed I'm gone…"

"It's not gonna happen", she interrupted before the disaster thinking got any worse. "I can tell you one thing for sure, Arrow Boy is not going to leave you behind. He's just a pirate fan and a geek, both of which you are not."

"Wow, thanks, I feel so much better", Sparkles grumbled sarcastically.

Catra sighed. She didn't know why she even bothered with this. Maybe because she felt the need to repay the girl for being there during her own breakdown. "I have *actually* been left behind. I know what you feel like and it feels terrible, but now… we're sort of back together. You said it yourself, if we work out, so will you."

"I said, you could give me hope", the princess corrected. "And you are not at all 'back together'."

She finally grabbed a plate, taking a few cookies. They were hopefully not too sweet. "Whatever. My point is that they are weirdly similar, always so eager to make sure everything is alright. Adora, annoyingly, won't give up, and neither will Arrow Boy."

Sparkles chuckled a little. "Yeah, they are kinda similar. They wanna make sure everyone's doing well."

"See? What did you say? Something about tough times and needing to work through that?", she reminded the other.

"You're annoying, I hate you", the princess mirrored her own words.

She had to laugh at that while she kept loading her plate, but then she noticed something odd out of the corner of her eyes. She didn't think much of it — it was probably just another party-goer wanting a snack — but then she looked up and saw a dark shadow in front of her.

Startled, she let her loot shatter to the ground with a scream and watched the shadow vanish.

"Catra?", Sparkles called out. "You know I didn't mean it, right?", she asked worriedly, apparently not having seen it.

Was she hallucinating?

She knew she had been in this situation before, back when Shadow Weaver had escaped and every shadow had made her jump. But this was different. She hadn't been anxiously looking for the sorceress at all — had kind of forgotten for a moment that she existed.

Catra swallowed and tried to take deep breaths. Was she losing it or did the witch send her spies to find … well, Adora mostly?

She looked over to the girl, who like everyone in the room stared at her. All the stares didn't help her calm down exactly, she felt exposed and cornered at the same time.

While it was surely a stupid decision, she turned and ran outside. Someone called after her, but she ignored it.

Outside, in an empty hallway close to the exit, she finally stopped. The little exercise helped get rid of the adrenaline and the cold biting into her skin made her relax a little.

Then she took a moment to think about what just happened.

Though she would never admit it out loud, Shadow Weaver scared her, always had. And especially after everything that had happened with the woman's escape and Catra's death sentence, and the portal and the sorceress' attempt to kill her, and now the

files to top it all of… it must have gotten worse. It was the only way to explain why it took her so long to calm down again.

There was no sign of any more shadows. Maybe she had imagined it after all? Maybe the sleep deprivation was just getting to her.

"Catra."

She turned around, her claws bared, but no one was there. Was this it? Was she finally going insane?

There was a hand on her shoulder and she instantly went to slash at it, but she only made the shadows disperse behind her.

She wasn't crazy, Shadow Weaver was really here. "You are a coward, show yourself!", she yelled, but when a shadow formed right in front of her, she jumped back.

"You were always quick to bare your teeth", the shadow said, now bearing a resemblance to the sorceress. "But your fear keeps holding you back."

Catra wanted to say that it wasn't true, but the woman would only mock her if she tried. "What do you want?", she asked instead. "Adora? She won't be coming back. Neither of us will."

"You think I want *you* back? I'll admit I haven't seen your defection coming, let alone that you'd join the rebellion, but I shouldn't be surprised. You have always been a disappointment", the woman told her with disdain. "But I have warned you to take Adora down with you. I regret not disposing of you before, but even you had your uses."

"You won't get to use either of us anymore. You have no power!"

"If you truly think that running away will keep you save, you are dumber than I thought", the sorceress said.

Catra forced out a laugh that was surprisingly lighthearted. "Your priced pupil must be even dumber then", she said. "It was Adora's

idea. She left first. Guess your mind games didn't quite work out." She sounded a lot braver than she had anticipated. Her heart was beating so fast, it was hard to even form a coherent sentence.

"Silence!" Shadow Weaver certainly didn't like that. The shadows around her grew denser and closed in on her. "Leaving the Horde was your death sentence, Catra. Adora can't protect you anymore and when I get her back, it will be my pleasure to make sure she won't remember you!"

Catra tried her best to fight against the shadows, but whenever she sliced through them, more closed the gap again, meanwhile the circle she found herself in was getting smaller.

"Getting away from you was the best thing to happen to her. I will make sure she stays away", she told the sorceress while uselessly fighting against the shadows.

She tried to rack her brain for any information on Shadow Weaver's powers. They grew weaker with distance and the Kingdom of Snows was very far from the Fright Zone. But would it be weak enough to not inflict any damage? Catra had felt a touch earlier and as long as the sorceress could touch her, she could kill her.

But she surely won't go down fighting.

Catra kept slicing into the wall of shadows, hoping to create a way out, but to no avail. It closed too quickly and the smaller the circle got, the harder it got to breathe, though she couldn't tell if she truly lacked air or if her growing panic might be to blame.

Either way, it certainly didn't help keep a clear head because it felt like she was back in that suffocation machine of Hordak, which only added to her terror.

She was trapped. She couldn't move anymore.

"Catra!" A voice called from beyond the shadows, but it was too distorted to recognize. "For the honor of Grayskull!" It was Adora.

Then a bright light cut through the darkness and judging by the odd noise that Shadow Weaver made, it seemed to be hurting her.

Catra could breathe again, the light also let air in. It moved until it was right in front of her. The shadows didn't grow back into their circle, they were forced to keep their distance from She-Ra.

"Adora", the sorceress happily greeted the girl.

"Leave us alone!", the blonde entity responded harshly with no room for arguments.

"Oh, Adora", the old woman repeated, now even more loving. "Is that why you thought you had to leave? Because you're a princess? I was delighted to find out, I never would have turned you away."

"Of course not. Not when you can use me." Adora was unwavering. "Leave. I won't let you manipulate me anymore. I won't let you hurt my friends."

"Your friends don't care about you. Do you really think the princesses want you beyond your use to their war?", Shadow Weaver asked softly. "Come back home, child, and all will be right."

"I'm not talking about the princesses."

Oh… Catra realized that the blonde had meant her. Adora had called *her* a friend. Of course she hadn't thought it meant her. It shouldn't mean her.

Shadow Weaver shook her head. "You're still hung up on that wretched creature? I thought by now you would understand how worthless-"

"No", Adora interrupted, which surprised Catra even more. "She is not. She is smarter than me, more agile than me, more elegant than me. She is an excellent fighter and a great friend. And you know that or you wouldn't have tried to keep her small her entire

life! She is stubborn and brave and an asshole, and I wouldn't chose anyone else to be my best friend!"

Catra was already paralyzed. Now her brain came to a stop too, uselessly trying to make sense of this situation.

And then the girl looked back at her and smiled. "I know who to trust", she told her and then turned back to the shadow of a sorceress. "And it won't be you. I am never going back. And I would advise you to think wisely before you threaten or hurt anyone ever again."

Shadow Weaver scowled at them for a long insufferable moment. Then, without another word, but a gaze of endless disappointment, the shadows disappeared.

When they did, Catra startled to realize how close she was standing next to the other, thanks to the suffocating shadow circle, and stumbled backwards a bit.

Then the light disappeared too, leaving only Adora in its place. Something clattered to the ground and then she was suddenly held by two strong arms. "I'm so sorry. I should have gone after you right away, I thought you wanted to be alone. I'm sorry. Are you okay? Do you need healing?", the girl rambled, but held on tight.

And Catra didn't fight it for once. The steady breathing on her neck and the hug pressing down on her were very calming. She needed that.

When she regained a bit control over her body, she impulsively hugged the other back.

Adora, for some reason, held her even tighter in response, then lowered them to the ground, probably worried that Catra would collapse.

They sat like that for a while. It was only when Catra felt somewhat like herself again, that she pulled back.

"How are you feeling?", Adora asked carefully.

Catra only shrugged, not trusting her voice to be stable.

"She can't hurt us anymore. We'll look out for each other. Just like we always have", Adora said so softly, so honestly, that Catra broke down again with tears. The blonde held her again.

After that, shame stopped existing. "I don't know what's happening", she bawled. Pacing, crying, breaking down, it was not something she used to do, and while she had tried to brush it off, she really was losing it. She just didn't understand why.

"I've been there", Adora said. "Last time, she went for me in Mystacor. I was panicked and paranoid. Every time I saw a shadow move I pulled out my sword. I destroyed some ancient crystals."

"That's not it", she mumbled. Somehow she knew this was only barely related to Shadow Weaver. Sure, she was definitely part of the terror, but that never bothered her this much before.

She tried to think back to when this started. Back to the portal, Hordak, the Crimson Waste. The waste — Scorpia had said back then that she had never seen Catra that happy. And then … everything started to be a blur. There was a party and Adora and Shadow Weaver. All that had mattered was the portal.

That was it. Back then, she has had nothing and it had made her go to the extreme. And suddenly she had to adapt to having something again. She was paranoid and nervous and how could she not be? How does one come back from that extreme?

"I think I'm still processing", she mumbled eventually.

"The portal?", Adora asked as if reading her mind.

She nodded. "I… I made a lot of bad decisions", she said, staring at the ground. "I'm not sure how to move on. I feel restless." Why ever she was confiding in the blonde right now was beyond her.

Just like it had been with Sparkles, but she guessed that deep down she must want it somehow. This dreaded thing called connection.

"There are a lot of things I'm not proud of, too", Adora said, sadly. "And it's hard to leave them in the past, but… I think it's easier if you have people supporting you, helping you. You have so many people that want to do that. You just have to let them."

Catra sighed and got up from the floor. Her legs were a bit shaky, but otherwise she was fine. "We should head back inside", she then said.

Adora followed her into a standing position. "Are you sure? I can wait until you feel better", the other responded because of course she does.

"I'll be fine. And we still have a princess to win over", she pointed out.

She heard the other girl sigh and pick up her sword. With a bright light it turned back into the bracelet form. "You're right", she mumbled, so they went back to the ballroom together.

They were quickly bombarded by people asking if she was alright, all of which she brushed off, though not everyone believed her. The people she didn't know all that well, namely the other princesses, were easily accepting of her half-baked excuse that she had a bathroom emergency, but the people she had spent several weeks in close quarters with, all furrowed their brows in disbelief.

"We can talk about this later", she grumbled towards Sparkles, who seemed like she had wanted to say something. The princess still didn't look pleased, but decidedly nodded.

"I'm just glad you're okay", Scorpia said, looking on the verge of crying. "I was so worried."

Catra sighed. "I'm fine, really. It wasn't anything major."

"Okay, sure", Adora scoffed next to her, but also didn't appear very eager to tell the story.

"You've caused quite the scene", Arrow Boy then told them. "Even Frosta came over to ask about you."

"Did you use the time to try and convince her to join the Alliance?", Catra asked, trying to steer the topic away from herself.

"We tried", Adora said awkwardly. "It didn't go great. Even the other princesses tried to convince her, it was a whole group effort, but Frosta didn't seem impressed by anything we had to say."

"It was so frustrating. Actually it was probably for the best that you weren't there", Sparkles told her.

"Yeah, the name Frosta is very fitting", Scorpia added and shivered for effect. "She was so cold the entire time, even the sea princess had more facial expressions."

Catra sighed. Remembering the last Princess Prom, she did get to know Frosta as a very cold and serious person, though seeing her in battle, she knew there was a different side of her, one she just had to access. "I'll handle it", she said and walked over to the girl, who was currently yelling at a server.

"The snow peas and the cookies are touching. Do it right", she heard the princess say and then watched the server walk away quickly.

"Princess Frosta", Catra called out and gained the young one's attention.

"I see you are back. Doing better I hope? I wish for all to enjoy the ball", the girl told her and Catra nodded.

"Thank you for your concern, I have heard that you asked about my well being. An honor, really", she tried not to overdo it, but she had to make a good impression if anything was going to work.

"Yes, it is my duty as hostess", Frosta answered. "I expect you're not only here to thank me. Are you also going to ask me to join your rebellion?" She was smart, that was for sure. "I will tell you what I told your fellow rebels. The Horde hasn't threatened us here. The Kingdom of Snows has defended itself perfectly well for thousands of years. We do not need help."

Catra smiled. "You have no idea how well I understand that", she said because she did. She hated asking for help. "But you are incorrect. The Horde only ignores your kingdom for so long. Other kingdoms like Salineas or Brightmoon are their priority. They are already protecting you." She saw the girl open her mouth, but she wasn't done yet. "And", she added, interrupting whatever the princess had to say. "I can tell you that if the Horde wasn't so focused on the Whispering Woods, there would be nothing stopping them from attacking you."

Frosta frowned at her. "I have been informed about you and the other two that have defected from the Horde. Why should I trust you?"

"Do you think I'm trying to recruit you for the rebellion because that somehow helps the Horde?", she asked and failed not to laugh. "You are powerful, joining the rebellion would be the Horde's end. But if you don't… I know what they are planning and what they are capable of. You won't stand a chance." That was highly exaggerated. Without Catra and Entrapta there, they were mediocre at best, but even that had been enough to beat the rebellion before Adora had joined.

"If you're idea of recruitment is a threat, I suggest you leave and join the dancing. It's time for the announcement", the princess declared, but Catra stepped in her way.

"I'm not threatening you, trust me, that would look very different. You have been far from the frontlines your whole life. I am merely offering you a realistic perspective of war", she said.

"My parents fought with the Alliance and it did nothing for our kingdom. Or anyone else. Why should it be any different now?", Frosta asked, a clear sign that she was not all against it anymore, despite the highly defensive attitude.

"It will be different because you are not your parents. None of the princesses are", Catra answered easily. "We're better. And as much as I hate to admit it, we are close. A real team, not just a collection of people trying to work together. Friends"

That made Frosta's eyes light up a little, and her body language changed to something more open. It reminded Catra that the princess and ruler of this kingdom was really just a little kid. She wasn't entirely sure how to feel about that. Maybe this has been a mistake, maybe she shouldn't try to convince a child, no matter how powerful, to fight in a war.

"Okay", was the surprising answer. "But if I don't like it, I'll leave."

"You can do that if you don't feel welcome", Catra answered easily. "There's no pressure, everyone can just leave, but in the end we all just want to save the planet."

"Right", the girl mumbled with a solemn nod. "Good. If you'll excuse me." Frosta walked off towards her throne.

She would admit, she might have lied there. Just a little bit, but Frosta would most likely never know that Catra couldn't care less about any of the stuff she just mentioned. The others did and that would be enough.

After a second of feeling proud before remembering that manipulating a little kid was maybe not really an accomplishment, she rejoined the group of princesses and others that have all found each other again at this point. Even the net and wind princess were there now.

"And, how did it go?" Scorpia was by her side immediately.

Catra took a deliberate step away from the other — they really had to have that talk about personal space again, not that it did much good last time. "She joined", she told them shortly and everyone cheered.

"But?" Adora knew her too well.

"No buts, I was very persuasive", she said with a shrug. "Shadow Weaver had to be good for something."

The blonde winced and Catra wasn't sure if it was because of the implication or their very recent encounter with the sorceress.

"Wait, do you mean, you lied to her?", Sparkles asked, slightly shocked.

And Catra felt slightly offended. "No", she said firmly. "I may have exaggerated a bit, maybe appealed to what she wants, but I didn't outright lie." Not much anyway.

There was a scoff coming from the sea princess. "Isn't exaggerating pretty much like lying?"

She cannot say she was very proud of the fact that she knew how to … *convince* people, but she still didn't like it if other people looked down on her for it. "She's on our side, we got what we wanted", she growled.

"Okay, let's all calm down", Adora went in-between them. "Now that the Princess Alliance has been restored we should hold a meeting soon. Under no circumstances should we fight. That way, we surely lose. Catra got us Frosta, we should be happy about that", she told them.

Sparkles sighed. "I wasn't trying to accuse you", she mumbled and then stood in front of Catra. "I believe you and… if a little bit of stretching the truth is what it takes to have Frosta on our side, then that's that. No big deal."

Catra was willing to leave it at that, even if she wasn't sure how the other princesses would behave around her going forward and she felt the need to run bubble back up inside her.

But her chance passed when the background music stopped and a harsh light landed on Frosta who was standing up high above them. "It is my solemn duty as hostess to now announce, it is time for the first dance of the Ball."

Music cut back in, the cue for a slow dance done between several people. Everyone was required to participate, unless one had good reason not to, but since Catra was healthy and not missing any legs and couldn't exactly leave without causing another scene, she made her way to the dance floor with the others.

Technically, it would be the better etiquette to stick with her plus one, but since the first dance was done between several people anyway, and she did not feel like having another heart to heart with Adora, she cut in front of Arrow Boy, send him a barely sympathetic smile and started with Sparkles.

"Are you still avoiding Adora?", the princess asked as they took the first steps.

"Have you talked to Arrow Boy yet?", Catra shot back.

Then they stared each other down a little bit before Sparkles sighed, giving up. "I'm really sorry about how I reacted just now", she changed the topic to a similarly uncomfortable one. "You are smart and know what you're doing."

She sighed. "It's not a big deal. I get it, it's dubious. But she's stubborn and I didn't really see another way.", she told the other.

"I get that", the princess assured her. "And I'm happy you got her on our side." Then she had to spin towards the next person.

"How are you feeling?", Adora asked immediately when they came face to face.

Catra rolled her eyes. So much for trying to avoid her. "If this is about the Shadow Weaver incident, I don't wanna talk about it", she grumbled.

"I'm just worried about you", the other said, sadness all over her face. "I don't know what she said, but I cannot imagine it was anything good."

"I'll survive, always have", she told the girl and then evaded her reaction by being swapped with the next person. She was less than thrilled to see the flower princess approach. "Are you enjoying the party?", she asked to avoid any questions or uncomfortable topics.

"Yes, I am very much enjoying getting to know the rebellion. They're all so nice", the princess told her happily. "I believe that if we stand united, we can save our beautiful planet."

"Now that the Alliance is completely rebuild, that won't be hard", she answered politely, not sure what else to say.

"And now that you from the Horde have joined us", the princess added with a smile. "I have to say that letting you go was a huge loss for the Horde. But a tremendous win for the rebellion."

"Oh, uh, thanks", she mumbled awkwardly. Before she could say more, they had to switch their partners back.

Adora smirked at her. "Why so red?"

"Shut up", Catra growled, making the other laugh.

"Did Perfuma say something positive?", she asked, though it sounded a lot less mockingly. "I know it's a bit weird at first, but you'll get used to it", she added softly.

She didn't answer, only let herself go through the motions and hoped that the girl wouldn't start a new topic. To her relief, they stayed silent and soon she was spun back to the beginning.

Sparkles at least seemed to be over the earlier topic. "You and Adora actually manage to dance, I'm impressed", she told her sarcastically.

"We did train a lot." Catra hasn't even noticed how much easier it went compared to their lessons.

The princess snorted. "Yes, and you looked like you expected the other's touch to poison you", she mumbled. "Don't tell me whatever happened earlier miraculously fixed you?"

"No", she replied because it was true. Then she felt heat rise to her face. "We just… had a little moment."

Sparkles smirked infuriatingly. "A moment, huh?"

"We talked a bit. Maybe it helped ease some of the tension", she grumbled and hoped the music would stop soon, so she could be done with this.

"Well, I hope so because next dance, you won't be able to avoid her anymore", the princess told her and Catra realized that she was right.

She might have gotten away with not picking Adora as partner for the first dance, but the second would require her to dance with her plus one.

And just as she thought that maybe dealing with Sparkles for a few more seconds wouldn't be too bad, the music stopped already.

"Have fun!", the other girl cheered and left her alone to find Arrow Boy.

Catra took a deep breath and turned around to find Adora already staring at her. She mustered up a smirk and held out a hand.

The blonde rolled her eyes, but took it. They took their position just as the music set back in, and Catra was honestly a bit

surprised that she didn't have to fight Adora for the leading part. Maybe because they were used to it after all the training.

"I don't know about you, but I have a feeling we've been here before", she then said because she had to pass the time somehow. At least they actually managed to move somewhat smooth instead of being as stiff as their lessons had led her to expect.

Adora scoffed, but smiled. "I wonder why", she replied. Then her expression became more thoughtful and Catra really hoped she wouldn't bring the incident back up. "How do you think things will change now?", she asked, seemingly intend to use their limited privacy for a rather complicated discussion — at least it wasn't about Catra's emotional state.

But how was she supposed to know that? "I think… that the Horde was only quiet for so long because Shadow Weaver was too busy watching you", she said eventually. It wasn't really an answer, but it appeared to be enough.

"Do you think she knew?", the blonde asked with a worried look on her face.

"It seemed so", Catra mumbled. The witch had said that she had been 'delighted to find out' — it certainly didn't sound like Adora's identity as She-Ra was a new information to her.

Adora furrowed her brow in confusion. "But how? I thought we made sure that she wouldn't figure it out."

That was true. They did try to avoid any spying from the witch, but Catra had always known that they would never be able to avoid her forever. But this was a bit too early for her liking. Maybe they overlooked something.

"Scorpia", she realized.

The blonde shot a quick look towards the woman in question and then stared back at Catra, clearly trying to understand what she

was referring to.

She rolled her eyes. "Shadow Weaver might not have spotted you in Plumeria, but Scorpia was also there. And where there is one deserter, there will be the others. I'd guess that she spied on Scorpia to find you", she elaborated. They had only considered She-Ra and not the other members of the group.

Adora seemed to mull it over and reached the same conclusion. "Then she must have seen me transform in Salineas."

There was something else bothering her, though. "The better question is why she waited so long to terrorize us", she pointed out. After all, it had been weeks since their last mission.

The other shrugged. "I don't know", she mumbled, then an idea must have come to her. "Oh, wait… I think… there was something about the moonstone. Maybe Glimmer knows how it works."

Catra hummed noncommittally, her mind already a few steps farther.

Leaving alone all the things that she didn't know right now, what she did know was that the Horde mostly only operated at all because whoever was second in command organized everything. Which also meant that, so far, Shadow Weaver must have been too busy with her spying to give orders, but now? Knowing the witch, she would make sure they would be busy for a while.

"We're supposed to have fun", the blonde interrupted her thoughts with a smirk.

"A party in the middle of a war is a stupid idea if you ask me, and not really fun either", she replied. "I mean, every major threat to the Horde in one place. What could go wrong?"

Of course they both knew the answer — they had both lived it. It was probably only thanks to a lack of a princess in the Horde, and Shadow Weaver's obsession that they were safe.

Being reminded of past events seemed to worry Adora about the present though, because her eyes suddenly started to search the room. "You don't think, she'll do something else?", she asked, sounding slightly panicked.

"I don't know", Catra had to admit. "My guess is that she just wanted to mess with us, but I can't know for sure."

The other nodded thoughtfully, but didn't add anything. She did get back to focusing on the dance instead of their surroundings, though, which probably meant that Catra's theory had been enough to calm her, which would be weird. Despite the earlier words to Shadow Weaver, there was no way the girl really trusted her.

They have barely been able to hold a friendly conversation since they were thrown back into the past, and while they were at least not fighting as much anymore, it was still awkward, they were still not friends. And Catra wondered if they would ever be actual friends again.

Luckily, she wasn't left with that thought for too long because she caught Entrapta walking around the edge of the dance floor, babbling into her recorder, and she remembered that she had promised the woman to meet up with her.

When, finally, the music stopped again and she had officially done her duty of dancing twice, she quickly took her chance to get away. She saw many couples around her, including the net and wind princess, prepare for the next dance, but Catra was out of here.

"Well, as nice as it was, I'll go enjoy the party somewhere else now", she told Adora and walked off. Maybe she kind of ran away, but she didn't care. She needed to talk to someone less complicated.

Entrapta was back up on the balcony, so Catra went up there, too. For a moment, she debated climbing, but that would probably be

rude, so she took the stairs like a normal person. As she overlooked the scene, she spotted Scorpia with the group princesses at the buffet, while Adora hung out with Sparkles and Arrow Boy.

"Catra!", Entrapta called out and waved. "You're here!" She sounded surprised.

"I said I would check on you later", she reminded the princess, who turned back to look down on everyone.

"People say a lot of things they don't mean", the scientist pointed out.

Catra knew she was guilty of that as well. "I know", she said. "I'm trying to work on that", she told the other truthfully.

Entrapta now stared at her with a wide smile. "Oooooh, character development! That could be such a fascinating experiment", she squealed, but Catra took a step back.

"No", she shut the idea down immediately. "I only accept one experiment per lifetime and you already chose yours."

"Naww." The princess pouted.

"Why were you not dancing? Isn't everyone required to?", she changed the topic.

"I'm here for science, not dancing", the other pointed out before she pulled out her recorder. "Groups are breaking again, though some have preferred partners. Pre-made emotional attachment appears to be important."

"I'm not sure Frosta will like that", she responded, ignoring the observation part.

The princess just shrugged, she didn't care. Catra remembered why she thought Entrapta would be fitting into the Horde so well.

"Can I ask you something? Because I'm confused", the scientist then asked.

"Sure, what is it?", Catra answered, leaning herself against the banister.

"I don't fully understand the social dynamics of your group, specifically", the woman told her and pulled out a pad from somewhere and looked at some chart she must have made over the course of the night. "The sea princess and the pirate are here together, but she seems to hate him. Why did she invite him? And the pink one and Bow are just as confusing — do they have a romantic attachment or not? They seem tense. But then, so do you and the blonde one, so maybe that's normal, but-"

"Hold on", she interrupted there as she tried to process everything that just came out of the others mouth. Really, she had wanted to clear some things up before it became too much to remember, but she got hung up on one thing in particular. "What do Adora and I have to do with Sparkles' relationship?"

Entrapta blinked at her. "Well, you are my reference point", she said like it was the most natural thing in the world.

"For what?" She needed an explanation.

"Relationships, of course", the woman told her and shrugged, looking back at her pad. "The net and wind one are a too established couple to use as reference for the non-committed princesses, so naturally I used you."

"Wait", she had to interrupt again. "Adora and I are not together", she then clarified.

"You're not?" The princess was shocked, to say the least. "But…" She scrolled some more through her notes. "No, the data is very clear about romantic tension."

Catra had to take a deep breath to avoid causing a scene. "There is tension, yes, but it's certainly not romantic! We're not- We've

been friends, then we were not, and now … we're trying. It's awkward, that's it." There was a lot more to it than that, but the short version should be good enough for now.

The scientist looked at her in disbelief. Then her data, back at her, back at the pad. "That can't be right", was the conclusion she eventually reached as she scratched her head. "You've been very intimate."

"When?", she demanded proof.

"Well, you're her plus one. She was also the one to call and look after you when you ran out earlier. She defended you when you had that disagreement with the princesses shortly after. She keeps looking at you, and you keep looking at her. And just now when you danced you were very close. Your body languages revealed comfort — a lot more than you had with the pink one." Entrapta paused shortly. "I have more."

"No thanks", she mumbled quickly. She didn't really know what to think of this, but she did know that she and Adora were not a couple. "Look, we grew up together, of course I'm closer to her than I am to people I met a few weeks ago, even when we aren't really friends anymore."

"Interesting." The scientist nodded. "I don't understand."

Catra sighed. "I might be close to Adora because I'm used to it, but that doesn't mean we're together", she tried again. "Just like Mermista takes Sea Hawk as a plus one because she likes him and pretends he's just her ride. Sometimes, things look one way on the outside, but are different on the inside."

Entrapta seemed to think about it. "What about the parallels with the pink one and Bow?", she then asked.

"I don't know. They claim they're not together. They are a bit tense today, though, because Sparkles thinks he'll leave her", she said.

"How can he leave her if they're not together?"

"Friends can leave you too", she answered and tried to make it sound the least condescending as possible.

The princess hummed and made a note on her pad, then took her recorder. "Catra has cleared up some inconsistencies, but I'm still not sure I quite understand. Some of the data just doesn't add up. I will have to prolong the experiment a few days to gather more data while I'm in Brightmoon."

"Wait what?"

"Oh, you said it would be okay to come visit. I ran some calculations and figured that our gathering today would be the most convenient time to join you. I am all packed", the scientist explained.

Somehow Catra was not surprised. "I'll go tell the others, so that they're not confused, but for the future, try to give us a warning ahead of time."

"I thought our agreement was notice", the other said, cocking her head.

"I knew you were coming, but not when. I'm not even sure they have a room for you", Catra tried to explain.

"Oh… I'll try to be more specific next time and don't worry about a room, I'm all prepared to make my own accommodations", Entrapta told her. "Your friends are by the buffet, have fun!"

"You too", she mumbled and went back downstairs.

Thanks to Entrapta she found the others easily. They were conversing, getting to know each other some more and having fun. Is that what they have been doing last time too? Had Catra been just to focused on winning to see it? And speaking of winning, now that all the princesses agreed to fight, they would have to find a way to win the war, especially since the Horde was

bound to make a move now that Shadow Weaver could focus on that again.

Maybe she should talk to Adora about that sometime soon, figure out what they wanted to happen or not happen — but not today.

"Catra, there you are", the girl in question spotted her quickly. "You disappeared so quickly...", she mumbled sadly.

"I was with Entrapta", she supplied before the blonde had a heart attack. And because the scientist's observations were still stuck in her head, she went over to Sparkles without another word. "So, possibly slight problem", she started and the princess groaned.

"What now?", she asked.

"Remember when we all had our missions and I said that Entrapta was coming to visit soon? Well, soon is today. She is packed and prepared to leave for Brightmoon with us", she told them.

"You're kidding", Sparkles said hopefully.

"No."

"But… we can't just- We don't even have rooms", she stumbled over her words.

"She said she is prepared to make her own accommodations, whatever that means. And I've seen where she lives, I'm pretty sure she'd be fine with the floor somewhere", she tried to calm the other down before remembering something. "And besides all of that, I am not currently living in the room prepared for me, so she can have that."

"Fine, if that's okay with you", Sparkles said. "A bit of a warning would have been nice, though", she grumbled.

"Already told her", Catra responded. "So, what's the plan anyway. How long do we stay?"

"We were actually thinking about leaving", Arrow Boy told her. "We've been here for hours, we did all the things we needed to and honestly? I'm starting to freeze."

"A proper shirt might do the trick", she mumbled, but by his flabbergasted expression she guessed that he has heard her anyway.

He didn't say anything though, and didn't seem really mad either.

Despite them saying they wanted to leave, they stayed for another hour or so. Mostly they got stuck when they tried to say goodbye to Sea Hawk who seemed to make it his mission to not let them leave. Somehow they managed to keep making their rounds, saying goodbye to a bunch of people that Catra still only knew from battle, since she hadn't really talked to any of them.

Entrapta found them easily and joined them at the exit. The scientist got all her stuff back at the check-out and then they were off.

With the chatty princess here, who told everyone about the great discoveries she had made, calling it the best social experiment she had ever been to, it was a lot less silent than the way here.

When they finally made it back to Brightmoon it was late enough that even the guards were dozing off and Catra was exhausted enough that she left the group immediately upon entry into the castle.

Back in her greenhouse, she fell on the mattress she had. She was exhausted but afraid to sleep, especially after she had seen Shadow Weaver today.

Every time her eyes fell shut for a second, she saw her, but specifically she saw the day of the portal. The sorceress hadn't held back her hate against her in the slightest. If Sparkles hadn't passed out then, Catra would be dead.

Or maybe not, who knew. In all honestly, she could recall a few moments in which she should have died and somehow didn't. Those were too many coincidences to be realistic — it was weird that she was still around. Maybe she should check out the library again soon, maybe they would have a book on her species that could explain this.

But not today. Catra was way too tired and she knew she couldn't put off rest much longer, but how was she supposed to sleep like this?

Her body demanded it, especially after a long day like this and several days going without it. But sleeping would result in nightmares.

Unless…

When she had slept in Sparkle's room she didn't have any for once. Though the princess wasn't an option today. Not after all she told her about the elaborate routine she and Arrow Boy always did when partying. But, she doubted Adora would mind some company.

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"I know it's late, but ice cream?", Glimmer asked the group when they had made it back to Brightmoon, and despite her obvious tiredness, she was still high on energy.

"Of course, it's tradition", Bow responded, equally excited.

Adora laughed. She would really love to join them, but she could barely keep her eyes open anymore. "We've been together constantly for weeks, you should use the alone time", she offered, instinctively not revealing her own needs.

Bow gave her a look. "Sure, Adora, go to bed", he told her softly. He knew the real reason — of course he did. "Scorpia, Catra, Entrapta, do you- wait, where's Catra?"

The girl had vanished again.

"She went that way", Entrapta supplied, pointing down the hall without looking up from whatever data she had gathered at the Prom. "I'll say no to the ice cream, too. Is there some unused space I could inhabit?"

"Yeah, Catra offered up her room", Glimmer mumbled. "One sec." Then she turned to Adora. "Should we be worried about Catra?", she asked.

"I don't know. She's probably just tired", Adora guessed. She was worried, too, though. Leaving the girl alone, when Shadow Weaver clearly had it out for her, was not something she was comfortable with. Speaking of. "Uh, quick question. The moonstone, what exactly does it do in terms of protecting Brightmoon?"

Glimmer gave her a suspicious look. "What exactly happened?", she then asked. "What does Catra need protection from? Is it this Shadow Weaver person?"

"What about Shadow Weaver?", Scorpia now asked too.

Adora sighed. "Shadow Weaver has been looking for us and now she found us. She kinda attacked Catra with her … weird shadow magic", she explained shortly.

Glimmer sighed. "Well, my mom always says that our runestone keeps the darkness away", she mumbled, seemingly unsure of how helpful that was, but Adora let out a sigh of relief.

"Thank you, that should do it", she said. "I'll go to bed now. Maybe check on Catra real quick and tell her she doesn't have to worry. Bye." She was off in an instant, hearing vague protests from her friends and some mumbling from Entrapta.

When she got to the greenhouse, no one was there. Nothing was there and she felt panic rise inside her. She called for Catra a few times, but without any reaction. Eventually she turned back inside. Maybe the girl wanted to be alone, and Adora wouldn't bother her, but it was weird that all her stuff was gone too.

She opened the door to her room and stood still in shock. And relief.

"Hey Adora", Catra said while wresting a lot of bobby pins out of her hair.

"Catra", Adora muttered, frozen in both her body and mind it seemed. "You're inside."

The girl snorted. "You have functioning eyes. Congratulations", she responded sarcastically.

At least it snapped her out of it a little. "What I mean is … are you going to stay inside?", she asked, possibly with a bit too much underlying hope.

"It's cold out", the other mumbled, releasing the last pin from the thick of her hair, placing it next to the others and… the files. Now she also noticed the mattress under the window.

"Right, of course", she responded with a bit of sarcasm of her own. Catra was so full of bullshit — after spending the entire day in the Kingdom of Snows, it felt like summer outside. And even if it wouldn't, one cold night does not explain why she brought all her stuff with her too.

Catra was intend on ignoring her, though and just went over to the mattress — however she had gotten that thing in here. Adora would let her, considering the day they have had.

The girl then started to change out of her suit, and she did the same, though she kept glancing over. Catra used her Horde underwear to sleep, which made her smile because she did too.

But more important were the scars, some of which she had seen the other girl get.

Catra's accusation from the Crystal Castle came back to her.

"You have never protected me! Not in any way that would put you on Shadow Weaver's bad side!"

Adora hadn't wanted to hear it back then, but Catra was right. Today might have been the first time that she didn't just plead with the sorceress, but actually put her foot down. And even that couldn't protect her friend since she had arrived a bit late.

When they were both done changing, she sat on her bed and still looked at the other. "Glimmer said that the moonstone keeps the darkness away", she told the other then. "We're not entirely sure what that means, but I think it could mean that her magic cannot reach us here."

"Yeah, I figured", the girl responded. "Back then, she knew you were in Brightmoon, but couldn't spy on you here. And when we hacked the Black Garnet, something about the moonstone kept the effects away."

"Right, that makes sense", Adora mumbled and stared the other's silhouette for a moment, unsure whether she should just be quiet now, but she decided to ask anyway. "Do you want to talk about it?" She meant everything. Today, their childhood, the last months, the portal, the nightmares — she would take whatever glimpse into her life that Catra would give her.

"Goodnight, Adora", was her response.

"Night Catra", she answered, though she still stared at the other's back for a while. She really wished that things would stop being this awkward. It was hard to imagine, but over a decade of friendship was really that easily destroyed by just a few months.

But this was a step forward, she thought. Even if Catra wasn't ready to have a proper talk yet, she at least had extended some

trust by deciding to move in here.

It made her happy. It meant that the other actually wanted to be friends again, and it meant that Adora had to get it together because her jealousy was entirely unfounded.

This wasn't perfect, and they might never get back what they used to have, but as long as she would have the girl in her life, Adora thought she could be … content at least.

And so, she was able to fall asleep with a smile for the first time in months.

Chapter End Notes

> Now that our girl has her favorite emotional support goddess back, she'll be a lot more stable going forward <333
>
> I hope you enjoyed the chapter! Next time we'll get to fulfill a promise and set up some things for the future. Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 14: Calm

Chapter Notes

I learned a lot about cats while writing this xD

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had no clue where she was. Looking around, she felt like this place was familiar and yet she couldn't remember why.

"Hello?", she called out, tough she sounded hollow, like she wasn't all there.

"Adora", a voice rang in her head and suddenly it all made sense.

Well, almost all because she was pretty sure that she had just been in Brightmoon with Catra and definitely not on her way to see Light Hope. What's going on? There was no way she was really in the Crystal Castle, right? She hadn't wanted to be here and she never would have come here.

Then the old hologram finally appeared in front of her in all her glory. "My name is Light Hope. I have been waiting a long time for you. I had reached out to you when you forged your connection with the sword", the woman said.

"Yes, I remember", Adora mumbled and rolled her eyes.

The other looked confused for a short second. "I had hoped you would come to talk to me. She-Ra must restore Etheria's balance."

"I've been a bit busy, you know? I mean, we're at war, in case you didn't know." Adora might be a bit flippant, but after their last talk, it was hard to ignore the frustrations that came up whenever she thought about the hologram.

Light Hope furrowed her brows ever so slightly. "I am aware, but nothing is as important as your purpose as She-Ra."

She groaned — she really couldn't hear it anymore. "Yes, yes, I know. Purpose, destiny, no choice, but again, we are at war. I'm very busy, so…" She turned around, trying to leave wherever she was, though it was clearly not real.

"Adora. Balance must be restored."

"I'm currently trying to restore something more important. If you would excuse me." How is she supposed to get out of here?

"Adora. You should not take this lightly", Light Hope warned and was suddenly in front of her, startling her, but also making her angry — she just wanted to get back to her room.

"Leave me alone!" This time she heard her voice more clearly and when she opened her eyes she noticed that she was back in Brightmoon.

She took a deep breath and stared at the ceiling for a minute.

Light Hope could plague her dreams, which she had already done the first time around after Adora had hit her head in the Whispering Woods, but before she had actually found the sword. She had kind of hoped that it wouldn't happen again — it was incredibly disturbing — but it seemed she had no such luck.

After a few minutes, she sat up, not feeling very eager to return to the dreamworld.

It was still dark outside. What was she supposed to do the entire rest of the night if sleep wasn't an option? She looked over to the other person in the room and wondered how she did it.

But she wouldn't ask her — for one did she not want to wake her, and she also didn't think she would actually get answer.

So, Adora silently tried to move to the window just to have something to look at and was heavily startled when Catra sat up suddenly. "No need to be sneaky", the girl said groggily.

"I wasn't trying to be sneaky", she defended weakly. "I just didn't want to wake you."

Catra sighed. "I wasn't sleeping."

Adora carefully sat down next to her. "Shadow Weaver?", she asked despite knowing that the other probably still didn't want to talk about it.

And for a moment, it didn't look like she would.

"It's not always her", Catra then said so quietly, that she almost didn't hear it over the noise of the waterfall. "It's her and Entrapta, and Hordak. And you. Sometimes."

Adora felt terrible. She never wanted to be the reason for Catra's nightmares. She was supposed to protect her from them. "I should have been there for you."

"I didn't want you to", the other said with a shrug.

"What about now?", Adora decided to ask. She was a bit scared of the answer, if she would even get one. They were still only at the start of rebuilding something, but there was hope.

Catra pulled her knees tight to her chest and avoided eye contact. "On our first night here, you said you wanted to forgive me", she then mumbled. Adora remembered. "Do you think you can?"

She took a moment to think, not about her ability to forgive Catra, which she had never questioned, but the state of their relationship. It has been just a few weeks compared to months of hurt, and things were still awkward and part of her was still mad about some things, but lately the girl was actually trying. And, Adora reminded herself, she had suffered too.

It wasn't hard to understand at least some of Catra's thought process. Throughout their time apart, Catra had simply acted on what she knew and felt. It didn't excuse her behavior fully, but Adora couldn't stand seeing the girl so broken. Truth be told, if the

roles had been reversed… Adora didn't know if she should judge the feline so hard.

"I think I already have", she answered then and the other looked at her again. "I know you're a good person. And that I hurt you. I cannot say for sure I would have acted differently if I had been in your place. I was angry with you, yes, but … I don't think it would be fair to blame you for everything. And now you do make better choices."

It was quiet a long time after that. "Adora?", the other then called out.

"Yeah?"

"I think… I know it's not the good-guy thing to do, but I think I really wanna see that old witch dead", she mumbled, surprising her a little.

Still, she understood. "I don't think killing her is the way to go, but I won't stand in your way."

"Really?" Catra sounded a bit amused, but mostly surprised.

Adora sighed. "I always tried to do the right thing and I hurt so many people in the process. I trusted the wrong people and blindly followed them to get answers. I don't know anymore if good and evil is that easy", she said. "I know this war is wrong. I know that I can't trust Light Hope or Shadow Weaver. And I know that I want you to be my friend. Everything else? We'll figure it out."

"Promise?"

Her hand found Catra's despite the dark. "I promise. We'll stick together this time and keep each other safe."

She expected the other to free her hand, just as she did last time, but she didn't. They stayed like this until they both started to doze off. Old habits died hard, it turns out, and they somehow found

themselves cuddling. Neither of them woke up screaming. And neither of them acknowledged it in the morning.

Still, Adora thought it must have helped because Catra was a lot more willing to talk to her and finally treat her as friendly as she did everyone else.

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Spending a day with Entrapta proved to be just as infuriating as she had imagined.

The woman had come prepared, with several materials in different thickness to test what she could cut through — wherever she had gotten all of these samples from, Catra didn't even want to know. On top of that, she had to extend and retract her claw a dozen times and her hands started to cramp.

"Does it hurt?", the scientist asked.

"No, why would it?", she asked back, sending a glare to everyone else.

When Entrapta had announced exactly why she was visiting this morning at breakfast, everyone had been immediately interested. Well, except Adora, who had decided that she had seen enough of Catra's claws up close and went to check on the horse.

The rest of the group was sitting in a half-circle around the area the princess had chosen and Catra felt even more uncomfortable than she had before.

"Well, sharp material is getting pushed in and out of very soft flesh. It would be logical for you to sustain internal injuries, but you don't. Fascinating", Entrapta babbled and wrote something down. "Can you do it slower?"

"I don't think so", she mumbled.

"Do it again, then", the scientist demanded, so Catra extended her claws. Again. "The extended nails have to be stored somewhere within the flesh. Also, there have to be muscles in place, unusual for most people, to make them move in and out", the woman babbled into her recorder.

Purple hair pressed down on her fingers and while she let out a low growl, she resisted the urge to pull her hand away.

"Instinctive reaction to touch is hostile", Entrapta kept talking. "Pressure points indicate that Catra's fingers indeed hold more muscles than the average person, though I would have to perform a scan to be sure." She looked up to Catra, then back to her notes. "Scan is not advised."

She had no idea what face she had been making, but it must have been scary enough to deter the scientist.

"Do they work the same on your feet?", she then asked, laying herself on the ground to take a closer look at Catra's toes.

"Yes, they do", she grumbled, really trying to keep it together. She had promised her, after all, that if the woman joined the rebellion she could experiment on her. But she didn't have to like it.

"Interesting", Entrapta mumbled to herself before quickly getting up again. "How is control? Have you ever had any accidents?"

Catra allowed herself to think about that. Sure, she's hurt several people throughout her childhood with her claws, but none of these incidents were really accidental. Neither had she ever hurt herself on accident. "Not that I know of", she answered eventually.

"So, you've always been in full control of them?", the woman asked.

"I knew they hurt, I knew they were weapons. I had to learn what their limits are, but yeah I guess it's rather instinctual", she said with a shrug.

"Fascinating", Entrapta mumbled again, writing more into her pad.

While they waited for her to be done, Catra looked around at her audience of Sparkles, Arrow Boy, Scorpia, as well as Netossa and Spinnerella, who surely should have something better to do. Then the doors opened and a small group of people came into the gardens — the other princesses and the queen.

"Uh, what's going on here?", the sea princess asked.

"A scientific experiment!", Entrapta exclaimed and cackled like the madwoman she was.

"She's testing on Catra's claws", Scorpia provided a bit more context.

"Really? I wanna see!" Frosta ran to the front and sat down a bit too close for comfort, but Catra didn't say anything. Push comes to shove, she could take a few more steps back before demolishing Entrapta's samples.

"What are you all doing here?", Sparkles then asked, looking very confused while she tried to be polite.

"Now that the Alliance is successfully rebuild, I have called them to a meeting to discuss how to proceed. Thaymor is steadily rebuilding and I thought the sooner the better", the queen explained. "Though I will allow you to finish your… experiment."

Somehow Catra expected the queen to leave again and do whatever queens did the entire day, but the woman stayed. Stiff behind the rows of princesses, Bow and Sea Hawk, but she stayed.

She sighed. "What now?"

"Well, we put them to the test!", Entrapta called out and maneuvered around her with ease. "I saw you cut through my robots, so I already threw out anything softer than the metal I use for them. I brought three of each and I want you to apply the least amount of pressure on one, cut through it with all force and then what you would do during training."

"In the Horde?", she asked for clarification.

The woman nodded. "You said there were never any accidents, and your … *friend*, the blonde one, doesn't seem particularly injured or fearful of your claws, so I theorize you must have been holding back."

Catra wasn't about to tell the woman about the paradox of that theory — Adora had been the one who had been the most injured by her claws and should have every reason to be afraid, but somehow wasn't — and just shrugged, simply doing as she was told. She had never really tested just how much her claws could withstand, so this was actually quite interesting for her as well.

She cut through it all with more or less ease, but she cut through. Different types of metal, rocks, glass, some things that had a too complicated name for her to remember, but Entrapta assured her that they were some of the hardest materials to find on the planet.

After each set of three, she was asked what it felt like for her. Most common materials weren't nice to cut through — the glass, for example, felt absolutely revolting — but were easy. Some of the rarer and harder materials met her with some resistance.

When all was done, Entrapta was close to her face again. "Any hurt? Any cracks or damage?", she asked, her hair getting a hold of her hands again. "Wow, they seem to be even sharper than before", she then mumbled, pulling out her recorder again. "It seems that cutting things occasionally helps the claws to stay sharp and functional. Did you know you had to do that? Do you usually file them manually?"

"I knew that, yes", she said. "But it's hard to find things to destroy without anyone getting mad, so yeah, I file them."

"Interesting. Now the same thing for your feet please!"

Entrapta pulled out another set of three per material. The angle was a bit awkward, having to kick sideways, but it worked.

Afterwards, the woman was staring at her feet again, then compared all the cuts in the samples. "This is fascinating!", she then yelled. "Okay, so, while all of your claws are very sharp, your feet show a lot less impact. It might be due to factors like the angle or your care of them, but they might be just naturally weaker. It's interesting."

Catra came a little closer to look at the materials a bit. Entrapta was right. With her fingers she cut through each and every sample, so that she could see the other side through the scratches she had left — even if some holes were wider than others. But her feet haven't made it all the way through on most materials, and it had felt a lot harder to cut something.

"Other interesting things", the scientist kept going. "Even with minimal force, there's a clear indent in every material. Especially fascinating, though, is the difference between your full force and what you did in training."

Catra moved to the samples in question. The difference was quite striking. She had never had a way of testing what her full strength could do — maybe this experiment was less of a waste of time than she had thought.

"While full force left several deep holes, leaving you to be able to look to the other side, your training force barely went further than the least force. There's a bit more depth to the cuts, but a far cry from full force."

"I'm really glad you're on our team, Catra", Arrow Boy laughed a bit awkwardly. He looked a bit scared.

"Why did you hold back, though?", Sparkles asked then. "I imagined the Horde would like to have someone who can inflict damage."

She shrugged. "Maybe, but they wouldn't have liked it if I made amputees out of my entire squad. They were already mad when I ripped out Octavia's eye and it's not like it impacts her all that much."

The girl stared at her for a few seconds with an open mouth. "Fair enough", she then mumbled. Catra swore she looked a bit paler.

"That was you?" Scorpia looked equally shocked, but if it was because of the cruelty of it or just the revelation was unclear.

"That was actually my next question!", Entrapta then called out. "So you have cut through flesh before, what does it feel like?", she asked way too excitedly.

"Do we really need to know?", Arrow Boy screeched.

"Yeah, that was already enough information", Sparkles added.

"Yeah… I mean, why?", the sea princess asked, looking sincerely disturbed. Just like everyone else. Well, except Frosta for some reason.

"You know", Catra answered. "I honestly don't remember why", she admitted. "Probably because she said something mean, but I do remember that it felt like butter", she told Entrapta and elicited a lot of disgusted noised from the crowd.

She did remember. She had overheard Octavia talk about their squad and Adora, how she didn't understand why Shadow Weaver valued her so much since she was only average at best. Catra got angry and might have made an impulsive decision that would ironically put her on Shadow Weaver's bad side for the rest of her life, but she didn't regret it.

"Well it makes sense", Entrapta then said. "If you can easily cut through metal, what is soft flesh?"

"Are we done?", Sparkles interjected again, probably trying to avoid more disturbing questions.

"Yes!" That was relieving to hear. "With the first tests", the woman added. "I need to analyze the data first, then we can do more testing to fill gaps."

"But we're done for today, got it", Catra said and retracted her claws for good. While it didn't hurt, it wasn't all that comfortable to do this over and over again. She flexed her fingers for good measure and walked up to Sparkles and Arrow Boy, but was run into by Frosta.

"It was so cool how you just sliced through it all!", she said excitedly.

"Uh, thanks", she mumbled, not sure how to respond.

Luckily the duo came to her. "That story with the eye, that was exaggerated, right?", Sparkles asked, laughing nervously.

"No", Catra answered easily. "I clawed her eye out. She still wears an eye-patch and she hates me."

"I would hate you to if you clawed my eye out", Arrow Boy mumbled.

"Okay, first of all, she deserved it. Second, I was six. And third, we've learned that I don't maim the people I even remotely tolerate, so you will be fine", she told them and it did seem to relax them a little.

The queen luckily cleared her throat before any further questions could be asked. "If we're done here now, I would suggest we commence the meeting", she said and it did not sound like a suggestion at all. "Where is Adora?", she then asked.

"I'll get her", Catra easily volunteered since she was the only one who knew where the girl was. Also, since a meeting was about to happen, she wanted to have a talk about further course of action.

***

When it was clear, that Catra was going to be busy being experimented on, Adora decided to use the time to check up on Swift Wind.

For some reason, the first place she looked were the stables. A dumb idea, as she should have guessed, because the stables were completely empty. Most horses still stuck around the perimeter after they had been freed — no doubt by Swift Wind — but he himself must be discovering the land around the castle.

Luckily, he was colorful enough that it wasn't all that hard to find him. "Swift Wind!", she called for him and he turned his head in her direction. "How are you? I thought I should check on you."

The horse cleared his throat. "Oh, I'm perfectly well. I was actually thinking about seeing you!"

Adora couldn't hold herself back and hugged him. "I am so glad you're … around. And well", she said awkwardly. She may or may not have momentarily forgotten that no one is supposed to know about the time travel.

"Is this the same weird thing that made you transform me?", he asked skeptically, but hugged her back with a wing regardless.

"What? That was an accident", she said, not entirely convincing even to her own ears.

Swift Wind stared at her with a blank expression. "No it wasn't. You told me what was going to happen. You knew what you were

doing", he accused and brought his face very close to hers. "I don't mind it. I love being able to think and talk! It's great!"

Adora sighed in relief and took a step back. "That's good."

His face just came close to hers again. "But you knew that too", he said and he was right. "What's going on?"

She sputtered. "I- nothing! It- I just…" She didn't actually have a good explanation for this.

"Adora", he said a bit softer and giving her a bit more space. "I am connected to you now, I can feel that. And as your companion, I demand the truth! How am I supposed to help you if I don't know what's going on?"

For all his dramatics, he often made good sense. She sighed. "Promise to not tell anyone. I sure hope you already know what a secret is", she mumbled.

Swift Wind pulled himself up to is full height again and waved his mane around. "As your noble steed, I will not reveal this to anyone. I swear on our bond", he said and she had to roll her eyes.

"Good." Adora did believe him, though. "So, I am kind of a time traveler."

"What?!"

"Not so loud", she shushed him. "There was a portal and I woke up back at the beginning, before I found the sword and… You and I have been really good friends before and I knew how much you loved to talk, and I did need to find Razz, so I just transformed you on purpose this time."

At first she thought, he was staring at her in shock, but then a tear rolled down his eyes and he dramatically turned away. "I am honored", he said and Adora's worries dissipated instantly. "I vow to become your best friend once more."

Best friend wasn't exactly what she had said, but she wasn't going to correct him. "I will too", she simply said.

"And friends talk", the horse exclaimed. "I'll tell you of my adventures of the week since I've gained extensive consciousness. The other horses are terrible listeners, let me tell you."

And so, he talked. About his discoveries in terms of talking and flying. How he had flown to Plumeria to steal apples, how he had ended up giving a guard half a heart attack when he demanded better oats for his brethren and then how he had freed the other horses and how disappointed he was that they did not go out to discover things like he had.

Adora was supportive throughout, except for telling him not to steal other kingdom's apples, though she doubted he had really listened — it seemed he had also discovered the skill of only hearing what he wanted to.

But it was nice, having him back. She had often thought of him as a burden during their beginning times, but now she really couldn't imagine life without him. She had missed him a lot.

"Adora!", she suddenly heard in the distance, even though it was hard over Swift Winds talking.

"I think someone's calling", she told the horse, who went quiet in response.

"Adora!" It was Catra, she now noticed. "Where are you?!"

"Who dares interrupt me?", Swift Wind asked, well almost yelled back.

"I'm here!", Adora called, knowing that Catra's hearing was good enough to find her. "Swift Wind, I need you to be nice", she told the horse.

He scoffed. "I am always nice. I'm great!"

Sometimes she wished she had that confidence. Instead of arguing with him, she looked over to where she had heard her name from last and spotted a figure in the distance coming closer.

"What are you doing out here?", Catra asked, clearly not pleased to be walking through a thick field of grass.

"Talking to Swift Wind. I told you", she reminded the other.

"Hello!", the horse in question went to introduce himself. "I am Swift Wind! Adora's noble steed!"

Catra stared for a few second. "You really weren't kidding about the horse", she then mumbled. "Uh, I'm Catra."

Adora smiled, she didn't quite know why. But the two of them had never met before, but now they did. It felt nice. "Oh, just a heads up, I told Swift Wind about the portal and time travel", she told the other and two pairs of eyes looked at her in confusion.

"You did what?", Catra hissed.

"I thought no one was supposed to know", Swift Wind complained. "I though I was the first you told."

"You are", Adora said quickly. "Catra also time traveled. But it's just the two of us, so no one else you need to worry about. You *are* the first I told", she tried to sooth him and it seemed to be working. So, she turned to Catra. "I had to tell him. I thought he would not remember anything before the transformation, but he did and I might have told him about the exact events that were going to happen to him."

Catra pinched her nose with her fingers. "You are an idiot, you know that?"

"Yeah, but he promised to keep it a secret", she told her.

"It's true", Swift Wind jumped in, clearly feeling better. "As Adora's noble steed and friend, she can confide in me with trust."

"I'll hold you to that", Catra mumbled. "Anyway, the queen has called a meeting. She also invited all the other princesses here. The war room is going to be crowded."

"Oh, can I come?", he asked, excitedly stomping his hooves.

"Sure", Adora said with a shrug.

"Are you serious?", Catra asked her, though.

"What? He's part of the rebellion, too", she defended.

The other girl groaned. "Fine, but I'm not explaining it", she told them and started to walk back towards the palace, both Adora and horse in tow. "I wanted to talk about our plan, though. The meeting will be about our next course of action, but I cannot come up with anything reasonable to say without revealing things I shouldn't know about."

Adora thought for a second. Catra knew the Horde inside out, but only because of her time spent working directly under Hordak, something she had never done in this timeline. "It's too risky to reveal our situation", she stood firm on that, though. "There would be too many questions and we would have to reveal that you…" She didn't find the right words.

"That I have actively fought against them and hurt them?", Catra supplied then.

"Yeah. Angella finally trusts us deserters and we're starting to be friends with the others. We can't risk that", she said. "We can just suggest a course of action without revealing anything, right? Nudge them?", she thought out loud. "Do you have a plan?"

"Something like it", Catra mumbled.

"Do you think you can give it to them, just plainly? As an idea?", she asked. She knew between Catra, Angella and Glimmer, that Catra would probably come up with the best strategy. Angella was too careful and Glimmer never thought things through.

The girl didn't answer for a while, thinking. "I can try", she then said.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed!! Next time: a tense meeting. Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 15: Storm

Chapter Notes

> I'm am not as happy with this chapter as I'd like to be, but I have also read it about a dozen times in the last few days, so what do I know?
> But hey! We're finally here! The Talk!
>
> ... uh... I would like to say have fun, but... (this is a warning, yes)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

On their way to the meeting, Catra thought about Adora's suggestion. But she knew it wouldn't work. The rebellion's biggest mistake throughout it all was their infighting. Between people being too careful or too reckless, they never settled on a proper plan. Somehow that worked out for the trio of their main fighters, but it also made them vulnerable.

Pitching a plan might work on Sparkles and Arrow Boy, who might trust her enough to listen, but would it get past the other princesses, who barely even knew her and already had a non-ideal impression of her? It certainly wouldn't get past the queen, who always brought up her worries. And without sufficient context, she would not be able to quell them.

She had to make a decision — put herself at risk with information she could not possibly have, not even through Shadow Weaver's files, or not give them anything and rely on whatever half-baked plan they would settle for.

When they arrived at the meeting, it was clear that space was limited. All the princesses found a space, but all the generals and other fighters were standing to the side — there was only one usable chair left empty.

But that was the least of their problems. The queen seemed to lose her nerves already. "What is one of our horses doing here?", she asked, massaging her temple.

Swift Wind quickly took over that answer. "I am my own horse, thank you very much. And I am here because I am part of the rebellion!", he announced.

It resulted in a lot of open mouthed stares before the obvious question of "He can talk?!" arrived.

The horse sighed. "Okay, I'll give you all a moment to freak out", he mumbled. And they did until Adora eventually shut it down.

"Enough! This is Swift Wind, the horse I accidentally transformed", she explained, though she stumbled shortly on the word 'accident'. "We have more important things to discuss", she reminded everyone.

Then their focus was on that last chair that Adora of course offered to her, but Catra declined with the argument that the blonde was a princess, and every princess had a seat at the table. Adora did not look happy about that, but Catra felt better standing next to the horse, and still mulling over her options.

"Alright then", the queen said, clearing her throat. "I have called the first meeting of the New Alliance to discuss our current position and how to move forward", she said and nodded towards a woman that Catra figured must be her first general.

She explained a few new developments since Princess Prom a couple days ago. Apart from the several territories the Horde already occupied, they have starting moving in on the borders of the Whispering Woods and the mountain range of Dryl. That of course put a lot of towns and villages at risk, like the newly rebuild Thaymor.

Apart from that, they resumed attacking Salineas, put up outposts at sea and took over a few more costal towns.

Overall their position could be worse, but the Horde was confidently gaining more ground, especially now that most troops had gotten a convenient holiday and sufficient rest thanks to Shadow Weaver's Adora-obsession.

If the rebellion didn't decide on a plan soon, they would take over Dryl and Plumeria, and with Brightmoon bordering on the latter, that would be next. And, as of this morning, scouts have also been spotted at the mountains leading to the Kingdom of Snows.

One wrong move and they were doomed.

The queen sighed. "Our chances don't look good. We need a foolproof plan if we want to stand a chance", she said, knowing the same things Catra did.

"Mom- I mean, your majesty", Sparkles spoke up. "We should fight back, gain our territories back. Now that we have all the princesses united, we can-"

"And what exactly is the plan here, Glimmer?", the queen interrupted. "I will not accept that we just barge in and hope for the best. And even if we get our territories back, then what?"

Catra noticed the glance that Adora send her way, along with a little encouraging smile, and decided to try and play it safe for now — who knew, maybe she was lucky.

She stepped forward. "Your majesty, not fighting back isn't an option. Glimmer is right, regaining the territories is a good first step to solidify our position", she pointed out.

But the queen once more shook her head. "True as it may be, the Horde bested us at every turn so far. How do we know we will succeed? And once we have pushed them back, what do we do? I cannot risk relying on the hope that it will work itself out. We cannot risk falling into a stalemate."

Nudging, as suspected wouldn't get them far. Maybe she could lay some vague things out that wouldn't be too suspicious."The Horde

really isn't as tough to beat as you think. They are more fragile than they seem and if you time it right, they'll break apart without much effort."

She was about to just keep going, suggesting a plan and hoping that if she talked long enough, nobody would question her, but a scoff interrupted her before she could go through with it.

It was the sea princess. "Fragile? My kingdom was already close to destruction, so was Perfuma's and the Whispering Woods have taken quite a bit of damage too. Doesn't look very fragile to me."

To her dismay, most of the other people in the room nodded in agreement with the princess.

Catra sighed. Silently, she tried sending an apology to Adora, but she couldn't tell if it was received. Then she took a deep breath and made her choice. "Hordak is smart, but isolated. He lives as a shut-in and doesn't trust anyone. He so obsessed with his own failure that he never takes risks. The real problem is Shadow Weaver, a sorceress and his second in command. She is mad for power and has a runestone under her control." She ignored the gasps. "But she's hardly a team player. She doesn't value other people or their lives very much and is solely focused on herself, which leaves the troops with no real backup. The few Force Captains are capable, but too scared of Hordak to go above and beyond."

She took another breath to continue. "With that in mind, the best way to beat them is to corner them. Take back the lands bit by bit until the rebellion covers enough ground, so that the Horde is *forced* to take risks. When Hordak is cornered he gets angry, he will take control and Shadow Weaver won't have a say anymore. Anger also makes him sloppy. His plans will be uncoordinated and not well thought out. It will be easy to crush him then. Then we only have to deal with Shadow Weaver. Hordak is weak and his body is falling apart, but Shadow Weaver will be strong as long as she has her connection to the rune stone. We need to sever it and we can do it one of three ways. Destroy her mask. Give the

runestone a new host, Scorpia. Or, of course, killing her." She took yet another deep breath. "The remaining Force Captains will be too unused to real power to take control and it shouldn't be much trouble to dismantle the Horde then. Is that fragile enough for you?"

The sea princess glared at her, while most others just seemed confused.

Adora is looking at her, she knows, but she keeps her eyes focused on the queen, who studied her carefully.

"Catra", the queen's voice rang through the unsettling silence. "You know surprisingly much about the inner workings of the Horde", she pointed out, rightfully so.

Catra waited for more, but there wasn't more. "I guess so", she responded nonchalantly. Somehow she thought someone would say something, but every pair of eyes was on her, waiting for her to elaborate. "Does it matter?", she asked, everyone really.

The queen stared at her for a long time — or at least it felt very long. "I suppose not." Some people were ready to protest, but the woman just held up a hand, silencing them all. "We are in a difficult position, and I have decided to trust our new recruits despite their background. It does not matter how Catra has obtained her information, what matters right now is how we use it."

"What about '*should* we use it?'", the general asked then, fixing her with a suspicious glare.

Sparkles shot out of her chair. "Of course we should!", she practically shouted. "I know Catra has … a difficult personality, but she has no reason to lie to us. She hates the Horde, probably more than any of us."

"And", Arrow Boy jumped in, too. "She has already proven that, while she'll be grumpy about it, she does want to help us."

Catra really wasn't sure if she was supposed to be flattered or offended.

"I have no doubt about it", the queen told the two and gave them a sign to sit back down again.

She sighed a short breath of relief, even as most of the others send her glances and muttered a bit to themselves.

The queen cleared her throat, quickly interruption the quiet discussions. "We will start working on the most efficient way of regaining territory. Time is of the essence." She looked at her again. "Catra?"

That startled her. With the open mistrust in the room, she had not expected to be called on again. Still, she complied. "We should start with the woods. It's our biggest asset in terms of defense. We cannot let them breach it. Then we move to the sea, cut them off supplies and hope. Then we secure the mountains", she answered after a few seconds of thinking.

After that, she gladly let the others take over. While she would like to make sure everything was planned properly, she didn't want to push her luck. If the princesses didn't get even the littlest bit of agency, they might start going rogue and then they were definitely doomed.

And all things considered, this already went better than expected. Sure, she might have lost some trust, but as long as Sparkles and the queen were on her side, they could win this. Even without her planning out every detail, no matter how much safer she would feel if she could.

But she knew that she had to step back. She was not a princess — not that she wanted to be one — she was a former Horde soldier with attitude problems and a load of information, a lowly cadet like her, should not have. It was honestly surprising she was allowed to talk as much as she did.

Once again, she thought that Adora had been right to side with the rebellion.

Still, she was getting soft.

Never once in her life had she offered up information as easily as today. Knowledge, especially in the months since Adora had left her, was her best bargaining chip. Hordak was clueless about most things outside his precious sanctum, things that Catra has had to deal with instead. She had constantly withheld something, just in case. There was power in that.

Now, she did look over to the blonde, who still glanced at her every other second. When she did finally catch Catra's eyes, she frowned. But she didn't look angry, more confused or concerned. It seemed to ask her why she put herself at risk like that.

She shrugged. Honestly, she didn't know. Giving away that power, just like that, for a group of people she really didn't care all that much about, except a few of them maybe… She couldn't say why.

Obviously, she didn't want to lose to the Horde — that would be suicide — but it didn't fully explain why she had done something like this.

She still wanted some revenge, and she knew that could be incredibly motivating — it had catapulted her to second in command within a month of actually trying — but even that didn't feel completely right.

The meeting went on and on and after a while the princesses became bold with their ideas. They managed to get a nice plan together on the foundation that Catra had laid. Still, she was glad when it was finally over.

"Catra", the queen called her once more. "Would you stay for a minute?" Once again, the woman asked but it didn't sound like a question.

She froze on the spot and watched everyone walk past her. When Adora looked back with worry, she only smiled in an attempt to be encouraging. She doubted it worked.

Eventually it was just two people left. "What can I do for you, your majesty?", she asked as politely as she could, but it still came off a bit sarcastic — she couldn't help it.

"Sit", the woman said and Catra did so, sitting exactly opposite her. "I want to talk about your speech." Of course. "I do not know how you managed to gather the information that you have, neither will I ask of you to reveal it."

"Really?", Catra asked surprised. "Why not?"

"Because I know you're doing it to protect Adora." What? "The guards gossip."

"I know", she mumbled, but this time that statement didn't clear anything up for her.

"I know of many conversations between Adora and Glimmer or Bow, but also yours with them. And…" Her expression grew softer. "I have eyes. It was very clear that Adora knew everything you revealed to us today and has probably asked you not to. Am I wrong?"

"No", she quietly admitted.

"I am, however, still a bit worried about your loyalties. They obviously don't lie with the Horde, but I'm not sure they lie with the rebellion, either", the queen said. "I… Glimmer is all I have left. I want to know her save and if she is to fight alongside you, which I sadly cannot stop, I want to know that I can trust you."

"I'll admit that I didn't care much about either side when we came here — if Adora hadn't dragged me with her, I would have probably been stupid enough to endure much more of the torture that they had in store. I … see now that she was right." It came out forced and she needed a second to consider her next words.

The queen used the short silence to voice her own thoughts. "You didn't have to stay. You know that, right?", she asked softly.

"Adora asked me to stay", she said because she had no better answer.

The queen smiled, it was sad and full of weight. "I know the feeling", she said quietly.

Catra sighed. "Your majesty, I'm a terrible friend. Probably a worse ally. But despite it all, Adora, for some reason, believes that I can be good." She laughed a little at the absurdity of it. "I don't know about that, but Adora cares about … everyone. I can't stand to hurt her anymore and that means I can't hurt her friends either. Not that I want to, now that I know them." It was a difficult thing to say out loud, but she needed the queen's trust, or they would all be lost. "And… Sparkles isn't all that bad, I suppose. I won't let anything happen to them."

She didn't know if she was making much sense, or if this was at all convincing to the queen. Maybe she could have put a bit more effort into this, but lying to the woman also didn't feel like the smart thing to do.

"Good", the other said, though, apparently happy with that — it *was* a much greater commitment than Catra had given when she had first gotten here. "I have one more question."

"What?", Catra asked, unsure what else would needed to be discussed.

"I told you about my husband, Micah. You said he was sent to Beast Island", the woman started. "Back then I thought it would be foolish to ask, but now that I know how much you really know…" She looked shortly at the chair next to her — the only one that always stayed empty. "Is he possibly still alive? He was a powerful sorcerer, stubborn to the end. Even after all this time, it's hard to imagine that he was so easily taken down."

She took a moment to think about that. They have always been told that no one survives Beast Island, but they also said that about the Crimson Waste and that turned out to be blatantly wrong. And if he's really that powerful…

"Maybe", she settled on eventually. "I've never been there. There are no records of anyone ever coming back. Few have seen it from afar when dropping people off. I also don't know how much of the stories they told us are to be believed, considering that most of what they say are lies. I guess there is a very slim chance he might still be alive."

The queen nodded. Neither of them had to say that the chances that he was eaten by something were far greater, or that even if he was somehow still alive, they had no way of getting him off the island.

"Thank you", the woman said regardless. "You may leave."

Catra simply stood up and did so. There weren't any words of comfort she could give her anyway.

Outside of the room, the hallways were surprisingly empty. Somehow she imagined that at least half of the earlier crowd would have listened in, but maybe the guards had ushered them away.

That was alright for her, so she simply went to Adora's room. The queen might not have passed any judgment, but the blonde surely would.

When she opened the door, she could see Adora pacing and when she looked up, she was by her side in an instant. "Are you okay? What did Angella say? Is she throwing you out?", she asked, being unnecessarily worried.

"No", Catra told her and took a step out of the girl's reach. "She just had a few questions, nothing big."

Adora sighed in relief. "Oh, good", she mumbled, then straightened up. "What were you thinking?!", she suddenly yelled. "You did exactly what we agreed not to do!"

She knew the other would be angry about that, but that didn't mean that Catra would just let herself be yelled at. "I had to do it or they never would have accepted the plan! You saw Sparkles! She had the same idea and was shut down immediately! I tried to advocate for her and it did nothing!"

"It was reckless! You should have no way of knowing any of that! Everyone has questions and are skeptical about you now. Honestly, *I* don't even understand how you know half of that."

Catra scoffed, crossing her arms. "I was Hordak's second in command, Adora. I spend every day with that guy, of course I know things about him!"

"Well, I didn't know that because you refuse to talk to me!", the other screamed with more frustration than she had ever heard. "You *never* talk to me, and don't think I never noticed how you always conveniently changed the topic. Why don't you just tell me what happened? I could help! We could have found a way to work around that." Adora took a deep breath. "I know most of the princesses are rather open hearted, but do you understand that if they lose their trust in you, they won't listen to you anymore?"

The girl had gotten a bit calmer, back to worried. Catra didn't like it, so she snapped. "What would you have me do?!"

It did the trick. "Just what we had said", Adora grumbled with barely contained anger. "Tell them the plan, nudge them-"

"We don't have time for nudging!", she interrupted. "The Horde is scouting out the mountain pass to the Kingdom of Snows! Why do you think that is?"

"They never act that quickly. We had time!", the other argued.

"No, we didn't! You might think you know the Horde as well as I do, but you don't. When you left, Shadow Weaver went even more mad than she already was, she will not stop at anything, not even Hordak's orders, to bring you back. You think Hordak is in control?" She forced a laugh. "He is pathetic and has no idea how to run that place. But Shadow Weaver does, and people listen to her. So, do you want to know why she's sending out scouts? It's to lure you out."

Adora scoffed. "Oh, and your brilliant plan, that you decided completely without me, will avoid that", she said sarcastically.

"No, but hiding isn't an option", Catra growled. "I made sure that you have allies with you and don't get yourself caught when eventually you make the stupid decision to go alone!"

"You think you know me so well! We've barely seen each other for a year. I have changed, you know!"

Before, it had been for show, but now she was laughing for real and it visibly deepened the frown on the other's face. "You have not changed. You still love to play the hero", she spat. "Well guess what, princess? Every single other person in this stupid alliance has a more useful power than you. You're not special."

"I never said I was!", Adora yelled, high pitched and fed up. "You're just insecure because of Shadow Weaver. It's not my fault that she had some delusion about me! It's not my fault that she hated you!"

"Oh are we talking about the past already? She *still* hates me! She tried to kill me and where were you?!"

"I was trying! I'm always trying and it's never enough! I don't know what I'm supposed to do, I don't know how to fix things! I don't know anything and no one is giving me answers. Not you, not Light Hope, not Razz. I don't know, okay?! But I do want you to be safe, don't you get that?!"

"No, I don't!", Catra answered honestly. "When is it finally clicking in your little brain?! I don't need you to protect me!"

"I don't care if you need me! I want you to want me! Why do you push me away, Catra?!"

"I don't know!" She really didn't. Somehow, she always ended up pushing people away, everyone — nothing personal. "Why are you so determined to invade my space?! I was perfectly fine without you!"

"Do you even hear yourself?" Adora looked at her with disbelief. "You were more unstable every time we met!"

"Oh, right, I forgot, my emotional stability is completely dependent on you, just like the rest of my life!"

The other had to physically take a step back. "I didn't say that, but you can't seriously think that being away from the Horde isn't doing you good", she mumbled, sounding unbelievably heartbroken.

Catra scoffed. "Don't pretend like you don't feel responsible for me. Isn't that what I always was? Just someone to take care of, to hold in line?"

"No." It hurt how earnest it sounded.

"Then what exactly were you trying to do just now?"

As the words, and maybe realization sunk in, Adora looked like she was close to tears, so naturally Catra turned around to leave the room. When she opened the door, she noticed that literally everyone was listening in, now looking incredibly guilty, but she just walked past them.

A part of her wondered if she should worry about much they have heard, but right now she couldn't care. She just walked until she ran. Where to, she didn't know, but somewhere where nobody would find her.

The thought of making Adora cry let her own eyes water.

Eventually, she stumbled into an empty room. One of the uncleaned spare ones, she guessed. The second the door closed behind her, she fell to the floor and bawled.

Why was she crying? It wasn't the first time, the two had fought. Though, it was the first time they had fought like this. This wasn't one of their battles of the last months. And before that? Catra had never told Adora all the things that bothered her. Neither did the blonde. Too scared of how Shadow Weaver would interpret it.

She supposed they aired a lot of pent up emotions just now.

Chapter End Notes

I'm sorry

Chapter 16: Sleepover

Chapter Notes

> We're chilling a bit again in this chapter. (Hopefully you'll like that after the drama of the last one (sorry, again...))
>
> Have fun!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It wouldn't be the first time she and Catra had fought, though they usually did it with their fists. Adora thought she would have preferred getting scratched. She rather had ended up in the infirmary than in a pile of cuddles with everyone telling her that it was okay to be sad and heartbroken.

Of course she had gotten comforted by the entire alliance, seeing as they had been listening in and felt extremely guilty about it.

From what Adora could tell, the princesses luckily didn't seem to have heard the beginning of their argument, but they certainly heard enough to have questions, which they all apparently decided to push aside for now for her.

This was a mess — even if she was safe for now, she would not be able to lie her way out of this. Not without Catra at least, who was nowhere to be found once again.

Honestly, Adora thought she finally understood. While it was nice to have all this support, she would really rather hide out somewhere, too. She didn't want to receive pitying stares, she didn't want to have to worry about answering questions, and she wanted some space to think.

Eventually, she figured, she would have to get it because she had no hope that the other girl would return anytime soon. Not that she wanted to be confronted with Catra right now. No, it would

probably be better if they didn't cross paths for the rest of the day. Which was probably also why she decided to skip dinner.

Glimmer tried to talk some sense into her, but Adora kept stubbornly saying that she was fine, even though she obviously wasn't, and that she wasn't hungry.

She was pretty sure that the princess was about to teleport her, but then Bow stepped in and allowed her some alone time.

It was only then, with the others gone, than she managed to calm down a bit. Well, she was too exhausted to still be panicking, to be more exact, but it hardly made a difference.

Catra, unsurprisingly, didn't come back. Adora, expectedly, didn't sleep.

She lay awake in the dark, repeating their fight again and again in her head. There was a lot she could have done differently — not losing her cool would have been a start. Yelling had never worked with Catra and she wasn't entirely sure what she had been thinking.

She had been frustrated. Weeks, months, years spend with the other and the girl never once talked to her. Adora supposed she knew why, but that didn't make it hurt any less. She understood that they didn't exactly have the best foundation for trust at the moment, but did Catra even trust her back then?

And then there was … the other thing. She did have to admit that she had always felt a certain sense of responsibility over the girl — mostly trying to keep her out of trouble with Shadow Weaver, but it wasn't like Catra ever listened to her anyway.

Was it really so bad that she didn't want her friend to be distrusted and shunned?

She didn't think it was. But the longer she thought about it, she did think she could see why it bothered Catra.

The girl always liked to make her own choices, even if she knew they were wrong, and she was smart enough to know what risks she was taking. And Adora probably should have acknowledged that.

Still, she stood by what she said — all this could have been avoided if Catra had just talked to her.

The morning came sooner than it should have. Adora looked about as terrible as she felt, but she didn't care enough to make herself more presentable. Everyone already knew what had happened and maybe her tired face would stop the others from asking the questions they were undoubtedly waiting to fire at her.

She was honestly a bit surprised to see Catra at breakfast, who looked about as bad as her and somehow Adora doubted the girl had gotten any more sleep than her — but maybe that was wishful thinking.

It was a quiet affair, overall. They received several worried glances, but everyone kept quiet — most either sensed the awkwardness between two people too stubborn to be the first to apologize, or they were wary of Catra, knowing how mean she could be.

They were called into another meeting shortly after. At least the discussions filled the silence. Adora sat at the table, next to Glimmer and Bow. Catra stood somewhere behind her. She wanted to look so badly, but she forced herself to keep her eyes on the queen.

"Time is of the essence, as we had established", she said. "That's why I want to discuss a definite schedule for the next days." She nodded to her general.

"We will start with the towns and villages on the borders of the Whispering Woods", she said moving to the map in front of them. "The camps have the weakest of the defenses, which does not mean they are to be underestimated. But no Force Captains have

been reported stationed in the areas. It's only foot soldiers and bots. It should be easy to achieve a win, making it ideal to start with and test our prowess on the field."

"Your majesty", Bow raised his hand and received a nod. "From what we know, the soldiers are the least of our problem. It's the tech that we have no idea about. If possible I propose to capture a bot or two, to study them."

"I second that!", Entrapta called out, almost flinging herself out of her chair with excitement. She had only looked bored in the meetings, busying herself with her pad instead, but at the mention of the tech she perked up.

The queen cracked a little smile at that. "I will allow it, but do not put your lives at risk for a capture", she told them and the scientists squealed in harmony. "Now, we will need to discuss who to send. It would be unwise to send all forces at once, just in case the Horde has a trap prepared."

Glimmer got up almost immediately. "I'll go!"

Angella sighed. "Of course", she mumbled.

"I'll go too", Adora said, essentially interrupting the incoming refusal. "And I think Glimmer is a good idea. Her powers may be limited, but they're powerful."

"I'll go too, of course", Bow said. "If I leave the bots to you, we won't have anything to study anymore."

"Hey!", Glimmer complained, but didn't have an actual defense.

Bow just smiled smugly. "You know I'm right." Then he seemed to get an idea. "Maybe Catra should come too! Her cuts can be lethal, but at least they're clean."

The princess scoffed. "I can take down a bot without destroying it", she grumbled.

Angella cleared her throat. "Anyway", she said sending a stern look to Glimmer and Bow. "Who else would volunteer for our first attempt at regaining territory."

"If Adora goes, I'm in", Swift Wind announced, waving his mane around.

"The woods are my home, I will fight for everyone living in it", Perfuma announced.

The general nodded. "That makes princess Glimmer, Adora, Bow, Catra, princess Perfuma and…. the horse. I'm afraid we still need maybe two more."

"I'll go!", Frosta then called out. "I don't wanna sit around and wait."

"I'll go too", Scorpia added, though a bit more shyly.

"That will do it. You leave tomorrow", Angella announced.

Soon after that, everyone filed out, Catra with a head start. Adora sighed and left with Glimmer and Bow, who encouragingly patted her shoulders on each side.

"Don't take it too hard. Friends fight sometimes", Bow said. "I'm sure she'll come around. She clearly cares about you."

Adora wasn't so sure about either of that. Since Princess Prom, they were on better terms, yes, but they were still a far cry from friends. And as for coming around, she didn't have much hope in that department either. "We never really had a fight like this", she mumbled in response, too tired to fight the conversation.

"Like never never?", Glimmer asked confused.

"I mean… we sometimes went a bit rough in training when we were mad", she said. She left out the enemy part in which they weren't just rough, but deadly. "But we never really talked about

these things. And we haven't really talked about it since we got here either."

The other two stared at her a second, then shared a look. "Well, that explains why it blew up that big", Bow then told her. "Having arguments is healthy. You really should not have let it fester so long."

"I know", she agreed. "But it's kinda hard being touchy-feely in the Horde."

"Your life is so sad", Bow said with so much pity that Adora wanted to sink into the floor.

"Okay, this is too depressing", Glimmer grumbled, and she had to agree. "We need to do something fun, hang out and relax."

"I would appreciate it if you could bring back the horses that Swift Wind freed", Angella said behind them. "Possibly before he can convince them to flee into the woods", she added while walking past.

"I guess, we'll do that. Not fun, exactly, but it'll do", Glimmer said and promptly teleported them to the entrance of the castle. "So, ideas?", she asked as they looked out to the area.

The horses have decided to discover the grounds a bit more since yesterday, though they still didn't seem very enthusiastic about being outside. Adora took her sword and turned it into a lasso.

It wasn't all that hard in the end. The animals were a bit startled, being approached by three randomly spawned people, and the fact that Glimmer decided to teleport them back into the stables, but apart from having to be a bit more careful to make sure they wouldn't run, it was pretty straightforward.

In fact, it was boring enough that they could continue their conversation.

"So", Glimmer said, and Adora already dreaded what was to come. "I know you said that you and Catra had a falling out or whatever, but… I always thought that you were in the same squad, right? Cause it kinda sounded like you haven't seen each other in a while."

"That's … complicated", she mumbled.

Bow looked at her for a long second, ignoring the horse behind him as it chewed on his shirt. "Is this the same kind of complicated as Catra having all this very specific insight?", he then asked and finally dealt with the animal.

"Yeah", she had to admit.

"You're not gonna tell us, then", Glimmer grumbled and didn't look pleased about that prospect.

She sighed. "I want to tell you, I really do, but I… I can't just make this decision without Catra." In the end, the feline carried the bigger risk, should they reveal everything, and therefore she should have the last word. Even if they were mad at each other right now.

"Okay, I guess that's fair", the princess mumbled, still not happy, but at least accepting. "What about the other stuff? You mentioned someone, uh… what was it?" She turned to Bow, who absentmindedly caught another horse with his trick arrow.

"Hope something, I think?", he offered.

"Light Hope", Adora supplied. "She's… uh, hard to explain. She's a hologram, programmed to train She-Ra, but she's not really great at sharing."

They both looked a bit confused. "When did you have time to meet her?", Glimmer then asked.

"I didn't. She bothers me in my dreams", she answered and received more confused glances. "I don't know how to explain

this… I just just know that she showed up in my dream, telling me all this cryptic stuff."

"Okay, but why don't you just let her train you then? If that's what she wants? Maybe she'll stop bothering you", Bow said.

Adora sighed. "This is gonna sound arrogant, but I don't need training. And I know that she's keeping something from me, something important. She keeps talking about balancing the planet but she won't tell me what that even means. She doesn't tell me anything. I don't trust her. "

"You're right, it does sound arrogant", Glimmer told her before quickly vanishing with a horse. "But, I get it", she then added. "She can't demand something of you, but not tell you any details."

"And you did already fix the Sea Gate and helped Plumeria. You seem to have a pretty good handle on your sword", Bow added.

"I wish Light Hope would agree", Adora mumbled, kind of having a feeling that she hadn't seen the last of the hologram.

The boy hummed thoughtfully. "I doubt you can reason much with technology, but you know who can be reasoned with?"

Adora groaned. "Can she?", she asked. "Because so far, Catra hasn't been a fan of sitting down and listening." She hauled in another horse. "Am I the problem? Why does nobody tell me anything?"

The other two shared a look. "I mean, again, Light Hope is a program, and as for Catra… I'm gonna guess she has a general problem with opening up", Bow said.

"I noticed", she replied with a pout.

"Well, you gotta fix it because I wanna know what you two were talking about", Glimmer demanded.

She scoffed. "Why do *I* have to fix it? I'm not the one refusing to talk about things and making everything more complicated than it needs to be."

Once again, the other two looked at each other with skepticism. "Do you really want me to respond to that?", Glimmer then asked, raising her brows in a slightly condescending matter.

Adora sighed. "Didn't you say that we wanted to do something fun?", she tried to change the topic, which she probably should have done from the very beginning.

The princess narrowed her eyes. "I know what you're doing", she told her. "But you're right. We're going into battle tomorrow! Probably. We should relax a bit. But don't think you're off the hook", she warned.

"Wouldn't dare to dream", Adora mumbled.

"Oh, we could do a sleepover!", Bow squealed in delight. "I love sleepovers."

"Yes, that's a good idea!", Glimmer joined in the enthusiasm.

Since it has been a while since they have had a sleepover — at least from Adora's perspective — she didn't need much convincing to be excited either. "I'm in!"

"Great! We'll finish with the horses, get some blankets and pillows to Glimmer's room and then we'll raid the kitchen!", Bow announced.

"Why my room?", Glimmer questioned and vanished again with another horse before appearing again.

"Well, my room has Catra", Adora mumbled, even though that was debatable. But all her stuff was still there, so the feline might show up, after all.

"Mine is too small, which is not fair by the way. I'm practically living in a closet", Bow said.

"Fine, my room", Glimmer shrugged.

"Sleepover!", Bow yelled excitedly and startled the two remaining horses.

With a sigh, Adora lassoed in one and led it away, while Bow used his trick arrowed to catch the other that had run off a bit at the loud noise. After that it was only hoping that Swift Wind wouldn't find out until after their mission, because otherwise they might have the same problem again tomorrow.

They quickly teleported back inside and separated momentarily to get blankets, pillows, and in Glimmer's case make space.

Adora dreaded going into her room and she simply hoped that Catra had found some way to keep busy.

Going inside, she got her answer. The girl was indeed busy, reading with furrowed brows and ignoring Adora. That was alright for her because she did not want to explain anything.

So, she simply went over to get her pajamas, pillow and blanket. She shortly stopped to think and decided to bring her hair brush, too.

She was already at the door when Catra's voice rang out. "Where are you going?", she asked, it sounded partly accusing and partly panicked.

"Glimmer, Bow and I are having a sleepover", Adora answered, barely looking at the other. "I'll see you tomorrow?"

"Guess so. Everyone already expects me to show up anyway", she grumbled. Right, Catra had never actually volunteered and yet she ended up on the list.

"It *is* your plan." She didn't mean it to sound judgemental, but when she heard herself say it, she knew it would be perceived like that.

"Get out, Adora", the other growled.

She shortly debated clearing up the little misunderstanding, but Catra wouldn't listen right now anyway, so she did leave and tried to find some excitement for her sleepover again.

Since it was pretty easy to hang out with Bow and Glimmer, she found it faster than she anticipated. They prepared their respective beds and then scared the entire kitchen staff before making them regret their career choice when they raided everything and vanished into thin air.

Adora always felt a little bad when they did that, but it was fun to see everyone's startled faces before they turn to resignation, that she couldn't help but laugh along with the others.

"We're way more efficient as three", Glimmer said once they somewhat calmed down. "Look at our loot!"

In their middle lay several cookies, pieces of cake, pastries she couldn't name and even some of the tiny food Entrapta had requested. They really had just taken whatever they could get their hands on.

"Why do they have so much cake around anyway? It's dinner time", Adora pointed out, but the others only shrugged. It didn't matter, really, so she dug in.

Literally. After a life in the Fright Zone, and also considering that there was no cake out in the field, she still considered pastries a rarity.

"Calm down", Glimmer laughed. "Leave some for us."

"Sorry", Adora mumbled over a mouthful and wiped some frosting from her face.

"Don't worry. I'm glad to see that everyone loves the food", Bow told her. "If I understand correctly, you didn't really have that in the Horde."

"No", she snorted. "We had ration bars. The gray ones were most people's favorite, they are way better than the brown kind. Though… neither should be called food. I'm not even sure what they're made off."

Bow stared at her in horror. "In that case, I'm even more glad that you guys finally get real food. That cannot be healthy."

"I mean, we survived so far", she said with a shrug and stuffed some more cake into her.

The gave her a look that very clearly told her that they didn't think that made it better. "Was… not surviving an option?", Bow then asked carefully.

"I- no", she stuttered. "I know that accidents during training could happen, but none of that should be lethal."

"Adora", Glimmer said sternly. "You clearly were not doing well there. I mean, apart from the questionable food, you were raised to be a mindless soldiers, that's not okay! And I know that Catra has scars. Those don't just appear."

"I know", Adora groaned. "But it's still… It wasn't all bad. Yes, it was terrible, but it was still my childhood."

Glimmer sighed. "I do get that. I'm sorry."

"Wait, wait, back up", Bow interrupted. "What do you mean, Catra has scars?", he asked in horror. "Does anyone else have scars?" He stared at her, now, clearly desperately expecting an answer.

"Not that I know of", Adora told him quickly. "Maybe a few small training ones."

Now both of them stared in shock. "So, that not only means that Catra has the most, but she also didn't get them in training?", Bow screeched.

Oops. "I thought we didn't want to talk about Catra?" Adora mumbled, hoping to avoid the topic.

"Okay", Glimmer said, but she was too smug about it. "You still owe me a proper explanation about Princess Prom, then."

"Catra will kill me", she groaned, falling back onto the floor.

"Not if she never knows", Glimmer said, now lying next to her.

"How do you even know about her scars? I know she would never show them voluntarily", Adora asked.

"Uh…" The girl made a long, high pitched sound. Obviously she did not gain that knowledge with permission. "I saw it during our makeover session. She asked me to look away, but I was too excited about her new outfit and peeked … and saw them", she admitted. "I assume Shadow Weaver."

"That was the sorceress that raised you, right? The same one Catra mentioned in the meeting?", Bow asked and she nodded.

"She had something against Catra. I don't know why, but … Shadow Weaver often punished her for no real reason."

"So… Princess Prom?", Glimmer asked carefully.

"She has these shadow spy things. She send them out to find me, but when she got Catra alone, I guess she decided to let out some steam. I'm glad I found her when I did", she explained shortly.

"She really had it the worst there, huh?", Bow asked and looked slightly disturbed.

"Yeah… which is I why I still don't understand why she didn't want to leave", Adora said, her frustrations coming back up.

"Oh, is that why she was so weird when my mom asked her to pledge her allegiance?", Glimmer asked.

"And every day since", Bow added.

She sighed. "Yeah… she's just so stubborn."

Now they both laughed. "No offense, but so are you", Glimmer told her and Bow nodded. "If Bow was treating me like this, I would have already given up, but here you are."

"Also, you could apologize too", Bow pointed out.

"Two peas in a pod", Glimmer sighed.

Adora threw a pillow at her, making her screech. "I get it, okay? But I always reach out and apologize. For once, she could make an effort!" That would never happen, though — Adora still clearly remembered Catra's vow from when they were kids.

"I'll never say sorry to anybody. Ever!"

And she hasn't. Not in any genuine matter, at least. Still, Adora stupidly held out hope. She really was stubborn.

Glimmer threw the pillow back. "Maybe tell *her* that", she said. "You seriously have communication issues."

The conversation didn't go much further as they now found themselves in the middle of a pillow fight. Glimmer didn't ever hold back, so Adora attacked her with all the strength of a soldier. Bow was too soft and capitulated after all of ten minutes, but he kept cheering them on from the sidelines.

Glimmer won, but only because she cheated and used her teleportation.

In the end, they ended up laughing on the floor again and neither of them remembered what they had talked about before.

This time around, they managed to keep the topic happy and away from Catra. They ate the rest of their snacks and talked either about the mission the next day — Glimmer telling them in advance how she was going to kick everyone's butt — or Bow and Glimmer reminiscing about their past.

Adora was reminded of a few moments in her own childhood, but didn't mention them as they involved both the topic of the Horde and Catra.

It was nice and she had fun and it did take her mind off of several things. And she felt truly connected to her friends again.

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Catra was fine. Why wouldn't she be?

She had peace and quiet and no one bothered her — it was perfect. Why would it matter if Adora decided that she didn't want to share a space with her? It doesn't. Everything was fine.

Adora could do whatever she wanted, they were hardly friends. Their relationship had already been on thin ice as it was, but now? Well, Catra didn't want to waste her energy on being delusional.

Honestly, she didn't know why she hadn't moved back to the greenhouse yet.

She tried to get back to reading, but the words flew past her without her actually processing any of them. Eventually, she put the book on magicats aside before she got frustrated enough to throw it — it looked a bit worn, and she had no idea how she would explain to the queen how it got destroyed.

But not reading wasn't the answer, either, as she figured out by destroying her pillow. Accidentally. She had really just formed a fist around the fabric and suddenly there were feathers everywhere.

Okay, maybe she was a bit angry, so what?

Why wouldn't she be? After an entire year in the oh-so-healthy rebellion, Adora was still the same annoyingly overbearing person. That had always been the thing she liked the least about the blonde and it seemed not even glitter and rainbows could get it out of her.

But it didn't matter anyway. What did matter was that she didn't have a pillow anymore.

She took a breath and spat out some feathers that somehow made it inside her mouth. Then she quickly smoothed out her hair before going over to knock on Scorpia's room. The large woman answered almost immediately.

"Catra!", she said, happy as always. "Come in, it's good to see you." She walked back inside, leaving the door wide open and sitting back down next to Entrapta. At least that friendship seemed to regrow just fine.

"I just wanted to ask if you have a spare pillow", she said, still standing in the door. "Mine had a little accident." She picked a remaining feather of her claw.

"Oh, of course!", the woman responded, getting up again and searching.

Entrapta shortly looked up to glance between the two before hunching back over her data pad, probably adding a note to her ongoing social experiment.

"Now where was it?", Scorpia mumbled, looking around in confusion. "You can come in and sit with us, if you want! We could hang out, play some boardgames, whatever really."

"Wait, are you proposing a sleepover?", Entrapta asked. "I've never had one. It would be a great opportunity to extend my research!"

"I really just want a pillow", Catra mumbled. She wasn't in the mood for that. The only sleepovers she had ever known were with Adora…

"On it", Scorpia said, still looking. "It's fine, the sleepover thing. I mean, you probably have something planned with Adora."

"No, she ditched me for tonight." She didn't know why she said that and she regretted it instantly.

Entrapta looked up again. "Is this because of your fight yesterday?", she asked with displaced excitement.

"I don't know, probably", she grumbled.

"Fascinating", the scientist mumbled, writing more notes.

Meanwhile Scorpia was too close to her face. "You poor thing", she cooed. "That is messed up. You should not be left alone, come on." She dragged Catra inside and made her sit next to them, the pillow seemingly forgotten.

"I'm fine", she told them.

Scorpia somehow produced a blanket that Catra suddenly found herself wrapped in. "Leaving you the day before battle, potentially", she scoffed. "We'll take care of you, don't you worry. We would never just leave you, right Entrapta?"

The woman looked up, a bit startled. "Huh? Oh, yeah!", she then said. "You were the first person to ever show an interest in me, and my research indicates that makes us friends. And that friends should support each other in hard times." Her hair reached out and patted Catra's head. "There, there."

She swatted it away and dropped the blanked while she was at it. "I just. Want. A pillow", she repeated.

"Yes, but what you need is the Super Pal Trio. I just came up with that, can you believe it?", Scorpia said with a laugh.

Catra rolled her eyes. Why had it been so important to her that these two were happy, again? She should have taken the flower princess mission instead, let someone else go to Entrapta and not deal with this.

"My data suggests having conversations about feelings with people your close with will improve your emotional and mental state", the scientist stated.

"I barely know either of you", she pointed out, even if it wasn't technically correct. But still, the only person she has ever been really close with was Adora. Sure, she also told Sparkles about her issues, but she had been at a low back then, so that didn't count.

"You're right, we need to get to know each other better", Scorpia said. Catra thought about protesting, but the woman already kept talking, so she just sighed. "So, I grew up in the Horde, but I know my family at least. More or less. I've seen their portraits, but uh I don't- I don't really know their names. But I know my grandfather gave Hordak our runestone. Allegedly — they might have lied about that. Anyway, well, I guess growing up in the Horde won't be anything new, it's the same for you, right?"

"I guess", she mumbled.

"And I didn't have any friends until you and Adora", she then said and frowned. "But … you knew that, too." She looked at Catra, who simply raised her brows. "Back when we met, the night before we fled the Horde. You knew me, somehow."

Catra had a barely existing memory of that night, but it was possible that something like that slipped.

"And you knew about Thaymor…", Scorpia kept remembering and Catra had no idea how to stop it. "And now in the meeting…"

"Interesting", Entrapta interrupted, but wasn't helpful either. "I didn't think it was all that weird, but since everyone has since confirmed that you should not know these things, I do want to know how that is possible."

"It's really not that hard to spy on people", Catra said. It was somewhat plausible. For someone as paranoid as Hordak, he had terrible security in his sanctum — his only alarm was that little abomination, and that was mostly absent, spying on people somewhere else.

Scorpia nodded. "I mean, I get Shadow Weaver. From what I heard you… met often." That was one way to put it. "But Hordak?" She shuddered. "I would be way too scared."

"Like I said, Hordak is not as scary as everyone makes him out to be", she told them. Don't get her wrong, with all his inventions he was a terrifying enemy to have, but without them he was laughably fragile.

"That makes sense", Entrapta easily gave in. "Honestly, I'm more interested to get some clear results on you and Adora", she then said, making Catra groan. "The data is getting very confusing. The timeline doesn't make any sense, but I am missing information on that anyway. More important is your relationship. You see, I kept studying on a real, long established couple — those two princesses, I forgot their names… Anyway, the data from them is very promising, and you and Adora do show signs of attraction towards each other, but ever since the meeting yesterday… it's weird. I don't have preexisting data on that."

She took a deep breath. "For the last time, Adora and I are barely friends anymore, let alone anything else. I don't have time for this anyway, we are at war."

"Do you have sufficient data to support that?", the scientist asked.

"It's my life! I know what I'm feeling!"

Entrapta looked at her for a moment, then she pulled up a chart and handed it to her. "My research suggests otherwise", she said while Catra read.

She barely understood half of that, despite having consumed a lot of psychology books, but she did read a few lines she did understand. "Anger issues? Emotionally stunted? Abandonment issues? Trust issues?", she said, feeling offended somehow.

"It's just a first draft. I'd have to observe you more for a more accurate analysis, but the signs are there", she explained, taking the pad back. "As I can tell from Scorpia's semi-helpful ramblings throughout the day, she shows some similar patterns, though her life was slightly different, enough to bear different results", she told them. "It seems that while Catra is more defensive, Scorpia compensates by being especially outgoing. This is the best experiment I've ever done!"

Catra was a bit too stuck between realization, wanting to tear Entrapta apart, and being slightly impressed to do anything but stare. The princess barely knew either of them and somehow was able to do all that?

Scorpia meanwhile also took a look at her own chart and mumbled all the way. "Oh, wow- yeah. Okay, that- yeah, that's accurate."

"I'd really like to hear more", Entrapta eventually kept talking. "There were a lot of things you said yesterdays that I can't quite place. Hold on", she said, pulled out her recorder and played it. Catra was once again too stunned to rip that thing apart.

"I have changed, you know!", Adora's voice rang through*.*

"You have not changed. You still love to play the hero", her own voice spat back*. "Well guess what, princess? Every single other person in this stupid alliance has a more useful power than you. You're not special."*

"I never said I was!", Adora yelled*. "You're just insecure because of Shadow Weaver. It's not my fault that she had some delusion about me! It's not my fault that she hated you!"*

"Oh are we talking about the past already? She still hates me! She tried to kill me and where were you?!"

Entrapta paused. "So was that a euphemism or did that really happen?", she asked innocently.

Catra only stared at her for a few seconds. "You've recorded us?"

The woman blinked in response. "You can't expect me to remember all this", she said. "So, true or not? If you won't tell me, I'll have to guess. Or ask Adora, she seems to know."

"True", she interrupted that thought process quickly. The last thing she needed was for this to be discussed with Adora. "On several occasions", she added grumpily because she could already feel the follow up question coming.

Entrapta nodded happily, wrote something down and resumed the tape.

"I was trying! I'm always trying and it's never enough! I don't know what I'm supposed to do, I don't know how to fix things! I don't know anything and no one is giving me answers. Not you, not Light Hope, not Razz. I don't know, okay?! But I do want you to be safe, don't you get that?!"

"No, I don't!", Catra answered*. "When is it finally clicking in your little brain?! I don't need you to protect me!"*

"I don't care if you need me! I want you to want me! Why do you push me away, Catra?!"

The scientist paused again and checked her notes shortly. "So, I don't really understand. I mean, you're clearly resenting her, for something, and she clearly developed a lot of guilt, that I don't

really know where that's coming from, and yet … you both want each other."

"That's not- What do you mean guilt?", Catra asked, despite not wanting to know the answer.

"I haven't seen a lot of her of course, but take Princess Prom, for example", the scientist started, missing the way Catra sank into herself. "While you were gone, she was constantly mumbling about how she shouldn't leave you alone. Then when you were back and you talked to Frosta, she kept saying that She-Ra should be a better help at recruiting the princesses. Then when we got to Brightmoon and you walked off, she only stayed long enough to make sure the moonstone could protect you. And then there's the obsessive need to fix things, like-"

"Okay, I get it", she interrupted eventually.

"Are you sure? I got more" When Catra growled, Entrapta at least got that hint. "Anyway, conflicting guilt. Not entirely sure why, but it's there. There's also very specific She-Ra related guilt, for some reason."

"Great", Catra mumbled.

"Not really, actually", the princess explained. "I doubt it's healthy and might start to affect her mental state, if-"

"I was being sarcastic", she interrupted again.

"Oh", the scientist mumbled and wrote something down before looking back up again. "Now to the part that confused me the most", she announced.

"I don't know!", her own voice kept haunting her*. "Why are you so determined to invade my space?! I was perfectly fine without you!"*

"Do you even hear yourself? You were more unstable every time we met!"

"Oh, right, I forgot, my emotional stability is completely dependent on you, just like the rest of my life!"

There was a short pause*. "I didn't say that, but you can't seriously think that being away from the Horde isn't doing you good",* Adora's voice continued, sounding just as sad as Catra remembered.

"Don't pretend like you don't feel responsible for me. Isn't that what I always was? Just someone to take care of, to hold in line?"

"No."

"Then what exactly were you trying to do just now?"

If she has had any illusions about getting a good night's sleep before the mission, she didn't anymore. That right there was going to be her nightmare.

"See that doesn't make any sense", the scientist said. "You talk about a separation, but… I thought you grew up together and I already consulted Scorpia, who confirmed that changing squads is as good as impossible." She took a look at her notes. "Also, what's with the responsibility thing?"

"I don't know", Catra mumbled. "It's always been a thing she did. She always had to fix things, lead people, make sure everyone's okay, but nobody could ever do that for her because … I don't know. She probably felt belittled, but somehow it doesn't occur to her that other people might feel the same way." She took a moment to breathe. "Why am I even telling you this?"

Entrapta fully looked at her now. "Because you need to tell someone. You don't know what to do with your emotions, so you need to let them out. You can't destroy things, so you yell."

"I wasn't-" She stopped herself when she realized how loud she had seemingly gotten without noticing.

"So, about the timeline?", the woman prompted then.

Catra sighed in response. "Can we not?", she asked, not believing this would be accepted, but at least she had tried. Maybe that's what she'd tell Adora after she would be forced to reveal their secret and give Entrapta enough data to diagnose them both with.

"We could play a board game", Scorpia suggested cheerfully then, startling them both. She must have noticed the two confused expressions directed at her because she adds to it. "I don't really understand what just happened. Lots of heavy stuff. I feel like I'm missing some context", she said, chuckling awkwardly.

"I could make a model, if that's easier", Entrapta offered.

"No!", Catra said quickly. "It doesn't matter if she understands, it's not like any of us can solve this right now", she said, but Entrapta obviously loved to argue, already opening her mouth. "A board game sounds great", she said, hoping that Scorpia would talk long enough for the scientist to find a new topic of interest.

"Really? Oh, good!", she said, getting up. "I don't know why, but there are a bunch here in the closet. Maybe they didn't have anywhere else to store them. I looked at some already, they're really fun. I mean, they seem fun, at least."

Talk she did, explaining what the games were about and how they're to be played. Entrapta ended up arguing over semantics, which delayed the process of actually playing. When they finally managed to do that, Catra found herself surprisingly enjoying it.

They played a few, with Entrapta playing by the book and Scorpia cheating to help out Catra, who told her a bunch of times to stop that, but the woman refused.

For a genius, Entrapta was terrible at any game that required an ounce of strategic thinking — not that the luck based games did her any favors either. She might have had better chances if she even tried to cheat.

Scorpia was terrible at most of these. She had trouble rolling dice, holding cards or even moving her pieces. It didn't seem to ruin

her fun, though, and sometimes, Catra ended up helping her instead of the other way around.

It sufficed to say that Catra won every single game. It was a bit laughable and she would have loved a better challenge, but when they all got ready to sleep on the floor, she had to admit that despite it all, she did have fun.

Chapter End Notes

Next time, we're going to finally actually fight in the war!
Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 17: The Rebellion Strikes Back

Chapter Notes

A few things (long note again, sorry)

First: Yes, the title is a Star Wars reference. Yes, that was very important to me.

Then: So, actually this chapter was supposed to be uploaded yesterday, but then I had a problem with my writing program...
During the first draft already, I have noticed that the program cannot hold anything over 100k words, so I had proceeded to split the fic in half and continue working in a new document. For the most part of editing this, everything still worked great. I did make the fic longer in the process though, adding about 15k words, which made it over 100k words long again. And yesterday my program crashed.

Worry not! Everything's fine! Being the paranoid person that I am, I have taken a backup every single time I changed so much as a comma. So, I now have a third document solely for the last three chapters before we hit the halfway point.
... I had really hoped it would pull through, but it had been lagging for a while and I kinda saw it coming.
I honestly think it crashed this badly because I also have had my computer turned on for like a month straight... I don't think that's healthy. So yeah, it took me a little while to make sure everything was running smoothly again. (and I did finally turn off my computer over night, she's fine, don't worry. She's been through worse)

But that's why we're a day late. (which probably isn't such a big deal for you, but it is for me, hence the infodumping...)

Anyway, I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Their morning was nothing eventful. They got dressed, got breakfast. Catra still didn't talk to her. And then they were off. Adora, Glimmer, Bow, Catra, Scorpia, Perfuma, Frosta and Swift Wind. And the general of course.

The rest had wished them luck, promised to swoop in if they needed to and made sure that the next strike, if this one should be successful, would be ready and prepared.

When they left for the Whispering Woods, little groups started to form quickly. Perfuma somehow managed to rip Scorpia away from Catra, adamant to get to know the other more. Swift Wind had taken to talking to the general about his horse revolution, and Glimmer, Bow and Frosta also found each other. Frosta had initially been torn between Catra, who she seemed to think was cool, and Glimmer, who was a bit closer to her age and wasn't grumpy, which eventually won out.

That left the remaining two to group together at the end.

Adora started to think — as she realized that — that maybe none of this was a coincidence. Maybe they had coordinated for the two of them to be together, forced to either suffer in silence or work it out.

Taking a deep breath, and remembering the talk from last night, she chose to deal with this. After all, she was definitely stubborn, but Catra was even more so.

"I'm… I heard you spent some time with Scorpia and Entrapta." It wasn't an apology. She had wanted to do that, but chickened out in the end. Instead she forced out a rather awkward invitation to talk.

Catra didn't answer for a long while and Adora already lost hope. "Not voluntarily. They might as well could have kidnapped me", she mumbled eventually.

Adora laughed a little. "Did you have fun?", she asked.

"No, they're annoying", Catra answered, but she looked to the side, making sure Adora couldn't see her face.

Not being close for the better part of a year didn't change the fact that she knew the feline's every movement and how to interpret it. So, she smirked. "I'm glad you had fun."

"Don't push it", Catra growled.

Adora held up her hands defensively. The girl was probably right. After their fight, she shouldn't pretend that everything was fine all of the sudden. Not until they actually, properly, made up.

And it looked like she couldn't avoid it any longer anyway. "I shouldn't have yelled at you. You were trying to do the right thing."

"I shouldn't have said these things to you", Catra was surprisingly quick to respond. "I know you're trying and… it is enough. It's a bit much, actually. That's the annoying thing about you."

She nodded, at least partly understanding what the other meant. "I didn't mean to be condescending. But it *would* have been nice if you had talked things through with me. Or at least warned me."

"In case you hadn't noticed, I did try *nudging* them", the other all but hissed, some lingering annoyance clearly still in her. But — surprising Adora again — she took a deep calming breath before continuing. "I didn't have much time to talk anything through with you. I had to make a decision, and I did."

"I … can respect that", she answered slowly, the words being much harder to form than she had expected.

"I guess I could … try to be a bit more open", Catra said with, what sounded like, an equal amount of strain.

This was awkward, though she supposed she should have expected that. "When has it become so hard to talk?", she asked, foolishly — she already knew the answer.

"When has it ever been easy?", Catra spelled it out regardless. "You were right. We have never really talked. Not about the things that mattered."

Adora hesitated a bit with her next question, unsure if she should say it. It felt like a dumb thing to even think, but she had to know. "Were we even friends?"

"Don't", the other said sternly, but judging by the way she frowned and tensed up, Adora guessed she must have had that thought before, too. "Do you really think I would have done half shit I've done if we hadn't been friends?"

She supposed that made sense. It was unlikely that Catra would have escalated things so badly if she hadn't cared about Adora at least a bit. "I want to be friends again. But … I still don't know what you want."

"I always thought I knew what I wanted. But lately I'm not so sure anymore", the girl mumbled quietly.

"You have no idea how well I understand that", Adora responded. They were always told what they wanted in the Horde, and now they had to figure it out on their own.

"I think… I don't want to be alone", Catra semi-answered then.

It wasn't exactly the admission that Adora had hoped for but it was more than she had expected.

The rest of the way, they walked in somewhat comfortable silence. She busied herself admiring the nature and scanning their surroundings — one can never be too careful.

At one point, she noticed Glimmer looking at her. As Adora looked back, the girl made a less than subtle gesture, asking the silent question of how things were going between her and Catra. She only nodded in response and got a thumbs up before the princess turned back to Bow, no doubt telling him the news.

Nothing happened for a while after that. Swift Wind moved through the groups a bit once the general couldn't hear all his grand plans anymore, and he did shortly end up next to her before moving on again, but that was about all the excitement they faced.

Only when the daymoon was already on its way to set did she have a little incident.

It wasn't anything drastic, though it did startle Adora when someone very suddenly and very tightly grabbed her hand. One look to her side revealed Catra, who immediately ripped her hand away again and crossed her arms in a defensive manner.

Adora scanned the woodwork, but couldn't see anything apart from a deer-like creature. "I doubt she's here", she said, hoping to have a somewhat calming effect. "And even if she is, I doubt she'll stand a chance against us."

At least Catra snorted. "I know", she admitted. "Doesn't mean I *want* to see her."

"Me neither, I'm just saying … she won't hurt us anymore." Maybe it was a bit bold to grab the other's hand, but to her continued surprise, Catra didn't rip herself free again.

Merely a couple hours later, the light of day almost completely gone, the general told them to stop. "We're about an hour away from Elberon", she said. "We'll rest and continue our way early in the morning."

Everyone was pretty happy to hear that, considering that they had been walking the entire day with hardly a break. But Adora had some doubts.

She leaned over to Catra a bit, despite the fact that they were already standing pretty close together. "Is that a good idea? If Shadow Weaver is spying on us, she could warn the camp", she whispered.

"She can't", Catra replied with ease. "Even if she does know we're here, she can't do anything about it. It would reveal that she is looking for you, which, I'm assuming, Hordak has explicitly forbidden her to do, just like last time. She can't give out orders without it getting back to him, and he can take her precious power away. Too much of a risk for a small camp."

It did calm her nerves a little to know that they were probably save, but it didn't stop her from looking for suspicious shadows.

During dinner, the general wanted to go through the plan one last time, but this time Adora actively advised against it, just in case. Nobody argued with her on that, on account of wanting the mission to go as smooth and with as little traps as possible, though the general did roll her eyes.

By the time it had gotten completely dark, they lay down on their makeshift best. Catra kept close to her, which did delight Adora, but also worried her a bit because she was pretty sure that the feline was probably just trying to stay safe from potential Shadow Weaver attacks.

Glimmer and Bow had put up their beds right next to them, which meant they were pretty cramped, a fact that Catra kept complaining about, but Adora could tell that it didn't really bother her — she was too calm for real anger.

"Our first mission together", Bow squealed into the night, quietly enough to not bother the others. "The Best Friend Squad out on the field."

"The what?", Glimmer asked.

"It's what I decided to call us. I think it fits. I mean… You and I are close, and so are Adora and Catra, and you and Catra are also friends now. We're the Best Friend Squad."

"I do not agree to be part of that", Catra grumbled and Glimmer chuckled.

"Me neither", she said. "But I doubt we can escape it, and if I gotta live with it, so do you, Horde scum." She went to ruffle the girl's hair, who immediately swatted the hand away and curled herself tighter into Adora.

Bow, who watched all of that, cooed. "How cute."

Catra hissed, making everyone laugh.

"Alright, we should try to get some rest", Adora said before anything could escalate.

Glimmer snorted. "We should especially try to fall asleep before Bow", she told them. "He snores", she whispered in conspiracy

"I do not", he protested. "Adora, do I snore?"

"Oh, I… uh", she stuttered. She had honestly no idea. If he did, it certainly hadn't bothered her.

Catra cackled. "A skiff could crash next to her and she would still be asleep", she laughed.

"That's not true", Adora now protested. Yes, she had a rather heavy sleep, especially for a Horde soldier, but it wasn't that heavy. Glimmer had woken her up enough times by teleporting into her room to know that she was still somewhat perceptive. "I'm sure Catra can help you, though. Everything wakes her up."

A tail hit her in the face. "It does not."

Glimmer chuckled. "Am I the only one with normal sleep here?"

"No, you're not", Bow answered. "You shoot glitter everywhere."

"Only a little", the girl grumbled. "Enough. Sleep."

"I'm trying, but you keep talking", Catra mumbled, but Adora could see her smile ever so slightly under the moonlight.

The princess hummed. "Yeah, while we're at it", she then said. "Wanna explain that fight? Cause it didn't make much sense."

Adora was about to insist that they finish with the mission first before discussing any of that, but Catra's scoff was faster.

"Nope", she said simply.

"But-", Glimmer tried to argue.

"That was a private conversation, Sparkles. None of your business, and confusion is what you get for eavesdropping", the feline interrupted and explained. It was rude, sure, but understandable.

Despite the darkness, Adora thought she saw the other girl glare. "Why not? What would be so bad if you explained what that meant?"

"Because it doesn't matter. It's something between me and Adora. Okay?", Catra then said.

The quiet that followed was a bit tense, and Adora really hoped that at some point they could manage to coexist without someone fighting with someone else.

Eventually, it was was Bow who cleared his throat. "We're sorry for eavesdropping. And you're right. We are not entitled to know what you were talking about in a private moment. Right, Glimmer?"

The girl in question let out a long suffering sigh. "Right", she admitted reluctantly.

"Good", Catra replied shortly.

They whispered a bit more about about everything and nothing until they were tired enough to fall asleep mid-sentence. They said their goodnights and then it was quiet, with only their breaths filling the air.

It was nice, all of them together as friends — or something similar.

When she woke up, the daymoon was barely bringing any light into the woods and something sharp poked her abdomen. Looking to her left, she saw Catra repeatedly stabbing a twig into her side.

"What exactly are you doing?", she asked because she couldn't tell.

"Proving a point", the other said and stopped her assault.

"Seriously?", she groaned and sat up. "You had nothing better to do with your morning?" She had to smile, though. Catra could have done anything with her time, but she had chosen to annoy Adora. Maybe she was reading too much into this, but she did think that it meant something.

The girl shrugged. "Not really." Then she sat up, too and looked around. "Looks like breakfast is almost done", she noted, while Adora struggled to get her tangly mess of hair back into a proper ponytail.

Maybe she could get away with it. She would be She-Ra for most of the day, anyway.

Catra only sighed and sat behind her. Without a word she carefully detangled and brushed her hair with her fingers and redid the ponytail. "Don't worry, I left your poof alone", was all she said when she was done.

"Thanks", Adora awkwardly mumbled, not sure what else to say. Or what to do now.

Luckily they were called over for breakfast then — a perfect excuse to get out of this potentially awkward situation.

It was mostly quiet, everyone eating their fill, but not too much so they could still fight. Then they broke down camp and kept walking the last bit of the way.

"We need a better insight before we attack", the general whispered once they got close enough to hear some commotion.

"On it", Catra said and elegantly flung herself up a tree.

The general eyed her suspiciously, still unsure about the girl after her info dumping, but the others seemed to have no such qualms. Then again, the rest of their team simply liked Catra or just didn't have it in them to distrust her.

Scorpia whisper yelled a "Go Catra!" while Perfuma clapped her hands and smiled, and Frosta shot her a thumbs up.

Then Catra was off through the trees and Adora couldn't help but worry. She knew the feline had all the skills required for spying, and that she was good at it. Catra also had the best senses of them all and could probably gather the most intel. She also knew that the soldiers in occupied territories tended to feel too safe for their own good and wouldn't expect anyone to spy on them either, giving the feline an advantage.

Still, she worried. She tried not to, but after all the back and forth and finally arriving at a point where they actually had a relationship again, she just really didn't want to lose the other again.

Was that normal?

Catra came back after a few minutes and startled to doodle a vague layout into the ground.

"At least 30 soldiers", she told them. "I haven't seen any of the villagers around. But I did see a few bots, but I think they'll be the least of our problems." Then she pointed at one spot on her map. "We can sneak in there. The more people we can take out before being discovered the better", she told them and looked at the general.

The suspicion was still clear in her face, but as everyone nodded, so did she.

Adora used the distance to the camp to quickly transform. She had to duck a lot while they snuck around, but it was better than yelling and emitting blinding lights in the middle of the village.

When they reached their entry point, Glimmer and Perfuma each took out one. Glimmer by teleporting one away to knock him out where no one heard him scream, and Perfuma let her vines encase the other fully to the point that Adora doubted that he could still breathe.

They moved further inside, trying to find people isolated enough to take out before a bigger fight broke out. At some point Catra and Scorpia went off into a different direction to cover more ground.

In the meantime they knocked out a few more soldiers, but after the tenth person, their luck ran out. Somehow they overlooked someone standing to the side, who immediately sounded alarm.

Everyone sprung into action. Swift Wind attacked from above, trampling the soldiers. Frosta had similarly little hesitations about punching someone's face in with ice.

Bow and Glimmer fought side by side as usual, while Perfuma gave the general some backup — the flowery princess was only willing to tie people up, not inflict any harm unless strictly necessary, but if it kept the general's back safe, Adora wasn't complaining.

Adora for her part kept looking around, while easily knocking the soldiers coming at her down with her sword. Where were Catra and Scorpia?

When they brought the bots out, Adora groaned.

Catra's estimation had been pretty accurate, but it still meant that eight people had to fight more than twice their numbers, and now with the bots, they were seriously in a tight spot.

"Remember to keep one!", Bow said in the same moment that an explosion sounded.

They turned to it and saw a bot break down with Catra on top, the insides in her hand. Next to her, Scorpia punched some people while muttering "Sorry."

Bow made a despairing sound, but Catra didn't seem all that bothered, instead jumping over to take down a guy that was about to attack the archer. "There are more, relax", she told him. "And focus." She jumped off again, efficiently cutting through armor and weapons.

At least Adora could focus a bit more, knowing the other two were unharmed. She decided to take care of the bot first, now that they had more backup. How had they done it last time? "Frosta!", she called over. "I need you to freeze one of the bots. Bow get ready", she called over and transformed her sword into a lasso.

She hauled in a bot and nodded towards the girl, who was ready to send a wall of ice the bot's way. Once that was done, they both made sure none of the soldiers interfered while Bow meddled with the thing.

Catra meanwhile took it as an invitation to quickly demolish the other bots around. Now they had only the soldiers to deal with, who grew more and more reluctant to fight, especially after Bow was done taking out the bot safely and the three could go back to actively fighting.

It took Glimmer teleporting into the unsure crowd and punching the first person she saw, for them to unanimously decide on a retreat.

Swift Wind decided to terrorize them on their way by attacking a few more from the air.

Adora sighed. "Stop it!", she yelled over the distance. "They're gone!"

"But it's fun!", he complained while she facepalmed. Still, he trotted back over.

"That seems to be all", the general said, looking around like she expected another group to jump out of the woodwork.

Meanwhile Perfuma took precautions and tied up all the knocked out soldiers that were left behind. They would be sent on their merry way later but they couldn't risk being attacked while they figured out what to do next.

"Now what?", Frosta asked.

"We should find the villagers", Adora said. "They will know what they want done about the camp. Either we help them dismantle it, or they use it for … whatever."

"Good idea", Catra said and walked off. Frosta immediately followed and the others did too, though much less excitedly.

"You were so cool back there", the girl said, stars in her eyes as she gleamed up at the feline.

The confused face that Catra made, made Adora snort loudly. The girl sent her a glare. "You uh did good too?", she then responded. It was clear that she had no idea what she was saying, but Frosta either didn't notice or didn't care.

"The way you jumped around and sliced through the bots!", she just kept rambling. "You took down more than anyone else!"

Glimmer scoffed. "Please, she couldn't have done more than us", she said, evidently jealous to have lost Frosta's attention.

Catra laughed, a wicked little thing. "At least I didn't run out of magic", she responded.

"You don't even have magic!", the princess defended.

"Thank goodness. I wouldn't want to switch", Catra said in the sweetest voice, Adora had ever heard.

"You're despicable", Glimmer grumbled, then smirked. "We still have a few more towns to safe. I say we keep count."

"Bots counts double", Catra easily agreed.

"Deal", the other responded with too much confidence.

Adora only shook her head as she started knocking on doors. Weirdly, no one responded. There wasn't even any noise inside, no shuffling, no whispering, just complete silence.

"Can I compete too?", Frosta now asked, looking excitedly between the two older girls.

"Guys?", Adora interrupted. "I'm not even sure anyone's here." She looked through the window, but still didn't see anyone. There were leftovers on the table, though, and it didn't look too old. Not like it was abandoned weeks ago when the Horde took over. "Someone *must* be here."

Catra's ear twitched suddenly. "Over there", she said and pointed to another house a bit further down the street.

Adora went over and knocked, but still nothing. If Catra heard something, there must be someone in here, though. She tried a different approach. "Excuse me", she called, hoping it would carry to whoever was on the other side. "The Horde is gone. We're the Princess Alliance. We just want to talk."

Now some noise came from behind closed door. Some whispering, but nothing more so far. Then it stopped and she already worried that they might have to take some drastic measures, but then the door suddenly opened and some butterfly-like creature was standing before her.

The woman gasped. "She-Ra", she mumbled out. She let out a breath and turned back inside. "We are saved!"

It didn't take long for everyone to run out of the house, take in the truth of Adora's words and promptly spread the message. Soon the entire village was out and about. Wary at first, staring at the newcomers and the battlefield and eventually celebrating.

It took a while for Glimmer, Bow and Adora to get them to calm down enough to discuss if they needed help getting back to normal or rid of the Horde camp.

Meanwhile, Perfuma, Frosta, Catra and Scorpia were slowly releasing the remaining soldiers that were starting to regain consciousness again, while Swift Wind had his fun chasing them away. Then the five went looking around camp, dismantling any cameras or other communication devices.

The townspeople told them that they would need no more help than their general protection, but they did try to coax them into a party. And while Adora would have loved to attend one, they were on a tight schedule. There were more towns and villages to be freed and the Horde must have surely gotten a signal from their earlier attack. They should get there before the Horde was too prepared.

The problem was just that neither Adora, Bow or Glimmer were mean enough to outright refuse and since Catra was still busy, there was no saving in sight. Surprisingly it was the general who curtly shut that conversation down and then ordered them to leave.

They needed to go back to Brightmoon. Glimmer needed to recharge and they had a bot to deliver to Entrapta. Also, this had been only a test, without the queen's permission, they would not be able to go to any more battles. Well, able maybe, but they would certainly receive consequences.

Adora detransformed and let the rest of the day pass by her. This time, the groups changed a lot more fluidly than on the way here. Glimmer and Bow were with her and Catra at first, then they were with Frosta while Scorpia and Perfuma took their place. For a

short moment, when Adora had been busy with Swift Wind, Frosta had occupied Catra too.

It was truly nice to see everyone interact with each other, especially with Catra in the mix.

They reached Brightmoon sometime in the middle of the night. They delivered the bot and Adora noticed the extreme amount of excitement in Entrapta at the prospect of studying it.

Angella agreed to let them leave again in the morning. Whoever wanted to switch with another rebel could, but most of them didn't want to. Adora had to be there as She-Ra — giving the people hope was her job. With the battle between Catra, Glimmer and Frosta happening, neither of them stepped down either. Bow and Swift Wind were a given when Glimmer and Adora were present, respectively.

Perfuma stayed too, for the reason of her protecting her people. Only Scorpia looked about ready to leave, but then she took a look at her friends and resolved herself to staying.

The only person that got replaced was the general, who felt it her duty to stay on the castle grounds rather than outside, especially since they clearly had it handled without her. Her spot got quickly taken by Spinnerella and Netossa, who also came as a pair and seemed to have some rivalry going on as well.

Mermista looked fine with that and said she was saving her strength for the seas when her power was the most effective. Sea Hawk was also okay with waiting for action as long as his princess was.

And Entrapta wasn't meant to fight anyway. Besides she was busy giving them technical support.

Then they finally went to bed.

Catra had run off early, as usual. Adora wasn't entirely sure what she was expecting when she had walked into the room, but it

wasn't the girl passed out in the big bed, instead of the mattress she had dragged in here.

She couldn't ask — didn't want to either, a bit afraid it would break the extension of trust immediately. So, she just went to bed, lying close to her friend, like she had before the sword ever happened, and she fell asleep to the other's purring.

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They settled into a routine of sorts.

Adora, Catra, Glimmer and Bow were always part of the strike teams, only the people around them occasionally changed.

Scorpia for example had to take a break from hurting the people she knew from time to time. Frosta, as young as she was, reluctantly had to sit some out. Swift Wind, Sea Hawk, Spinnerella and Netossa clearly loved the fight, but because of that were easily injured. Mermista and Perfuma had their preferred grounds.

They traveled from town to town, efficiently freeing them and made good progress. They had fun in the evenings before a fight during dinner or late night talks, which brought them all closer as an alliance — with as many missions as they did now, Adora thought it might have even gotten better than it ever was.

Adora and Catra would always sleep close together, though neither got much sleep compared to everyone else. Adora was being plagued by a very annoying Light Hope every other day, while Catra clearly had nightmares, but refused to admit it. Adora could only guess what they were about.

And things between them got a bit … different.

She found herself looking for the feline more and more across the field, and yes, she had done that before, but only as a precaution, now it was different. She more or less understood her own reasons of being worried about the other, but weirdly Catra did the same thing.

More than once had she spotted the other girl searching for her across the battle field — not that She-Ra was all that hard to find.

The rivalry between Glimmer and Catra was also still going strong, and now part of a routine every night where they would compare their count and even write it down on Bow's pad to keep track. So far, neither was winning. When one was in front, the other would double her efforts the next day to catch up. It was a constant tug and pull.

With the constantly increased effort, they were a force to be reckoned with, though. And if it helped to get rid of the Horde faster, Adora wouldn't argue with the methods.

It wasn't long until the borders of the Whispering Woods were entirely reclaimed and they moved on to the sea.

At that point, the Horde soldiers were better prepared for them, having been warned of the potential attack, and even increasing their numbers for better protection, but they were still outmatched in the end, even if they made it harder and the battles more dangerous for them.

Adora and Catra were waiting for Shadow Weaver to torment them again by now, but it never happened. They theorized that she was probably too busy trying to regain some sense of control to deal with them.

The rebellion was making progress pretty fast, after all. They barely took real breaks — only for food , sleep and to recharge Glimmer — and moved from town to town rapidly, hardly giving the Horde a chance to try and strike back. Not that it seemed that

they wanted to, apparently more intend on protecting the occupied territory they still had.

And even if they decided to try, whoever was currently not injured or on the strike team would go deal with it — some princess or rebel was always ready and available to fight. (Something that Catra had pointed out after the third or fourth town when the queen had voiced that concern.)

Honestly, though, Adora wished they could go even faster. She was tired and exhausted, and really didn't know how long she could keep performing properly.

Light Hope had been more or less manageable at the start. She would invade her dreams infrequently, Adora would wake up, calm down and go back to sleep. But now the ancient hologram started to get more persistent, bothering her anytime she fell asleep. The anger fueled her throughout the day, at least. So did the worry for Catra, who thanks to Glimmer decided it was a good idea to come along to take back the costal towns.

The amount of times the girl got distracted and almost hurt in the process because of the water was very worrying, indeed. She even managed to almost drown once, and she was lucky that Scorpia had gotten her out of the water in time, which Adora was eternally grateful for.

By the time, the Horde had to retreat from the sea, Adora was thoroughly done. Her body was in pain, her mind exhausted and she hadn't slept at all for three whole days. Not that it had been much better before.

Catra had noticed, but there was nothing she could do about it. It wasn't like nightmares that could be comforted away.

Fortunately, they would move back to Brightmoon for a few of days to get some proper rest after several weeks of just fighting, then they would secure the mountain paths.

When they made it back, Adora was absolutely ready to relax, but was instantly put back into fighting mode, when a bot greeted her at the door. And so was everyone else by the looks of it. Mermista had already produced a huge wave with the surrounding water to destroy that thing, but then Entrapta got in the way.

"Don't hurt her!", she yelled in despair.

Everyone dropped their weapons, but didn't fully relax again. "Her?", Mermista asked.

"Yes!", Entrapta said, now back to excitement. "Everyone, this is Emily", she introduced them and the bot beeped in greeting, assumably.

"Of course", Catra mumbled, but no one payed much attention to her.

"You named the bot?", Glimmer asked, tilting her head in confusion. "I thought you had dismantled it?"

The scientist nodded. "I did, and then I rebuild and reprogrammed her. She's nice now and super helpful", she explained before seemingly remembering something. "Oh, I didn't have a chance to check in with you yet! Did it work?"

"Yes! Your blocker was genius", Bow eagerly stepped in. "It dismantled any tech in the camps so quickly. Then we only had to deal with the people, which were easy to scare away."

"Great!", she exclaimed and excitedly clapped her hands. "Oh, I wanted to show you something", she then said and dragged Bow off with a strand of her hair.

Well, Adora guessed, at least they finally got to hang out and nerd together or whatever they were doing.

Emily trotted after them, beeping all the while. It somehow sounded excited.

Mermista groaned but didn't say anything more on the topic and simply went inside.

Adora was pretty happy to get to relax a bit. It wasn't exactly sleeping, but maybe it would do something for her body to rest.

They all went to get some food first, while congratulating each other on their missions. Glimmer and Catra still debated on who won, because despite everything and Catra's disadvantage near the ocean, they somehow managed to tie.

At some point, the queen came by for a quick check in. "Your plan worked really well, Catra", she said then. "We're not quite done yet, but I feel like congratulations are in order anyway."

Catra blushed and only nodded in thanks as Angella left again. Adora had to smile. From what she could gather, as well as their time in the Crystal Castle together, she knew now that, despite her portrayed indifference, the girl wanted to be recognized, and she was glad that she finally got it.

"Stop it", the girl hissed at her.

"I'm not doing anything", Adora defended herself.

"You're doing that weird smile you've been doing lately", the other grumbled.

She furrowed her brows. "What smile?" Yes, she was aware that she had been smiling, but what was so weird about this one?

"Oh, I know what you're talking about", Glimmer chimed in. "That cute lopsided grin she does when she looks at you."

Catra responded solely with a low growl and the princess swiftly extracted herself from the conversation again.

Adora still wasn't entirely sure what they were talking about. It was probably just the sleep deprivation making her act weird. And she also felt weird lately. Maybe she was getting sick.

They went to sleep shortly after, and as they had done while sleeping outside, she and Catra curled around each other.

It had become a habit after so many weeks and she liked it, it was comforting somehow to have another person there right next to her. Made it easy to fall asleep.

She regretted that, the second she heard the very familiar "Adora" directed at her.

Adora really tried to wake herself up, but simple annoyance never did the trick. Light Hope had to make her angry first.

"Adora, you are neglectful of your duties", the hologram cut straight to the point. She's been doing that more lately.

"We are currently winning the war. I'm giving people hope. Feels very productive to me", she grumbled because she couldn't stay silent, either.

"Your duty as She-Ra is to balance Etheria", she was told for the hundredth time.

"What for?!", she snapped. "Tell me!"

Light Hope was quietly staring at her, before repeating. "Your duty as She-Ra is to balance Etheria."

Adora groaned. "Why?", she tried again. "You never tell me anything. How am I supposed to trust you?"

"My system has been created to aid you, She-Ra, in fulfilling your destiny."

She wanted to cry. She felt frustrated and despairing. "I can't do this anymore! Get out of my head! Leave me alone! I'm not doing anything if you won't tell me anything."

"You do not come to learn. You do not come to train. You will fail without my guidance", Light Hope told her, making her laugh.

"Yeah, okay, sure. For your information, I'm plenty good with the sword. I don't need you!", she yelled. The other stared at her. No answer came this time. "I do not need you. Now get out of my head!", she repeated and woke up with a start.

Since they laid so close, it also startled Catra awake.

"I'm sorry", Adora mumbled, looking at the girl's wide eyes. "Light Hope again."

With that, Catra fell back down on the bed. "Seriously? Does she think driving you to the brink of sanity will help her?", she asked, voice tired and raspy.

"I don't know", Adora answered. "I just wanna sleep."

"That'd be great", the other mumbled and soothingly rubbed her arm a bit. It steadily became slower until it stopped completely when the girl drifted back off to sleep, indicated by a steady purr, but Adora still lay awake.

There had to be a solution to this. Technically, she had one already, but she couldn't do anything about it. Mara's message probably had something for her, but her ship was still buried deep in the waste. Until Bow or Entrapta picked up its signal, there was nothing she could do about Light Hope.

Unless…

A thought settled into her sleep deprived, probably delusional mind. Huntara had said something about a sandstorm, but why wait for one when they could just make one? Then they would have to get the ship out of the waste, though, so Entrapta could fix it.

She thought about all the princesses and their powers. Mermista and Frosta were pretty much useless in the waste. Glimmer was not strong enough to teleport something so huge. But Perfuma could use the plants to lift it. Hopefully.

It could work. She just had to convince Spinnerella and Perfuma to come with her to a random mission during their supposed free time to the Crimson Waste. But it could work.

Chapter End Notes

Forgiveness (can you imagine?)

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So, not gonna lie, I do not love this chapter. I think it's too cramped, and I don't like that everything is more of a mention than an actual thing that happens, but damn it, this thing is already 200k words long, we do not need another two chapters just so I can describe every battle and little dinner interaction.

They've all grown closer, Catra is doing cat things by constantly being in Adora's space because she can now, Adora is having feelings, and they are going to the Waste!

So, I hope that you enjoyed this one regardless, and until next time! Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 18: The Waste - Part 1

Chapter Notes

> So, kinda like the mission chapters, this is sort of just a fun rewrite of the Waste episodes, but I do hope I made them different enough to still be entertaining <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora hadn't slept anymore that night, instead she ran conversations in her head, trying to figure out the best way to bring up Mara's ship and convince the two princesses to come with her to the Crimson Waste.

Mara's ship was easy to explain. At this point everyone knew that she didn't sleep well and they would hopefully all understand the necessity of her receiving the message.

However, the Crimson Waste was still known to be uninhabitable, and while Adora knew that it wasn't true, she couldn't tell anyone that. So, how was she supposed to convince anyone to follow her there?

She had thought about it for hours now, but none of the options she came up with were very convincing.

Maybe it would be enough to explain to them why she needed the ship.

Somehow she managed to stumble into the dining hall for breakfast. Catra kept sending her worried glances, but fortunately didn't say anything.

Adora waited until everyone was at the table. Perfuma was an early riser and had already done her entire morning routine, but Spinnerella and Netossa were always a bit late. Not as late as Glimmer, but still more on the later side.

"What are you planning?", Catra asked eventually, apparently noticing all the nervous energy.

"Nothing", Adora answered instinctively, then sighed. "I can't wait for nature, I need Mara's message before Light Hope drives me completely insane", she admitted.

Catra nodded. "So, we're going to the waste." It wasn't a question, just a fact that the girl was surprisingly easy to accept.

"*I'm* going to the waste", she told the other. "With a bit of help, but there's no need for anyone else to put themselves in danger."

The girl didn't look impressed. "You're doing the hero thing again", she pointed out. "Stop being a dumbass. While you got scammed last time — yes, I know about that — I ended up ruling the entire waste."

She did have a point there, if Adora had to be honest. Still, she sighed. "That's true, and I appreciate that you want to help, but after what I learned last time, I think I'll be fine."

"Oh yeah? How do you plan on finding a ship that is still buried?", the feline asked with a raised eyebrow.

Adora took a breath to answer and deflated. How *was* she going to find the ship without it being such a big landmark? She racked her brain for memories. "Well, there was something about a constellation."

"What are you whispering about?", Mermista asked loudly, making them the center of attention. "Is it about your sleep issues? I can help, I know this very relaxing technique where you engulf yourself in water."

"Oh, I could guide you through some meditation if you'd like", Perfuma offered.

"I don't need help relaxing, I can sleep just fine", she responded and received condescending looks from literally everyone. Even

Glimmer and Bow, who have arrived at last and only heard that last bit of the conversation. "What I mean is, I can fall asleep easily, it's the dreams that are a problem."

"Nightmares? Maybe a calming tea?", Perfuma asked, in no way less worried.

"Not exactly", Adora sighed. She tried to recall all her scripted explanations, but could only vaguely remember them. It turns out, sleep was important. "There's this hologram, Light Hope, she was created by the First Ones to guide and train She-Ra, and she's able to communicate with me through my dreams, which is annoying at best."

"A hologram can communicate with you?", Entrapta chimed in excitedly. "How does that work? Are you half robot?"

"No", Adora said quickly before the woman got the idea to dissect her. "No, but she can access the sword, which has some magic bond with me. I think. She said something like that."

"Well, it explains your messed up sleep schedule", Glimmer mumbled. "Don't think I haven't noticed. I thought Catra was a bad influence on you, but if it's this Light Hope again… Wait, does that mean you haven't slept in weeks? You had mentioned her already before we even went to free the towns, why didn't you say something sooner?"

"Well, it was manageable", she mumbled awkwardly while Glimmer stared her down like a disappointed mother. "She had gotten a lot more persistent lately, so my sleep has gotten worse, which is why I came up with a plan." Great transition.

"Okay, great!", Bow cheered. "So how do we fix this?"

"I need to talk to Mara", she said.

"Who's that?", Frosta asked. "Never heard of her."

"She was the She-Ra before me. Light Hope told me that she went nuts and almost destroyed the planet, but I don't believe that."

"But isn't this Mara dead?", Perfuma chimed in again, then gasped. "Oh, I always wanted to do a seance!"

Adora was a bit taken aback by that, but kept going regardless. "No, that won't be necessary. She has left a message for me. I just need to access it."

"Great!", Glimmer called out. "So, where is this message? How do we get it?"

Now for the hard part. "It's on her ship. In the Crimson Waste."

The reaction was not as immediate as Adora had expected. They mainly just stared at her, frozen in shock for a while.

It was Entrapta who broke the silence. "So, a ship? As in, sea ship or space ship?", she asked with barely contained excitement.

"Space ship", Adora answered easily and almost went deaf during the following scream. At least someone was excited.

"But the Crimson Waste is dangerous. No one survives there", Perfuma carefully said, fear sketched into her face.

Catra snorted in response, and quickly filled her mouth with porridge to avoid answering to any of the questioning glances.

"I know", Adora tried to get some of the attention away from the girl. She tried to think of something else, something she could say to mainly convince Perfuma and Spinnerella, who looked like she didn't expect to be involved in this at all.

"When do we leave?", Glimmer interrupted any attempt she could have made.

"What?", was all she could force out.

"You didn't think we'd leave you alone in this?", Bow added, apparently also on board. "The Best Friend Squad has each others backs! Catra, you're also coming, right?"

"Wouldn't miss it for anything", she replied with a smirk.

Adora sighed. "That's really not necessary. There's no need to put us all in danger", she tried, but Catra immediately shut her down.

"Don't even", the feline told her. "Now, apart from the problem of finding it, you've clearly thought this through, so who else do we need?", she asked because she knew that they would have to get the space ship out of the sand somehow.

With another sigh, Adora resigned herself to her fate. "We need Spinnerella and Perfuma", she simply answered, effectively startling both women.

"Me?", Spinnerella asked surprised.

"The ship is buried, we need a sandstorm to get it out, and once that is done, we somehow need to get the ship back here, so I thought Perfuma could use the plants there to help transport it here, so that Entrapta can fix it", she explained and the scientist across the table let out another excited screech at the prospect of working on a space ship.

Perfuma did not look happy, though. "I don't know if I can do that", she told them nervously.

"Please", Adora begged. "I know that the waste is scary and dangerous, but I really need your help."

"It's not that I don't want to help, I just… I don't think I'm strong enough", the princess replied deflated.

"I know you can do it", Bow tried to cheer her up. "You're so strong! And maybe we can also learn something more about First Ones tech that could help us win the war."

Perfuma still didn't look particularly convinced. "Since no one else can offer support in that department, I suppose I could try, but… I really don't know if I'm the right choice", she mumbled anyway.

"Thank you", Adora told her sincerely, which at least brought a smile back to her face.

"If Spinny's going, so am I", Netossa then told them, making Adora groan on the inside.

"Too many people pose a risk", she pointed out. A big group certainly wasn't helping them with the nature there. As for the people living there, a big group would just draw unwanted attention. Which was why she had wanted to go alone with Perfuma and Spinnerella. "We should-"

"Can I come too?", Scorpia then asked.

"Sure", Glimmer answered before Adora had a chance. "We'll leave in an hour."

She dropped her head on the table, giving up.

Catra cackled next to her. "If you really thought they would let you leave on your own, you're more sleep deprived than I thought", she said and patted her back with pity.

At least she got Perfuma and Spinnerella to come, which was the most important part if she wanted this plan to succeed.

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The Crimson Waste was just as she remembered, terrifying and dangerous. The only one having fun was Catra, who easily evaded the quicksand and had laughed when Glimmer had taken a dip in it, and seemed genuinely happy to be here.

Adora cannot say she really understood that, and neither did anyone else by the looks of it. Most of the others had been traumatized three steps in, when a bird got killed by some thorny bush. Whoever hadn't been, was shortly after when they discovered the quicksand, various lizard and had seen a sand snake from afar — at least they didn't have to run from one of them this time.

And as if that wasn't bad enough, they had no map.

Of course they had gotten one from Entrapta — Adora had told her what she remembered about the Serenia constellation that marked their destination, and the woman had been able to make sure that they would find the area with the help of the map. It was just that none of them had accounted for the pad overheating after half an hour, rendering it absolutely useless.

This was about as much of a disaster as it had been last time.

"So", Perfuma chuckled awkwardly after another close call with quicksand. "Do we know where we're going? Without a map and all?"

"Uuuh…" Adora though. She had hoped that with Entrapta's help they could avoid the whole making deals with strange criminals thing, but it seemed like they had no other choice. But there were so many problems attached to that. "Catra?", she called out and the girl stopped atop a rock.

"What's up?", she asked while Adora walked over.

They were barely out of hearing range of the others, but they could manage if they whispered. "Small problem."

The girl snorted. "I noticed Miss 'You don't need to come, I got this'."

Adora glared at the other. "Well do you have a plan?", she hissed. "I didn't think the stupid pad would overheat. Well, I could have guessed, but I didn't."

"Relax, we've got a pretty easy option here", Catra told her softly. "We just need to kidnap someone."

"What?!", Adora screeched loud enough for the others to look over in concern. "No, we cannot kidnap someone. We're the good guys."

The girl's carefree smile vanished. "On paper maybe", she grumbled. "I remember a few things that didn't exactly give you the moral high ground."

She sighed. "Do we have another option?", she asked — this was not the right place for this discussion.

Catra rolled her eyes. "I'm afraid there won't be any option here that is completely nice", she told her. "We need a guide, one way or the other, and no one here is going to help us willingly. Unless you wanna try your luck with that purple woman again."

Adora shook her head. "It took quite a while to actually get her on our side. There was a lot of backstabbing involved", she explained shortly. "She led us to the wrong place and threw us in a pit. Then we fought her and only when she saw She-Ra did she help us. And then you came."

"I'm flattered to be such a big part of that memory", the other replied flatly. "But she's still an option, we just got to backstab her back."

Adora frowned. "How are we supposed to do that?"

"She doesn't have to know there's a dozen of us. We just have to send out a few, make her believe you're easy prey, and then ambush her."

Her brow furrowed even more. "So, we're basically back to kidnapping", she summed it up.

The feline sighed exaggeratedly. "Fine, come up with something yourself then, *good guy*", she muttered and hopped off the stone,

leaving Adora to just stand there.

But she had already tried to come up with something for the last hour while they had somewhat blindly walked around and didn't get anywhere.

She decided to give herself a few more minutes as they kept walking until the tavern came into view.

Who knew if Huntara was even in there. Maybe she had business elsewhere. But she remembered that none of the other patrons even acknowledged them and the two goons that had, tried to beat them up. Apart from the backstabbing, Huntara had been nice at least.

"So, did you figure something out?", Perfuma asked then, since they had stopped again.

Adora sighed. "Glimmer, Bow and I will go ahead and check it out", she announced then, nodding towards the tavern. "You stay here and listen to Catra."

"Uh, why?", Netossa asked, making this more complicated than it needed to be.

Luckily for her, agreeing to her plan made Catra a bit more talkative again. "Because I'm the only one who's been able to stay away from quicksand, for one?", she offered.

"Right", the princess responded, not impressed. "So this isn't about whatever you two were whispering about?"

"I mean, sort of. There is … something like a plan", Adora awkwardly replied.

Glimmer sighed then. "You two know something, don't you?", she asked, looking at both of them.

"No", she scoffed in response and laughed way too much. Catra glanced at her and just shook her head, telling her to stop.

"Maybe", she admitted. "But, it's kinda hard to explain, just trust me."

"We already trusted Catra's odd knowledge, it would hypocritical to not trust you now", Bow said then. "Let's go check this out then."

"You know, for someone who complains that no one tells her anything, you're not exactly sharing a whole lot either", Glimmer grumbled as she joined them.

Adora grimaced apologetically, but led them away. Or, she would have if Catra hadn't stopped her.

She looked at the feline questioningly, and after a short look around them, the girl leaned in for another whisper. "I think it's better if you go through with it. Fully. There are too many people here she could ask for help", she said quietly enough that Adora even missed a few words, but she did get the gist and nodded. Then the girl looked at Glimmer and Bow. "Help her out as much as you can, considering her limited lying skills", she said much louder and if Adora wouldn't know how true that was, she would be a bit offended.

The others looked at them a bit weird thanks to all of the whispering, but they accepted it for now, and they could finally make their way over.

To say she was nervous would be an understatement, especially because she couldn't act. She had to be there to pick out the right person, but there was no way she could replicate the naiveness of last time, so she would need to rely on her friends to do most of the talking.

"So, can we get a bit of insight on the plan?", Bow asked about halfway to the tavern.

"We are going to get some help", she told them vaguely. "Whatever you do, don't tell anyone we're more than three."

"Who are we supposed to-", Glimmer started but interrupted herself when they entered the tavern and she spotted the people inside it. "Okay, got it. Not as abandoned as I thought."

"Apart from the question of how did you know that, are we sure these are the kind of people we should be asking for help?", Bow asked in a whisper.

So far no one seems to have noticed them yet. "Without a guide or a map we're pretty much dead. We need someone to get us to the ship", she whispered back.

"I'm honestly surprised you don't know how to get there yourself", Glimmer mumbled and then sighed. "Do we just ask around, or…?"

They would have to because these people seemed to be operating on a minding one's own business mindset. As long as they weren't approached, they would ignore the newcomers. They probably didn't want any trouble and just a drink.

With a sigh, Adora began to talk to people, but just like last time, they were largely ignored. Glimmer and Bow also didn't have much luck.

She saw Huntara in the corner — and she sighed in relief that she was here at all — but didn't want to approach her directly. The woman probably wouldn't respond well to that, considering rule two, not to annoy her while eating.

Adora was about to stand on a table again, when they were finally acknowledged by the two goons. "You're outsiders", the goat lady told them, already cracking her fingers.

She would have to pretend not to know anything. "Yeah, we're hoping someone would give us directions?", she asked in the best innocent tone she could muster. To her ears she totally failed, but it seemed these two were tone deaf.

"We don't like outsiders", the goat lady hissed. "And since the Crimson Waste didn't take care of you… we will", she threatened, the two coming closer.

Adora took a step back, Glimmer and Bow hiding behind her. She really hoped Huntara would be bothered enough to help them because if not, she would have to bring out She-Ra.

Her hand was already on her bracelet, ready to transform, when a glass shattered to the ground and a bunch of people scrambled away in fear. The same fear that now shone in the two goon's face.

"We didn't mean to disturb you", one said quickly, but it didn't help her. The two were quickly thrown out to where Catra was hopefully waiting for them.

Meanwhile, Huntara stood tall in front of them. "There's only two rules in the Crimson Waste", she stated. "One, the strong make the rules. And two, don't annoy me while I eat." Everyone very quickly kept minding their own business again. "I made rule one. They broke rule two." She looked around, making sure that everyone was scared of her or something, then she turned to their little group. "Kids, what are you doing? Don't you know you can't trust anyone in the Crimson Waste?"

Glimmer chuckled nervously, slowly peeking out from behind Adora. "Up until two minutes ago, we didn't know there was anyone in the Crimson Waste", she said with a small glare in her direction.

"Scoundrels, criminals, outlaws, all of them", Huntara told them. "Be careful, kids. Next time, I might not be around to save you." She walked back to her table, leaving them in the middle of the room.

"Her. We need her", she told the others.

"What?", Glimmer asked in shock.

"All the scary people are scared of her, which is not usually a great sign", Bow pointed out. "I don't know. Maybe we should talk to the others about this?"

"Yeah, the others we were not supposed to mention", Glimmer chimed in. "Why don't we just ask for a map?"

"Because no map is as good as Entrapta's. And even with a map, we almost died. A map is not getting us past all the scary things out there", Adora hissed. "We need a guide."

The two shared a look. "And then what? What happens to the others? And what if that woman is evil after all?", Bow asked and it was valid.

Adora turned around, making sure that no one was listening. "Please, trust me. We need to get her to take us and Catra and the others will handle the rest. We might have to take a little detour, but I promise we'll all be safe", she tried to explain quickly.

"That still doesn't explain how you knew about a guide existing to begin with", Glimmer pointed out in a whisper shout. "First Catra, and now you. What's next? Scorpia knowing some weird stuff? Not to mention that fight that you don't want to explain."

"I…" She didn't really know what to say here. "I'm sorry, I can't tell you, but neither Catra or I are trying to hurt you."

"But you won't tell us anything either."

"Guys", Bow went in between them. "For now, we'll accept the secrets, and we do trust you. Right Glimmer?"

The girl sighed. "Yes, of course we do."

"Thank you", Adora said and then went over to Huntara's table, where the woman already cleared out her drink. She looked over to Glimmer, who took over with a sigh.

"Excuse me?", she said and at least gained the woman's attention. "Hi, can we join you? I'm princess Glimmer, and that's Bow and Adora, we're-"

Huntara slammed her cup into the table, startling all three of them. "Blondie, Boy, Glitter, got it. Huntara. Now what do you want?"

Glimmer's smile became a bit strained, but she persevered. "We're looking for something at the center of the Crimson Waste. You seem to know this place well. Can you take us there?"

The woman leaned back. "Did you not hear what I just said about trusting people?", she reminded them.

Adora suddenly felt the need to think about that. Knowing what she did, Huntara never intended to help them and she also wouldn't have a chance to talk to her goons again, which meant that this plan was set into motion the second they had walked through the door. Now she felt even more stupid about what had happened last time. Luckily they had backup this time.

"We heard", Glimmer said. "But, you said that while saving us, so we thought you might want to help us", she pointed out, sounding to effortlessly naive that Adora was honestly jealous.

The woman sighed. "If I say no, you'll go out there and get yourselves killed, is that it?", she asked.

"I mean, not ideally, but yeah", Glimmer answered with a shrug. "A map at least would be great", she mumbled under her breath, making Adora roll her eyes.

"A map won't help you", Huntara answered, then got up, spinning her weapon before making it retract. Adora had seen that before, but it was still a cool move. "Well, looks like you've got yourself a guide."

The woman extended her hand, which Glimmer shook tentatively.

Then — because Huntara was apparently done with eating — they left the tavern immediately. Being back in that heat wasn't very pleasant, but more important than that were the others. Adora did her best to discreetly look around, but she didn't see a single thing. That was good, then their guide wouldn't spot them either.

She took a deep breath and tried to stay focused. Catra had this under control, and Huntara didn't seem like she suspected anything. And even though they were walking purposefully into a trap, at least the woman couldn't call on anyone's aid then, and … maybe Adora had some time appealing to her empathy.

She realized now that it had been probably better to not immediately ambush her, because she doubted that would help convince the woman to help them. This way, Huntara might warm up to them and might actually want to help them.

They could do this. She might not really have an idea about how this would play out, but they could absolutely do this. And she trusted that Catra had a more proper proper plan than she did.

"For a place that's supposed to be uninhabitable, the Crimson Waste sure is habited", Glimmer started a conversation after a few minutes of silence.

"The Crimson Waste takes in all sorts", Huntara told them. "They come running from the law, from their enemies, from different kingdoms."

"From the Horde?", Adora asked. She had to. It was the one thing that helped them last time to appeal to her good side, and they really needed help.

"The war will destroy all those idiots caught up in it", Huntara growled.

Adora didn't know why she thought that would work. It was the Horde combined with She-Ra that had done the trick, but how was she supposed to bring that up without it looking suspicious?

Then again, Huntara might have only heard about it because of the ship's message. That hadn't been unveiled yet. Great, so she had nothing.

Okay, maybe not nothing. "I was in the Horde too,", she told the other. Last time, she had only had an inkling, only the woman's reactions to the topic, but this time she knew for sure that this would get to her. Just like now when Huntara grunted and didn't look at her. "I deserted and joined the rebellion", she kept going.

Huntara scoffed. "Then you're a fool. One girl can't make a difference against the might of the Horde."

Adora smiled at that. "Well, I didn't leave alone", she told the other. "My friend joined me. And … her friend."

The woman scoffed. "The rebellion has failed time and time again. Even three people won't make a difference."

"You're wrong", Glimmer suddenly said. "If it hadn't been for them, we never would have taken our lands back! It was thanks to them that we finally made real progress. A few people can make a difference."

Huntara looked at them intensely, like she was weighing her options. "Whatever you're trying to do, it's not working. I want to be here. And I'm not joining the war", she told them in a very definite tone. "We're almost there", she then said over her shoulder.

Adora sighed, and only hoped that Catra would be there on time.

Chapter End Notes

Next time: Catra's POV, some morally dubious actions, and Mara!

Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 19: The Waste - Part 2

Chapter Notes

Another chapter so soon? Yes! For several reasons xD

I really felt like it was such an odd place to leave the last chapter, and this one was already done, so I just ... decided to upload it right away.
There's another (slightly selfish) reason that I'll expand on more at the end.

For now, I hope you enjoy part 2 <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was patiently watching the trio walk towards the tavern. They hadn't exactly discussed what to do in detail, but she assumed that Adora had at least agreed to her methods. She doubted the blonde would have even suggested it if the plan wasn't to ambush the purple woman.

"Do we get to be in on the plan?", Netossa then asked with a certain impatience in her voice. "There is a plan, right?"

Scorpia laughed. "Of course there is", she said with all the confidence only someone as obnoxiously positive as her could possess.

Catra's eyes never left the tavern. "They will find a guide for us. We will make sure this person is actually helping."

"Wait, there are people in the Crimson Waste?", Perfuma asked nervously, her voice reaching a higher pitch.

She rolled her eyes, not that the others could see. "There sure are", she told them. "You didn't really think that nothing survives here, right? There are plants and animals, so why not people?"

"Okay", Netossa agreed surprisingly easy. There were steps and then the woman was leaning at a rock next to hers. "So, they convince someone to to guide us through the waste. You assume they'll try to scam us, which is why … we're doing what exactly?"

"I'm not assuming anything. No one lives here voluntarily, these people are criminals. The guide will hopefully think these three are easily scammed, and we will prove them wrong", she explained with an evil little smirk.

For a moment she thought that she should not have said it like that, considering how against it Adora had been and that Netossa was looking at her for a very long time, but then she finally nodded and smiled. "I like you", she said, which made Catra look over shortly in surprise before quickly remembering to watch the tavern.

"Taking advantage of other people's goodwill is not a one-person-job. The helpers will probably come out first to set up the trap", Catra continued then. "We'll be practically getting our own guide. Then they'll lead us to whatever secluded area they were planning to ditch the others at and swoop in and safe them."

"Yeah, probably a dumb question, but how do we know who is the correct person?", Scorpia asked. It wasn't a dumb question by any means, but Catra still couldn't answer it without ominous knowledge.

At this point, though, who cares. "I'll know", she told her.

"You know, Catra, maybe we should try to approach this a bit more openly", Perfuma then suggested. "I find it the tiniest bit counterproductive to leave us out like this."

She sighed. "When I think of more, I'll tell you, but for now, this is all I got."

"I'm just saying, that I think our combined energies might be more in sync if we-"

Catra picked up on something all the way over by the tavern, and shushed Perfuma to focus on it. She couldn't make out much, just that something loud had happened. Soon two very familiar faces were thrown out.

"I need two nets", she called out to Netossa, who got ready immediately. "Quick." Then she ran off.

She was faster than Netossa, but that didn't matter — the woman had a good range with throwing her nets. The two goons were bundled up before Catra even reached them. That at least means she didn't have to hurt them, yet.

Catra didn't waste time on pleasantries, and started to haul the first body back to their hiding point. Netossa did the same with the second without needing to be told.

It was a bit of a struggle with their two captures fighting against the restraints, but at least they weren't screaming for help — they probably hadn't even thought of that.

"Wow, you are just as fast on sand as everywhere else", Scorpia said with her admiring voice again when they had made it back.

"Now what?", Spinnerella asked, helping her wife haul the lizard girl the last few meters.

"Who are you?!", the goat lady demanded. And she was way too loud.

"I'd advise you to keep quiet or Scorpia over there will make sure you won't be able to talk at all", Catra lazily threatened, but as pathetic as these two were, it was enough.

The goon scoffed, but was a bit quieter. "You don't get to tell us anything. You have no idea who you're dealing with!"

"You know, I wonder", Catra started, ignoring the other's words completely. "You lived here a while, so I'll just ask. How long does it take for someone to die of thirst here?", she asked, an innocent

finger put on her chin in thought. "And on that topic, do you think anyone will come save you if we leave you here to dry out?" She crouched down in front of them to really see them sweat in fear.

Then she heard in the distance how more people left the tavern. It was the goon's boss and her newly acquired trio of dumbasses.

Hope sparked in the goons' eyes, but Catra acted quickly, softly lifting the other's chin with her claw while raising her eyebrows in a silent dare. Her nail was pointy enough to get the threat across. She half expected any of the princesses to reprimand her, but none of them did. They did watch her closely though.

The goat lady didn't even breathe while they waited for the others to get out of ear shot again.

It was only when Catra's sensitive ears didn't pick anything up anymore, that she released the other's throat. "So… what'll it be?", she then asked.

The goon laughed nervously. "Hey, you know, we don't think of you as an outsider at all", she rambled. Catra vaguely remembered the wastes' odd outsider policy. "Whatever you want, boss."

The lizard girl nodded intensely.

"Good", she purred then got back up again, facing the others.

They looked slightly disturbed, but — and maybe this desert was making her hallucinate — they also looked a bit impressed. That couldn't be right, though.

The only one thoroughly freaked out was Perfuma. "Was this really necessary?", she asked.

Catra rolled her eyes. "In this place, you gotta be mean if you want anyone to listen. Isn't that right?", she asked towards her new old minions.

"It's rule one", she scrambled to answer. "The strong make the rules."

The princess took a deep breath. "I don't like this place", she mumbled then.

"We won't stay here long", Spinnerella assured her, while Catra went back to dealing with the goons.

"Now, your old boss is leading our friends to the wrong place. Take us there." She sliced away the nets around them. "One wrong move and you're dead, got it?"

The two nodded and then started to walk. Catra waved for the others to follow, which they did, even if a bit reluctantly.

It didn't take long for Scorpia to find her way to her side. "You really had them going", she laughed. "It's just a feeling, but it seems like you're really in your element here."

"I guess", she mumbled. Somehow she didn't find the compliment as nice as last time. Maybe because of the entire Shadow Weaver thing. It was mostly the witch's teaching after all.

Scorpia didn't seem to notice. "I admit, apart from the thugs and murderous environment, it is kinda nice here. I might be a bit biased, though, my exoskeleton is loving this dry climate", she exclaimed.

Catra really didn't like the woman's happy attitude. "Tell Perfuma that", she said then. "If she can't find her peace with this place, who knows how useful she will be."

"Oh, yeah, I can do that. Always here to help", Scorpia responded, clueless as always.

"Thanks", she responded and then listened to the receding footsteps. If she wanted to focus on it, she could probably listen in to their conversation about whatever, but instead she chose to think a little.

She wasn't particularly a big fan of thinking about her mental state, but it was weird — last time she has had so much fun tormenting these two goons, while now it felt a bit like a chore.

She wondered if her expectations were just different. From being send to die, it was a pretty big improvement to end the day with being in control of every major gang. But now, she had allies and was send here on a mission. Maybe her memories had painted it better than it actually was. Maybe being at such a low had messed with her perception.

Don't get her wrong, she had fun. She didn't love the waste by any means, but she got along with it. It was just the culture here that didn't feel as enjoyable anymore.

"You okay there, Catra?", Netossa asked softly.

Catra noticed the goat goon try to subtly glance at her, so she hissed at the idiot for good measure before answering. "I'm fine", she said. "Just thinking."

"About Adora?", Spinnerella now chimed in, taking her wife's hand.

"What? No", she spat like it was the most disgusting thought in the world. "Just… that I've changed. I think."

"Well, that's good. Right?", the pink haired princesses asked her with a kind smile.

"I don't know", she answered honestly before noticing the two goons slowing down. "Hey, we don't have time for breaks. Move it!", she yelled at them and they picked up the pace again.

Meanwhile Netossa shook her head. "They'll get there, you'll see", she told Spinnerella.

Catra almost felt the urge to ask what that was supposed to mean, but she suspected if she kept talking about feelings, the two idiots leading them might try something. Last time, she had

to fight that Tung Lashor guy because of the two and as much as she would love her whip back, she didn't have time. They couldn't leave the others hanging.

So instead, she listened in to Perfuma and Scorpia after all, while still paying attention to where they were going.

She was honestly surprised to hear the princess so worked up. "They're the one plant I can't control or keep alive and everyone says they're so easy, but you still have to water them, and I always underwater then overwater and I… I just can't do this. How am I ever supposed to move the ship?"

"Oh, wow", Scorpia mumbled. Whatever she had tried to talk to Perfuma about, she obviously had not expected this rant. "I've seen you, you're great with plants. Maybe you just need to get to know them? Is that how that works? I'll be honest, I don't know anything about plants. Never even seen one until we fled the Horde."

"I've tried so many times to keep one alive. I tried everything, but they just hate me", Perfuma said, completely hopeless."I just don't get cacti! They're so rough and unfriendly."

"You know, maybe it's like with people", Scorpia then said. "Some people are also rough on the outside but a great friend inside."

"Maybe", Perfuma relented. "I will try, but… " She took a deep breath. "That just now was about Catra, wasn't it?"

Scorpia chuckled awkwardly, while Catra debated whether she wanted to hear that. "Yeah, she can be pretty rough. And she has a habit of pushing people away, though sometimes she's really nice. I know she's a good person, she just… has a lot of baggage."

The princess hummed. "She is a very closed off person, that's for sure. But I do believe that everyone is capable of good and she has helped us greatly. I feel like she doesn't trust us, though. It's sometimes a bit hard to stay zen around her."

"She just needs a bit support, is all", Scorpia easily replied. "It's not like friendship is much encouraged in the Horde. We're all leaning."

"Which I think is great." Perfuma got a bit of her enthusiasm back. "I just don't wish to see you get hurt."

The woman laughed. "Oh, Catra would never hurt me. Don't worry."

They kept talking, but Catra stopped listening, instead holding out for their missing trio to figure out if they're close.

Scorpia put way too much faith in her, she decided. Especially for the minimal amount of time they had actually spent together.

The woman might not remember anymore, but Catra *had* hurt her. A lot. Repeatedly. Which was why Catra had avoided her. And if she had to be completely honest, she didn't really think they would work together. They would always end up annoying or hurting each other, just like last time.

Call her a coward, but it was probably better to stay away and let Scorpia have her delusions.

"We're almost there boss", the goat lady told her nervously, ripping her from her thoughts.

"Great, then everyone quiet", she told them. "We don't wanna spoil the ambush, after all", she said for a bit more context. "Oh, Netossa. Could you handle them, just in case."

There was maybe the beginning of a protest on the goat lady's mouth, but it was quickly interrupted by a net encasing them once more. "You're welcome", the princess said proudly.

"Thank you", Catra responded before turning to the goons. "We'll get you when we're done. If you didn't lead us wrong, of course."

They didn't, she could hear the distant voice of Sparkles yelling, but she wanted to scare them a little.

She went in first, having the group follow behind her. It didn't take long for them to reach a weird pit in which all four of them were.

Adora was calm, that she could tell from up here. Sparkles however kept waving her arms around frantically, talking about how they had to be wrong, that Adora had said the ship was buried in sand and this was clearly not it.

The big gal meanwhile looked around tensely, probably expecting her goons to show up any second. Well, this was not gonna be a good day for her. "Do your thing", she whispered to the others, trusting that they would do what needed to be done.

Catra jumped down carefully, and without a sound until she was perched up behind the purple one. "Looking for something?", she asked.

The woman was fast, she had to give her that. Her own reflexes were luckily good enough, but a millisecond later and she would have been hit.

Purple would have probably loved to chase after her, but was hit with a strong gust of wind, giving Catra enough time to find her footing again, and to strike at the weapon in the woman's hand. Once that was out of the way, a net immobilized her quickly. Then the woman opened her mouth but shortly collapsed. After she had fallen to the ground, Catra saw Scorpia shyly lowering her tail.

"Good work", she said and jumped back a bit when the purple woman groaned. It seemed even Scorpia's poison wasn't enough, but it would do for a few minutes. "We should probably get the other two."

Scorpia happily ran off to get them, meanwhile their lost trio came closer. "Wow, that's what I call an entrance!", Arrow Boy cheered.

"I'll admit, I didn't think this would work. I'm impressed", Sparkles said. "Especially since I knew we were gonna end at the wrong place. Do you know how hard it is to think of something to complain about on the spot?"

Catra chuckled. "I didn't think that would ever be a problem for you."

The girl rolled her eyes. "What now?"

"I have an idea", Adora chimed in. "Though it'd be great for her to be fully conscious", she added and carefully tapped the woman on the shoulder, but nothing much more than a groan came out of her.

"Scorpia's poison is really powerful", Perfuma noted, just as the woman came back with their two hostages.

"Oh, thank you", she said and plopped the two down next to their old boss.

"We still have no idea where the center is", Sparkles complained, sitting down on a step.

Catra sat next to her and shrugged. "Either Adora can charm her enough or we just use my favorite method. I'm sure these two will happily lead us. Am I right?", she called over.

"Right, boss", the goat lady responded with all hope lost.

Really, Adora should have listened to her — kidnapping and scaring one of the lower criminals would have been so much easier than this. Especially since they had to kidnap and scare them anyway.

"What did you do to them?", Arrow Boy asked. "They had a bit more fight in them earlier."

"Nothing. I just played by the rules of the waste", she said vaguely.

"You cheated", the purple lady protested, though it didn't look like she could sit up. Still, the poison seemed to dissipate quickly in that huge body.

Adora leaned down. "No, we didn't. But you did, abusing our trust like that", she told the other. "Then again, they don't exactly teach honesty and goodwill in the Horde."

The woman grunted and at least found enough strength in her to roll over to look at Adora. "I was a Horde soldier", she admitted. "They told us we were heroes, freeing Etheria from the evil princesses. But when I saw what we were doing, how Hordak just threw soldiers away, well. I left. And I have no ambition to return to this war."

Catra was honestly surprised by how many people needed to get on the field to figure out how messed up the Horde was. She really thought everyone knew that, but first Adora and now this gal apparently didn't.

"I understand the feeling", Adora said. "But I'm not watching people get hurt. I won't run away."

The woman straight up growled at that.

"We won't be forcing you to fight. But please, help us find the center. There's something there that could help us win this war against the Horde. It'll only help your people", the girl tried to reason with her anyway. Sometimes she was really too good for her own good.

Purple sighed. "I don't know what you want there. It's literally a waste. But I guess I owe it to you", she surprisingly said.

"Can we really trust that?", Catra asked, because wasn't that a bit too fast?

The woman now sat up and laughed a little. "One of your friends?", she asked towards Adora who nodded. "Yeah, I'd recognize those trust issues anywhere. Don't worry, kitty, you've

proven you've got what it takes for the waste. I'll take you for real this time."

Now it was Catra's turn to growl. "You better."

They waited until the woman, Huntara as she learned, could stand up and walk, then she and her goons got untied and they started to walk towards the center.

During the first part of the walk, the woman only yelled at her minions that they were careless enough to get themselves caught. Then she tried recruiting Catra, which she just laughed at. In another life, maybe, but as things were, she didn't really want to live in the waste.

Some more time was spend in silence while she listened in to more conversations. It seemed that Scorpia and Perfuma had really grown close over the last few weeks, which was nice.

"Alright", Huntara then announced somewhere in the middle of the waste. "We're here. At absolutely nothing." Apparently, it really was *the middle*.

"We'll see", Adora only said. "Spinnerella, we need a good bit of wind", she then said. "Is there somewhere we could maybe shelter ourselves?" Looking around, there was only a couple of stones, which were too small to fit all of them.

"I can whip something up", Netossa offered.

They all huddled together and let themselves be surrounded by the woman's nets. At least they had a nice view of Spinnerella's hurricane that was oddly careful at wiping away the sand.

Catra watched, really hoping they would find it and make all this effort worth it. Adora took her hand then, nervously squeezing it. She squeezed back. This had to work. The ship couldn't be anywhere else.

It took at least twenty minutes for the winds to lay free some corner of the ship, and she heard the blonde loudly let out a sigh of relief. With a clue found, Spinnerella's winds became a bit more intense to dig up the whole thing.

Naturally, she was soon exhausted, so, they took a break. Sadly they didn't have many resources on hand to restore her energy much. Obviously they brought a lot of water, but not a lot of food — an oversight on their part, they really should have prepared better.

Still, the woman powered through, at least enough to access the entrance. Which they decided had to do, to give the princess a bit more rest.

"So, this is Mara's ship", Sparkles mumbled as they made their way inside.

"Yep", was all Adora responded.

It didn't look much different from last time, maybe it had a bit more furniture. And it was a lot smaller.

"This is incredible", Arrow Boy almost shouted. "A First Ones ship? This thing used to travel through space!" He looked around. "Is it just me or did this thing look a lot bigger from the outside?"

"We just need to find a door", the blonde said confidently and walked further inside, the others following.

Then suddenly. "She-Ra. Etheria. Gone." Everyone got scared by that, even Adora.

"You couldn't have warned me?", she hissed after she calmed down a bit.

"I kinda forgot", the other said.

Meanwhile Sparkles chuckled. "Oh, nice, a haunted space ship."

"It's not haunted. That's the message I was talking about", Adora told them. Then she turned her bracelet into a shield and angled it oddly towards the floor.

Catra wanted to ask when a bright light appeared and a door opened, leading into the cockpit that she remembered. Despite the creepy voice that kept repeating itself, they all followed inside.

She spotted the goat goon reaching out to some crystal, so she went over to hit their hands. "Don't touch anything", she told them.

They took a step away from the console. "Sorry, boss", they said nervously.

Then a hologram that looked like She-Ra materialized in front of them, along with some other weird readings on screens. "I am Mara, She-Ra of Etheria, and I am gone", it said. Over and over, in a loop.

Catra had gotten here very late last time and had missed all that creepiness, but this time she would get the whole show. Or what functioned of it anyway. She wasn't sure whether she would have preferred to stay outside.

"Well, that's unsettling", Huntara mumbled. "What does any of this mean?" She pointed at the readings that lit up before them.

"It's a code", Adora explained while looking for… something. "It says Mara, Portal and Serenia."

"And what does that mean?", Sparkles asked then, looking around warily like she expected another hologram to pop up somewhere.

Adora didn't answer, seeming to have found what she was looking for and put her sword into a hole in the control panel.

A different hologram appeared, in the seat. She looked hurt. "I don't have much time", she said, glitching heavily. "I barely made it out. If you are seeing this, it means you wield the sword. You

are the new She-Ra. It means I failed. I was supposed to be the last. And I am so, so sorry." For a moment, it looked like the hologram was collapsing, but then it came back. "I don't know what they told you, but it wasn't all bad at first. We were the first ones to settle Etheria, to really study this planet's magic. How could it go so wrong? Light Hope— use— the— can't— weapon— the weapon— weapon."

And with that, the hologram froze. It didn't look like it was going to get started again.

"What weapon?", Sparkles asked completely in shock.

"I don't know", Adora answered truthfully.

Then suddenly, the hologram jumped back to life. "I opened a portal to a completely empty dimension and pulled Etheria in. I hid us from the rest of the universe to keep everyone safe. This is the one place they'll never find us. I saw what they would do. The deaths that would follow. I couldn't stop them before, but I can now. Hiding is our only option", Mara said quickly, desperately. "Maybe it's been a week. Maybe it's been thousands of years. I never wanted to be a hero. I won't be remembered as one."

An alarm started to blare, the light turned red, but nobody cared. They were all too fixated on the ancient message. "You have the Sword now. It is the Administrator Key to our planet. With it, you can activate a portal. So I'm begging you. Don't do it. Leave us here. If you open a portal, death and destruction will follow. For the good of the universe, Etheria must stay in Despondos. If not, everyone will–"

It was gone.

Catra looked over to Adora, who looked just as shaken as the first time. She couldn't help but wonder … if she had heard the full message, would she have still opened the portal? Or was she simply changed enough to finally recognize how dumb she had been before?

Adora walked over to lightly touch the chair. "She was afraid in the end, but so very brave", she said quietly. "She was a hero to at least one person." Then she looked up with resolve. "We will get this ship to Entrapta, so she can fix it. Perfuma?"

The princess startled. "I hate cacti!", she then blurted out. "I love and honor all things, except cacti! I can't control them, I can't lift the ship. I'm sorry."

"What? You're one of the strongest people I know. If anyone can do this, it's you", Adora tried to be uplifting, but it only had a limiting effect.

"They just won't listen to me", the princess mumbled.

Catra sighed. "You always tell me to be more positive, where's that attitude now?", she asked, trying to sound as soft as possible.

"Cacti are very negative plants", she pouted.

"No, Catra is right", Scorpia then said. "We need to try a positive attitude, come on. Let's try together", she offered.

Perfuma seemed reluctant, but then smiled. "Alright. I'll try."

They all went outside to minimize weight in case whatever they were doing did work. Then they sat in the little bit of shade by the stones — which was laughable and Catra was sweating intensely as they were all getting burned by the sun — far enough to give the two privacy.

Well, Catra could still hear them. Not that much was to be heard apart from frequent humming. Scorpia had suggested meditating, but Catra doubted that would do much.

Meanwhile, she turned to Adora. "Are you okay?", she asked quietly.

The girl sighed. "I don't know. It's always weird seeing her or hearing anything from her. And the things she said about the sword and the weapon, whatever it is, it worries me. And I guess I feel sad for her."

"Because of the hero thing?"

"Yeah", the blonde sighed. "All I've got are Razz' and Light Hope's mentions of her. Razz seemed to like her a lot, remembering her fondly, but Light Hope said that the burden of She-Ra had gotten too much for her and that she lost it."

"She seemed pretty sane to me", Catra pointed out. "Like she knew what she was doing."

"I think so too. But then what does that mean for me?", Adora asked.

Probably nothing good. "I don't know", Catra mumbled. She also didn't want to think about that.

It seemed like she didn't have to because she heard a squeal from Perfuma and it sounded happy. She turned around to look and and saw a bunch of thick roots come out of the ground. The princess seemed very satisfied with that and even went to hug Scorpia before making them grow more.

Then Scorpia ran over to them. "We need a bit of help with the sand", she told them.

Spinnerella was at it right away, clearing out the ship more, so Perfuma could lift it out. "Cacti have roots!", she told them excitedly.

Not particularly a new discovery, if one asked Catra, which luckily nobody did. At least they would get the ship to Brightmoon like this.

Chapter End Notes

This is it, people! The official halfway point!! *throws confetti around*
And that's why:

SMALL ANNOUNCEMENT
I will be taking a little break, like a good old fashioned mid season hiatus!

But don't worry, it won't be good old fashioned six months, and I'm certainly not leaving you with a 2-year-Netflix-hiatus. No no no, I will already return with the next chapter on 8.May (that's a Friday in 12 short days), and we shall continue with some revelations and Razz shenanigans (and some Catradora <33)

I'm just ... tired. I have been pretty much filling my entire free time with editing this, and while I love doing that and I enjoy rereading this fanfic and sharing it with you, I just need a week of doing literally anything else. (For the people who are good at math, yes I know that 12 days is more than a week, but you see, I took into account the extra time I would need to edit the next chapter and maybe work a bit ahead)

This is where the aforementioned selfish reason comes in: this was planned to be updated on Monday, but then I was like "It's already done, and it feels weird leaving it open in the middle of the chapter for so long, and the sooner I post, the sooner I can take a break!" So, here we are xD

I hope you will still be with me after this break because we are finally getting closer to my favorite part of this entire thing, hehehehehe

So, until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 20: Mara

Chapter Notes

Hiiii!!

I gotta start this off by saying THANK YOU so much for being so understanding and even telling me to taker longer if I needed it <333 You're all really sweet, and I am eternally grateful that you chose to read my silly fanfic <33

But, I also have to confess that I've lasted barely three days before my brain bombarded me with thoughts about what I wanted to improve, and the urge to edit got pretty strong... Don't worry, I did force myself to chill, but I have been editing obsessively since Monday xD The hyperfixation is pretty strong, it seems, and I am happy to report that I was able to return to this story with renewed excitement <33

And oh boy, am I excited!!
The next three chapters might honestly be my favorite out of this entire thing, and that is all I will say on the matter.

Now, without any further ado, please enjoy a bit more Catradora sweetness <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Getting the ship to Brightmoon was overall a rather easy endeavor — not counting all the close calls with quicksand, and the slightly complicated plan to get a guide. But once Perfuma had managed to get along with cacti, it was only a small hassle to transport it.

Being back in Brightmoon was the bigger problem, in Adora's and Glimmer's humble opinion.

It turned out that Angella had obviously wondered about where half of her rebellion went, and Entrapta had helpfully answered.

Both of them now waited at the entrance of the caste, the queen clearly angry and the scientist naturally ecstatic.

So much so, that she barely left any room for anyone to get a word in, while she kept asking question and exclaiming her excitement, which left the queen to only be able to glower, which was probably why Perfuma, Scorpia, Netossa and Spinnerella slowly and carefully left the scene as they were not the focus of the woman's ire.

It was probably also why Catra happily volunteered to help the scientist find her way to ship — in a clearing just outside of Brightmoon, where they had to leave it since it wouldn't fit anywhere else — and also help moving Entrapta's stuff because the woman now wanted to live there.

Adora had half a mind to protest, but then Angella cleared her throat to get her attention and she had to let the pair go. Well, as long as Entrapta wasn't damaging anything, it was probably okay. And Catra would be there to make sure nothing important would be taken apart.

There was nothing left to do but face the wrath of the queen, who ushered them into the throne room, glaring all the while.

To be fair, wrath might be an exaggeration, but the woman did yell at them, starting with: "What were you thinking?!"

Glimmer bravely scoffed. "The ship has a bunch of useful information, not to mention that Entrapta now has more material to work with and help us. And Adora needs the message on it to sleep."

Angella massaged her temple. "I don't care why you need the ship, I want to know why you thought taking some of our best fighters into a lethal territory was a good idea!"

"I didn't actually want to take them all", Adora decided to jump in. "They just came along."

The queen just sighed at that.

"And", Bow said then. "The waste is … yeah, still lethal, but many people live there, and it really wasn't that bad."

"Did you know that before you went there?", the woman asked skeptically.

Since he clearly didn't know how to answer that, Glimmer helped him out. "No, but it worked out, and we're all still alive."

Now the queen scoffed, which was such an odd sound that Adora almost missed her next words. "Then why did you not tell me? If it was such an easy and safe mission."

"Because we didn't know it would be!"

"And what if you had died? I never would have known?"

"But we didn't!"

The mother daughter duo went on like this for a few more minutes, seemingly without ever reaching a conclusion. And at some point they were hardly talking about the mission anymore.

Adora really felt like she shouldn't be here for this — it started to feel very private — and judging by the looks she exchanged with Bow, she wasn't the only one thinking that.

So, she tried to be polite and tune it out, instead thinking about other things. Unlike last time, Huntara wouldn't be much of an ally anymore — she had decided to stay in the waste and out of the war, just like she had said she would, but at least she had offered to help them if they ever needed to brave the waste again.

And the most important part was the ship, anyway. With Entrapta, it shouldn't take all that long to get it to full functionality again. If she doesn't get distracted that is. Her only hope was that the ship was entertaining enough for her to stay focused on it.

"Adora", Angella's voice rang out, bringing her back to reality. "As I was saying, I will order a team to the mountains, just as we had planned."

Oh, they had gotten to battle plans — at least that was less weird than family drama, she could deal with that. "Great, I'll get the others", she responded dutifully, but was stopped when she saw the woman shake her head.

"No, you will stay", she told her and Adora had the impulse to defend herself, though she wasn't sure from what. "Glimmer is grounded, Perfuma and Spinerella need rest and you do too. Until that message is repaired and we figure out how you can get some proper sleep, I will forbid you to go into any battles."

She was flabbergasted to say the least. "But- I'm She-Ra, I need to be out there, I'm fine."

"You haven't slept in a week. You will only put yourself in danger. As your queen it is my duty to make sure my rebels are in good condition. Spend some time with your friends. That is an order." And with that she left.

"Don't take it so hard", Glimmer told her. "At least she didn't yell at you."

"I can't believe I'm grounded. Is that allowed?", she asked. She cannot remember that something like this ever happened. But she also never had been in this terrible of a condition.

"You heard her, she's the queen", Glimmer answered with a roll of her eyes.

"Since we have nothing better to do, what do you say about visiting Entrapta?", Bow suggested. "I'm not sure she has gotten anything done yet, but it's better than sitting around."

Adora chuckled a bit. "You just want to hang out with her", she pointed out. "And I know you want to mess with the ship too. But sure, let's make sure it's even still standing."

Bow laughed. "Can you blame me? It is a First Ones space ship!", he said, his excitement almost rivaling Entrapta's. "And I'm sure she has enough self restraint to keep it intact." He got some skeptical looks from her and Glimmer in return, but neither of them said anything.

Instead, Glimmer changed the topic. "So… You and Catra", she said. "You've gotten closer."

"Yeah?", Adora replied, a bit unsure. Where was this going? "We're friends again. We've talked weeks ago, we're getting better at … friendship stuff. Talking and all that. I thought that was clear." And not something that would need to be discussed.

The two shared a short look. "You're friends?", Bow asked for a clarification, confusing Adora more.

"What else would we be?" She tried to find answers in her friends' curious faces, but she couldn't make sense of anything.

Glimmer hummed thoughtfully. "You cuddle a lot for friends", she then said.

"What is that supposed to mean?", she asked helplessly.

"Nothing", the princess responded with a shrug. "Just an observation."

"We've always done that. Now that we're friends again, we're doing it again. I don't get why you're making such a big deal out of it", she grumbled.

Both her friends looked at her like she had grown a second head. "Okay, so either we've got it wrong", Bow whispered to Glimmer.

"Or they're more hopeless than we thought", the girl finished the sentence.

"Got what wrong?", Adora almost screamed with frustration. "What are you talking about?"

"I though you were grounded", a new voice interrupted any further conversation. They had reached the exit to the castle where the other princesses assembled for their mission. It was Mermista who had called to them, and now looked at them with lazy confusion.

Adora took a deep breath, trying to calm down enough for this new conversation. "Technically I'm only grounded from fighting, not exploring."

"We're checking on Entrapta", Bow provided further context.

The others nodded, seemingly satisfied with that, and got back to their last preparations. With four people essentially grounded, Catra busy with watching Entrapta, and Bow and Netossa too loyal to leave their side, it pretty much forced everyone else to go.

Not that Frosta, Mermista and Sea Hawk were too mad about that — they were very ready to beat up the Horde. Scorpia was still rather hesitant, and probably a bit tired too, but ready to fill the void. Luckily the mountains weren't too heavily fortified.

"Well, good luck!", she called over to the little group, trying to hide her grief at not being able to come.

"We don't need luck", Mermista told her with a roll of her eyes. "We are the best, so … have fun having a boring day or whatever."

Adora snorted, but seeing as Frosta and Sea Hawk let out a battle cry, while Scorpia cheered them on, she didn't have the heart to argue with them about who really was the best.

"Just be careful", Bow filled the void of her lacking response and got a few thumbs up in return.

Then they just left the others to it and walked towards the ship. It wasn't a long walk, since they had managed to find a clearing big enough pretty close to the castle. Still, after their hike through the

waste, Adora's legs started to complain regardless of the short distance.

Since it was so short, they also didn't fill the air with chatter — and since their last conversation left her extremely confused, she didn't feel the need to get back to that — which was how they managed to overhear voices from inside the ship.

"I agree", Entrapta said. "You fight mostly close range, but it's impractical in some situations. I could probably make something for you. Any preferences?"

Catra hummed. "How do you feel about a whip?", she then asked, making Adora sigh. She remembered Catra gaining a whip before the portal, though she had never really seen her fight with it. The girl must have liked the thing a lot to request it now.

"Oooooh, interesting choice", the scientist cooed just as their troop arrived inside the cockpit. "From the data I have on your fighting style, it would be perfect for you. Flexible and sharp, I like it", she declared.

"Is it really a good idea to give Catra more lethal weapons?", Glimmer asked with a nervous chuckle then.

Catra scoffed. "Easy for you to say, you can teleport out of range." Then she looked at their little group. "What are you doing here anyway? Can't you trust that we have it under control?"

"This ship is beautiful", Entrapta chimed in. "There is so much to learn here, I don't know where to start!" For most people that would be reason for despair, but the woman simply laughed with maniacal enthusiasm.

"Really?", Bow asked, running over. "Did you make any discoveries yet?"

That opened a whole can of worms into Entrapta's endless ramblings, but the boy didn't seem to mind, asking questions in an equally rapid fire manner as the woman answered them.

Looking at them, Adora couldn't help but feel bad — this is what the two have been robbed of the first time around, just because no one came back for the scientist.

"So", Catra then said. "What are you doing here again?"

"Right. Uh, we're grounded", she told her. "The queen wasn't happy about all this and decided to leave us out of the mission to reclaim the mountain passes."

"You must hate that", the feline laughed, making her pout. "But that means we still get our free time, which is nice."

Adora sighed. "I need to do something", she let out in a slightly whiny tone. But she knew she wouldn't last, sitting around and relaxing.

"Of course", Catra mumbled. "Well, apart from cleaning up, which I'd rather not do, I don't know how to keep you busy. But if you really feel it, there's a broom over there", she said pointing at a corner.

Adora would admit, that she honestly thought about it, but then she remembered something. "I think I'm gonna go find Razz."

"The one you keep mentioning?", Glimmer asked.

"Yeah, I mean, she's an old lady living alone in the woods. Someone's gotta keep an eye on her", she mumbled. "And she might know something. Maybe she can help."

"Great, I'm in. Surely beats sitting in here and listening to these two", Catra said, quickly shooting the two nerds a look. "Or that", she added, pointing at Emily, who was … rolling on the floor. Possibly her form of playing around? "What about you Sparkles?"

"Yeah, another endless walk through dangerous terrain to meet an old lady? I'm gonna go with no. Besides, someone's gotta make sure nothing gets set on fire in here", she answered and

then looked at them with an odd expression. "But you go have fun."

Since Catra decided to ignore it, Adora simply followed her outside the ship, where they stood for a while as she tried to figure out which way to go. She had something of an idea where to go, but a good bit of every time she stumbled upon the woman's hut was pure accident.

"Don't tell me we are already lost", Catra cackled.

"We're not lost, I'm just trying to remember", she grumbled in return and just started walking. "That the woods are constantly changing their layout isn't helping either, you know?"

The girl still laughed. "Yes, of course. I just can't help but think about all those times during survival training where you boasted about how great you were. I don't see much of that greatness right now."

She snorted. "I did beat you every time, though", she pointed out. "And you always copied me."

"Who else? Kyle?" She let out a mocking laugh that quickly turned into a real one. "Oh, remember when he managed to tie himself up during trap lessons!"

Adora laughed too now, the image still fondly present in her mind. "But the teacher was impressed that he made the knots so advanced on accident."

They had to laugh so hard that they put in a little stop to catch their breaths. This was nice, she decided. They hadn't joked like this in a long time. She had really missed it, seeing Catra so relaxed and happy around her.

"You're staring. Why?", the girl then ask, squinting her eyes in suspicion.

"I was just thinking how nice this is", Adora said with a shrug.

"Don't be a sap, you're worse than Scorpia", Catra quickly shut their good mood down and kept walking.

Honestly, she shouldn't be surprised. "I'm serious. I mostly know you miserable or gloating at best. I like being happy and relaxed with you." No answer. "I like your smile." Suddenly, Adora ran into the other, who had stopped for some reason. "Is something wrong? Some animal? Shadow Weaver?", she asked, looking around, but nothing was to be seen.

"I really need you to shut up", the other grumbled and started walking again.

Adora was majorly confused. "Did I say something?" She reached for the other's hand, a motion that has become rather natural. "Please talk to me. Did I do something wrong?"

Catra sighed. "Why do you always assume you did something wrong?", she mumbled under her breath. "No, Adora, you didn't do anything."

"But then why did you…?" She wasn't even quite sure what it was about the other's behavior that gave her the feeling something was wrong, but Catra was clearly reacting to something.

"It's fine, don't bother with it", the feline grumbled.

Adora scoffed. "That is clearly not true. Something bothers you, so I bother too. You had fun just now, so what did I say to make you grumpy?"

"I'm not grumpy." Catra sounded a bit offended. "Why can't you just leave it?"

"Because I care", she answered like it was obvious because it was. "You always do this. I ask you what happened that you act weird and you never answer me."

"Yeah, like you're such an open book", the girl replied sarcastically.

"I literally just told you what I was thinking", Adora defended. "And don't even try to change the subject. Unless Razz jumps out of a bush somewhere, we are having this conversation."

"How I wish for an old lady right now", Catra mumbled quietly, but not quiet enough.

She sighed. "Fine, you wanna be stubborn? Okay", she gave in, knowing she couldn't force the other anyway. "You do whatever you want, no matter what I say."

It was quiet after that and Adora regretted saying anything at all. She should have just lied, no matter how terrible she was at it. Now their nice carefree moment had turned into something sour. At least they could still find Razz, she supposed.

"You have a nice smile, too", cut through the silence after barely a minute.

Catra didn't look at her, actively turning to the side, which Adora thought was a bit cute. "Is that why? Because I made you a compliment?", she asked softly, honestly trying to understand.

The other still didn't look. "I'm not used to it, okay?", she growled.

Yeah, that was clearly what had made her weird. She should have guessed. No one from the Horde was particularly good at processing emotions. "Then we need to get you used to it. Let's see…" She thought about all the things she liked about the other. "I like your eyes. I think your hair is nice. I very much like your new outfit, but I told you that already."

"I got it, you can stop."

"You are very smart and make great plans. You are an amazing fighter, which I should have told you more often."

"Adora", the feline growled in warning, which she ignored.

"You are extremely strong and capable and brave-" A hand stopped her from talking, manually closing her mouth.

A look to the side revealed a furiously blushing Catra, which made Adora feel … something. "I mean it. Stop."

Adora mumbled out an "Okay", which was completely unintelligible, but Catra still released her, having understood it apparently. "I meant it", she then said. "Just in case that wasn't clear."

Catra growled in return, but it was a lot less scary with the blush persisting. They were also still holding hands. "Let's just find this old lady."

The silence that settled in between them was a lot more comfortable than before, so Adora was fine to walk side by side, and tried to focus back on Razz. She had a feeling that no matter how many times she would visit the woman, it would always be a pain to find her. But it was fine, they had time — she was grounded, after all.

After a while, her thoughts circled back to what they had talked about before the short weird tension. The Horde's survival training was certainly teaching helpful skills, but in the Whispering Woods none of the tactics that were supposed to help with orientation would do her any good.

"Do you miss them?", she then asked as the thought came to her.

"Miss who?", Catra asked, tilting her head.

"Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio", she clarified — the question had come a bit out of the blue.

"Not really." The girl shrugged.

She furrowed her brows. "I do. We haven't exactly been close, but we did grow up together. You were kind of my priority this entire time, I've barely even thought about them." The other didn't say

anything, but Adora thought she saw a bit of the blush return. "Do you really not miss them? Not even a bit?"

Catra sighed. "They hated me. I hated them. I don't miss them."

"I don't think they hated you", she mumbled.

The feline scoffed. "Alright, I don't think Kyle is even capable of hate. I don't know anything about Rogelio, but Lonnie?" There was a tense look on her face.

Adora knew she should probably drop it, but she was too curious about her friend. "What was it like? After you became Force Captain?", she carefully asked.

Catra shot her a short calculating look — like she tried to figure out what Adora's angle was — but she didn't seem to find something. "Kyle congratulated me and was the only one who was willing to be in my presence. The others took my orders but otherwise avoided me." She seemed thoughtful for a moment. "I think I might miss Kyle."

She had to smile a bit at that, and she probably would have had more questions to annoy the other with, but she noticed Catra's ear twitching and naturally stayed quiet as the feline tried to follow whatever noise she had picked up.

They walked in silence a bit longer, but soon Adora could spot Razz's little house through the trees. "You are great!", she told the other excitedly.

"What did we just talk about?", the girl responded slightly agitated.

"Sorry", Adora chuckled. "But I'm not sure I could have found her without you." Since Catra only answered with an eye roll, she decided to go over and peak inside the house. "Madame Razz?", she asked and was hit with something. "Ow."

Looking down she saw a ball of yarn rolling around her feet.

"Oh, Mara dearie!", the old woman exclaimed. "I did not expect you today."

"I'm Adora and I wanted to check on you and also ask you something because we got Mara's ship and-"

"Adora", she was interrupted. "You are talking nonsense again."

Catra laughed. "Yeah, she does", she agreed.

"You're not helping", Adora told her, but the girl just shrugged.

"Who are you?", Razz asked then, suspiciously looking at Catra. "I do not know you."

"She's my friend. Catra", Adora explained quickly, but it didn't seem to make the woman less wary. Eventually, Razz went back to whatever it was she was doing. "Razz? We found a message from Mara, but it's not working fully. Anyway, she mentions a weapon and-" The woman gasps and pauses shortly. "You *do* know something! Please tell me, I need answers."

"Don't be silly, Madame Razz can't help you", she said, confusing Adora a lot.

She took a deep breath. Then remembered something. "Last time you said we would go berry picking when we met again", she said. "Wanna go do that? Maybe you'll remember something then."

"Madame Razz remembers", she was told in a stern voice. "But it's not time. It's the wrong time, Adora, dearie."

"Then when is the right time?", she asked, her voice starting to lean on desperate. "You knew Mara. You must have known something. I'm so tired, I can't deal with Light Hope anymore and the only people who actually talk to me are dead or you, so please."

Razz stared at her for a long few seconds. Then at Catra for some reason. Then back at her. "You did something", she then said. The woman looked like she ran calculations in her head. "Silly Adora, you shouldn't mess with time like this."

She shared a look with Catra, who looked just as surprised. "What do you mean?"

"We don't have time!", the woman announced and started to rummage through her stuff again, though this time it looked more focused. "I thought… But now we're already late", she told them and started to throw different ingredients into a bowl.

"What are you doing?", Adora asked, more confused than ever. Had it really been a good idea to come here?

"I'm baking a pie. Don't ask silly questions."

"What for? Is this really important right now?", she asked and got hit with the broom, making Catra snort.

"This is important", Razz said. "I need… There's something missing… Sugar!" And she ran off.

"Razz!", Adora called after her before groaning and taking chase.

"Are we sure about this?", Catra asked, keeping pace with her. "I mean, she seems … uh, not really … all there?"

"I know", she huffed. "She's a bit confused… I think? But she does know something. You heard her. How did she know that about our time travel?"

"We don't know if she referred to that", the other mumbled.

"What else could it mean?", Adora asked and expectedly didn't receive an answer. "She knows more than she lets on. I just have to figure out what she means."

Catra suddenly stopped. Adora did too when she noticed. The girl looked around in confusion. "She's gone", she then said.

"Yeah, I can see that", she responded while trying to catch her breath.

"No", the other said, while shaking her head. "No, I mean, I heard her, but suddenly she was … gone. Nothing."

Okay, she could admit that was weird. "Maybe she just stopped walking?"

Catra shook her head once more. "Maybe, but unless she dropped dead, I should still hear her mumbling or stepping on grass or something."

Adora had to process that for a second before becoming very worried. "You don't think she's-"

"No", she got interrupted and she let out a sigh of relief. "If she fell over, I would have heard that too, but she didn't. Relax."

"How am I supposed to do that? Razz just vanished into thin air!", she exclaimed. "I mean, I know that she's magic, but I doubt she can teleport. That shouldn't be possible, right?"

"You gotta calm down", Catra told her. How can she stay so calm? "She's gotta show up somewhere. Last I heard, she was over there. Come one."

At least they could walk now instead of run, but there was still no sign of the old woman. "Razz!", she called out, but received no answer. Not that she had expected one.

After a few minutes of mindlessly stumbling around, Catra perked up again. "Over there", she said, running off again. And indeed they found the woman.

"There you are", Adora said. "Where were you?"

"What are you talking about, Mara? I was right here", Razz told. "Now what was I… Sugar!" She just kept going, no explanation. "Come on, Mara, we need to get sugar." At least they weren't forgotten.

"She obviously knows your name, so why does she sometimes call you Mara?", Catra then asked.

Adora only shrugged. "I don't know. But I know that correcting her is fruitless." They soon came into a clearing. An old ruin of the First Ones laid there destroyed and Razz rummaged through it. "Razz! Be careful. This could be dangerous!" Especially considering what happened at the last ruin.

"Don't be silly, Adora", the woman mumbled. "Look! Sugar", she then laughed and happily walked off again, but Adora felt the need to look at the ruin a bit more.

It was clear that nature didn't destroy it. There were cuts all over it. "Mara did this?", she whispered horrified.

Catra leaned in, looking at the damage. "I mean, I know I said she appeared sane, but… Are you really sure she wasn't crazy?"

This time the feline had to take a broom to the head. "My Mara is a good person. Here." She shoved a basked into Catra's hands. "Be useful and help an old lady pick berries."

The girl was left with her mouth hanging open in shock. Adora really tried to hold back, but broke out laughing anyway. Catra threw the basked to the ground to cross her arms.

She tried to calm down, but chuckled still when she leaned down to pick it back up for her. Then she spotted a crystal on the ground. "What's this?", she asked.

"Why don't you ask your all-knowing weirdo?", Catra grumbled.

Adora rolled her eyes. "Don't be mad", she said. "I've gotten a hit to the head, too."

"Yeah, well, you got your hair poof to protect you", the girl grumbled and walked off to follow Razz.

She pocketed the crystal and followed too. "You always have to make fun of it."

"It's not my fault you look ridiculous", the other quipped back.

"I made you a bunch of compliments and this is what I get?", she pouted, but broke into a grin when she saw the unimpressed face of the feline. "It wouldn't kill you to say something nice from time to time."

"I did, don't you remember?"

Adora thought as they reached the first berry bushes and started to lazily collect some. It was true that the girl had reciprocated the thing about the smile. "You could at least be a bit less mean."

Catra scoffed. "I have never been nicer in my life."

At this point she could only roll her eyes. "Let's get some more berries before we're hit again. I doubt this is enough", she simply said. "Uh, where is Razz?", she then asked because she hadn't really paid attention to the woman and couldn't see her anywhere.

"Not again", the other groaned. "No, wait, she's over there."

As if on cue, the woman stumbled through the woods. "Mara, what are you doing here?"

"We're picking berries? Making pie?", she offered, hoping the other would remember. "You said it was important that we make a pie. Is it important because of Mara? Do you remember? Anything? I, Adora, came to you for help."

"Adora", the woman mumbled. "Yes, Mara wanted me to warn Adora. You need to talk to Mara! It's getting late, we have to hurry! We need to put the pie in!" With that she ran off. Again.

"What? Why?!", Adora yelled after her. She exchanged another look with Catra and ran after her.

When they made it to Razz' house, she had already finished mixing everything together. She lit up when she spotted them. "Berries! How very thoughtful of you, Adora!"

At this point she just sighed and sat down on the ground. If the few berries they had managed to pick were enough, who was she to argue? "I'll just wait for the pie to be done and hope it'll clear something up", she mumbled mostly to herself.

Catra sat down next to her, chuckling a little. "You're doing that bad, huh?"

"I'm too tired for this", she admitted.

"Looks like we got some time", Catra said. "I'll watch over you."

Adora just managed to stare for a little bit. "I don't know…", she mumbled. "I don't think Light Hope will care about that."

"Even a 20 minute nap has to better than staying awake. I promise I'll wake you if she tries something", the other assured her.

Maybe it really was the lack of sleep, but whatever hesitations she had, vanished at the softness in Catra's voice. So, she leaned her head on the girl's shoulder and got comfortable. She fell asleep in a matter of seconds.

"I'm glad you found someone, Mara", was the last thing she heard before she completely drifted off.

However long she slept, it wasn't long enough. When Catra woke her, she wasn't sure she had slept at all, but she must have because it was starting to get dark outside. And then there was Razz, who was missing again. Now she was certainly awake. "Razz!"

"She just left", Catra told her. "We gotta hurry. She just took the pie and ran."

"But where to?", she asked, standing up quickly.

"I don't know, but she kept rambling something about Mara." Catra took her hand, dragging her along as she followed whatever sounds the old woman made.

They stumbled through the woods, catching up to Razz fast, but sometimes lost her behind a tree or bush. The old lady was fast and even though Adora had already known that, it still surprised her.

"Razz! Wait", she tried to call out but either she really wasn't loud enough, or once again ignored. She guessed the latter.

Finally, something else came into view. The ship. That's where Razz was headed.

When they made it inside, chaos had already broken out with Bow and Glimmer trying to calm Razz down, who only got more agitated as it went on. "Leave her", she told the others. "That's Razz. She… What are you looking for?", she asked the woman, who kept searching with a steaming hot pie in her hands.

"Mara, of course. She wants to talk to you", was the answer.

She turned to Entrapta. "Did you get the message fixed?", she asked, hoping that the woman was referring to that.

"Yes", the scientist replied enthusiastically. "Well, theoretically", she then added less so. "I've fixed the hologram capabilities and server, along with the memory disks, but something is missing. I have no way of replicating it, at least not within the next hours."

"Some data crystal", Bow added and pointed at a hole in the consol.

"It looks like..." The crystal she had found by the destroyed statue.

Without hesitation, she pulled it out of her pocket and inserted it. At first, the lights completely went down and she feared to have broken the ship completely. But then they came back on and a hologram started forming in the middle of the room. Everyone around it jumped away, even Emily.

It was Mara. Obviously hurt as she was limping and grunting on her way to the control panel.

Light Hope flickered to life behind her. Adora panicked for a second, but this wasn't the real deal, just part of the message.

"What are you doing, Mara?", the hologram asked.

Mara ignored her and kept pressing buttons.

Something in Light Hope flickered. "You have de- de- destroyed my interplanetary systems", she said and paused shortly as they hit some turbulences. "You are beha- be- behaving erratically. Where is the sword, Mara?"

"The sword is gone", Mara responded angrily. "There's not going to be a She-Ra anymore." She walked around, pressing more buttons. The purpose of it evaded Adora, however.

"It is your destiny to be She-Ra", Light Hope responded, making her roll her eyes. She had heard that one too many times.

"She-Ra's *destiny* was to be a part of your machine", Mara yelled. "But I won't *ever* let you use her again."

"The Heart of Etheria has been activated. Your mission will be fulfilled. There will be peace throughout the galaxy. You will be ... a hero."

Mara slammed her hands down on the consol. Maybe it was a glitch in the hologram, but Adora swore, the woman cried. "How

will destroying worlds bring peace?"

Light Hope narrowed her eyes. "You're trying to di-disable me. It will not work. The Heart of Etheria will achieve its function, as will you. *You ...* are She-Ra. This is your destiny."

Mara looked absolutely shocked, but why? "You're not Light Hope", she said. Now Adora was sure she was crying.

"I am the same basic operating system", the hologram responded.

"You're not her!", the other yelled. "And you don't get to tell me what my destiny is." She slammed her hand down on the console once more, making Light Hope disappear. "Activating portal into the dimension of Despondos in three... two... one..."

Then the scene disappeared. Nobody said anything, too stunned by what they had just witnessed. And that was a good thing because it wasn't over yet.

Just like in the Crimson Waste, Mara appeared again in the pilot's seat in the back of the room. "Adora?", she called out, holding out a hand. "I know you're there. Razz said you would be there."

Adora walked closer, willing to press her own to the spot, but before she could, Mara collapsed into the chair with a grunt.

"I don't have much time. I barely made it out. If you are seeing this, it means you are the new She-Ra. It means I failed", she repeated what they already heard. "I don't know what they told you, but it wasn't all bad at first. We were the first ones to settle Etheria, to really study this planet's magic." She took a shaky breath. "How could it go so wrong? You *can't* trust Light Hope. She's been reprogrammed to set off the weapon at *any* cost. The weapon..."

"What weapon?", Adora asked even though the other couldn't hear her. "What happened to you?"

"I didn't know what they were doing until too late. I knew they were rerouting Etheria's magic for their own purposes ... siphoning it, collecting it in the planet's core... The Heart of Etheria Project. It was supposed to be an energy source, capable of so much good ... but that's not what they made. My people turned our planet, all of Etheria, into a weapon. And *She-Ra* is the key."

"What?"

"I opened a portal to a completely empty dimension and pulled Etheria in. I hid us from the rest of the universe, to keep everyone safe. This is the one place they'll never find us. The weapon can't hurt anyone else here. I saw what they would do ... the deaths that would follow... I couldn't stop them before, but I can now. Hiding is our only option", Mara started to talk quicker, more frantic as she went on. "Adora ... this isn't over. The Heart of Etheria is *still* siphoning magic, storing it. It's unstable, it will tear Etheria apart if it goes off again."

"The portal", she mumbled and suddenly felt a hand in hers. Catra.

"So it's up to you now. I couldn't stop it. In the end, I wasn't strong enough. But you… Adora, you will be more powerful than they ever planned." There seemed to have been more turbulences. Then Mara started to cry again. Adora realized that the woman must have known then, that she would die. Still, she smiled. "Adora... I believe in you. You can save the world we love."

This time when the hologram powered down, it didn't go back up again.

They stood in silence as Adora allowed herself to cry a little. In her last moments, Mara never once thought of herself. Only of her people and how she could help the one who would succeed her.

"Mara wasn't crazy. She was a hero, she should have been everyone's hero. And Light Hope…" She didn't even know how to finish that sentence.

"She was brave, my Mara", Razz said and put her pie down on the chair. "She has promised me that we make pie."

Adora went to hug the old woman. She was patted on the arm after a few seconds, so she let go.

"At least I'm still around to make pie", the woman mumbled, which somehow lightened up the mood.

"Well this is fascinating", Entrapta decided to say now. "I've done a lot of research and studies on portals, but they always reached a dead end, like something was blocking them, but that surely explains it. Our planet's portal capabilities must have been shut down when she disabled the system to access the interface."

Then she went to scroll through her pad before showing them something, that apart from herself and maybe Bow nobody could understand.

"The Heart is also an interesting topic", she kept going. "I've come across the term several times when researching First One's tech, but I never figured out what it was. I have however studied this planet's magical distribution. A lot of it flows through the runestones, and data indicates that the princesses were much more powerful a hundred years ago, and even more another hundred years before that. So where did the magic go? It was stored somewhere at the core of the planet, though that was just a theory. Until today!"

She had shown them several different graphs and half-hearted illustrations, but the succession of them was too quick to truly read any of it.

"Okay, but what does that mean?", Adora then asked. "It's a weapon, and She-Ra is the key and it might tear our world apart. Light Hope keeps telling me that I have to balance the planet. I

am guessing it has something to do with this. So, what does that mean and how do we stop it? How can we make sure, it doesn't go off?"

"Well... I don't know", Entrapta said unhelpfully. "I have a theory for the balancing thing, though. If I am correct and the data speaks for itself, the Heart gains its magic through the runestones. If all of them are active, I'd guess, the planetary system could be regenerated and the Heart activated."

"Wait", Glimmer said. "But then why hasn't that happened yet?"

"Judging from folklore, She-Ra has been gone for a thousand years. Her runestone may be smaller, but no less important. Actually, it's the most important. The sword can direct its power. Without her, the planet probably wasn't balanced", Entrapta explained. "Though now that the sword is active again, I have no idea why we haven't all died yet."

"Scorpia", Catra supplied. "She's not connected to her runestone. Shadow Weaver has made sure of that."

"Do we have to be grateful for that?", Adora asked, feeling slightly disgusted at the thought.

"I don't think so. It's not like she did it to save us. If she was here she'd probably tell us to use the Heart", Catra pointed out.

"Right", she agreed. "So, how do we make sure no one uses it?"

No one had an answer to that.

"I mean, logically, any machine that big needs to have a failsafe", Entrapta then pointed out. "But until we find it, I guess our only option is to make sure Scorpia never connects with her runestone."

"Can't we just destroy it for good measure? Just in case?", Glimmer asked, shrugging and trying to look casual, but her voice betrayed the panic.

"I wouldn't advise it", the scientist said. "The runestones have been woven into the planets natural balance. Destroying one could mean irreparable chaotic damage forever." And remembering the Battle of Brightmoon, she was absolutely correct about that — they really shouldn't mess with it.

"Great, so we just hope and pray?", the girl almost screeched.

"Can I do something?", Adora asked. "If She-Ra is the key, there must be something I can do." There needed to be something. Simply hoping wasn't going to do it for her. As long as the Heart remained active, Light Hope would keep terrorizing her because apparently she was responsible for all this now.

Entrapta seemed to honestly think about it, getting the data on her pad to help. Meanwhile, Razz only laughed.

"Silly, Adora", she said without a care in the world. "Your people didn't make She-Ra. They had no control over her, so they made the sword. But She-Ra is so much more than just her weapon"

It rang a bell, weirdly enough. Hadn't Light Hope told her something like this too? That the First Ones had bound She-Ra's magic to the sword? If that control was gone, would it stop the Heart?

She got the bracelet off her arm and stared at the sword. "Entrapta? If we destroy the sword, would that help?"

"What?" Protests came from several directions, but not from Entrapta. That was all that mattered.

"The sword is the key to this planet, but only connected to She-Ra, no integral part of the natural balance. In theory, I would say yes. Destroying the sword should render the Heart useless, while also not causing any irreparable damage to the planet", was the final answer.

"Wait, wait", Glimmer cut in. "Let's think about this."

"What's there to think about?", Catra asked with clear frustration. "We have an option that won't tear the planet apart, let's do it."

"We are still at war", Glimmer pointed out. "Maybe we should focus on that for now. We need She-Ra. The mountains are as good as reclaimed, we need to move into the Fright Zone soon. Who knows what will happen without her."

"Glimmer's right", Bow agreed, even if a bit reluctantly. "We have two threats hanging over us and the Horde is a bit more imminent right now. As long as Scorpia stays away from her runestone, nothing is going to be activated. Right after this is over, we can go destroy the sword."

Adora wasn't sure what to do. She needed to do what Mara told her, which was to stop the Heart, but at the same time, she had a commitment to the rebellion. Could she confidently say that she will be just as helpful without She-Ra?

She sighed. "Fine. But we'll destroy it *right after*", she said.

The two looked relieved. "Yes, we promise", Glimmer said before she and Bow went to hug Adora.

They were right. As long as Scorpia didn't connect with anything, they would be safe. The only problem left was Light Hope. Or better, Angella. She could do a few more days without sleep, but she would have to lie to the queen that she had slept.

And if she managed to jump over that hurdle, her sleep deprivation really wouldn't be that obvious since She-Ra didn't get afflicted with Adora's issues.

It would be fine. At least that's what she believed until she was released from the hug and noticed that Catra was missing.

Chapter End Notes

(little clarification: I am working on a very headcanon basis with Razz, which is that I think she is literally jumping

between Mara's and Adora's time, hence her disappearance here. I also think that she is essentially living in a time loop, so that she relives certain stages of Mara's and Adora's time again and again, hence why she knows that this story isn't canon anymore)
<-- also sorry, if this explanation was unnecessary, but I did feel like it's important

Anyway! Hope you liked it! Until next chapter (for which I will give out no spoilers except for "hehehehehehe") stay hydrated <333

Chapter 21: Consequences - Part 1

Chapter Notes

Warning for mentions of abuse towards the end

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wasn't even sure what she was mad about. She just knew that the feeling overcame her and before she opened her big mouth to hurt anyone, she decided to run.

Maybe the day had drained her — running after that old lady sure wasn't what she would call fun. Maybe her patience had run out, so that being around people had become unbearable.

Or maybe, it was the thing with the sword.

It shouldn't surprise her as much as it did that Adora decided to ignore her opinion on the matter in favor of being the hero. That stupid sword was nothing but trouble and she would gladly see it destroyed. Yes, she did understand that the rebellion might be less powerful without their warrior princess, but they forgot the most important thing.

As long as that sword existed, Adora wouldn't sleep.

The worst part wasn't even that her so called friends chose to value Adora's power over her health, but that the blonde herself did too.

Adora would always choose to be the people's hero, even if it meant that her wants and needs would never be met.

Catra felt like an idiot for ever hoping that it might be different this time.

"Catra!" As if summoned, here she was to worry about Catra instead of herself.

She kept walking. Maybe the blonde wouldn't spot her through the woods. It was dark, after all.

"Catra!" The girl got closer.

For a moment she considered climbing a tree to get out of sight, but they did share a room. Confrontation was inevitable, so why bother?

She let herself be found. "Catra", Adora breathed out in relief. "Are you okay?"

She couldn't help but roll her eyes. "I'm fine. Just tired", she lied. Well, not entirely. Despite Adora's best attempts at comfort, sleep still didn't come easy to her. She wasn't half as sleep deprived as the blonde, but tired nonetheless.

"Oh… I mean, it was a full workout day, chasing after Razz", the blonde joked.

"Exactly", she responded shortly.

She could practically feel the other's eyes on her, but she kept her own trained on the path.

For a long time, Adora didn't say anything, didn't ask anything. If Catra would turn around, she would imagine the other's brows were furrowed, deep in thought. "Is it because you got reminded of the portal? Are you worried about the Heart?", the other then asked. "Is this about the sword?"

"Adora, I'm tired. Just leave it", Catra growled back.

"So it is about the sword", the other mumbled. "Do you really hate seeing me be She-Ra so much, you'd risk us losing the war?"

Catra couldn't believe what she was hearing. A mocking laugh escaped her. "Yeah, like She-Ra will be of much help when Adora can't even walk straight." It wasn't even an exaggeration, the blonde had stumbled several times already. In fairness, it had

been a long day and it was dark, but that usually didn't stop the other from being in top form.

"She-Ra will be fine. She doesn't get affected by my problems", Adora explained.

She just shook her head silently. So a chance to be the hero really was worth self destruction, huh? Maybe she shouldn't judge so hard, considering her own attempts at proving herself and the lack of regard for herself that had come with it. Still, she did.

"Come on, I don't want to fight again", the girl pleaded.

"Then don't", she spat and kept walking. Until Adora reached for her hand, which she swiftly pulled away.

She wished she couldn't see this well in the dark because the hurt in Adora's eyes was unbearable. "I don't understand", she mumbled.

Catra sighed. "You never do", she responded.

"Then explain it to me." There was a pinch of desperation in the other's voice. "You said you wanted to be more open. Please, Catra."

"What's the point? You'll be the hero, no matter what I say. I can't stop you and I won't try. I know how that ends for me", was all she said before she resumed her walk to Brightmoon. Adora didn't follow her.

Somehow, despite the relief at that, she was also sad about it. It meant that she was right, that she couldn't keep Adora from destroying herself.

Of course, Catra could try, but then she remembered the portal. That's where her trying had led. Not only to her own destruction, but the entire planet's. All because she could never stop Adora from anything, least of all being selfless.

The castle quickly came into view and at this point, she did want to go to bed. At the same time, she couldn't bring herself to enter their bedroom. She didn't know what Adora would do, but she would surely show up soon enough and Catra needed a bit more time to herself.

So, she had a choice between the garden or the library to hide out, but she wasn't in the mood for silent reading or learning about her stupid mental health, and everything she had learned about her species had honestly disturbed her. That was why she made her way to the garden.

She probably should have expected that this was where Perfuma had decided to rest. Catra was already turning on her heels to leave for some closet to cry in, when the princess noticed her.

"Catra", she called out. "Would you like to join me?"

As much as she just wanted to be rude and leave, she turned back towards the gardens. She really rather wanted to stay here. "For what?", she asked.

It made the other smile, making Catra regret having asked. "A round of meditation. It helps me to recollect my strength."

"I'm not good at sitting still", she told the other truthfully.

"That's okay", Perfuma said. "We could do yoga, or … just stroll and talk?", she offered with a curious tilt of her head.

Neither of these options were very appealing to her. Though silly positions still beat talking, so she went over. "Let's do the yoga thing", she grumbled reluctantly.

The princess seemed happy either way. "It's a great way to clear your mind", she told her and began guiding her through the breathing and positions.

They started off simple, so Catra could find her center or whatever. It wasn't easy at all. In fact, after about ten minutes,

she just lied about having found it, so they could move on and she could appear a bit less pathetic.

The clear mind part also didn't quite work for her. Whenever Perfuma told her to close her eyes or just stopped talking, she kept thinking about everything.

Adora wasn't completely wrong that the mention of the portal had sent her spiraling a bit — after having heard the message in full, she regretted all of that even more than before. She was an idiot for believing that she could somehow win because of it. Even worse, she had wanted to destroy the work of this woman, who had sacrificed her life to make sure they could live in peace.

Catra hadn't known all that back then of course, but that didn't stifle her guilt at all.

On top of it came the sword. She had come to terms with She-Ra. There was no way she would ever love it, but she could tolerate it. What she couldn't tolerate was that it hurt Adora. And then Catra proceeded to hurt her too. The blonde's sad face in the dark was replaying in her mind.

When had she started to care about the girl so much?

They were friends before, sure, but had they ever been this close? She couldn't tell for sure, but she doubted it. Certainly not in the Horde where every softness would become a weakness. Then they had been enemies and while Catra had admittedly held back for most of it, she hadn't cared much about the other's well-being anymore.

Now she was here and had tried to distance herself as best as she could, only for everyone to push a connection with her and worst of all, it worked. She wasn't going around calling anyone a friend, aside from Adora maybe, but she still … cared.

"Catra?"

The soft voice ripped her out of her thoughts harshly, making her lose balance and fall to the ground.

Perfuma looked down on her in surprise and worry. "Maybe we should try talking, after all", she then said. "With your mind so clouded, the only solution is to vent it out."

Catra got back up. "I don't want to talk."

"It won't offer you any solutions, but it will give you a chance to find some. Talking things through can be very helpful. If I hadn't talked about my issues with Scorpia, I would have never discovered that cacti weren't so bad after all", the princess explained softly and patiently.

"I still don't want to", she growled.

To her frustrations, it didn't seem to faze the other at all. "Catra", she said, still full of softness. "I know that you like to keep your heart guarded and I'm sure you have good reason for that, but I can see that it is hurting you and your friends. I only want to help."

She sighed. "I appreciate it", she grit out. "But I just … can't."

The princess nodded, surprisingly. "That is alright. Healing takes time. And I won't demand anything from you that you are not comfortable with. I just wish for you to be able to unblock your negativity."

"Did you do this with Scorpia, too?", she couldn't help asking.

"I did", the woman said, smiling even brighter — probably because Catra hadn't shut her out completely. "I've seen how much it bothers her, out in the field, to fight her old friends. She was really excited when I offered. We talk and meditate together whenever we have time. And she's really sweet, just a little unpolished."

She snorted. That was one way to put it. "Yeah, social competence isn't a skill we got taught."

"You know she sees you as a friend, right?", the princess asked. "She didn't say it, but I'm pretty sure another part of why she wanted to do it was so she could be a better friend to you."

"Sounds like her", she replied vaguely.

"You care for her, right? At least a little?" It didn't sound very sure, more hopeful, reminding Catra once more that she was a terrible friend.

"I try", she answered honestly.

"That's the most important part", Perfuma said happily. "People are a lot of work, but trust me when I say that it's worth it."

Catra didn't reply anything to it right away. Instead, she chanced a glance to her room — the light was on, Adora was back. Her one friend, who she just couldn't help but constantly fight with. "Fine", she sighed and dragged the flower princess with her to her trusted shed. "I don't want to be seen", she explained shortly.

The confusion on Perfuma's face quickly dissipated. "That is perfectly fine", she said and sat down on the ground despite how dirty it must be. The woman patted the spot next to her, which she reluctantly took. "Alright, this is supposed to feel good, so whatever we talk about is completely up to you. You are free to refuse any topic that you want. I am merely trying to guide you through your emotions."

Catra nodded despite not really understanding what this meant.

Perfuma didn't seem to notice, or she ignored it. "I have a feeling that your past still holds a lot of power over you. If you'd like, you could talk a bit about your old home", she suggested.

An amused scoff escaped her. "That pile of junk isn't anyone's home", she said, but the princess kept patiently looking at her,

waiting for either rejection or agreement."I don't know where to start", she admitted therefore.

"Is any memory coming to mind when you think about the Fright Zone?", the other prompted.

"Not good ones", she mumbled in response.

The woman seemed to understand it for what it was, a refusal to talk. It didn't seem to deter her. "I have heard a bit about life in the Horde. I understand that it wasn't easy. How did you deal with that?"

"It's fine, I got used to it", she told her and shrugged.

Perfuma clearly had to fight to keep the pity from showing on her face, but Catra was grateful for the attempt. "And emotionally?"

Catra wasn't sure what that referred to, but she still tried to find an answer. With the original question in mind, she tried to figure out what she had done to deal with her emotions. "I tried to think about it as little as possible", she mumbled. That included her feelings on the matter, she guessed.

The princess hummed. "How in tune are you with your emotions, would you say?"

She snorted. "Not at all, what do you think?", she replied. That was one thing she wasn't even ashamed of. "The Horde didn't really encourage emotions anyway."

"I have noticed", Perfuma said. "Adora and Scorpia experience similar issues, as far as I can tell", she told her. "Being aware of one's inner workings is a vital first step to relationships, though. If I may, I think that the reason you and Adora fight so much is that neither of you can communicate how you feel."

"Maybe", Catra agreed. She doubted the blonde would understand her regardless, but she didn't want to discuss that.

"Speaking of Adora. There must be good memories with her", Perfuma then prompted.

"Sure", she answered. "We were always together. We comforted each other, we defended each other, we played together, got into trouble together", she listed, leaving out that Catra would always receive more punishment.

"Then what strains your relationship now?"

She sighed. "She left me. Got her sword and didn't care what would happen to me", she said. She refrained from saying anything else, not even to acknowledge that the blonde had come back for her this time around.

"I see." It was clear to Catra that the princess disagreed, but she didn't say that for some reason and only kept smiling. "Have you ever talked to her about how you felt?"

Catra opened her mouth to reply, but then noticed that she didn't know. It was the topic of several of their fights, physical and verbal, but had she ever told the other the whole of it?

"I understand your anger", the other kept talking when there was no response. "It is healthy to let yourself feel it and even vocalize it." Catra raised a brow in surprise. "I am worried that you're holding on to it too much, though. And you can't let go of it, unless you tell Adora how you feel and clear out the air."

"And how do I do that?", she asked. Insulting Adora was a lot easier than being vulnerable with the girl.

"Maybe we could practice it. You could tell me, for a start. How did it make you feel?", Perfuma asked.

Catra hated this. "Angry", she mumbled and the other nodded encouragingly. "I don't know. I was… hurt, I guess. After everything, after they have lied to us and hurt us, she never once thought of leaving, but suddenly she can glow, and she runs off to save everyone else. And now she's going on and on about how

she cares about me and wants to protect me, and expects me to believe it. And I don't need protection, I've survived this far, no thanks to her, and she-"

Perfuma softly cleared her throat. "When voicing our feelings, we should try not to get offensive. Try to stay focused on yourself."

She groaned, but thought about a way to rephrase it anyway. "I never felt protected by her, and when she left, I felt betrayed. We were supposed to stick together, but … I guess we had different ideas about what that looked like. I want to fix things, and I know she does too, but I *feel* like she just wants to ignore everything that happened, and I just can't do that."

"I am proud of you Catra", the other cooed. "That was good. Now, what would you like from Adora? What would you want her to respond or do?"

"I don't know", she mumbled. "I don't really mind most of … her. She just always had a tendency to put others before her, and … I would like it, if she could worry about herself, at least once in a while. I mean, how can she not understand that I have a hard time to believe she cares, when she cannot even care about herself. She doesn't have to be the hero every single time. Eventually, it will kill her and then I-" She stopped herself before she said something stupid. "I just … We're supposed to take care of each other."

Perfuma nodded enthusiastically. "You did great", she told her. Another compliment — it made her face heat up, so she looked away. "I think that was enough for today. You already made some great progress."

"Thanks", she said awkwardly.

"And I think, if you tell Adora what you just told me, you'll be able to grow even closer", the princess said with a smile.

Catra hummed, not willing to give a more committal answer. "I think I'll go to bed now", she said instead.

The other didn't stop her, or called her out on the lack of a response. And during their shared way back inside, she didn't try to force a conversation.

Somehow, she thought, Perfuma must have recognized that she had exhausted all of Catra's talking capabilities for tonight.

Eventually they separated and she readied herself to go into the bedroom. Despite her test run on the princess, and her advice, she still didn't feel like confronting Adora right now. And she wouldn't have to because their room was empty.

The light was on, so the blonde had definitely been here, but she apparently hadn't stayed long.

Catra debated what to do. She could just get to bed and wait for the other to show up. Or she could wait normally and have a very awkward encounter.

She chose the first option, got changed, turned off the lights and lay in bed. There was no way, she would be able to sleep. Even with Adora here, she doubted she would get much of it, so she stared at the wall, listening to the noise of the castle.

Since half of them were out on a mission, and all her neighbors were still out, it was pretty silent apart from the occasional guard stomping by.

At some point, though, she heard different footsteps. Adora's. And Sparkles and Arrow Boy were there too, she supposed, but that was less important.

All that mattered was that she closed her eyes and pretended to be fast asleep when the door opened. She heard them say their goodnights, then the door closed again. Adora changed into her sleep wear and carefully went to lie beside her.

"I know you're not asleep", the blonde whispered then. Catra stood her ground, though, not betraying anything. "You know I have to do this, right?" She really tried to keep her breathing

steady to keep up the illusion of sleep. "It's not because I don't care about what you have to say", Adora kept going regardless. "But sometimes what I want doesn't matter. I have a responsibility to the rebellion."

The girl obviously waited for an answer, but she wasn't getting one. Not because Catra didn't have one, she had several starting with "Screw the rebellion" and ending with "What about your promise to me?", but she didn't say any of it. If she did, she might burst out crying.

Adora sighed. "Goodnight, Catra. Sleep well", she said, without any trace of sarcasm or anger. Just pure sad softness.

Catra almost said it back, but the tightness in her throat reminded her why she couldn't.

She didn't pull away though, when Adora snuggled a little closer. And she may have let her tail move to lay over the other's waist.

Maybe, they could talk tomorrow.

***

Adora had gone back to the ship after Catra had left. She still didn't understand what got the girl so down. She was clearly bothered about something and Adora guessed it was the sword. Catra had been in favor of destroying it, after all. Not very surprising either. Though, Adora had thought that after all this time the feline would have gotten used to She-Ra.

She sighed and tried not to let it show when she reentered the cockpit. "Where's Razz?", she asked when she couldn't spot the woman.

"She went home", Bow answered and excitedly pointed at the seat. "But she left the pie."

"We're not eating it", Adora told him, earning a pout. "It's for Mara." That got some acceptance at least.

"So, where's Catra?", Glimmer then asked.

"She was tired", Adora said. Even though she doubted that, it was what Catra had told her, so it was good enough as an answer. "I am too. We should head back. Let it all sink in and discuss it with the rest of the Alliance when they get back."

"Good idea", Glimmer easily agreed and stretched a little. "What about them?", she then asked, pointing to Entrapta and Emily.

"Entrapta is gonna live here now", Bow said with a chuckle. "I don't think you can convince her to come back with us."

Adora had no doubt about it, so they let the woman be and and left, while listening to Entrapta's reassurances that she will keep researching the Heart as they said their goodbyes. It was quiet on the way back, all of them stuck in their own heads, thinking about all this new information.

Adora's mind was especially crowded. Not only did she finally have confirmation that she couldn't trust Light Hope, but it put their last actual in-person talk in a completely new light — the hologram had told her that being She-Ra was her destiny, that she didn't get to chose. It would mean that if by some chance the planet got balanced, she would even be able to stop it. Light Hope would use her as a part of the machine and she doubted she could fight against it.

She glanced down at her bracelet, her sword. If She-Ra existed before the sword, she would exist after it, too, right? Maybe destroying it wouldn't do much in the great scheme of their plan to defeat the Horde. She-Ra should still be there.

But how? In what way? The sword had made accessing her easy, but without it?

With a sigh, she looked back into the darkness, following her friends. She couldn't risk it. If she didn't know how to transform and someone would get hurt because of it, she would never forgive herself.

"Are you and Catra fighting again?", Bow then asked when they got closer to Brightmoon.

"No", she said quickly. "I don't think so." Catra might be mad at her, but they weren't fighting. Yet.

"It's just, the way she left…", Glimmer pointed out. "It didn't exactly scream happiness."

"Catra's always mad at something. It's going to be fine." She had to believe that.

"If you say so", the princess mumbled, unbelieving, but unwilling to push Adora.

When they got to the castle, the first thing she did was go to their room. It was dark inside, which didn't mean much, but when she turned on the lights there was still no trace of Catra. Wherever she was hiding, she was sending a clear message of wanting to be left alone.

Maybe that was why she took her sweet time getting down to the dining hall to get something to eat. Not that she ate much — Mara's message had taken a good bit of her appetite away and she couldn't stop thinking about the unstable weapon at their planet's core.

Glimmer and Bow tried to lift the mood, but considering they had heard the same thing, it wasn't all that effective.

At some point, she couldn't put off going to bed anymore. She had left the lights on, to let Catra know that she was there at

least, so when she opened the door to find the room in darkness once more, she knew that the other was here.

She tried to change as quietly as possible, but when she lied down next to the girl, she knew immediately that it hadn't been necessary. Catra was only pretending to be asleep. Usually, she wouldn't call her out on it. In the Horde it was only a sign of Shadow Weaver's torment on the girl, but this time Adora had caused it.

So, she did say something. Even when no response came, she kept talking, trying to appeal to the girl, but to no avail.

Catra couldn't be all that mad though, because she let Adora snuggle close without protest.

Adora didn't want to sleep and probably wouldn't be able to either with all these things rummaging in her mind. Maybe the other had a similar problem because it took hours for her to fully fall asleep.

Adora was restless, tossing and turning the entire night. It must have bothered Catra, but since she didn't sleep either, she probably didn't care that much. However, the moment the feline did fall asleep, Adora carefully extracted herself from the sheets.

The girl needed sleep and she wasn't going to risk waking her. Instead she went to quietly pace the room, looking over every so often to make sure the other was still sleeping.

Eventually, with her anxious energy in need of something to do, she carefully opened a drawer in their vanity and reorganized their socks. She felt incredibly stupid, but it kept her busy for a little while. She did the same with their other clothes until everything was neatly folded and stacked. She even put the shards of Entrapta's disk in a neat little pile.

By the time that was done, dawn was already coming, the first bit of light making it easier to see.

After all that pacing and standing for hours, she had to sit down on the ground in front of the newly organized dresser.

She tried to clear her mind, simply looking at anything and everything in the room. Until something new caught her eye.

Something green peeked out from underneath the dresser, so she pulled it out. It was one of the files that she had stolen from the Fright Zone and that Catra had then taken. The rest of them laid on top. This one must have fallen down, but how would it get underneath the dresser?

Curiosity got the better of her, so she opened it.

It was easy to understand how it had landed there — Catra must have hidden it.

The file had reports on their entire squad, with hers and Catra's being the longest, spanning over almost a dozen pages, while the others barely got one.

She didn't care much for the others, though. If Catra had hid it, then their reports would be why. If Catra had hid it, there was probably good reason for it.

Adora glanced up a the girl, straining to hear the soft purring that indicated that she was asleep. Then she started to read.

Her file wasn't at all surprising. She came from a portal, Shadow Weaver saw potential, all of which she already knew.

Her eyes skimmed the text, trying to figure out why Catra would want to hide it from her. It was mostly all praise, which might bother the feline but still wasn't a good reason to hide it away. Similarly, while all their plays and adventures during their childhood were marked as problematic, and Shadow Weaver thought their friendship would be an easy way of manipulation, even if she didn't approve of it and was disgusted by it, it wasn't anything new. They knew that.

Don't get her wrong, it was terrible to read of the extent of manipulation and torture that the sorceress had afflicted upon her, most of which Adora hadn't even realized had been that bad until reading it now. But it wasn't anything terrible enough to make Catra think she would have to hide it from her.

The daymoon was peaking over the woods already by the time she had finished skimming her report. She could hear the morning guard change outside in the hallway.

Maybe… maybe she was thinking about this the wrong way. Catra was blunt and wouldn't shy away from pointing out all the wrongs of the Horde to others. It was her own pain, she usually hid away.

Adora felt like she was invading the girl's privacy, but she still pulled up Catra's report.

Shadow Weaver seemed to have hated Catra from the moment she first saw the girl. She noted that the feline was impulsive and aggressive and rebellious — all the things Adora loved in her friend, that the sorceress saw as a threat to her power.

When the two became friends, Shadow Weaver marked it with potential to manipulate, but hated it all the same. Adora might have been an easy target, but Catra wasn't.

Breathing became harder the more she went on. When Catra had scratched out Octavia's eye, Shadow Weaver decided that she rather wanted the girl dead, but couldn't kill her off since it meant losing power over Adora.

Everything the sorceress did after was specifically designed to break Catra in any way that was possible. It was all in here, in great detail. Every single time the girl had been punished or threatened throughout her life, every moment Adora wasn't there for because Shadow Weaver preferred talking to Catra alone, every pain that her friend refused to talk about.

Every slap and hit, every scar, every shadow, every lightning bolt, every time Shadow Weaver illustrated to the girl how easily she

could be killed.

By the time she got to the end, she was crying and breathing heavily. And she was angry. Adora had never felt this much anger before, not even in the portal.

To imagine that none of that would have had to happen if Shadow Weaver had just left them alone. If Catra wouldn't carry all that with her, would she have made different decisions? She thought so. Adora probably would have, too. She wouldn't have healed the sorceress for one.

Adora took a few deep breaths and wiped her tears. The moon was well in the sky and she knew everyone was going to wake up any minute. She had to be gone before that.

Chapter End Notes

hehe...

Chapter 22: Consequences - Part 2

Chapter Notes

> warning for angst, and some liberties I've taken with the magic system
>
> I have unironically never been so scared to upload a fanfiction chapter before... I have so many doubts and worries, please don't hate me...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora grabbed her clothes that were neatly stacked on a little chair and got dressed quietly. Every so often, she looked over to make sure Catra didn't wake up.

Her brain was running on autopilot as she walked through the halls. Some of the guards looked at her in confusion, but they didn't stop her. They had no reason to.

It didn't take long to reach the stables, it took longer to find where Swift Wind had run off to to plan his horse revolution.

He had taken to the meadow near the woods and she hated waking him, but while she would love to do this on her own, she wouldn't be fast enough without him. "Swifty?" She touched his back, applying a bit of pressure. It did the trick.

"Adora?", a groggy voice asked. "Is something wrong?"

"Sort of", she admitted, looking back to the castle, making sure no one would stop her. "I need your help."

"Of course. I am your noble steed", he said with conviction, apparently awake enough to let his mane wave dramatically in the wind. "I'm here to support you."

"Good. We'll need to go to the Fright Zone", she told him, which seemingly made his confidence waver a bit.

"The Fright Zone?", he repeated as if to make sure he heard it right. "But … that's where the Horde lives. Shouldn't you have backup?"

She shook her head. "No, this is something I have to do alone", she said. "It's okay if you don't want to come, but-"

"Of course I'll come", Swift Wind said easily. "It is my duty to stand by your side. And … something is clearly wrong. I'm not leaving you alone."

"Thank you." She climbed onto his back and they were off.

The only thing separating the Fright Zone from Bright Moon was the Whispering Woods, so their way really wasn't long, and yet it felt like forever to her.

Once they were finally past the woods, she told Swift Wind to fly low and try to reach the back without being seen.

Considering he was literally rainbow colored against the green metal of the Fright Zone, it wasn't easy, but they managed — it was early, the guards were tired and didn't pay much attention.

When they made it, she got off of him and took a look around to make sure they were safe. "Stay here", she told Swift Wind then, but before she could walk off, he bit into her jacket to stop her.

"Adora, whatever is going on, I want to be by your side. It's my duty to make sure nothing happens to you", he said.

She couldn't help but smile. "I know, Swifty", she whispered, leaning her head against his. "But I need to do this alone. Don't worry, everything will be fine. I'm not trying to take down the entirety of the Horde." Just one person.

It was clear that her friend was still antsy, but she gave him a reassuring smile and snuck inside.

Considering what a disaster their rescue mission for Glimmer and Bow had been, it was laughably easy to get inside now. Maybe she had been right all along and should have just gone alone back then. Luckily they hadn't needed to go at all this time.

This wasn't a rescue mission, though. She didn't need to find out where to go, or sneak anyone out, and she was just one person who could easily hide when someone crossed her path. She knew where the Black Garnet chamber was, and she knew Shadow Weaver practically lived there. She also knew that no one would care to check up on her, no matter what noises came from the inside.

She took another deep breath and then walked in.

The sorceress glared, probably expecting some idiot cadet to sneak into her sanctum, but when she saw Adora her eyes widened in surprise. "Adora", she said so softly that she almost believed it.

In fact, she had believed it, once upon a time, that the woman actually cared, that in some twisted way she might even love her. And Shadow Weaver really might, but any love Adora had held for the woman had vanished when she got to around age seven of Catra's file.

Still, she couldn't just walk up to the sorceress because she would surely suspect something and Adora needed the element of surprise to succeed. It was also the reason she hadn't transformed into She-Ra yet.

"Dear child, I always knew you would be reasonable", the woman said, coming closer.

It was only when she was close enough to reach out to touch Adora's cheek, that she finally moved. Her fist connected with the

other's chin so quickly and harshly that it was only followed with stunned silence.

Adora swore she saw a crack in the mask. "We're past that", she growled. "I'm here for my friend and I will make sure you can never hurt anyone ever again."

The sorceress chuckled as she straightened back up. "I see you have gotten around to reading the files you have stolen from me", she said. "I'm surprised it took you so long. I imagine that brat has hidden them from you."

She had her sword pointed at the woman's throat before she could even fully form the thought to do so. "Don't even try", she told her. "I know everything."

"Do you now?" Shadow Weaver didn't appear scared at all. "For Catra you were only a means to an end, she just needed you to protect her. Once she doesn't need you anymore, do you think your *affections* will be returned?"

Adora hated the way the woman said that, but she also found it a bit funny — oh, how little Shadow Weaver knew. They were already through it all, the separation and the hurt, and they had come back to each other. She was willing to bet some care must be returned.

"You have no idea", she laughed. "But even if she were what you think she is, I'd still do this. Because you've hurt my friend and I'm gonna make sure you pay."

Shadow Weaver sighed. "If that's what you wish."

The woman would not go down without a fight, which Adora had known, and she was prepared to fight too. "For the honor of Grayskull!", she called out quicker than the shadows could engulf her.

Her own light destroyed them before they could do any damage. Then she swung at the sorceress.

She had never seen Shadow Weaver fight, only threaten and hurt innocent children. Somehow, she had always reasoned, the woman must know how to hold her own, but Adora had to admit that she was good even.

But no matter how good, Adora was younger and faster. Whenever the sorceress tried to strike, she cut through the magic with her sword or defended against it with her shield.

The only problem was that Shadow Weaver hid in the shadows of her own creation, making it hard for Adora to figure out where the woman actually was — she would have to find her if she wanted to do real damaged and she had never wanted anything more.

In an attempt to get to the sorceress, she got more ruthless by the second, tearing the walls apart and whatever machinery or sorcery ingredients that were around the room, even accidentally destroying the mechanism for the door. At some point she swore her sword must have also collided with the runestone, but she couldn't focus on it.

She would do anything to finally get to her target.

But Adora didn't manage to get closer, no matter what. She wouldn't give up so soon, though. Her imagination fueled her anger with everything she could now picture has happened in this room.

"You are wasting your energy", the sorceress eventually said, though it sounded strained. The woman was exhausted. "Do you think the princesses care about you? That they'll praise you for striking me down?"

"I know they don't approve", Adora answered even if she knew she shouldn't give into it. "But I don't care!" She sliced through another wall of shadows, and thanks to their talking, she knew the woman was right behind it, so she send some magic down the path as well.

Shadow Weaver grunted, so Adora must have hit something of her.

"These people are not your friends. They just want to use you, don't you see that?", Shadow Weaver tried again.

If she weren't so focused on her surroundings, Adora might have rolled her eyes. "All I see is a pathetic attempt at saving your own life", she grit out. "Didn't you see that coming? That your actions would have consequences?"

There was no reply to that. Maybe the woman finally realized that she wouldn't get far trying to manipulate Adora.

The attacks also stopped coming, so she guessed it was more likely due to trying to be sneaky.

She used the break to focus all the energy inside her to send out a blast in all directions. It effectively made the shadows surrounding her disappear while also hitting Shadow Weaver, who slumped against a half standing wall.

Adora didn't waste a second to let her fist connect with the sorceress' head once more, though this time it was to destroy the crystal that connected the woman with the runestone.

Surprisingly, Shadow Weaver cried out in pain because of it. Not that it mattered as Adora focused the tip of her sword on the woman once more.

She remembered that talk she has had with Catra forever ago. The girl had told her that she wanted to see Shadow Weaver dead, and she had responded that she wouldn't stand in the way even if she thought it was wrong.

And now it would be so easy to kill the woman. It was what she had come here to do. And yet, she still couldn't bring herself to do it because she *knew* it was wrong. In any case, it should be Catra's call.

Her hesitation was noticed when the sorceress let out a low laugh. "You are too good, Adora", she said, again in that overly affectionate tone.

"You overestimate me", Adora answered calmly. "The only reason I'm not going to kill you is because I'm sure Catra would love to do it herself."

Shadow Weaver didn't respond, at least.

From her experiences the first time, she knew that the woman wouldn't fight anymore. She couldn't, not until Adora healed her. Whatever dark magic she had been using, it would kill her soon enough anyway. And it made her weak enough to not having to worry about her much.

She took a step back, running calculations through her head on how to best smuggle the sorceress out of here. Adora could easily carry her as She-Ra, but what if they got caught? Then again, she could probably take a few soldiers.

Contemplatively, she looked down at her sword and shockingly noticed a hair thin crack in it. How did that happen?

Adora took a deep breath before panic could overtake her. It was fine, they wanted to destroy it eventually anyway, and until then, she just had to be a bit more careful. Maybe if they took the back way through the storage units, she could avoid as many fights as possible.

She was just about to step towards Shadow Weaver again, to drag her with her, when she suddenly couldn't move anymore. There was something around her, some light. Even the sorceress looked surprised.

In her struggle, she lost her grip on her sword and with that on She-Ra, feeling completely defenseless as her surroundings started to change.

***

Catra woke up when the daymoon started to blind her, which was too early thanks to the terrible placement of the window in their room. Still, despite that and not having slept for at least half the night, she felt rather rested. And she hadn't had any nightmares tonight.

When she finally cracked her eyes open, she noticed that something was off. Adora wasn't here.

It wasn't a weird thing in itself, the girl was usually awake before her and knew how to keep busy, but something about it today still felt off to Catra.

She really tried to shake the feeling, convincing herself that Adora was probably already in the dining hall or something, but when she went to grab her clothes, she saw it — the open file next to the dresser.

A closer look revealed what she feared to be true. Somehow Adora had found their file that she had hidden away. She had made sure it couldn't be seen — unless the girl had lied down on the ground, of course, but what were the chances?

Not in her favor, apparently.

Catra didn't get dressed. Instead she jumped out the window and ran to the stables on all fours.

She hoped against hope that Adora didn't do the stupid thing that she had feared she would do once she found the reports.

Knowing that Swift Wind wouldn't stay in the stables, she searched through the yard, the gardens, the meadow — anything that had grass — yelling out that horse's name, but nothing. He was gone. Of course he was.

Her lungs were failing her, but she kept running. This time her destination was inside the castle.

She made it in record time and had no energy to quietly open doors anymore.

When Sparkles fell out of bed, she shortly felt sorry, but her own heavy breathing reminded her of what she was here for. "I need you to teleport me", she got to the point, when the princess stood again and looked about ready to insult her.

At her request, she seemingly forgot all about her curses. "What?", was all she got out.

"Adora is gone. Swift Wind too. She found the file. She's in the Fright Zone and I need to get some sense into her before she does something she'll regret", she rambled all in one breath, that she barely had to begin with.

"Whoa, what? Catra, calm down", Sparkles said, carefully taking her hands and forcing her to sit down. "What happened?"

"I don't know. Adora found the file, our file, where all the bad stuff is written down. I hid it because I knew she would do something stupid, but she found it and she's gone and now she's doing the stupid thing", she tried to explain better, though she doubted it worked.

Still, the girl nodded. "How can I help?"

"I need you to teleport me to the Fright Zone", she repeated.

"Catra, I'd love to help you, but I'll have run out of power before we even make it halfway to the Fright Zone", the princess told her.

"No", she said confidently. "I know you can do it. I know you're more powerful than that. You're dad was a sorcerer, right? You just need to use all the magic within you." She had seen it before. Sure, the princess had gotten help from Shadow Weaver, but

Catra believed wholeheartedly that the girl could do it on her own just the same.

"I don't know how to do magic", she pointed out.

"Please, Glimmer, try it. If not for me then for Adora or the rebellion or something. She's in danger. Please." Catra wasn't one for begging, but in this moment it came very easy to her.

There was something in the other's face, some emotion she couldn't place. "Okay", was the answer eventually. "I'll try, but don't be mad if it doesn't work."

"Deal", she agreed maybe a bit too quickly, but it didn't seem to bother the other much.

"Can we at least get dressed. I really don't wanna go to the Fright Zone in my pajamas", the princess then mumbled apologetically.

"Fine", Catra grit out. In her mind, it was time wasted, but she understood that showing up in sleepwear was not the best of ideas.

Back on all fours, she sprinted back into her own room to pick up the clothes that she had dropped earlier, and quickly put them on, but she didn't bother with her hair. By the time she had run back to the other girl's room, Sparkles surprisingly already waited for her — as slow as she knew the princess to be, she was truly shocked, but grateful.

"Okay", the girl then said and took her hands again. "I'll teleport us to the moonstone first. A bit more space and a chance to recharge a bit", she reasoned and Catra nodded.

Even when she was braced for it, she dry heaved every time, but at least she didn't vomit and she collected herself rather fast. "Now what?", she asked.

"I should ask you that", the princess pointed out. "You said I can do it. How?"

Catra didn't know, but she didn't spend half her childhood in Shadow Weaver's vicinity and not pick up a bit of sorcery. It wasn't a lot since it wasn't really useful knowledge to her, but it was something.

"You have two different power sources. The runestone and whatever you get for sorcery", she said. "You know the runestone, but you need to connect to the sorcery."

The other hummed. "And how do I do that?"

"I don't know. It's there. I know it is, I know you are incredibly strong, you just need to allow yourself to be confident in that." Most of it sounded like nonsense to Catra, but she wasn't lying. When the girl had abducted her that one time, she had proven that she had more strength than anyone was expecting her to have.

Glimmer took her hands, then she closed her eyes and took a deep breath. All the while Catra prayed to whoever would listen. If this didn't work, her only other option was walking — there was no way she could get to the girl then. She already didn't know if she might be too late.

Before she could spiral, the air around her shifted. Something was happening, something that the princess was doing. She braced herself for the teleport long before it happened. But the more energy started to surround them, the more she expected it.

Sparkles' face wasn't calm anymore, but frowning and full of tension as the magic thickened until it encased them.

And then, Catra felt the somewhat familiar feeling of being teleported.

When the feeling stopped, she turned to do her obligatory dry heaving before she even had a chance to look around. They weren't inside the Fright Zone exactly, but they were not far away either. They had already crossed a bit more than half of the wasteland before it — maybe a few hundred meters more and

they would cross into the Horde's territory. Reaching the center shouldn't be too much of a hassle from here.

"I did it", the princess whispered in wonder.

Catra forced a little smile onto her face. "You did", she affirmed it. "We need to find Adora", she reminded then and started running.

Since Glimmer only barely kept up with her as is, she resisted the urge to run on all fours again, though she would prefer it as it was faster.

It was still early, and the outskirts of the Fright Zone were rather empty, which didn't surprise her much — security ironically was neither Shadow Weaver's nor Hordak's strongest suit. She just hoped the inside was just as lazy.

"Swift Wind!", she suddenly heard behind her and stopped to look at the other girl, who looked up. Sure enough, she saw the rainbow horse above them."Down here!", Sparkles yelled and the horse came down to them.

"You're here! Good!", he called out. He looked worried.

"Where is Adora?", she asked right away because nothing else mattered right now.

"She's inside, but something bad is happening. I know it. She's probably fighting someone. I don't know. I don't like it, I should be there", he rambled full on nervous energy, a feeling that Catra understood.

"Let's go then", she decided and ran off again. She could hear the other two following her.

"Do you even know where to go?", Sparkles asked her from atop the horse — the teleportation must have exhausted her.

"I've got an idea", she shot back and kept going, this time on all fours again since Swift Wind could easily keep up.

Catra had paced this place so many times in her life, she could find anything in there. She could also easily avoid the guards because she knew their schedules by heart. Schedules that Shadow Weaver has apparently not thought about changing.

They weren't as fast as she wanted to be, but they got steadily closer.

Almost there.

"Wait", Swift Wind suddenly said, making them all stop.

"What?", Catra growled. She couldn't stop, they were almost there.

But the horse looked disturbed enough that she waited. "She's gone", he then said.

"What do you mean she's gone?", Sparkles asked when Catra's throat felt too tight to do anything but force air into her lungs.

"I don't know how to describe it, but since she transformed me I've been able to feel where she is, but now I don't", the horse clarified. "She was right there and now-"

She didn't bother to listen to the rest of that, and instead took off again, barely paying attention if the others followed her.

The Black Garnet chamber hadn't been much farther, but when she tried to open the door, it wouldn't budge. Catra slammed her hand against the button until it broke, then she cut the door into pieces. There was no time for patience.

The entire room was in shambles, but not a single person was in sight. All that was there was Adora's sword.

Catra numbly went over and picked it up.

"You're too late", an all too familiar voice croaked out then.

Shadow Weaver leaned against a wall that was barely standing, and looked closer to death than she had ever seen her. Adora had been here, no doubt. "What did you do?", she growled, her claws still extended, ready to cut the woman's throat. If this had something to do with this witch, she swore she would kill her.

"I didn't do anything", the sorceress told her, though. "And I won't tell you anything either."

She couldn't stop herself if she tried, so she gave into the impulse to grab the woman and hold her against the wall so that she could look her in the eyes. "I would talk if I were you."

"Your threats mean nothing to me. You still are nothing more than a nuisance", the sorceress hissed.

"I think they mean a lot", Catra challenged. "If you actually hold value to anything, it's your own life. If you want to keep it, talk."

They only stared at each other for a long long time, willing the other to break. But Catra had noticed the cracked mask, the lack of a crystal atop of it — this one time, she was the one with the upper hand and the sorceress nothing but powerless.

And she knew it. "She was taken", came the answer as expected.

"By whom?"

"I wouldn't know." The woman shrugged. "All I know is that before Adora had the chance to finish what she started, a green light appeared and she was gone."

Catra let go suddenly enough that Shadow Weaver dropped to the ground like a sack of potatoes. Then she picked up the sword again that she had let go of in favor of lifting the old woman. She couldn't help but wonder — if they would have destroyed it like they should have, would Adora have still come here?

What's more was that Adora had gone weeks without proper sleep, and without She-Ra, she was completely defenseless at the

moment. Wherever she was now.

"Catra!", Sparkles called for her when she finally caught up. "Where is she?", she then asked when she couldn't spot Adora.

She didn't answer, only gripped the sword tighter as she stared at it with renewed hate. Under her glare, she noticed a crack in it. Adora had damaged it — but what in this room would be strong enough to withstand a hit from She-Ra?

"Catra?", the princess softly tried to get her attention.

A hand landed on her shoulder, but she pushed it away as she looked around. She had seen that sword cut through almost anything, so what could possibly damage it?

Her eyes landed on the runestone. The sword was a runestone too. This stupid, terrible sword, that stole her best friend *again*.

Before anyone could stop her, or she could think this through, she took a few steps forward and starting to hit the runestone with the sword as hard as she could.

She did hear the protests from Glimmer and Swift Wind, and she swore even Shadow Weaver, behind her, but clearly none of them were brave enough to get in her way — considering she was wildly flinging an almost indestructible sword around, that was probably a good idea.

It didn't take many hits for Catra to run out of anger and start crying. It took a few more until a blast of light threw them all back.

Her back hurt when she tried to get up, so she cowered on the ground for a few more seconds, letting the last of her tears stain her face. The runestone was still there, but in her hands was only the hilt of what once was a sword. The rest of it was strewn about the room.

"Have you completely lost it?!", Glimmer asked then, pushing herself up first. "I know you hate She-Ra, but did you maybe think that you could have killed us!"

Catra only scoffed, even though she realized now that the girl was right.

"You could have done more than just kill us! You could have destroyed the runestone! Have you not listened to anything Entrapta said?!", the princess screeched.

"Have I listened?!", she spat back, finding enough energy in her again to get up. "Have you listened when you told Adora to keep the sword even though it was killing her, not to mention is a danger to us all?!"

"Was!", Glimmer corrected. "Congrats, you saved the planet! Now what? Adora is still gone, and now so is She-Ra!"

"If you would have let Adora destroy the sword, like she should have, she never would have come here!"

Glimmer scoffed. "If you had just talked to her about the files, like I told you to, you could have stopped her!"

"Ladies!", Swift Wind finally went in between them. "I think the how and why doesn't really matter right now. Where is Adora?"

Catra took a few deep breaths, but it didn't really help her calm down. "I don't know", she answered truthfully. "Taken by someone, if she's to be believed", she said with a nod to Shadow Weaver, who seemingly got knocked out by the blast.

Sparkles sighed, also trying to stay calm. "So, what do we do now?"

She stared back down at what was left of the sword — she was starting to think that maybe she should not have destroyed it. After all, it was the only thing of Adora they had left right now. "I don't know", she repeated and ignored the tears that kept running

down her face. "We could kill her since Adora has already started to", she grumbled because, even if this situation would not be also her fault, she still deserved it.

"No!", both Glimmer and Swift Wind said. "You have got to relax. We are not murderers", the princess empathized. "We can take her prisoner, though", she compromised.

Catra rolled her eyes. "Fine. Let nature take care of her", she mumbled.

The girl found a bit of rope somewhere in the chaos and bound the woman just in case, while Catra took care of finding at least most of the shards from the sword. Then they both pushed the woman onto Swift Wind.

After that, they stood there for a few seconds as they all had a bit of processing to do. Adora was gone, Shadow Weaver was defeated and … if they were already in the Fright Zone…

"We should go before someone spots us", Sparkles then said, right as Catra had gotten a different idea. "We'll find her, don't worry", the girl told her in an attempt at comfort, but for once she wasn't thinking about Adora.

"In a minute", she only mumbled and made her way down the hall as quickly as she could. Glimmer was right, the longer they were here, the more dangerous it became for them, which is why she tried to be fast.

If they were already here, they really should take advantage of it.

Finding Hordak's sanctum was just as easy as the Black Garnet chamber. And the guy wasn't expecting a visit, as was obvious by the lack of bravado, and armor. A quick look around also revealed his little gargoyle to be lazing around.

She had imagined this moment differently, more difficult and confrontational, but in the situation she found herself in, Catra was pretty okay with something easy and sneaky.

With as much stuff as he had lying around, she quietly picked up the first heavy thing she could find, carefully snuck up to him and hit him with it with all her strength.

He fell forward in his chair with barely a grunt. This really was a bit anticlimactic.

His abomination did spot her then and came flying right at her to, probably, scratch her eyes out, but she defended herself with the piece of scrap metal she had hit Hordak with. She had hoped that she could knock out the little beast too, but that thing was too quick.

She was eventually saved by a pink blast and an extremely angry looking Glimmer.

"Thanks", was all Catra said to her before she grabbed some wires, for lack of better things around, and bound Hordak like they had Shadow Weaver.

"Thanks?", Glimmer scoffed. "What is wrong with you? I get that you're worried and maybe a bit desperate, but that doesn't mean you can just run away and make big decision completely without us!"

Swift Wind nodded. "We are your friends, you should talk to us", he said.

Catra meanwhile tried her best to drag Hordak over to the horse — the guy was heavy, even without his armor. "You want me to talk? I'm pissed! Because Adora just cannot stop being the hero, even though she told me that killing Shadow Weaver would be wrong, but of course she'll do it when she thinks she needs to protect me." She turned to look at Glimmer. "And I'm pissed at you because you didn't let her destroy the sword because you were worried, and now look! We defeated the Horde completely without her!", she yelled. "And you!" She glared at the horse. "Why did you bring Adora here?!"

"Because she asked me to, I didn't know what she was planning", he defended.

"Then ask!"

"Okay!", the princess spoke up again. "I get it, you've got all the reasons to be angry. You could have still talked your decisions through with us."

"How about I do better next time my best friend gets abducted thanks to her hero complex?", she hissed in response.

"Catra", the girl sighed and helped get Hordak onto Swift Wind. "I'm worried too, you know? And I'm angry with her too. But you can't let that out on us."

"I know", she mumbled. Lashing out and pushing people away still seemed to come very natural to her, but she did know that it was wrong.

The little admission seemed to placate the princess for now. "We can talk more about that later, but first, we need to get out here. We won't be able to help Adora by getting caught."

Catra could agree with that, too. So, she lead them without any more protest or running off.

She heard commotion in the distance — someone had probably found the destroyed Black Garnet chamber, and it seemed that the Horde became a lot more lively now that the day had fully begun. That was why she chose the lesser used corridors at the back, which mostly lead to storage and rooms full of contraband. If things truly hadn't changed too much, everyone would get to training or meetings, and the few outliers down here shouldn't give them much trouble.

It was almost relieving when they stepped outside. At least they had accomplished something — the war was practically over with both the Horde's leaders now prisoners of the rebellion — and they managed to not get hurt.

They did loose Adora, though.

And as it turned out, that was the least of the problems they had to face.

Not in the form of any soldiers, but in the sky. Hundreds of ships hovered over their planet and Catra had a feeling she knew who they belonged to, but that shouldn't be possible. It wasn't possible.

"What is that?", Sparkles asked, a spike of panic in her voice. It confirmed that Catra did not hallucinate.

"We need to call a meeting. Now", was all that Catra answered. Her mind was too crowded with worries to formulate any other sentences.

Glimmer then worriedly tried to figure out how they would get back, since she did not have enough energy to teleport them again, but Swift Wind easily offered to carry them all, even if it would surely exhaust him.

Catra barely noticed any of the discussions and couldn't even remember how she got onto the horse's back. Her mind was too occupied with the looming threat above them.

If she was correct, then she could only hope that Adora was okay.

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Adora suddenly stood in a white room. It was mostly empty, save for someone who sat in a chair right in front of her.

What was happening? Where was she?

"You're not my brother", the person in the chair said. He sounded calm, if not a little confused. "I have received this transmission. It took me a while to determine its source and it has lead me to this interesting planet. This is all very curious."

Adora was inclined to agree. "Who are you?", she asked instead, though.

The guy laughed, though it sounded bored. "That shall not concern you, child", he said and looked at her so intensely, she couldn't help squirm. "You are familiar, but I don't think we've met before." He stood up and walked a bit closer, making her take a few steps back to keep them at distance. "I had aimed for my brother, but something in this dimension must have confused my machinery."

The Heart, if Adora had to take a guess. Though, she didn't quite know how that made any sense.

"So familiar", he kept going. "Yes, I must have fought one of your ancestors."

That took her by surprise. "You fought the First Ones?", she couldn't help but ask.

"Yes, that's right", he told her, way too calm for this type of conversation. "They were quite a pest." He looked at her too intensely for comfort. Something about that made her skin crawl.

"What do you want?", she asked, instinctively reaching for her bracelet, but … her sword wasn't there. She had dropped it.

Whatever was happening, she did not like this guy and she doubted his intentions were in any way good. How was she supposed to protect the planet without her sword? She didn't even know where she was.

"I desire only peace and order", he said, spreading out his arms like he wanted her to understand that the sterile white and a lack of furniture was exactly that. "I can see your planet lacks that,

even more so now that my brother has tainted it with his conquest. For order to thrive, this whole mess must be wiped away."

It was then that Adora realized who was in front of her. This was the rest of the Horde army that Shadow Weaver had told her about back in their old life. She had a bad feeling about this. "I won't let you do anything to this planet."

He stared at her curiously once more. "Yes, of course. The valiant protector", he said with a certain amusement in his voice. Like he didn't believe she could do anything to him. "I am not disappointed that it was you I found. I do hope you will be cooperative."

Adora was panicked and confused all the same. She knew that this was bad, and she realized that he must have recognized something in her just now — just like Shadow Weaver had when she had decided to raise her, this guy must know she was magic. And she had no idea what she was supposed to do now.

And why was she supposed to be cooperative? Cooperative in what?!

Despite her rapidly beating heart, she stood up straighter. "No", she then said loud and sure. "I won't let anyone hurt my planet. And I won't be helping you with anything."

"Disappointing", the guy sighed. "But worry not. All creatures have a place in service of Horde Prime."

If it wouldn't have made the fear inside her grow even bigger, she might have acknowledged that she had a name now. But she was too panicked. She had no sword, no power and was stuck with this maniac in a place that she didn't even know where it was. She had no idea what was going to happen to her now.

Worst of all, she had exhausted herself too much. The lack of sleep, the fight against Shadow Weaver and now this, it left her

defenseless against the arms that grabbed her and carried her away.

She did find the pride in her to fuel her legs enough to at least walk to her doom, though.

On the way she also found some windows and could clearly see now where she was. In space. She was on a space ship. Now she didn't even dare start to hope that she could escape.

Luckily — or not depending how she looked at it — she was only thrown into a cell by two guys who looked identical, and like a cleaner version of Hordak. It was creepy.

They didn't say anything to her, only did their job and left.

Adora looked around her cell. It was quite comfortable. Not Brightmoon's idea of a prison, but definitely a step up from the Fright Zone. Though, the translucent barrier and the lack of privacy it entailed was just as bad.

She sighed and sat down on the bed.

She had no sword, it was now lying beside Shadow Weaver. She had left the rebellion without saying anything. Swift Wind was still there, but he also wouldn't know where she was or what happened to her — just as Angella had predicted, she did end up in a situation where no one would know if she had died. At least she didn't drag anyone else into this mess with her.

As she sat there, on a bed that felt even harder than the Horde standard, she felt oddly empty. At first she thought it was probably because all her strength and rage was gone, but she soon realized the real reason.

Adora couldn't feel She-Ra anymore.

There was no energy left in her to truly panic about that, but she was still worried.

What was she supposed to do now?

Chapter End Notes

So, THIS is what the tag "it gets better before it gets worse again before it gets better again" refers to. THIS is where it gets worse.
Because what would be worse than seperating these two again?

Stay hydrated <3333

Chapter 23: Horde Prime

Chapter Notes

I have a love-hate relationship with this chapter... One day I hate it, the next I like it, then I hate it again xD Well, right now I like it, so I hope you do too <33

(Also, I had to check something a few chapters ago to make sure a scene still made sense (I can't remember what's canon in my own fanfic lol) and I noticed a whole lot of typos... That's the price of not having a beta reader, I guess xD one day I might go back and fix that, but for now I'll live with the shame and apologize once more for the typos that I'm sure are in here, too)

Now! Have fun!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Where have you been?!", Angella's voice boomed through the hallway when they had made it back. A guard must have alerted her, but Catra couldn't tell for sure, she hadn't been paying attention.

Bow was right behind her, looking just as worried. "Are you okay? What happened?", he asked more quietly, though with an anxious shriek to his voice.

The queens eyes landed on her. "Is that the sword?"

"Where is Adora?", the boy added after having done a head count.

"What is going on with all these ships hovering above the planet?", the captain of the guards joined in then.

"What happened to them?", Bow asked, pointing at their prisoners on Swift Wind's back.

"Everyone quiet!", Glimmer yelled then, and it did become silent with even the guards in the background stopping in their tracks to avoid making any sound. If Catra hadn't been so occupied by her racing thoughts, she might have been impressed.

The princess looked at her then, as if asking for guidance or an explanation, but she had neither. She could barely even think in coherent sentences, she was admittedly afraid, and she was certainly not in any condition to hand out orders.

Which must show on her face because the girl sighed. "Swift Wind, I hate to ask this of you, but someone needs to alert the princesses in the mountains", she said apologetically.

The horse nodded without hesitation. "On it", he replied and let some guards help him get their prisoners off of him before making his way outside again.

"Bow, please alert everyone on the grounds. We need to hold a meeting", she kept going, and the boy also nodded before doing what he had been told. "And mom, we need to take care of them for now", she finished, pointing at the two people, still knocked out, on the floor.

The queen didn't answer right away, instead eying Catra with worry. Well, Catra was worried too, and she couldn't look the woman in the eyes — this was her fault, after all. She couldn't prove it yet, but she just knew it.

Glimmer shook her head. "Leave her. She hasn't been responsive since we left the Fright Zone."

"What?", Angella asked, sounding extremely alarmed now.

"I'll explain when everyone is here, I promise. But we need to deal with Hordak and Shadow Weaver first."

The woman nodded and instructed the guards on where to put them. If Catra hadn't been so mentally absent, she might have

made fun of the request to put them in a spare room, but as it was, she couldn't care less.

She was left alone then, standing frozen in the middle of the hallway, a tight grip on the remains of the sword, with her mind too occupied to move. She should probably go to the war room to be present for the meeting that she wanted to have, but she felt paralyzed with the questions that repeated themselves in her brain.

How did Prime get here? Why did he come here? Why did he take Adora? How was she supposed to explain this?

She didn't know the answers to any of these questions, though she had the crippling feeling that all of this was her fault somehow.

That Adora had been taken definitely was — Glimmer was right, she should have talked to Adora, if not about the files, then about everything she had discussed with Perfuma, maybe then the girl would have stayed. Maybe not, staying had never been Adora's strong suit.

But maybe, if she hadn't been so damn stubborn, they would have stayed up talking the entire night. Maybe it would have distracted Adora, and she never would have found the files.

Maybe. Catra started to hate that word. But maybe if Adora was here, she wouldn't feel so alone and uncertain.

Prime would have showed up either way, probably, but at the very least she could have had Adora — wasn't it ironic how much she missed the girl already? After such a long time of pushing her away, all it took was a few weeks being side by side, just like old times, and Catra couldn't imagine having to sleep alone anymore.

She shook her head. It didn't matter. The bigger problem was Prime.

He shouldn't be here. Why would he be here? The portal never happened, the message was never sent, how would he know how to get here? No one in their right mind would think to visit an empty dimension unless they *knew* it wouldn't be empty. So, how?

Did Hordak manage to build a portal again? Without Entrapta, unlikely — the guy hadn't even been able to use the right cables without the woman. Besides, it would have never worked without Adora's sword.

Her mind kept circling around the portal. Something that had been able to change their reality, and they had messed with time and space a lot. Hadn't Adora's weird old lady said that, too?

What if Catra really was the unluckiest person alive and somehow Prime received that message anyway. It didn't make much sense to her, it didn't feel like it should be possible, but she didn't know enough about how portals worked to completely disregard it.

Someone cleared their throat next to her, startling her out of her thoughts. "Catra?"

The hallway was completely empty now. She had not noticed how that happened. It probably meant that the meeting was about to start, and that she should get a hold of herself. How was she supposed to explain this?

She slowly turned to look at Glimmer. "I don't really know what's going on", the girl said then. "I know that you're … distressed, but I need you right now."

Well, that snapped her out of it. "I'm not distressed", she hissed and started to walk off. She was downright panicked, there was a difference.

"Well you have been kinda frozen for two hours", the princess mumbled and Catra tried not to look shocked about that. "Everyone's worried, by the way. Just as a warning. My aunt Casta even came to know what she's supposed to do now."

And Catra would have to disappoint her. She didn't know much about what was going on, much less about what they were supposed to do, and she was still trying to figure out how any of this was even possible.

When they entered the war room, all eyes were immediately on them.

"Uh … is that the sword?", Mermista asked with something like worry in her voice, and everyone now stared in shock at what was left of the thing.

"It's a long story", Glimmer sternly shut down any questions, and the sea princess merely rolled her eyes.

Catra took a look around then. She didn't think the room had ever been more packed. There were so many people here, most of which she had never seen before. And all of them radiated nervous energy.

"I think it's time for a full explanation", the queen then prompted.

Glimmer shot her another look, and sighed once more. "Okay, well … Adora tried to kill Shadow Weaver, but she has been taken by someone and I guess it's the same person who's commanding all these ships. Catra and I tried to stop her, but we were too late, but we did take Shadow Weaver and Hordak prisoner. Also, the sword is gone now, which is fine! Because there's also a planet-destroying, thousand-year-old super weapon at the heart of Etheria that could theoretically tear us all apart because the last She-Ra has disabled our portal capabilities by hiding us in an empty dimension or something, but with the sword gone, that is not a worry anymore. What is, is the ships or whoever is in them", she rambled all in one breath.

All that followed was silence, most people just stared with their mouths hanging open in shock.

A woman with a halo stepped forward then. "Do we know who they are? And how did they even get here? You said our

dimension is empty apart from us."

"And what do they want with Adora?", Netossa added.

"The real question isn't how they got here", Entrapta chimed in then, seemingly deep in thought. "Our portal capabilities might be broken, but that doesn't mean anyone else's are. But how did they know where to look? We have no records of anyone coming to our dimension since the last She-Ra pulled us in here. Why now?"

The woman asked the same question that Catra had asked herself earlier as well. And the scientist was the only person who would be able to confirm her theory, even if she already dreaded the answer. Asking for Entrapta's opinion would also put her in a position where she wouldn't be able to evade telling the truth anymore.

For her own sake, she really shouldn't take that risk, but… what if Prime was not here because of the message? What if he had come here knowing something, what if he had taken Adora because he needed her? They wouldn't know how much they should worry unless they knew the why, and in order to know the why, Catra would have to ask, and reveal much more than she ever wanted.

"Entrapta?", she called out into the returned quiet, and everyone looked at her. The woman in question nodded attentively. Catra took a deep breath. "Just hypothetically, if someone build a portal to send a message to someone outside of our dimension, activated it, messing with time and space, causing time to turn back so that none of that actually happened … would the message still go through? Hypothetically."

"That's a fascinating question!", Entrapta exclaimed excitedly.

"It's an oddly specific question", Mermista pointed out, but she was ignored.

"With our portal capabilities disabled, it would make sense that trying to activate any portal, no matter how small, would result in space-time-issues", the scientist rambled over any protests. "As for sending anything with it… I cannot be sure without further research, but I suppose it is possible that any issues would only affect our dimension. So, even if our time gets turned back, the message could still have reached the unaffected universe. Though, there's a lot of variables involved that could have still stopped it from going through."

"What are the chances, would you say?", Catra asked because she … well, she didn't want an answer, but she needed one.

Entrapta quickly scribbled something down on her pad before looking back up after a minute. "Well, since I have never seen or been inside a portal, I really cannot say for sure, but … assuming that the portal would stay open long enough and no further disturbances apart from the destruction of our dimension took place, I suppose the chances are roughly 80% for the message to have reached its destination", she answered then. "Hypothetically, of course. It's hard to say for sure on the spot, without further research and parameters."

So, bad news, this probably was all Catra's fault then — if she hadn't pulled the switch, none of this would be happening.

Good news, if Prime was truly here on a mere whim due to that message, he might have just gotten Adora on accident — the girl had been relatively close to Hordak at the time, it wasn't entirely unlikely. But she wasn't sure if that was really a good thing. If Prime didn't necessarily need her, Adora might already be dead.

Bow interrupted her thoughts with a nervous laugh. "How hypothetical are we talking, exactly?", he then asked.

"Not very", Catra mumbled in response, not even bothering to hide anything because she doubted she would get away with not explaining it, again.

"Wait, are you trying to say … that time and space… What?!", Glimmer stumbled through a barely coherent sentence. "And how do you know that?"

"The age old question", Mermista naturally had to grumble then.

All eyes were still on her, and she felt more uncomfortable than she already was. Well, the least she could do was clear up all of the confusion she and Adora have caused.

"Hordak originally comes from a larger army. Horde Prime's army. I think the ships are his. Conquering is apparently his thing, which is why Hordak is also obsessed with it", she started explaining. Now for the hard part. "Hordak has been trying to build a portal for years. If not to go through, to send a message." She had to take a steadying breath. "He… *We* opened one. Adora shut it down and it sent us back in time to the day she found the sword. With another chance, she decided to change things. But that first time around … I didn't leave the Horde. I became Hordak's second in command." She ignored the gasps around her. "That's how I knew everything. Because I had to take care of everything in the Horde since Hordak was too busy building his portal. Not that he cared."

It was silent for a long time as everyone processed that.

"Well … that explains a lot", Glimmer then mumbled. "It kinda explains everything. I still have a few questions, though."

"Why are you and Adora the only ones who remember?", Netossa decided to ask one already.

Catra shrugged. "Not sure. Adora kinda makes sense, she was the key to it all. The portal followed her. As for me…" The portal had kind of centered on her too. It had portrayed *her* perfect reality, not Adora's, and it did not kill her outright like everyone else. "I guess it might have something to do with me being the one who had activated it." She wasn't really proud of it, and she was sure it became noticeable.

"Did you not know how dangerous that was?", Bow questioned, clearly hoping despite probably knowing the answer.

"No, I did", she answered simply.

"But then-", Glimmer started, but Catra really didn't want to discuss this. Not that they had time for it either.

So, she interrupted the girl. "A lot has happened that day, most of which I can hardly even remember. Yes, I've made a lot of terrible choices. Yes, we were enemies. And yes, that's why I hated you for no reason. You can distrust me all you want now, but I won't let you judge the decisions I've made — they were bad, but they were mine, and I cannot say I regret all of them", she told them sternly. "The portal was admittedly not my proudest moment, and I will also admit that it's my fault that Prime is here now, so how about we focus on him instead of things that didn't happen and that none of you remember?"

Sparkles, as well as some other princesses, seemed ready to argue with her on that, probably on the basis of 'but it did sort of happen', and she really didn't want to hear a single thing.

"So, how do we defeat him?", Frosta saved her, and pulled the attention away from her shortly. "That's what matters, right? To get rid of him", the girl looked at her, eyes wide with fear.

Catra took a deep breath and sighed. "I really don't know anything about him. The only one who does is Hordak and … he's not very talkative." Unless your name is Entrapta. Which was a terrible idea. "But I do know how to make him talk", she added anyway.

"How?", the queen ask, the slightest distrust evident in her voice, which was to be expected.

She chose to ignore it and instead turned to Entrapta, who was furiously writing down notes. "Entrapta?", she tried getting the woman's attention, which luckily worked. "How do you feel about a lab partner?"

The scientist's eyes brightened up. "I always wanted to have a lab partner!"

Angella shook her head, though. "We cannot risk letting Hordak run around freely", she said sternly, still looking at Catra skeptically, like she expected her to have some secret plan that would help the Horde.

"He won't", she answered, pushing her worries aside for now to focus on coming across as determined as possible. "He'll be locked up with Entrapta. And he's not much of a threat right now without his armor, so I doubt she'll have trouble managing him", she pointed out.

It seemed like the older woman was weighing her option. She also seemed to try to figure out if she still wanted to trust Catra. "Are you sure about this?", she then asked.

"I am. The two of them are going to hit it off and once he trusts her, he'll talk", she told her as confidently as she could. The scientist herself didn't question that statement at all, simply happy to be given a lab partner.

"Do I even want to know how you know that?", Bow mumbled, looking slightly disturbed at whatever ideas he came up with. At least he didn't seem like he completely distrusted her.

"Pain. A lot of it", was the answer she gave. Thanks to that weird relationship, she was almost sent to Beast Island and actually send to the Crimson Waste to die.

Meanwhile, the queen still seemed unsure. The woman looked around at everyone present. Most people were still processing or sending skeptical glances towards Catra. Then she sighed. "Alright. Hordak will be put under the care of princess Entrapta. What do we do with the other one?"

"Don't engage her", was the easiest answer she had given all day. "She doesn't have any power anymore and I'm pretty sure she's

dying because of it, but she's still a snake. She will try to manipulate anyone who comes close to her. You can't trust her."

The woman nodded silently.

Maybe Catra had foolishly hoped for her to say something about her own fate, but it didn't seem like the queen had any intentions of doing so.

Instead, it was Glimmer who jumped up. "We have beaten the Horde, and we will beat this Prime guy too", she said confidently. "But no matter what fight, it is important that we can trust each other. *Everyone* in this room has already proven plenty of times that they're trustworthy. And I expect us to stand just as united as we have before." She shot Catra a quick look, making it undeniably clear that she had been advocating for her specifically.

She couldn't help but feel grateful when a round of nods followed the declaration — most were more hesitant, but some nodded with more enthusiasm.

Even the queen nodded along and took the word again. "The plan for now is clear. We have no idea what Prime will do, so all we can do is wait. We will hope that Hordak will give us useful information. And … with the Horde essentially dismantled, and considering the circumstances, I suggest giving the remaining soldiers the offer for shelter." Once more, everyone nodded in agreement. Then the woman looked at Catra, a lot more softly again. "But what do we do about Adora?" The queen's voice was said and solemn, like she already expected her to be dead.

She couldn't help but scoff in response, but luckily she didn't have to elaborate.

"I can continue to fix up Darla, then we can get her", Entrapta suggested.

"Who is Darla?", Bow asked carefully, but the woman just laughed.

"Oh, I named the ship Darla!", she explained.

Somehow this shouldn't be all this surprising. And it was good — emotional attachment meant that Entrapta would prioritize fixing it up, and the sooner that happened, the sooner they could save Adora. But it could also mean that the scientist might forget about Hordak.

"You should fix the ship as fast as you can, but you still have to deal with Hordak. That is … more important. We need any information you can get out of him, or people might get hurt", she told the woman clearly, even though it hurt her unreasonably to admit that Adora was less important.

Entrapta nodded, more serious than Catra had ever seen her. "I will report", she told her.

It didn't do anything to make her feel better. She wanted to urge the woman to get the ship ready immediately, but she couldn't do that. That would be irresponsible and put them all at risk against the unknown threat of Horde Prime. But she wanted to.

This was exactly why she had wanted to avoid being close to anyone again. Caring about people had never done her any good, why did she expect it to work out this time? Why did she let herself be convinced that she wanted to be friends with Adora again? She should have stayed away, just like she had planned from the very beginning, then everyone might still hate her, but at least Adora would be here, safe and sound.

The meeting was dismantled then, since most people were exhausted and they had a lot of new information to digest. And Catra couldn't really find it in herself to listen anymore either. They had talked about the most important things, though they didn't exactly have a great plan, they were on the same page at least.

For now, she was glad to be able to leave. She needed to calm down, and she needed to think about all this in peace and quiet to

figure out a bit more than 'wait and hope'.

But on her way outside the room, Glimmer and Bow came up to her.

"I don't want to talk about it", she said before the two could even get a word in. "This was already more than I ever wanted you to know", she admitted with a growl.

"I can see why", the princess responded easily and blocked her path anyway. "Look… I meant it in there. I trust you, and whatever happened in a different timeline that we don't remember can stay there. I just want to know one thing… Why did you stay? Why did you join the rebellion this time?"

Catra sighed. "I just … couldn't leave. I felt betrayed and was too proud to follow her", she told them and they looked at her with understanding. "This time, Adora literally kidnapped me. Besides, Shadow Weaver and Hordak both tried to kill me several times — why would I do that again? I couldn't win, so I could at least make sure they lose."

"That makes sense", Glimmer mumbled thoughtfully. "And I am glad that you're here this time. Especially seeing as you got us to victory within a few months." She shuddered. "I really don't want you as my enemy."

Catra chuckled a bit. "You weren't all that easy to defeat, even without me."

"Still", Bow then said. "We've seen you, you're a ruthless fighter and your plans have always worked in our favor. I really can't imagine that we could have won against the Horde if you had worked for them", he pointed out. "I mean, I'm sure they don't give out the title of second in command for nothing."

"I guess not", she mumbled. And yet, Hordak had never actually trusted her.

"And you're motivation this time really was purely revenge?", the boy then asked after a few seconds. "Really?"

"You think I lied?", she challenged.

"I thought you were doing it for Adora", he told her.

"No", she admitted. "Not in the beginning", she added. "But I guess … at some point I did start to do it for her", she realized. She didn't actually have to make plans, didn't actually need to put herself at risk with information she shouldn't possess, but she did. For her.

They both awed, making her roll her eyes. "That's so romantic", Bow cooed, his eyes resembling that of a puppy.

She groaned, but couldn't stop the heat from rising to her face. "Not you too. Adora and I are not together", she growled.

"You sure act like it", Glimmer told her with a smug look. "I mean, half the castle thought you were bitter exes when you first got here, and lately you really could have fooled everyone. But clearly neither of you have any idea what your behavior looks like from the outside."

Somehow her face got even hotter. "It doesn't matter. We don't even know if she's still alive", she said then, deflecting a bit.

The two lost their grins at the reminder. "Of course she is", the princess told her softly. "Adora's tough. We'll save her, don't worry."

"We?", Catra asked, slightly surprised.

"You don't think we'll let you do this alone, do you?", the princess mocked. "We might have been enemies in some parallel universe, but now we are your friends. We do this together."

"We can't let the Best Friend Squad get separated", Bow agreed. "We got your back."

Catra knew, logically, that they have been building a bond, and she had been announced a member of their dumb squad before, but this somehow felt more official. More real. So far she could have believed they warmed up to her solely for Adora's benefit, but now — with the blonde gone and everything out in the open — she felt like they actually liked her. She didn't exactly understand it, but she was grateful all the same. "Thank you", she told them.

"How do you feel about a sleepover?", Glimmer then asked. "I don't think anyone would like to be alone tonight."

"Yes! No one should be left alone at a time like this. We could make it really big and cozy, boosting comfort and morale!", Bow suggested.

Catra wasn't all too sure about this, but she also thought that it was a good idea for them to stay as closely together as possible — she couldn't have explained why, but some instinct told her it would be better. "Sounds good", she therefore gave in.

The others didn't seem to notice her hesitation and immediately ran off to notify everyone.

In the meantime, Catra went to her room that looked exactly like she left it. Bed unmade, the file on the ground, and the odd sense of something missing in the air.

She really hoped that Adora was okay, and still alive. If she was dead, it would be her fault. Because it was her fault that Prime was here to begin with.

If Adora was dead, she didn't know what she would do. She couldn't lose the girl again after just getting her back.

Catra picked up the file, closing it gently even though it did not deserve such a treatment. It made a fine addition to the sword in her collection of things that ruined her life. Shadow Weaver might belong in there too, but she could live without more reminders of that witch. The reminders of Adora were enough.

Always Adora.

She had denied the implications every time. Because they were friends. Just friends. Only ever friends. But … she had never even really thought about it. Had never dared. And it was not the right time to do so right now, and yet she couldn't stop herself.

Does someone almost destroy the entire world because they're angry at a friend? Does someone fixate on destroying a friend because they were left by them? Do friends regularly share a bed and cuddle? Does one usually feel like their soul would be ripped apart at the mere thought of losing a friend permanently?

Do you really think I would have done half the shit I've done if we hadn't been friends? That's what she had said to Adora after their last big fight. And now she wondered… Would she have done half the shit she had done … if she hadn't loved Adora?

She shook her head and took the file and sword, along with a pillow from Adora's side of the bed, and went downstairs to look for the others.

Even if… It's not like Adora would ever want her like that anyway.

Catra found everyone in the dining hall that had been turned into, what was essentially, a giant bed. Mostly because it seemed that everyone brought about a dozen more pillows and blankets than necessary.

Glimmer was next to her in an instant. "There you are!", she said. "It's all a bit stiff right now, but I'm sure we can have a little fun. We managed it before, why not now?"

She only hummed because she doubted the girl wanted an answer anyway.

Bow joined them after having caught up with the princess, now standing next to her as well. "Don't worry", he told her. "I'm sure the others will come around again. I mean, Swift Wind, Scorpia, Entrapta, Perfuma and Frosta already don't seem very deterred."

As if on cue, the pair of her pseudo friends waved over excitedly.

"Come on!", Glimmer exclaimed and dragged them both over.

Frosta and Perfuma quickly joined their little circle, the latter having brought snacks. Swift Wind, once he spotted her, stayed oddly close to her for some reason that Catra wasn't about to question because he was another thing that Adora had left behind and she didn't actually mind him behaving like a protective barrier around her.

The conversation started off dull and unimportant enough that she safely let her thoughts wander, but soon Frosta started to insist on her telling a few stories from the other time, and since everyone seemed to have questions, all seven of her companions demanded a bit of gossip from her.

Eventually, she did decide to tell them about the safe parts. Including the time she had been kidnapped by Glimmer and Bow, minus anything related to Entrapta. Or how she hated paperwork and how she had to run around trying to figure out how armor was made, explaining that she was secretly happy that Adora had stolen some files, just because it probably messed with Shadow Weaver. Or, the time when she defeated all the gangs in the Crimson Waste, minus everything about Adora — the name Tung Lashor had everyone rolling on the floor.

Over time, more of the other princesses and guards and volunteers came to listen as well. After seeing, or rather thinking, that she wasn't trying to hide anything, they relaxed a bit around her.

But Catra had a lot to hide, and she left out rather much, actually. Like how she had used Entrapta as a bargaining chip, or that the woman had been with Horde, or that she had visited Shadow Weaver in her cell, or how exactly she had ended up in the Crimson Waste, or how that trip had continued after Tung Lashor.

Nobody seemed to notice. To them, she just told a few fun stories, and no one asked how they might be connected.

Eventually, one by one, they started to drift off to sleep, but Catra didn't. She lay awake in the dark, unsure what she was supposed to do. Sleep, probably, but she couldn't. She was too vulnerable again even with so many people around. Or especially because of them.

She missed Adora, missed their quiet moments, and the overly cuddly habit the blonde had that somehow reduced the chances of Catra getting any nightmares.

The pillow she had brought might smell of the blonde, but it didn't even come close to being a suitable replacement. She should have never gotten used to sleeping again.

In an attempt to find some peace, she grabbed what was left of the sword and pulled it a bit closer.

Catra wouldn't know what love was supposed to feel like. Just like with friendship or general social decency, the Horde had failed to teach anything about it. All she knew was the concept of it — to chose another person and spend one's life with them — but she had no idea what it was supposed to feel like.

Safe and happy, if she had to guess.

And she had been happy, for a short time until Mara's message. As for safe … it was hard to say with all their unspoken baggage between them, but at the same time, there was no one she felt safer with.

And … maybe … if she would be stuck with Adora for the rest of her life, she might not hate that.

She sighed. Her confusing feelings really didn't matter right now, might never. All that mattered was to remedy her mistake and make sure Prime wouldn't take over the planet or hurt Adora.

Maybe some day they could deal with feelings. Maybe not. Catra didn't care as long as that idiot would be save.

***

Adora felt cold when she woke up. Instinctively she reached for Catra and the panic that took a hold of her when she wasn't there let even the last bit of sleepiness disappear.

Right. Catra couldn't be here. In fact, it was a relief to know that she wasn't.

She sat up and took a few deep breaths to try and rid herself of her anxiety, but it was a fruitless attempt. Even with the knowledge that none of her friends were here, she still didn't feel very calm.

After avoiding sleep for so long long, she still managed to pass out occasionally, despite her growing restlessness. And with some rest her cognitive abilities seemed to return to her, along with the realization that she was stuck on an alien ship while her friends had to face who knows what completely without her or She-Ra.

Adora felt oddly refreshed for a prisoner, but also guilty and afraid.

And that made it hard to sit still, so she got up and automatically went through the motions of the light early training that she was used to, even if she wasn't sure how early it really was.

Everything was bathed in light, bouncing off the white walls. No window, no clock. There was no telling how long she had managed to sleep. Maybe she napped. Maybe she had slept an entire day. She wouldn't know.

The Hordaks running around and regularly checking in on her seemed to know at least.

One of them — maybe the same every time — would regularly visit her cell to bring her meals and ask if she needed anything, while reminding her that she was Prime's *guest* and could ask for anything she might need.

Adora felt weird about that every time and send them away as fast as she could. She didn't feel like a guest. Stuck in a room that looked like a cleaner version of the cells in the Fright Zone, she wouldn't call herself a guest. She had actually tested that by asking if she could stretch her legs a little, walk around a bit, which was denied. She was to stay in her room until Prime decided otherwise.

When she pointed that irony out to them, they were only confused — Prime had called her a guest so she couldn't be a prisoner. Honestly, she wondered if the original Hordak also lacked those critical thinking skills.

At least she got food. Since Hordak came from here, she had expected to be forced to go back to ration bars, but what was put in front of her was actually edible. It wasn't as good as anything Brightmoon had to offer, but at least it had taste.

So far, she has been fed seven times. Since she was actually hungry every time, she guessed that they gave her food based on normal breakfast, lunch and dinner times, which meant she must have been here for a little bit over two days.

And Adora was getting restless. She had thought that Prime would do something with her, or to her, after his whole thing about everyone having a place serving him, but it felt like he had forgotten about her existence. Which made her panic a little because if he wasn't busy trying to get her to 'cooperate', then what was he doing?

He had said something about wiping Hordak's mess away, so probably that. She didn't know what exactly that entailed, but she doubted it was anything good.

And she was stuck in a cell with no way of helping anyone. She really was a terrible She-Ra.

It was after meal eight that a Hordak irregularly came by. She knew it was not a regular patrol because it was too soon after she had eaten.

"Horde Prime requests your presence", he said and deactivated the force field.

Despite having expected it to happen eventually, she couldn't help but be nervous. "What does he want?", she asked because at the very least she'd like to be able to mentally prepare.

"Horde Prime wishes to talk to you", he answered and lead her away.

She sighed. "About what?" This time there was no answer, like they were programmed to a certain amount of phrases. It was frustrating.

She had already noticed that, whenever she asked about anything other than the food or any commodities they offered, they just wouldn't answer. They wouldn't even tell her that they were not allowed to or anything, they would just stare and wait until she dismissed them.

They didn't walk very long and she was led to something that looked like a dining room. Horde Prime stood in front of a bunch of monitors, though what exactly he was looking at, she couldn't say. Entrapta might have understood the symbols but she didn't.

"Ah, little sister", he greeted her and the Hordaks left them alone. "How nice of you to join me."

She scoffed. "Like I had a choice", she mumbled.

To her surprise he laughed a little. "You are right. I should say, how nice of you to be agreeable. Have a seat." He pointed to the chairs between them at the table.

"I'd rather stand", she told him. If she sat down now, her anxiety would kill her. And she also didn't trust it — who knew what those chairs would do.

"As you wish", he relented and sat down himself. She still remained standing. "Are you comfortable? I strive to treat my guests well."

Adora really wasn't in the mood for small talk. "What do you want?", she asked because he obviously wanted something. Otherwise she wouldn't be here.

"I have busied myself with gathering information", he complied easily. "But some things are still unclear. I was hoping we could learn from each other."

She wanted to tell him no right away, but she had questions of her own and she might not get another chance to ask. "So I get to ask questions, too? And you'll answer them?" The last part was important. After all, she could ask all she wanted, if no one told her anything it wouldn't do her much good.

"As long as you answer mine", he offered and she nodded. She would have to think well about this because at some point she would not be able to answer, or more likely wouldn't want to.

He looked at her expectantly, clearly waiting for her to make the first move and she was not sure why. Or if she liked it. But she could hardly refuse now. "Why does everyone on this ship look like Hordak? What are you?", she asked therefore.

"Hordak? My brother has given himself a name. How disgraceful", he said with a sigh. "My race has long since been forgotten. I have liberated my planet and created an empire in my image. They are my clones."

Adora had not expected that, and she would like to say that weirder things have happened, but that would be a lie. "Okay", she mumbled, hoping her disgust didn't show.

"I wish to know about this planet", he then said. "I have encountered those you call the First Ones before, though I have been unaware of this settlement. It must have been a minor unimportant planet for them, and yet my brother has failed in conquering it", he mused. "Why?"

"Well… the princesses have been fighting tirelessly against him", she mumbled unsure, as his eyes seemed to stare into her soul, making her more nervous than she should be. "I don't know, Hordak doesn't seem to be much of an organizing kind of guy, the planet also has a lot of dangerous terrain, and the princesses are pretty powerful", she rambled and only barely stopped herself from saying too much.

"I see", he said with a weird knowing smile that made her skin crawl.

She swallowed down her anxiety and tried to focus. "Why are you here?", she then asked. "I know you said something about a transmission, but why did you follow it if you hate Hordak so much?"

"I do not hate my little brother. He is merely a disappointment whom I cannot allow to taint my image any longer", he lazily corrected. "I have received his message a while ago, but I could not determine its source. Not anywhere in the Known Universe, at least. Imagine my surprise to find a planet in a dimension long believed to be empty." He shrugged. "How could I not see for myself what potential it may hold."

That was unsettlingly ominous. She didn't even know what she was supposed to respond to that, and it seemed she wouldn't have to.

"Your rebellion is of great fascination to me", he simply kept going. "They are woefully unprepared and yet, they persist." He got up from his chair and went to his monitors. "After my ships arrived I had noticed two big groups of people gathering. One seemed to be my brother's excuse for an army. But the other…"

The monitors sprung to live and Adora gasped at what she saw. Brightmoon had been attacked. The castle had suffered significant damage, but at least the runestone seemed to be fine. But her friends were nowhere to be seen — what happened to them?

"I have attempted to finish what my useless brother has started, but somehow the entire might of the rebellion has evaded me."

A sigh of relief escaped her. Prime didn't seem to appreciate that very much.

"Disappointing, but predictable. Tell me this. That stone. What is its purpose?", he asked, correctly assuming that she wouldn't tell him anything about her friends. Not that she knew anything.

At least this she could answer. "It's a runestone. It's part of the natural balance of the planet. Every kingdom has one." She left a little part out, namely that the princesses got their powers from it, but he didn't need to know that. She knew she wasn't a good actress or liar, but she didn't lie exactly. It just wasn't the whole truth. Hopefully he couldn't tell. "What are you going to do with me?", she mirrored him and kept talking before he had a chance to call her out.

"While I have gathered information, I have also refreshed my memory on the topic of the First Ones", he said while seemingly studying her. "And She-Ra. I must have met your predecessor, you show the same naive heroism as her. And only something that powerful could have irritated my machines enough to miss my brother."

He sat back down again while he let her process, but she wasn't sure what to do with that information. Or what it meant for her.

Luckily, it didn't take long for him to keep talking. "Your people have found a remarkable way of controlling you. One, I'm afraid I cannot replicate." He sounded annoyed at that. "So, I need you to act voluntarily to activate a portal to bring us out of Despondos."

She couldn't help but find a bit of amusement in that. "You're stuck here?"

His mirroring smile made the dread reappear. "Not exactly. If I distanced myself from your planet, I could get back. I would like to take this planet with me, however."

Adora wanted to ask what he needed their planet for, but for one she could imagine it, and she had already wasted a question, asking two in a row no less. "Without the sword I can't activate anything. And even if I could, I wouldn't do it for you", she settled for telling him. She wouldn't do it for anyone — she owed it to Mara to leave them here.

He didn't seem bothered by it, which didn't calm her in the slightest. "This planet truly is fascinating. I wonder why you were hidden here. What did the First Ones do to warrant this isolation?"

It was then that she realized a few things.

One, the reason he let her ask the questions first was so she would be forced to eventually answer this one, no way out, not without breaking their deal and he probably bargained that She-Ra wouldn't do such a thing.

And two… she had not noticed that when he had just told her about wanting their planet and needing her to activate a portal, he must have already known something. Maybe not the extend of the Heart, but he knew that this place held something powerful. He was probably just looking for confirmation.

What did the First Ones do? The only possible answer to give was that they turned their planet into a weapon.

If he knew, her confirmation wouldn't change anything, but if he had just guessed and really needed an answer, she should not give him one.

Apparently she took too long to make a decision because he sighed in disappointment. "I would have thought you to be a

woman of your word, little sister", he lamented. "But your distressed silence will be answer enough. And despite it all, your insight has been very helpful" he told her with a smile as two clones showed up. "I will not require your presence any longer. If I can do anything to make your stay more comfortable, please let me know."

Adora wasn't exactly forced outside, but the clones persistently tried to drag her off. "You can't open a portal, the planet will tear itself apart!", she warned him, not for his sake, but for the safety of her friends.

"The First Ones' workings have always been rudimentary. I can assure you that I have the means to avoid such tragedy", he told her with barely constrained annoyance.

The clones got a bit more insistent. "I won't let you do that. They won't let you do that. They'll defeat you!"

He only laughed, though. "Without their hero? Every planet has their rebellion. It has never stopped me before. But worry not, they will be granted to bask in my light."

Now she was forced. They all but carried her out of the room as she tried desperately to get back to punch that guy in the face.

In the end she only punched a clone before the barrier of her cell was reactivated. It wasn't what she had wanted, and it also had only little effect, leaving her to pace frustratedly and occasionally punching the walls.

At least she knew her friends were safe for now. Without a home and who knows where, fighting for their lives.

The destroyed castle was stuck in her mind. It had always been a safe place, always the last one standing, protected both by the woods and the sea, and now they had to flee it.

But where to? Any other castle or town was probably too easy to discover.

It was only a matter of time before they were found again and then... Adora didn't want to think about it.

She knew they were smart and resourceful. Still, she worried. Prime was obviously much more dangerous than Hordak. And speaking of, what was *he* doing? It didn't seem like Prime was allied with him, but did the Horde still exist? Did the rebellion have to fight on two fronts?

There was too much to worry about and there was nothing she could do to help. Trying to get off this ship, as much as she would love to leave, would probably be a fruitless endeavor. There was nowhere for her to flee to, even if she made it out of her cell.

She felt more useless than she ever had. In a way, she wished that Prime had just killed her, at least then she wouldn't be tortured by worry. Her friends must worry about her, too. Did they know where she was? Did Swift Wind tell anyone? Did Catra try to go after her? She was certainly smart enough to figure out what Adora had planned. Did she find Shadow Weaver? The woman would have probably loved to tell the girl all about Adora's disappearance.

Did Catra worry about her like she worried about the girl?

It was a dumb thought. Even if their friendship had been steadily rebuilding, the girl must be way too busy defending the planet to worry about Adora.

If only she had her sword with her, then she could fight Prime and help them at least a little. Then again, not having the sword also meant that Prime wouldn't be able to control her. But at the same time it made her useless.

She hated this!

There had to be something she could do besides rotting in this cell. Something that would help her friends. But apart from keeping information and She-Ra away from Prime, she couldn't do anything.

Adora was a lot of things, but certainly not a hero.

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: I have a sourdough starter named Darla! I wanted to name her something She-Ra related and I thought it fit her really well xD (and she makes delicious bread)

Anyway... I don't have much to say about the chapter, so until next time! Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 24: Leader - Part 1

Chapter Notes

> Hiii, sorry for the longer wait <33 I don't have much to say for myself. First I missed my self-imposed deadline because I didn't like the chapter and kept revisiting it, and then I was editing so much, I forgot about it... And then I just gave myself a week to make sure the next few chapters would be ready to go, so here we are.
>
> To be fair, I still don't really like the chapter, but it's okay enough. We have a little time jump and I was struggling a lot with exposition. I tried to fix as much as I can, but I don't know... I think it's still weird, but if I keep editing it, this story will never get done...
>
> Anyway! Few trigger warnings for some small little self deprecating thoughts, as well as violence (nothing too graphic, but it's still there)
>
> Have fun <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's been 17 days since Prime showed up. 16 since they had to flee Brightmoon and about nine since most people lost all hope.

Catra couldn't blame them. It wasn't easy to stand tall in the face of these odds. They lost almost all territory in that time and no matter how much they fought back, Prime seemed to have an infinite amount of resources, bots and clones.

At least they were all still alive, even if she felt anything but.

Honestly, the only reason they were still standing at all was the fact that the princesses were a stubborn bunch.

They were mostly motivated by all the people at camp that believed in them, and relied on the rebellion to safe them, which Catra kind of understood — it really put things into perspective to see hundreds of people desperately try to survive.

17 days. Hordak couldn't conquer Etheria in thirty years, but here they were hiding in the woods and losing everything within 17 days.

Back in Brightmoon they had all bargained on time, assuming that, while worse than Hordak, their way of thinking was at least similar, but that turned out to be false. Hordak had been so afraid of failure that he barely took risks, but Prime marched in with the mentality of someone who had already won.

And he was winning.

They had no home, no plan, no She-Ra, they were running out of resources and time. If Prime didn't kill them soon, they would starve. The entire rebellion knew that, but no one has openly acknowledged it yet. Probably because they couldn't bear to disappoint all the townsfolk that were crammed into tents around them.

At least they were safe from a mass panic because the normal people didn't seem to realize how bad their situation really was. She saw them, whenever she or any of the princesses walked through camp — the way their moods brightened with hope. They really believed the rebellion could save them.

Catra doubted it.

If only they had just a bit more knowledge about Prime, then they could plan and strategize, but the way it looked, they would be dead before that happened.

Entrapta allegedly got Hordak to warm up to her, but it hadn't wielded many results yet.

They had figured out that Hordak was a clone of Prime and that he had been cast out for his failures, but apart from that he had resorted to talking solely through grunts. And if that didn't change soon…

Her thoughts kept trying to work something out, but it always ended in the seemingly inevitable outcome of their doom.

They were utterly helpless. Villages and towns were conquered and they could only watch. Prime's army was unsettling — his clones kept going even if they lost a limb and could only really be knocked out by a hit in the neck, which was not the easiest to reach, especially since most of the princesses were not close ranged fighters. They also seemed to have no mind of their own, which meant they were no source of knowledge either.

She had tried, but they only kept repeating how great Prime was.

Catra should have never opened that portal.

Next to her, Swift Wind sighed, startling her out of her growing desperation. "Nothing?", she asked, already knowing the answer.

Swift Wind shook his head. "It's like she's not even there", he mumbled.

It was a possibility that everyone kept ignoring — she knew they just tried to be careful around her feelings, but it pissed her off. The horse was the only one she could talk to about Adora, which was probably why she kept coming back to him to watch him attempt to connect to her.

"Maybe she is gone", she whispered, not willing to believe it herself. "Why would he keep her alive?"

"Maybe she's just too far away", he reasoned with a sad voice, hope dwindling by the day. "She's never been off the planet before, maybe that just happens."

"Maybe", she agrees. She really hated that word, but it was too much of a comfort to at least pretend for a moment that there was hope. Realistically though, it would be smart to get rid of Etheria's biggest protector. "I'll go check on the others", she said and got up. "Can you check on Razz?"

The horse nodded and trotted off. They had found the woman when they had retreated from Brightmoon, and they couldn't just leave her alone in the middle on an invasion. Razz was still very confused as to what was going on, so Catra and Swift Wind took turns making sure she was doing alright.

As Catra walked through camp, looking for anyone from the Alliance, she noticed again how crowded this place was. There were too many refugees — townspeople, children, guards, sorcerers — but they kept saving more because they just had to.

She stumbled over a plush version of She-Ra and looked for the nearest crying kid to return it to. When she found a mother daughter pair, she walked over to hand the toy back and was engulfed in a hug.

Catra awkwardly patted the girl's back, and tried not to think about this kid's fate too much.

She couldn't even tell where they had been from anymore. They had evacuated anything that had been invaded — anything they could reach without putting themselves at risk, at least, which only included everything in and surrounding the Whispering Woods.

When she was let go off, she kept stumbling forward, once again thinking about what they could do to stop Prime, but … she had nothing.

All she could do was make plans for rescue missions, and make sure they were save and not starving.

Eventually, she came past their war room tent, which was the source of a lot of yelling, so she decided to check in.

"The sorcerer's spell will only keep us hidden for so long, we have to do something", Netossa pushed.

"And what? We don't stand a chance against his army!", Glimmer responded.

"But Hordak won't talk. We could just take a clone and ask them", Mermista proposed.

"They only talk about how great Prime is. They're useless", Frosta said.

"We have let ourselves be pushed into a corner. Hiding out here, starving and tired. We never should have abandoned Brightmoon", Castaspella lamented.

Catra rolled her eyes as she walked in then. "We couldn't hold Brightmoon", she said, startling them all with her sudden appearance. "You were there. We needed cover"

The sorceress pulled herself together quickly. "Great, we have cover", she scoffed. Maybe it was just her luck, but her and sorcerers didn't seem to get along. "And we are losing. Hordak isn't giving us anything. We need a better plan."

"Well, we don't have a better plan. Frosta's right. No one else will give us the information that we need. The only one, we at least have a chance with, is Hordak", she reminded them, even if she hardly believed in it anymore either.

"We can't sit around, waiting for him to say something", Mermista groaned.

"We haven't been sitting around", Glimmer said with annoyance. "We have done plenty. Evacuations, scouting missions and keeping everyone safe until we can learn more."

"They won't be safe until Prime is gone", Netossa told them. "We need a better plan."

"There is no better plan!", Glimmer all but screamed. "This is all we got. We need to stop arguing! We are doing what we can, and we will keep doing it. Because our scouts reported that another one of his spires has been spotted near Thaymor."

"Wait, wait, wait", Mermista interrupted. "Didn't we just save Thaymor?"

"No, you're thinking of Elberon", Frosta supplied.

The sea princess groaned. "Can everywhere stop getting invaded for like five second?", she complained. "How is there even anything left?"

"We just gotta face it", Castaspella chimed in again. "Whatever we're doing is clearly not working. Catra's plans were great as long as she knew the future or whatever, but right now-"

"Even before I got send back in time, I could beat your asses with as little as I got", Catra growled. "And the only reason my plans have worked better this time around was because I wasn't fighting Adora anymore. The only person allowed to criticize my planning is her!" No one dared to say anything. "Bow, Netossa, Spinnerella and Mermista go evacuate the town. Glimmer, try and find a place for them. I'll check on Entrapta."

Maybe the woman finally had good news, or something else that could help them.

She walked out without waiting for an answer, and unwilling to be part of this argument any longer, but thanks to her hearing, she still knew how that conversation continued.

"Who made her boss?", Mermista grumbled.

"She is our best bet", Angella finally spoke up, though she sounded utterly defeated, which was probably why she stayed quiet most of the time. "And unless someone else can come up with a better strategy, I will not allow for any more discussions."

"She has gotten us this far. You cannot say that her plans don't work. We might be tired, but we're alive, in no small part thanks to her", Bow pointed out.

"Her quick thinking has gotten us out of several tight spots with the clones. Not to mention out of Brightmoon", Spinnerella also spoke up on her behalf.

"But does she have to be so mean about it?", Castaspella grumbled.

"She misses Adora", Glimmer said softly. "And we expect a lot of her."

Catra growled to herself to drown them out. If it weren't for the fact that they were all very doomed, it would honestly be funny how quickly people forgot about her past as the Horde's de facto leader when being confronted with a bigger threat.

Who made her boss? She would like to know that too, actually. Sure, Glimmer had taken over some of the organization and planning, but most things were Catra's job for some reason, and she was always the one who had approve missions.

Okay, maybe she had dug her own grave here a bit because she had voluntarily taken over their evacuation from Brightmoon, found them a save place, made sure they could discreetly move Darla, made a shift plan for the sorcerers to keep their spell intact at all times, and did pretty much everything else in terms of organization in order to keep busy. But that still didn't mean that she should be listened to.

Desperate times, desperate measures and all that, but putting that much trust in her, of all people, took it a bit far.

Catra has kept them alive, sure, but Castaspella was right, she had also gotten them cornered. And, not to forget, this was all still her fault.

But that didn't mean that she wanted to be pitied either, and she refused to think about why Glimmer had called a meeting without notifying her — she had to make every big decision, but was not invited to trivial meetings?

"Catra!", someone yelled then, and Catra focused back on the present. "Catra!", her name was called out again, and this time, she spotted large pincers waving wildly from the other side of the crowd.

She decided to make it a bit easier for the other, and met the woman halfway in the sea of people.

"Oh, thank goodness I found you", Scorpia breathed out as if she's been running around for a while.

"What's going on?", she asked suspiciously. If the woman looked this worried, something bad had happened.

"I'll uh… show you", the other answered and lead her to Entrapta's lab — in other words Mara's ship.

It didn't look like anything had exploded, the interior still looked pristine and all the science stuff was also in place. But both Scorpia and Entrapta were nervously looking around. "What happened?", she asked. She didn't have the nerves for this.

"I lost Hordak", Entrapta then blurted out. Catra was too stunned to speak. "I had to pop out for a sec and when I came back he was gone", she kept going. "I didn't think he would run away, we made progress, he was opening up!"

"We thought he might have just needed to go … nature's call and all", Scorpia awkwardly added. "But he obviously didn't come back."

Catra groaned and pinched the bridge of her nose. As much as she would love to be rid of the guy, they had to find him. Even if he never gave them any information, they couldn't risk him giving any to Prime.

"Don't worry!", the scientist told her with the usual excitement. "When I made him another suit of armor-" She paused briefly when Catra raised her eyebrow. "For a better state of living!", she defended.

Somehow it didn't surprise her anymore that Hordak chose now to run — now that he *could* run and wouldn't topple over weakly after three steps. But she kept her comments to herself and instead calmly took the pad from Entrapta that the woman was holding out.

"I installed a tracker, just in case. Don't tell him that, though."

"That's good", she mumbled, slightly impressed at the scientists foresight. She stared down at the screen that centered a dot in the middle of the woods. When she zoomed out a bit, she could clearly see what settlement would be nearest. "Scorpia, you're coming with me. Entrapta, keep repairing the ship and not a word to anyone", she instructed and was already on her way outside before she stopped once more. "I'm not mad", she told the other and then left.

It had always been clear to her that Entrapta needed some reassurances occasionally and while Catra had never been one to give them easily, Perfuma had encouraged her to do so, considering the circumstances and everyone's need for positivity in their lives.

Even though they were in such a dire situation, the princess somehow always found time to sit with Catra and Scorpia, and made sure they learned how to heal. It didn't feel very productive and Catra had protested against it, but she had to admit that Perfuma was somewhat right in saying they should at least perform optimism for others to hold the rebellion together.

Even if she had to lie. Catra was angry at Entrapta for being careless enough to not only give their prisoner an update, but then to also leave him alone. But at the same time she should have seen this coming, so it was a bit on her too.

"We need Swift Wind", she said then, looking through the crowd.

"Got it", Scorpia responded and started searching, too. "And then what? I mean, it's good to know that you got it under control, but uh… How exactly do we get *him* back?", she asked in an conspiratorial matter, probably due to the people around.

She was just about to tell the woman when Swift Wind suddenly stood next to her, and she used her breath to hiss instead.

"Did something happen?", he asked, looking in between them. "I'm getting weird vibes from you. Like you're planning something."

She spent too much time with that horse. He had developed an odd tendency to show up whenever she needed him lately, and she had yet to find out how he did that.

Catra shook her head and checked the pad again to confirm where Hordak was headed. "We're going to Alwyn. I'll explain on the way", she told him, because she didn't want to disclose more in the middle of the crowd, and also they didn't have time to stand around and talk.

Swift Wind let them get on his back without further question and took off. A few glances went their way and Catra was sure the remaining princesses would be alerted, but she couldn't focus on that.

"So", he said once they were in the air and out of earshot. "Didn't we lose Alwyn last week?", he asked then.

"Yes", she hissed. It had been a pretty big loss for their supplies, and that humbling defeat bothered her more than when they had to give up Brightmoon. She just hoped that most of the clones and bots had left the town since there was no fighting anymore.

"Should we have gotten backup?"

They probably should have, but they sadly didn't have the time. "Hordak has run, and if we have to go on foot, he'll either be already back in Prime's ranks or dead", she explained. "Besides, the princesses are busy evacuating Thaymor."

"Okay", he replied, clearly processing. "Getting Hordak back. How hard could it be?" He sounded more sarcastic than he had any right to be.

She swallowed down an offended growl. "Fly low, we cannot let ourselves get spotted", she instructed and the horse complied. "Our main goal is Hordak. If we have to fight it's purely to get him, and once we do, we'll fly off and lose any enemy between the trees. No risks", she said strictly and the other two nodded.

The rest of the way was silent, always mindful of possible surveillance bots scouting the area, but so far they were lucky.

But it seemed that's where their luck already ran out — with a look at the tracker pad, she saw that Hordak had managed to make it inside the town. They had to hurry.

She swallowed down a frustrated groan. "No time for scouting, fly in", she told the horse. Catra really hoped there wouldn't be much of Prime's forces around. They really should avoid a fight if possible. But it seemed their luck also didn't cover that area.

They weren't exactly able to get a nice overlook with how low they were flying, but she could see something. No bots, but still a good amount of clones. And Hordak in the middle of them.

Catra strained a bit to hear them.

"Do you truly think you are worthy to stand beside Horde Prime?", a clone mocked. She couldn't tell which one. Not that it mattered. "You have become an abomination and should have been dead a long time ago."

Time to intervene before their only source of knowledge got himself killed.

Catra had agility on her side and once they were close enough, she simply jumped down. It was barely higher than out of her window in Brightmoon to the garden.

She went straight for the little circle forming around Hordak, efficiently using their delay in action due to the surprise by clawing at the clones' necks and scratching them anywhere she could reach, cutting into flesh as she jumped from one to the next.

Technically, she only needed to hit the neck, so she might be overdoing it, but she needed a bit of an outlet for her persisting anger. And she had to admit she found it quite enjoyable to tear them open. Those clones were no better than bots anyway, which made them fair game.

If they were feeling, the princesses surely wouldn't take it kindly, but with the way it was, no one had any problem with her crippling a few of them.

She noticed Scorpia and Swift Wind taking care of and holding back the reinforcements that came running when they noticed the attack — they weren't quite as ruthless, but she didn't expect them to be.

They just had to hold them until they had Hordak, who currently cowered on the ground surrounded by his dead brothers. The position was probably an attempt to get out of range from Catra's claws.

"Come on", she demanded and nudged him with her foot. "We gotta go."

"My place is with Horde Prime", he remained stubborn and it disgusted her how submissive he sounded.

"Your place will be six feet under if you don't get up", she told him with barely contained anger. She'd rather kill him now before she left him behind.

That got him to respond at least and he looked up. Whatever he saw on her face — maybe the confirmation that she was serious — also made him stand up and that was all she needed him to do.

Really, he didn't need to act completely voluntarily, but she needed him to at least not be difficult.

"Scorpia!", she called out and they switched places so smoothly, if she wouldn't know better she could have thought they had rehearsed this.

Catra went at the clones, tearing some more apart while Scorpia used her size and strength to force Hordak onto Swift Wind. Carrying three people wasn't easy for him, but they didn't need to get far. Just out of sight, for now.

When she heard the horse neigh, she left the fight behind and jumped onto his back as well, right as he took off.

The clones chased them for a little while, but Swift Wind kept flying low, so they were quickly hidden by the woods.

A few more minutes went by before they stopped, the horse collapsing in exhaustion.

Everyone got off him, and Catra turned her attention to Hordak, who didn't even look the slightest bit guilty or embarrassed.

"What were you thinking?", she asked him like she was his disappointed mother. That thought made her wanna throw up. "That they'll happily take you back? Don't you think if Prime wanted that, he would have taken you? Like he took Adora? That guy doesn't care about you or anyone!"

"Like *you* care", he grumbled, but having the decency to at least look ashamed, now that she had called him out.

"We flew out here to save you, didn't we?", she snapped. "You do realize they would have killed you, right?"

"Of course I know! I'm not as dumb as you think!"

"Yeah, you certainly proved that by running towards the people wanting you dead!", she said sarcastically.

"Okay", Scorpia went in between them. "Maybe we should calm down and have a more productive conversation. Like Perfuma has shown us", she suggested, but Catra was past productivity with this guy.

"I didn't have to save you", she just kept going. "I would be delighted to see you dead, but sadly for all of us, you are still needed and Entrapta likes you for some reason. So whether you help us or not, the least you could do is not give us more work!"

"Entrapta likes me?", was all he responded while looking away ashamedly. These two would be the death of her.

"That is true", Scorpia chimed in again. "She's really worried about you."

Hordak didn't answer anymore, but he looked like his entire world view was just challenged, and maybe it was. She didn't care.

"Let's just head back", she grumbled and turned to walk. "If you run again, I'll kill you myself."

Thanks to the Horde's training, she could manage her adrenaline pretty well and didn't need a long cooling down period. Still, she hoped for a quiet walk back, so she could think and calm her anger a bit.

Sadly, it took only a few seconds before Scorpia had caught up to her. "Wanna talk?", she asked with a smile, handing Catra an already dirty handkerchief so that she could clean her claws of the weird green goo these clones called blood.

She took it gratefully, but didn't answer the question.

"Or, uh, we could do that one breathing exercise. You know, the one that helps you… Gosh, I forgot which one. I think yours is a bit different from mine", she rambled on and Catra couldn't stop the low growl that escaped her. It did make Scorpia stop, though. "Okay, got it. I can respect that."

For that development alone she wouldn't stop Perfuma from bothering them. It was clearly still an internal battle for Scorpia to give Catra space and to just accept things — as was visible right now from the tight frown on her face that looked like she needed to pee — but she tried.

And so did Catra.

She didn't know what she was supposed to say quite yet, but she already took a breath and looked at the woman, only to notice an angry red spot on her arm. "What happened?", she asked, honestly worried.

Scorpia looked confused for a second before following Catra's gaze. "Oh, that. Don't worry about it, it barely hurts."

"I took you here, I am responsible for you. Tell me what happened", she repeated, a bit of the anger, that she couldn't seem to get rid of, shining through.

The woman straightened up a bit — Catra's tone of voice probably reminded her of the Horde. "A clone got me, is all. Really, it doesn't hurt. Much."

She rolled her eyes. "Get Entrapta to look at that", she told her.

They had actual healers, and she knew that, but she didn't trust any of them. And the scientist was surprisingly good with medical procedures — quick, precise and most importantly unaffected. Catra hated nothing more than the healers gushing and worrying over her and pitying her state.

They clearly didn't like her because of that, but she rather sent the people she cared about to people she trusted. And they could

glare all they wanted, she wouldn't change it.

Being the reason anyone had to get hurt, the least she could do was make sure everyone had the best possible recovery, even if it meant delaying Adora's rescue by distracting the scientist.

"You're tense", Swift Wind suddenly said next to her. "You weren't that tense earlier."

Catra quickly took a look around her before glaring at the horse. "Who's watching Hordak?", she hissed.

"I got it", Scorpia volunteered happily and let herself fall back.

She heard Hordak grumble something, but she didn't care to understand it. "I'm fine", she said instead since Swift Wind still stared at her.

"No, you're not", he argued. "You were relaxed earlier. Well, more burdened actually, but calm. What destroyed my work?"

"Your work?", she scoffed.

"Yes, of course. Emotional support is one of my many skills", he replied, waving his mane around a bit. Sometimes she wondered if it hadn't been better if Adora had not transformed him again. "So?"

She sighed. "Nothing. It's just the fact that I had to run into the woods to save Hordak by starting an unnecessary fight that got one of us hurt that bothers me a bit." Along with everything else that was happening, but she didn't want to talk about that.

He stared at her for a while. "You sure you weren't overthinking again?"

"No, I wasn't", she insisted. She hated that he started to notice things — she clearly spent too much time with him.

"Sure", he said sarcastically. "We're all doing our best", he then said more softly, as if that would help her sleep at night.

"Prime is doing better", she responded.

"Which is not your fault", Swift Wind told her despite it not being true.

This was her fault. It was her responsibility, and it was on her to fix it.

And maybe if she had an actual idea of how to win this, she wouldn't mind that, but as it was, apart from the plan she had helped make before they had to flee Brightmoon, she had nothing.

Well, that wasn't true, she had a whole bunch of worries and nightmares, but that wasn't anybody's business.

"We're almost back", she said when Swift Wind was obviously waiting for a reply.

She heard the horse sigh, a clear sign he was giving up for now. But it seemed he wasn't entirely done yet. "People believe in you for a reason, maybe you should start to believe in you too."

All she could do was scoff in response. She didn't want to talk about why no one should believe in her, and how she would have actually preferred it if they all distrusted her after everything she had told them.

So, she simply kept her eyes trained on their destination, which wasn't even visible thanks to the sorcerers' spell, but that hardly mattered to her.

When they entered the camp, they received some stares as most people probably didn't even notice Hordak had been gone. He held himself with the poise of a warlord though, not shying away from the gazes, which she had to acknowledge, she supposed.

Entrapta had obviously not gotten too distracted in the meantime because she ran towards them before they had even made it to the center of the camp, all but slamming into Hordak and starting to ramble about something that she needed his opinion on.

Catra, Scorpia and Swift Wind were left behind as he was dragged off by the scientist. No last warnings or threats, not even a reminder to Entrapta to be more careful in the future, were possible.

She only sighed, letting it be, because she didn't have the energy to deal with this. She only wanted to tell Scorpia again to let her wound get checked, before going to help Glimmer organize some space for their new refugees if she needed it, then she would make a new ration plan and maybe figure out a way they could harvest the surrounding woods safely to avoid starvation.

But then someone behind her cleared their throat.

Catra turned around with great reluctance to spot Mermista standing there with her arms crossed.

The woman didn't say anything, just glared and walked off.

The three of them decided that this probably meant they were supposed to follow, so they did.

They went to the war tent again. Since everyone was present, she guessed the evacuation of Thaymor went smoothly. "Already back?", she asked them since no one else wanted to start.

"Thaymor wasn't a big deal", Bow answered her with a smile. "Most people had already fled before the spire could fully land. We found them in the woods with barely a bot around."

"And, I've already set them up", Glimmer added proudly. "We are running out of space, though. And I doubt they'll be very comfortable." Another thing to add to Catra's list to deal with.

"Uh, can we focus?", Mermista interrupted then. "Where were *you*? With Hordak?", she accused, glaring at Catra. Well, some people still held a bit of distrust for her — it comforted her a bit if she had to be honest, even if it could be annoying at times.

She sighed. "He decided to run, but I doubt he'll do it again", she told them.

"How did Entrapta lose him?", the sea princess asked once more.

"He's back, he won't run again. Nothing else matters", she growled. For some reason, despite the assumption being a correct one, it still made her angry to hear the princess think so little of the scientist — of course it would have been nicer to avoid all this, but the woman *had* prepared for the possibility at least.

"Maybe we should have restrained him, after all. Like Shadow Weaver", Perfuma suggested thoughtfully.

"Entrapta said they were making progress", Scorpia defended her friend now, too.

"We didn't benefit much from that progress, though", Netossa pointed out.

"We figured out how to disable the clones. That's not nothing", Bow reminded them. Right, it was only due a lab incident that let them know about the neck thing — hitting the clones had become so second nature to Catra, she almost forgot there was a time when she didn't know about that. "We should just give her a bit more time."

"How much more time do we have?", Castaspella asked.

"We can't just barge in, it's too dangerous." This coming from Glimmer really said a lot.

The girl looked at Catra with a tired, pleading look, so she took over again. "Hordak has been attacked by his own kind. I think he might understand now that he'll be doomed if he doesn't help us.

Give her a another day and if she doesn't have anything by then … we can think of something else."

The people in the room were both unhappy and relieved to hear that. Catra really couldn't win with them. Now she just had to think about what else they even *could* do.

"Good news!", a loud screech interrupted any thought she could have tried to form and Entrapta came barging in. Well, she was a princess too, so it couldn't really be called that. "I know how to defeat … whoever we're trying to defeat." She had started off loud and excited and ended confused.

Catra snorted. It lightened her mood, at least — she was really getting too attached to these people. "Horde Prime?"

"Yes!" The excitement was back.

"Are you serious? Don't tell me Hordak actually talked?", Mermista asked skeptically.

"Of course he did", the scientist answered like there was never any doubt. And maybe she really never had any. "Hordak kept calling Etheria a backwater planet, so I had already assumed that Prime's technology is way more advanced that ours, but I never imagined how advanced."

"What does that have to do with defeating Prime?", Castaspella interrupted with an infuriatingly condescending tone.

"It's all connected through a hivemind!", Entrapta screeched excitedly. "He might even be more advanced than the First Ones! Though, Hordak said that Prime didn't do magic, so not quite."

"Can you really find a way to defeat him?", Catra asked, barely sounding any softer than the others, but her agitated state was just the norm these days.

Entrapta nodded erratically. "We just need to infect the hivemind somehow. That way, we can shut all his armies down at once!

There would have to be a server room, or something like that. And we would need a virus." Her excitement dimmed a little before she thought of something. "The virus that infected my castle would have been a perfect base, but I don't know where it is. It just vanished", she said with a shrug.

Catra sighed, her own excitement leaving her. "Anyone volunteering for a mission?", she asked. Of course that stupid disk would become important.

"Mission? What mission?", Netossa asked skeptically.

"The disk is in my room. In Brightmoon", she told them. "I didn't think we would need it."

During the panic, everyone had decided to listen to the first person who yelled, which turned out to be Catra, who instructed them to simply run. Some were smart enough to grab some of the food from the dining hall, but they did not have time to take anything with them apart from the things conveniently lying around.

She had been lucky to have had the sword and her file lying next to her already — the latter one having been sacrificed to the first fire at camp because that much information really didn't belong in anyone's hands — but the disk had been left behind, along with everything else.

"You have got to be kidding me", Mermista groaned.

"Great, I'll come!", Glimmer said at the same time. "I can recharge if we're already there."

"That's too dangerous", Angella chimed in. "You'll be vulnerable and easily spotted. I do not allow it."

"I'm still going", the girl told her mother.

"I'll go too", Bow then said before the queen had a chance to answer. "I'll watch out for her."

"And I'll watch out for Catra", Swift Wind declared.

"I don't need anyone watching out for me", she grumbled. "Fine, should be enough. A smaller team is better for sneaking around. According to the scouts there are still a few bots around, but if we get in at the back-"

"And what if you get caught anyway?", Mermista asked. "I say, we put up a distraction. Me, Frosta and Perfuma can put up a fight to make sure nobody sees you."

Catra stared for a few seconds. That was surprisingly helpful. "Uh, okay, thanks", she said because so far the sea princess has not been the most active. Sure, she had fought, but outside of battle she was rather passive — passive aggressive for that matter, but passive all the same. She cleared her throat. "Alright. You fight the bots at the front, we sneak in through the back. We get the disk, and alert you. We should try to be quick, if reinforcements arrive we'll be doomed."

"In and out. Sounds quick enough", Glimmer said, optimistically as always.

"Let's hope so", she mumbled.

Chapter End Notes

> So... just as a warning, it is possible that updates will be a bit irregular going forward, depending on how fast I can get through editing.
> The next three chapters should be good and ready, but everything after is... Well, I haven't really looked at much of it yet, and I did make a few changes that will lead to inevitable rewrites. I doubt the upload schedule will be a complete mess, and I'll probably manage to still update one chapter per week. And maybe this is all bigger in my head and nothing will change.
> We'll see. Just wanted to let you know in case it is that bad.

Anyway, see you next time when we get the disk and check in on how Adora is doing!! Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 25: Leader - Part 2

Chapter Notes

First of all: Happy Pride Month everyone!!!

Sadly, that doesn't mean that we'll quickly reunite our main couple, that's still a few chapters away, but I can proudly say that the first days somehow fueled the gay as I have rewritten the confession scene, which is a lot better now. Can't wait for us to get there... eventually

That probably also tells you a lot about how much editing I've gotten done throughout the week xD

Anyway, I hope you have fun with this one, even if this chapter also suffers from me having looked at it so much I started to hate it <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had found interesting ways to pass the time. Sitting in her cell alone for days, save for the clones occasionally dropping in, made her feel rather restless. She has never been particularly restful, but now she was bouncing off the walls with all this anxious energy she couldn't get out.

So, she found ways to entertain herself.

First it was tedious things like making her bed and keeping things clean, which wasn't hard considering that Prime seemed to like white and spotless. Then she had moved on to find imperfections until it became a game for her. Little cracks in the wall, the floor, dust in the corners, spots on the clones' clothing and even cracks in their perfect attitude.

She was painfully aware that this was a potential sign of descending into madness, but what else was she supposed to do?

Prime hadn't called for her again after their first talk. She kept getting food and she had admittedly lost count at some point, which only fueled her desperation. It had been over two weeks, that she knew at least.

But apart from that, she knew nothing. Not what Prime planned to do with her since she refused to help him, not how her friends were doing, not what happened on Etheria. Nor what was going on with the old Horde. Was it still active? Were they fighting for Prime now? And if they weren't, what did they do? Was her old squad okay?

Catra had been right all along, Adora was a terrible friend. She should have taken her squad to Brightmoon, too. The first time around, she might not have had the chance, but this time? She had been so focused on Catra, she plain forgot about them. And now they might be dead.

Just like all her other friends might be. At this point, she has had several nightmares about all the possible outcomes of this situation, one worse than the last, and in all of them she had to watch at least half of her friends die.

And as if that wouldn't be enough, she also got weird dreams about She-Ra — like she didn't already feel terrible about being useless.

Adora had tried, after her misery had sunk in enough, to connect to her again, but she just didn't know how. She did believe Razz and that She-Ra was more than the sword, but she couldn't figure out how this was supposed to work without it.

She sat around for hours, focusing on feeling just the littlest spark, she even tried meditating, though she was sure she did it wrong. Nothing helped.

Maybe the problem was that she didn't exactly dare to say the magic words very loudly — even when she knew no one was

around, she still felt watched, and the less Prime knew the better, so she kept quiet.

At this point, she didn't hold out much hope to ever connect with She-Ra without the sword. If only she hadn't dropped it. But, she reminded herself, this way she couldn't be controlled at least.

She wondered if anyone had taken it, if it was save.

Since Prime hadn't boasted about his victory yet, he certainly cannot have found it anywhere, so she did believe that somehow the sword must be with the rebellion and away from him. Otherwise, he would have already activated the Heart, right?

The uncertainty of it all really was driving her mad — she had so many questions and worries, and no one would answer them. A rock had more insight than those clones.

And the worst part was that she knew that Prime knew. That letting her rot was making her mental state slightly instable. Maybe he was even counting on it.

"Little sister."

She jumped almost out of her skin. Even without a clock, she had gotten a pretty accurate feeling for when someone would bring her food, and after all this time, she hadn't expected anyone to show up irregularly either.

"Yeah?", she acknowledged the other's presence once she calmed herself a little.

"Prime wishes to see you", the clone told her as calmly as ever.

She let herself be guided since she had no choice but to obey anyway. There was no reason to waste her energy on fighting when she would just end up in the same cell again.

For some reason, she thought she would be lead to the same room as last time, but she ended in a room full of stuff. Artifacts,

weapons, and a bunch of other things she couldn't even name.

"Little sister, thank you for joining me", Prime told her like he had already forgotten she was a prisoner.

Adora resisted the urge to roll her eyes and remind him of the fact, sure that he was just messing with her. Instead she waited for him to say whatever he wanted to say.

"I thought you might enjoy a diversion. These are tokens from many worlds", he informed her as he waved a hand towards the walls lined with stuff. "Worlds that I brought into my eternal light."

"You mean, worlds you destroyed", she couldn't keep herself from saying. She will admit that she still didn't know what exactly his deal was, but she got the gist of it.

"I take no joy in destruction", he said, though it sounded rehearsed even to Adora's ears. "But the weeds must be burned away so that new life may flourish. You should understand that. She-Ra brings balance, does she not?"

"She-Ra protects people. All of them", she replied with emphasis. "She doesn't destroy."

He smiled in an odd, condescending manner. "But your old She-Ra did, did she not?", he asked curiously but didn't give her time to answer. "She has taken your true place in the universe from you, separated you from your people, and destroyed your planet's balance."

"No", she said confidently. If she believed in anything, then that Mara has been a hero. "The First Ones took everything. She only tried to protect us. From them. And from you. She might have isolated us, but she never destroyed life."

He hummed. "She may have never taken a life, but she has destroyed them", he corrected her. "People that have build a life on your planet were suddenly ripped from their homes, or loved ones. Only due to her 'protection'."

She studied him, but he didn't give anything away. Why were they discussing this? Adora doubted he cared much about how people felt right now, let alone people who have lived a thousand years ago. "Where is this going?", she asked therefore.

"You condemn me for trying to bring peace to the universe, but hail the one who has sought your misery. I am trying to understand where your heroism draws the line", he told her calmly.

Adora scoffed. "What you want isn't peace."

"Such conviction", he sighed "But I haven't called you here to discuss philosophy. I thought you might be missing your home."

She wasn't sure what to say, because yes she did miss it, but she also was afraid of what he wanted her to see.

This room also had monitors, and even without her response, they turned on. As expected, she didn't like it.

The picture that lit up behind Prime was more disgusting than anything her nightmares had come up with so far. Some of his clones were lying, clearly dead, in the woods, their bodies unnaturally torn open, their sickly green blood everywhere.

"My brothers have been securing their post when they were attacked unprovoked. This is what your friends left behind before they fled again", he told her. "Is that more peaceful?", he asked, probably rhetorically.

She answered anyway. "They wouldn't attack unprovoked. They must have had a reason." Her friends sometimes showed a tendency for violence, sure, but they wouldn't just mindlessly kill. "You have invaded their home, they have every right to protect themselves."

Prime sighed. "I have not expected you to understand", he said with pity. "You are far too emotional. Far too attached." He spat the last word out like he was disgusted just to say it.

The screens changed. Now they showed Brightmoon, which she had thought to be abandoned, but there were Mermista, Perfuma, Frosta and Swift Wind all fighting several bots on different screens.

Adora's eyes flickered over them fast, not sure where she was supposed to look. On another screen, inside the castle, were Glimmer and Bow, also fighting, with the latter shooting arrows and the former firing spells with a sorcerer's staff — she didn't know when that happened, but she guessed without being able to recharge, she had to find a different way to fight.

Not that it mattered. None of them looked to be in the advantage. They were losing.

They were losing until one camera turned off. Adora was taken aback for a second and she saw Prime's eyes narrow. The screen came back to life with a different camera angle.

Catra. She fought the bots surrounding Glimmer and Bow almost alone, jumping and clawing and showing off what she had always held back in training. Adora smiled even if she knew it was unwise.

The feline said something, which she couldn't hear, but she watched them run away. Something followed them, though, because they didn't get out of sight from whatever was filming them. The monitor paused on Catra's face then. She looked so tired.

"She is quite a nuisance", Prime then said, making both Adora's smile and heart drop. "Your rebellion is as unorganized as they come, but she…" He looked at the girl with disdain. "They have found a remarkable replacement for their hero, I will say. Under different circumstances, I would have liked her to enter my light. Have her under my command. She has potential", he kept musing, and it made Adora's skin crawl. "It's a shame, but she's too rebellious. There is no use in my empire for that."

She needed a second to process all of that.

Starting with… replacement for her? She supposed she shouldn't be as surprised as she was. Catra was smart and quick and calculating. The feline has lead the entire old Horde for almost a year and made them more effective. If anyone could keep them save, it was her. Honestly, if they needed to place their hopes in anyone, Catra was probably the most logical choice.

It just surprised her considering that Glimmer and the other princesses were still around, all of which she knew could lead the people.

Well, even if Prime overestimated Catra's role in the rebellion a bit, they probably still relied on her to strategize. And if the feline took a bit more charge during the battles, Adora was nothing if not proud.

Still, the rest of what he said made her anxious. The words reminded her painfully of Shadow Weaver, but worse. And she knew what they meant. Entering his light at least meant survival, even if she was sure that it would not be worth it. Having no use for him meant death.

"You are never gonna get near her." She knew she shouldn't say anything, shouldn't give anything away, but she felt afraid beyond compare and she couldn't stop herself from acting on her protective instinct.

Prime looked at her for a long time. "Interesting", he then said. "Anger, fear, you heart rate elevated when you saw her. She is special to you. Is she not, little sister?" It sounded mocking.

"She's my friend. Just like the others", she said, slightly confused. And maybe it made her nervous that he was singling Catra out as more important to her — she was, but in that moment Adora kind of wished she wasn't.

"No", he replied way too smugly. "That's not true. I have seen this countless times before. You are very much like people

everywhere. Uselessly forging these strong connections, and for what? They make you weak, and blind. Though for once, they might be serviceable."

Impulsively, she crossed the distance between them, and grabbed him — somehow, she felt more confident and stronger in that moment. "Don't you dare touch her", she all but growled.

Then two pairs of hands grabbed and pulled her back. She fought uselessly.

Prime looked at her with some odd satisfaction. "Thank you, little sister. This was very insightful", he told her. "And don't worry. I have no intention of hurting her."

The 'yet' stayed unspoken as the clones started to drag her off despite her kicking. And whatever strength had fueled her was quickly replaced by dread.

Whatever Prime thought about her and Catra, it was now clear to her that he planned on using the girl to force Adora to help him. But she couldn't help him, not without the sword, not without being able to connect with She-Ra.

What if he went after Catra, and Adora failed to 'cooperate'? She didn't even want to start imagining what he would do to the feline — her nightmares would probably fill the blanks anyway.

And worst of all, the screen had been paused the entire time. She had not seen any of her friends escape. What if he had done something to them already?

She should have just kept her mouth shut. Being a terrible actress, he probably would have noticed anyway, but she could have at least tried to keep her friend save.

And now, she had doomed Catra because of her stupidity.

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She should have been more careful, she knew that, but Brightmoon had been, guarded yes, but otherwise abandoned by Prime. It wasn't supposed to be this full of bots, it was supposed to be quick.

Catra rummaged through her drawers, pulling out everything except for that disk. Where did they put it? It had been a while and she had forgotten. Or maybe she hadn't and some clone had found and destroyed it already.

A scream made her stop for a second. She debated abandoning the mission, but forced herself to keep searching. There was no telling what would happen if they didn't get the disk. It was the only advantage they had. But with every drawer she ripped apart, she felt herself hyperventilate more.

She heard the entire battle outside and in the hallway. Where did all these bots even come from?

When they had gotten here, everything had been how their scouts had described it — a few bots guarding the entrances, but otherwise quiet. Just like it had been since they had to make camp in the woods.

Their distraction team took care of the few guards, and Swift Wind got them successfully into the castle through the back. Everything had worked so smoothly in fact, that she had sent the horse to help the others. And then they had been surrounded by bots in the otherwise empty castle.

Glimmer had used whatever reserves she had to get Catra to the bedroom before she went back to help Bow. And now Catra had to listen to them fight for their lives and losing, while grappling with the reality of this mission being a lost cause. Which was entirely her fault.

She forced herself to take a few deep breaths, so she could focus. There weren't that many drawers left and if the disk was here, it would be in one of them.

Pulling out more and more stuff, she really did start to belief that it was gone, but of course, as luck would have it, it was in the very last drawer she pulled out.

With a sigh of relief, she picked up the shards and shoved them in her pockets, careful that she had all of them.

Then she darted outside into the hallway, following the noise of battle. It wasn't hard to find or to sneak up on. With ease, she jumped at the bots, disabling them. Or most of the ones around her friends, as more came out of different hallways.

"We gotta get out of here!" She grabbed the others and started running in the other direction, the two stumbling a bit, but keeping up with her. But they wouldn't make it out like this. "Glimmer, you got something left?"

"Uh, not much", she said through heavy breathing. "Maybe I can get us somewhere close by?" It was doubtful, that much was clear, but Catra didn't want to get to safety.

"How about the moonstone?"

The princess looked shocked to say the least, but grabbed onto the two of them regardless and soon after, Catra felt the nausea rise in her as the world blurred shortly and they fell out in bright daylight. She threw up on the floor as Glimmer went straight to recharge and Bow took over defenses.

"You okay?", he asked her, shortly glancing over before scanning their surroundings again.

"I'll be fine", she mumbled and joined the watch on the other side to really cover everything.

She had the perfect view on the battle with the others. They were keeping the bots busy, but they needed help. Perfuma hardly fought anymore, seemingly injured. Frosta was getting sloppy due to exhaustion, and Mermista and Swift Wind wouldn't be able to hold them much longer either.

Then there were the bots inside the castle, who came running out now, looking for their missing targets.

"How long does recharging take?", Catra asked because they were extremely short on time.

"A few minutes", Glimmer answered. "Why?"

"We need to get the others out", she told her.

"Is it just me or did they somehow know we would be here?", Bow then wondered. "I mean, Brightmoon is miles away from any other town, so how did they get here so quickly?"

"Maybe they hid. Brightmoon is a pretty important stronghold, maybe Prime expected us to be back", Catra suggested. She would admit, it was odd that their scouts kept reporting low activity but suddenly there were bots everywhere. Like Prime had seen them coming — an unsettling thought. "I'll go help. You'll be fine, right?"

"Sure!", Glimmer said too confident for Catra to believe it. The girl groaned when she saw her raised eyebrows. "We can handle ourselves. Go help, we'll get you once we're done."

She sighed, but nodded.

On the way down the incredibly tight stair case, she kept her eyes and ears pealed. As she knew now, anything could show up at any second, but as she fought off the bots trying to take advantage of Perfuma's injury, nothing happened.

No reinforcements, nothing. At this point, some alarm must have reached other units. The lack of incoming threats made her more

anxious than any creepy clone ever could.

Prime set up an ambush with the apparent goal to overwhelm them and finish them off, but right as they were getting hurt and exhausted, he went easy on them?

To be fair, there were still enough bots around to make the battle impossible to win. But too little to stop them from escaping. And that just didn't sit right with her.

But even if it was highly suspicious, if Prime gave them the opportunity to flee, they should take it.

She just hoped Glimmer would be done soon because even her strength was starting to leave her. Catra thrived on striking quick and hard, not on long tedious battles. And with the others almost completely drained, they would soon be dead.

They were steadily getting surrounded by a circle of bots, and Catra was about to instruct Swift Wind to get at least Frosta and Perfuma out of here when both suddenly vanished in a pink cloud.

It seemed Glimmer and her had the same priorities.

She and Mermista were next, which left her heaving on the ground as always, with Perfuma and Bow gently patting her back, while Glimmer took care of Swift Wind.

"Great, that should be all", the girl said when she was back. "We should get going before they find us."

"One sec", Catra mumbled as she tried to regain her breathing.

"Sorry, there wasn't really much time for a warning", Glimmer apologized. Not that mentally preparing herself helped a lot. A bit, but there was just no getting rid of the nausea.

"I'm fine", she grumbled as she got up.

Swift Wind immediately came over to give her a chance to grab onto him, which she did — being teleported twice after exhausting herself left her a bit weak on her legs.

She quickly looked at everyone. Most seemed to be fine, just fatigued. Nothing they haven't dealt with before. But Perfuma had a big wound on her side and could hardly even stand.

"Swifty?", she asked weakly. For once, she was glad she was spending so much time with the horse because he understood without her having to say more.

Wordlessly, he knelt down and let Perfuma crawl onto his back. It was a bit unfair since he was tired too, but he was still the strongest out of all of them.

They quickly left then, before they were found, and the sooner they made it to camp, the sooner they could rest in safety.

The woods did give them a good bit of cover, clearly favoring the rebellion over Prime, but Catra still didn't fully trust it — they might have the advantage in the woods, but that didn't mean nothing could get in here. So she kept an eye on their surroundings, just in case.

"I just hope this stupid disk was worth it", Mermista complained, still breathing heavily.

"Uh, you did get the disk. Right?", Bow asked, slightly nervous.

Catra nodded. "I got it. I just hope that was all of it."

"What do you mean, all of it?", Frosta asked skeptically, looking downright panicked.

"Well, we had to destroy it because it was evil, so it's in pieces", she shortly explained.

"We're really giving an evil disk to Entrapta? Are you sure that's a good idea?", Perfuma asked carefully. "She's your friend. You

should know if this is right."

"One, not friends. Two…" She remembered all the times, the woman had tinkered with things that she wasn't supposed to or how her obsession with the disk had turned out for them in the Northern Reach. "It's the only chance we got", she settled on then.

Mermista groaned again. "You're so vague", she complained. "What do you know?"

"A lot, but none of it is relevant right now", she deflected.

"Feels relevant", the sea princess grumbled with a suspicious glare.

Clearly, not all of the princesses valued the scientist very much, or trusted her, or wanted to deal with her at all. Which she should have expected after having listened to Entrapta's excessive ramblings back during their time in the Fright Zone.

Catra had even used it to manipulate the woman to stay back then, believing to have exaggerated that they would just leave her, but after spending this long in extremely close quarters with them, she noticed that she hadn't exaggerated anything. Entrapta had simply downplayed the princesses' distaste.

And though she and the scientist were never really close, she had made the decision to keep everything about the woman's time in the Horde a secret.

Call her crazy, but just because everyone was willing to look past everything Catra had told them because they needed her, still didn't make her believe that they would extent the same grace to Entrapta, who they barely tolerated on a good day.

"It's really not", she responded with a little hiss.

"So", Bow went in between before Mermista could answer — it was always him or Glimmer who came to her rescue when she

grew tense around certain topics. "Should we worry? About just now?"

"We should always worry when it comes to Prime", she replied courtly. As much as she needed to be 'rescued' lately, she honestly felt a bit offended. How fragile did they think she was?

"Fair", Glimmer said. "It's just… okay, he knew we would be there. He knows and sees all blah blah. But… I'm not the only one who noticed how he kinda backed off, right?"

"Yeah … he did", Frosta mumbled, apparently just noticing it now. "Usually he would have sent more bots."

"And we almost died anyway. I don't get why this is such a big deal", Mermista argued. "Maybe he didn't want to waste more bots if he didn't need to."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Prime doesn't care about waste. He loves to show off how much better he is than us, how many more resources he has. We always have to be quick and focused, defending more than fighting because otherwise he will overwhelm us. It is quite a big deal that he didn't now."

"He's planning something then", Glimmer concluded. "What do we do?"

She had about enough of that question, especially when she was the one who had to answer it. Seriously, why did everyone act like she would know?

"We'll get the disk to Entrapta. That's our only hope", she told them anyway.

As much as she would like to say more, she didn't have anything. They would have to get to his server, but how? And even if they managed to shut down his armies, then what?

It was better to keep quiet. She would figure something out, she had to, but that would hardly come about in a discussion with the

princesses.

She found herself wishing for the hundredth time that Adora was here. The blonde could have good ideas. And if nothing else, she was great to brainstorm with.

But Adora wasn't here, thanks to Catra's terrible decisions.

Instead it was her that everyone relied on, and no matter how much she tried to busy herself, she just couldn't shake that this was wrong. She-Ra should be here, guiding them. It should be Adora who took care of refugees and lead battles.

And sure, her role here wasn't entirely new to her. Catra had done this before … but in the Horde. Where it didn't matter if people were scared of her or thought she was losing it. Here, she had to be optimistic and infallible. And she was terrible at it.

Clearly, or Bow and Glimmer wouldn't feel the need to be so careful around her.

She wasn't Adora, didn't have her sunshine, wasn't as responsible, or noble, or sympathetic. As much as she had always hated it, she understood why everyone was drawn to the blonde — she understood it very well, actually — and someone like that, who could inspire with their mere presence, would be a lot more helpful than Catra's attitude right now.

But this was not the right time to think about that. She still had a job to do. And they were getting closer to camp, which also meant closer to Entrapta.

Immediately upon piercing the illusion spell, she separated from the princesses to go to the scientist. She wanted to take Perfuma with her, but the princess trusted her own healers more and if Catra had to be honest, it was probably better if Entrapta could start working on the disk right away.

Naturally, she could be found in Mara's ship. That place had really become the woman's home, with all her stuff being here and even

the onboard kitchen being used. She barely even left it.

Catra heard her rambling long before she had reached the cockpit. She stopped in the door, slightly confused about the picture in front of her. "How's it going?", she asked, seeing the woman stuck under the console, probably repairing something.

Hordak stood next her, rather awkwardly holding several tools and staring at Catra like she was the greatest threat on the planet. She glared back with a look that she wished could kill.

Entrapta didn't seem to notice the tension as she popped out from underneath the control panel. "Catra!", she screamed excitedly. "I'm glad you're back, I have made great improvements on the ship, come look!"

She was dragged off to look at something she could best describe as cables sticking out. "We've been gone for only a few hours", she mumbled instead of commenting on something she didn't even understand.

"Oh, I've been working on it for days", was the easy answer. "Space is such a fascinating thing. Not that Despondos has a lot of it, but the basics are the same as in the Wider Universe. Like crushing pressure, freezing temperatures, vaporization… Right, Hordak?"

The guy only nodded silently.

"In order to achieve maximum velocity for lift off, the necessary repairs and upgrades to the shields, the engines and the life support are extensive, but don't worry! I've already repaired the drive. Now we got the shields to reactivate, and we just need to stabilize them. The system is also upgraded and functioning, so at least we have something to tell us where it hurts."

"Interesting choice of words", she mumbled, though it shouldn't surprise her when the woman had a pet robot named Emily.

"And, thanks to Hordak, we have a guess as to where exactly Adora is!", the scientist kept going, making Catra perk up. "Hordak said that if Prime took her, she will be on his flagship. And it's also where the server room would be, isn't that great! It should be easy to tell apart from the others, and even easier to reach, but…"

"Prime does not leave things unchecked. He sees all. His clones are everywhere, notifying him of disorder", Hordak finished for her.

Catra deflated. "So, even if we reach the ship, we won't get far." It wasn't a question, just the fact that was to be concluded from that.

Well, she had kind of expected something like that already. Of course being on Prime's ship would not be easy, there would be clones there too, and they surely wouldn't be okay with them doing some sightseeing.

She had to admit it hit different hearing it said out loud from Hordak, but that still didn't change the fact that disabling Prime's systems was the only hope they had.

With a sigh, she pulled the shards out of her pocket and placing them in a free space somewhere between junk and equipment. "Anyway, here's the disk at least. Or what's left of it."

Entrapta radiated with excitement and was practically bouncing.

Catra snapped her fingers, getting the woman to focus back on her. "Do whatever you want with it, but keep it away from the ship", she warned. "Without it, we're doomed. We have to get the virus to Prime somehow", she reminded the other.

Something like realization flashed in the woman's eyes and she nodded seriously. "I will be careful", she promised. "And I would never want to hurt Darla", she added and patted the console with her hair.

"Good", Catra sighed. "I'll leave you to it," she said and went back outside.

She stood there for a moment and breathed. It was about dinner time, but despite the day's difficulties, she didn't feel very hungry.

Instead she decided to think about the next big problem. They had the disk, Entrapta could make that virus, but then what?

Hordak, as much as she hated to admit it, was right — Prime would know they were coming, he would be prepared for them. They would have no way of actually getting far enough into his ship to search for a server room. Or Adora. And since Hordak himself thought it to be impossible, she doubted he would know how to work around it.

But maybe someone else would.

This was a terrible idea, and she knew it, but they didn't have time for Catra to sit around and drive herself mad. If this could be a shortcut, she would take it. Even if she really didn't want to.

She walked towards one specific tent that she had avoided since it was put up.

On the way, she did that breathing exercise that Perfuma had shown her. Because before she could realize her horrible plan, she would have to talk to Lonnie.

Catra spotted her old squad from afar, laughing and having fun even if their posture was tense.

They had only reluctantly agreed to the offer of shelter, and with the lingering hostility between the rebellion and former Horde soldiers, it was hardly a surprise that they would stay ready for a fight.

As she came closer, she really hoped they wouldn't try to fight *her* — after the day she had, she was not sure she would win.

Luckily, Lonnie settled for a simple glare for now, but if she thought that she could get rid of Catra with that, she really didn't know her well enough.

Kyle looked around confused due to his friend's shift in mood, and smiled brightly when he spotted her. "Hey Catra", he called out.

For some reason, he had been happy to see her again after they stumbled upon each other during an evacuation mission. It seemed, he was still happy to see her.

Lonnie, as mentioned, was not. She stood defensively in front of her friends, her arms crossed and the scowl persisting. "Would have thought you already forgot about us", she grumbled. "Wouldn't be the first time."

Catra took a deep breath — seeing as they weren't on good terms with each other, she had not exactly made it a priority to clear the air. Something she would have to do now. Even if her entire body rebelled against it.

Still, she forced the words out. "Look, I don't like you, and probably never will, but … I- I should not have let my anger out on you growing up. And we should have taken you guys with us when we left." This was as close to an apology as the girl was ever going to get.

They all stared at her in shock. Rogelio's mouth was hanging open, Kyle's eyes were big and wide, and Lonnie raised her eyebrows so high, they almost hit her hairline.

But they didn't say anything, so Catra decided to add a little something because she was not taking the entire blame for this. "To be completely fair, I was literally kidnapped, I couldn't have done anything for you even if I wanted to, but you still didn't deserve to be stuck there, facing Shadow Weaver's anger."

"Am I dreaming?", Lonnie asked full of confusion, shaking her head as if she could snap herself out of it.

"I wish you were", she answered honestly. If not for the fact that she needed something, she would have avoided them until Prime was gone or they were all dead.

"I … okay", the girl mumbled, still shocked but she seemed to recover. "Uh… I guess I shouldn't have given you such a hard time?", she awkwardly, and unnecessarily, tried to reciprocate. "And … I guess … I'm glad that you got out. I mean, you look worse than I've ever seen you, but you seem happier … sometimes. Point is, leaving was good for you, I suppose. And I can't really blame you for it." She glanced back at the tent for a moment.

"But for not taking you", Catra finished the thought that she was sure the girl was having.

The other didn't deny it. But her posture did loosen a bit in the face of understanding without being judged.

Similarly, the other two relaxed as well, and Rogelio started to grumble something that Catra didn't understand — she hadn't spent nearly enough time with him to even gauge his emotion.

He seemed to notice because he rolled his eyes and patted the open space next to him.

She looked over to Lonnie to make sure she understood correctly. The girl nodded and sat back down next to Kyle, so Catra took the other side next to Rogelio.

This was still very awkward, she would never truly belong with them and that was okay.

"Kidnapped?", Lonnie then prompted. "Really?"

Catra nodded. "Adora had Scorpia knock me out. When I got to, we were already in the middle of the woods", she told them.

"Didn't know she had it in her", the girl replied with a little laugh. "You must have been pissed."

She snorted. "I was. I yelled at her some, she surprisingly yelled back. Well, not that surprising… I had pushed her a lot. I don't think she really cared about what I wanted back then."

"Yeah, I heard about your enemy phase", the other commented — everyone had heard about the time travel story by now, the Brightmoon guards were gossips after all.

"Like she normally doesn't think she knows what's best for others", she grumbled sarcastically.

Lonnie shrugged, not disagreeing. "But she was right."

"Once", she growled. Adora, for example, was not right when she decided to run to the Fright Zone on her own because she probably thought that killing Shadow Weaver herself would be best for Catra. Yes, she had mentioned wanting the woman dead, but not like this.

"The Horde was really terrible, and everyone is much nicer here", Kyle said cheerfully then like that would make Adora's actions better. "I really do get that both of you left."

"I'm still pissed that you just deserted without wasting a thought about us", Lonnie had to point out again. "But … I do not blame you. I don't think I would have taken you if the roles had been reversed", she admitted, and honestly, that was fair.

Catra was more surprised that open communication really did solve issues quickly. She should have listened to Perfuma sooner. Maybe then Adora would be here.

"Thanks", she mumbled quietly. This was getting uncomfortable.

"Okay, enough about this", the other girl seemed to feel the same, even a bit red in the face, though Catra doubted she herself looked better. "How bad does it look for us?", she then asked, ever the observant one. "I mean, judging from the rings under your eyes, I'd say we're screwed."

"We're losing", she didn't even try to hide the fact. "Prime is inching closer by the day, he's got almost everything under control and I … I don't know what to do", she admitted, but couldn't look at any of them. "Adora should be here, she's the hero."

"But she isn't here", the other said like she had needed a reminder. "You are. You're leading now and … I hate to tell you this, but you're actually good at it." Her face looked like she had eaten a lemon.

At least she had to laugh. "I'm not a leader."

Lonnie scoffed. "You're making all the plans, you're the one yelling at everyone, the princesses listen to you, you manage resources, you made the shift plans, you organize everything around here — sounds like a leader to me."

She knew the girl was right. With as many jobs as she had taken over, and being the one mostly thinking about what to do, she had a bigger responsibility than the queen right now. It still didn't feel right.

"Is it really that bad?", Kyle asked nervously after no further answer came from her. He looked around like a clone could jump out behind a tent at any moment. Not a bad instinct, actually.

"Yeah", she told him, making him squeak in fear. "Entrapta is working on a way to disable Prime's systems. With that down, we might have a chance", she then added. "But we have no way of reaching his servers."

"Well, if you can do anything, besides being annoying, it's strategizing. You've always been infuriatingly good at that, so put it to good use", Lonnie said nonchalantly, like one would say Etheria is round or the grass is green.

It did help make her feel a bit more confident. "I'll try", she responded and got up again. "Mind if I go inside for a minute?", she asked, though she didn't really need permission.

Still, the other girl stopped her. "You of all people should not talk to her."

"I need to", she told her. "I'll be quick." She didn't wait for more protest and simply went in. Though she did hear Lonnie sigh in exasperation.

It was dark in the tent. No one had bothered to put a light in here, and it smelled like rotting flesh.

Maybe it wasn't actually all that bad, but most normal things tended to be slightly overwhelming for her. At least that also meant she could see in the dark, see the pitiful picture that Shadow Weaver presented, tied up and forgotten.

"What a nice surprise", the woman said, sounding as honest and caring as ever, but Catra was done falling for it.

"I'm only here on business", she told the other and saw her eyes narrow. "We're up against a maniac, and I thought if anyone knew something about that, it'd be you."

A light chuckle escaped the sorceress. "You're here because you wish to gain knowledge on how to save Adora", she corrected. "Don't think I haven't heard your little chat. You want to reach Prime, but not for his servers."

"I can want both", she growled.

"Keep telling yourself that. You've always been rather territorial and selfish. I don't believe for a second that you really care about anyone here", the woman said with a bored type of disdain. Like she couldn't fathom that she had to explain this.

Catra took a deep breath and actively had to hold back from extending her claws. "Believe whatever you want", she told her. "You and Prime have quite a lot in common, and I want to know how we can trick him. I can't keep him from spotting us when we'll try to come to his ship, but I can get him to lower his guard."

A sigh. "You might be smarter than I give you credit for", Shadow Weaver grumbled. "I have heard a bit about Prime during my time in the Horde. He is self-centered and confident in his power. He doesn't think he *can* lose. That can make people blind."

"So … he does not see all?", she asked, trying to find the right meaning behind the words. This woman just couldn't make things easy for her.

"Only an egomaniac would think he could", the sorceress told her.

Catra thought about that for a moment. It was a fact that Prime did have eyes everywhere. According to Entrapta, they were working in a hivemind, which meant that any information always reached him. But … he couldn't see inside their spell. There were no bots or clones here. He wouldn't know how many people were on the ship that would be on its way to him. Maybe a B-team could sneak around.

Shadow Weaver sighed. "You are just as delusional if you truly think you can beat him. And if you think that Adora is still alive, you are naive", she spat. "I have worked for Hordak long enough to know that Prime is not a merciful creature. What need would he have for her? It's not like she can be She-Ra."

This time, she couldn't hold back the claws anymore. She ripped open the woman's shoulder when she got close and grabbed her. "She is not dead." She just couldn't be. "And if you wouldn't be such a scumbag, she never would have been taken."

"You are letting your emotions get the better of you", Shadow Weaver responded in a hiss. Though if from anger or pain was unclear. "*You* have driven her away and now she has been the first casualty of this new war. Both of you were disappointments in the end."

For some reason, that calmed her down immediately. She let go of the woman and took a step back. Once upon a time, this would

have hurt her greatly, but now… Now she knew that this woman didn't care enough to really mean that.

"You're not disappointed in me, or Adora", she said quietly. "You're mad at yourself because you didn't get us to do what you wanted. You don't feel anything for anyone. You cannot love anyone but yourself. And that is sadder than my life could ever be."

Catra didn't wait for an answer, and simply left.

Neither of the three guardians asked her anything or stopped her, probably knowing it wouldn't do them any good.

She walked all the way to her own tent before she allowed herself to have a little breakdown.

As suspected, this had been a stupid idea.

And just because Shadow Weaver's cruelty towards her didn't bother her much anymore, what she had said about Adora did.

Catra knew, of course, how unlikely it was for the blonde to be still alive. The sorceress was right, without the ability to be She-Ra, what use did Adora have to Prime? Why would he keep her around for so long?

Maybe she was delusional, maybe she was too emotional, but she couldn't let herself believe that Adora was dead. She had to be alive and until she saw a corpse, Catra would not start to doubt that. She was gladly delusional and worried if it gave her the feeling that there was still something left to save. If it gave her something to cling onto.

She wondered if Adora worried too. She snorted at the thought — of course Adora worried, it was all she ever did. That girl wanted to be everyone's hero so bad, she hardly cared about her own health, only about other people.

Catra glanced at the remains of the sword that was next to her makeshift bed. She had kept it, though she wasn't entirely sure

why. Glimmer could have taken it, or Swift Wind, or anyone else. But she wanted to have it.

She has hated that thing since the first time she had seen it, and hated She-Ra along with it. She had wanted to get rid of them both, and in a way she did by destroying it in a fit of rage. Wasn't it a bit ironic now, that she wished for nothing more than for Adora to be here and use it?

What was done was done and if nothing else, no one had to worry about the Heart anymore.

And it didn't matter anyway. The sword being intact or not would hardly have an impact on Adora's current state. If she still had a state to be in.

She took a deep breath. They would get the virus to work, they would make it to Prime, they would trick him and hopefully defeat him, and … they would get Adora. That was all that mattered right now.

Even if she was delusional to think that, she would never give up on saving Adora — she didn't get her friend back only to lose her now. She just had to hold on a bit longer.

Chapter End Notes

> Sooo, out of everything, I'm kinda the least happy with the talk between Catra and the squad, but ... it was worse before rewriting it, so ¯_ (ツ)_/¯
> And maybe I can get away with pretending that was all on purpose to show how uncomfortable the situation is and that's why it doesn't flow that well... Yeah, I like that xD
>
> Anyway, gonna be another week of wait and then we'll go on a little adventure <33

Chapter 26: Beast Island - Part 1

Chapter Notes

I, once again, don't feel too great about this chapter. I don't like the pacing, but apart from that it's fine, I think...

Anyway, I don't have too much to say here, so let's get to the trigger warnings because hehe ... there are a few
*clears throat'
First, there's another small timeskip, but nothing too terrible. Then, warnings for angst apply, including a little panic attack, mentioned trauma, neglect, desperation, mild humiliation, self deprecating thoughts, and a few suicidal thoughts.

I did try to make note of everything as I just read through it, and I hope I didn't miss anything. Honestly, in my humble opinion I think it's all still rather tame, but I warn you anyway just in case <333 Have fun!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

If any of the princesses had seen her talk to Shadow Weaver, they at least didn't bring it up.

But she might just be avoiding them too much for them to even get the chance, because she couldn't stand their constant worry.

Catra was aware of how terrible she was doing, she didn't need any of them to tell her that she needed a break.

Busy was good for her, and her biggest problem wasn't her health, but the fact that it had gotten harder to keep busy now that there were no towns left to save. They still took in refugees if they found them, but it simply did not fill enough time.

And that only lead to her worrying. Prime had invaded everything by now — except for a good part of the woods, and she wondered why that was. It made her nervous.

It probably had something to do with him letting them go, back when they got the disk from Brightmoon, but the thought that he was sparing them for some reason didn't make her feel calmer in the slightest.

He was planning something, she just knew it, and she really didn't want to find out what he was waiting for.

Which was probably why she went to check on Entrapta in every bit of free time that she had. Luckily, it didn't seem to bother the woman that she showed up every few hours, though Hordak certainly wasn't happy about it. Not that she cared.

Admittedly, if it weren't for Hordak and her inability to sit still, she would be living with them just to be the first one to know when it was done.

Fortunately for all of them, she did find other ways to keep busy, like managing their dwindling resources, or handling small disputes within the refugees, or avoiding the princesses.

But eventually her way always lead her back to Mara's ship, always hoping that the virus would finally be done. She knew these things took time, but after almost five days it really wasn't unreasonable that she got a bit antsy.

"Any progress?", she asked, as she entered the cockpit again, as if the scientist didn't always have some development to ramble about.

Entrapta smiled brightly when she saw her. "Catra! Good, you're here!", her shrill voice greeted her as if this wasn't the fourth time they saw each other today.

A strand of hair pulled her closer to the woman that vibrated with excitement.

"I finally completely restored the virus and ran some analysis", she told her. "It is fascinating. I knew the virus had to be powerful but the data is suggesting that's it's highly destructive. It must

have gotten damaged in the centuries down in the mine, but I have restored it to what I think was the original intent."

"Which means what?", Catra asked with forced calmness, resisting the urge to demand a more concise answer.

"It has probably been created to fully destroy any First Ones tech from the inside. Letting it rot in a mine made it turn tech evil, minimizing and redirecting the damage it was supposed to do, but I worked on it to make it fully destructive again", Entrapta explained.

"So it works?" She had to ask, just to be sure she actually understood what the other was talking about before allowing herself to hope.

"Yes! In theory." The woman looked contemplative. "I cannot be sure until I can test it on something big, possibly to the scale of Prime's servers. The problem is just that we don't exactly have much tech to spare", she mumbled, looking around like she was hoping to find some.

Catra nodded, slowly processing that they really had a chance. "So, we need to find something", she then said.

"Ideally", Entrapta agreed without any of the worries that were appropriate.

Because, where were they supposed to find something? Everything was swarming with bots and clones.

One option would be the beacon in the woods, but she doubted they would get in without the sword, and she didn't really feel eager to go there either.

The only other thing she could think of was Bow's dads' library, but that place had been pretty much raided three days ago — which was the only reason they even got to know about it, and also why the pair was with them now. If anyone could step foot in

there, they would have stayed, a fact that they had been and still were pretty vocal about.

In other words, they had no place, that they could reach, to get tech.

The prolonged silence must have signaled to Entrapta that Catra didn't have anything, because she suggested something of her own. "We could ask Darla. You remember Darla, right?"

"The ship? Yeah", she said, and had to admit, the idea wasn't half bad.

The woman laughed as she dragged Catra over to the control panel. She noticed Hordak, who had been cleaning in the background, look over curiously as Entrapta powered up the ship, but he kept his distance — as always when Catra was around. "Say hi, Darla!"

"Welcome", a computer voice said.

"Isn't she cute?", Entrapta cooed and went to hug the holographic orb that had appeared in the middle of the panel. Emily beeped out some protests.

It squirmed out of her grip. "What can I assist you with?", Darla then asked.

Catra decided to ignore the weirdness of all that. "We're looking for a place to test a dangerous virus on some tech", she supplied. "Somewhere damage won't matter", she added because they should probably try not to destroy anything important.

The board computer calculated for a while and Catra wondered if it took so long because of how old it was or because there was so much data. Eventually, Darla was with them again. "The only place of no relevance with technology is … Beast Island."

"Good girl!", Entrapta cheered.

"Beast Island?", Catra repeated. The universe truly hated her. "We can't go to Beast Island. There has to be somewhere else. What if I allow a little damage?", she asked anxiously, her heart beating rapidly just at the mention of this cursed place.

"Every other place that contains technology is of too high relevance. Damaging it is not recommended", Darla told her. "The Hazardous Materials Disposal Site known as Beast Island is ideal for your endeavor."

"We should tell the others", Entrapta reasoned and ran off before Catra could stop her.

Neither could Hordak, who stood just as shocked in the now silent room. For once the look they shared wasn't one of hatred. "You can't let her go there", he said, though he sounded like he would rather not talk to her.

"Nobody is going", she told him seriously, though a bit of fear still shone through her voice. Then she went to run after the scientist.

Even though she wasn't even a mediocre fighter, Entrapta was fast, and apparently already made it to the war room tent. Barely anyone was there, but the woman explained her progress on the virus anyway, and by the looks of it nobody understood a thing.

"Catra", Glimmer sighed in relief, when she came in. "Please tell me you can translate", she begged.

She briefly wondered why the princess, Bow and Scorpia apparently held a private meeting, but shook her head and focused on the topic at hand for now. "She got the virus to work. At least in theory. We need to test it", she explained shortly, though her voice still sounded a bit shaky.

"On Beast Island!", Entrapta added unhelpfully.

"Beast Island?!", Scorpia screeched, looking like she had just woken up from a nightmare. That was the correct reaction if anyone asked Catra.

"What's Beast Island?", Bow asked, rather confused about Scorpia's reaction and by the way he looked over to her, her own fear must be on full display.

"It's a terrible place!", the woman blurted out before Catra had a chance to answer. "With blood beetles, and trees with razor-sharp blades instead of leaves." She shuddered.

As much as it was debatable how much of the Horde's horror stories were actually true, she knew that Beast Island was dangerous, or it wouldn't be the number one place to send your worst enemies. "It's where the Horde used to send traitors and prisoners", she added to give a bit more context. "There's not much known about it. No one ever came back from it. It's a fate worse than death."

Glimmer laughed nervously. "So, why do we wanna go there again?"

"We need to test my virus!", Entrapta chimed in. "It's crucial we test it before using it. If not we could run the risk of it failing and us … well, dying I guess. And Darla said it's the perfect place!"

"Beast Island will kill us before we can test it", Catra told her.

"We'll just have to prepare and-", Entrapta started, optimistic as ever.

"You're not going to Beast Island!", Catra interrupted rather quickly. And loudly. But she hadn't been send back in time only for her to let the woman meet her fate on Beast Island regardless.

The room fell silent and stared at her with more worry than she had ever seen them portray. Even the scientist seemed more unsure than usual, looking at her with wide alarmed eyes.

"I mean… To be fair, they said the Crimson Waste was dangerous too", Bow carefully said.

"This is not the same!", Catra insisted, still yelling because what kind of an argument was that? "Beast Island isn't just difficult terrain. I don't even know what we would have to deal with. There's nothing we could prepare, no plans we could make that would save us."

"We have run unprepared into a lot of things, including the waste, but also Prime", Glimmer said then. "We've survived him without knowing anything about him, and I doubt there are worse monsters out there than him. We can do anything."

Catra could not even come close to understanding how the others stayed so calm when she felt like hyperventilating. "There's a reason Hordak sent traitors there and not the waste or the front lines — he wanted to make *sure* they are dead", she said, slightly loud again, but she didn't care, not when she started to feel a bit faint. "I don't want to go there, I couldn't even send Shadow Weaver there even though she deserved it!", she rambled pathetically.

"Whoa, hey", Bow said calmingly and carefully guided her over to a chair before she collapsed. "There's clearly more going on than just a few horror stories. Wanna talk about it?", he asked, soft and open like he always did.

Glimmer came to her other side. "No pressure", she told her. "We know the … other time is not your favorite topic."

Catra had to take a few calming breaths before she was ready to say anything. "There's not much to talk about", she mumbled then. "I was supposed to send Shadow Weaver, but couldn't, which gave her the opportunity to escape, for which Hordak wanted to send me to Beast Island."

"Wait", Scorpia mumbled then. "Is that why you hate him so much?"

"Among other things", she confirmed. "I mean, I didn't even go. He changed his mind and sent me to the waste instead."

"No, that does not make it better", Glimmer told her and sighed. "Okay, we'll find something else then. There have to be more places. Like a ruin or something?"

"Darla said there is no other place", Entrapta chimed back in then, though she still looked a bit shaken from being yelled at, which was weird. Yet, she stared Catra down with a certain determination that already told her how this was going to end. "You need that virus. We need to save the planet."

Catra sighed. She knew she was right. They had no other option, and no other chance than this. That didn't mean she had to like it, but she would have to accept it. "Fine", she mumbled reluctantly. "But only if you stay with me at all times. No running off and you have to listen to everything I tell you, got it?"

Entrapta gave her a short quizzical look, but nodded anyway. "Got it!"

"Are you sure?", Bow asked carefully.

"We are all in danger until Prime is gone, and … if a different kind of danger is the only option we have then so be it", she replied, and wished she felt as confident as she just sounded. "Let's pack. And we gotta find a place to put Hordak because there's no way I'm taking him."

Her friends shared a skeptical look. It was Bow again who bravely spoke up. "Honestly, it doesn't look like you should go. We can just-"

"Don't even try", she growled and got up. She was still scared — it would be stupid not to be — but since they could hardly leave the scientist behind, Catra had to come and make sure she would stay alive.

"Fine", Glimmer sighed. "I agree with Bow, but it's not like we can stop you. Or her. So, when do we leave?"

"As soon as possible right?", Bow guessed.

"I'll come too", Scorpia chimed in then.

"Hold on", Catra then said. "You're still injured", she told the woman, who deflated a little but also didn't look too unhappy about being excused. "And you two are definitely not coming."

Glimmer scoffed. "I can do whatever I want."

She hummed. "I doubt your mom will agree."

The girl laughed mockingly. "Well, you see, I just won't tell her."

"Again?", Bow exclaimed with concern. "Glimmer, you got to tell her. You know she'll worry."

"Are you gonna tell your dads?", she challenged.

"That's different, and you know it. Your mom at least lets you fight now. My dads are still mad at me for lying to them for years, I doubt they'll let me go if I tell them", the boy pointed out.

"Hypocrite", Glimmer hissed.

Catra cleared her throat then before this escalated. The last thing they needed was infighting. "Both of you are asking or I'm not taking you", she said, and hoped that at least one of them was forced to stay behind.

"She'll never let me go!", the princess complained. "Come on, we'll be fine. She'll barely know I'm gone."

"I'm sure she'll notice the ship missing", Bow mumbled and earned a glare.

"I'm not discussing this", Catra said sternly. "If you wanna die so badly, at least say goodbye."

That finally put things into perspective for them, and they stopped arguing.

So while Glimmer and Bow went to deal with their respective parents, Catra and Entrapta walked back to the ship to prepare it for a proper flight.

She had to ignore Hordak's intense glares, and also had to take regular breaks cleaning out the cockpit to breathe — she was still not warming up to the idea of going to Beast Island, but … she couldn't not go and risk everyone getting killed. She had to make sure they all made it out of there alive.

Once, Entrapta ran outside to deal with some small last minutes repairs that Darla pointed out.

Catra decided to use the time. "*You* try stopping her", she growled at Hordak, who still scowled at her.

"You are the one in charge here", he almost yelled at her. "If anyone could stop her, it's you. I thought it's your job to keep us alive."

"Which is why we are testing that virus. So your insane brother doesn't kill us all", she hissed back.

"You act like that's my fault", he grunted and kept securing all of Entrapta's tools.

"It is!", Catra snapped. "You and I, we're responsible for this, whether you like it or not. You're just lucky not to remember, but you send that maniac a message, and are just as much to blame as I am, but at least I don't sit around and mope!"

"I do not mope!" Now he did yell. "At least I don't punish myself for my actions! I can live with them!"

"I'm back!", Entrapta interrupted their … discussion. "Did I miss something?", she asked, apparently noticing the tension in the room.

"No", they both said quickly and went back to their respective tasks — at least that they could agree on.

Soon after, Glimmer and Bow showed up, along with Perfuma who had seemingly volunteered to be Hordak's and Emily's babysitter.

It honestly surprised Catra to see them, but by the looks of it, neither goodbye must have gone exactly great.

According to Bow, his dads were still angry enough to not even have listened to him. And Glimmer… The picture the princess painted was certainly a concerning one, with Angella so incredibly hopeless that she didn't object to her own daughter going on a suicide mission.

Well, Catra wouldn't dwell on any of it, since the situation clearly worried both of them. And they had to focus on surviving.

"Everyone ready?", Entrapta asked them, and they all nodded with a certain amount of apprehension. Then the woman turned to Darla. "To Beast Island!"

***

If her mental state hadn't started to crack before, Adora was definitely going mad since Prime had shown an interest in her relationship with Catra.

That day, she hadn't done much more than stare numbly at the infuriatingly white walls for hours before throwing her food back at the clone that had brought it to her.

For a moment she had worried that her outburst would have bigger consequences, but the next day, the clone came back to feed her like normal.

She had stared at the plate and briefly debated going on a hunger strike, but she had already failed as She-Ra, she did not need to

make it worse by being malnourished if she did get a chance to help her friends.

That also meant that she couldn't sit around stupidly anymore, so she got busy the way the Horde had shown her — by hitting things.

At this point, she was on her fifth set of furniture because for some reason they kept replacing them. She would feel better if she could hit the clones, but while Prime didn't seem to mind that she repeatedly demolished her room, since nobody stopped her, he probably would mind if she showed any hostility towards him.

But she would love hurting him more than anything. Though she couldn't tell how much of that anger really was her own, and how much was the result of feeling trapped and throwing furniture around for days.

Then again, anyone who threatened her planet and Catra probably deserved a bit of pain.

And how was Etheria doing? Was it even still standing? Was anyone still alive? Was she holding out hope for nothing?

Was Catra still alive? Was she okay? Adora didn't know what she would do if she wasn't.

She heard the clones share orders sometimes — they still sent people down to Etheria, and they wouldn't do that if there was nothing left to save, right?

But more importantly, as she realized a few days after she has heard the last order, if they sent clones to Etheria from here, she could leave this ship.

Adora was admittedly not at her best right now, her body tense with anxiety and her mind fatigued, having been plagued by nightmares for weeks. But she just had to try.

It was dumb and risky, and she knew that, but she couldn't stay here any longer, couldn't keep failing everyone — she had to get back to Etheria, she had to make sure that Catra would never meet Prime.

She thought of … well, something like a plan, and waited until the next time a clone brought her food.

A very sharp leg of the newly destroyed chair was lying next to her, and just out of sight from the cell's entrance.

The clone gave her an odd look, and she cursed herself for her terrible poker face. She tried to smile at him to assure him that everything was normal and fine, but that seemed to make him debate whether he wanted to open the cell at all.

She would admit, she would also be suspicious if her prisoner, that had been throwing chairs for the last few days, would suddenly be calm and collected.

But it wasn't a big secret that she was growing more emotionally instable. And they still didn't have the greatest critical thinking skills, so maybe she could get out of this.

"If Prime wants me to act more normal then maybe he should consider not imprisoning me!", she snapped at him, which weirdly enough did make the clone less suspicious of her, and he finally deactivated the force field.

He barely had the time to lower his hand again. She got up and hit him with the chair leg so fast, she even impressed herself a bit. He fell forward with a grunt, and she hit him again in the neck — she had noticed the odd shape of the back of their necks a while ago, and she was relieved to find out it was indeed their weakness.

She didn't celebrate though, and simply ran.

Every corridor in this place looked exactly the same, as she had already figured out, so any guess was good enough to drive her

forward. She only ever stopped briefly to stare into different rooms, but none of them were what she was looking for.

The hallways had always been empty when she had been lead around, so she had hoped to avoid running into any clones, but it seemed that assumption had been wrong as she ran into three of them after rounding a corner, and not far enough from her cell if one asked her.

"Little sister", a clone greeted her with suspicion all over his face. "You should not be here."

"Oh, well…", she forced out with an awkward little laugh as she backed away a bit. "I just needed to stretch my legs. Pretty sure I've asked for that ages ago, seems like I was finally granted it."

All three clones furrowed their brows in synchronism. "Lord Prime has given no such orders."

Before they could fully figure out what that meant, she had knocked the first one out with her chair leg. The other two stood in shock, so she had enough time to strike down the second one. And by the time the third one charged at her, she was already evading him to get to his neck, too.

She was about to let out a sigh of relief that she was still in pretty decent shape, when the room suddenly turned red, and an alarm started to sound.

"Damn it", she hissed and kept running.

But she still had no idea where to. With time against her, she frantically stumbled through the halls, glancing into any room she could find, but none of them looked to be the right one. Then again, she had no clue about tech to begin with, let alone alien tech — maybe she had already run past the right room.

No, she couldn't allow herself to think like that. The right room had to be somewhere, and she had to find it before the clones found her.

Breathing became harder the more she ran, and she could hear the clones in the distance, which meant she really had to hurry. Or give up, but that was not an option.

Finally, when she already had the feeling that the clones were breathing down her neck, she found it.

Coincidentally, a clone vanished right at the moment she had run past, luckily confirming her guess. Otherwise, she wasn't sure she would have risked running inside.

Once there, she quickly smashed the control panel for the door, which made it close permanently, then struck down the two remaining clones who were already coming for her.

When that was done, she was wheezing with every breath, and her lungs and legs hurt, but she couldn't stop now.

Adora forced herself forward, flinching at the sound of the clones trying to smash the door in, and looked at the control panel.

From what she could tell, the coordinates for Etheria must already be in there, she just had to figure out how to activate it.

And fast because the clones had already managed to split the door open a bit. She really wished she had listened to a few more of Entrapta's ramblings, maybe then she could make sense of this.

"Okay", she mumbled anxiously. "Those are the coordinates, that's safety, the system's overview, so that…" She clicked on something and hoped nothing would explode.

But luckily, the screen only lit up with a single message "Initiated". The tube on the other end of the room was glowing a slight red, probably indicating that something to transport was still missing.

The clones were almost through, so she quickly made her way over, but just as she was about to reach it, she tripped.

Looking down, she saw a clone having squeezed himself through the door and holding onto her ankle. She kicked him swiftly and tried again to reach the tube, but by now, more than just one clone has made it into the room.

They basically threw themselves on top of her to stop her and she did not have the strength left to fight much.

She tried, she really did. She dug her nails into the tube's opening, she kicked and punched whoever she could but there was an endless supply of them, and only one of her.

In the end, she could do nothing but flail around uselessly as they dragged her away.

By the time they reached Prime's throne room, she truly had nothing left anymore. She had failed. Again. The world's worst She-Ra.

Prime looked equally disappointed in her as she was in herself. "For this planet's greatest protector, I have assumed you to be a bit smarter", he lamented. "I will admit that I have neglected you lately, little sister. I understand that isolation can make some behave erratically."

He paused like he expected her to defend herself or something. But he was out of luck. She was determined to go on that hunger strike and just perish. Without She-Ra, he would not need to get Catra, and at least she could be safe then.

He sighed. "If it's assurances you need, I can guarantee you that your Catra has not been harmed."

At that, she did look up, making him smile this creepy, disgusting grin.

"No one in your precious rebellion has", he kept going, and motioned at the giant monitors behind him, that lit up showing a map of Etheria that had Horde symbols all over it. Except for the Whispering Woods. "They are fools if they think that I would not

be able to notice their illusion spell. They are not as stealthy as they think they are. But I am willing to leave them be, for now."

"Why?", she asked carefully, dreading the answer.

"I still need them, of course", he laughed condescendingly. "Without them, you will be even less cooperative. And without them, the weapon at the heart of your planet might not work."

She should definitely reconsider starving herself. Without She-Ra, nothing would work, and he had to leave without taking Etheria with him.

Prime grabbed her face harshly, forcing her to look at him. "I advise you to play nice. If you try to escape again, or harm yourself, I will not hesitate to wipe them all out. Your weapon might be useful, but it is not a necessity. Am I understood?", he snarled.

She swallowed down her fear. "Yes", she mumbled and was let go of.

"Good", he said, sounding a lot more calm than just now, like he did her a great kindness. She hated him so much. "I am glad to have found an agreement with you, little sister."

Adora once again didn't say anything, feeling more defeated than ever. She couldn't do anything right.

He leaned back in his chair and looked at her for a long while with a sense of satisfaction. "Take our guest back to her room", he then ordered. "I don't think she'll be making any more trouble."

She let herself be dragged off, and kept lying on the floor of her cell where she had been deposited until her dinner came. For a long while she didn't touch it, not hungry and her appetite lost a while ago. Just like her hair tie had been lost somewhere during the invasion of the clones into the teleport room.

Without She-Ra, all alone, and now her ponytail gone too … who even was she anymore?

Eventually, she forced herself to move and eat. Not out of any leftover survival instinct, but strictly out of fear of what Prime would do should he think she was trying to get in his way again.

She spent the rest of her night — or what she assumed to be night, at least — mostly crying in between bouts of numbness.

Nothing mattered anymore. If she did or didn't disobey his orders, Prime would destroy her planet and everyone on it eventually. But the least she could do now was buy them every scrap of time they could get, so they might figure out how to do what she can't — defeat him.

So, she played nice. Ate her food, stopped destroying the furniture, and waited. Either for her end, or his.

***

Catra had been forced to crawl into the smallest room in this stupid ship and she hated it.

Apparently they were also testing Darla while they were already on it and about halfway through their journey, some electrical issue hit them and they had been sitting in the dark. And because she had the best vision, they sent her to fix it.

Ironically she still needed some light to see, and even though she liked being away from Bow and Glimmer's worried faces, she she did not have fun stumbling over boxes.

Well, at least she had some quiet to think about what to do. Like she had said, there was nothing to plan about Beast Island, but they needed a plan for after, *if* they made it back.

They would have to fly up to Prime's ship. She guessed that the clones would greet them, they would probably take them prisoner or something and, if they were smart, search Mara's ship. So, their virus-bearing B-team would have to hide somewhere, but how could she avoid them being found?

She decided she would have to ask Entrapta about it, since she knew the ship best.

For now though, she had to hope to find the right button without getting possibly electrocuted. Why did this thing not have any emergency lights? Everything else still worked, why the stupid lights?

With the limited outlines she could see, she was impressed she even managed to find the right room. She carefully pressed something and nothing happened. Well, at least she wouldn't get hurt.

She pressed more buttons until suddenly the lights came back and she hissed at them as they blinded her.

Once she could see something again, she made her way back, hoping whatever the other buttons did, didn't mess up something else.

"I'm just worried", she could hear Bow say when she got close enough to the cockpit again. "She doesn't seem … uh…"

"Stable? She's not", Entrapta finished.

Of course they decided to talk about her while she was gone. And she was still too far away to defend herself properly.

Glimmer sighed. "We're all tired and stressed, and she is freaked out. We cannot blame her for being a bit more … aggressive than usual", she evidently tried to sound cheerful.

"According to my data, she is more than just stressed", Entrapta chimed in again. "She is chronically sleep deprived, and hasn't

shown up to the last … uh … eight meals. It's really no wonder she's irritated. And then there's the stress, and the worry, and Adora", the woman listed.

Bow let out a little screech that Catra knew to identify as extreme worry. "Of course, she's not okay. She's doing literally everything while being in pain. I mean, if you were missing, I don't know how terrible I would be doing", he rambled anxiously, probably referring to Glimmer.

"We never should have allowed her to take on so many jobs", the girl said. "Relying on her plans, good, but … she's literally everywhere. If I try to take care of anything, someone will tell me that Catra has already done it. No wonder if she doesn't sleep!"

"Or eat", the boy added.

It was silent for a few seconds. "I mean, it was just an observation. I'm no healer", Entrapta mumbled then, clearly unsure about what to do with these two and their overflowing emotions.

When Catra finally rounded the corner, she was spotted immediately and her two friends straightened up as if she hadn't been able to hear everything.

"I'm fine", she growled. "How much longer?"

"Just a few more minutes", Entrapta answered — Catra must have stumbled through the dark longer than she had thought. Or the way was a lot shorter than Darla had thought. Maybe both.

"Fine?", Glimmer scoffed then. "Have you looked at yourself lately? You need to sleep and eat, and you need to relax. I'm sorry we didn't see it sooner, we should have-"

"What?", she interrupted. "Ignored all the towns that were in danger? Given up on the first day? We all did our part, there was nothing you could have done."

"Yes there was", Bow argued. "You didn't have to plan everything, you didn't need to be responsible for everything."

"But I am!" Catra regretted saying anything, and she quickly tried to think of anything she could say to get herself out of this situation. "It's… I-"

Conveniently, an alarm started to beep red all around them, and then the ship was falling, which effectively ended any further discussions.

Bow and Glimmer held onto the chair, while Catra dug her claws into the floor for some hold, and Entrapta hovered over them laughing maniacally.

She already thought they were going to die before they even set foot on the island when the ship stabilized itself before they could hit the ground.

"We're here!", Entrapta screamed excitedly even though she had fallen face first to the ground.

"I already hate this place", Catra mumbled in response.

The woman ignored her and ran over to the control panel. "This is odd. Darla shows no sign of internal malfunction", she told them. Which meant the most likely cause was this cursed island.

"Great", she growled. If this place was just half as terrible as the bedtime stories in the Horde, they were already as good as dead, just like Adora might be.

"So, not the best sign", Glimmer said awkwardly and only slowly separated herself from her anchor. "But, the ship is still okay, and we do plan to destroy this place with the virus. Everything will be fine." She didn't sound very convinced of it, but nobody called her out on it.

Entrapta apparently took it as a sign to leave, because she was out the door before anyone could stop her — she really wished

the woman would stop doing that.

The princess ran after her to make sure she didn't die, while Bow gently coaxed Catra up from the ground she still tethered herself to.

"Are you sure you want to come?", he then asked. "You know that we'd all support you if you wanted to wait here."

She shot him a glare. "I'm going, and I don't need to be pitied."

"We're just worried about you", he told her. "And you know that. I know you're not used to it, but we just want you to be okay, just like you clearly want us to be okay."

Catra didn't dignify that with a response, instead she walked out. She only reluctantly set foot on the beach, but she forced herself all the same.

This place was weird — the island was very much alive with something, but it didn't sound or feel like anything she had ever encountered before, which did nothing to ease her anxiety.

"Fascinating", Entrapta said, walking around and studying the bits and pieces of tech that were lying around. "This is ancient! The First Ones must have dumped whatever they didn't need anymore here."

"The navigation did call it a disposal site", Bow pointed out.

"Is this gonna be enough?", Glimmer asked, hopefully looking to the scientist for an answer. Catra seemingly wasn't the only one who felt a bit uncomfortable.

"I'm afraid not. It doesn't seem to be working anymore. I need something active", the woman told them. "We need to go further in. Somewhere on this island has to be active tech, we just need to find it."

"Have we considered that maybe the ship is too old to give accurate information?", Catra suggested. "Maybe all of it has already rotten away." It was unlikely, but everything in her body told her not to enter the forest before them.

From somewhere the scientist produced a pad. "No, something is definitely still working", she said. "Can't tell where, though. Whatever tech is out there is jamming the signal."

"Wait, is that why we almost crashed?", Bow then asked.

"Probably!" Entrapta was way too excited about this. "I really want to study this! Do you think I could take some readings?"

"No", Catra growled. "We're destroying whatever is on this island and then we'll leave, possibly before we get eaten."

Entrapta pouted, while the other two shuddered. "Well, okay", she mumbled sadly. "Let's go then!"

Catra wanted to call out to the scientist already, reminding her of their deal, but even though the woman was vibrating with energy, she stayed where she was, waiting for the others to be ready.

That was … odd somehow. Then again it wouldn't be the first time Entrapta had listened to her lately, so maybe the woman was just finally developing some social skills.

It was just that she had lived completely alone for decades, probably, and the only priority in her life has always been tech. Even Catra's request to watch Hordak has been turned into the scientist enabling his escape by building a new set of armor for him.

So yeah, she still thought it was weird that Entrapta was honestly waiting for them and didn't just run off to look at the next shiny piece of tech.

She wasn't the only one confused by that because they all stood there for a minute, first staring at the scientist, then warily looking

towards the trees.

Eventually, Bow's sigh broke the silence. "I guess we have no other choice. Creepy woods it is."

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter will hopefully not take a week (I have made pretty decent process editing, so unless I hate it on my next read through, it should come out sooner) <333
Until then, stay hydrated <33

Chapter 27: Beast Island - Part 2

Chapter Notes

> Since we're still on Beast Island, the warnings for angst still apply, including the usual Beast Island shenanigans, trauma, mental breakdown, and minor mentions of suicidal thoughts.
>
> Have fun!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As they went into the forest, Catra instinctively extended her claws because she was not about to trust that everything would work itself out. It didn't take long for the others to do the same and Bow readied his bow and arrows, and Glimmer conjured her sorcerer's staff. Even Entrapta took to walking on her hair to minimize noise.

The woman still occasionally went to look at some tech lying around, but she kept close and Catra always made sure she was safe in her discoveries.

But the deeper they went, the harder that became. Nothing here looked, smelled or sounded natural and it quickly became darker with every step. The latter was not much of a problem for her, but with everything being so weird, it was difficult to actually keep time or their position straight, let alone the position of anything else.

And there certainly was something else out there.

"So", Bow whispered eventually, a bit awkward and with his eyes flickering across the trees. "How's everyone doing?"

"This place gives me the creeps", Glimmer hissed. "I can't explain it, but there's something bad going on here."

"Yeah, same", the boy mumbled and then looked at Catra.

She opened her mouth to repeat the sentiment, but instead she stopped walking and forced the others to do the same. When she noticed they wanted to ask, she held up a hand to tell them to be quiet. Just like everything else. Noise normally didn't stop for any good reasons.

"Oh, no", Glimmer groaned quietly, apparently having noticed the difference too. "Did you have to start talking?", she grumbled to Bow.

He scoffed in response, clearly not happy to be blamed for this.

Catra growled lowly — she didn't have time to figure out why they were so weirdly hostile today. "Entrapta", she called out in a semi whisper instead. "Come back here, please", she told her and even though the woman looked confused, she came back to their group.

Then she looked around, trying to figure out where the threat was because there had to be one. "We should keep moving. Quietly", she whispered to the others. She didn't know how good that idea really was, but standing around waiting to be attacked didn't feel like a plan to her.

As it turned out, they didn't have to wait long because a giant creature jumped into their way just seconds after. At around the same time, she started hearing some loud noise that seemed to want to tear her skull apart. Where did that come from?

"Catra?", Bow asked worriedly, but it hardly registered as she tried pressing her hands over her ears, but it didn't help.

"We need to get out of here!", Glimmer screeched, which only added to the pain.

Shortly after, she somewhat noticed how her environment changed, but her body was still too busy adjusting to that noise that vanished as suddenly as it came.

"You didn't even throw up. What just happened?", Glimmer asked, sounding somehow more panicked than she already had been.

Catra could only furrow her brows. "Did you not hear that?"

All three of her friends shared a look. "Uh, not exactly", Bow said, looking and sounding downright terrified.

"Did the Horde reports say anything about sounds that only people with heightened senses can hear?", the princess asked, and also looked over to Entrapta like she hoped she had any ideas, but the woman just shrugged.

Catra shook her head as her own response. "What happened with the monster?"

"I teleported us hopefully out of range. We should probably keep moving, though", the girl answered. "I don't know how much I have left, so we should try to stay as much away from monsters as we can."

"Agreed", she mumbled, and they got back to walking.

Back to the careful march through this creepy place. They were somehow more tense than before, and Catra couldn't really tell why. Maybe it was the encounter with their first real threat, or the revelation that she heard weird noises, but something was out of place.

And as if that wouldn't be bad enough, they were also lost. She had barely been able to keep her orientation in this place to begin with, but after being subjected to the painful sound, as well as being teleported, she had truly no idea where they were anymore.

A thing that she didn't tell the others. There was no need to make whatever was going on worse.

"Are we sure we're walking in the right direction?", Bow asked eventually, apparently being braver than her to call out how lost they were.

"What even is the right direction?", Glimmer shot back. "There's some tech, but we cannot figure out where it is. We're just wandering around aimlessly for … I don't even know how long. How long have we been here already?"

Everyone else shrugged. It was hard to tell with the trees blocking all the light.

The princess groaned and sat down on a rock. "This is useless, and creepy, and Catra hears sounds. I don't like this. We never should have come here", she said desperately.

"That's what I've been saying this whole time", Catra growled.

"Let's just head back, maybe we can find a way to sneak around Prime and destroy a temple or something", Bow suggested, sounding as freaked out as them.

"And where is back?", Glimmer pointed out now, rather aggressively. "And also … everywhere else is full of clones and bots, I doubt even a bug could sneak around that."

"No need to be so cranky", the boy grumbled.

"Guys", Catra interrupted because she had a feeling these two were close to arguing again. Seriously, first at camp and now here? What was going on with them? "We don't have time for this. Who knows when that monster comes back, or something else. Can you get it together enough to get through this?"

The girl scoffed. "You're one to talk. You avoid us for days and now snap at us constantly. Being stressed is one thing, but it's not an excuse to let your frustrations out on us."

"Why do you think I've been avoiding you?", she replied rather sarcastically.

"Right, because wallowing in self-pity is so much better than talking to us", the other grumbled.

"Guys?", Bow tried to go in between them, but Glimmer just glared at him.

Catra, eager to talk about something else, obviously went and defended him. "You're not behaving any better", she accused. "What is going on with you? You've always been best friends, but today you seem to only be criticizing him."

"That doesn't matter, we are talking about you right now", the princess quickly deflected.

"I'm fine", she growled for what felt the hundredth time.

Sparkles rolled her eyes. "For someone so fine, you love to neglect yourself."

"I'm busy."

"You don't have to be!", the other snapped. "We could have helped, why won't you let us help you?"

"Because I don't want to think about Adora!", she yelled back and sank down next to a tree when the only response were stunned faces. "If I stop running around, I'll think about it all, and I already feel terrible enough, okay?"

It was silent for a moment and then Glimmer sighed, deflated. "I feel terrible too", she quietly admitted. "I'm not really mad at you. I just … I should have done more, should *be doing* more. I'm supposed to be queen one day, and I let you do everything and then got angry about it. It's selfish, I know, but I hate how good you are at everything."

Catra stared for a second. "I'm not", she mumbled. "I mean, sure I got a bit of experience from the Horde but … I could never lead the people like you can. They're all at least a bit scared of me, I know that. It was the same way back then too. I'm great at making things orderly, but … I don't have what you and Adora have. The people would follow every stupid plan you made without question because … they love you."

It was more than depressing to admit that out loud, and despite every one of Perfuma's advice, she did not feel the promised relief of finally having told someone. She just felt even worse.

"That's not true", the girl insisted. "Yes, you can be a bit scary, but the people like that they can depend on you. *I* liked depending on you. I liked not having to deal with anything, at least for the first week or so. I was freaking out and I never thought about what a burden that must have been for you."

Bow cleared his throat then. "Not exactly on topic, but since we're already here… I'm sorry I lied to you all about my family", he joined in too. "It's just … they don't approve and they had all these ideas about who I was, and in the rebellion I could be myself. I was scared that if you knew, it would be weird, that you'd see me differently."

Catra was glad for the slight topic change — she couldn't do more talking.

And luckily, Glimmer allowed it. "I thought I knew everything about you. It's like you lead a double life", she told him clearly. "And it hurt to think about how much I didn't know about my best friend."

"You know everything about me", the boy told her. "It's my dads who don't really know who I am."

This was a sweet moment, Catra thought, still a bit depressing but sweet. But she couldn't find herself enjoying it, and her brain started to feel a bit foggy.

She didn't really know why, and she started to lose the energy to figure it out. Maybe her bad habits finally crashed in a pounding headache. Or maybe that odd sound that came back was to blame for it. She should probably care about that a bit more but … she was so tired.

"Catra?" She looked up to see her friend look at her with worry.

"What?", she said. It came out a bit slurred. Okay, now she *was* worried.

"Catra!", Glimmer yelled and suddenly ran over to her tear some vine away from her, but she only got it onto herself.

Vaguely, she felt something creep up her legs as she distantly watched her friend wrestle with the vines themselves. At some point, they let out grunts of pain as they covered their ears. They heard it too.

She wanted to help them, wanted to do anything, but … for some reason she couldn't move.

Now they would all die and she had no one to blame but herself.

She should have gone with Adora when she had first gotten the chance. Then there would have been no portal and none of this would have happened.

But it did happen, and as she slowly felt herself slip away, she knew that she deserved this. She should have met her end here a long time ago, but she never should have let the others come here. Why did she let herself be convinced? Did it matter now? Catra had failed to keep them safe.

And now they would die. She didn't want to die. Her vision blacked out and she didn't want to go.

So when some light crashed down next to her, she tried her best to focus on it, hoping it would help her stay present.

Shortly after, she suddenly felt lighter, and there was a hand on her shoulder. "Are you okay?", a voice she didn't recognize asked and shook her a bit. "Come on", he insisted and shook harder.

At that point, she did regain enough brain power to push whoever away and hiss. It was then that she realized that the vines were gone, and she was still alive. She straightened up a bit, which was

apparently enough of a sign of life from her for the guy to leave her and blast more vines.

What just happened?

Catra took a quick look around. Bow and Glimmer seemed to be fine, a bit shaken maybe, but it didn't look like they had passed out like she had.

Entrapta on the other hand was currently freed by the strange man from a cocoon of vines.

She stumbled up to run over — they hadn't really payed attention to her anymore in their arguing, how long has she been like this?

The man quickly made space for her after he had gotten the vines off of the scientist as much as possible.

"Come on, Entrapta", she mumbled. "Please don't be dead, don't do this to me", she pleaded and shook her just like the guy had shaken her. "I can't let you die again. Hordak's gonna kill me."

"Hordak?", came a weak reply as the woman opened her eyes. "Catra?"

"Yes! Please tell me you're okay", she demanded with desperation.

Entrapta sat up. "I'm … okay. What happened?", she asked curiously.

"I don't know", she mumbled and looked over to where the others stood. "Is everyone okay?", she asked, still full of panic.

They all nodded, a bit confused but alive.

Catra let out a shaky sigh of relief and was about to interrogate the new person in their midst a bit because she would like to understand what was going on, but before she could say anything, she was stopped by a loud rumble too close for comfort.

"We have to move quickly", their mysterious savior spoke up then. "This part of the island is dangerous, you were lucky I found you when I did. Come on." He waved for them to follow, and they all looked at Catra for guidance.

"He did save us." She shrugged and decided to trust him for now. Another person on this island couldn't be all that bad, and he hadn't done anything to harm them.

So, they all quickly ran after him for a while until he stopped at a clearing and conjured a magical dome.

Wait a second. Magic guy on Beast Island? She never would have thought she would say that, but Angella might have been right all along. "King Micah?", she asked carefully and received a confused look from everyone, even him. Okay, maybe she had been wrong about that one.

"Huh?" The guy looked shocked. "You know who I am?", he asked.

Or, she had been right. "Uh… sort of", she answered and chanced a glance at her companions, who were mostly frozen in shock with their mouths hanging open.

Except for Entrapta, of course. "Fascinating", she said, getting closer to him. "How did you survive this long? What did you eat? How did you sleep with all the threats? What is it like here? Can you catalogue all the monsters for an overview?", she rambled on, not leaving any space between her questions for him to answer.

"Is she always like this?", the king simply asked her, pointing at the woman, who still rattled off questions.

"Yeah, pretty much", Catra shrugged.

"What about them?" He now pointed towards the other two, who still didn't move, which seemed to make him suspicious. "Are they real? You are real, right?!", he screamed that last part in a certain

type of desperation — this guy was not doing all that great, that was for sure.

She nodded slowly. "Yes. Very real. You just saved our lives", she reminded him and shot the two a glare, so they would hopefully get it together.

"My apologies." The king cleared his throat. "It's been … quite some time since I've talked to someone else. Anyone real, that is", he explained and looked over them all as if he wanted to make sure he really wasn't dreaming.

Catra already dreaded having to be the one to comfort the guy, but luckily, that was about when Bow finally snapped out of it. "Are *you* real?", he asked, the surprise still clear in his voice. "We kinda thought you were …" He looked over to Glimmer shortly. "Dead."

"If the Horde had their way, I would be", he said somberly. "They exiled me here, but I survived!" He stared at them again. "How did you get here? Can you get me away from here? Can you get me to my family? Do you know them?", he asked with the earlier desperation returning.

Catra looked over to Glimmer, who had yet to say something, hoping she might want to take this one, but it didn't seem like it. "Uh, yeah… We can bring you home", she told the men instead. "And uh… I guess we do know them."

"Really?", he asked hopefully. "How are they? How's the rebellion doing? And my sweet baby Glimmer?", he asked like this was a completely normal situation to catch up on some things.

She really started to have some doubts about this guy's mental state. And she also didn't really know how to answer this without sending him spiraling.

"That might be complicated to explain right now", the boy jumped in awkwardly.

The king only tilted his head in confusion. "Complicated how?"

Catra sighed. Honestly, who cared? They needed to get this moving along. "We're getting invaded by a guy that's somehow related to Hordak", she filled him in and received a glare from Bow, but she only shrugged.

"I'm confused", was all the king said in response.

Unfortunately for them, that was the moment Entrapta decided to help. "Since your assumed death, the rebellion collapsed, and the Horde almost defeated us, but they rebuild the Alliance and we were actually winning against the Horde, but then Prime showed up and now we're hiding out in the Whispering Woods. Also Hordak is our ally now and She-Ra is back, but she's been captured by Prime, and Glimmer is an adult."

The man stared for a long time.

It was once again Bow, who took over. "That was *not* how I would have told you all that", he mumbled apologetically. "But, it's all true. And uh…" He looked at Glimmer, who seemed a lot calmer now that the cat was out of the bag. "I'm Bow, that's Catra and Entrapta and that … is Glimmer." He shoved the girl a bit forward, clearly hoping for a family reunion.

"Glimmer?", the king asked in surprise. "But you're … so old."

At least that broke the ice a bit as the girl laughed. "Uh… I guess I've grown up a bit", she mumbled awkwardly.

"You're really my Glimmer?", he asked again, slowly making his way over. It was probably not as sweet as Bow had wanted it, but they did share a short hug before the king seemed to realize something. "What are you doing here? You shouldn't be on Beast Island, this place is dangerous!"

"If it makes you feel better, I was against it", Catra grumbled.

"We're here because we have to test Entrapta's virus", Glimmer gave him a proper answer. "It may be our only chance to defeat Prime, and save our friend."

He furrowed his brows. "This is an odd choice for some test."

"It's not *some* test!", Entrapta then yelled, looking offended. "This might save the universe!"

"Yes, I understood that. And I'm grateful you're here, but I really think you could have found a safer place for that", he clarified a bit.

"Every other place is full of Prime's forces. We didn't have a choice but to come here", Glimmer told her father sternly. "And you can help us! We need to find still functioning tech, do you know where we can find some?", she asked hopefully.

But Micah only shook his head. "It's too dangerous. This place is a mass of ancient tech, mostly degraded, but something at the center never stopped signaling. The signal dulls your resolve, exposes your vulnerabilities, it pulls you in", he told them with a faraway look. "Everything that stays on Beast Island becomes a part of it eventually."

Catra's anxiety spiked again. "Is that what I've been hearing?", she asked, despite not really wanting an answer.

"Yes, which is why you should get off this island!", the man told her, grabbing her shoulders with a desperate urgency that made her flinch. But she didn't push him away, because that urgency resonated with her.

She remembered how it had felt earlier, how afraid she had been. The only thing this trip has been good for so far was to give her the realization that she didn't want to die, but that certainly wasn't worth staying here for any longer. Saving the planet sadly was.

"Is it really that bad?", Glimmer asked with her usual fake optimism. "I mean, it was painful, but…" She clearly didn't know

how to finish that sentence.

"The longer you stay here, the more often you will hear it and the more dangerous it becomes", Micah said, letting go of her. "I've heard it every day, for months, years. But I fight it! And I won't let you stay any longer. You already came too close to succumbing to it."

"Are you trying to say those vines were part of that?", Bow screeched in panic.

The king nodded. "They come when you're at your weakest", he told them. "When you already lost hope."

They all shared a disturbed look. Well, that would explain something, the three of them had been pretty hopeless, lamenting about terrible they've been feeling. But why would Entrapta be affected just as badly as Catra had been? The woman had been enthusiastic since they got here, the exact opposite of hopeless.

And speaking of. "I won't leave until we test my virus!", the scientist demanded. "It's important!"

"She's right", Glimmer agreed. "I want to get away from this place, I really do, but … this is our only chance. If we don't get this virus to work, Prime is probably going to kill us all. We don't have another choice."

Bow nodded. "Maybe you and Catra should already go back to the ship, and we'll-"

"No!", she and the king protested at the same time. "If you suggest one more time that I stay behind, I'll personally throw you at the vines", she growled, and the boy took a deliberate step away from her.

"I'll come too", Micah said. "Without me, you'll get lost out here. And I won't leave my babygirl alone."

Glimmer blushed hard as Catra tried her hardest not to laugh. "Dad!", she complained.

He ignored her. "It's a long way to the center. We should get going while we still have light", he told them before giving them all a serious look. "Try to stay hopeful and positive. If the signal gets to us, we're dead."

They all nodded, and then the protective dome disappeared and they followed the king deeper into the woods.

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As they followed Micah, Glimmer warmed up to him more and more. At least whenever Entrapta wasn't occupying him with her million questions.

Catra and Bow followed a bit behind, and despite their new guide, she still kept her eyes and ears on their surroundings. Just in case.

"I can't believe he's been alive this whole time", Bow mumbled to her at some point, when he couldn't keep the excitement contained anymore. They were close enough to the others to hear their chatter, but distant enough to have their own conversation without being heard if they were quiet enough.

"Me neither", she replied a bit bitterly — as she had also told the queen, she had fully expected him to have been dead for a long time already. "He's a bit weird though."

"That's to be expected after all this time alone", he said. "But Glimmer seems to be happy to see her dad again. And imagine how Angella and Castaspella will react."

She furrowed her brows slightly before remembering. "Right, she was his … sister?"

He nodded proudly. "I think everyone will be happy to see him", he kept going then. "I can't wait to get back and tell them."

If they got back, her brain helpfully supplied.

It was then that the signal started to drone again, making her groan in pain. She didn't think it possible, but it was louder than before. She would rather take a hundred of Bow's sonic arrows over this! "Definitely getting stronger", she forced out, resisting the urge to press her hands on her ears again — it didn't do anything anyway, and she'd rather not risk damaging them.

Bow carefully reached out, and she let him steady her a bit.

"We're getting closer", Micah then said. "Don't let it distract you", he warned and stabbed a vine with his stick. "Catra, tell me about yourself. What are things you like to do?", he asked, obviously attempting to get her to focus on something other than her consistently hopeless thoughts.

Well, it worked at least, since she had to ignore her doubts in favor of finding an appropriate answer. "I read, I guess", she mumbled eventually. She didn't actually have many hobbies. Or any at all.

"What do you read?", he kept asking.

"Mostly psychology stuff", she said, slowly drifting back to her guilt as she thought about why she had read it to begin with.

Her friends seemed to notice. "What about sleepovers?", Bow supplied, ripping her from her despair again. "Okay, maybe you don't like them, but you never complain either, so I wanna say you do."

She scoffed. "You can't prove that", she told him, but she did feel a bit lighter with the topic change. "And Glimmer was right, by the

way. You do snore."

"Hah!", the girl exclaimed in triumph while the boy playfully pouted.

"You are good friends?", Micah asked, and didn't sound like he was trying to distract them anymore. More like he was actually interested.

"We're the Best Friend Squad", Bow said proudly. "Though, one of us is-" He cut himself off, with a look at Catra.

"Oh, do you still have your favorite stuffed animal? The one I made for you? Kowl?", the man then asked Glimmer excitedly, either not noticing the little slip up, or managing to read the room and ignoring it.

"Yeah, I do." The girl blushed a bit at the admission. "And I started using your old sorcerer's staff, training with aunt Casta! So I can still help, even without my runestone", she told him proudly.

And her father seemed to share that feeling. "Maybe when we get back, you can show me what you got", he suggested.

"It's only been a few weeks", Glimmer told him awkwardly. "I don't know if I can do anything but defend myself a little."

Catra was inclined to agree. She knew that the princess could be better, she had managed to teleport them to the Fright Zone, after all. Whatever Castaspella was teaching her was clearly not working all that well.

Suddenly the king stopped, grabbing Entrapta to pull her to a stop too. He listened to their surroundings, and so did Catra. The loud noise from the monsters in the distant was gone for the moment. But another sound took its place. Some animal, pretty close.

"What is that?", she asked as the man squatted down to listen to the ground.

"It's the Pookas."

"Pookas?", Bow repeated. "That sounds adorable." He looked over to Catra, who shook her head in terror. "More terrifying things that wanna eat us?" She nodded. Like they didn't have enough problems already.

"They travel in packs, hunting their prey across the island, luring them in and surrounding them until it's too late", the king explained. "Right now, they're hunting us."

Catra had a pretty good read on where they were hiding at the moment. They came from behind them, which would be a good thing for them. "We have to get to the center, quick", she told the man.

He looked like he might want to protest for a moment, but one look at all their determined faces and he ran off without another word. They followed.

The creatures were getting closer by the second, and she told them as much. Bow, Glimmer and Micah all readied themselves to defend their group. So did Catra, but with the others being more wide ranged fighters, she mostly took care of leftovers and whatever got too close to Entrapta.

But even though the Pookas were packing more damage than their group, they still didn't give up, probably confident that they could overwhelm them with their numbers.

"Almost there", the king told them.

Being so close to the center, the signal came back, loud enough for Catra to lose her footing. Even Micah had to stop to get his bearings.

"This was a terrible idea, we need to turn back", he told them.

"No", she said, supporting herself on a tree. "We have to keep moving!"

The man shook his head. "We should have left when we had the chance."

"I don't think that's an option anymore", Entrapta chimed in, vaguely pointing at the flood of animals around them that were mostly kept at bay by Bow and Glimmer, who started to falter too though, slowly slacking to the ground.

Catra growled to herself, cursing herself again for letting them come with her. "Entrapta, you take Bow. Micah, take Glimmer", she ordered and went to slash at some Pookas, which made them regain their distance a bit. Enough to hopefully make it to the center without being eaten. "Let's go!", she then yelled at the others and they were running again.

To their luck, Glimmer was not the most stubborn at camp — Catra beat her by a lot, so she pushed through the pain, and kept running along the scientist and king, who hopefully had a better idea on where they were going than she did. She might be able to move her feet, but she could not do much more.

They soon reached some sort of bridge leading to … something. She didn't have the mental capacities to think that hard about it, but it must be the center.

"Now what?", she asked. The signal got more high pitched, forcing her to search leverage on the stony surface of whatever they were looking at. The Pookas kept getting closer, too. Bow and Glimmer were completely irresponsive now.

"Give me a sec", Entrapta said, moving her hands and hair along the surface.

"This is pointless", Micah mumbled, dropping to the floor next to his daughter. "I shouldn't have let you come here."

Catra couldn't disagree with him. She also couldn't protect him from the vines that crept up to him, nor from the Pookas that had reached the edge of the bridge. Entrapta was the only one still standing, surprisingly unaffected this time.

"I can't fight", she told the woman. With the signal droning on, it was a miracle she was able to form words. "This is all my fault. If I hadn't opened that portal, Prime wouldn't be here. We wouldn't be here. We're doomed and it's all my fault." She felt something on her leg, but she didn't have the strength anymore to care.

Suddenly, something different dragged at her and then it was dark. The signal was gone, but her mood wasn't.

"I know I build that portal", she heard Entrapta say. "You didn't say it, but I know that your stories don't add up. I did bad things" The woman produced some light. It looked like a blowtorch, wherever she had been hiding that. "Something happened to me back then, didn't it? It's pretty obvious with the way you tried to not let me come and don't want me to be in danger. So, I guess I'm glad you opened that portal. Because if you hadn't, I might be dead, so thank you."

Without the signal, Catra at least managed to look up. "Don't thank me", she told the other. "*I* happened to you. You warned me about the portal, but I didn't listen. I was mad at you and I really hurt you." She still couldn't tell her that she send her to Beast Island. It was too terrible. Besides, she had a feeling the other already knew.

Entrapta smiled and patted her with a strand of her hair. "You saved me from the virus and helped include me. I also know that the other princesses don't really trust me, and you defended me. You've been a good friend, now."

If Catra cried that was no one's business but her own. The others were still not quite present anyway, but apparently Entrapta had dragged them inside too, at least.

The scientist waited patiently for her to calm down, which didn't take long — she was used to pushing her emotions away and she knew that Perfuma would tell her how unhealthy it was, but they had bigger problems right now.

"I'd understand if you wouldn't want to talk to me anymore", she then said, and she meant it.

"You're the reason anyone talks to me at all", the woman pointed out to her. "I build that portal. I must have been in the Horde, too. I probably built a bunch of stuff that hurt them. I was friends with Hordak before. But you never told anyone that. I do want to thank you."

"I'd really rather you wouldn't", she grumbled and got up to check on the others, who showed some signs of life again.

But before she could take a step, a strand of hair stopped her. "I forgive you if you forgive me."

She sighed. She had been really mad at the woman back in that other time. But she hadn't felt that in a long while anymore. Annoyance, occasionally, but no anger. "You never did anything wrong. I've forgiven you already."

Entrapta smiled. "Good! Because I did too", she laughed.

Catra fondly rolled her eyes, and finally went over to where their companions slowly stirred.

"Catra?", Bow asked groggily as he clearly tried to make out her face in the dim light of the blowtorch. "Where are we?"

"The center", she told him and helped him up before she went to check on Glimmer, while Bow just kept looking at her. "The signal seems to be gone for now, but we should keep moving."

"Are you okay?", he then asked. "You held up much longer than us. I doubt that was easy for you."

"I'm sorry we couldn't help you more", Glimmer also lamented.

"You did", she told them. "If you hadn't distracted me earlier, the signal would have gotten to me a lot sooner. I have a lot of

vulnerabilities to expose, it seems. But I don't think anyone wants to talk about why we let ourselves be affected."

They nodded in agreement with her, shutting down that line questioning in both ways, as she had hoped — not because she didn't care, but she really doubted anyone wanted to discuss their deepest insecurities at the moment, especially after talking had already lead to them almost dying once.

Besides, they had bigger problems, because Micah was still lying there unconscious. "Your majesty?", she called out to him, as Glimmer carefully shook his shoulders.

"Come on, you didn't survive all these years to give up now", the girl gently pleaded.

He shot up. "I need to get to Angie!" Everyone was a bit taken aback by that.

Catra shrugged it off. "That's the spirit", she told him.

"There's a light back there!", Entrapta called, thankfully interrupting the slightly awkward situation.

"Should we go towards the light?", Bow asked anxiously.

Catra only sighed. "It's not like we have another choice", she mumbled and followed Entrapta's blowtorch.

Soon they came into a room that definitely still had functioning tech. Entrapta was all over it in an instant and for once Catra understood why. Whatever was stored here could tell them a lot of secrets — about their planet, the First Ones, the Heart. It would be a shame to destroy it.

"Do we have to?", Entrapta asked too, sadness written all over her. "Look at all this data!"

She came closer. "Do you have any way of downloading it?", she asked.

"I have a few drives with me, but I don't think it will be enough", the woman contemplated. Then she gasped. "We could store it on Darla!"

"And how are we supposed to get it there?", Catra pointed out.

"Who's Darla? Another friend of yours?", the king asked behind them.

"Technically she could come to us, but I don't know if the signal would jam it- OH!" Entrapta used her hair to hover above them now, looking at the tech in front of her, babbling to herself. "Aha!", she then screamed and teared off some piece at the top.

Catra half expected everything to shut down, but it didn't. "What did you do?", she asked curiously.

"I temporarily disabled the signal", Entrapta answered cheerfully. "I can't disable it fully right now, it's too degraded, but now we can get Darla here!"

"I doubt we have enough time to-"

The scientist whistled loudly, making Catra's ears ring. "Hey Darla!"

For a moment nothing happened, but after a few long seconds something bumped into the cave's wall from outside, shaking it enough for everyone to stumble.

Entrapta only giggled. "I'll go get the cables", she announced and walked back outside.

Catra sighed. "I'll make sure she doesn't get attacked", she mumbled and ran after her. It seemed that the giant ship cutting through the trees at least got rid of any imminent threats for the moment, though.

Entrapta greeted the ship overly lovingly and vanished inside of it for a few minutes before coming out with several thick cables.

They went back inside the cave and despite everything being melted together, the scientist somehow found a way to connect the cables to the tech.

"Now we wait", the woman announced. "I'll go check on Darla's side!" With that she was back outside.

"I'm still confused. Who is Darla exactly?", the king asked, looking after the scientist.

"Would you like to meet Darla, your majesty?", Catra asked with a smirk.

The man was remotely enthusiastic about the prospect and followed her outside where she presented the First Ones ship. He stared at it with an open mouth. "So, Darla is not a person, got it", he mumbled, though he seemed no less confused.

Bow and Glimmer had followed too, and they all went inside while they waited. It was the safest here, after all, and if something happened they could just leave. Catra liked that.

"This is fascinating", Entrapta drooled when they reached the cockpit. A screen lit up a bunch of information, rapidly being loaded into the ship's hard drive. "I've had theories about the Heart, and it seems I was correct. All the elemental princesses are involved. It needs all their runestones engaged to work. And this explains why She-Ra is so important, too." Now, Catra was listening. "She channels the weapon's power and focuses it, she's the only being strong enough to withstand the destructive energy of the Heart. That's why the First Ones needed to control her! When the Heart is deployed, She-Ra will raise her sword and fire it. Once the planet is balanced, no one can stop it. Not even the First Ones could control it, that's why they left."

"I take it all back, it was definitely a good thing that you destroyed the sword", Glimmer mumbled almost to herself. "Never should have doubted you."

Catra almost wanted to tease the girl for that admission when the worst of all thoughts came to her. "Prime knows", she said.

"What do you mean?", Bow asked.

"Think about it, he hasn't done anything to destroy the runestones, or kill people. He's got everything under control, except the woods, where we are. And I kept asking myself why. It didn't make sense. He has the numbers to annihilate us and it seems to be the goal too", she rambled.

The realization seemed to hit him. "We need to get back."

"We need that virus", Catra reminded them. "How long will this take?", she asked Entrapta.

"Download estimated for another four minutes and thirty seven seconds", Darla answered for her.

"Great, do you need to make some preparations?", she asked Entrapta again.

"I got everything ready. Any adjustments need to be made while I'm working with the tech", she said with her usual enthusiasm.

Catra sighed and sat down. Bow came to sit next to her, while Micah still got used to the ship and Glimmer paced nervously in front of them.

"If he knows, that at least means Adora has to be alive, right?", Bow tried to cheer her up as they watched the king sniff the console.

"*If*. I might be wrong, and Swift Wind can't feel their bond anymore, and- and Shadow Weaver said Prime is not one for taking prisoners", she said, avoiding the boy's eyes.

"Shadow Weaver?", Glimmer asked in shock. "What were you doing, talking to her?"

"Spare me the lecture", she grumbled. "I wanted to get an egotistical, power-hungry opinion on the matter. I thought maybe I could get something out of her that could help us, or give us ideas at least. And … I *did* get an idea of how we can trick him, but a lot of luck would need to be on our side, and I'm still not sure about the details and…" She sighed. "We'll still have to go up there and defeat him, and I want her to be alive so badly, but it's unlikely. *If* he knows something about the Heart, he might be waiting for something that could force her into She-Ra, I guess, but how likely is that?"

"We'll get Adora back", Bow insisted. "She's not dead, I know it."

She sighed. "How?"

"Because you're smart. You wouldn't hope if you didn't believe Prime still needs her." He smiled and she smiled back, even if a bit awkwardly — it was still weird to receive compliments.

"And I'm sure your plan will work", Glimmer chimed in too. "Your plans always work. We got this."

A beep interrupted them. "Download complete", Darla told them and shut down the screens. Coincidentally, the signal came back in that moment to torment Catra.

She took a breath. "Let's test that virus before I lose it", she said, motioning for Entrapta to follow her, which she did. Bow also came with them, just in case, though Catra didn't know what case he was referring to — it probably had something to do with everyone's overbearing worry for her.

Back inside, the signal got duller again, but wasn't quite gone this time. Entrapta pulled all the cables out and pushed them into Bow's arms, who only reluctantly left them to carry it back to the ship.

Then the scientist produced the virus from her hair. "Okay. Last time, it was activated by simply touching the tech with it, but because of Darla, I have put a safety in it, so that it cannot infect

her", she told her, while attaching the disk to the tech per smaller cables that also came out of her hair. Then she pulled out a pad, connected it to the virus and typed away. "If I calculated the effects correctly, it shouldn't take much for it to spread."

"What if you didn't?", Catra asked curiously.

"I'll have to make adjustments, but I'm pretty confident that I created a good base." Her pad beeped. "It would actually be better to leave it unrefined. First Ones tech is as close in advanced tech as we can get to Prime's, but his is bound to be different." She typed more.

"Meaning?"

"I'll save the code on the pad instead of the disk. That way, if the code doesn't work on Prime's ship, it will be easier to adjust", the woman explained, not stopping her typing even once.

Whatever Entrapta was doing, the tech at least reacted, making the signal stronger and somewhere something short circuited. "I have a feeling, this thing doesn't want to be destroyed", Catra mumbled.

"This is great!", Entrapta laughed. "Don't worry, almost got it!"

Catra noticed something light up on the outer parts of the cave. The light started to move to the center, along cables and connections, right to where Entrapta was sitting.

She called out to the scientist, trying to warn her, but she kept stubbornly typing on her pad.

If she didn't move away soon, Catra feared the woman would be burned to a crisp. Out of experience, she knew electroshocks were not pleasant.

She was already reaching out to drag the other away from the tech when the entire thing powered down and they were sitting in the dark, save for Entrapta who got illuminated by her pad.

"It worked!", she told them. The signal was gone. It was eerily quiet.

"You could have died!", Catra yelled at her.

Even with the flimsy light, she saw Entrapta shrug. "I was almost done, but it was quite fascinating how it tried to protect itself. It would have been so nice to study", she said sadly.

"I already let you download the data", Catra grumbled. "Now let's go before something else happens and we lose you anyway."

Entrapta produced her blowtorch again to have some light to disconnect all the cables and pick up anything she needed or wanted to take with her.

When they came back out, the island almost sounded normal. Like it was actual nature and not filled with disposed ancient technology. From what Catra could hear, the scary animals were still around and probably would stick around, making this place not much safer than it was before, but she couldn't care less. She just wanted to get away from here.

"What happened?", Glimmer asked hopefully. "Did it work?"

"Yes", Catra told her and everyone sighed with relief. "Darla, take us back to camp", she told the computer. "I don't want to spend another second in this place."

"I can understand why you were so against it", Bow told her with a strained smile.

Micah laughed awkwardly. "This is actually real?", he asked, and started to pinch Bow's face for some reason.

"Yes", he mumbled with half his mouth being stretched by the king. "We talked about this already, remember?"

The man sighed. "Yes, but I couldn't let myself believe it", he said. "So, it's all true? And we're actually going home?"

"Well, our home is currently held by bots, but yes. We're getting you away from here, and everything will be alright now", Glimmer told him with a hug.

"As alright as things can be, hiding in the woods from some maniac", Catra grumbled and went to look out the big window. It was only barely visible from here, but there was Prime's ship hovering above their planet.

Adora had to hold on just a bit longer.

Chapter End Notes

> I would like to promise less angst for the next chapter but ... as I stare at my content warnings notes (yes I have a seperate doc for that) I'm afraid it's not getting better just yet. But soon!
>
> Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 28: Rescue - Part 1

Chapter Notes

Here it is! The moment you've been waiting for!

Warnings for angst still apply, including minor discussions of depression, and death...
Also, incoming usage of semi-canon info

Have fun <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After a very exhausting trip back from Beast Island, on which she had to listen to Entrapta's ramblings as she read through the information about the Heart and Micah's nervous questions, she had left the welcome party rather quickly.

Catra was sure the reunion of the king and queen was lovely, but she honestly didn't care much.

She could hear some of it — crying, laughing, declarations of worry and relief. She was happy for them, she really was, and she was glad that the return of the king clearly inspired hope in the people who had recently lost it, but … selfishly, she couldn't help but be jealous too.

Considering everyone's surprise, any discussion would have to be delayed, which meant any attempt to rescue Adora would be delayed.

It was probably unreasonable, but as she munched on a piece of bread while she listened to the excitement outside, she just felt bitter. And she felt terrible for it, too.

"Here you are." Bow spoke softly as usual and yet the sound felt incredibly loud in the small space of her tent. She rolled her eyes,

having been wondering already how long it would take until someone felt the need to check up on her. "How are you feeling?"

"I'm fine", she growled and took another bite.

He sighed and sat down next to her. "I'm not", he said. "I'm glad that Glimmer has her dad back, but … it's hard. Seeing them be a family when my dads still won't talk to me."

Catra would lie if she said that didn't surprise her. Bow was the upbeat type, always supportive, rarely complaining. Of course that didn't mean he couldn't feel sad, as proven on Beast Island, but it still came as a shock.

And then he came to her of all people, the last person anyone should ask for emotional support. He probably thought she must feel similarly and would be able to understand him. Well, he wasn't wrong. "When I saw them … I don't think I've never felt more alone", she mumbled reluctantly.

It felt only fair, after he had listened to her without judgment when it came to things from her past. And considering the fact that she had yet to confess to most of her evil actions. The least she could do was try to be there for him.

He smiled appreciatively, though it looked sad regardless. "I try to stay hopeful, but I'll admit Beast Island was…"

"Yeah", she agreed. "It's not the greatest place to go when you already hit rock bottom."

Now it was his turn to look surprised. "I didn't know you felt like that", he then said quietly. "I noticed you were working yourself into an early grave and that you weren't doing great, and you said you tried to avoid thinking, but … I didn't think it would get this bad so quickly."

She sighed. "I've never been good to begin with", she told him and his eyes started to water. "It's gotten better", she tried to placate him. "But … not good. Not enough to survive all this."

"You could have talked to us", he stated carefully. "I know it's not your favorite thing to do, but we would have supported you more if you had let us."

"I know", she had to admit. She knew they were worried and would have taken every burden from her if she had so much as alluded to the fact that she was tired. But … Hordak was right once again, she *was* punishing herself.

Bow leaned into her a bit, not enough to really be in her space, but just to signal that he wanted to comfort her. "You're not alone, Catra. You're not alone to blame and you're not alone in fixing this."

"I know", she repeated. Logically, she did know it, but it didn't help in making her feel in any way less guilty.

"How about this? Since everyone's busy celebrating, you, me, and Swift Wind could hang out. A little exclusive sleepover", he suggested, regaining a bit of his usual good mood. "We all deserve a little break, and you seriously need sleep."

Catra sighed. She knew he was right — nothing would move forward anymore today, and she did need to get into slightly better shape if she wanted to save anyone. Not that she could do much to improve her condition in the short time, but something was better than nothing. "Fine", she mumbled.

Back on Beast Island, Bow had said that he thought she did like their sleepovers, even if he wasn't sure. Well… She liked them sometimes.

When they had camped out during their fights against the Horde, she had found herself having fun often. But since then, whenever they did get her to hang out with them, she only noticed the gaping hole of someone missing and she liked them a lot less.

Now it served as an even more stark reminder of her misery — Glimmer was missing too, having regained someone lost while Catra still had to hope that Adora was even alive.

At the same time, she did have people around her — well, one person and a horse, but whatever — and realized, finally, that she was long past the days when she felt like everyone was out to get her. They really did care about her, and she cared for them.

If she wouldn't, she would hardly spend hours lying to Swift Wind that Beast Island hadn't been that bad — Scorpia had apparently told everyone about the Horde's bedtime stories and everyone had freaked out, including him.

She wouldn't joke around with Bow.

And most of all, she wouldn't dare to fall asleep around them.

Of course, she was quickly woken by a nightmare in the early morning, but she was glad she was able to sleep at all.

That didn't mean she felt very eager to return to it, and since she didn't want to wake the others she went to check on their rations again.

She knew the numbers probably haven't changed much since the last time she took stock — she was confident that they were exactly what she had calculated them to be. But their resources wouldn't last forever, and Catra had taken to redoing her work every few days, gradually minimizing everyone's rations a bit each time to make them last a little bit longer.

The few edible and reachable resources from the woods did give them a bit more to work with, but not enough. At some point, there just wasn't more she could do. No matter how much she tried to stretch what they had, they would run out in less than two weeks.

She had long seen it coming and had worried about it, but now they would hopefully manage to get rid of Prime before they had to reach that point.

If Entrapta said her virus worked, she could trust that — the woman managed to build a portal despite their broken planet

working against her, she could deal with destroying a server.

Still, the sooner they put their plan into action, the better. She had to think about the worst case scenario, which would be them failing, and they might need a bit more time to stay afloat then. They shouldn't waste it now.

Which also meant she had to interrupt the peace of the newly reunited family.

Bow and Swift Wind were already worriedly looking for her after she had left without notice, and naturally helped her notify everyone.

Most people were a bit irritated or sleepy despite the day moon being well in the sky by now, but they didn't complain outright, so Catra didn't care.

She also didn't wait for the queen to give her permission to open the meeting — the woman did look a bit more like herself, but she hadn't really participated in any decision so far, and Catra doubted she would now.

"Our resources won't last much longer, and it's doubtful we'll even make it there. Prime has everything under control. He is more powerful, more prepared and he is clearly planning something", she simply started. "We think he might know something about the Heart, but we cannot wait to find out."

Whatever had remained from the small moment of happiness the day before was gone in a flash.

"It is weird that he hasn't killed us all yet", Netossa mumbled, slowly realizing that Catra was right.

"But… Why hasn't he done anything yet? With as quickly as he has gotten us surrounded, why wait?", Spinnerella asked then, still a bit confused.

"That's easy", Entrapta took over answering. "He needs She-Ra. He's probably trying to pressure her, using our lives as leverage. That or he knows that he at least needs some of us for the Heart to work. Either way, he still needs us alive."

Everyone stiffened even more then. They all knew they were losing, but being reduced to a means to an end in Prime's schemes was something entirely different.

The queen cleared her throat awkwardly then. "I suppose you have a plan?", she asked hesitantly, looking at Catra.

She nodded. "Entrapta?", she prompted and the woman happily took the floor.

"The test was a success!", she told them excitedly. "I was able to modify my virus and it completely destroyed any existing tech on Beast Island, rendering it a lot safer than it was before. I am positive that my virus will work against Prime!" She took a short moment, clearly rethinking that statement. "Obviously I can't really say for sure because his systems are different from the First Ones' tech, but I'm … 63% sure!"

"That doesn't sound good, exactly", Perfuma carefully said.

"It's more than fifty", Netossa pointed out with a shrug.

"It's the best we can do with what we had available", Catra agreed. "We have tested the virus, and we have tested Darla. The only problem we still have to face is Prime's hivemind, but luckily for us, he has left us completely alone. Prime might see all, but he chose not to disturb our illusion and he cannot know what his clones can't tell him."

"Which means what exactly?", Mermista interjected, rubbing her temples.

She never thought anyone other than Entrapta could make people react like that. "It means, we distract him. Make him think we're

solely there to save Adora, while Entrapta can sneak around and disable his severs."

That was the short version at least. She was still unsure about how to hide anyone in the ship so that the clones wouldn't find them, and she was a bit worried that they wouldn't be able to distract Prime, or that either group would be caught. But they could discuss all that in a minute.

"Sounds good!", Glimmer enthusiastically supported her. "I'm in!"

"Me too!", Bow naturally said too.

"No." Somehow it didn't surprise her much that Angella had something to say about that. "You will not go anywhere, Glimmer. And as for the plan… It's too dangerous to engage Prime directly."

"I agree", Castaspella had to join the discussion then. "Could we not try to hack him through one of the spires? We do not need to go up there."

Maybe not in theory. "We have to", she still said. "To save Adora."

"Catra", the queen said, suddenly awkward again. "We all wish for her to be safe. But that doesn't mean we should risk any of us. Going straight to Prime is madness, we do not know anything about what it's like on his ship. *If* she has survived so far, she will survive until we can safely get her. I will not allow you or anyone else to risk their lives for a rescue mission when we can safely disable him from here."

The woman was so calm in explaining this to her that it almost sounded condescending. And maybe it was, but in either case, it made Catra incredibly angry. "Even if we defeat Prime from down here", she replied, forcing herself not to yell. "What if he decides to flee and takes Adora who knows where? He opened a portal to get here, you think he can't take one back?", she pointed out. "With our own portal capabilities disabled, and She-Ra gone, we would never get her back."

"Catra", the queen tried to interrupt her, but she wasn't having it. For weeks the woman was barely a ghost in camp, but now she wanted to take charge? Absolutely not.

"I'm not risking her like that!", she snapped, effectively shutting the imposing woman up while the entire room stared at her in shock.

Unfortunately, the queen had a lot of practice having yelling matches with her daughter. She stood up straighter and glared at Catra. "You may think me cruel but I will not risk many for one person."

Catra glared back without shame. "Of course *you* wouldn't. I would risk everything for her", she said slowly, growling ever so slightly. "And if I have to destroy this damned planet *again*, you will not stop me."

It had always been Adora, her greatest motivation. It didn't matter if she wanted to impress her or beat her, keep the girl around or destroy her — Catra would always go to great lengths to achieve her Adora-related goals.

"I will not stop you", the queen said to her surprise, though she didn't soften down one bit. "But I can stop everyone else. No one is leaving camp unless I say so."

After weeks of dealing with everything, suddenly Catra didn't have a say anymore.

After everyone had walked on eggshells around her the entire time to avoid upsetting her, suddenly Adora didn't matter.

After they had gone to Beast Island and got her husband back for her, the queen suddenly had too much to lose to allow another mission.

Catra couldn't hold back the scoff. This woman truly was a coward.

And there was nothing she could do about it.

Admittedly, the plan absolutely was dangerous and risky, but was leaving one of their friends behind worth the alleged safer option?

She stormed out, since there was nothing left to discuss anyway. Whatever they decided to do, they would do it without her.

Catra could only think about what she herself was supposed to do. Even if the queen technically allowed her to leave, how was she supposed to get anywhere? Even if she managed to convince Entrapta to leave the ship to her and use the autopilot, it wouldn't do anything if the woman wasn't on board with her.

She walked into her tent, her sad empty tent that was only filled with the remains of what she had lost.

Once again, she found herself cursing that stupid sword, and her own dumb decisions. She couldn't help but wonder where she would be now, if she had done anything different. And she questioned why she even cared.

It wasn't like she could change it. It wasn't like she could get Adora back. That broken sword would be her eternal reminder that she had lost the one person who meant more than anything to her.

"Catra", Glimmer called for her quietly, sneaking into her tent before she could spiral into her favorite kind of despair.

"What?", she growled — she couldn't stop it, the anger rushing back in with the reminder of the meeting just now. "Get out! I don't need you to pity me!"

The princess was not impressed. "Do you need a secret runaway plan, maybe?", she asked sarcastically.

She blinked, calming down in an instant, too busy being confused. "What?"

"After you left, Entrapta told us that the plan with the spires actually poses the bigger risk", the girl explained. "Like you said, Prime would only suspect us coming for Adora, not his servers. But the spires are heavily guarded, and they are not the main server. She said getting in would be harder and finding enough time to hack into the server first before using the virus even more so. She said your plan is better, if it works."

"If", she repeated. 63%. The best they could ask for and yet not exactly good.

"Mom is still against it... I think it only sank in how dangerous Beast Island was after we had already left and Scorpia told all these stories. She's scared and tries to protect us", Glimmer said, but in no way less determined. "But we will never be safe until Prime is gone, and I won't leave Adora behind either. So my dad will distract my mom while we steal the ship. Are you with us?"

"Are you serious?", Catra scoffed. "Didn't you hear my speech in there?"

The girl smiled even brighter — a rare, hope filled grin. "I knew I could count on you, Horde scum."

"Right back at you, Sparkles."

The princess held out her hand and Catra gratefully took it.

She really shouldn't have doubted her friends to completely ignore the queen's order, but at the same time it was a pretty big risk. Big enough that if it were for anyone but Adora, she wouldn't be sure herself if she wanted to take it.

But as they snuck through camp, winding their path in between the many tents to avoid being spotted, she knew that she would still do it to save them all. Adora might be her biggest motivation, but that didn't meant she would let all of these people die just because the blonde was already by her side.

She supposed that's where Catra and Angella were different — if she had gotten Adora back, she would have fought even harder, instead of resigning herself to fear.

At some point, she picked up the king's soothing voice coming from the queen's tent. She really hoped that whatever they were talking about would distract the woman.

It only took a little bit longer until they reached the ship and she spotted Swift Wind, who nervously looked around and sighed in relief when he saw them.

He was really not subtle when he walked over to them, awkwardly nodding at the people around who all frowned in confusion.

Luckily, they were still perfectly hidden behind a tent, or they would have already been spotted — had that been part of the transformation too? That the horse had to be just as much of a terrible liar as Adora?

"Everyone's ready", he whispered when he was close enough.

"Good, then we can leave quickly", Glimmer replied with a small nod.

Swift Wind still seemed to have something to say, though. At least he opened his mouth a few times and looked incredibly conflicted.

They didn't have time for this, so Catra tried to rack her brain for anything that might be bothering him. Adora being gone did, she knew that. Getting her back should make him happy, or not? Unless… "You should stay", she said then. "Without She-Ra, someone's gotta protect the people down here."

He let out a big sigh, relieved but clearly guilty about it. "I'm sorry, I know I should be there as Adora's steed", he mumbled while tears formed in his eyes. "I just don't belong in space."

"It's alright", she told him. "We got this. You're needed here more", she tried to assure him.

Swift Wind nodded, though he still looked regretful. "Don't let this be goodbye. Be careful. And bring back Adora", he said and quickly nuzzled her face a bit.

"We will", she said and gave him a little pet.

He then went to walk through the crowd, who were all still confused about his odd behavior and therefore easily distracted by it. So, while no one was paying attention, they snuck onto the ship.

They were already expected and Bow spotted them immediately. "All aboard! Let's go", he told Entrapta, who went to type something into the computer.

"Fast launch activated", Darla's voice called out. The ship powered up rapidly, rattling them all a little.

Sparkles squeezed her hand. "Ready?", she asked.

"Ready." Catra nodded.

Bow carefully grabbed her other hand. "Let's save the planet."

***

Prime's ship was a lot farther away than it had looked, but they were slowly getting closer. Painfully so, and even though Catra was incredibly nervous to get there, she wished they had already reached it because it had been hours and she was starting to feel incredibly agitated and impatient.

At first they had all been tense, ready for what was to come, but then they realized how long this journey would actually take and everyone got busy with something.

Entrapta and Hordak — no, she didn't know either why he was here — started to tinker on something, Bow made some adjustments on his trick arrows, Glimmer practiced her spells and Catra filed her nails.

It wasn't the greatest way to pass the time, but it kept her somewhat calm and focused on something other than their possible death. She still looked out of the window from time to time, staring at Prime's ship in the distance, hoping Adora would really be there.

"Uh, guys?", Glimmer said into the tense silence at some point.

Catra teared herself away from the large ship in front of them to look at the princess who seemed a bit distressed.

When everyone's attention was on her, she drew a rune into the air, but it flickered and vanished before it could actually fulfill its function. "I think I can't do magic in space."

"What?", Bow screeched.

Entrapta hummed intrigued. "Probably for the same reason the bird horse can't connect to Adora. We're too far away from the planet."

That was … not ideal, but not the worst either. "Fighting wasn't part of the plan anyway", she told them. "We should avoid provoking a fight if possible, actually." The only thing that could pose a problem was that they couldn't teleport away in case of an emergency.

"Right", Glimmer mumbled, still a bit high pitched and anxious. "It's fine. I honestly feel a bit weird and empty, but we'll be back soon, so no problem. Right?"

"Ideally", Catra replied, a bit unsure herself. There was so much that could go wrong, but she didn't feel the need to make the others even more nervous.

"Speaking of fighting!", Entrapta then called out and ran towards a pile of tech.

"I just said no fighting", she told the woman with a bit of irritation.

Naturally, she was ignored. "I just remembered that I got something for you! Between the virus, repairing Darla, and Beast Island, I completely forgot", she kept going excitedly and then pushed something into Catra's hands.

She had honestly no idea what she was looking at. It was a thin, cylinder-shaped thing that had a few almost invisible buttons on it. Since she didn't know what else to do with the thing, she decided to press one, and when she did, it got longer fast.

Looking at it in it's entirety, she finally realized what it was. "A whip."

Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. "I've worked on it for a while, but with everything going on it took a lot longer than I thought", she told her. "I tried to make it easily transportable, without having to constantly roll it up, while still keeping the flexibility and increasing deadliness", she explained with glee.

"Uh, what?", Bow chimed in, looking a bit terrified.

"It's an option", the woman waved him off, though. "You can change the texture from a normal whip to razors. And you can cut off the whip part! I thought it might be practical, in case it gets stuck or something — it would be a shame having to completely rebuild it. That way you can just refill it. I put two in there, so you have a spare, and I can easily make more."

Catra hummed appreciatively, letting her hands run over her new weapon. It looked like metal, but felt like the leather she has had before, and it was a nice weight in her hand.

She especially liked being able to rid herself of the thing, remembering how Shadow Weaver had electrocuted her through

it. "I think I like it", she said. Of course, she couldn't say for sure until she had tested it, but that wouldn't be a good idea in close quarters.

"I actually took inspiration from the data I have on your claws", Entrapta told her excitedly. "It uses the same method of extending or retracting deadliness."

She smiled at the other. "Thank you. I'm sure I'll find a way to test it. When we're back", she emphasized because she stood by what she said. Even if their plan didn't run smoothly, which was likely, they should still avoid an attack.

"So… What exactly do we plan to do?", Glimmer asked, looking mostly at Catra.

"Entrapta and Hordak will have to hide out somehow, while we go and distract Prime. I'm sure we'll find something to stall — Adora, the invasion, maybe we'll insult him a bit. The important part is that we buy time for Entrapta and Hordak to find access to the hivemind and shut it down", she told them, leaving out her worries.

"I doubt he'll just hand Adora to us", the princess mumbled. "So, we'll look for her when everything is shut down, right?"

Catra nodded and wanted to keep going, talk a bit more about the details, but someone cleared their throat before she could.

Someone who hadn't talked at all since they had entered the ship. "Is this how you plan?", Hordak asked. "You are already dead if you think that Prime is so easily fooled."

"You got a better plan?", Catra challenged and the guy looked away. "Thought so."

"Prime's ship is a maze and can only be navigated per the hivemind", he said anyway. "We will never find the server room or your friend."

"We?", Bow suddenly cooed and Catra watched in amusement as the choice of words caught up to the former warlord. "You are part of the team!"

"I am not", the guy protested and if they hadn't all seen him at his weakest already, the accompanying glare and half-shout would have had more effect.

As it was, Bow kept bullying Hordak by telling him how adorable it was that he cared.

Catra chuckled. "Didn't you listen?", she told him with a smirk, happily joining in. "You're with Entrapta to get the virus in place. You're part of the rebellion now." She had fun watching him sputter, trying to say something in his defense, but he knew she was right.

"It'll be fun!", Entrapta told him. "We can hide outside! Just think of the data!"

That stopped everyone in their tracks. "What do you mean, outside?", Bow then asked in confusion.

"I have made space suits. You know, just in case. We're in space, I thought better to have them and not use them, but now we can use them!", the woman easily explained.

"When did you have time to make and test them?", Glimmer questioned skeptically.

"I didn't test them", she replied with a carefree smile. "Yet! This would be the perfect opportunity!"

Catra shrugged. "Good enough for me", she said and put the whip into a pocket.

She didn't know when, but at some point she had really started to trust Entrapta, so much so that she was now willing to walk into possibly the most dangerous situation of her life, all while having

to trust the woman on every front — that she wouldn't die hiding outside and that her virus would work.

So close to Prime's ship, she did wonder if this was truly a good idea. And if it wouldn't have been better for Glimmer and Bow to stay behind at least. She was glad that they were here, of course, but she was also worried they wouldn't survive this.

There was no time to turn back now though, and as if to prove her right, the ship started to rumble and alarms beeped — somehow she didn't think this was a failure in the system.

"Alert. We are being pulled in by an outside force", Darla confirmed.

"Entrapta, get the spacesuits ready and hide. I doubt we'll have long", she ordered the scientist, who nodded and grabbed a very reluctant Hordak before running out of the room.

"This is it then", Glimmer said once they were alone, taking deliberately deep breaths to stay calm. "We'll be fine, right?"

"Of course", Bow answered, though his worried frown said otherwise. "Nothing could beat the Best Friend Squad."

Catra rolled her eyes fondly at the stupid name, but stayed quiet. She didn't have any positive affirmations to give. Either this worked, or they were dead. No other options.

They were unsettlingly close to Prime's ship now and their own appeared insignificantly small next to it.

She really hoped this worked. And that Entrapta and Hordak first of all managed to hide and not get caught.

An opening let them through and they were pulled into a giant hall that had nothing in it.

Catra took a few deep breaths too now. The last thing she wanted was for anyone to know how scared she was. And they probably

had better chances to buy time if Prime thought them to be tougher targets. Maybe.

It was only when the opening, they had come through, was fully closed again, that clones entered the hall.

She opened Darla's hatch, who confirmed that the air outside should be breathable, and held her head high as she walked out.

"Try to stay calm", she hissed at her friends, who oozed with fear like they wanted to be easy prey. To be fair though, they did not have as much experience with appearing more confident than they were as Catra.

That was why she placed herself slightly in front of them, hopefully signaling to the clones that if they wanted to mess with someone, it should be her.

"Welcome", one of them said as two others stiffly walked past them into the ship, probably searching it. "Prime is awaiting you."

They were not given a chance to respond. The clones positioned themselves in a circle around them and started to walk, forcing them to follow along. At least they were neither searched nor restrained, though they might as well had been — there wasn't much room to move with the clones surrounding them. No way to run back to the ship and flee.

Shortly before leaving the hall, she could hear two sets of synchronized steps walk down Darla's ramp — clearly the search party coming back empty handed. So unless Entrapta and Hordak had died, that part of the plan was running smoothly already.

Catra shortly debated letting the others know, but she could hardly say it out loud, and she doubted any gesture she could chose would convey her message, so she did nothing. They had to focus on their job anyway and it wouldn't do much to distract them now with unclear hints that they would mull over.

She herself tried to focus on the path, but as Hordak had said, it was impossible to know where they were going. Every corridor was the same sterile white, there was barely even a door.

But this was hardly a maze, certainly not in the way Dryl was — full of traps and confusion, put together without any thought or reason. No, this was simply a place without landmarks. She doubted it was actually all that hard to navigate, but if everything looked the same, of course no one could tell left from right anymore.

This realization did make Prime appear a lot less impressive in her eyes.

Still, she worried a bit about their other team finding the server room. And she worried about finding Adora later. Just because it was a lazy attempt at confusing one's senses didn't mean it wasn't working.

But one thing at a time. She took a quiet, subtle deep breath, grounding herself again. They would face Prime soon and she had to be ready and focused for that. And the white empty hallways, along with the creepy clones already made her nervous enough.

It took a weirdly long time of winding through the endless corridors for them to get anywhere. She understood that the ship was big but at some point she did think they were just lead around pointlessly to waste their time, slowly make them lose hope and sense, but eventually they did stop.

The clones came to a halt so abruptly, she almost ran into them, and Glimmer and Bow did bump into her a little. She leaned a bit to the side to see past the clones and watched as a swipe of one of their hands opened a door into another huge and empty room.

As they went inside, the small army of clones moved a bit to the side, so they could properly face Prime.

They were seemingly in his throne room. At least, a guy who she assumed to be Prime, simply because he looked different from the

other clones, was sat in a big chair with big screens behind him, admittedly giving an air of authority.

He eyed them curiously.

"I'll be honest, I have expected you to be smarted than come directly to me", he told them, leaning back in his chair in a relaxed manner like nothing could harm him. Like this was just a casual chat. "But you Etherians do seem to lack a proper sense for your own inferiority."

Catra wasn't sure she was hearing correctly. Okay, yes they were losing, and it was possibly stupid to be here, especially from his perspective, unaware of their broader plan, but … was he serious? He clearly was, smugly looking at them like he knew them inside out.

She really didn't know what to say to such a blatant display of ego, but she did have to restrain herself from laughing at the ridiculousness of this.

Luckily, Glimmer stepped in, clearly not as taken aback and more offended which always fueled her confidence. "You have one of our own. We want her back and then you can crawl back into whatever hole you came from!"

Not the most eloquent thing to say, and not really a response to what he had said, but it would do. Their job wasn't to win a debate, they just had to distract him.

And it seemed to work. Prime sighed with a certain weight, like he was going to explain the world to them now, which sounded terrible, but if it gave them time, Catra would live with it. "It baffles me how little you Etherians understand", he lamented. "Your dimension is beyond disgraceful. I want nothing more than to go back to the wide universe that I have brought into my light. Back to the order and peace I have created. But your planet still has something of interest to me."

He let the words sit for a second and Catra knew now that she had been right — Prime knew about the Heart. Which would mean that Adora must still be alive.

She tried to not let her relief show, but she noticed Prime focusing solely on her and she had a feeling that he saw it anyway. She didn't know why he was so interested in her, though. And it worried her a little.

"As for your She-Ra", he kept going then, still staring at her. "I was not unhappy about having caught her instead of my defective brother. She certainly has more uses to me, though she is ... stubborn", he said with disdain. "She refuses to see reason. She certainly has proven not to be the smartest. You must be aware of this too, and yet you want her back." His brows furrowed as if he truly didn't understand the concept of friendship.

Well, surrounded by versions of himself and trying to destroy the universe, he might really not know what that is.

"She is very smart", Bow naturally came to Adora's defense. "She's brave and loyal and she's a great friend."

Prime didn't dignify that with a response. He didn't even look at the boy, still staring into Catra's soul while she defiantly stared back — she didn't know what else to do, and she was not about to let him see any of her worries by evading him.

After another few seconds, he waved a hand, still not looking away from Catra, and she heard two clones leave the room. He then sat up a bit straighter, making himself appear taller.

"Her attitude has given me a lot of grief", he kept talking, ignoring Bow completely. Catra wondered if the guy had even heard him. "I have thought about ways to fix this, but I couldn't try to gain access to her mind without risking disabling her powers, and she would be even more difficult should I have tried."

What did that even mean? Gaining access to her mind? Clearly that didn't happen, but the fact that it had been an option was

disturbing enough.

"I have tried to make her understand, but she remained blind to my vision", he said, sounding almost sad. "In the end, it seemed her rather primitive emotions are the key."

Catra grit her teeth. They had known that he was probably trying to pressure Adora with her friends as leverage, and they had known about the risks of coming here voluntarily. But she would admit that she had hoped they could distract him long enough without being submitted to possible torture.

She knew it didn't work like that, but she still tried to send a mental message to Entrapta to hurry up.

Then the door behind them opened again and Catra refused to look, simply hoping it wasn't the others having been caught and dragged here.

Glimmer and Bow gasped behind her and if Catra hadn't been stuck in this arbitrary staring contest, she might have looked now, but she honestly didn't really want to see.

"I am very glad you came here on your own", Prime then said too smugly for comfort. "It spared me the effort of catching and dragging you here", he told them — or maybe just her, seeing as he had ignored the others so far.

Her fur stood on end, but she didn't dare smooth it down. She was too busy to keep her poker face intact and her breathing even.

It was only when Adora entered her field of vision that she failed at everything.

Her eyes left Prime's and she couldn't stop the obvious worry from entering her expression. She understood the earlier gasps.

The blonde was still in one piece at least, but otherwise she looked absolutely terrible. Her hair was open and greasy, her

clothes disheveled, she looked weak and tired. Not even in the portal has Catra seen the girl so hopeless.

Adora stared back at her with terror. "What are you doing here?", she asked absolutely panicked, her eyes raking her body like she already expected Prime to have hurt her.

What happened to her?

"We're saving you", Glimmer answered again because Catra was still unable to form a single sentence. The princess sounded a bit unsure, but a lot more composed than Catra felt.

Prime's laugh startled her out of her staring and she focused back on his infuriating arrogance.

He stood up from his chair to walk over to where Adora was being restrained by two of his clones. When he put a hand on her shoulder, Catra instinctively extended her claws. But she couldn't actually do anything — not on his ship, not with all these clones around.

"I have a theory", he then said, staring solely at Catra again. "You are so proud of your emotions. Let's put them to the test."

She jumped up before he could even snap his fingers — she had seen this coming and took out two clones before they could move at his command. But the door opened again and dozens more swarmed in.

This was exactly why she had hoped they could avoid a fight. Just like down on Etheria, they didn't stand a chance, but she was panicked, unsure what Prime was planning, and she would at least try to fight her way out of this.

Bow shot his arrows and Glimmer hit them with her sorcerers staff, but it simply wasn't good enough. She tried to help them but she could barely handle herself — with dozens of opponents, she wasn't even granted a second to get her whip out. Not that she thought it would help.

She really only had her speed and agility, and for a second she debated whether she could make it back to the ship, but even if she could, she couldn't just leave with all her friends stuck here.

"Catra watch out!", Adora suddenly screamed behind her and she only barely dodged the arm lunging at her.

She had let herself get a bit too distracted, and she was punished for it by evading her attacker but losing her balance in the process. The next clone who tried to grab her was a lot more successful and while she severely damaged them with her claws, they just weren't bothered by the pain.

And just like that, they were all restrained. It was a bit embarrassing to be beaten so quickly, but it wasn't like she had expected anything else.

Prime took a few sweet seconds to look between her and Adora, clearly waiting for something before sighing. "It's a shame, really", he said with not a single amount of regret in his voice. "You are quite the asset to behold. Catra, was it?"

He clearly awaited an answer, so she growled in response.

Now he did look a bit regretful. "I do hope I won't have to kill you", he remarks like it was just an afterthought.

There were protests all around her, as they struggled against their restrains, but Catra tried to stay calm. This was fine. Even if she died, she should be fine. Hopefully. Unless she was wrong. Then this could be a problem, but she believed that she had done her research correctly. And she had several experiences to prove her point.

She would still like to avoid death if possible.

"Leave her alone!", Adora then yelled, sounding so unbelievably heartbroken. "I can't help you, I can't turn into She-Ra!"

Prime hummed, seemingly not interested in what the girl had to say. "I'd like to confirm that if you don't mind", he said and waved for a few more clones to come forth.

Most of them went to stand beside Adora, but one came to a stop in front of Catra. She had a terrible feeling about this.

"Love is such a pathetic predictable thing", he kept talking, and sat back in his chair to enjoy the show. "So fragile and yet … so strong. At least you should hope so, Catra."

A hand then grabbed her throat, and though it wasn't tight enough to truly hurt her, something told her they would get there soon.

She had no chance to fight back either, with the clones around her holding her arms and hands with more pressure, and she was also kneeling in an awkward position — she barely had any room to move at all.

"Catra!", three people screamed at the same time the grip gradually got tighter.

Well, now she was starting to feel a bit panicked, bad memories from her last time being suffocated coming back to her. Maybe, just in case she was wrong, she should make sure she could leave in peace. Somewhat.

"I'm sorry", she blurted out while she still could. It shocked Adora enough that she stopped struggling for a second. "I'm sorry for not coming with you, and hurting you, and being terrible to you. I'm sorry for not talking to you. I'm sorry for blaming you." She could list more things to be sorry for, but air was becoming limited supply and she simply did not have time for that. "I'm sorry for … for everything."

"No!", Adora protested, resuming her struggle with renewed effort, knowing damn well that Catra was only apologizing now because she thought she might actually die. "No, no, no, don't you dare!"

"Don't worry, I'll be fine", she still deliriously got out even thought she could not really breathe anymore.

Hopefully, her theory was right. And hopefully Entrapta and Hordak would save them soon.

"Catra!", Adora screamed incredibly desperate. "You never should have come here!" It almost sounding like she was crying.

She couldn't tell anymore. She couldn't breathe. She was getting dizzy, and she only partly noticed that she was about to black out.

Her senses didn't seem to fully work anymore as noises became hazy.

There was a bright light, some shouting. She didn't know if any of that was even real.

She really hoped she had some lives left.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter coming soon, I promise!!

Until then stay hydrated <33 (seriously, drink something, especially if you're also melting in the heat)

Chapter 29: Rescue - Part 2

Chapter Notes

And we continue!

Warnings for angst still apply, including maiming, violence, and discussions about dying
And more exploration of semi-canon info
Also, we have some timeline overlap between POV's (just a disclaimer in case it could be confusing)

I hope you enjoy <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After her escape attempt, Adora barely felt alive anymore. She never moved from the floor and really tried to not throw up when she forced down her food.

She had no idea what else she was supposed to do and she was honestly too scared to come up with something else.

If Mara already thought she wouldn't be remembered as a hero, then what was Adora supposed to say? She felt so useless. Because she was.

It felt like forever and yet it was too soon when two clones suddenly opened her cell. There was no food in their hands and no empty words directed at her.

Since she was not sure what was going on, she didn't bother to try and get up, which only gave her a few bruises as she was harshly dragged off the ground and forced to keep pace with them.

She stumbled a lot as they paid absolutely no attention to whether she was actually walking or if they hauled her along. Meanwhile she was incredibly anxious — she understood the

harsh treatment after her previous stunt, but there was still something about it, and their lack of "Prime wishes to see you" shtick, that set panic loose inside her again.

They lead her into the throne room that she had arrived in and that she had seen again just the day before.

Adora swallowed hard, unsure what this meant. Surely nothing good.

A larger group of clones stood in the middle and Prime talked to someone, full of his usual smugness and some … vague interest.

"I am very glad you came here on your own. It spared me the effort of searching for you and dragging you here", he said.

Adora's blood ran cold and she raked her head to see through the wall of clones to hopefully find her worst fear untrue.

She didn't. Her eyes met with Glimmer and Bow, who probably mirrored her own terrified face as they gasped. And when she finally rounded the circle of clones, she shared a worried look with Catra.

No, this couldn't be happening.

Her friends looked fine, afraid but at least they weren't hurt. Still, they shouldn't be here. How did they get here? Prime said he didn't drag them here, so what? They came here voluntarily? Were they insane?

Adora vaguely heard herself ask them why, but she couldn't hear Glimmer's response over her own heartbeat as she still tried to make sure Catra really was okay. She had to be okay.

Prime's mocking laugh ripped her attention away from her friend then. He had a serene look of victory on his face, and how could he not? He knew she cared about her friends and now he had a way to pressure her.

Just that it wouldn't do anything. She couldn't do anything.

She was ripped from her spiral again when he put a hand on her shoulder. He pressed down hard as if daring her to make a wrong move. But she didn't dare move at all. She hardly even breathed.

And she stopped breathing entirely when her friends had to fight.

All she wanted to do was run over and help, but Prime still dug his fingers into her shoulder, keeping her tethered to the spot — he was stronger than he looked.

But so was Catra. She was fast and ruthless and Adora loved to think that she could win this, but she knew better. Even if she defeated all the clones in this room, there were thousands more on the ship.

Bow and Glimmer already got overwhelmed, meaning the opening doors and following flood of reinforcements were solely for Catra.

The girl got more reckless quickly and it evidently cost her her focus.

Adora saw the attack before she did. "Catra, watch out!", she screamed and watched the feline dodge with relief, only to be captured seconds later, the force of clones too overwhelming. "No", she breathed.

For a moment, nothing happened. Like Prime was waiting for something, but then he did start to talk to Catra.

The girl only growled and if they weren't in such a terrible situation, maybe Adora would appreciate the rebellion a bit more.

He sighed in response. "I do hope I won't have to kill you", he said, and despite knowing that it was dumb, Adora started to desperately struggle against her restraints. She wouldn't be able to fight all these clones either, but she would gladly die in Catra's stead.

"Leave her alone!", she begged more than anything. "I can't help you, I can't turn into She-Ra!", she confessed, stupidly trying to request mercy, but clearly Prime didn't care about her feelings or her friends.

"I'd like to confirm that if you don't mind", he said like he was asking permission. He wasn't and she knew that.

Why did she have to be so stupid? Why did she have to be such a terrible actress? She never should have let him know how much she cared for these people.

What was she supposed to do now that her friend's life was in danger and she got restrained even more?

Prime sat back down, relaxed, almost bored. "Love is such a pathetic predictable thing", he said with an undertone of disgust. "So fragile and yet … so strong. At least you should hope so, Catra."

"Catra!", she screamed and heard her own plea echoed twice. Glimmer and Bow struggled and failed just the same, as the feline was slowly cut off from breath.

Adora focused on the girl's chest, watching it rise and fall irregularly, but at least air was getting in and out, but for how long? She had to do something, but she couldn't. Without She-Ra, she wasn't strong enough and without the sword she had no idea how to be She-Ra. Also, that was exactly what Prime wanted, so She-Ra was a terrible idea anyway, but by everything, she would do it if it saved Catra.

"I'm sorry!" It was like the world suddenly slowed down. Adora didn't believe what she was hearing. "I'm sorry for not coming with you, and hurting you, and being terrible to you. I'm sorry for not talking to you. I'm sorry for blaming you. I'm sorry for … for everything."

"No!", she said before she could fully process all of that. There was no way Catra was honestly apologizing. If she was really

apologizing then only because … because this might be the end. "No, no, no, don't you dare!", she yelled, suddenly angry.

Adora would rather live her whole long life with Catra as her enemy than have her apologize right now.

She couldn't lose her. Not like this.

She didn't want an apology, not if it meant losing her.

She wanted-

"Don't worry", the girl croaked out, making Adora wince. "I'll be fine."

She wanted to scream a lot of things in that moment — most of them about Catra being an idiot and an asshole, but that didn't come out of her mouth. "Catra!" she sobbed instead. "You never should have come here!"

Her eyes started to water and she blinked the tears away quickly because she needed to see the irregular breaths coming in, needed the girl to survive this.

Somehow, she expected the always rebellious girl to do something, say something again, but nothing came.

Catra's muscles went slack and something in Adora broke.

Like a dam being broken, she felt something rush inside of her — it felt weird and hot, but also oddly familiar.

She knew she was stronger somehow, like she had been back when Prime had first threatened Catra.

Maybe it was ridiculous. Maybe she really was going insane. But the feeling inside her tugged her forward and she freed one arm to reach out to something.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" The words came to her like an instinct being awoken and to her own surprise, she grew taller and stronger and glowing — had she always been this bright?

There was a sword in her hand, though it was different. She still used it without problem to get rid of the remaining clones trying to hold her down.

She had to get to Catra, quickly. Maybe she could still heal the girl and everything would be alright. She could still fix this.

Unfortunately, Prime was prepared.

Adora did not manage to get more than a few steps closer to the girl. For every clone she threw to the side, three new ones arrived from a seemingly endless supply of them.

She vaguely heard Glimmer and Bow cheering her on, but it was just too many and her new connection to She-Ra was unexpectedly fragile.

The sword was gone the second she had opened her palm once as a clone crashed into her and she had no idea how to summon a new one. With only her fists, she wasn't quite as powerful and even if it took them a while, eventually enough clones had arrived to hold her down again.

Prime didn't seem deterred in the slightest, but he did keep a certain distance from her as he got up and walked over to her friend. "I knew your Catra would get you there", he said triumphantly. The clone moved to the side then and Prime looked at the girl skeptically for a few seconds until she coughed. "Good, you're still alive", he said and sounded honestly happy. "As it turns out, I will need you for a little while longer. I wouldn't want to separate you two."

"Let her go", Adora said in no way less desperate, even though she was She-Ra now. "I'll open your portal, but you have to let her go", she tried to bargain, now that she actually could do

something. Maybe. It was still doubtful if she could access the Heart without the sword.

Prime looked at her curiously. "Why would I do that?", he asked in a disdainful tone. "Keeping her here is the only way to secure your cooperation. After all, I already know how well you keep your word."

Sadly, he had a point there. She had not exactly build a great reputation of being trusted, having evaded his questions as much as she could, not keeping her word of answering him if he answered her, trying to run while hurting his clones in the process.

But she couldn't just let this happen. There had to be something she could do, but … there was nothing. Even when she was She-Ra again, she was utterly useless.

"You can't do that!", Glimmer yelled too then. "You won't get away with this, we'll stop you!"

He laughed again. Always so mocking. "If you are referring to your friend and my defective brother, I assure you they didn't get far on their way to sabotage me. You miscalculated. I see all. I know all."

Adora blanched at the idea of there being more people dragged into this, just because she had made some dumb decisions.

Prime sat back down on his throne, victoriously glaring down at them.

He had won. She had failed.

And Catra was still not moving. But she was breathing.

***

Entrapta happily walked through the corridors. Her space suits had been a success and it made her evidently happy, but also very inattentive. Hordak had to grab her several times to make sure she didn't run into any patrolling clones.

It seemed to be her usual state, as he had learned, to be rather distracted, bouncing from one project to the next, her science always the top priority on her mind to the point of risking her own existence.

Somehow, during his time as her lab partner, he had come to worry about her safety.

He didn't pretend to understand, but she called him a friend, so he supposed that would explain his … emotions.

It was an odd thing to care about someone. Someone that wasn't Prime at least. That always came easy to him, even when he had wanted his death.

Entrapta was the complete opposite of his brother. Kind, happy and in love with everything her backwater planet had to offer. She had a certain appreciation for the imperfect. And she never assumed to know, always ready to experiment and ask questions, no matter how much they annoyed others. Her determination to understand science and social dynamics alike was admirable.

The goal was less so, in his eyes. Understanding and being friends with the others didn't serve her in the slightest and he did not understand why she kept so generously offering her knowledge and skills.

The other rebels clearly did not think highly of her, with the exception of his own former soldiers. He never thought highly of princesses either, but he wondered if he maybe should have recruited Entrapta anyway.

He shook his head, subtly. His Horde was a thing of the past and there was no use dwelling on it. Not that there was a part for him in the rebellion either. Not like he wanted one.

All he wanted was for his … friend to be safe. In the midst of Prime's ship that was a difficult endeavor, though.

"Do you think we're getting closer?", she asked then.

"I do not know. I have no connection to the hivemind anymore", he reminded.

The woman hummed and spun around herself a few times, frowning. "How does anyone get around in this place? Where are the vents? Or doors? It's so empty!"

Hordak winced at her loud complaint and quickly pushed her along before they got found by any clones.

"It has to be somewhere in the center", he mumbled. That sounded about right. It was hard to remember anything that has never been his own thought.

"Oh, that makes sense", Entrapta encouraged all the same and forced them to a stop. For a being so small, she was surprisingly strong. "Where is the center?", she then asked.

They had taken several turns without keeping track of them. There was no telling where they were or where to go.

Then a pair of clones walked past them in a hurry. They didn't seem to have taken much notice of them, which Hordak was grateful for, but Entrapta decided to run after them.

There was no time to stop her or even ask what she was planning, so he simply resolved himself to sneaking alongside her and keeping an eye out.

The clones lead them to a room that was decidedly not the sever room, but Entrapta's eyes lit up anyway.

She bounced on her hair excitedly as they waited for the clones to come back out. Hordak did not understand why it was necessary

to enter a room they knew was not their destination, but he waited.

The first chance they got, Entrapta ran into the room. It was the cloning chamber.

"Stand guard?", she asked. It wasn't an order — he was unsure if the woman was even at all capable of ordering people around — but he listened anyway.

His faith in her had not been strong in the beginning, but he soon learned how brilliant she was and while unorthodox she knew what she was doing.

Right now, she was getting to work on one of the capsules, connecting it with her data pad.

After a few more seconds, he could hear her giggle. Why was unclear.

"Oh wow", was the next thing. He glanced over briefly, but apart from her usual curiosity, he couldn't discern anything. "Oh, wow!", she repeated with more glee.

"What?", he then asked, feeling the slightest bit anxious, not knowing what was happening.

"Prime's hivemind is infinitely more complex than I could have ever imagined!", she exclaimed with awe.

Hordak stared dumbly as he processed this information. "His hivemind?"

"I'm in!" She shot him a bright smile and he stood in utter shock. Three minutes on a cloning pod and she had hacked the hivemind?

Then it hit him. If she was in the hivemind, everyone would know about it. Prime would know about it.

"We need to get out of here", he told her with urgency, but she kept typing something.

"I just need another minute", she said, typing with incredible speed.

He doubted they had another minute, but he waited until he heard steps down the hallway. Then he went over to grab her despite her protests, even helping her pack up.

They managed to get out of the room just before the clones arrived, but they were spotted. He knew this entire endeavor was a mistake. With the rebellion planning things so badly, it was incomprehensible to him how he had failed to win against them.

Entrapta still stared down at her pad as they ran. Suddenly hair grabbed him and pulled him into the exact opposite direction he would've chosen.

To his bafflement, she lead them to the server room. Whatever she had done in that minute must have been enough.

"Aha! We made it", she screamed out as if she hadn't believed they would. She pulled out the virus disk and several cables from her hair. "I need maybe ten minutes!"

She ran over to the center while the clones that were working in the room were too shocked to move.

By the time they were ready to attack, Hordak was already next to them and struck. It was one of their biggest weaknesses, the lack of their own thoughts meant they were delayed in their actions if they had no prior instructions.

Hordak had another advantage over them — Entrapta's friendship. While she had labeled it as '*ethical dilemma number 64*', she had made him a new armor and kept tinkering on it whenever she noticed him struggling even if he tried to hide it.

She had been very much aware that the rebellion wouldn't like him getting an upgrade, or the ability to move without pain, but it didn't stop her and right now, he was happier than ever that she ignored her perceived morals.

Right now, it meant that he had the strength and agility that the clones lacked. They were good fighters, Prime made sure of that, but Hordak was better. If only by a bit. But it was enough to hold them off.

"You're doing great!", Entrapta encouraged while sticking way more cables into the server than could be possibly necessary.

He was doing okay, for now. That was the advantage the clones had over him. They were many. It didn't matter much that they had lesser strength, in a fight a hundred against one, they would always win.

The only hope was that Entrapta managed to shut down the hivemind.

Hordak almost laughed then. Hope — such an idiotic concept and somehow he understood now why people hoped. When there was a future to want, hope came naturally.

It was odd to want something. The only thing he ever knew to want was to be back with Prime, but now he wanted to protect Entrapta. And it gave him the endurance to see this through at the very least, but with his defective body he still had limits.

"Almost there!", Entrapta yelled. "This is taking longer than I thought, but it's all so complex!"

He couldn't answer, needing to save what strength he had left to fight off the incoming clones. Realistically there had to be an end to them, but he doubted he could fight long enough to reach it.

They were getting cornered now and he felt his body failing. He would keep going of course, but it was rather irritating.

Then suddenly a strand of hair pulled him back.

Entrapta stood in front of him and took a deep breath before whistling loudly. "Darla!", she screamed from the top of her lungs, which said a lot considering her normal volume of speaking was already quite loud.

A few seconds later, the ship crashed through the walls and took out the clones in the room, stopping right in front of Entrapta like that thing knew exactly where she stood.

The woman turned around with a smile. "You did really great! This should buy us a few minutes", she told him and went back to her work, while he caught his breath.

"I had it under control", he grumbled, leaning against a wall.

"Didn't doubt it", she told him without looking up. "There were a lot of them, though. Even all the princesses combined struggle against them. I was just trying to help, but statistically you held yourself much better than anyone else. Maybe even Catra. I'd have to conduct further testing."

Hordak took the positive evaluation for what it was. He had never payed much attention to Catra in the Horde, not even after she defected, but he had been able to see quite a lot of the girl when he was stuck at camp and during his attempted escape. She was capable and certainly a threat on the battle field. Being on par with or even exceeding her abilities was quite the compliment.

He couldn't dwell on the oddly positive feeling that thought brought with it however, because just like Entrapta had said, they bought themselves mere minutes. He could already hear a number of clones trying to circumvent the ship blocking the entrance to the server room.

With a grunt he got up to give his lab partner more time, but apparently she didn't need it.

"Are you ready?", she asked, bouncing on her hair excitedly and looking at him with the brightest smile he had ever seen her wear, and she was smiling a lot.

It took him a second to understand what she was referring to. The virus was installed. He nodded.

"Oh, I hope this works. Here it goes!" She slammed her hand on the button of her pad.

Hordak had no doubt in Entrapta's abilities, but he also knew how perfectly Prime developed his resources and hadn't been all that confident about this plan. But as the power went down and they sat in the dark with Entrapta cheering, he thought that even though the woman was imperfect in every possible way, she was stronger than Prime could ever hope to be.

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Here's the thing about having several lives — it's not as convenient as one might think. Catra didn't just magically regenerate, she simply kept living when she shouldn't be.

The first time it happened was at Princess Prom, the first time around, when she had let herself fall off a cliff. The drop was a lot deeper than she had anticipated and when she had landed on their vehicle, she passed out shortly and crawled inside with what felt like broken bones throughout her body. She put on a smile and a show, but she had never been in more pain, which had really made her wonder how she was still alive.

Of course she didn't just immediately think that she might have actually died.

Then those mechanical spiders offed her once more, making her really question things, but it wasn't until Hordak killed her and she

woke up in a cell with her lungs aching that it finally clicked for her. Maybe that was why death hadn't meant much to her when she threw herself into the portal. Or after.

So, when she had the chance, she had checked out Brightmoon's library to figure a few things out about herself and apparently she wasn't imagining things. Her species did have the ability to evade death. Sometimes. And not forever.

She couldn't decide if she counted herself lucky or not to have been one of the few born with this dumb ability, but she had to admit, it did come in handy sometimes.

Honestly, most of all she was just glad that Shadow Weaver had clearly never cared to learn more about her because if she had known, Catra surely would have lost a few lives throughout her childhood.

Prime didn't seem to know either. At least he sounded honestly surprised when she coughed up a little blood — that she instantly swallowed down again because she was not giving him that satisfaction, and she didn't want anyone else to see and worry more than they already did.

Since he just kept on ignoring her, she thought it was safe to say that he probably thought she had just passed out. He certainly didn't seem to know that living despite dying was a thing she could do.

It wasn't very practical anyway. The sensation of death followed her, weakened her, and overall wasn't pleasant. She would appreciate this ability more if it fully healed her, but it didn't. Her throat hurt, her vocal cords felt tight and her body sore from the lack of oxygen.

Catra tried to take some subtle deep breaths to regain some life and strength, even if it felt like being stabbed.

Turns out that suffocating was her least favorite way to die, especially when her throat had been squished, but she couldn't

deal with that now. Talking wasn't important right now anyway, being able to move was.

Despite what Prime had said, she had to believe that Entrapta and Hordak were still working on the virus and as long as no one dragged them in here, she would trust that they were fine. So she had to get ready to fight again.

So, she kept quiet, didn't move and just kept breathing.

Even if she increasingly became more nervous and every sound startled her as she was waiting for the telltale sign that they had failed, but instead she only heard Prime, which was just as bad.

"Now what to do with you?", he asked, sounding bored. "I have use for these two, but you?"

Catra's heart beat faster, which wasn't great for her pain levels at all, but Glimmer and Bow being in danger didn't exactly help to stay calm — she might have several lives, but they didn't.

"No!", Adora seemingly had the defense covered, though she was unsure how much that would help considering how little impact her pleading has had before. "They're part of the Heart too! You can't kill them!"

It must be the sheer panic in her voice that somehow made the girl convincing because, while her statement was true for Glimmer, Bow certainly was not part of the weapon. Not that Prime needed to know that.

"Is that so?", he asked skeptically. Even though Adora did *sound* more convincing than usual, Catra didn't see her right now and couldn't tell if the girl had given herself away with her face.

The following silence stretched itself unbearably long, with her friends' fate hanging in the air and Catra's dumb body making her pain unnecessarily worse due to the frantic heartbeat and stiff anticipation.

Luckily for everyone, the power went down before any judgment could be passed.

The hands holding her loosened, confirming that it must be the virus doing the damage and not something else, and she sighed in relief to know that Entrapta was safe. And Hordak too, she supposed.

Catra was still feeling rather weak, especially since her healing process had been halted by her anxiety just now, but she freed herself from her restraints anyway.

Her entire body protested and revolted the quick movement as she made her way to Prime, but she pushed through.

The pain made her a bit slow and left her dazed, and she could barely hold onto any clear thought with her brain yelling at her to stop moving. She had a hard time walking straight, or even seeing, despite usually not being bothered by darkness, but her goal was still clear.

She had to make her way to Prime before anyone could get their bearings and protect him.

They had this one chance while the hivemind was disabled to get rid of him for good. And someone had to use it.

Despite her impairment, she somehow managed to jump forward and actually land on Prime, finding leverage with her claws in his face. His scream was satisfying to say the least.

He also started to frantically move, making her even more dizzy and she had to spend too much brainpower on not throwing up that she kind of forgot to cut through more of him. Like his throat.

Instead, he soon grabbed her and pulled her away, her claws tearing a good bit of skin off, and she landed harshly on the ground with the air knocked out of her, which wasn't great after she had just died because of not breathing.

But even that she couldn't fully focus on, as her body desperately tried to keep functioning. The only thought she had at that moment was pain and how disgusting it was to have Prime's skin stuck on her hands.

Somehow, the world turned red then and she was sure she was about to pass out again — though she hoped this time, she could skip dying.

"Catra!", someone screamed, which she barely heard over her own groans of pain.

Still, she tried to get up to get closer to the voice, even if her world was moving in odd circles.

Her attempts didn't get her anywhere, and they didn't seem to matter anyway because she was swooped up in someone's arms, which did nothing for her spinning vision, which then very quickly lead to a headache.

"Are you okay?", the voice asked again, this time a lot closer.

She dared to open her eyes again — when had she closed them? — and tried to find the source of the voice once more. And yeah, she was being carried by the voice. The girl looked strangely like Adora, but in a weird way. Catra couldn't really put her finger on it.

"Catra, please talk to me", the girl begged. This was definitely Adora.

She gave up on trying to understand anything else, though. She was in some serious need of rest. And a first aid kid probably. But, being carried and not having to move her aching body already did take a remarkable load off of her brain. Most of all, it stopped screaming at her, though it still gave her enough grief to slow her down.

Looking around a bit, despite her vision not having gotten much better, she saw Glimmer and Bow in front of them, as well as

clones littering the hallways that they were running through, but none of them moved to stop them, useless without the hivemind telling them what to do.

"We need to find Entrapta and Hordak", she croaked out eventually. Her voice sounded terrible, and she wasn't sure if that was intelligible at all.

Adora's cute little worry frown got worse and she tightened her hold on Catra. "Don't worry, I'll heal you once we're safe", she promised.

"I'm fine", she mumbled. It was a blatant lie that she didn't have the energy to make convincing.

The blonde took a deep breath. "Where are the others?", she asked then, and not towards her.

Catra was so offended, she was tempted to shove the girl away and walk herself, but … even without currently using them, she could feel her legs tremble and everything still hurt and tingled uncomfortably, and she still couldn't see straight. So, she stayed in Adora's arms. Her huge, muscular arms.

She had enough brainpower to shake herself out of that one — this was really not a thing she should be thinking about right now. Or ever.

"Server room", Glimmer answered between puffs of air. "Don't know where it is."

Catra briefly wondered, since there was evidently emergency lights, which she just identified the red around her as, if there was an emergency hivemind or something. And how long it would take for it to activate.

If they would have managed to kill Prime, maybe that wouldn't matter, but she was pretty sure he was still around and that meant they were very short on time. As usual.

"Uh, Catra?", Adora mumbled after a few more turns. Did she need something or just wanted to make sure Catra stayed awake? If it was the latter, the girl really had nothing to worry about — the longer she stayed unmoving, the more present she felt .

Still, she hummed whether to answer or placate her, though she was not particularly eager to use her damaged vocal cords.

"Is there any chance you can hear them or something?" Okay, so she really did need something. That was good. Less insulting.

She shook her head. If she had, she would have told them already, but she had been rather busy trying to stay afloat, so maybe she should try to listen purposefully before giving her final answer. But all she heard was the confused mumblings of clones, their own steps and labored breathing.

And something else. A deep rumble from somewhere within the ship that she couldn't quite place. But it did come closer.

"Something's coming", she hoarsely told them as crashes started to accompany the weird sound.

"What is?", Bow asked, his usual high pitched panic voice present.

All she could do was shake her head again, though. She didn't know.

As it steadily came closer and became louder, the others could hear it too eventually and grew just as nervous as Catra was. They all turned around and ran back where they came from to get away from whatever it was.

But when it finally crashed through the floor behind them, they all relaxed. It was Darla who had violently made its way through Prime's ship to find them, apparently.

Adora stared in a mix of shock and surprise but shook her head to recover quickly and ran inside the ship with the others.

Entrapta awaited them, excitedly waving at them when they entered the cockpit. "Great! It worked!", she laughed. "Is everyone here?"

Glimmer and Bow only nodded as they tried to catch their breath, which was enough of a sign for Entrapta to tell Darla to bring them home. Which also meant continuing their way, rampaging through more of Prime's ship.

It was a bumpy ride to say the least and Catra hissed a few times when Adora lost her balance and knocked into something. The impact, even cushioned by the girl, caused a good deal of pain to resurface.

Definitely her least favorite way to die.

Only when they were outside of Prime's ship, and Darla was able to fly stable and steady again, did Adora lower her to the ground.

She was so incredibly gentle about it, Catra was about to complain, but every thought completely vanished from her brain when Adora suddenly leaned in and carefully touched their foreheads together.

The girl was still holding her tightly, like she could slip away at any moment. Then she started to glow and Catra belatedly realized that Adora had been She-Ra the entire time.

It wasn't the same godly light that usually shone from her, though. Even this entire time, her glow hadn't bothered Catra, which was why she probably hadn't realized it, on top of all the damage that clearly made her dumber. The light was warmer now, more soft, almost soothing.

And as it encompassed her, she felt relief almost immediately. Her body felt lighter, the pain subsided, her vision stabilized, and she could feel her thoughts calm down and become coherent again.

This was what coming back from the dead was supposed to feel like.

When it was over, she almost missed the warmth. And she missed Adora as she pulled away, but she had regained enough of her strength to hold herself back from doing something stupid.

The blonde detransformed then, but didn't stop holding her, the consistent heartbreaking worry still carved into her face.

"Hey Adora", she mumbled and allowed herself a small smile. Her voice sounded and felt normal again, which made her happier than she was willing to admit.

The girl sighed in relief and smiled back so softly it made Catra reconsider doing the stupid thing. "Hey Catra", she replied. "You're an idiot."

"That's my line", she complained weakly. She probably still needed a bit of rest, but right now she wanted to stare at Adora some more.

Unfortunately, Bow chose to clear his throat then, absolutely ruining the moment.

Both of them turned to glare at him, which he blushed at. Also, generally everyone watched with varying degrees of interest and redness in their face. "So, how did you even find us, Entrapta?", the boy asked awkwardly, while pointedly not acknowledging the hostile reaction to his interruption.

"Oh, I used the tracker in Catra's whip", she said excitedly. "I knew it would be useful!"

Catra honestly wanted to be angry at that, but it did save them, so she would tolerate it. For now.

She had bigger things to worry about at the moment, like the fact that she had Adora back and they had a lot to talk about — Perfuma had really used her time those last weeks to instill in her the importance of clearing the air before making any other move. If she even wanted to do that, but at the very least, Catra wanted

her best friend back. And for that, they wouldn't get around talking. For real, this time.

Well, it had worked with Lonnie, how much worse could it go with Adora?

Entrapta came a bit closer to them then, as they slowly separated a bit and Catra tried to sit up. "So, new She-Ra. How does that work? Tell me everything", she said, getting out a recorder and activating it.

Adora stuttered a bit, unsure what to do, while Catra send a small pleading glare to Glimmer, who grinned and winked in response.

"Adora has been through a lot", the princess told the scientist gently, pushing her a bit away from the girl. "We should let her rest first. Catra, why don't you show her where she can sleep?", she suggested so over the top that she was sure even Hordak got the message.

Somehow Adora didn't, though. While the former warlord rolled his eyes at the obvious scheme, Entrapta furrowed her brows but smiled with realization after a few seconds, and Bow send her a thumbs up, Catra wondered why she bothered at all with trying to be sneaky.

At this point she would bet a full blown love confession would fly over the blonde's head.

Still, she sighed and grabbed Adora's hand to drag her down the corridors.

Forget love — that would never happen anyway. But they did need to talk regardless, and the sooner she got that done and over with, the sooner they could be friends again, and that was really all Catra wanted.

Chapter End Notes

Who would have thought to see Hordak's POV?
Fun fact: This chapter has been going through some of the most drastic changes while editing, but Hordak's POV has not changed even a single sentence since I first wrote it last year xD Do with that information what you will ¯_ (ツ)_/¯

Next chapter hopefully will be ready still this week, though real life is getting slightly chaotic just now, so it might not. We'll see.

Until next time! Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 30: The Talk

Chapter Notes

> Despite the terrible heat that is slowly turning my brain to mush, I bring you another chapter! And still on time for Pride Month, which I did not expect to happen, not gonna lie xD
>
> Only minor warnings this time for a tiny little mental breakdown, and some awkwardness
>
> Have fun!! (I really hope you like this <33)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wasn't entirely sure what was going on when Catra very determinedly dragged her off to somewhere to ... sleep? Well, that's what Glimmer has said at least, though everyone's weird reaction made her question that.

Not that she would mind spending some more time with Catra, and she doubted she would be able to sleep anyway, at least not without making sure the girl really was fully healed and healthy.

"Are you okay?", she therefore blurted out when they had ended up in an empty bedroom, her worry evident in her voice.

Catra blinked at her and took a deep breath. "I'm okay", she replied, but knowing the feline, that might be a lie. The suspicion must show on her face because her friend sighed. "I'm really fine, I promise", she assured. "Are *you* okay?"

"Sure", she answered quickly, uselessly lying. She shook her head just a second later and started to let the anxiety she had accumulated for weeks crash into her. "No! You almost died! I was scared out of my mind! And I've left you all and failed everyone. I couldn't be there to help. I should have been there! You never should have had to come here!"

"Yes", the other said slowly, almost carefully so.

Adora let herself slid down the wall she was standing next to and rested her head on her knees. "I couldn't do anything. I was completely powerless, and he showed me Etheria and you, and then I sat in a cell and no one would tell me anything." And she was crying. "I didn't know if any of you were okay, and I couldn't help anyone because I'm useless."

She couldn't say what she was expecting to happen now — back in the Horde, they never had a chance for moments like these, and in the rebellion they had been too busy reconnecting to really be vulnerable with each other. And mental breakdowns were kind of new to her as a whole.

So, it did come a bit as a surprise when Catra stayed quiet and simply sat down next to her. The girl gently coaxed Adora's head away from her knees and started to carefully comb through her disgusting, greasy hair.

It was calming though and under different circumstances she could have imagined it being enough to console her, but after weeks of going almost completely without contact, she didn't manage to stop sobbing.

She has missed the girl so unbelievably much.

"You're not useless. You never have been", Catra said eventually, after Adora had quieted down a little. "But you don't need to be the hero in every scenario."

"But I do!", she protested, with her voice tight from crying.

The other still combed through her hair. "No, you don't", she told her firmly. "I can kinda understand where that comes from. I mean, Shadow Weaver did always tell you that you were responsible for everything, but that doesn't make it true. That was just her way to control you, just like she'd use punishments to control me."

"But-" There was a small tug on her scalp — it wasn't painful or anything, but still a clear message to shut up.

"I know you want to help whenever, that's just how you are", Catra kept going like nothing happened. "But I seriously need you to think of yourself from time to time. Be a bit selfish occasionally. Stop thinking you know what's best for everyone or that we're helpless without you."

The girl shortly left her hair alone, so Adora deemed it safe to say something. "I know you're not helpless", she mumbled carefully.

"Oh?", the other replied while wandering the room, searching for … something. It sounded sarcastic. "Is that why you decided to run off in the middle of the night to kill Shadow Weaver?"

Right… "You're angry." It wasn't a question. She should have guessed that's where this conversation would be headed sooner or later.

Catra sighed and finally came back to her. "Of course I'm angry", she replied and went back to the hair. Adora wasn't going to complain about that. "I'm angry, and I'm worried and I-"

Nothing followed. "You?", she decided to be brave and ask.

The girl's hands vanished from her head again. "I fixed your hair poof", she said and though Adora knew that wasn't how that sentence was originally supposed to end, she couldn't help but excitedly pat her head.

She almost started to cry again when she felt her hair truly being back to it's normal, proper state. "Thanks", she said with relief.

Catra moved to sit in front of her now. Luckily her gentle touches didn't stop as she carefully started to wipe Adora's tears away. "You're not responsible for any of this", she said. "I won't stop you from helping, or being She-Ra, but this is not your responsibility. It's mine."

Now she furrowed her brows. "What?"

"Prime's here because I opened the portal. Hordak sent a message through it, and Entrapta said that even though time turned back for us, doesn't mean it did for the other universe", the girl explained, still wiping her cheeks but not looking at her. "This is all my fault, so it's my responsibility to fix it."

"That's ridiculous", Adora mumbled.

"Why's that?", Catra challenged. She really seemed to believe this.

She took a moment to think about that because it had been more of a feeling than actual logic, but the longer she thought, the more reasons she found. "Okay", she said then and pried the feline's hand away from her face to hold it in hers instead. "You might not be completely innocent, but Hordak built that portal, along with Entrapta. He sent the message. And since you already brought it up, Shadow Weaver messed you up a lot, and I sent you over the edge. So… no, you're wrong, and it is *my* responsibility after all."

Catra snorted and shook her head. "Still no", she said. "Even if I'm willing to let any of that count, you have an even littler part in all of this than me", she pointed out.

Adora sighed. "I can't just sit back and do nothing."

"I'm not asking you to", the girl clarified, sounding just the slightest bit annoyed. It was hard to tell, though. "In fact, I'm happy that you're back, along with She-Ra. All I'm saying is that you shouldn't run off alone, or sacrifice yourself."

She probably should pay more attention, but she ignored most of that in favor of focusing on one thing in particular. "You missed me?", she teased and earned a growl.

"Adora", the other warned.

"Sorry", she mumbled and sighed again. "I just … I don't want to talk about it. It worked out fine so far."

"You got abducted." Catra very clearly had to hold back from yelling here. "And we are talking about this. Now. Because if we don't, we never will and I refuse to deal with you if you can't even remotely understand where I come from." Now she was getting a bit louder.

She still didn't really feel like talking, but she did see the point. And she didn't want Catra to ignore her for the rest of their lives. "I'm She-Ra, I'm not supposed to stand back, I'm not supposed to be saved. I *am* supposed to protect people, that's literally my entire job description", she relented and tried to make the other understand in turn.

The girl did seem a bit relieved about that. "That doesn't mean you have to kill yourself."

"Nobody said that", Adora agreed.

"But you act like it", the other pointed out to her. "You have gone weeks without sleep, explaining to me that it doesn't matter because She-Ra 'doesn't get affected by your issues'. Despite all that, you go to the Horde *alone* to fight an absolutely unnecessary fight. And back there you yelled around about Prime letting us go and you doing what he wants", she listed.

Well, if she put it like that, it really did sound like Adora had a death wish. But she didn't.

"And that's just the last two months. I have more", the girl threatened with a slight glare.

"No", Adora mumbled awkwardly. "I see your point."

Catra let out a big sigh. "Good", she said. "Can you also see how that would bother me? To see my friend run headfirst into danger all the time without taking her own well being into consideration? What would you do if I was like that?"

She opened her mouth and quickly closed it again. That was a good question. "I would probably be very annoyed with you", she admitted slowly.

"Thank you!", the feline yelled, airing out a bit of her frustrations that she held back so far, and that Adora completely understood now.

"So… how do we fix this?", she asked then because while it was great that she finally understood Catra — a bit — it would be better if she could stop making the girl angry altogether.

"You could try to think things through more", her friend suggested. "And you could talk to … someone. Just stop hurting yourself."

She nodded. "I'll try", she promised. "Something else?"

"Yes, actually", Catra responded surprisingly easy. "All that goes for non-She-Ra-related stuff, too. You never do anything for yourself. I mean, you needed to see an entire town destroyed before you decided to leave the Horde. What about how they treated us?"

The girl had clearly thought about this a lot. Which probably shouldn't surprise her. "Is that why you … didn't want to leave?", she asked, really trying to understand. "Because I did it for strangers?"

The feline had to take another deep breath. It was honestly admirable that she stayed relatively calm in the face of Adora's idiocy.

She would admit it, she was a bit slow sometimes, especially on the topic of feelings.

"Yes", the other told her then. "I didn't leave because after everything the Horde had done to us, you- it *felt* like you chose some strangers over me. You never considered leaving before, but suddenly you do?"

Adora blinked, processing. "I never thought it was possible", she told the other honestly. "And we had a plan to conquer the Horde, so … I guess I didn't consider it. But I did know that you weren't happy, and that day, when I saw you, I did want you to come with me. Go somewhere better."

"Felt like you were more interested in the safety of everyone else and I was just an afterthought", the girl grumbled, but at least she seemed a bit less angry.

"Okay, I admit, I may have been a little panicked about the people around", she said. "But … you were never an afterthought. You were always on my mind and I never stopped thinking about you."

For some reason, Catra got a little red and looked away in embarrassment. Did Adora say something wrong?

The girl cleared her throat then. "Point is", she said a bit too quickly to come off as casual. "I… Sometimes, it didn't feel like you really cared. Like Shadow Weaver said, I was just your responsibility."

"No, that's not true", she defended and earned a raised eyebrow. "Maybe a little", she admitted. "I just… I always tried to make Shadow Weaver proud, so she'd be nicer to us. I know now that it was impossible, but … I guess I did end up wanting to control everything so she only had me to blame."

It wasn't necessarily new to her, the sentiment had dictated her entire life — even outside the Horde, she was always quick to take responsibility and the blame when something went wrong — but she had never said it out loud before.

Hearing in out in the open really made her realize how terrible she must have been — not just bossing around Catra, who hated nothing more, but also taking charge with Glimmer and Bow who had their own strengths and great ideas.

Catra simply nodded, encouraging her to keep going if she wanted to. Showing her that she was ready to listen as well.

"And when I became She-Ra, everyone expected so much of me", she said, remembering both times saving Plumeria and how everyone just thought she could solve all of their problems. "I wanted to be the hero they wanted me to be, and … I have kind of neglected everything else. I was really terrible, wasn't I?"

"Not worse than me", Catra replied with a shrug. "In the end, you're still a good person. A bit annoying, but good."

"And yet, you felt like I didn't care", she pointed out.

"Did you feel like I cared?", the girl shot back.

Adora had to laugh then. The other was right, they had both hurt each other, even before they got separated. They had both kept their feelings, worries and frustrations a secret, straining their friendship in the process long before Thaymor ever happened.

"We're really messed up, huh?" Neither of them were perfect, and maybe … she could accept that one day.

"Yeah", Catra easily agreed.

"You know I *do* care, right?", she then asked because she just had to make that clear. "I care about you so much that even after we became enemies, I couldn't stop thinking of you as my friend. And it really hurt to fight you."

"I know. I care about you too", the girl mumbled. "And I'm sorry."

It shocked her just as much as the first time to hear that. She honestly couldn't believe that Catra had said it at all, let alone twice in one day, but she did say it.

What was worse was that before, she could have easily brushed it off as the girl wanting to clear her slate before dying, but now? It felt so sincere, Adora was about to start crying again.

"I'm sorry, too", she said after she had gotten over the surprise. "And I promise that I'll try to be better."

"Good." Catra smiled again and it was the most beautiful thing Adora had ever seen. "I'll hold you to that."

She chuckled a bit. "I'm sure you will. You look out for me, right?" It was a leap, maybe, but she felt brave enough to try.

Her friend looked a bit taken aback for a moment before bringing back the smile. "If you look out for me", she replied and Adora nodded eagerly.

She patted the space next to her and Catra moved to sit beside her. They were still holding hands and Adora dared to rest her head on the girl's shoulder. She noticed the other tense up a bit, but when she tried to move away in response, her friend gently guided her back to her shoulder.

Well, Adora wasn't going to question it, that would only ruin things. "Catch me up?", she asked instead.

For the next hour or two, she listened to Catra recounting everything that happened since Adora had decided to run off one night.

It was hard to listen to her friend describe the absolute panic she had felt, but what was really hard for both of them was the feline admitting to destroying her sword.

She was mad, naturally, but she also kind of understood — that was just after they had talked about the Heart, and Catra had still been angry and the entire situation surely didn't make that better.

The only thing that made her calm down again and choose not to yell at the girl was the fact that, for one, she herself had been in favor of destroying it before Glimmer had stopped her, and she was still She-Ra. She had managed to transform somehow, so she didn't even need the sword anymore. And Catra did look a bit guilty about it, so she let it go.

The girl also explained why Hordak was with them now, that Shadow Weaver rotted away in a lone tent, and that their old squad was safe, which was a relief for Adora.

Then she talked about how she had to reveal their time travel secret, which was … fine. She would have liked to have had a say in that decision, but it was her own fault for having missed it and she had admitted before that it was mostly up to Catra anyway, because she had more to lose from revealing her past. So, it was fine.

Next, they went over leaving Brightmoon, and how the feline started to take every single job because of her guilt which almost lead to another heart to heart, but Catra refused to talk about that, insisting that she was fine and has learned her lesson, though Adora doubted that.

How they ended up back in Brightmoon to get the disk was a story that they could both participate in telling, as she had seen parts of it on Prime's ship — a fact that seemed to clear up to Catra how they had managed to escape.

The next part did end with a bit of yelling again as the girl revealed they went to Beast Island. What avoided a full fight was Catra's insistence that she had protested against it a lot.

Anyway, Beast Island was apparently even more terrifying than the Horde had told them because sounds that dull your resolve and vines that suck the life out of you were definitely scarier than monsters with razor sharp teeth.

At least they all managed to get out alive and mostly unharmed, if they didn't count the mental scars, and they got king Micah back, who was shockingly still alive.

Then the girl explained what their plan had been, coming here, which was to damage Prime's servers so he could be defeated, and safely rescuing Adora once the threat was neutralized.

That had clearly not exactly worked out as they had imagined it, and Adora couldn't help but think back to it all. She couldn't help to still regret having let Prime know about how important Catra was to her, even if he probably would have figured it out eventually anyway, no matter what she would have said and done.

He was eerily good at reading people and he had assumed correctly that Catra could hurt her the most.

Adora carefully snuggled a little closer, just to make sure the other was truly alive next to her, and this wasn't just a dream. She had really missed this, and she was sure that she could not have lived with herself if she had let the other die.

All the more reason to be happy that the feline was okay. That they were okay, and that they had talked and could finally put all their misunderstandings behind them. She was sure their friendship would only be stronger.

Prime had mocked their 'strong emotional connection', but she was glad for it. How else could their friendship have survived all of this hurt? He just didn't know what true friendship was like, he had even mistaken it for love.

She supposed there was a fine line between friendship and love — or at least she thought so, considering she had no experience with the latter, but she remembered Glimmer saying something like that at some point during one sleepover or another, back at the very beginning when she had been confused about most things.

With Catra as her only close friend before, she has had to learn that there were boundaries they had crossed that were rather unusual for friends. Things like what they did right now. She couldn't imagine cuddling up like this with Bow or Glimmer. Hugging yes, occasional hand holding and other light touches, sure. But with Catra she could do a lot more, like basically fusing together in an attempt to cuddle. Like breathing the other in as if she was the air she needed to live. Looking at her like she was the most beautiful person in the world.

Wait.

She carefully looked up at her friend, who talked about Glimmer's discovery that she couldn't do magic in space, but Adora wasn't really listening anymore.

Instead, she reevaluated things.

She had always been thinking and doing stuff like this, and the feline had never said anything about it being weird. Then again, they both grew up in the Horde, neither of them could have known about proper friendship etiquette. But now they did. And they still haven't changed anything about their behavior.

Maybe she was jumping to conclusions and there was a completely different, and less consequential explanation for why she felt so different about Catra.

Oh, who was she kidding? She was in love with her best friend.

How had an insane overlord realized it before her?

There was no way she could have figured it out in the Horde, that much was forgivable, but what was her excuse for all the time since Glimmer and Bow had explained every type of relationship to her?

Well, Bow and Glimmer always acted more like she and Catra had growing up, and they were best friends too, so that was probably why she had never thought it was weird. If they did all the cuddling and sneaking glances and touches, then that was just normal best friend behavior, and so was her own.

Wait.

"Are Glimmer and Bow a thing?", she asked out loud, randomly interrupting Catra who looked incredibly confused.

"I mean, they deny it, but … if you ask me, the signs are there", she answered after a few seconds. "Glimmer was freaking out at

Princess Prom about Bow leaving her and someone else being more important to him, so it's at the very least one side." She stared at her with furrowed brows. "Why are you asking?"

Adora felt her face heat up. "No reason", she lied. It sounded more like a question than anything. Then she noticed she was still very much attached to Catra.

Before the other could answer and interrogate her, she suddenly sat up and knocked her head into the wall behind her.

"Adora?", the girl asked, looking a bit startled.

Honestly, she was too. "I'm fine."

She should have just kept her position, now she would have to explain why she panicked out of nowhere. But she couldn't tell Catra that she was in love with her! That would be weird. And possibly friendship ruining because there was no way that the girl could love an idiot like her who couldn't think things through enough to stay cool.

How do you tell someone you love them, anyway? What's the protocol for confessing to your best friend that you've unknowingly fallen in love with them?

"What's going on?", Catra asked then, interrupted her flood of thoughts.

"Nothing", she tried to say as innocently as possible, but it sounded like she was about to hyperventilate.

The other didn't look impressed. "Sure, you concussed yourself because you just felt like it", she mumbled sarcastically.

She didn't even bother answering that one because it would only make the situation worse. Instead, she carefully touched the back of her head to make sure nothing was bleeding, but she seemed to really be okay.

"If Beast Island didn't get you this freaked out, I doubt Sparkles' odd relationship with Arrow Boy did", Catra pointed out and crossed her arms. "What was that about anyway? Why do you suddenly care if they're together?"

"They're my friends. Of course I care", she defended because it was true, but she also knew the girl wouldn't let that count as her only answer. She sighed. "I just realized that … they act a bit different from how friends are supposed to act. Closer", she said which was probably the worst way to go about this.

The other shrugged. "They've known each other a lot longer than everyone else", she reasoned.

Adora could possibly get out of this now if she was smart about it, but she also had to admit that she was curious.

Her friend had never complained about their dynamic, had initiated a lot of it too, and obviously that didn't have to mean anything, but it could. Was she brave enough to potentially ruin things, though? Because one way or the other, telling her would change everything.

Then again, up until now they had never really told each other anything. And now they knew they cared for each other. That was good and she liked that. And they had been through worse, they should be able to get over unrequited feelings, right?

She took a deep breath — if Catra could be brave enough to actually talk things out and discuss her feelings, then Adora could to it too.

"We're also a lot closer than with our other friends", she said eventually, definitely cowardly testing the waters, but she just couldn't shake the thought that this could ruin them for good. If there was the singlest sign that the other was uncomfortable, then she would simply abort and go back to blissful ignorance.

The girl looked at her skeptically for a while. "Yes, we are", she then agreed like she was waiting for more of an explanation.

Either Catra didn't quite understand where this was going, which she doubted, or she did know and wasn't appalled by it, which would be great. The girl was smart, she could put two and two together. And between her asking about their friends' relationship status and comparing their own to theirs, it wasn't hard.

And her friend looked more expectant than anything else. A bit unsure maybe, slightly nervous. Her tail was moving anxiously, her ears just the littlest bit pinned back. Like *she* expected rejection.

Adora didn't like that. And maybe that was the push she needed as she took a deep breath and decided to unceremoniously blurt it out. "I love you."

Catra sat stunned for a few seconds that felt endless, and she already worried that she had misunderstood something again, but then the girl started to relax and smile. "I… I love you too", she mumbled and turned a bit red. It was cute.

She too relaxed now, though it was a lot less the graceful quiet relief and more like she had just avoided a heart a attack. "Thank goodness", she breathed out and felt her face turn incredibly hot when Catra was mean enough to laugh.

"Just figured it out, huh?", she teased, making Adora heat up more if that was even possible.

"How long have *you* known?", she shot back because if she had known then why couldn't she just release her from this torture earlier?

"I didn't know about you", she clarified. "But I figured it out shortly after you left."

"Oh", she mumbled, a bit of guilt returning. "Why didn't you say something just now?"

She shrugged. "I didn't think you'd like me like that", was the easy answer. "I was just happy if we could manage to be friends

again."

Alright, that made a lot more sense. "So…", she started then, endlessly curious and ready to tease, now that they were in the clear. "How happy are you now?"

The girl groaned and turned more red. "You just have to ruin it", she grumbled and glared, though it didn't really have any heat behind it.

"Well, I might have only realized it five minutes ago, but I'm very happy", she said and leaned back into her previous spot, now that she had nothing to worry about anymore. "You like me."

A sigh. "Yes, I do." It sounded regretful, and Adora only laughed.

She shortly sat back up a little because she couldn't help but be smug about it. "You *love* me."

The other rolled her eyes in great annoyance, but the red in her face was persistent and greatly minimized the effects. "Yeah. I do", she said so sincerely, that Adora's face was heating back up a bit, a fact that made the feline smirk.

"Ass", she grumbled even though it wasn't at all warranted.

Catra snorted. "Idiot", she shot back easily, like nothing had changed between them. And Adora wouldn't want anything to change. At least not too much.

She sighed, but smiled — Catra loved her, how could she not? "You always have to have the last word", she said disapprovingly regardless.

So, when the other girl opened her mouth to reply, probably to deny Adora's assessment while ironically proving her right, she decided to lean forward a bit. She didn't intend to actually do anything, but the simple motion was enough to make the feline forget what she was about to say.

That had been exactly what she had hoped for, and she felt very smug about that.

"Shut up", Catra growled into her grinning face, while she was red as a tomato.

"I didn't say anything", she defended because she really didn't.

The other rolled her eyes. "Good", she said and suddenly, there were lips on hers.

For all her smugness, she froze just the same and needed a second to get her body functioning again to actually kiss back.

For the lack of education in the Horde surrounding this topic, they both knew what a kiss was, though neither of them could ever figure out what was so special about it. She got it now. This was nice.

Which was maybe why she pouted a bit when they separated, but her supply of bravery was empty for today, so she didn't dare ask for more — were there rules around kissing? Was there an acceptable amount? Maybe she should ask Glimmer. Or someone who actually had a relationship.

But for now she leaned back into Catra's shoulder and the girl rested her own head on hers.

"So, since when do you know how to express your feelings anyway?", Adora then asked curiously as the thought occurred to her. Technically, she had wondered a little about that earlier already, noticing that Catra managed to stay calm unusually long, but in light of airing out misunderstandings, it hadn't been important.

"Perfuma is … a very stubborn person", the girl grumbled, which wasn't really much of an explanation, but Adora could fill the gaps.

She knew the princess could be rather passionate about being one's best self. It did surprise her that Catra let her help, though. But it was probably safer not to question that.

And speaking of safety, as they sat on the ground despite there being a bed just three steps away, she felt herself drift off to sleep in the presence of the person she loved, and she allowed it.

For once, she wasn't worried about nightmares, she didn't have to pay attention to clones. She could just rest and be safe. And when she woke up, Catra would still be there and they would still love each other.

Chapter End Notes

I know "singlest" is not a word, but it fits, so it stays xD

Until next chapter where we check in with the world on the ground again! Please stay hydrated <33

Chapter 31: The Next Step - Part 1

Chapter Notes

> Hiiii!
> This one is a bit more chill before we move into the final few chapters <33 I honestly can't believe this is almost over, even though it doesn't really feel like it when I look at how much editing I have left...
> But it's fine!
>
> I hope you enjoy this chapter! Despite being chill, I have placed my one and only f-bomb in here (I thought it fit xD)
> Have fun <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Despite being relatively at ease, and having a rather heavy sleep, it seemed her time on Prime's ship left her a bit unsettled because she got incredibly startled by a knock. She shot up, anxiously awaiting some clone to drag her off and it took a few seconds to take in the dark and dusty room to realize that clones don't knock.

Catra squeezed her hand in assurance before looking over to the door where Glimmer tentatively peaked into the room. "What's up, Sparkles?", she asked.

"Just checking in", the princess said, eying them curiously. Adora wondered why? Because they were on the floor? Or was this the same thing that made them all act so weird earlier. Did they know something? "We're close to landing."

The feline nodded in acknowledgement and got up. She quickly stretched herself, leading to several bones loudly popping back into place, leaving Adora with a horrified expression. "Let's go", the girl said, ignoring her two friends' pained faces.

At least she held out a hand for Adora to help her get up, and she smiled gratefully in return.

Glimmer still looked in between them like she was trying to solve a puzzle. "Have you *talked*?", she asked eventually on their way to the cockpit. "I assume you did because otherwise you would have sat in there in silence for hours."

"Since you already know the answer, I'll ask how it's looking on Etheria instead", Catra shot back with a roll of her eyes.

The other girl glared and scoffed, but didn't say anything more on that topic. "Bow and Entrapta have been trying to contact the camp since we entered the atmosphere, but so far we didn't have any luck."

"That doesn't sound good", the feline pointed out, but Glimmer only shrugged.

"I know, but maybe we're just too far away. They don't have much to work with down there after all", she said, sounding a bit worried too, though.

Catra hummed noncommittally as they entered the cockpit.

Adora decided to run to the window to see what her home looked like — she couldn't believe she actually got to see it again. With the way Prime had had been talking, she had been afraid of the state it would be in, and … it wasn't great, but a far cry from her nightmares.

The place was actually mostly looking normal, apart from the spires everywhere and a bit of destroyed nature wherever they had landed. And she spotted a few towns that weren't standing anymore. But nothing they couldn't rebuild and that was a relief.

"Hey Adora!", Bow called out and waved with a bright smile. "How are you doing?"

"Oh, uh … I'm fine, I think", she said a bit unsure. Truth be told, even if she was relieved and happy, she was also still scared and guilty. This was not over yet, and she didn't know what was going to happen now.

"Well, you've been through a lot", he replied empathetically. "I'd understand if you're a bit shaken."

"Shaken, yeah that's a good word." Not accurate, but good.

He didn't really look like he believed her. "It's good to have you back", he said instead of calling her out, though.

"I'm glad to be back", she affirmed. She really was because now she could actually help and do something. And she could make up for her mistake of just leaving and getting herself imprisoned.

Catra went to stand next to her, silently squeezing her hand and Adora didn't stop herself from leaning into the other, and she was absolutely giddy that she was allowed it.

"So you have talked", Glimmer exclaims smugly, but with an approving look. She most definitely knew something.

"Uh-oh", they heard before she could ask. Entrapta was staring down at a data pad, looking more worried than she had ever seen her. "Small problem."

"What?", she asked anxiously because if the always cheery, even in the face of certain doom, scientist was worried then everyone else should be terrified.

"I've been trying to fix whatever was messing with communications, but our systems are running smoothly", the woman explained. "And I can't even get a weak signal working. Something on their side must be wrong."

"Wrong how?", Bow asked carefully, only his frown giving away that he must be panicked.

Entrapta seemed to think about this for a moment. "Well, optimistically, they might just have technical issues. Realistically… We probably did make Prime very angry."

"Maybe it's for another reason", Glimmer suggested awkwardly, but when everyone looked at her skeptically, she sighed. "Yeah, I know."

"Well, how long until we land?", Adora asked impatiently. "They probably need our help." And now she actually could help. At least she hoped so — she had no idea if she could summon She-Ra again so easily.

"And all of the rebellion's best fighters are here", Hordak grumbled from a corner. "You really didn't think this through."

Catra shot him an angry look that he decidedly ignored by pretending he was cleaning up after Entrapta. "They know how to take care of themselves", she growled in his direction regardless. "We'll get through this."

"We're very close to landing, maybe another twenty minutes or so", Entrapta told them then, effectively interrupting any potential for a fight to break out. There was obviously a lot of hate between the former warlord and his second in command. "What do you say, Darla?"

"Estimated remaining time of flight is … 18 minutes and 24 seconds", the computer told them.

Adora furrowed her brows. "Darla?", she asked quietly and Catra shook her head.

"Don't ask", she grumbled and leaned back against the wall, her arms crossed and tense.

The girl was clearly worried, just like everyone else. Except Hordak, of course, who didn't look like he could care less.

Adora knew that everyone dealt with their nervousness in their own way, but he really didn't appear very interested in any of this. At least the others were, if their behavior meant anything.

Entrapta was more all over the place than usual, still trying receive some signal. She and Adora occasionally ran into each other in their respective pacing.

Glimmer and Bow stayed out of their way and stuck close — seriously, how has she never noticed?

Honestly though, she would like to stay cuddled up with Catra too, but sadly she was too tense for that. The feline was similar. From the outside, she might look rather unbothered, but Adora noticed the quiet tapping of her foot, the sway of her tail and the subtle flex in her fingers.

She was sure she would get scratched at the very least if she dared to go over and try to comfort the other. Not that she was any better. It was only because she could see her run-ins with Entrapta coming that she hadn't punched anyone yet.

And she hated that.

Twenty minutes felt like an eternity, one she would like to spend with Catra, but she couldn't because… It was probably the Horde again that she had to blame.

Eventually, they heard a gasp from Glimmer, who had looked out the window in intervals. So now everyone rushed over to see what she did.

Adora didn't know what the camp had looked like before, but right now she only saw ruins. A few half standing tents, scorched earth and what looked like supplies strewn around.

The sight didn't get better standing directly in front of it.

Entrapta had tried to get the ship landed as quickly as possible, but now they all looked like they would rather take off again. This place wasn't just hastily abandoned, it was completely destroyed. It was a miracle and a relief that there weren't any corpses lying around.

Catra sighed, the first to break out of their collective shock, though she wasn't any less distressed, her ears pinned back in grief. "This probably means that Prime's forces are still functioning", she mumbled as she looked over the damage.

"He probably had a backup", Entrapta supplied instantly. "Every good program has a backup. I didn't see one though, when we were up there, or I would have destroyed that too, but I did-"

"This wouldn't be much of a problem if we had just killed him", the girl interrupted with a growl.

Glimmer let out an unamused laugh. "We all know you tried", she grumbled. "And almost got yourself killed. Wasn't one brush with death enough for you?"

"I was fine!", she defended.

Now Adora had to scoff too. "You were barely responsive", she pointed out.

"Whatever", the girl snapped and straightened up. "We have to live with this now. We should fan out, try to find anything, a clue about where they might have gone — footsteps, broken branches, ideally a message", she said then and ordered them in groups and directions.

Glimmer and Bow, as well as Entrapta and Hordak would work together, and Adora and Catra would each take their own quarter of the area.

It surprisingly didn't take much for them all to do what they were told. It was quite impressive. "You know, seeing you so commanding is … a good look on you." Hot. It was hot, but she didn't want to blurt that out again, so it came out rather awkward.

"Uh-huh, can we focus?", Catra responded unimpressed. Everyone else was already working, after all. "You'll have plenty of time to be insufferable later."

Still hot. "Yes, commander", she said, her voice taking on a slightly suggestive tone that she didn't even know she had but didn't regret as the other blushed just the slightest bit again.

She walked off before the girl had a chance to pay it back. And Catra was right anyway, they should really focus.

The camp was depressing, there were clear signs that people had lived here, but now their fate was uncertain. Adora didn't honestly think that anyone has had any time to leave a deliberate hint, it didn't look like they could have had time for much of anything, but she did look out for any mark that could have been left behind rushing through the woods, like Catra had said. But there was nothing.

There was plenty of destruction, of course, in and surrounding the camp, but it was everywhere. Nothing was distinctive enough to be pinned on either the people's hasty departure or Prime's forces.

The rebellion, or what was left of it, must have some plan of reuniting them, though. So, she looked her quadrant over three times, hoping she had missed something, but there really was nothing.

With a sigh, she was about to turn back — maybe the others had more luck — but then she heard a twig snap.

She got ready to fight instantly, but relaxed when she saw Catra. The girl was usually quieter, but maybe she just didn't want to startle Adora. "It's just you", she breathed out, happy that she didn't have to see a clone again so soon. "Did you miss me already?", she couldn't help but tease regardless.

Catra shrugged, oddly nonchalant. "Didn't want you to disappear again", she said, coming closer and resting a hand on Adora's cheek.

This was a bit odd, but they were new at this, she supposed. "I won't", she replied easily, even if she wasn't entirely sure what to

do with the hand caressing her cheek.

The girl smiled. A sweet, almost shy smile.

No, this wasn't just odd, it was wrong. "What is happening?", she asked, very confused at the other's unusual behavior.

And then the feline laughed. It sounded nothing like Catra.

It was rather instinctive, and maybe an overreaction, but she kicked the other's feet, making her fall backward with a shriek. She did quick work pinning the girl to the ground.

Even if she had been surprised, Catra was a better fighter than this.

"What is going on?", Adora demanded. The girl struggled heavily, which made this entire thing even weirder. She wouldn't put it past Catra to pull some joke on her, even if the timing would be terrible, but then she would have just laughed it off, called her an idiot and moved on. "Who are you?!" Because it surely wasn't her friend. Girlfriend? Whatever.

"Okay, okay, I give up", this … person whined, so unlike the real Catra. "There's no need for violence!"

"Adora!", another Catra called out and soon rounded the rows of tent remains with a bit of worry on her face. "I heard a scream, is everythi- What the…?", she mumbled in shock as she spotted her doppelganger. The two lookalikes stared at each other for a few seconds before the presumably real Catra grabbed the fake away from Adora to ram them into the next best tree. "You better explain what the fuck is happening before I slice you into bits!", she growled.

"That's my girl", Adora sighed, and only noticed after two pairs of heterochromatic eyes stared at her that she had said that out loud. That had been supposed to stay in her head, but at least it wasn't as embarrassing as the hot outfit incident. "What? That

one behaved weird, I'm just glad it's really you", she mumbled in defense, feeling the blush rise to her face regardless.

"Wow, I had a completely wrong read on your dynamic. That's on me", the fake then mumbled, looking in between the two of them with a certain interest. They flinched slightly when Catra turned to glare at them again. "I'm on your side", they then said quickly, lifting their hands in surrender. "Can you please let go of me?"

Catra shared a look with Adora, who shrugged — it was a rather polite request and so far they hadn't actually done anything bad. The girl carefully, and reluctantly, released the fake and stepped away just enough to still be able to restrain them again if necessary.

The fake righted themselves, dusting themselves off, and cleared their throat. "If I may introduce myself…" Suddenly, it was Adora's own face standing opposite to her. She let out a slightly embarrassing yelp and the fake smiled with satisfaction before changing again. "My name is Double Trouble", they said and bowed.

Tall, lean and mostly lizard adjacent, Double Trouble had a shit-eating grin and a theatrical presence.

Adora glanced over to Catra, who she shared a skeptical look with. Then they both turned back to the shapeshifter, waiting for a bit more explanation. Luckily, it seemed they loved to talk.

"I do apologize for the mix-up, but I just couldn't resist. Getting a chance to play you was too good to pass up, kitten", they said, making the girl growl, low and dangerous, but it didn't seem to bother them. "I could have used some more preparation — I admit you are a challenging character — but being discovered this quickly is quite embarrassing."

Catra furrowed her brows. "I've never seen you before, why would you think you'd know me well enough?"

They laughed. "Oh darling, I've been here since day one", they told them like it was the most ridiculous thing to talk about. "Well, maybe not exactly. At first I tried to blend in with big brother, but it turns out that mind controlled people make for a dull audience."

"So you've blended in here?", the feline asked with a scoff, crossing her arms.

"You kept evacuating towns, no place was safe anymore, so I just smuggled myself in", they said with a shrug. "You all were a very interesting crowd to observe. Especially you, kitten. So much guilt eating at you, so little hope keeping you alive. You are a fascinating character."

It was an overall weird way to hear someone described and Adora saw Catra's fur bristle, indicating she was clearly uncomfortable, so she stepped in. "So, why are you still here? Why didn't you flee with the others? You said you're on our side. Prove it."

Double Trouble sighed, long and dramatic. "You really make a great pair. All business and no fun", they complained. "But if you insist, I shall comply. I did flee with the others, but after most people… They just ran wherever and I wanted to keep safe. The only way that's going to happen is for you all to reunite and defeat Prime, so I offered my services and went back here."

"So you know where the others are?", Adora asked hopefully.

It looked like a great chore for them to admit any of their knowledge, but it was possible they just did that for dramatic effect. "Yes, darling, I know."

"How do we know we can trust you?", Catra now asked. "For all we know, you'll lead us into a trap."

They looked appalled at that suggestion. "You're always so paranoid", they grumbled with a roll of their eyes. "But I guess, you won't know", they said with a shrug. "If you cant believe I'm doing this out of the goodness of my heart-"

Catra interrupted with a fake chuckle. "I know your type. You don't do anything out of the goodness of your heart."

They gave her an impressed nod. "Not bad, kitten. This is the second time I've been called out. I really gotta step up my game with you. I love a challenge!"

Adora cleared her throat. What was the deal with them? "Back on topic. Why should we trust you?"

"Like I said, I want to be safe. I value my life very highly and the only way to survive this is by helping you", they said with a sigh.

Catra scoffed. "Not highly enough if you think messing with me or Adora is a good idea", she pointed out.

"It was just a bit of fun. I had assumed even you know what that is."

There was another growl escaping from her, and Adora swore she saw her eye twitch a little. "We're in the middle of an invasion!", she practically yelled, looking about ready to scratch Double Trouble's eyes out. So, Adora quickly pulled her aside a bit. "What?", the girl hissed.

"They are kind of our only chance at finding the others", she said carefully, quickly glancing over to their possible ally who she admittedly also didn't fully trust. But… "And having a shapeshifter on the team might not be the worst."

"I'll gladly help in any way I can." They jumped apart when Double Trouble was suddenly right behind them. "For a price, of course."

Catra, getting her bearings quicker than Adora, smirked. "You said it yourself, right? You value your life." She made a show of extending her claws and they took a step back with their hands raised defensively in front of them.

"No need to get violent", they said. "Nobody said the price had to be money."

"Then what do you want?", Adora asked, both curiously awaiting and dreading the answer.

"A smile", they replied, leaning a bit into Catra's side. "I haven't seen you smile the entire time I've been here. It would really flesh out your character."

The feline growled and grabbed them by the shirt. "Listen here. You smuggled yourself into our camp, and got our protection. If you value your life so much, then you probably want to keep that protection, right?"

They sighed. "You drive a hard bargain, kitten, but fine."

***

Catra was more than skeptical about the shapeshifter who claimed to be their ally. She didn't trust them as far as she could throw them and if she had to be completely honest, she didn't even trust them that much either.

Not only have they admittedly switched sides based on a whim, they also decided the best first impression was to mess with them.

Still, she had to agree with Adora, they were the only chance they had to find their friends. Unless Entrapta had implemented a tracker in someone apart from Hordak, but she doubted that, otherwise the woman would have already excitedly told them so.

When they made it back to the ship, everyone was already anxiously waiting.

"Finally", Glimmer breathed out. "We thought something happened to you, and who's that?"

Double Trouble took a deep breath, no doubt preparing do to something dramatic, so Catra slammed a hand over their mouth.

"That's Double Trouble. They're a shapeshifter and *allegedly* know where the others went", she made the introductions quick and removed her hand again before they got any ideas.

"Rude", they complained after she was done. "And I do know where they went. I am a creature of my word."

"As long as you benefit from it", she growled. They just had this weird infuriating quality that kept making her angry.

They shrugged. "Details, darling."

Adora cleared her throat and not so subtly placed herself between them. "We should probably move this along. I haven't seen any of Prime's forces but I doubt they'll leave us alone for long, and the ship is kind of a dead giveaway."

"Oh, no problem!", Entrapta exclaimed and clapped her hands twice. Slowly, the ship vanished in front of their eyes.

They all stared in wonder and confusion. "Was it always able to do that?", Bow asked then, and the woman cackled.

"The mechanics were highly experimental and incredibly damaged before I fixed it, but theoretically yes", she told them with a bright smile.

Catra took a deep breath and chose not to engage this conversation — she didn't know how long that had been fixed, but it was probably way before they went to Prime and she was not in the mood to yell at the woman for not telling them this before they went up there.

"And you're only telling us now?!" Glimmer had no such hesitations. "We could have used this!"

Entrapta stared cluelessly for a few seconds. "Like I said, the mechanics are highly experimental, and Catra's plan has relied on Prime seeing us coming, to be able to distract him, so I don't see how that could have helped us."

"We could have made a different plan!", the princess screeched.

"Okay", Bow went in between. "It would have been nice to have known before running headfirst into the heart of an evil empire, but we made it out and we're fine, and we really shouldn't be yelling. We don't know if there might be surveillance bots close by."

Glimmer took a deep breath. "Fine, whatever", she grumbled and turned her glare to someone else. "Now you." She pointed to Double Trouble who has watched with amusement. "Do you know something or not?"

They didn't seem at all deterred by the hostility. "I know lots of things, including where your friends are." They paused shortly and grinned. "Have you ever noticed how similar you and Catra are? It's fascinating how many mannerisms you share despite growing up completely differently."

Catra growled again, a common occurrence in their presence it seemed. "Stop psychoanalyzing us and be useful", she said. "Where are they?"

"Of course, kitten. Work first, fun later. If you would follow me", they said with an exaggerated gesture towards the woods.

"Are we sure about this?", Glimmer carefully whispered next to her.

"No", she said honestly. "But as usual nowadays, we don't have any other option."

She was just about to take a step forward when Entrapta suddenly ran in front of her. "What about Darla? We can't leave her behind, and what about my stuff and the logs?", she asked, sounding absolutely panicked.

"We can't take the ship with us right now, not without knowing where we're even going", she told the woman. "It's hidden for now, we can come back for it when we know where we can put it."

"But, the camouflage effect has so many bugs, the First Ones weren't able to fully develop it before Mara crashed the ship, what if it malfunctions?", she pointed out.

Catra had no answer. If it got discovered, they would lose it and everything that was on it, but they really couldn't risk flying it somewhere without even knowing if they could land it there.

"It won't", Hordak jumped in, surprisingly and also incredibly awkwardly. "Your work is always … very technologically sound."

And she had thought that her and Adora must have been painful to watch. It did seem to cheer Entrapta up, though.

"Alright", the woman mumbled, not quite sounding happy, but at least accepting.

"Cute", Double Trouble cooed, clearly fake. "But we really should get going", they said with urgency, looking around a bit worriedly.

"Right, let's go", Catra agreed reluctantly and everyone followed with varying degrees of trust, most of them keeping an eye open for any traps or suspicious behavior.

They kept as quiet as possible, considering the threat that still surrounded them, and the dubious character leading them.

At some point, she felt Adora sneak her hand into hers. It was something they have done multiple times before and that had become natural to do, but now it kind of felt different.

Something had changed since their talk and at the same time, nothing at all. The touches, the teasing, they've done this before, but now there was this added layer. Because they loved each other — that was still hard to wrap her head around.

When she had talked to Adora, that outcome had been the furthest from her mind and now here they were. The hand squeezes, their shared glances and their words all carried a new meaning now.

She would have to get used to that, if only so she could stop embarrassing herself by blushing constantly.

Still, she shot the blonde a small encouraging smile because now that they had found some certainty in their relationship, she wouldn't want to ruin that.

"Naww", Double Trouble turned it back into a frown. "And there was my smile. You two are so cute. I was not sure what to make of your obsession, kitten, but this is pure love if I've ever seen it."

"Obsession?", Adora repeated with confusion, though the little smirk on her face promised to be another source of annoyance.

"Focus on the road", Catra hissed a the shapeshifter.

"I can multitask", they said with a grin and turned to the blonde. "She kept staying up with the horse just for the slightest sign from you. And when the princesses were getting antsy she told them only you had the right to criticize her, and when-"

"How attached are you to your face?", she interrupted.

They took a step back and sighed. "I know we got off on the wrong foot", they told her with that weird grin that made her doubt the sincerity of their words. "But you really shouldn't take it personally, it's just a bit of fun. And judging from earlier, I'd say the obsession must be mutual."

She raised an eyebrow and looked over to Adora, who had gotten a bit red. "You think?", she asked despite knowing the answer — even as enemies the girl had run off to chase after her in every single fight, just like Catra had sought her out every time. Once the first thing falls into place, it really isn't hard to figure out the rest.

Still, Double Trouble nodded, seemingly happy that she was willing to indulge them. "No one's been able to see through my performance this quickly", they said. "I've been watching you for weeks, and I'll admit some details were off, but usually people either don't notice, or they don't think anything of it."

"You probably could have fooled plenty of people, but not me", Adora told them smugly. "We grew up together, I know how she acts."

They hummed. "I see", the replied in an odd tone, like they doubted that was the entirety of it. "My performance would have to be airtight to fool either of you, then."

Catra hadn't been there to see their 'performance' and couldn't actually judge how well the shapeshifter had portrayed her, but it was clear that they thought they had done a pretty good job and that for Adora to know every detail of Catra there had to be more going on that simply growing up together.

Well, they didn't know how growing up with zero privacy could help that along.

"Can you change into anyone?", she asked because she was not discussing any of that with them. And she was curious.

Double Trouble scoffed. "What I do is much more than changing", they told her with disgust for her assessment. "Sure, I can physically replicate anyone, but that doesn't mean a thing if you can't be them emotionally! It's an art, kitten."

"You're a performer", she said, no less disgruntled. "I should have guessed."

"Now you got it", they said excitedly. "I knew we would get along."

"Calm down", she warned. "We've met ten minutes ago with you pretending to be me, and you tried to get payed for something you allegedly offered to do. I don't see much of a future for us."

They rolled their eyes. "Always so pessimistic. I did give you a discount."

She made some sound between a snort and a scoff because she really couldn't believe what she was hearing, but the way they said it was also a bit funny.

"So", Adora said then, looking at them with a questioning gaze. "How much further is it?", she asked carefully like she was unsure if she should interrupt the conversation.

"We're almost there actually", they replied and started to walk a bit in front again, almost looking honestly excited to have reached their destination.

Catra glanced over to the blonde, who had been rather quiet the last few minutes. "You okay?"

She nodded. "Of course, it's nice to see you talk politely to people. Bit weird, but nice."

"I've always talked to people", she replied confused.

"You insulted people and drove them mad", the other corrected. "I rarely saw a civil talk between you and anyone. Especially not someone who has made the worst possible first impression."

Catra couldn't really deny that. "Well, after everything that happened today, I must be in a good mood", she said because she was not admitting that Adora was right.

The girl seemed to know anyway because she snorted and smiled. "Of course. It couldn't possibly be that I was right all along and

the rebellion is a much better place and their manners are rubbing off on you."

She scoffed. "It's definitely not that", she noted. If anything it was Perfuma's insistence to annoy her with all her talk about healing or whatever.

"Sure", the other replied sarcastically.

"Ta-da!", Double Trouble interrupted then, proudly presenting…

"A wall?", Adora asked, tilting her head in confusion. Not that Catra was fairing any better, and the others that quickly caught up with them also looked a bit irritated.

The shapeshifter rolled their eyes and went to pull the moss aside to reveal an opening.

Before any of them could express their understanding or surprise though, some vines bound them all together tightly.

Next, Perfuma and Scorpia jumped out ready to fight, but they quickly dropped their stances when they saw who was in front of them.

"Oh, you're back!", the flower princess squealed excitedly. "I told you they had positive energy", she then said, hugging Double Trouble, who did not look all to comfortable with that, making Catra laugh a little.

"Catra!" Scorpia ran up to her, trying to hug her, but seeing as they were still tightly bound together, she ended up hugging everyone.

She felt probably just as unpleasant as the shapeshifter. "Yeah, uh remember what Perfuma said about boundaries?", she reminded the woman, who did let her go, but only in favor of gushing over the next person.

"Entrapta!", she squealed and hugged their group again. "Oh, I'm so happy you're all back and still alive!" And she was crying.

"Your worries were valid. Statistically, we should all be dead", Entrapta said unbothered by the emotion, and Hordak nodded solemnly.

"What?!", Glimmer screeched. "You said Catra's plan was good, why didn't you mention that before?"

"Statistically, that knowledge would not have stopped you."

"She has a point there", Adora mumbled and Catra had to agree. It would not have stopped her, and knowing the princess, it wouldn't have stopped her either. Bow, maybe.

"Adora!", Perfuma yelled. "Oh, they got you and you are healthy! Or not? Are you hurt?" The woman ran over to check on the girl.

She laughed awkwardly. "I'm okay. A bit tight, though."

"Oh!" Perfuma quickly released them. "I'm so sorry. We were on guarding duty and heard something. I hope I didn't hurt you."

"We're fine", Glimmer said, walking over and hugging the other princess. "We're glad *you're* all okay. We saw the camp."

Their two friends' mood shifted immediately. "They attacked in the morning", Scorpia explained then. "We tried to fight them off and save as many as we could, but … most of the villagers panicked and just ran away. We don't know where they are. The rebellion and a few who managed to stick with us hid out in the woods, and eventually we found this place."

"And then we were all worried about you and what we would do if you came back", Perfuma continued.

"If?", Catra had to question real quick, because she was a bit offended. Despite the statistics not being in their favor, she would have thought these people to have a little more faith in them.

The flower princess at least looked apologetic. "We didn't know how you were doing and if you were okay. But we did want to believe in you, so we sent Double Trouble to get you. Since they can hide out the easiest."

"You're welcome", they said and bowed deeply. A bouquet of flowers immediately landed in their hands, courtesy of Perfuma, and they were naturally ecstatic about that.

"Oh, the queen will want to see you", Scorpia then told them. "She's been worried sick. The king too. Everyone really, but she's *the queen*, you know?"

"Seriously?", Glimmer groaned. "We haven't even been gone a day."

"We do need to talk, though", Catra pointed out. "We have to discuss what we do now. Prime is still out there, probably angrier than ever."

They all nodded at that. The war was far from over. If anything, she had a feeling it had only just begun.

"Fine", Sparkles sighed. "I'll just go fight with my mom real quick, then we can get that done." She walked off, already looking defeated.

Catra rolled her eyes at the dramatics and followed along with everyone behind her. She heard Perfuma making sure that no surveillance bots were around to see them before she let the moss cover the entrance again.

The cave wasn't the biggest, and still very crowded with various tents even though most people had fled elsewhere, but it would give them safety for the moment and she really couldn't ask for more.

Looking around, she saw several people that she recognized, from the rebellion, the Horde, some town or the other, and she swore

she spotted Razz' poofy hair. It was a relief to see them all okay, even if it was only a fraction of their previous camp.

"Catra!" a familiar voice yelled loudly, and shortly after a horse ran into her.

Luckily, she didn't feel like she broke anything, but it certainly wasn't pleasant to have a huge and heavy animal crash into her, even if he was just happy to see her.

"Get off me", she grunted, pushing the other away a little. "What's with you?"

Swift Wind did not let that deter him as he kept nuzzling her face. "I was worried about you! We were attacked and you were still gone and- Adora!" He repeated the procedure with the blonde, who looked to be similarly pained as Catra felt. "You're back!", he cried.

Adora was a lot happier about the lack of personal space, hugging the horse right back. Well, it had been a while since they saw each other. "Yes, and I'm so happy to see you, Swifty", she assured him.

"What is going on?" The queen and king made their way through the crowd that got louder and more excited as they noticed the return of their team.

The queen especially seemed to be shocked to see Adora again, while the king quickly went to gush over them all.

"Are you all alright? Nothing hurt?", he asked repeatedly, going from one to the next, but steering clear of Catra after she sent him a warning glare. She could not be hugged by another person.

Adora also seemed to notice the pair, letting go of Swift Wind and walking over to the frozen queen. "Your majesty, I apologize for leaving without notice and getting caught. And that I put you all in danger", she said and looking guilty to match.

Angella didn't do anything for a long few seconds before she suddenly went to embrace the girl. The woman quickly let go again, but she was clearly relieved to see her again. "I'm just glad that you're back with us in one piece", she said. "You should rest and clean up a bit. I think after the recent events, we could all benefit from that. We can discuss more in the evening."

Catra was about to protest, but the queen send her a short look that looked almost forgiving, so she decided to let it go for now. There was no need to make the woman angry again so soon.

And she was a bit tired. Maybe now that Adora was back, she could finally get some sleep again.

Chapter End Notes

> We're slowly reaching the end, emphasis on slow xD I'm in the middle of editing the finale and have been for the past week. Which is why I'll probably only post once per week for now until I can get that done... Better like this than get it all out faster and then let you wait for weeks...
> The chapter count might also go up by one, but that's still unsure. I'm just putting it out there now, in case that I'll randomly change it one night.
>
> Anyway, next chapter will come out next weekend and until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 32: The Next Step - Part 2

Chapter Notes

> New chapter! After this we'll be officially in the finale (yes, the finale is long, but hopefully good? I'm still only halfway through editing it xD)
>
> Anyway, for this chapter I only have a little warning for a minor panic attack at the beginning (nothing too graphic) And, since the show was very vague in terms of the First Ones, there are a few headcanons in this chapter as Mara's time gets discussed
>
> I hope you have fun <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Somehow, Adora ended up in a tent with Catra.

She understood they were short on space — Glimmer and Bow were put with their families respectively, though the boy snuck in with his friend in the royal tent. And Entrapta and Hordak were given a little tech tent to inhabit together, and everyone else had to room with someone too. And she and Catra had been sleeping in the same room for a while now, but…

Well, things were a bit different now and she was possibly a bit unsure if that would make sharing a bed awkward. She really hoped not.

It didn't seem to, because Catra took a nap the second she hit the mattress without feeling the need to discuss this arrangement. She was probably exhausted after the fight she had put up to clean herself. Seriously, she knew the girl wasn't a fan of water but this much drama around a wet cloth was melodramatic.

But it was clear to her that Catra felt good being clean, and honestly, Adora did too. She finally felt a bit more like herself

again, now that she had been able to wash the time on Prime's ship off. If not for their surroundings, she could almost let herself believe things were normal again.

She knew they weren't, which was why she couldn't find it in her to sleep. She did sit down next to Catra and let her curl around her body, but her time was probably better used trying to reach She-Ra again. No matter what, they would need her and she had no idea how she had transformed last time.

Yes, she had been extremely worried about Catra, and that was surely an effective way to do it, but she didn't really want to have to worry about the feline's life constantly. So, she had to find a better way.

Razz had said it, the magic was inside her and not dependent on a sword.

She took a deep breath. The last time she had tried this she had been on Prime's ship and too scared to actually succeed. Well, she was still scared.

What if her earlier transformation had been a fluke? What if she didn't manage to transform again? What if Prime attacked them and she would be just as useless as when she was his prisoner?

Suddenly there was a hand on hers and she flinched at the contact. "Breathe", Catra told her softly.

Adora wanted to respond that she didn't need to, but had to realize that she was indeed missing the air necessary to produce words.

The other groggily sat up and quietly instructed her to breathe together until she felt a bit more like herself again.

"What was that?", she asked carefully then. She hadn't even noticed that she had stopped breathing.

"Your body's reaction to fear", Catra told her matter-of-factly. "I usually tear things apart, Scorpia becomes overly affectionate, and you … apparently freeze."

She furrowed her brows. "That's never happened before", she said. When she was afraid or unsure she tended to hesitate a little, but never completely stop functioning.

Catra rested her head on her shoulder, nuzzling a bit into her neck — new, but she liked it. "You've been through a lot. I can't imagine the last few weeks having been good for you." She liked that a lot less.

"I guess", she mumbled. "I was actually just thinking about how I managed to turn into She-Ra."

"You can't always know what's gonna get to you", the other told her. "But in your case, I'd assume you're scared to mess up again."

Adora sent the girl a small glare for the accurate guess. "How much time have you spent with Perfuma exactly?", she asked then and Catra laughed.

"I have experience with that stuff, dumbass", she responded, lightly flicking her forehead. "And I have a lot of experience with you. I know how you tick."

"Great, maybe *you* can tell me how to become She-Ra so I don't end up failing everyone again", she said it mostly sarcastically, but she honestly meant it.

Catra seemed to notice the truth in the request, because she only rolled her eyes and didn't start being rude back. "How did you do it before? With the sword?"

"I just … did it. I don't know", she mumbled.

"Helpful", the other commented.

"Well… I had a bit of trouble at the very beginning and Razz taught me that it was my doubt and fear holding me back", she said as she remembered. "But fear helped now, didn't it? I only transformed because I was scared for you."

The girl hummed in contemplation.

And Adora really tried to stay focused on this issue, but … Catra was really pretty and while she had always known that, she saw the other in a new light now.

Or not. This wouldn't be the first time she had stared at the girl in awe over the course of their lives. Looking back, she did not understand how it took her this long to figure it out.

Catra has always been important to her, more than the rest of their squad, or even the Horde. The hurt she had felt after leaving was probably worse than it should have been for friends. And she supposed focusing her entire energy on the feline in every battle also wasn't exactly a normal thing to do.

And back in the Horde, she tended to talk about Catra … a lot, annoying the others greatly. And she had been called out for staring and getting distracted by the girl in training a few times. She had gotten better at ignoring the other over time, but she still has had way too many close calls.

She really should have figured this out a lot sooner.

Then again, everyone she had met had thought that Catra was pretty, so was it that weird for her to not think much of it?

"Adora?" She hummed in response, not quite ready to focus on something else yet. "You're glowing."

That ripped her out of her staring. "What?", she asked, staring down at herself and did indeed catch just the slightest hint of a glow before it vanished.

"Did you mean to do that?", Catra asked skeptically.

"Not really", she mumbled, trying to figure out why it happened.

"What did you do? Whatever it was, it did something", the girl said, which made sense.

Adora felt her face heat up. "Well, I- uh…", she stumbled along. "I just … looked at you." Though she didn't exactly know why that would make her glow.

Catra raised her eyebrows expectantly. "You looked at me plenty of times today, there must be something else", she pointed out. Then something like realization crossed her face. "You looked at me, huh?"

She blinked in confusion. "Yeah? That's what I said?"

The girl leaned a bit closer, which was very close because they already hadn't exactly left a lot of space between them. "Interesting", she mumbled close enough for Adora to feel her breath.

Throwing impulse control out of the window, she leaned in for a kiss — she had wanted to do that again since they were on the ship, and Catra happily leaned into it and even indulged her a bit longer than last time.

But eventually, they had to part again and the girl smirked smugly. "Yeah, you're glowing again", she told her then. "I mean it's great that I can turn you into a literal goddess, but there has to be a better solution to this", she added with a chuckle.

And she was right. "I'll just have to keep practicing."

As much as she didn't want to, she carefully extracted herself from their tangle of limbs and stood up.

With a deep breath, she held out her hand to the empty air. This was a bit weird, not already having a sword to grasp, but it would be fine — at least this way, she couldn't lose it again.

Alright, let's review. From Razz she knew she had to be determined and self-assured. She had plenty to fight for and she knew she was needed. She would do her job, and that conviction already made her feel something.

Good, then she knew that her care and love and even fear for all these people helped, too. She had to protect her friends and her planet, not just because it was her job, but because she deeply cared for them.

There. "For the honor of Grayskull", she said loudly, but a bit unsure.

She was relieved when she felt herself transform, and without the First One's sword, she really felt the power come from within her and not some runestone. Maybe it was because she hadn't done this in a little while, but she could swear that she was stronger than before.

Looking down at herself, she also noticed that she definitely received an upgrade. She finally had some proper pants! And no weird cape, and her hair — as much as she had loved the long silky strands — were up in a long ponytail and out of her face.

"You look hot", Catra blurted out then, and blushed up a storm with wide eyes as she seemed to noticed what she had said.

Adora only laughed. "Where have I heard that before?", she asked, remembering her own reaction to Catra's new outfit. It felt like that was ages ago.

The girl just rolled her eyes, but still a bit red. "You always looked ridiculous as She-Ra. This actually looks like you. Or, what you would look like if you had a sense for fashion."

She scoffed. "I don't dress that bad!"

"Sure", the other responded sarcastically.

"You're mean", she pouted.

"You knew what you were getting into", Catra pointed out and she was definitely correct.

"So did you", she shot back. "My style cannot bother you all that much."

The girl shrugged. "I can like you in spite of that. I can look past much bigger flaws, your clothes really aren't that big a deal."

She scoffed. "Wow, way to make a girl feel special", she grumbled and the other rolled her eyes.

"You know exactly what I mean."

And Adora did know what she meant, they just had an entire talk about that. Still she sighed dramatically and flopped back down on the mattress, almost throwing Catra off due to her bigger mass as She-Ra. She snorted involuntarily. "Oops?"

The other growled. "You're a terrible liar", she pouted. It was kind of cute, but Adora was smarter than to say something like that out loud.

"Sorry, it really wasn't on purpose", she said instead and held out a hand for Catra so they could cuddle some more. "It was funny though", she admitted.

"You're lucky that you're comfortable", the girl grumbled and practically lay herself on top of her. "She-Ra is warm, that's nice", she then purred.

Adora chuckled. "I'm glad you can … warm up to her", she teased and had seen the pained groan from the other coming before she had even finished the sentence.

"You're awful", Catra complained.

"But you like me." That would be her favorite argument going forward, she already knew that.

The girl only sighed, clearly not able to deny that statement but also unwilling to confirm it. Adora didn't mind, she knew it was true regardless.

"Hey!", someone unfortunately called from the outside then. It sounded like Glimmer. "Meeting in five. Try to separate, yeah?" By the sounds of it, the girl ran the second her message was delivered.

A smart decision, considering that Catra was growling after her. Well, Adora wasn't all that happy to have their cuddles interrupted either, but she did understand that they needed to discuss their situation and quickly form a plan.

The feline knew that too, which was why she moved away, a slight frown on her face as she surely thought about the problem at hand already.

Adora stood up again. "Should I … go like this?", she asked, pointing vaguely to herself. And She-Ra.

"Why not? They'll know she's back that way", Catra replied casually.

The girl had a point, so she went outside without detransforming and brought her glowing presence into the war room tent.

Everyone gaped at her, some in shock and some in awe. She hardly focused on that though, too busy taking everyone in — she had missed them all greatly, and she was glad to see they were all mostly unhurt. And she did spot her old squad too.

They looked especially stunned as she carefully weaved her rather big person through the tight crowd. "Uh, hi", she said awkwardly.

Kyle carefully waved at her, while Lonnie nodded, possibly approvingly. "You look good. For a princess", the girl mumbled somewhat bitterly.

"Thanks", she replied, even though she wasn't sure if that had been a complement at all. "And I'm sorry", she then said because she really should. "I should have thought of you and taken you with me too, and I'm really sorry I didn't. I was really worried about you."

Lonnie sighed. "Whatever", she grumbled. "I haven't really been that mad anymore since Catra talked to us. I forgive you if you save the world, okay?"

She snorted. "Okay", she agreed easily.

"Adora!" Frosta slammed into her before she even had time to turn around. "You're back!"

"Wow, they actually got you back", Mermista mumbled too, looking honestly astonished.

Spinnerella and Netossa also greeted and waved at her excitedly.

They looked like they were about to come over too, but Angella cleared her throat then. "If everyone is here, I would like to start", she told them, gently and sternly at the same time.

Adora smiled apologetically and moved herself back over to Catra, catching the last bit of an eye roll from the girl. She wondered what that was about, but wouldn't ask right now.

The queen took a breath once everyone had settled down. "First things first. I am glad that Adora is back and that things have worked out, but if any of you disregard my orders that blatantly again, it will have consequences, even if I can only enact them after the war is over."

"Oh, does that mean we're allowed to do something now?", Catra grumbled sarcastically and earned herself a glare.

The king stepped in then. "Of course we will fight", he said with a certain softness of understanding. "But for that, we might need to

be caught up on the situation a little. Why did Prime suddenly attack us?"

"Well, we may have kind of made him a bit angry", Glimmer answered awkwardly. "We stole She-Ra from him. Entrapta managed to put his hivemind out of order, at least temporarily. And Catra scratched his face off."

"That's so cool!", Frosta squealed, but collected herself when the queen and king stared at her. "I mean bad", she corrected. "Badass", she mumbled under her breath, making the pair of rulers sigh.

"Why would you provoke him like that?", Angella asked, specifically directed at Catra.

The girl scoffed. "I was trying to kill him, but I'm afraid I was a little busy not dying after he tried to kill me."

"Why doesn't matter", king Micah spoke up again, shooting his fine a soft look — he seemed to be mediating between the two. "The question is what do we do now. How do we deal with this? He clearly doesn't care about keeping us alive anymore, even though he would still need some of us for the Heart to work."

"The way he barged through the woods… If he keeps behaving like that we might not have a planet left, even if we defeat him", Perfuma added worriedly.

What followed was silence. No one seemed to know what to do now. But Adora might have a little idea. "I think he's still after the Heart. He only kept from attacking because he tried to convince me to help him. No that he lost She-Ra, I'd guess he'll try to brute force his way in." She thought for a second, for any other information he might have given her. "He said something about the First Ones having inferior technology. I think he might be able to use the Heart even without She-Ra or the princesses."

"This is bad", Entrapta said then. "We definitely have to safeguard the Heart somehow."

Hordak awkwardly cleared his throat. "Destroying it might be your best option."

A short silence followed. "That's a possibility?", Castaspella asked suspiciously.

"Yes!", the scientist happily replied for him. "No operating machine can work without an emergency protocol or a failsafe, something to completely shut it down in case of malfunction", she explained. "We just need to find it."

"And then what?", Angella asked, seemingly intrigued by the idea.

"Well, since the Heart has stored thousand years of magic, shutting it down would release all the magic inside it, making the princesses and sorcerers stronger", Entrapta explained. "Theoretically."

"That's some good news at least", Mermista sighed, though she didn't appear very optimistic. As usual.

"It is", Hordak spoke up again and took a deep breath. "Magic is the one thing Prime doesn't understand and can't really defend against. It's your only chance to beat him."

Catra stiffened beside her. "You couldn't have mentioned that before?", she growled.

"I think your bigger issue is finding it", he shot back with a glare.

Adora really wanted to ask about the girl's hate relationship with everyone. Well, Hordak she kind of understood, at least from Catra's perspective. But still, she felt like she missed some context.

"Actually", Entrapta said awkwardly. "We don't just need to find it. I don't even know what it is or how we would get it to the Heart."

Everyone sighed collectively. Nobody expected this to be easy, but did it have to be this hard?

"Can we somehow find out?", Adora asked carefully.

To her relief, the scientist nodded. "With all the data we took from Beast Island, I'm sure we can figure it out. Could take a while, though."

"We don't have a while", Mermista groaned.

"She's right", Catra agreed. "If Prime is angry enough to attempt wiping us out despite needing some of us and he has the means to take the Heart by force, we might not even have days."

"Maybe we could ask my dads for help", Bow volunteered. "They've been studying the First Ones all their lives. I'm sure they know something."

"Great! Let's do it", Adora enthusiastically exclaimed.

"Then it's decided", the queen spoke up with more eloquence. "We will find out more about this failsafe and then see where'll we go from there."

Most people were seemingly just happy that the meeting was over, which was probably fair. Everyone was anxious and sitting around didn't help, and the place was incredibly crowed too, not exactly comfortable. And the odd mix of former Horde soldiers and rebellion fighters also didn't seem to get along great.

Adora was just as relieved to leave, though for slightly different reasons.

She detransformed now and followed their little group to find Bow's parents, who were unsurprisingly in the tent assigned to them. She was honestly happy to see them again, even if they wouldn't know her.

"Dads?", Bow called out as they walked into the tent.

"Bow!", came the squealing noise of Lance, who crushed the boy in a hug.

Behind him stood George, who looked disgruntled at best. "You're back then", he grumbled.

Bow sighed as the rest just stood there. "Yes, I am. And I'm okay, we all got out safe", he lied — crashing one ship through another didn't really deserve to be called safe, neither was all of them being at least threatened with death. "And we need your help."

Lance seemed excited enough, but he kept glancing at his partner. George just crossed his arms and scowled.

Glimmer stepped forward then. "We need your help to save the universe. Two universes, actually. Please."

"I know you're mad at me", Bow added since it still didn't seem like the two men were convinced. "I lied to you and kept a secret from you and my friends, and I understand that finding out like this also wasn't great. But can you please be mad at me after we made sure that no one has to die?"

"Why didn't you tell us?", George snapped then. Apparently they haven't had this conversation yet. "You lied to us *for years*, and then you barge in and drag us out of our home-"

"Because it was attacked!", Bow interrupted. "And I knew you would hate that I fight, that's why I didn't say anything. I'm sorry, I know that was wrong, but we really *really* have more important things to take care of right now."

"Nothing", the man growled. "Is more important than family."

The boy sighed. "That's why I need your help. It's why I fight. Because I want you to be safe, as well as my friends, and everyone on Etheria."

George still frowned heavily, looking angry enough that even Adora was a bit scared of being yelled at, but Lance stepped forward then, putting a hand on the other's shoulder. "We should help them", he said. "There *is* an invasion going on."

The other man sighed, loosing a bit of tension. "I know", he agreed and looked at them with still a bit of anger but also determination. "What do you need help with?"

"We need to find out where or what the failsafe for the Heart of Etheria is", Adora took over answering since Bow and Glimmer were kind of busy being relieved. The two men glanced at her confusedly — right, she was new to them. "I'm Adora", she quickly introduced herself.

Lance had literal stars in his eyes. "She-Ra?", he asked in awe and she nodded. "Oh, I have so many questions!"

"Maybe later?", she offered. "I'll gladly answer, but maybe we should save the world first?"

"Yes, yes, of course", the man said and focused immediately. "Failsafe, you say? We have done some research on the Heart, but we never got anywhere with that."

George nodded. "The First Ones seemed to have kept that top secret. We were only able to discover fragments."

"Would you be willing to help Entrapta sort a bunch of information?", Catra asked then. "We found some data on Beast Island, some of it on the Heart, but it's a lot and we're short on time."

"Of course!", Lance answered excitedly for both of them, already bouncing on his feet.

And so, their now rather large group slowly and carefully made their way through the woods to where they had left Mara's ship — Darla, Adora reminded herself.

There were a few surveillance bots flying around, but either they managed to evade them entirely by hiding behind the trees, or Bow, Glimmer and Catra took care of them. It seemed the girl had actually received a whip from Entrapta, and it made some quick and clean cuts.

The feline certainly had fun swinging that thing around and even though it was clearly sharper and more dangerous than a normal whip, she seemed to have a pretty good handle on it. Adora wasn't at all worried about being accidentally hit, unlike Glimmer who had nervously teleported away once when it came a bit too close for comfort.

When they reached the old camp, it looked just as abandoned as a few hours before, and Entrapta tentatively clapped twice and cheered when Darla reappeared, only to have Catra hiss at her to be quiet.

They quickly made their way inside and the camouflage was reactivated, so they could safely work for a while.

Adora couldn't do much to help, so she sat down and cuddled with Catra. Glimmer and Bow essentially did the same, though they still kept a bit more distance. And Entrapta and Bow's dads animatedly discussed history and technology, both of which were out of Adora's depth.

Catra seemed to be paying attention, but as much as she furrowed her brows, she couldn't be understanding much of it.

Eventually, there was a collective sigh coming from the corner and when Adora looked over she saw a screen lit up with First Ones writing. "I can translate that", she offered.

Lance hovered over her in a second, startling them enough that she and Catra kind of fell over. "You can?!"

"Uh… yes?", she mumbled from the floor. "I'm a First One, so yeah."

"You're what?!", everyone screamed now. Everyone except Catra, who somehow didn't look very surprised.

"Have I not mentioned that yet?", she asked awkwardly, and remembered that she really hadn't. Since they couldn't mention the portal, she hasn't had a chance to tell anyone, and while

everyone knew about the portal now, she only had been back for a day. "Anyway, I can read that, so let me help", she tried to get them back on track.

The three historians were enthusiastic about having her help, but the conversation didn't stop just because she had a job now.

"Did you know?", Glimmer accused Catra.

"Not exactly", the girl responded. "I knew she came from a portal from somewhere else, but not where. It does make sense though."

"So … does that make her an alien?", Bow asked, clearly trying to process.

"Guys!", she interrupted then. "We're kinda busy here, I need to focus", she hissed. Reading the First Ones writing wasn't actually that hard, but she would still prefer if they had silence to discuss this, or they would sit here for days.

Everyone went quiet at least, but now they were all interested in what was happening and came over as well.

It was a bit crowded, but fine. "Okay, this is about some rebel group in Arxia. It looks like a report. I think they were imprisoned? It's very vague. And it doesn't say what their crime was."

"Oh, that's great!", Lance cheered.

"It is?", Glimmer asked skeptically.

"Yes! The First Ones were only here to mine our magic, so rebels implies that some people were fighting against that. If anyone had a reason to find the failsafe, it would be them", he explained and went to the several screens to search for something.

"And this is from the data we took from Beast Island, meaning they wanted to get rid of this knowledge", Entrapta added. "If

they were this concerned about one rebel group, then probably because they got too close to some secrets." She too went to scroll frantically on her pad.

Glimmer gasped. "Like the failsafe!"

"That's a pretty thin straw we're grasping here, don't you think?", Catra pointed out. "Maybe they just didn't like anyone knowing about someone being against them. Maybe they were arrested for something else."

George shook his head, though. "I doubt that. We have plenty of records at the library that could prove several rebel groups to have existed. Why is only this one on Beast Island?"

Catra seemed to think about that for a second. "Fair", she admitted.

Adora went back to work again, trying to read as fast as she could while three people kept quickly changing the documents they found. "Wait!", she yelled out eventually, ripping Lance's arm away from the screen before he could change it again. "This says something about Mara", she explained while she skimmed the text.

"What does it say?", Bow asked, trying to push himself into the already tight space.

"The rebels. They called themselves the Friends of Mara. She… I think she was leading this group", she told them. "They were the ones caught at Arxia, but empty handed."

"Does it say that specifically?", Catra asked, the only one sensible enough to not squeeze herself in here.

"Yeah", she answered. "Why?"

"Well, it implies that the First Ones thought they should have something", she pointed out.

Glimmer took a step back. "Let's think about this. Assuming the something is the failsafe, then … doesn't that mean they had the failsafe? If the First Ones assumed they should have it, then there must be reason for that, right?"

"True", George mumbled, mulling it over. "They might have gotten caught before they could use it."

"Leading to Mara sealing the Heart's power on her own", Adora finished the thought. "It does make sense."

"In theory", Entrapta chimed in. "Catra is right, the something could be the failsafe, or anything else. We don't know if other important things have existed."

Lance sighed. "Sadly, there seems to be no direct mention of the failsafe. Plenty about the functions of the Heart, and some about the possibility for a shut down, but nothing about how to do that."

"Well, whatever the rebels had, the First Ones didn't find it", Adora told them then. She had read a bit further and she wasn't sure if that helped them, but she felt the need to bring it up anyway. "Whatever it was, the rebels felt it important enough to hide it."

"Okay, so…" Catra pinched the bridge of her nose. "We still have no idea what or where the failsafe is, just some mention of Arxia. And we don't even know if they hid it there, just that they got caught there", she summarized.

"I'm afraid that's all we can do with the information we have", Lance said apologetically.

"I still think this is it", George said then. "Why only put information about this rebel group to Beast Island? Why keep everything so vague? They were trying to hide something and with as little as they talked about a failsafe at all, it is plausible it's that."

Bow nodded seriously. "We should definitely check out this place", he agreed. "But uh … where is Arxia? I've never heart of it."

"Darla?", Entrapta prompted the computer.

"Synchronizing geography. Arxia was an outpost located in … today's Mystacor", the ship told them.

"That's perfect!", Glimmer cheered. "We have my aunt and dad here. Maybe they know something."

Catra scoffed. "Don't you think they would have already said something if they did?"

The princess seemed to think about that for a second. "Still, they know the place really well, they could at least give us some pointers. Maybe." She sighed. "Or not, but we should definitely run this past them before going on a mission."

"You should also think about who delivers it", Entrapta said so nonchalantly, it almost didn't register to Adora as a real problem.

"Wait what? Why?", she asked after a second of processing.

The woman blinked at her like it should be obvious. "The Heart was volatile to begin with, now it holds a thousand years worth of instable magic. I think it's safe to assume that whoever deploys the failsafe will have to withstand all of that. And die."

"Are you sure?", she breathed out, feeling worry overtake her. "I mean … we know using the Heart will have disastrous results, Mara said so too. Maybe it's different when we just release it", she tried to stay positive. Why did someone have to die?

"With the entire magical energy of the last thousand years bursting out at once? Unlikely", Entrapta told her very unhelpfully.

Adora wrecked her brain for a solution that might not involve her friends to become a sacrifice for the greater good. "What about She-Ra? She was always supposed to withstand it, right?"

The woman hummed and seemingly ran some calculations on her pad. "Honestly? Who knows?", she said after a moment. "A normal person is definitely very dead, but you? I wanna say fifty fifty. Maybe."

Yeah, that didn't sound great either.

"Adora", Catra warned despite the fact that she hadn't even said anything yet. But the feline knew her too well.

She didn't want to do it, didn't want to potentially die, didn't want to leave Catra behind. But they both knew she would risk it if there was no other option.

"We'll find a solution", she sighed. "I promise." She didn't know why she hoped that would calm the other.

It didn't. In fact, the girl didn't talk to her the entire way back. And in their tent she curled in on herself, her back to Adora.

She stared at it the entire night, hoping the feline would turn around, but eventually the girl fell asleep and any chance they had to discuss this was gone.

After everything they had talked about, she did understand why Catra was angry, but Adora hadn't even agreed to anything yet. And she did want to find a solution, there had to be another option than killing herself.

For possibly the first time in her life she had something to live for that wasn't just a self assigned purpose to protect everyone around her. She realized that she wanted to live.

She had to find a solution, and she would. And they would talk about this because Catra was smart, maybe she had an idea. If anyone could safe her, it would be her best friend.

Chapter End Notes

Next time, we're going to Mystacor! Finally! Though, it sadly isn't for a vacation like Bow has wanted all the way back in ... one of the earlier chapters xD

Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 33: Mystacor - Part 1

Chapter Notes

> Hiii! So, after all this time I think the ao3 curse has finally found time for me xD Nothing major, don't worry! Nobody died, no houses burned down, no one had to be rushed into the hospital! I just hurt myself repeatedly this week xD
> I might get a teeny tiny scar on my hand and I also probably won't be able to walk properly for a few days, but I'll be fine, I'm just dramatic and clearly too dumb to live xD
>
> Anyway, I still come here with another chapter for you to (hopefully) enjoy! It's not my favorite, but I still think it turned out rather decent, so let's quickly get trigger warnings out of the way and get to it!
>
> Warnings for mention of suicidal thoughts (very very minor) and some anxiety.
> Also, I hope youre ready for some Shadow Weaver slander <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora restlessly drifted in and out of sleep throughout the night. She didn't quite know why — yes, she was nervous about their situation, but she suspected it might have more to do with their not so recent reconciliation that she didn't want to mess up.

At some point she gave up trying to find peace and instead impatiently waited for the other to wake up.

Glimmer had run around last night and demanded to have another meeting as early as possible which Angella had taken literally. Which left Adora with a little problem, namely that Catra was not a morning person.

They had to talk before the meeting, but it was questionable if the girl would wake up early enough to still have time for it. Or Adora

risked waking her, which she would rather not, knowing how cranky the other could be.

So, when the soft purr stopped and Catra stirred just around daymoonrise, she perked up. "Catra?", she called out and got a groan in return. "We need to talk." She didn't let herself get deterred.

Another grumble followed, that sounded vaguely like a curse word — it was hard to understand the other when she was curled around herself with her face stuffed into her knees.

"Please?" Adora let her hand brush softly across Catra's arm. "I know it's early, but I'm sure the meeting starts soon and-"

Suddenly Catra sat up. It was so abrupt, she almost hit Adora. "What do you mean soon? Why didn't you wake me?"

"Because experience tells me, you scratch", she answered calmly. "And you're already mad at me, I didn't want to make it worse."

The girl sighed and rubbed her eyes — though if out of frustration or sleepiness she couldn't say. "I'm not mad at you. I'm worried you'll do something stupid", she then said slowly, obviously having to hold it together so she won't yell.

"I have the best chance surviving it, apparently", Adora reminded. "I don't want to do it", she then admitted, which at least made Catra look at her. "If I don't have to, I won't."

Catra searched her face, skepticism in her eyes. "If anyone volunteers, you won't jump in?", she then asked carefully.

She nodded. "I doubt anyone will volunteer, though", she had to point out. "I actually hoped you might have an idea on how we could avoid death for anyone."

"Adora", the other sighed. "There's no way we can avoid it. You heard Entrapta, whoever deploys the Failsafe will have to withstand the Heart", she reminded gently.

"So… what do we do?", she asked, a bit sad that things looked so bleak for them.

Catra seemed to think about the problem while they got ready for the day. At least she made that cute face with the furrowed brows and slightly pursed lips while her tail swayed with focus.

Eventually, the girl looked at her again, and seemed to want to stare into her soul "If anyone else volunteers, if we find anyone else who could do it, will you stand back?", she then asked as if Adora hadn't made that clear yet.

But the feline's mismatched eyes were serious and left no room for anything but a clear answer. "I promise", Adora said and it was easy, though it shouldn't be. She was She-Ra, she should do it, but staring at Catra, there was no way she could let the girl down.

"Good." That was all the other said.

Adora was admittedly a bit confused. "Do you have a plan?", she asked then because something about this felt a bit odd. Like the girl already had someone in mind, and it made her very nervous.

Catra sighed and seemed to think about it. "I need you to trust me on this", she then said, not making this situation any less worrying.

"Okay." Still, if the other knew how to get a more preferable outcome, she could be supportive.

They made their way to the meeting with some of the tension remaining, but otherwise fine. At least they were talking again.

And at least they were awake, which could not be said about some of the others. Frosta had dozed off on the table and even Sea Hawk almost fell off the chair when he couldn't keep himself awake anymore.

The longer they waited for the rest to arrive, the worse that got. Even Glimmer, who had asked for this, had a few close calls.

But once everyone had finally arrived, the princess regained a bit of energy again as she stood up and opened the meeting. "Alright, we have a lead on the failsafe. We haven't found its exact location since the First Ones were apparently very secretive about it, but it or at least a clue might be in Mystacor."

"Mystacor?", Castaspella asked surprised. "I think I wold know that."

"Mystacor has a lot of secrets", Micah chimed in. "There are forgotten catacombs and chambers. It is possible."

"That would be great", the girl breathed out in relief. "And it's why I wanted the meeting to happen so early. I thought we could send someone out to check it out today, considering our limited time … and food", she told them awkwardly. "But we have a few things to figure out first."

"Like what?", Netossa asked with yawn.

"Like … do we plan to use the Heart before destroying it?"

"What?", Adora cried out. "You heard Mara, we cannot under any circumstances use it."

"We were just thinking, that maybe we might wanna teleport out of Despondos first", Glimmer explained.

"The Heart at its current state is completely unusable", Entrapta chimed in then. "The planet isn't balanced, and She-Ra's sword was the most integral part of it. Theoretically we could try to use her new form, but it's more likely for the planet to be ripped in half than anything functioning."

"And Prime probably has more armies in the wider universe. It would put us at an even greater risk when Prime already holds every advantage in this fight", Adora added even though Entrapta's argument was a lot more impactful.

Glimmer sighed. "Fine, so we'll stay here. That brings us to the more important questions of who's taking the Failsafe."

"Who's taking it?", Frosta repeated, bleary eyed and groggy. "What does that mean?"

"We still don't know much about the Failsafe, like what it even looks like, but what we do know is that someone will have to risk their life using it to shut down the Heart", Bow elaborated.

"I vote Shadow Weaver", Catra said immediately, not even with great intensity or hate, just calculated calm.

If that was what Catra had thought about earlier, Adora could honestly get behind it. "I agree."

Angella leveled them both with a slight glare. "We are not murderers. We cannot just decide to send her to her death", she told them sternly.

"Why not? She's already as good as dead anyway", Catra argued. And it was a good point.

"Are we sure the person going has to die?", Micah asked now, going in between the two again.

"Positive!", Entrapta chimed in. "Judging from the data the First Ones have left behind, the magic will flow through whoever delivers the failsafe, ripping them apart. Especially now that there is so much more stored in the Heart after a thousand years!" She ended with a slightly maniacal laugh.

"Okay…", Micah mumbled looking a bit disturbed.

"We don't have a lot of options, unless someone has a death wish?", Catra said and looked around, but everyone stared at the floor. "That's what I thought. Shadow Weaver is the best option — she deserves it and is already dying, so who cares?"

Angella rubbed her temple. "What about She-Ra? The Heart has a connection to her, no?"

"My current estimation says that Adora has a roughly fifty percent chance at survival", Entrapta chimed in quickly, holding up her pad with her calculations that nobody could understand anyway.

Adora was about to interject that she had already promised not to go, but Catra beat her to it. "If you don't want Shadow Weaver, then I'll go."

"No!" Adora shot out of her seat, not being able to stay calm under the circumstances. "No, you are not going!"

"You don't get to make that decision, Adora. Remember what we talked about?"

"Yes, but not you!" That would explain the bad feeling. Of course Catra had a plan B, but nothing could have prepared Adora that it would be the girl herself.

"I'm with Adora", Glimmer then said. "You are not going. Have you completely lost it now? Was almost being killed by Prime not enough for you?"

The girl had the guts to roll her eyes. How could she be so calm? "Oh, please. It wasn't that dramatic."

The princess scoffed. "Evidently not. Do you really want to die?"

"Of course not." At least that was something. It was the entire plan, Adora suspected. Catra knew that Adora couldn't break her promise nor let the girl die, forcing Shadow Weaver back into the role of sacrifice.

Well, she had no problem with the witch receiving some punishment. "We'll take Shadow Weaver", she said and crossed her arms, sitting back down. Catra's tail swayed happily at the announcement.

"Adora", Angella sighed. "If we force Shadow Weaver to die for us, we are not better than the Horde."

"She's our only option", she told the queen and turned to look at Catra, who despite the heavy topic had a certain smugness to her. That girl had known what she was doing when she made Adora promise. There had never been a plan B, just mean and deceiving coercion. "I can't go because I promised to stand back if someone else volunteers", she said through grit teeth, staring at the feline who seemed pretty unbothered by her glare. "I won't let Catra go. Shadow Weaver is our only option."

There was a slow clap from the corner and Adora was about to get She-Ra out when she saw it was only Double Trouble. Who invited them? "Well played, kitten", they praised and walked out of the shadows. "I knew I liked you." They leaned in close to Catra, who hissed, but they were quick enough to get out of scratching range. "I wanna come to Mystacor. This is my favorite drama."

Angella massaged the bridge of her nose. "Let me get this right. Adora is forced to refuse, so we are forced to let Shadow Weaver die."

"It's not much of a loss", Catra told them with a calm smile. "Trust me, the world will be a better place for it. And again, she is already as good as dead."

"I still think this is wrong", the queen told her. "But if we have no other choice, so be it. As for the team to go to Mystacor…"

"Oh, me! I'm coming!", Glimmer called out, raising her hand excitedly.

Her mother glared her down, though. "After disrespecting my orders? Absolutely not. You are to stay here."

"But", the girl tried, but sank down with a pout when Angella send her another glare. Bow patted her comfortingly.

"Catra and Adora will go. Since this was your plan, it will be your responsibility. Double Trouble goes as well, I suppose", she kept going, sounding like she had absolutely no nerves for this. Adora agreed that it was way too early.

"I'm coming too", Castaspella said. "Someone has to know the way around."

"I know a bit about the secret passages", Micah chimed in. "I'll come, too." Angella send him a shocked look, but he responded with a calming smile. "I'll be alright, Angie."

Somehow that was enough to calm the woman down. Adora really wished it was this simple with Catra. They would probably have to have another talk.

For now though, they still had some things to finish up, and she saw Frosta, Scorpia and Perfuma ready, hands raised, wanting to come too, but the queen shook her head. "Five people should be more than enough. We cannot risk being detected, the fewer people the better", she explained softly.

"Six", Entrapta chimed in again and received some confused looks. "You'll need to take the prisoner lady with you. Since we don't know what the Failsafe is, we cannot ignore the possibility that it might need to be bonded to the person delivering it."

"Alright then", Micah said. "We should get going soon. Glimmer is right, we should not waste any time."

That was all Adora needed to recognize them as dismissed, and to grab Catra's hand and drag her back to their tent for even the illusion of privacy — she was all too aware that everyone would be able to listen in, especially since they would have to wait for them now.

"Relax, I never would have actually gone through with it", the girl grumbled the second Adora let her go to pace a little.

Honestly, she could even believe that. "This isn't about what you would or would not have done", she replied. "Why didn't you tell me?"

"I did tell you to trust me", Catra pointed out.

"Are you serious?" She had to hold back from yelling here. "Do you know what it's like to be put on the spot like that? To actually think you would kill yourself?"

The other raised an eyebrow and Adora realized that she did indeed know what that felt like.

"You should have told me", she still said, not willing to back down. She did understand that the entire plan had been less so a plot against her but against the queen, though even knowing that didn't make her feel better about it.

"You're a terrible actress", the girl replied seriously, like she was about to dissect a crime. "I needed you to be vocal about not wanting me to die, to pressure Angella a bit more. If I had told you, she would have known something was up."

Sadly, that did make sense. "That's not the point!", she said still. "Did you spend a single thought on how I would be feeling? Or just how you could best manipulate everyone?" It was mean, and she knew it the second the words have left her mouth.

Catra glared at her. "Of course I knew how you'd be feeling, but unfortunately we have bigger problems right now!"

"Oh that's just great", she grumbled sarcastically. "So you get to monologue at me that I am too heroic or whatever, but you get to do this?"

"At least I never thought about going through with it!"

"I'm still mad at you!", she told the girl.

"That's fine!", she yelled back.

Adora had to admit, she was a bit taken aback by that. "You-what?"

The girl took a breath. "It's fine if you're mad at me. And kinda normal for us, I guess. It's not like it's the first time", she mumbled a lot calmer than just now.

"But … I don't want to be mad at you", she admitted. "I just … I almost lost you several times already. Do you have any idea how scared I was?"

"I can imagine", the other mumbled, at least looking a bit guilty.

Adora sighed. "Can we maybe stop doing this?", she asked then. "I already said that I would be trying to think a bit more about myself, but it would be great if you could do the same. I mean, how can you be so calm talking about your own death? Even if you never planned to actually do it."

Catra looked more than just uncomfortable now. "I just … I don't know", she said. "I don't wanna talk about it."

She realized something then, something she couldn't really put into words, but that made her incredibly sad. Without thinking much, she walked closer to the girl and carefully hugged her.

"I cannot lose you", Adora mumbled then. "Please don't make me think I will."

"I'm sorry", the other whispered against her. And at this point, what else was she supposed to do but forgive her?

"Let's go save the world", she replied, hoping to sound reassuring. The thought was probably macabre to say the least, but somehow Adora was happy about the prospect of the sorceress, that had dealt them both so much pain, dying for the greater good.

Catra smiled and they left the tent to join the others that were awkwardly waiting — they had definitely heard some of that.

But, weirdly enough, nobody seemed to have bothered getting their prisoner yet. "Where's Shadow Weaver?", she asked, ignoring the very uncomfortable atmosphere.

"We didn't really feel like having her around", Micah replied with a disgruntled look on his face. "So, we held off on getting her."

"She's in the tent all the way over there", Castaspella told her, equally displeased, pointing towards a small and dark crevice in the back of the cave. They really tried to push her away as far as they could.

"I'll go get her", she said and stalked off, briefly wondering why the pair of siblings were in such a bad mood at the mention of the sorceress.

But it really wasn't important right now. She had to focus on facing Shadow Weaver right now, especially since their last encounter had been rather violent.

In front of the lone tent, she took a deep breath and then went inside. If it had been darker this far into the corner of the cave, it was pitch black in the tent itself. She barely even saw a rough silhouette.

"Adora", a soft motherly voice called out in surprise. "You're back."

"Yes", she answered curtly, not allowing any of that to get to her. "I need to discuss something with you."

The sorceress hummed, intrigued. "Despite our … falling out, I'll be more than happy to provide guidance."

Adora rolled her eyes at the description of her murder attempt, but she was pretty sure the other couldn't see it. Then again, she had also managed to see it was her and not someone else, so maybe she could. "No, I don't need that", she told her. "You're going on a mission."

"A mission?", the woman repeated with a certain disgust to her voice.

"Yes. We are going to Mystacor to retrieve the failsafe to the Heart of Etheria and you will have the honor to deploy it", she explained vaguely.

Shadow Weaver scoffed. An odd sound for her to make. "I know of the Heart. People talk. Tents aren't thick. I know how volatile it is, how dangerous."

"We have discussed who to send and thought you would be the best option." She might be making this sound more positive than it was, but it wasn't a lie.

"Of course", the woman cooed, almost sounding sarcastic. "I'm sure Catra happily volunteered me." She spat the girl's name with the same hate as usual.

"Catra volunteered herself. *I* offered you up", she defended with a little anger in her voice. And since it got a bit brighter in the room, she assumed the emotion was enough to make her glow again.

At least she could see Shadow Weaver's shocked wide eyes before she schooled her face into something neutral quickly. "You're She-Ra. You could survive this."

"Guess we'll never find out." Adora was honestly impressed with herself at how calm she sounded.

"Then let this wretched creature kill herself if she wants to. There's no need for me to have a part in this", the woman practically hissed.

Adora, still slightly glowing, leaned in closer. "If we didn't still need you, I would finish what I started right now. You realize that this exact attitude is what makes you so perfect for the job, right?"

"Please see reason, child. This is your destiny", Shadow Weaver tried it soft again.

It reminded her of Light Hope. "Maybe." She shrugged. "But you should use whatever is left of your life to do something good. Catra is not the one having to make up for anything."

"I've heard about your time travel, too", the sorceress told her smugly. "I know that that's a lie."

"Is it?", she challenged. "It never happened anymore. And as for me… I'm not really sorry to tell you, but love makes forgiving very easy."

The woman looked like she was about to have an aneurysm. This turned out to be more fun that Adora had expected. "You cannot seriously-" Shadow Weaver was so disgusted, she couldn't even finish that sentence. "She'll only make you weaker. Don't get your hopes up, that thing is incapable of love."

Adora just smiled smugly. "Oh, you don't know everything. She's the reason I'm She-Ra again. I'd say I'm plenty strong. And loved."

"Is it strong to cowardly send me to die?", the sorceress spat.

"I promised Catra not to do it. Nothing...", she added, daring the other so say something. "Nothing is more important than that. Certainly not you."

She waited a few seconds for more useless arguments, but Shadow Weaver only glared at her.

"Glad to have that settled. Can you walk?", she asked and leaned back when there was no response.

To her surprise, the woman got up with a pained groan. "We will see who takes the failsafe", she said ominously and walked past Adora.

Out in the daylight, it was obvious that it strained her a lot, but she held her head high regardless.

They joined the group, Shadow Weaver receiving a glare from everyone except Double Trouble, who didn't have the displeasure of meeting the sorceress yet.

Micah got ready for them to get going, but Adora, having a found a very fun way of torture, walked up to Catra with a grin instead of joining the currently forming circle. The girl raised her brows in confusion.

"I love you", she said and practically heard Shadow Weaver roll her eyes.

Catra, still slightly confused but also slightly blushing, looked between her and the sorceress for a second before also starting to grin. She understood. "I love you too, idiot", she said, going even a step further and pulling Adora down into a kiss.

When they pulled apart, she saw Shadow Weaver stare in absolute shock — the woman had really not believed her.

Everyone else though … looked relieved? Adora would have expected them to be uncomfortable maybe, but that was a bit weird.

She leaned over to Catra. "What is happening?", she whispered.

"Everyone kinda knew before us", the girl grumbled in response.

"And it was painful to watch", Lonnie commented then from a corner where she and the rest of their squad were eating breakfast. "At this point, I'm surprised you figured it out at all."

The other two nodded solemnly.

Adora decidedly did not want to respond to that, so she turned to their group instead. "Well, if everyone's ready, we should go."

Shadow Weaver grumbled something under her breath, but moved to stand in a circle with them, directed by Castaspella. Adora made sure to put as much distance between the woman

and Catra as possible, which made them stand on opposite sides, glaring at each other, which probably also wasn't the best, but they couldn't really switch around anymore.

Castaspella and Micah then performed a teleportation spell. Glimmer had been ready to do that, of course, but Angella was rightfully suspecting her daughter might use it to sneak herself onto the mission and had forbidden it.

Sorcery would work just the same.

It took a bit longer, but eventually magic started to surround them and Catra gripped Adora's hand tightly as the world around them started to blur away.

When things took shape again, they were surrounded by trees and bushes and only when she peaked through the greenery, did she see Mystacor's buildings.

"We did it", Castaspella cheered quietly. "Landed perfectly in the hiding spot."

That was smart, to teleport them to a location where they would be safe for now. And she couldn't see any clones or bots around, so they really could relax for a moment.

She used said moment to check on Catra, who was taking some very deep breaths — it seemed it wasn't just Glimmer, but any type of teleportation that made the girl sick. Adora placed a hopefully comforting hand on her shoulder.

Meanwhile, Micah also went to take a look. "We need to be quiet and careful. There could be clones anywhere. If they see us, it's over. We would be lucky if we could manage to get out again", he reminded them.

"Should we… gag her?", his sister then asked, pointing vaguely towards Shadow Weaver.

"Why would I sabotage this?", the woman asked. "Getting caught by Prime wouldn't help me."

Castaspella looked at her skeptically, no doubt thinking that it would still sabotage their plan to sacrifice the woman, but she didn't say anything.

"If push comes to shove, I know a few spells", Micah assured ominously and then gave them the sign that they should move.

They did so carefully, keeping an eye on possible threats, but also on Shadow Weaver who despite growing weaker by the second seemed determined to prove to them that she could still outrun them even if she was dying. Well, at least she wasn't holding them back.

Every so often, they hid behind trees, rocks, or nooks of the buildings to make sure they were still in the clear, and a few times they had to evade a clone or bot. They seemed to be patrolling the place, which at the very least made them predictable enough to evade, even if they made it harder to gain ground.

Adora was also a bit nervous to see the likeness of Prime again, which she tried her best to hide — they were already slow enough, she didn't need to make it worse — but something told her that Catra saw it anyway since she started placing herself in front of her, cutting her off from view

She would complain if the clones wouldn't freak her out this much.

Eventually, they managed to get inside, which only made things harder for them, though. No matter how huge the building was, the hiding options were very limited since most halls and rooms just consisted of straight walls and not many possibilities to stay out of sight.

They had a few close calls, but somehow always managed to find a spot at the last moment. And then they spent a lot of time

listening to sounds and making sure they were truly in the clear before moving on.

And then Shadow Weaver started to try to give them advice. Luckily they were all so stressed out with the situation that they never let her get father than "You could-" or "If you-" before someone sent her a glare and a non-debatable "No."

But, despite all of that, they managed to make it to the hall that supposedly lead to the secret passage that would hopefully get them to the Failsafe. The problem here was just that Micah only had vague memories of all the secrets he had figured out when he was a kid.

And being out in the open hallway, with no means of hiding and the intense amount of pressure that brought, certainly didn't help him either.

"If I could-" Shadow Weaver started again, and if it wouldn't be for the fact that they tried to be stealthy, Adora thought everyone would have groaned in annoyance. As it was, they only rolled their eyes.

"No", Micah interrupted once again.

This time, the woman didn't give in so easily, though. "I know these halls better than you. I can help."

"I don't trust it", Catra said and she had a point. There was no way the sorceress actually wanted to help her own death along.

"You stay out of this!", Shadow Weaver hissed.

Adora stepped between them. "*You* are the one having no right to talk", she spat right back.

"Uh, hate to interrupt this lovely conversation, but I hear footsteps", Double Trouble said, pointing down the hall.

"We need to go. Regroup", Castaspella mumbled, sounding slightly panicked.

"We just need a bit more time", Catra told her. "Double Trouble, could you handle that?"

"Anything for you, kitten", they said with a grin and transformed into the perfect unsettling image of a clone and walked towards the sound of steps.

They all held their breath for a moment, listening to the vague sounds in the distance, hoping their distraction worked. She looked to Catra for a sign since she could probably hear it the best.

The girl was just as stiff with anticipation though, not giving anything away for what felt like hours until she eventually relaxed. And so did Adora.

She nodded to the king to keep going, and he went to look at the wall some more.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for the possibly weird ending! I've written the entire chapter (apart from the very last scene) as a huge blob of text and I didn't know how to divide it any better...
>
> Next chapter is still taking a week because I'm STILL in the middle of editing the last few chapters. I unfortunately cannot make things easy for myself and keep making it longer and adding stuff... And all the self-made accidents didn't help either (especially with my hand busted for five days straight). So, until next time! Stay hydrated <333

Chapter 34: Mystacor - Part 2

Chapter Notes

> I'm a day late because I am still struggling with the finale (ノ °□°) ノ ⌒ ┻━┻
> I have spent the better part of the week rewriting the same 500 words because I just couldn't find a way to get where I wanted to because I just had to change the ending!
>
> ... Anyway, I'm a bit frustrated, which is why my motivation for this story is a bit down at the moment, but I am going to finish this! (Also, I've figured out the scene, it's fine, I'm fine) I think my point was that somewhere in that time, I decided to only post this chapter once the finale is close to being finished, hence the small delay <333
>
> I don't have much to say otherwise. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I know it was here", Micah affirmed, probably to himself, though he nodded to the wall. And then, he took a step back and started to perform some spell that Adora couldn't say she recognized, and the wall actually opened.

Admittedly, she had not known what to expect here and the heavy wall sliding to the side was certainly not it, though it probably was the most logical thing to happen.

They allowed themselves about three seconds of wonder before they fled into the small passage.

Once they were all through, the wall closed again — she suspected there must be magic at play here. Or they had been just lucky to be fast enough. Either way, it was nice to have a thick barrier between them and the clones now. She could not imagine having to figure out the failsafe with the threat of Prime

breathing down their necks. Hopefully, Double Trouble would be fine in the meantime.

"I could have shown you this long before we even ran into the risk of getting caught", Shadow Weaver told them. She was talking in a normal volume now, not bothering to dampen the full extend of her displeasure.

This time, the groans of annoyance did follow.

Micah grabbed the woman rather harshly then. "Let's hurry this up. But be careful. Who knows what traps were installed here", Micah told them, not even bothering to answer the old sorceress as he dragged her along.

They nodded seriously and followed.

And since the pair of siblings seemed to have Shadow Weaver covered, Adora allowed herself to relax a little.

"You okay?", Catra asked quietly, glancing at the others to make sure they wouldn't hear.

"Of course", she lied. She just had to be okay.

But the other kept looking at her intensely, clearly seeing through her. "It's okay, you know?", she then said. "To freak out."

"Are you freaking out?", she shot back, trying to evade her own issues for a little while longer — there was no evading it forever, she knew that, but she would stretch this out as long as possible.

"I mean… we had to rely on so much luck so far, and we have no clue what Prime will do now or how we can stop him. I suppose I'm a bit freaked out", she replied casually enough that Adora debated whether that had been sarcasm or not. But Catra seemed to be honest.

"Oh", she mumbled because she had honestly expected the other to … at least lie. How was she, as She-Ra, supposed to be

confident when not even Catra was?

The other grabbed her hand then. "Adora, that's … natural, I guess", she told her. "And it doesn't make you a bad person or something."

"I know", she defended. She did know that.

"It also doesn't make you a worse She-Ra", the girl added, because that … was a more difficult aspect.

Adora frowned. "Being freaked out usually doesn't help me *be* She-Ra, though. So, I'd argue that it does make me worse", she hissed, feeling a bit offended for some reason. Catra hasn't actually said anything to insult her. "I'm sorry", she sighed. "I just…"

"I know", the other filled the unsure silence. "Being She-Ra is important to you and you're afraid you'll fail everyone if you can't be her."

"I hate it when you do that", she grumbled in response.

Catra rolled her eyes. "You have everyone's support. With or without godly powers", she told her sternly. "You don't have to carry everything on your own. And if you let us support you, I'm sure She-Ra will be fine."

She knew that, theoretically. It also made sense — her recent discovery that her friends make her stronger supporting the other's claim. She just had a hard time accepting it on a deeper level. If she wasn't responsible for everything, then who even was she?

But Catra must see something in her apart from the, for her, so infuriating trait to throw herself headfirst into solving every problem, so she has to have value beside that.

Maybe she could focus on that for the moment, and once this was all over … she would talk to Perfuma. Clearly whatever the

princess was doing worked.

Before she could tell the other as much though, a flame burst up in front of their group.

They all jumped back in surprise and someone shrieked, probably Castaspella by the sound of it.

"Is everyone okay?", Adora asked, rushing forward because she and Catra have fallen a bit behind during their talk.

She didn't get a verbal answer, but Castaspella nodded as she tried to regain her breathing, and Micah went to investigate the flame blocking their path.

"Just an illusion", he told them then. "I'm sure that's not all they have, though. We have to be careful."

"At least that means we're on the right path", Catra pointed out.

They only hesitantly walked through the fire, still unsure if, or when, they weren't dealing with illusions anymore. And as Micah had said, it was uncertain if there were more traps waiting for them.

So, they were treading carefully, and just as slowly as if they were avoiding clones. But either they were lucky enough to avoid the rest or there just weren't any more. In either case, Adora was just happy to avoid more surprises.

And speaking of surprises, Shadow Weaver was oddly quiet and holding up relatively well. As Adora watched her, she could tell that the woman got definitely more nervous the closer they got to the failsafe — it was obvious in the way she clenched her fists and slowed her steps ever so slightly.

After her ominous agreement earlier, Adora was sure the sorceress would not go down without a fight, however that might look like. Still, the closer they got, the more she watched the woman, looking for any signs of betrayal.

But eventually, they made it to a huge room with some odd contraption in the middle without any more complications.

"Is that the failsafe?", Adora asked slightly confused. "I kinda imagined it … well, smaller."

Micah went over and inspected it. "Was there nothing else your friend found out? Didn't she say something about … uh, data?"

"It seems the First Ones really tried to keep this a secret", Catra supplied. "All we know is that some rebel group found it, but they were caught before they could use it. They hid it somewhere, but…", she trailed off.

Shadow Weaver scoffed. "It might not even be here?", she mocked. "Why am I surprised?"

They collectively decided to ignore the woman.

Adora changed places with Micah, who took over keeping an eye on the woman as she went to check out whatever it was they were looking at.

"This is First Ones writing", she mumbled. It wasn't helpful, nothing more than numbering the parts, probably for better assembly, but what was written here was not as important as the fact that it *was* written there. "This is definitely old enough to be the failsafe. Or something like that."

"That would be good", the king sighed with relief.

Meanwhile, Catra walked over to look at the contraption as well. "No matter how big, if this was it, the First Ones surely would have gotten it out of here", she then pointed out. "But they didn't. You said they never found it. Maybe this thing is just for storage."

"You mean the failsafe is inside that thing?", Castaspella asked skeptically.

The girl shrugged in response. "Just a guess."

"Okay, but how do we get it? If not even the First Ones managed to crack it open, how are we supposed to do that?", the sorceress pointed out.

Adora sighed. "A password." Everything always needed a password. Even Light Hope had one. "Uh… Eternia? For the honor of Grayskull?" Nothing happened. "She-Ra?" Still nothing. "I hate this. This is just like Light Hope!"

There was a hand on her shoulder and a mean chuckle next to her ear. "Calm down", Catra told her. "Of course this isn't going to respond to the First Ones' most generic passwords. What would desperate rebels do?"

The question was for everyone, but no one seemed to have any idea. Adora tried to remember anything about the rebels. But all the information they had was that they had maybe hidden the failsafe here, they were probably arrested for it, and that Mara had been leading this group.

"Mara", she called out, but still nothing happened. It would have been too easy anyway, but she felt confident about this line of thought. The rebels fought with Mara. The First Ones had even said they were friends. And only other allies or friends were supposed reach this. "Friends. Uh, we're friends of Mara!"

By all means, this should not have worked, but suddenly the thing in front of them started to glow brightly and opened up, breaking into three sections. There were more symbols on it now, too.

Adora got closer to read. "Someone needs to go inside and accept the failsafe", she told the others.

"The rebels had time to build this and leave instructions, but couldn't get that thing to the Heart?", Catra asked with a roll of her eyes. "What does that even mean?"

She leaned around another column. "Uh, the failsafe is some sort of code", she read at an awkward angle. "It has to be bonded to someone, I think?"

The feline just shrugged. "I guess we'll find out."

"Yes, as long as it's not your life on the line", Shadow Weaver sneered.

"We discussed this", Adora interrupted before a fight broke out. "You are taking it."

The woman sighed. "She-Ra is a being of pure magic. She's the protector of our planet. Adora, don't you see? You are strong enough. There is no need for a sacrifice", she tried her usual method again, sounding like the loving mother she never was.

Adora was so over this. "You're right. She-Ra is the protector of our planet, now more than ever. Which is why I'm not risking it", she said. "I'm needed more than you are."

Despite having had this conversation before, sort of, Shadow Weaver still looked taken aback. "You cannot force me in there without risking yourself", she hissed back.

"You underestimate me", she replied. "I am merely giving you the option to go voluntarily before I throw you."

She heard Catra snort behind her, making the sorceress glare at the feline intensely before she directed her ire at Adora, evidently very disappointed about what her prized student had become.

It took a few seconds for anything else to happen — maybe Shadow Weaver just hoped that with time her evil stare would take full effect, or maybe she debated which option she preferred. Either way, eventually she walked off towards the failsafe on her own, head held high and anger in her fists.

The rage was evident enough that everyone took a step back from the woman, even though no one was really in the way.

Adora took Catra's hand again as they watched her step inside the contraption. She didn't know why, but despite the fact that she

kind of liked the sorceress to get what she deserved, she also felt … sad? A bit conflicted maybe.

Especially since it looked to be a rather painful process as the magic activated and flowed through the woman's body, and a symbol slowly appeared over her chest.

She didn't exactly feel guilty — she had meant to kill the sorceress before, after all — it was just a little uncomfortable. It wasn't really what She-Ra was supposed to stand for.

Catra looked a bit conflicted too, even if she managed to hide it better. So, maybe it wasn't really a question of heroism, but something else entirely.

Shadow Weaver collapsed on the ground then, the contraption shut down and a magical code glowed in the shape of a heart over the woman's chest.

Okay, now she really started to have second thoughts, but then her hand got squeezed and ripped out of that.

"Don't let her get to you. She's already dead, with or without this", Catra reminded her.

"She's right", Micah chimed in then as he went over to carry the unconscious body. "I'm with you, she deserves this."

"Oh, I agree", Castaspella said too, glaring at the other sorceress.

She shared a look with Catra who looked just as confused. "Do I wanna ask?", she then asked.

The king chuckled a little at the awkwardness. "I've known her when she was still Light Spinner. I have probably as much to blame her for as you."

"Oh, yeah she said something like that once", Adora mumbled. "Something about being a teacher. I should have guessed you know her."

"What did she do?", Catra asked curiously, even taking advantage of the unconsciousness of the sorceress to poke her head, making it bob back and forth a few times.

"She manipulated me into performing dark magic, so she could get more powerful", he said nonchalantly, like it was no big deal. Then again, this man had been on Beast island, so it might really not be for him.

"She almost killed him", Castaspella grumbled with much less carelessness.

"Wait", Catra then seemed to realize something. "If you were on our side about this the whole time, then why didn't you say something earlier?", she asked, a bit of anger coming through. "I wouldn't have needed to scare Adora if you had just done something."

"Yeah", Adora realized. "Why didn't you help us out?"

The siblings looked at each other sheepishly. "You know how Angella is", Castaspella then said.

Catra scoffed. "Yeah, I know. I had to deal with her inaction ever since I joined the rebellion, but especially since she suddenly decided she wanted to make decisions again."

The sorceress sighed. "I know we had our differences in the beginning, and I didn't always agree with you either", she said and Adora could just stand there and listen to a discussion about things she had not been present for. "But, let me tell you this. I've known her longer than you, and I've seen her hopeless state and the life she regained when Micah returned. She just isn't used to having to make quick and sometimes hard and morally dubious decisions, which is exactly why nothing we could have said would have helped you."

"Angie is… She's scared", Micah also chimed in.

"She's frustrating", the feline hissed in response and the king chuckled a little.

"For someone like you, who has grown up in war and knows how to make split second decisions, I can imagine she is. But she means well", he told her softly.

It didn't really seem to make the girl calm down, though. Adora hoped she could be a supportive presence at least and squeezed her hand a little. "I honestly don't care", Catra grumbled, a bit of anger leaving her, but the annoyance remained in her voice. "From my experience, meaning well is often the opposite of doing good." She shared a short look with Adora and she knew what the girl meant.

Both of them have often assumed they knew what was best for the other. She herself liked to do that a lot as it turned out.

"And sometimes, there just is no good option", the feline added. "Someone was always going to have to sacrifice themselves, I was just trying to avoid it being someone who matters."

Micah smiled. "I know, and I don't think you did anything bad", he assured her. "I'm just trying to show you that Angie is not a bad person either."

"I know", Catra reluctantly admitted. "But she is starting to become a nuisance", she couldn't help but grumble anyway, but before anyone could say anything else, she cleared her throat and straightened up a bit. "And it's nice to know that you're on our side anyway", she clearly tried to end that topic.

"Yeah", Adora decided to help. "It really is. I know that no one was really all too thrilled about us choosing a sacrifice, so that means a lot." Despite her focus on Catra during the meeting, she had seen the conflicted glances from most of the other princesses. Not that she could blame them, but some support was still nice.

It seemed to relieve the two. "How could I not support She-Ra and my savior", the king joked and shrugged off some of the

tension of that conversation. "Let's get out of here then, and meet back with … the shapeshifter. I'm sorry, I'm still learning names. There are so many people in the rebellion."

"Double Trouble", Catra supplied with ease, seemingly already over their little dispute just now. "I really hope they're fine and didn't get caught."

They all nodded in agreement. It would be terrible if something happened to them, especially since they had bought them some time.

At first, they were careful, just like on the way in, but they quickly started to hurry up a bit more, eager to get back to the proper safety of their camp. And getting outside was a lot easier too, since they already knew what to look out for. The only problem was the exit itself.

Should they just open it and hope? They didn't have much of a choice, since they couldn't tell what was going on on the other side.

Catra tried to listen for anything, but either the wall was too thick to make out anything or they were in the clear.

So, after a short discussion, Micah opened the wall again without much fanfare.

They then waited, again, for something to happen, but nothing did and Catra also confirmed that everything was quiet. And that meant they should start moving before a patrol did come by.

Bit by bit, with the same caution as before, they walked the same way back that they came from, always on the lookout for threats, or Double Trouble, but no one showed up.

As they got closer to the exit, Adora started to really worry about the shapeshifter.

And then they also ran into a clone as they rounded a corner — how did they not notice him?

She was about to summon her sword, the words already on her tongue, when the clone sighed with an unusual amount of sass.

"About time, kitten", he said and after a second of processing, all of them let out a sigh of relief. Double Trouble turned back into themselves. "Do you know how boring these people are? I was dying here!", they hissed. "Please at least tell me I didn't do this for nothing."

"We've got it", Catra told them and pointed at Shadow Weaver's glowing new accessory.

"Good. The outdoors are currently cleared, they think there's an issue at the back, but I don't know how long that will distract them, so we should get going", they said and took the lead without any further discussion — no one complained, they all just wanted to get out of here.

And their distraction seemed to be reliable because they didn't run into a single patrol and safely made it back to their trees without any problem.

Shadow Weaver was still unresponsive, so they had to get a bit creative about how to make her hold hands with anyone when she couldn't even stand. Turns out performing a teleportation spell sitting and looking like they were more likely to bring someone back from the dead worked just as well.

Back at camp, they all gave themselves a moment of relief — that was part one of their overall plan done.

"So", Catra then said, turning to Double Trouble. "How did you know when to perform a distraction?"

"I didn't", they shrugged. "I told you I was bored."

Adora couldn't believe that Double Trouble's boredom saved them from having to sneak around, wasting more time and possibly getting caught. But she also wasn't going to complain if it worked.

"Well", Castaspella sighed then. "I will inform Angella that we're back. I'm sure she'll want to know."

"I'll put Shadow Weaver somewhere she can't escape", Micah said. "Not that I think she can, but considering she's our failsafe now, better safe than sorry."

That left Adora, Catra and Double Trouble.

And the latter was grinning at them. "I have to ask. Did you really just turn the old lady into a human sacrifice? Is she human? I'm not sure."

"Me neither", Adora had to admit.

"Yes, she will probably die when the Heart rips her apart", Catra answered the other bit.

"Cold", they commented, but sounded rather impressed. "What happened?"

"We don't have time for all of that", the girl grumbled.

They were about to, no doubt, argue with that, but were interrupted by a cloud of glitter landing in their midst.

"Aunt Casta said you are back and you got the failsafe!", Glimmer cheered. "You got to tell me everything!"

Double Trouble pouted, but accepted that their curiosity was no match for the princess and left them alone.

But, neither of them were very eager to deal with Glimmer either, which made it so perfect when Micah came along again. "You're majesty!", she called out with probably too much enthusiasm. "Glimmer is curious about our mission, why don't you fill her in?",

she suggested in no way subtle, judging by the way Glimmer glared at her and Catra rolled her eyes.

The king just looked like a startled deer. "Yes", he then said. "Talking to my daughter, I can do that", he mumbled under his breath before nodding to himself.

Glimmer sighed. "If you want some alone time you can just say that, you know?", she called her out. "It's not like your relationship is much of a secret anymore after your very public announcement earlier."

"Don't you want to spend time with your father?", she shot back, not wanting to answer this.

"I do", the other replied. "I'm just saying there's no need to try and be sneaky." With that, the father daughter pair was off to find a more comfortable place for their conversation, she supposed.

Meanwhile, Adora turned to Catra who already expectantly waited. "I'm pretty sure there'll be another meeting soon. We could use the time and ... hang out a little?" She meant cuddling. She needed a nap after not sleeping the entire night, but she was still a bit awkward around the dos and don'ts of having a girlfriend.

"Sure", the girl responded and shrugged, but slipped her hand into Adora's with too much eagerness to realistically come off as casual.

She was not going to lie, she loved this new development of their relationship. It made her feel a lot less guilty about sacrificing Shadow Weaver. How could she feel bad about it when it meant that she could see Catra this happy, every day for the rest of their lives?

No, absolutely no regrets there.

***

Entrapta stared at the data in front of her. She had no clue how long she had done that, but she knew that Scorpia had brought her food at some point that had since grown cold, so she safely estimated something around four hours.

Rubbing her eyes, she finally left the screen in front of her to grab some of it.

Since she didn't get anywhere, she might as well fill up her energy levels.

The larger size of the buns bothered her a little, but hunger forced it down regardless. Some other things, like the bread, were awkwardly cut down, probably by the woman's pincers — she was sweet like that.

Her virus hadn't failed. It just hadn't been thorough. How could it be when she has had literally no idea what she was working with?

The First Ones technology had been a good test, but Prime's hivemind was more complex than anything the First Ones had ever build.

She was smart, she knew that — it was kind of the only thing she had going for herself — so she had accounted for the possibility of her virus not doing the damage it was supposed to. Preparation was everything, but with everything happening rather fast, she has had to work on it during their flight.

Hordak had been a great help, remembering as much about the hivemind as possible, but it still hadn't been easy to make a spying program this small, and she has worried about it either not working or getting caught, but so far, she seemed to be safe.

Then again, her view of the hivemind was very limited, and in a system so big and complex, something so small was easy to hide.

Its size also posed a problem, though. The plan was to use her program to improve her virus, but she just couldn't understand the hivemind well enough to do that, which was crucial if she wanted to destroy it.

And she would have to.

Entrapta had made the calculations, using the data she had collected since Princess Prom as her base to predict the most likely course of action.

She knew that shutting down the Heart wouldn't help them much against Prime, just boost their powers. That combined with the rebellion's way of doing things, plus Prime's anger, meant that a fight was almost a given.

And even with more magic on their side, they would lose. There are just too many bots, too many clones and with their connection, that the rebellion couldn't replicate, Prime had the advantage.

The most important variable was the hivemind.

Entrapta couldn't fight. She was terrible with people. She had no idea how to make a proper plan. Tech was her only strength and if she couldn't even use that to help … she was completely useless.

As if sensing her thoughts, Emily ran into her. Well, whatever really went through the robot's circuits, it still cheered her up. A smile spread across her face and she patted her friend a few good minutes before she she grabbed her recorder, leaned back and listened to her own theories. Maybe she had something new to add after hours of staring at the same data.

"I have managed to gain access to a part of the hivemind! It is very complex and almost realistically resembles actual neurons. Note, I need to research neuroscience." That was not going to happen. She had no way of accessing anything, which was frustrating enough, even without the pressure. "Anyway! I know why the virus hasn't worked. The technology of the First Ones is

differently complex, reliant on magic, which Prime doesn't employ or even understand, according to Hordak. My virus has temporarily confused the clones, cutting off their connection, but the hivemind is complex enough to have survived. It's not enough to disconnect, I need to fully destroy it, otherwise it might be able to persist."

There was a long silence after that. She was pretty sure that's when she started to stare at the screen. She has turned off the recorder at some point when she noticed she didn't have more to say.

She sighed. "Okay", she said to no one in particular, but talking helped her think. She activated the recorder again, just in case she would have a breakthrough. She moved over to the disk with the virus and hooked it up to a screen next to the hivemind. "No wonder this didn't work", she mumbled as she began trying to sync them up a little. This needs to be a perfect fit, or it wouldn't work. Not with something so three dimensional.

According to Catra, she had build a portal once. Sure it had been extremely unstable and collapsed, taking all of time and space with it, but that wasn't to blame on her skills, but on the planet's interface being damaged. Point was, if she had been able to do that, this shouldn't be too hard.

But … it might still take too long.

She needed more data.

Determined, she grabbed her pad and and a stray antenna, and decided that she would just have to broaden her view of the hivemind. It wouldn't take much effort, considering she already had access to it, she just needed to see a bit more.

A simple peek also shouldn't put her in much danger of being found. It would just capture a moment at best and not mess with anything, but it could reveal more about the hivemind's workings and help her figure it out quicker.

So, she didn't bother waking anyone. Most people didn't like her enough to bother listen to her explaining the matter anyway, and her two friends probably were with their respective loved ones, so she shouldn't interrupt.

And as for Hordak, she wasn't entirely sure if he still counted as a prisoner, and she didn't want to get him in trouble.

And it was overall safer this way. Even if she would be caught, Hordak or Bow could work with the virus just as well, and she couldn't fight anyway, so it wouldn't be a big loss. Not like if she would take Catra, or Scorpia, or Hordak with her and they would get caught.

Yeah, better to stay alone.

There were guards at the entrance, of course, but they didn't seem very interested in her activities — they were supposed to make sure no one got *in*, after all.

Once she was outside, she let her antenna try and pick up a good signal. It took a while since they were a good bit away from any of the spires, but eventually she got something and followed it.

She even tried to be as sneaky as possible, using her hair to walk since it was quieter than her legs — after performing many delicate experiments with it, she just had more experience being careful with it than the rest of her body.

It was also easy to hide in the darkness of the night, and the stark white of the bots was easy to spot and evade on her way to the spire.

Though, as she saw more of them and got closer to her destination, she started to slow down and studied her surroundings a lot more.

Eventually she stopped completely behind a larger bush, so she could see what the place looked like and if she could get some view of the hivemind already — if she has learned one thing from

Catra then that it was often better to do things one step at a time, to really evaluate one's position.

So, she took her time, and … there was a surprising amount of clones here.

Entrapta had only little data on what an appropriate clone-to-occupied-territory ratio was, but this spire had three to four time her estimated amount and it struck her as odd. But maybe she had been overestimating Prime's forces and he really does need that many to fight the princesses. Though, they didn't appear that weak when Hordak had been fighting them.

She dared to go a little closer since she was curious and also hadn't gotten a clear signal yet anyway.

A few bushes nearer to the spire, she saw even more clones, though she also started to be able to see the hivemind clearer.

Just a little bit more and it would be great. Looking around, she spotted a big boulder and decided to sneak over there after making sure the coast was clear.

The spot was perfect! Her view of the hivemind was crystal clear and she could already make out some of the latest orders that were flying around. With so many clones, it made sense that she would get the most transmissions here — must be an important place.

Carefully, she made her her way through the system, trying to figure out where to go without drawing attention to herself. She knew that if she messed up, everyone would be able to see her — that's how hiveminds worked — so it was a painfully slow process.

She wanted to discover it all, but she had to focus on improving her virus, and maybe she should try to figure out what was going on here too.

So, she went through the latest active communication channels and quickly spotted Prime's newest orders, though they didn't

make much sense to her.

Apparently, the clones were guarding something. It did look like they were building something, judging by the metallic contraption in the middle of the area, so maybe it was that? It certainly would explain why so many clones were here at once — some were building and the others were guarding. But the question remained, what?

Entrapta took a second to once again make sure she was safe. She had almost forgotten about it, but it didn't seem like anyone was suspecting her to be spying.

Back to work then.

The information she was looking for cannot be too old, under the assumption that whatever was going on here was a new development, related to their rescue mission. But the hivemind was full of minor orders since the clones couldn't form a single original thought that turned this into a longer process than it needed to be.

But when she did finally find something, she felt herself grow a bit nervous. Prime was still trying to access the Heart, just like Adora had said, but that wasn't the part that scared her.

He had the sword. That's what they were guarding.

Entrapta packed up immediately and snuck away from the spire as quickly as she could without being spotted. Which was to say, very slowly.

The farther she distanced herself from the spire though, the faster she ran. They had so much less time than they had thought.

When she made it back to camp, she was yelled at by the guards that had been too slow to stop and inspect the situation. By the time they had caught up with her, she was already in Catra's tent, yelling the girl's name.

The feline, having a rather light sleep, was awake immediately, jumping up in panic and accidentally punching Adora, who was now also awake.

"What are you doing here?!", Catra hissed, clearly angry, which Entrapta supposed was fair. The girl was usually cranky in the morning, and being woken by yelling never made anyone happy.

"You have to get to the Heart. Now", she explained herself immediately. "Prime has the sword. He can access the Heart at any moment. He's still building something, though I doubt that'll buy us much time."

"Hold on, slow down", Adora grumbled then. "I thought my sword is broken", she pointed out.

"Yes, Catra has broken it, but it seems that he has found it while he destroyed our last camp and judging by the bits and pieces I could gather, he has put it back together", she told her.

"Is that even possible?", Catra mumbled.

"With the right knowledge." Entrapta shrugged. "Adora has said herself, and the hivemind proves, that Prime has more than exceeded the First Ones' technical capabilities."

"Okay", the girl responded, nodding. "He still can't activate the Heart without She-Ra. Or Scorpia for that matter."

"Well", Adora chimed in again. "He did say something about being able to work around the original construction of the Heart. I wouldn't put it past him to manage to work around that as well."

Entrapta pulled up something on her pad and handed it to Catra. "According to the data on Beast Island the magic of the Heart gets channeled through the sword, and someone needs to focus the weapon. The First One's chose She-Ra because she's the only person strong enough, we've discussed that, but … I suspect Prime might be replacing her with a machine. As for Scorpia … hacking a runestone isn't all that hard in theory."

"Not just in theory", Catra said with that certain look that told her that Entrapta had probably done that already in the other time.

She wanted to get excited about that, but they needed to focus. Maybe once this was all over, she could ask the girl for more information. "I don't know how far he is in the process of circumventing the First Ones' systems, but once he does, and he activates the Heart, I will not be able to stop it anymore. Even Prime wouldn't be able to stop it anymore. The Heart will keep powering up unless…"

"We shut it down", Adora finished her sentence. She then glared past Entrapta at the two sorcerers that were still awkwardly standing beside her. "Wake everyone. We got an emergency", she ordered and they were gone.

The two girls also got ready to be somewhat presentable and Entrapta made her way back to her lab for the moment.

Her virus was far from improved, but she didn't have the time to work on it longer. Hopefully, with the few glimpses she had gathered, she could adjust it enough to destroy the hivemind and help her friends.

Chapter End Notes

> So, how many people were wondering what had happened to the sword? Cause the characters sure didn't xD
>
> Now, I'm not making any promises for the finale... Right now, I do feel confident that I can finish it by next week, but I'm really bad at guessing or estimating something, so if it takes a bit longer than that, I'm sorry...
>
> Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 35: The Heart - Part 1

Chapter Notes

Hi! Did I mention I was bad at guessing? Because I am xD

Okay, story time, feel free to skip (warnings at the bottom):
So, for context, the original draft of the final chapter (in my doc it is one, I cut everything up for you <33) was about 14k words and cut into three parts.
When I left you last chapter, I had 2/3 parts done and rewritten (I chose to change some significant details so everything had to be rearranged...), and with only one section to go, also knowing I would be able to recycle about half of the original, I though a week sounded doable.

... So, uh, it wasn't. The last part was supposed to be 6k words top and I have turned it into 11k... I do not know how, but it does explain why it took so long.
Honestly, it probably shouldn't surprise me when I spent an entire week thinking "I'm almost done" while writing about 1.5k words every day. That adds up, but alas, I am bad at math...

And to answer the possible question of why I didn't just upload part one in the meantime: Because again, it is technically all the same chapter and I wanted it to be consistent. Like imagine I would have uploaded one, and then figured "oh, to make the ending work, I need to put something in the beginning", but the beginning was already done and posted. What then?
... Have I mentioned I'm paranoid? Cause ... yeah...

Anyway, I have made everything about twice as long as it should have been, so you have 4 final parts instead of 3 now, yayy!

Now for the warnings:
First of all, I am tired and at this point, I've been working on this chapter (as a whole) well beyond my capabilites, and I feel like I have lost all understanding of the english language, so I once again aplogize for any typos or other stupid stuff.

Then:
warnings for a few sadistic tendencies from Catra, and a bunch of anxiety
Also I hate the word "definitiveness" but sadly it was the best fit (not much a trigger unless you're me, but whatever)

Now, please enjoy <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sorcerers took 'wake everyone' to heart. Even the few remaining refugees groggily hauled themselves to the entrance of the cave, where they had chosen to stay since even just the people who could fight wouldn't fit into their meeting tent.

And while everyone got here, Catra's mind was running through every option they had now.

Shutting down the Heart should obviously be their priority, but once they did, Prime would expect an attack against him. He was smart enough to know that they would be more powerful and safeguard himself further. In the best case scenario he would cut his losses and leave them alone, but somehow she doubted that would happen.

Hordak has spent 30 years trying to conquer Etheria. His creator would probably be similarly stubborn.

That meant they would need to disable the Heart and the hivemind at the same time if they wanted to stand a chance.

Right now, the only way to achieve the latter was to let Entrapta hack into a spire, but she has said herself that it would take longer and was more dangerous than getting into the hivemind

directly. She would need someone to make sure that she had the time necessary to do that.

Which brought her to the next problem. Depending on how much time they had left, which didn't seem to be a lot, their best bet would be to perform an attack to delay Prime's process and distract him from Entrapta's doings.

But Adora, Catra, and potentially Micah were the only people who could successfully not be manipulated by Shadow Weaver, which meant at least one of them would be missing from the battlefield.

Catra didn't think her own absence would be a problem, but She-Ra and an extremely powerful sorcerer would be pretty a big loss.

Of course she had faith in the rebellion, which was something she had never thought she would say, but she did. Most of them had magical powers, namely the princesses and sorcerers. She knew that the old Horde soldiers could hold their own too, if they would agree to fight that is. And everyone else had their own weapons. She wasn't sure what Sea Hawk had, but he wasn't dead yet, so that had to count for something.

Still, to give them the best chances they could get, their most powerful assets should be on the battlefield and not holed down wherever the Heart is — they would need to figure that out too.

She sighed. "Adora?", she prompted and the girl hummed. "I think I should take Shadow Weaver and disable the Heart. You should support the others in battle."

The girl looked at her now, intensely. It cannot be surprising to her that they would need to fight, so that look must be her worry for Catra. "No", she then said, as suspected.

"They need you more than I do", she argued.

"I'm not leaving you alone with her", Adora said sternly. Well … it had been worth a try.

With another sigh, she turned back to the crowd that had steadily formed. At this point, it seemed like everyone was here. Everyone except Entrapta, who no doubt was frantically working on her virus.

"What is the meaning of this?", Angella then asked as she somewhat gracefully made her way through the mass of people.

"Entrapta has informed us that Prime is close to accessing the Heart. So, Catra and I will go and shut it down right now before anything bad can happen", Adora explained.

"And what are we doing here?", Lonnie questioned, though it sounded like an accusation.

"We cannot let Prime get more of an upper hand than he already has", Catra said then. "Shutting down the Heart might give us a power boost but it won't defeat him. More likely, it will warn him and we cannot let him protect himself. So, while we go deal with the Heart, Entrapta will hack into a spire, but for that, everyone else needs to keep the clones busy and away from her."

There were a murmurs going through the crowd, which made sense. It would be a battle they could not win. Not until the hivemind was disabled. Being nervous was a natural reaction.

But some also nodded, ready to defend their planet and finally end this.

"Alright", Glimmer said full of her usual determination. "You two should go. We'll take care of everything else."

"Are you sure?", Catra had to ask. Her experience told her that most of these people shouldn't really be trusted with strategizing. And they would need a good strategy if they wanted to survive against Prime long enough for Entrapta's virus to work. She would feel safer if she could make a plan herself.

Luckily, Micah stepped forward before she had to awkwardly explain that she thought all of them were incompetent. "Don't

worry. We'll make sure Entrapta has time and that no one gets hurt", he told her with an encouraging smile. "You should really get going now. Shutting down the Heart might not be enough to defeat Prime, but it will give us more power and with that hopefully more time."

She knew he was right. "Okay", she relented. "As long as you're in charge", she mumbled though. If she trusted anyone with this, it was him.

Unfortunately, Angella had something to say about that, unsurprisingly. "That is not-"

"My choice to make?", she finished, sounding only slightly mocking, which was impressive for how frustrated she was with this woman. "I think it is. We don't have time for you to may or may not decide if you want to act, we *have* to act now! This entire time, you didn't know what to do and let me make all the tough choices. And you still don't know what to do. So, quoting you, as long as you cannot come up with a better plan, I will not discuss this."

She glared the queen down, hoping she would not want to fight her on this because they seriously were running out of time, but she was honestly a little anxious since the woman clearly had a problem with Catra's earned authority among the rebellion.

In the end though, Angella could only stare in shock. And shame.

Now Catra felt a bit bad, but the woman seriously needed to hear it, and if she didn't get punished for it, even better. "Micah's in charge", she repeated with definitiveness and already wanted to leave, but decided that maybe she could trust one more person here. "And Glimmer too."

"Wait what?", the girl responded in surprise.

"I know you can be good at bossing people around if you want to", she explained easily. Over the last few weeks especially, the princess has shown that she had what it takes to lead and she

was naive if she thought that Catra hadn't noticed her part in keeping the people calm and organized.

The girl still seemed a bit unsure but nodded dutifully anyway, so Catra took it as her sign to go get their sacrifice.

Adora pulled her to the side though, before they could get far. "Small problem", she then said. "Do we know where the Heart actually is?"

Right. She had almost forgotten about that. "Not really", she mumbled. "But if anyone knows, it's the nerds", she added and turned around again to scan the crowd for Bow's dads, the blonde did the same, naturally knowing who Catra had been referring to.

"There", the girl pointed out when she spotted them and they ran over right away.

"Hey, did the Beast Island files say something about how to access the Heart?", she asked without much fanfare, though she doubted that the information had actually been floating around when the First Ones were already so secretive about the failsafe. But they had nothing else.

"The First Ones kept it well guarded, but…", George said slowly, furrowing his brows in thought.

"There was one line", Lance finished the sentence for his partner. "The Heart is being hidden by the facilitator. We don't know who that is, though."

Catra nodded and looked over to Adora as they slowly made their way back out of the crowd. She had no idea if the girl truly knew anything, but she was kind of the only person who could know what that meant.

Adora clearly thought about it, her face scrunching up in that cute way it did whenever she used her brain cells. "I think… Light Hope", she mumbled.

"No", groaned immediately. "Do not tell me we have to go back to the weird nightmare castle."

At least the girl also didn't look very thrilled about it. "Well, she said- I think, that's what she said she was. Maybe. No, I'm sure that's what she said when I first met her, after you-" She cleared her throat awkwardly. "Well, after you let me fall down a cliff."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "You had bring that up?"

Adora shrugged apologetically. "I'm sorry, and I mean, it had to happen or I wouldn't have been able to talk to her, and then we wouldn't have this information right now, so really I should thank you."

"Don't", she grumbled.

"Different problem", Adora then said as she seemed to realize something. "I don't think Light Hope would want us to shut down the Heart. As much as she kept annoying me about balancing the planet, I think she's more likely to be programmed to activate it. And she can control the entire castle. If she doesn't want us to reach the Heart, I doubt we will."

Why can't anything ever be easy? "We'll just have to try", she replied, sounding more confident than she was, because Adora was right. That dumb hologram would probably be working against them, but… "We don't have another choice."

At this point she felt like a broken com message, repeating that sentiment over and over. But that's just the way things were.

Adora knew it too, and nodded. And then they finally made their way into the tent, still tucked away somewhere at the farthest end of this cave.

Shadow Weaver looked as pathetic as ever, slumped in the back, surrounded by a magical prison, her incoming death evident in the way her body trembled ever so slightly. The glow of the failsafe

over her chest was the only thing that gave a sign that she was still alive.

Catra hadn't been all that sure if the sorceress would be recovering from their mission, but she seemed fine now. Or as fine as a still dying woman could possibly be. And that was good because if she had died prematurely, they would have been really screwed.

"It's time, then", the woman said, not asked. Still, she made no move to get up.

Adora took care of that with a sigh, walking over and pulling the other up. "I'm afraid so." There was a tinge of sadness in the girl's voice, almost unnoticeable.

Catra understood, somewhat. Shadow Weaver had raised them — if that could be called raising at all — and it would have been better if she had left them alone, but in the end she had been there all their lives and it would be weird for her to be gone.

Somehow, she felt a bit … less excited than she had expected, too. Don't get her wrong, she sincerely did not have a problem with killing Shadow Weaver, and even if it was cruel, it was still kind of satisfying to force her to save the world. But she supposed losing a constant like that, no matter how hated, would always be a bit sad.

"We need to hurry", she only said instead of acknowledging that, though. The faster they could get this over with, the better. Not just for her emotional state, but because the sorceress was really fragile and probably wouldn't live much longer — she doubted the Failsafe would still work with her dead.

The blonde nodded and carefully dragged the woman outside. At least Shadow Weaver did try to use her legs now.

They walked through the barely organized chaos to reach the cave's entrance, and Catra let her gaze wander over the crowd that would soon go into battle. She really hoped she could trust

Micah and Glimmer to come up with a plan that wouldn't kill them all.

"Hey!", the princess in question called out to them then with Bow in tow. "This is it, huh?", she mumbled awkwardly.

"Guess so", she replied just as unsure. She noticed in the other's expression that she knew just as well that they either win this or die. This may be a goodbye for good.

"We'll be fine", Adora said, surely knowing the same thing but being able to stay more positive. "We got this. I know we can defeat him, I mean … you already almost did."

"Of course", Sparkles agreed with a tight smile. "Just … be careful", she told them and looked like she was about to burst a vein.

She looked mostly at Catra, actually. So, with a sigh, she motioned for the princess to get over with it. Only a second later, the girl had pulled them both into a hug, while Adora had dropped Shadow Weaver, and Bow also didn't take too long to join in.

"Take care of each other", Glimmer said, sounding close to tears now.

"You too", Adora answered, squeezing them all tighter before they took a step back. "And good luck."

"We don't need luck. We're the Best Friend Squad", Bow told them with more confidence than he should have in this situation.

At least they all managed to chuckle a bit. "Still", Catra then said. "Good luck."

A bit more solemnly, but the other two nodded with small smiles. "Go", Glimmer then said. "You got this."

"I hope so", Adora replied and lifted Shadow Weaver back up from the ground.

They barely looked back after that as they walked into the woods. Mostly for their own sake because one more look at their friends would just make them hesitate more, but also because of Prime — he was already working on activating the Heart and they didn't know how much time they actually had.

Sadly, the dying woman in their midst was not able to keep up with their preferred speed.

"We need to be faster", Catra complained at some point because, now being away from the chaos and the necessity to plan and keep a cool head, the panic really started to settle in.

"I'm very sorry to be such an inconvenience to your plan to sacrifice me", the woman answered sarcastically. If it wouldn't surprise her so much that the sorceress was capable of sarcasm, she might have tried to scratch her eyes out.

"You're right", Adora replied too, effectively ignoring the comment. Then she stopped and placed Shadow Weaver in Catra's arms — both of them made a rather disgusted face and tried to get as much space from each other as they possible could. Meanwhile, the blonde took a step back and reached out to summon her sword. "For the honor of Grayskull!" And a blinding light later, She-Ra stood before them.

The sword vanished again as the girl needed both hands to take Shadow Weaver and throw her over her shoulder.

Catra allowed herself a second to stare at the hilarious picture and welcomed the cruel satisfaction she felt with open arms. That was still better than feeling sad.

Adora took a moment to properly secure the woman in her grip and then they kept going.

They were definitely faster now, and it wasn't too long after that the mossed-over ruin started to come into view. She suspected that the woods might have been helping them get here because

she could swear that the camp should not have been this close to the castle.

They also hadn't seen any surveillance on their way, which was probably a bad sign. But Entrapta said that Prime was building something, so they all most likely went to protect that, but that just meant more work for the others. Another reason to hurry.

Adora quickly opened the door for them through magic connection or whatever, and they made their way inside. Where it would have been completely dark if not for Adora's glowing quality.

Last time Catra had been here — which had been a while, to be fair — the place had been lit up brightly, so this was a bit weird.

"Hello?", the blonde called out, seemingly similarly confused. "Light Hope?" Nothing happened, not even a flicker of a creepy hologram. The girl sighed. "Seriously? I'm finally here and she doesn't want to talk?"

"I'm not sure that's it", the replied because last time Light Hope hadn't wanted to talk to Adora either and the lights still had worked.

"Warning", something did come to life then, scaring them. Catra even extended her claws. "Planetary facilitator Light Hope protocol offline. Manual administrator access not recommended at this time."

"I told you, she said she was the facilitator", Adora cheered before the rest of it hit her. "Wait, what do you mean she's offline?"

"Warning. Planetary facilitator Light Hope protocol offline. Manual administrator access not recommended at this time", the hologram repeated.

"Why did I expect an answer?", the girl groaned. "Okay, nevermind Light Hope, this is actually good for us", she then said and looked over to Catra who could only nod in agreement — this was certainly better than having to fight against the hologram.

"Can you show us the way to the Heart?", she asked instead, putting Shadow Weaver down like she expected a longer conversation here.

"Planetary facilitator Light Hope protocol offline. Manual administrator access not recommended at this time", it repeated once more, leading to Adora letting out a slightly crazed laugh.

"Every. Single. Time. Why can none of these things give straight answers?!"

Catra didn't know that. "Let's calm down", she said instead of replying to her probably rhetoric question. "We knew these things wouldn't make this easy for us."

The other nodded with a little pout. Cute, but unhelpful. "You're right. Let's think."

That was the right attitude, and Catra was already a step ahead.

As far as they knew, Light Hope would have been against them reaching the Heart, which would mean that the rebels back then would have needed a different access anyway. So that meant that the hologram not being here really shouldn't hinder them, even if she was the facilitator. She was just hiding the Heart, she wasn't the entrance. Theoretically.

The rebels must have had a plan. If they went as far to steal the failsafe, they must have already had a way to deploy it. It would not be too farfetched to think that maybe they have installed an override into the system.

That would naturally need some password to be activated since only the rebels were supposed to know about it.

She stepped forward and decided to simply try something. "We're friends of Mara", she said because she doubted these people had been creative. Or even had the time to be.

And something did happen. The hologram in front of them scanned them. eventually landing on Shadow Weaver and making the failsafe on her light up. "Welcome, friends of Mara", she then said and an opening appeared behind her.

"How did you know this would work?", Adora asked then, shock clearly written on her face.

Catra only shrugged. "I didn't", she mumbled. "Come one, before it decides to close it again", she added and started to walk towards the long and dark path that was positively ominous.

She-Ra picked up Shadow Weaver again and quickly followed.

Though they didn't stay quick for long. She knew that they should really hurry, but she wasn't sure if they could trust this path yet, and by the looks of it, Adora felt the same. So, they treaded carefully.

She also kept glancing at Shadow Weaver, another thing she didn't trust. In more than just one regard. "Is she still alive?", she asked at some point because the woman was too still for her liking.

"I think so", the other girl mumbled, picking the sorceress up from her shoulder to look at her.

Shadow Weaver scowled at that. Definitely still alive. "As much as I appreciate your worry, I am simply trying to spend my last minutes in peace", she spat and the blonde slung her back over her shoulder without another word.

Catra didn't trust it. There was no way that the sorceress — the same person who had pretended to care about her just to break out of the Horde, knowing she had sentenced Catra to death — was just suddenly accepting her fate.

Something was going to happen, she just knew it. The woman was not done yet, it just wasn't possible.

A hand suddenly wrapped around hers and she looked up at Adora who smiled softly. "It'll be alright", she said and Catra was almost tempted to believe it.

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"Are you sure about this?", Hordak asked as she pushed some more cables into his arms.

Entrapta had to be honest, she had not listened to a single thing that the king had told them — she could hear it all through the thin material of the tents, theoretically, but she had been so focused on working on her virus that she hadn't actually listened.

Hordak had though, because he was a very considerate lab partner, and as long as one of them knew the plan, she felt pretty safe. "They were successful so far", she told him then.

He sighed. "It is utterly suicidal to attack Prime outright", he grumbled anyway and he was right.

The plan that the others came up with was rather simple, from what he had told her. While Adora, Catra and the dying lady went to shut down the Heart, the princesses and others would start a fight to stop Prime from finishing his contraption, and simultaneously distract the clones and bots, so Entrapta and Hordak could sneak into the spire right next to the battlefield to access the hivemind and destroy it.

"They don't expect to win." Entrapta didn't know much about strategy, but she did know that the purpose of fighting wasn't to defeat Prime. That was her and Hordak's job.

"I know", he acknowledged grumpily. "It's still dumb."

"And that's why Prime won't see it coming", she pointed out to him as she grabbed the last few things. "Do we have everything?", she then asked.

"I think so", he answered in his usual resigned way that told her that she had clearly over-packed, but she was rather safe than sorry.

They didn't have time to sort through the stuff again anyway, because Scorpia peeked in then and alerted them that everyone was ready to go.

When they went outside, the king was just finishing up some speech, probably meant to inspire people.

She found that interesting. Wasn't staying alive and saving their planet motivating enough? Entrapta was tempted to form some theories but reminded herself that she needed to focus — this time, Catra hadn't told her how much her job mattered, but she was smart enough to know how serious this was and that everyone relied on her.

So, she didn't rush to get her recorder and talk a bit about how weird it was that everyone loved their planet and yet they needed someone to tell them again how much they loved their planet to be motivated to fight. She would have to remember it and analyze it later.

If there was a later. Their chances were not really in their favor.

Data showed that the dying lady would pose a problem no matter how dead she already was. It also supported Hordak's claims that the attack on Prime's forces would be a losing one, putting all the more pressure on Entrapta to succeed.

The problem was just that she wasn't even done rewriting her virus. She would have to do it there. And hope that she would be fast enough.

Another weird concept. Hope. She never did that, always rating her success or survival purely off the data she had collected prior. People usually hoped for the impossible and she liked to stay realistic. But she very much didn't want to be blown to bits by the Heart or shot by a clone that looked just like Hordak, and she supposed that want was greater than her statistics. Fascinating.

She shook her head harshly. Focus.

They were now finally ready to get going and they first of all needed Entrapta to tell them where they had to go.

After she had done so, the royal pair took the lead and everyone followed very carefully. As it seemed, Prime didn't care much about surveillance anymore, but the more they could surprise him, the better. So, they tried to stay hidden and quiet.

When they got close, everyone sorted themselves into smaller groups and started to surround the soon to be battlefield. Luckily there were a bunch of rocks here to hide behind.

Meanwhile, she and Hordak already tried to get as close to the spire as possible. Then there was a sign and everyone started to attack.

It was interesting to watch the reactions. Despite being connected to a hivemind, the clones all showed different faces of confusion or shock, maybe surprise. It was hard to tell.

Before she could get too much into observing, Hordak gently tugged at her and she moved to follow. They snuck up to the spire while avoiding the battle as much as they could — it would be best if they weren't spotted at all, since Prime wouldn't know about their meddling that way.

As they wanted to walk in, more clones came running from the entrance and they had to duck quickly behind the rock again.

Hordak bravely took the first look and confirmed that they were in the clear. The clones didn't seem to have spotted them because

they ran straight to assist their allies.

They tried getting into the spire again and this time, they managed to do it.

Luckily, this place was a lot smaller than Prime's ship and it was also a lot emptier — apparently every force had run outside to hold the rebellion. At least that meant they could quickly find the sever room.

Entrapta immediately hooked her equipment up to the hivemind. "Come on, baby, don't disappoint me", she mumbled as she started to finish up her work.

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Adora was nervous as they walked down the dark corridors, careful not to take a wrong turn and never knowing if their choices would be correct.

If only that was it, though. There were several things that rummaged through her head. First and foremost the Heart. What if they didn't find it? What if they took too long? What if the failsafe wouldn't work? What if Prime activated it?

The other thing were her friends, obviously. While she and Catra were somewhat safe down here, they were up there fighting for time, risking their lives. Maybe the feline had been right in saying that She-Ra should have been part of the battle, but how could she leave the girl alone with …

Shadow Weaver.

She could tell that Catra was suspicious of her, and honestly Adora was too. She still remembered that talk she has had with the sorceress before they went to Mystacor, her defiance back then.

None of that had exactly lead anywhere, so naturally she was still expecting something to happen.

Then there was also Light Hope. Adora didn't quite understand why everything here went offline, though she suspected it might have something to do with the destruction of the old She-Ra. Training her had been the hologram's only purpose, alongside activating the Heart, but without the sword she would have no purpose anymore.

Despite her grievances with the woman, she still felt a bit sad to never see her again. Other than Shadow Weaver, Light Hope at least tried her best with the programming that she had. Adora could honestly believe that she had cared, in her own way.

So yeah, there was a lot going through her head right now, which was bad because she really should focus on their task. Even after she has opted out of everyone's idea of her destiny, she was still the protector of this planet. She had a job to do and couldn't allow herself to get distracted.

But she already was, not having been really present for the last few minutes as she worried about their situation and friends, who she should protect right now.

"Hey", the feline called out as if she could read her thoughts. "You okay?"

"I … I'm starting to get a bit nervous I guess", she didn't even bother lying. Not when her girlfriend knew her inside out. "But it's fine. Just worries." There was nothing they could change about the situation anyway, just hope that it would work out.

The other hummed. "Me too. It all kind of depends on Entrapta", she then said. "And I know that shutting down the Heart is important, but not as important, and I trust her, but …"

Adora has not even thought about that, too concerned with herself, but the girl was right. Defeating Prime depended on Entrapta more than it did on them.

If Entrapta shut down the hivemind, then the Heart would be little more than an afterthought, a precaution for the future. But if she didn't, only then did the Heart become more of a priority, to make sure this power doesn't fall into Prime's grasp.

Would the scientist fail? If Catra trusted her then she probably wouldn't, but she had also admitted that she didn't know how far along Prime was with his plans, so time might be the bigger issue here.

"We should probably hurry", she mumbled then as she reached a new high of anxiety. "I don't think Entrapta will fail, but she might not be fast enough."

"That's what I'm worried about", Catra agreed. "But if we rush, we might end up wasting more time by going the wrong way."

Adora groaned. The girl was right, once again. "Well, we have to do something."

"We already are", the other reminded her.

But it didn't help her feel less frustrated — like Micah had said, at the very least they should buy the others some time and make them stronger. "Let's just go faster until we reach another juncture, okay?", she tried to compromise.

The girl easily gave in. "Yeah, okay", she said and they started into another run.

It did make her feel the slightest bit better, more productive, but it didn't completely quell her worries. She didn't expect it to. While it did help make progress on their mission, it still didn't change their circumstances.

Which also included making impossible decisions. "Do you think we're on the right path at all?", Adora had to ask once they were presented with new corridors to chose from.

"No", the other admitted instantly. "But we've been here too long to second guess ourselves. So, which way?"

She didn't know. They have had this choice to make about a dozen times already and every time, Adora had chosen a path on a whim. Catra had followed without protest every time. But with every new decision they had to face, she became a bit more unsure.

They had to see this through though, walk it all the way to the end and if it turned out to be wrong then, they had one path less to chose from, she supposed.

Being nervous wouldn't get them far in a guessing game, so she simply listened to her gut and veered to the right. Catra followed.

But of course the short moment of peace couldn't last long.

"You are wasting your time", Shadow Weaver chose to speak up again then. At least it gave them a sign of life.

"So what?", Catra hissed with barely contained rage. "You want us to leave the Heart to Prime? Let him kill us all? You're not gonna live any longer if we lose, you know?"

It was clear by a quiet grunt that Shadow Weaver had a different opinion, but she stayed silent. That seemed to be all she had so say and Adora rolled her eyes.

The woman had been doing that a few times now — saying something and once she received backlash, she wouldn't answer anymore.

She really didn't know what the point of that was. What did the sorceress try to achieve apart from annoying them? A small sigh escaped her and a good bit of her conflicted feelings left her body with it.

Once, she had told Glimmer and Bow that she had to believe some good was in everyone from the Horde, even Shadow

Weaver, but now… The woman would really never change.

It was probably still wrong to kill her, morally speaking, but she figured that was a crisis she could go through once this was done and everyone was safe.

Especially since she already had one going on. Maybe she could talk to Catra a bit more, get her to think about something else for a few minutes. It's not like there was anything interesting down here.

But then a loud shriek cut through the silence before she could.

"What was that?", Catra asked as they both stopped walking, and already got into a fighting stance, taking her whip into her hand.

"I don't know", she responded and summoned her sword. "I don't think it's good." That much was clear. And it really shouldn't surprise them to find traps down here.

Neither of them started to move again, and instead studied their surroundings. Whatever was making this sound, they couldn't see it. Not yet, anyway.

She shared a look with her friend and nodded. They kept walking, slowly and carefully since they had no idea what they were dealing with or where it came from.

Eventually, it was Catra who spotted it first, pushing her to the side as a green tentacle-like thing shot out from the darkness of the corridor.

Adora, in retaliation, shot a magic blast somewhere into the direction the thing had come from. She didn't even get close to hitting it, but at least they had gotten a better look at it. It was … hard to describe, but it was big and oozing with something that she was sure she did not want to get in contact with.

She lunged another blast of energy down the hall, but this time the purpose was just to give them some more light. Catra might

be okay in the dark, but she wasn't.

Now that she could see it for longer than just a glance, she found it much easier to evade it when it tried to hit them again. But they couldn't evade it forever.

Quickly looking around the now brighter hallway, she noticed that the only way forward was on the other side of the little cavern that the monster was in. And they would need to go through. She somehow doubted this thing would be here if this wasn't the right path — well, that was a relief at least.

So, she put Shadow Weaver on the ground, hopefully a safe distance away, and gripped her sword tighter. "We gotta fight", she then said.

Catra nodded quickly and jumped away from another tentacle. "Just be careful. I'm not sure this wasn't put here for you."

Adora hadn't even considered that. It was clear enough that this was a trap for anyone who wanted to shut down the Heart, but who would realistically come down here? Who had access to the Crystal Castle? Who would be the biggest threat?

Mara. She-Ra. Her.

Taking a breath, she took it on anyway. She had Catra, and as long as she paid very good attention, everything would be fine.

She didn't even need to say anything, they moved towards it as one and the feline charged in first, distracting the monster with her very fast whip, giving Adora the advantage to direct a blast at it without noticing.

The thing staggered back, giving Catra the opportunity to cut straight across its face. The damage reminded her of the girl's claws — Entrapta had really thought about that design, apparently.

She shook her head and focused again.

They worked perfectly in tandem, paying attention to each other's movements while still focusing on the monster and staying a reasonable distance away from it — the biggest advantage of both of their new weapons was being able to stay at range, which Adora liked very much considering the circumstances.

As they steadily cut through the monster's skin she realized that Catra would have a better chance at killing it. It at least seemed like the thing was more damaged by the whip than She-Ra's blasts. Which just proved that it really was here to stop her specifically.

Still, she kept attacking it, seamlessly switching their roles to her doing the distractions and Catra doing the damage.

The girl clearly seemed to notice too because shortly after Adora had changed her approach, so did the feline, attacking more and more until she managed to cut off one of the tentacles.

It was leaking with the weird liquid that was oozing out of the monster's entire body and judging by the odd hissing sound the green stuff made, she was pretty certain it was most definitely poisonous.

Sadly that meant that, as great as once tentacle less was, it now lay around as another obstacle to avoid in the already small space.

This fight went on longer than it should have, but as they both had to keep their distance and only one of them could do real damage, it stretched on for what felt like forever. So when another cut of Catra's whip made the monster stagger back and it stopped attacking in an attempt to curl in on itself, it almost felt too good to be true.

Adora shared one look with Catra and they attacked together, the feline slashed the monster open more and deeper than it already was and She-Ra send out another blast that seemed to fester inside the thing, setting it ablaze.

Just to be sure, they watched it burn, catching their breaths, and only when the coaled crisp of the monster remained, did they relax.

"That was … something", Adora mumbled, a bit out of breath. "How did that even survive all this time down here?"

Catra just shrugged. "I don't know, but this is a bit extreme, even if they didn't want Mara to shut down the Heart."

"Agreed." From the looks of it, it would have been death by poison. That was sincerely a bit cruel. And speaking of. "Are you okay? You didn't get hit or anything?"

"No, I'm fine", the other answered, and for once Adora believed it. "What about you?"

She smiled in relief. "Me too, all good. Though I must say, this was a workout." It was unusual for She-Ra to feel any kind of strain, not impossible, but rare enough that she never really thought about it as a limit to her powers.

"What am I supposed to say?", her friend laughed in response, shaking her head with a fond smile before looking past Adora and staring in shock.

Her heart dropped a bit and she whipped her head around. Seeing what Catra saw, she felt dread creep up inside her. "What? I put her right there!", she said frantically, searching the hallway with her eyes. The light was still up and the corridor was narrow, certainly not wide enough to be able to hide somewhere.

"She ran", Catra growled.

Chapter End Notes

Finally some whip action!!!

The next chapter will come much sooner, I promise! Mostly because I go on vacation soon and I want this to be over

before that... (I love this, but I am sincerely tired T.T) So, I'll try to get it all out before the end of next week, hope that's okay <333

So until next time, stay hydrated <33

Chapter 36: The Heart - Part 2

Chapter Notes

Told you, it'd be sooner this time <33

Okay get ready for basically everyone to get a POV now (I'm being dramatic, it's just one more person), and for some uh ... predictable, terrible fate to befall one of the characters (well terrible depending who you're asking I guess xD)

Anyway, warnings:
more anxiety, some pain (nothing graphic), and some violence (nothing graphic)

I hope you have fun <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer had honestly not expected Catra to put her in charge. That the girl yelled at her mom had been a thing she kind of saw coming. After several discussions between the two that ended with the feline having to fight to do the right thing, it had been only a matter of time until she finally snapped.

No, more surprising was that both of them actually gave up control.

She had managed to have a short talk with Bow about it and he was convinced it was a sign of growth, but Glimmer wasn't so sure — it felt more like a sign of desperation.

It definitely was for her mother, who had kept to the background after being yelled at, looking a bit ashamed and unsure. She had almost not come because she had felt they would be better off without her.

And Catra also hadn't necessarily looked happy. She hadn't looked proud of her moment of frustration, and extremely hesitant about

leaving the planning to them.

The girl was good at hiding her feelings, but Glimmer had noticed how scared she was. And she suspected it was because she couldn't make sure things ran smoothly.

Catra had always been very obsessed with that, even back when they had fought the old Horde, which was probably also why she had risked sharing her 'forbidden knowledge' with them. It didn't matter how much she pretended she didn't care, she clearly did.

And that was something that motivated Glimmer to keep them all safe. If Catra wasn't here then someone else had to make sure they would survive this.

She and her dad came up with something rather simple. They separated into groups with each one of the main rebellion fighters in them, speak the princesses as well as Bow, Sea Hawk, Swift Wind, Castaspella, her dad, and even Double Trouble.

Then they would each attack a section of Prime's forces, so they were somewhat coordinated and wouldn't lose precious time during the battle trying to figure out who covered what.

Her dad had also made sure, in his speech, that everyone knew that the main goal was distracting them. It was more important that everyone stayed safe than to win. And while they were at it, they would also try to stop them from finishing whatever they were building.

Simple enough. Or so she had thought until she had actually seen the battlefield. Entrapta may have said that Prime was close to accessing the Heart, but by the looks of whatever stood in the middle of the wide area, it was more than just close.

She hadn't been entirely sure what to expect from the ominous words that Prime may have found a way to get to the Heart, but it certainly hadn't been the tall and creepy tower of machinery that loomed over them. In the middle of it was Adora's old sword and

even from further away, Glimmer could see where it had recently been broken, but it was somehow holding together now.

It had only taken one look she shared with Lonnie to see they were on the same page — if Prime was already done building then their plan should be to stop him from using it.

That turned out to be a lot harder than expected, though. None of them really managed to get close.

Glimmer and her group hadn't been the only people to come to the conclusion that Prime was farther than expected, but apart from her mom, who could fly, and Spinnerella, who could also kind of fly, no one could actually do anything to stop the clones from tinkering with it.

And two people, no matter how powerful, were just not enough.

Even with everyone here, fighting and distracting as many forces as possible, they couldn't avoid it for long.

Especially as with time people started to run out of energy. Naturally, the clones and bots did not have that problem, and after … who knows how long, Glimmer found herself wishing that Catra and Adora would hurry up — a power boost would be great right about now. That or Entrapta would shut down the hivemind, but she doubted either would happen anytime soon.

From what she knew, the First Ones were rather protective of their weapon, so it would probably take them a while. And Entrapta hadn't been done rewriting the virus when they got here, so that would take some time as well.

Unfortunately, they were severely lacking in that department.

They could probably still go for a little bit, but she would really appreciate it if someone could do something.

If only she could use her teleportation, then she didn't have to get in close and could save some of her physical strength, but she

couldn't risk running completely out of energy, so she had to rely on her meager sorcery skills and hitting people with her staff.

And after being woken in the middle of the night, she was also tired and it was getting to her.

Bit by bit, she fell back a bit, hid behind the rest of her group to take a few breaths and recollect some strength.

She was just about to go back into battle when a bright light stole her attention. To her horror it came from the machine — it was the sword.

Quickly taking in the situation, Glimmer spotted a lone clone messing with the controls. Somehow, in everyone's exhaustion, he must have slipped past her mom and Spinnerella.

Before she could yell something however, or even teleport over there to take care of him herself, the entire thing lit up, clearly activated now, and it didn't take long for her to feel the effects.

She felt a strange tug and it was quickly becoming painful, and she wasn't the only one. There were slight groans from around her. And then before she could make sense of it, she saw some symbols light up on her skin and felt what little remaining magic she had inside her leave her. She couldn't even stand anymore. Or notice much of her surroundings, the pain completely blinded her.

"Glimmer!", she heard someone call, it sounded vaguely like Kyle.

When she tried to look around, she saw her group having formed a rather protective circle around her, and through the cracks she noticed the groups next to her having done the same. She thought it must be Frosta's and Perfuma's.

"I'm fine", she grumbled and tried to get up, but she did not have the strength.

"We got you, princess", the boy told her with a wavering voice and a strained smile. "Don't worry."

But she did. Not just for herself, but everyone else.

Trying to remember, she knew only the princesses with runestones should be affected, meaning the sorcerers, Spinnerella, Netossa, and most importantly Entrapta should still be able to function, but … if the Heart channels the magic of Etheria, then anyone connected to magic would at least be weakened.

Glimmer once again wished for Adora and Catra to hurry up. Hoped they could make this stop.

***

If Shadow Weaver wouldn't already be destined for it, Catra would swear to kill that woman.

They were running now, running back where they came from because the sorceress most likely didn't manage to make it past them while they had fought, and she also wouldn't voluntarily go towards the Heart.

Of course this had to happen, she wasn't even surprised. She should have known — she had known, had been suspicious the entire time, but in the face of some unknown creature, she has had different priorities.

And now, they were frantically checking every single corridor for the woman, but she was nowhere to be seen.

She must have hidden somewhere. With the hallways being pretty long and straight, the logical conclusion was to hide out in one of the branching corridors.

There was one other option, however. Shadow Weaver might have somehow managed to store away enough magic to escape this place altogether. And in that case, they were doomed without any

hope. Even if they could actually find her out there, it would take way too long.

Still, Catra was convinced that the sorceress had to be here. Despite the woman having done this type of thing before, she doubted she could have actually done it in this case. Last time, she had needed her badge and the magic powder inside it to actually escape and Catra knew for a fact that Shadow Weaver didn't have that with her. And the failsafe has severely weakened her too.

She had to be here.

And if it was the last thing she did, Catra would find that hag and she would enjoy watching her die. Even if the witch had actually managed to escape, she would find her and tear her apart before the Heart or Prime would have the chance.

"Catra", Adora stopped her in her tracks. And why did she sound so far away?

As she reluctantly turned around she knew why. The blonde hadn't followed anymore for a bit, leaning against a wall and breathing heavily a few many meters behind her. She looked exhausted. "What? What's going on?", she asked and walked back, getting a bit worried.

"I don't know", the other mumbled. "I just … I'm-" She didn't get much farther than that before her transformation started to flicker and Adora slid down the wall, all but falling to the ground.

Catra rushed forward, checking the girl over — maybe she had been hit by that green monster thing after all and she just hadn't said anything, or hadn't noticed. But she didn't see any injuries.

Meanwhile She-Ra flickered some more and eventually vanished completely. Adora made an absolutely horrified expression at that, no doubt mentally terrorizing herself already. "She- I don't know what's happening", she got out as her breathing became irregular.

"Hey, it's okay, there has to be a reason for this", she tried to soothe her, which was hard since she was kind of panicking herself. The new She-Ra was clearly a bit less stable than the old one, being more tied to Adora's emotional state than a runestone now, but … that still didn't explain the sudden exhaustion.

And then the hallways started to light up around them.

That at least seemed to ground the blonde. Or maybe the added stress of what this undeniably meant just made her freeze. "The Heart", she managed to mumble though.

Catra would admit that all of this was not a good sign. Especially the fact that this place, that had been offline up until now, was suddenly coming back to life. And, she supposed, the Heart was the only reason it would do that.

"But I thought you weren't connected to the Heart anymore, without the sword", she pointed out, hearing a bit of her anxiety shine through in her voice.

Adora shook her head, looking absolutely desperate. "I don't know", she muttered. "I'm still connected to Etheria."

And the Heart siphons all of the planet's magic. If Adora was already weakened despite not being a direct part of the machine anymore, then how bad were the others doing? "We have to hurry", she said, getting rid of her panic and trying to find her determination again. "I'll keep searching for Shadow Weaver. Stay here and rest for a moment."

"No!", the blonde protested naturally.

She sighed — she couldn't have this conversation again, especially not when they had so little time for it.

Before she could say anything though, Adora beat her to it. "I'm not injured, just a bit exhausted. I'm fine", she grumbled and pushed herself to stand again, with visible effort.

"Don't be stubborn, there's no way you can just keep going like before", she argued, barely able to hide her impatience.

Clearly, the other was just as annoyed with her own insistence. "Yeah, this sucks, but I'm still She-Ra."

Catra only barely swallowed a groan. "We've been over this. You don't need to play the hero all the time", she repeated the sentiment for what felt like the hundredth time. "Especially when you're weakened like this, I can handle Shadow Weaver."

"I know! I don't care!", Adore cried out. "I still want to help you, and our friends who might not be able to defend themselves all that well anymore, cause if they die, it'll be my fault!"

The girl swayed a bit again, though she didn't know if it was due to her current weakness or the emotional outburst. Either way, Catra was a bit stunned. "It's not your fault", she told her, not sure how the other even got that idea.

"I let Shadow Weaver escape", she responded weakly. "If I had just … secured her better, then we wouldn't be searching for her right now. We could have already shut down the Heart and the others wouldn't be in danger." She leaned back against the wall, defeated. "Why can't I just get this right? I'm supposed to protect people but every time I try, I seem to make things worse."

Catra calmed herself a little and decided that she would waste a minute to deal with this. "You always try to do the right thing. That's more than most people can say", she tried to reassure the girl.

"How does that matter if it always leads to disaster?", the blonde asked weakly.

She didn't really have an answer for that. "This isn't your fault", she repeated instead. "You didn't force Shadow Weaver to run, or Prime to be … himself."

At least that got a little chuckle out of the other. "That … honestly doesn't make me feel better", she admitted.

"Yeah, I know", she said with a tight smile. She also still couldn't always believe what people told her to be true, but she has gotten better at it. "Once this is all over, we really got to get you a session with Perfuma. But right now, if you really want to come, I need you to focus."

Adora perked up then. "Yes!", she agreed easily. "I can do that."

"Let's go then." She held out a hand and the blonde eagerly took it.

Catra didn't run anymore, not with the other's state in mind, but she still tried to hurry as much as she could.

Hopefully it wouldn't take much longer for them to find Shadow Weaver. Seriously, they hadn't fought for that long, how far could a dying woman possibly get?

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Entrapta just couldn't figure out the hivemind and it was stressing her out.

Even with the entire system at her fingertips she still had to be extremely careful — she was all too aware that if Prime noticed, he could easily send down a teleport beam and get her away from the spire.

Then there was also Hordak, who stood guard and who she worried about because no matter how much he tried to hide it, he was pretty fragile. Her upgrades helped, of course, but she would still rather avoid him getting hurt.

Luckily, the distraction seemed to be working because no one had bothered them so far.

That didn't at all ease the time pressure, though. If anything, it made it worse.

She was so close to finishing up her virus, but it had to be a perfect fit or it would be wasted like last time, and that was the problem. How was she supposed to fit a virus perfectly to a system that was literally infinite?

Tech was the one thing she was good at, the only way to help, and even though she didn't understand strategy, she did know that everything depended on her. Entrapta wasn't allowed to fail and it was stressing her out!

She wasn't used to stress and she had no idea how to deal with it. How did Catra do that? Well, the feline was prone to lash out and hurt people — that wasn't really an option for her.

Usually she would throw herself into her experiments, but right now her experiments were the problem.

A soft touch on her shoulder violently ripped her out of her thoughts then. She nervously looked up and was relieved to see that she hadn't missed some intrusion and it was just Hordak.

"Uh…", he mumbled awkwardly, pulling the hand back now that he had her attention. "I, uh, noticed you were … shaking a bit." He cleared his throat, a bit of color appearing in his face. Cute, really. "Are you worried?"

"Yeah", she admitted easily. "I'm pretty sure it won't work like this, and I don't know how to fix it and everyone's relying on me and I'm not used to that, and the virus has to be perfect and it's not", she rambled. "Prime's hivemind is just too complex…"

Hordak frowned then. "You told me you didn't like perfection."

"Well, actually I said, there's value and beauty in imperfection as without it scientific discoveries and improvements wouldn't be possible", she corrected before noticing where he was going with that. "Oh… But… It hasn't worked before because it wasn't really tailored to the hivemind."

"Prime despises chaos", he told her then. She already knew that, but she listened anyway. Hordak usually had useful things to say. "So … maybe the answer isn't to cater to his perfection, but to destroy him with our … imperfection?"

Entrapta took a moment to think about that.

It was an interesting view on things. And wasn't that the base of their plan to begin with? Hordak had told them that Prime didn't understand magic, which lead them to want to destroy the Heart as it would greatly disadvantage him.

Magic was natural and chaotic to its very core. She had spent enough time studying the First Ones' attempt at controlling it to know how impossible and unstable it was.

So, following that logic…

Prime's hivemind might pose infinite possibilities, but it had a pattern. That much she had figured out. Her original idea had been to replicate that pattern, so her virus would fit perfectly, but just because it was predictable in theory didn't mean it was easy.

But … she didn't have to fully understand it in every detail. She just had to break it.

Smiling brightly, she went back to typing, changing her code once more. This might not have been exactly what Hordak had meant, but she was sure it would work and it would be a lot simpler to implement.

"You're a genius!", she told him with great enthusiasm. "The hivemind may be too complex to replicate, but if we can confuse enough pathways, we can make it short circuit!", she explained

her thought process. She didn't have to create the perfect counterpart, didn't even have to understand it, all she had to do was add enough nonsense to it until it destroyed itself. "I just hope we still have time."

"I think so", Hordak said. He was calm, she noticed, which was probably odd but did wonders to calm her down too, so she didn't intend to question it too much. "If he hasn't noticed us yet, the distraction must be good enough."

"You think?", she asked, still not looking up or lifting her hands from the keyboard. "He seemed to have his eyes everywhere."

She saw him nod out of the corner of her eye. "That is something he prides himself on, yes. But with all his clones and bots outside, there's no one watching us. Who will tell him we're here?"

Entrapta hummed. "Makes sense", she decided. Since he had experience being further up in the ranks and having limited control over the hivemind, he must know and she trusted his judgment.

"And I suspect that anger is getting the better of him", he then added.

Emotions, she had only limited knowledge about that too. "How so?"

"Merely judging from his latest attack on the camp and this entire situation, he is lacking the usual care he puts into his conquests, like he has done in the beginning", Hordak started to explain, pausing shortly to gather his thoughts. "He likes to take his time and learn, even if he ends up destroying it all. But now he is angry and, out of experience … it will blind him."

That made Entrapta look up briefly.

He has had his moments at the beginning of their time together when he would be easily irritated — even worse than Catra — but she hadn't bothered much with it. Letting it out was healthy, or so

she was told, so she has let him let it out as long as he didn't damage anything or anyone, but he seemed to be fond of non-destructive yelling, so she has let him.

After a while, he seemed to understand that she didn't look down on him or want to imprison him or hurt him. She had been just excited to have a lab partner, and no matter how reluctant or angry, he was very helpful. Which she had told him.

At some point he had become calmer, according to her data, and now he seemed to be stuck in that weird phase that all the other Horde people were also in — that awkward realization that previous behavior had been wrong and harmful, while trying to figure out how to be better.

Shame wouldn't do, though, not if she could help it. So, she smiled at him. "I'm really glad that you're not angry anymore", she told him. "Once this is over, we can work on being happy."

Entrapta swore, he blushed again, but she had to keep focusing on her virus. She has yet to actually touch the hivemind since she didn't want to risk Prime noticing them before she was ready. In the end, this being an invasion into his system, they only had one shot, so she still had to focus and make sure this had the best chances to work.

Just a few more minutes and this would hopefully be over.

Huh, there it was again. Hope. What an odd concept.

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Catra's lungs were downright burning as she checked every single off-branching corridor and she slowly lost hope. Adora was somewhere behind her, doing much worse and trying to keep up.

At this point, they might as well consider giving up and trusting Entrapta to be fast enough to save them all.

The problem was just that she didn't like leaving important things like the lives of the rebellion and the entirety of Etheria to someone else. She has always preferred doing big stuff like that herself — obviously she wasn't just going to trust others with it, no matter who they are or how capable they were.

So, she kept going.

She was so focused on her search that she almost ran past Shadow Weaver, but she quickly realized and came to a halt, briefly wondering if she had been hallucinating before walking the few steps back to glare at the miserable little heap in front of her.

The woman didn't look very great. Carefully, she leaned in a bit and wanted to check for a pulse, but then the head lifted suddenly to glare at her, startling her and making her jump back with a hiss.

"I'm still alive", the witch spat and fell into a coughing fit shortly after.

The woman might be still alive, but evidently wasn't going to be much longer.

"You found her?", Adora asked excitedly then, if not a bit out of breath. It seemed she had caught up.

"Yep", she simply replied and allowed herself a quick moment of relief. After this entire ordeal she thought she deserved to take a nice long breath to calm down a bit. Then she turned her attention back to Shadow Weaver. "Come on", she said, and reached out to grab an arm to pull the other up, but the woman wasn't helping, making it really hard to budge her from her spot.

"I will not", the sorceress said, stubbornly remaining where she was.

It occurred to Catra then, that maybe the plan hadn't been trying to escape, but the woman just wanted them to fail. Tough luck then, because she was not going to let that happen. With a growl she grabbed the witch's ankles and started to dragged her over the floor.

"Are you insane?!", the woman snapped.

"I'm practical!", Catra hissed back. She sincerely didn't know how else to move the sorceress since She-Ra wasn't an option right now, and she herself was definitely not strong enough to carry a grown woman. "We will all die if you don't get up, and you will die anyway. What is your problem?"

The sorceress scoffed, which might have been more impactful if she had been standing. "I will not be executed and sacrificed. I will not die on your terms, but mine!"

She could not even form a coherent response to that. Well, she had one, it being an interesting stance to have considering the woman had willingly sent Catra to her own death once. But she knew that, technically, that hadn't happened anymore, still she was not convinced the sorceress wouldn't do it again if given the chance.

Luckily Adora had her covered. "I'm pretty sure you already lost that right when you almost killed Micah back when he was a kid. Don't pretend like *he* had a choice", the girl grumbled with a roll of her eyes, which was impressive when she barely managed to stand.

"You good?", Catra asked, concerned that maybe she should not have let the blonde come with her, after all.

"Yeah, just…", she wheezed in response, finally taking some deeper breaths to refuel her lungs. "One second."

She only nodded and started to drag the sorceress along already. Right now, she would be even slower than Adora, so she didn't worry too much about the girl catching up once she was ready.

And they were still short on time, so she'd rather not waste more of it, especially since they had a long way to walk back.

How Shadow Weaver had made it this far to begin with was unclear to her. This woman had not been able to keep up with them back in the woods, but now she could make it halfway back to the entrance of this cursed place?

At the very least, she seemed to be weak enough now to not fight back, which was something. But also worrying because it meant the sorceress was close to dying, and they had to make it to the Heart before that happened.

And on that topic, she worried about something else, now that her mind wasn't occupied with their search anymore. "Hey Adora?", she called out to the girl, who was still resting down the hall. She really didn't make much progress here.

"Yeah?", she replied, sounding a lot better already.

"Do you think the failsafe will work when the Heart is already activated?", she voiced her thoughts because … they only ever discussed the use of the failsafe while everything was still offline. And didn't Entrapta say something about not being able to stop it once it was activated? Did that only count for controlling it from the outside, or for everything?

"Uh", the other mumbled, clearly saying that she didn't know either.

With a little grunt, Adora pushed herself off the wall and started to follow. Just like Catra had predicted, she was faster than her, easily catching up.

"I hope", the girl said then.

"Great", she grumbled. Hope was the one thing she kind of didn't have anymore. This just looked way too bad for anything to end up going well, in her pessimistic opinion.

"You will never make it in time", Shadow Weaver just had to add. "Not like this. Not when the Heart is already preparing to fire." The announcement was followed by another cough and the failsafe over her chest flickered a bit.

Catra tugged harder in response. "Shut up", she growled. "I survived Beast Island, and I will survive this. So stop being such a terrible and miserable person, it's not gonna save you."

Unsurprisingly, there was no further answer. Thank goodness.

"Can I help?", Adora asked then, walking beside her now.

"I don't know how", she replied honestly. Maybe the girl could grab an ankle too, but seeing how exhausted she had been by just walking, Catra doubted that would be a good idea. "It's fine, I got it."

"Okay", was the reluctant reply. She was clearly not happy about having nothing to do, but they sadly couldn't change anything about that right now.

All they could do was make their way back to the Heart.

Both of them were silent during their walk as they were too exhausted to do much more than focus on their own feet in front of them.

And maybe worry a bit. Catra had little to no sense of time down here, and she was wondering how long the others have had to suffer already, and what it looked like for them. There should be plenty of people there who should not be affected by the Heart at all, and hopefully they could keep the others safe.

Even most of the magic users, aside from the princesses, should be relatively fine. Like Adora. She might be weakened and unable to help much right now, but Catra thought that if push came to shove, she could and would still throw punches. It would exhaust her a lot and she wouldn't be able to do it for a long time, but … if it was similar for the others, it was hopefully enough to not die.

Maybe she did have a little hope left, after all.

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Adora was regaining some energy, if only through sheer anxiety. They were making painfully slow progress and since they both strained themselves to keep going, they had no breath left over to talk and distract themselves.

It was even worse than the first time walking this path. She had already been extremely nervous then, that they'd be too slow, that they would fail. And now they already had. All they could still do was try to avoid the worst.

That's what she tried to focus on as they steadily made their way to the Heart. At least they didn't have to take guesses as to where they were going anymore. It gave her the illusion that they were faster somehow.

They probably weren't — last time, they had been basically running the entire way, and now even walking at a decent pace seemed impossible — but whenever they passed another juncture, she felt a bit of relief flood her. One down. Progress.

She hadn't counted them before, but somehow she still thought the cavern with the monster shouldn't be much farther.

Hopefully, they would make it there. They had taken only two short breaks since they had found Shadow Weaver, and Adora could feel her entire body shake, protesting against the intense stress of moving it so much when it would rather lie down.

That was not an option, though. Not when her guilt weighted so heavily on her mind.

No matter what Catra said, if Adora had just paid a bit more attention then they wouldn't be here. If she had done a lot of things different, then none of this would be happening, but there was no need to go that far back into the past. Not right now, at least.

Catra was right with one thing, they had to focus if they wanted to help anyone. So she focused on staying upright and putting one foot in front of the other, making sure she didn't stumble.

And eventually, they did reach the cavern again.

"Finally", the feline breathed out and stopped, allowing them another moment of rest.

Adora gladly took it, leaning against a wall and breathing heavily. "Never thought I'd be so happy to see a dead body", she said with great difficulty as she tried to supply her limbs with air.

The other only nodded, too out of breath to do much more. It made sense. While Adora only had to carry her own body, the girl had pulled Shadow Weaver all the way back, obviously she would be doing a bit worse.

"How much farther do you think it is?", she asked once her body seemed sufficiently refueled and breathing became a bit less frantic.

"No idea", Catra mumbled, also seemingly calming down a bit. "But I think, they wouldn't just place a poisonous monster anywhere."

"Must be close then", she finished that thought and the girl nodded again.

Shadow Weaver stayed silent, which she was both grateful for but also suspicious about. Nothing out of the sorceress' mouth would be good, and yet it was weird that she didn't feel the need to mock them or something. The woman always had something to say.

At the same time, with the failsafe dangerously flickering over her chest, indicating that her life was coming to an end, she might just not have the energy for it anymore. Still, Adora had kind of thought the woman would go out with a bit more … something. Noise, fight, a bang, whatever. The silence was unsettling.

Not really a great thing to add to her already depressive state of mind. "We should keep going", she mumbled then, nodding towards the sorceress.

Catra followed her gaze and frowned with worry. "You're right", she said and kept dragging the woman over the floor, and carefully past the green monster.

The girl had not let go of the witch's ankles while resting, having been smarter than Adora and keeping her secure.

She shook her head, reminding herself again to focus, and followed the other. Her legs were burning at this point — actually, her entire body was burning — but she pushed through anyway. She could rest properly once they didn't all die.

It was a miracle they haven't already. Surely, with as much time as they had wasted, the Heart must be ready to fire sometime soon.

And speaking of. "Do you hear that?", Catra asked her then, her ears moving around like she tried to figure out where the noise came from. Whatever it was, because Adora didn't hear it.

"No?", she replied honestly.

"It sounds like…" Realization seemed to dawn on the other's face. "A heartbeat."

They shared one short look before they both doubled their efforts. It really couldn't be much farther, and that knowledge filled them with hope and some more energy. Almost there.

At some point, Adora could hear it too, the distance sound of a deep and steady beat. So close.

It really didn't take much longer for them to enter a big cave that was pulsing with energy, a large structure at the center that undoubtedly had to be the Heart. Its pulse was so strong now, standing directly before it, that she could feel it in her bones. And it was alight in the colors of the rainbow as it charged up with the magic of the planet.

If it weren't so dangerous it would actually be really beautiful.

As it was though, this didn't mean anything good. Looking around and trying to figure out how to go about this, she saw a platform right underneath it, and a narrow walkway leading to it.

She carefully started to make her way over — considering the rest of the castle hadn't collapsed in the last thousand years, she didn't think that this little bridge would be too frail to carry them, but … it was old and after everything that had gone wrong today, she just wanted to be safe.

Catra seemed to share that idea because she followed with similar caution. Or maybe she was just trying to make sure that she didn't accidentally drop Shadow Weaver over the edge.

Either way, it was once again a slow process.

Due to the feline's added baggage, Adora made it to the platform a bit faster and was able to look around a bit. There wasn't much though, nothing to determine how to go about deploying the failsafe.

Maybe Shadow Weaver had to get to the center and then … something would just happen? That was her only guess right now, and it was the only thing that made sense.

After all, there was nothing else here but the Heart. Where else, but this platform, was the failsafe supposed to go?

She turned around to check on Catra's progress and tell her what she thought, but as she did, she saw the girl also examining their environment, having no eyes on the sorceress anymore. And in the second it took Adora to take all that in, the woman already took her chance, casting a spell that pushed Catra backwards and right over the edge.

Her own fatigue was forgotten as she ran back. "Catra!", she desperately yelled out the girl's name.

"Get her to the center!", was the response.

Adora breathed out heavily. If she could answer she was okay at least, and now that she was a bit closer, she did see the feline's claws holding onto the walkway for dear life. But how long would she be able to hold on? She should get the girl to safety first.

"Adora! Move it!" Catra of course knew what she was thinking. Her voice sounded so strained though, so full of exhaustion and effort.

"But-", she was about to protest, stuck frozen to the spot, but Catra wasn't having it.

"Get the failsafe!", the girl repeated, a bit of frustration seeping into her voice now, but Adora still didn't manage to move, warring with her mission and saving her love.

What finally snapped her out of her daze was not the feline's anger, but Shadow Weaver's.

She had noticed the sorceress pushing herself up from her lying position during their current conversation, but she had been too focused on Catra to fully care about that. Now, though, the woman was drawing up another spell, so Adora crossed the last bit of space and tackled her.

That second blast was still fired, and she heard it hit something, but she didn't think it could have hit Catra. The girl still let out a shriek, which wasn't helping.

She dared to look over quickly to at least confirm that the other really was fine, and spotted a bit of smoke coming from a spot not too far from her hands. But Catra was still there, good.

Shadow Weaver meanwhile wrestled a bit with her and tried to attack again, but this time Adora was a lot quicker to react and she restrained the sorceress' hands before any more spells could be drawn.

"Why are you doing this?", she asked, not really knowing why — she didn't want an answer, nor did she need it, but something in her demanded it anyway. "If you're mad, be mad at me. I tried to kill you before, and I'm the one killing you now."

"You're only doing it because of that brat", she spat in response, still trying to break free. Adora might be weak right now, but Shadow Weaver was weaker and therefore unsuccessful. "She has always been a worthless nuisance. If I'm dying, I'm taking her with me."

She could only sigh in response. Honestly, what did she expect? "No", she said with a small grunt as she was still fighting with the sorceress. "You won't, but you will save the planet."

There was a laugh that quickly turned into a cough. "You are not strong enough to get me there", she said victoriously.

"Displays of physical weakness are discouraged in the Horde, remember?", she replied and pushed herself up, the woman's hands still held tightly. "If you think I can't push my limits, you must have forgotten about that", she grumbled as she took on Catra's position in dragging Shadow Weaver forward, though she did it by the hands to avoid more attacks.

This time, the sorceress did try to fight back and made this unnecessarily harder than it already was, but in the end she was too close to dying to do it for long and Adora used her chances when the woman had bouts of weakness. Sadly, the failsafe started to flicker again and she really tried to hurry this along.

When she made it back to the platform, she deposited Shadow Weaver as much in the middle as she could without busting out a ruler. Then she stepped back a little, hoping something would just happen and she didn't need to solve more puzzles, not with Catra and her friends still in danger, not with her body shaking and about to collapse, not to mention the Heart being so close to being fully charged.

Adora already started to panic again, but then the failsafe started to glow more strongly, which she assumed meant something was working, so she stepped back a bit further.

Really, she wanted to run back to Catra immediately, but was too afraid to lift her eyes off the woman.

Shadow Weaver stared back, her eyes full of hatred. "I hope you can be happy", she said before the Heart started to light up too, and Adora really couldn't keep looking at … anything.

The light quickly filled the entire room and she couldn't tell what was happening anymore.

There was an odd sound that she couldn't quite place but knew it made her uncomfortable — like Catra's claws on metal, just horribly unpleasant. And then she could feel a huge wave of magic and power wash over her.

It was extremely overwhelming and she stumbled backwards, almost losing her footing entirely as she had to withstand that raw energy. Briefly she wondered what that must have felt like cursing through a body before being ripped apart.

And then it was already over.

She cautiously opened her eyes again and found herself in darkness.

They did it. The Heart was shut down.

Relief washed over her. They did it. Just in time.

"Uh, Adora?", Catra brought her back into her panic.

She immediately sprang to action. "For the honor of Grayskull!", she called instinctively and thankfully felt herself transform.

Now being able to see something again, she rushed over and quickly grabbed the other's wrists to pull her back up and into her arms because she would admit that was possibly the scariest day of her life. Right after the portal, to be fair.

Catra had fallen into the unknown in both cases, though this time she at least let Adora help her back up.

Surprisingly, the girl held on just just as tightly as she did. She had expected her to brush it off or something, but the feline had firmly attached herself to Adora's body, her claws digging a bit into her back even.

It seemed that she hadn't been the only one who was scared. "It's alright, I'm here. She's gone. We did it", she tried to soothe her friend a little.

She hadn't actually checked on Shadow Weaver, though. It was safe to assume that she was dead now, but she hadn't bothered to actually confirm it. So, she looked over to the platform from her crouched position and saw nothing but a mask.

"She's gone", she repeated, rubbing some circle's into Catra's back.

"Good", came the raspy response.

"Are you okay?", she asked, now that she knew the other was responsive. "Not hurt or anything?"

Catra naturally sighed even though she was still clinging to Adora. "I'm fine, don't worry", she mumbled. "And it didn't hurt. Much. I was already in pain as it was, I would have barely noticed it, if not for the doom below me."

"This is really nothing to joke about", she grumbled, still not believing how chill the girl could be about stuff like this.

"Force of habit", she said apologetically and sadly pulled back a little to look at her. "Seriously though, I'm okay."

Adora let herself feel the relief again, hoping it wouldn't be taken from her again. "Good", she mumbled, nodding to herself to convince her body to relax. "What now?", she couldn't stop worrying completely.

"I don't know", Catra admitted. "The rest is up to the others. There's nothing more we can do, we'd never make it in time to help them."

The girl was right and Adora took a deep breath to calm down some more. That was really all she could to right now if she wanted to do anything.

They had done their part, shutting down the Heart. Hopefully it would help their friends. Hopefully they hadn't been too late.

She looked over to the lone mask again. "She's really gone", she mumbled and felt … weird. Shadow Weaver surely deserved it and she doubted she would develop regret anytime soon, but something about her absence was still getting to her.

Catra hummed. "She's always been around to bother us. If not for the murder attempt, I would be tempted to be sad", she grumbled.

A chuckle escaped her. "I don't think she'd want us to be sad. She wished us happiness after all", she replied sarcastically, making the other laugh.

"I'm glad you take her last words so lightly", she said with a shake of her head.

"Well, it's the better way of looking at it, no?"

"Absolutely", the other easily agreed with her. "Better than having more stuff to discuss with Perfuma."

She nodded and let silence settle over them a little. Usually, she wouldn't like that, but right now, she didn't mind there being absolutely nothing. No noise, nothing to do. The worry didn't leave her, and neither did the fatigue.

But Catra remained right. Everything else was out of their hands, so she let the exhaustion get to her and she lay down where she was sitting, staring up into the darkness.

The feline followed her shortly after, also never interrupting the quiet.

If not for the unknown that would await them outside, this was actually kind of nice.

"Light Hope is gone. Shadow Weaver is gone", she whispered at some point — could be minutes or hours after they had moved to lie down. "If we get rid of Prime too, we might actually be able to sleep at night."

"Wouldn't that be nice?"

Chapter End Notes

> Full disclaimer: I'm generally always against the death penatly. I don't think that's a decision someone gets to make for any random person, no matter their crime.
> That being said, Shadow Weaver is a fictional character, and I am allowed to fictionally kill her because she is a terrible person and I hate her :)
> Also also, I am just as allowed to portray Catra and Adora in a mostly good light for their actions because they were hurt by Shadow Weaver and I love them :)
>
> Only two chapters to go to resolve everything whoo! Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 37: The Heart - Part 3

Chapter Notes

Second to last chapter!!

There's again a bit of violence in here, but nothing graphic. And another "warning", this entire thing is Glimmer's POV... It wasn't supposed to be, but then I realized I had to resolve something from ages ago, so it got a bit longer...

Anyway, have fun <33

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer wasn't able to be aware of most things happening around her anymore, not with her energy completely drained and the pain robbing her senses.

All she knew was that Catra's and Adora's old squad were valiant protectors around her, and that at some point, Bow's team had joined them, which was nice considering that her group, as strong as they were, were steadily losing ground.

That made sense, she supposed. Before, they had been able to move around, evade, find better angles to attack, but now they were stuck in a purely defensive position which limited them greatly.

"You okay?", Bow asked then, using the short moment of his team giving them a little advantage to check in on her.

She didn't really have the capacity to form sentences though, so all that came out of her mouth was an unintelligible grumble of pain.

"They can't take much longer", he tried to soothe her, though she doubted it.

At this point, she wasn't all too hopeful anymore. The Heart was surely close to being fired, and no one could save them then. She couldn't and wouldn't tell Bow that, though. His optimism was one of his best qualities and she didn't want to take that from him.

"We're trying to keep everyone safe as long as it takes, just … hold on", he added then, since she didn't give an answer, and joined the others again.

Glimmer wasn't entirely sure what that meant, but she assumed that Bow's group must not be the only one to come to a princess' rescue. There were plenty of non-magic fighters that should be unaffected by the Heart, but she wondered if it would be enough — if her brain still served her correctly, half their force was at least severely weakened.

She hated this. They had been doing so well, why did this have to go so wrong? And why was it still not over?

They knew Entrapta hadn't been fully done with the virus yet, and she has had a feeling that Adora and Catra would face some issues on their way to the Heart, but the fight had been going on for a while already and she had kind of hoped that they'd be faster. At least one of them.

Glimmer trusted them, all of them — they were competent and determined — but if they had run into troubles that delayed them this much, then it really didn't look great for any of them anymore.

And yet, she found herself wishing for a happy ending. "Come on", she thought. "I know you can do it."

Maybe some force of the universe had heard her, or this was just a well timed coincidence, but in that exact moment she could feel the pain ease from her. And not just that, she felt charged, super-charged even. She hadn't felt this energized in … ever.

A bit confused, not quite sure what to think, she sat up and saw the weird symbols on her body vanish. Looking around, she also

saw the clouds of magic that had been channeled into Adora's old sword disappear. Along with that came sighs of relief and exclamations of surprise from all around her.

And as if to confirm, the machine in the battlefield's center lost its light and seemingly its functionality.

They finally shut down the Heart — she wanted to scream with joy, but thought of something better.

With her energy levels so elevated, she teleported away and punched the first clone she could find.

In the midst of confusion among them all, that was the only sign needed to get a proper fight started again. And with her powers at a new high, she did not hold back in using her teleportation to her advantage.

This time, it was on the magic users to protect those who had defended them until now.

Not all of them seemed happy about that, and she could see her own group looking rather annoyed at being ushered back by Bow, even though they were clearly exhausted.

She decided to go over real quick.

"Glimmer!" Bow had engulfed her in a hug before she had even fully materialized. "I'm so glad you're okay."

"Uh, weren't you the one saying they would make it?", she pointed out, with her face squished between his arms.

He let go with an awkward chuckle. "To be fair, they were cutting it pretty close", he mumbled. "Of course I believed in them, but I was getting worried there a bit. And you were in so much pain!"

"But I'm fine now. More than fine", she tried to reassure him. "All of us are, by the looks of it, so … I just wanted to make sure you can get some rest."

Lonnie cleared her throat then. "I appreciate the offer, princess. But-"

"No buts", she interrupted right away. "A little break is the least I can do for you after you have protected me."

The girl clearly wanted to say something, but got interrupted again by a grumble from Rogelio after which she only sighed. "Only a few minutes. You won't stop me", she relented then.

"Wouldn't dare to try", she replied honestly and threw herself back into the fray, which had thinned out a bit.

With their magical power boost, and the clones' small delay of confusion, they had managed to knock out quite a few of them already. And Netossa had a lot more imprisoned in one of her nets.

There were still plenty left, though. Not to mention all the bots.

Just as predicted, even with increased power, they still had to rely on Entrapta to deal the final blow. But until then, they would continue their mission to distract them.

Especially when it was so fun now!

And she knew she wasn't the only one thinking that, she could see the others being just as energized and even grinning sometimes as they beat up the clones.

She also noticed them be a bit less attentive, which she understood — their increase in power made her unfocused too, the boost in energy getting to her head. So, she tried to keep an eye on the spire, reminding herself that her mission was to protect Entrapta, who was hopefully okay.

Having been incapacitated for a while, and everyone working more defensively, she had no idea if any clone or bot might have taken the opportunity to retake their position inside the spire.

But she would keep an eye on it now, so that it wouldn't happen, and hope that it hadn't happened yet.

Though it seemed she hadn't needed to worry too much as only a few minutes later, the spire lost its lights too, and the bots and a few clones collapsed in front of them while the rest just looked around as if lost.

Glimmer, and everyone else, just stopped, observing what was happening before slowly coming to the realization that this must mean the hivemind was shut down.

She teleported over to Bow again, since he knew more about tech. "Do you think Entrapta did it?", she asked, still keeping an eye on their enemies.

"It looks like it", she replied hesitantly. "I don't know what else could have happened."

"Does that mean we're safe?", Kyle chimed in excitedly.

But she and Bow only shared a short look. "Not quite", he answered then. "We stopped Prime, but now we need to deal with him. But if everything went well, he should be pretty powerless now", he added to console the other boy a little.

It did seem to help at least as he relaxed a bit and turned to his friends to spread some of his good mood.

Meanwhile, Glimmer dragged Bow a few steps away from the group. "We should probably talk to the others about what to do now."

He only nodded and she teleported them into the small circle that had already formed around her parents, who were on her within a second.

"Glimmer!", her mom cried out and almost crushed her in a hug. It didn't help when her dad and aunt decided to participate. Eventually they let go, though. "Are you alright? When the Heart-"

"I'm fine", she said quickly before the woman started crying. "Are you?"

Her mother calmed down a little and smiled. "Of course I am. Thanks to Adora and Catra."

She raised her eyebrows. "Are you saying you're grateful for their plan?", she tried to clarify because after all the discussions and disagreements, it would be quite the admission.

"I'm not saying that I think murdering someone against their will was good", her mom answered sternly. "But … am I glad we have been prepared."

"And", her dad felt the need to add. "We can also be glad it wasn't one of the good people being sacrificed." He received a small glare for that. "You know everyone would have missed Adora a lot more than they will ever miss Shadow Weaver."

A sigh. "I am willing to accept this as it is, but let's not discuss this anymore."

Glimmer could get behind that. Don't get her wrong, after everything that she had learned about the evil sorceress, she was more than happy to have her gone, especially when it meant that two of her closest friends didn't have to die. But she did understand the moral issues with this decision, had been against it too back when they had taken her prisoner and Catra had been ready to tear her apart.

It was all a bit complicated, and for the sake of everyone she was ready to put this to rest.

They had more important things to talk about anyway.

And as if on cue, Entrapta joined them outside. "You're still alive! Good!", she greeted loudly and went over to their little group, Hordak slowly trailing after her. "I can confirm that I have successfully destroyed the hivemind. Permanently. It self imploded."

"What?", Bow mumbled, seemingly a bit shocked by the revelation. Everyone else was just confused.

The woman ignored them, though. "Are Catra and Adora not back yet?", she asked instead, looking around. "I kinda need their opinion on something."

"Uh, no", Glimmer replied. "They definitely shut down the Heart, but if it took this long to get there, they might still need a while to get back. Why? What do you need?"

Entrapta looked up at her with a slightly skeptical look. "I'd rather wait", she settled on eventually.

Now she was starting to feel offended. "Why? What's wrong with me?"

"I'm going to assume that you do not want an analysis on your personality", the other mumbled a bit unsure. "And I guess theoretically you're not wrong for it, I just value *their* input more."

Definitely offended. But before she could do or say something to that, Bow luckily stepped in.

"Well, Catra and Adora will not be here for a while. Can you really wait that long?", he asked making the other think about it. "We're friends, I'm sure we can give you an opinion just as well."

Entrapta hummed contemplatively. "Alright, it'll be another experiment", she said with a shrug then. "So, Hordak and I were thinking that we could rehabilitate the clones."

"What?", Glimmer almost shrieked. "These things tried to kill us!", she pointed out.

The woman did not look impressed. "They were just given orders. Like the Horde soldiers were giving orders. To be completely fair, those were still able to make proper decisions, but they were heavily manipulated which comes down to about the same thing. Are we planning on punishing them too?"

She stuttered, not entire sure. They hadn't really planned on punishing anyone yet, and it would pose too many problems — like who actually had fault, and what about Adora, Catra, and Scorpia who had defected, as well as the fact that most soldiers that were with them right now were probably the most innocent and only a small portion of the entire original Horde, as well as Hordak who had helped them so much that they could hardly punish him now, right? Not to mention the time travel issue.

"Furthermore", Entrapta didn't give her a chance to actually process anything. "Other than the Horde soldiers, the clones have no idea how to survive. We broke them, abruptly cutting them off from the only life they have ever known. Leaving them to fend for themselves would with 97% probability result in their deaths."

"But-", she tried to get a word in, but the other clearly wasn't done yet.

"Not to mention that they are by all means innocent." That was an interesting statement. "Since they had no capability to form their own thoughts, and therefore make decisions, they should not be held accountable. Instead, we should teach them how to properly fit into this world and make sure they become good people. They are essentially babies, emotionally speaking. Would you punish a baby?"

What was she even supposed to say at this point? "Fine", she sighed.

"Glimmer", her mother carefully interjected. "Maybe we should discuss this with everyone, get a few more opinions in."

She only shook her head. "Entrapta's right, though. If we start to punish people, we really run into a lot of issues as to who deserves what, and then we'd also have to punish our own friends and people", she pointed out. "Many did bad things during the war with either Horde."

Her mom was hesitant with her reply, clearly thinking it through. It was clear that some of Catra's words were still bothering her and she tried to not shut her down outright, but she was still a very careful person.

"Of course, not everyone had much of a choice", she eventually answered with a look to Entrapta, referencing her words on the matter. "And some things will be more complicated than others, but there are people who have undeniably done very bad things. I know I have just said to let it be, but we have killed Shadow Weaver as a punishment for her crimes. It feels wrong to let everyone else go without any repercussions."

That was fair, they couldn't just let everyone get a pass without question. But she still didn't feel all too comfortable with punishing people who have already more than made up for their crimes. "I think that everyone who has voluntarily helped us to defeat Prime should be let go. They have risked their lives, I think that's enough", she tried to compromise then. "And everyone else who has fought with the Horde can still be trialed. If we find them."

A sigh. "Alright. Just … what about Hordak?", her mom asked awkwardly considering the guy was standing right beside them.

"I will remain in Entrapta's care, helping rehabilitate my brothers", he surprisingly answered for them. "I will not leave Dryl until you deem it safe."

"It also won't be possible without a map", Entrapta helpfully added. "That goes for all the clones too, so you really don't have to worry."

Glimmer thought that was good enough. She still wasn't a big fan of Hordak, or the idea to keep the clones around, but she had to admit that the former warlord had been helpful and has already portrayed some improvements in personality thanks to the scientist, so … she could live with that arrangement.

Her mother still didn't look fully convinced. "That … sounds like a plan", she slowly forced out. "I would like to discuss that with the entire Princess Alliance though, if you don't mind."

"Of course", she agreed easily. "Naturally, everyone has to agree. Or at least most of them."

She shared a smile with her mom, which had been rare ever since she had joined the war. But she was really happy to have finally found some middle ground with her. And all it took was some yelling from Catra.

Bow cleared his throat then. "That still leaves Prime", he reminded them. "I doubt rehabilitation will do much for him."

"I agree", her dad chimed in again then. "If no one else, he definitely deserves punishment. Not just for what he put us through, but also what he has seemingly done to other planets as well."

They could all agree on that. As terrible as Hordak had been, next to Prime he really didn't appear that bad anymore, especially now that he was so much calmer.

"Well, the first thing would be finding him", she pointed out, looking up to where his ship was. She remembered it was pretty huge and full of maze like structures.

Bow nodded next to her. "We'd need to figure out how to get up there, too", he added. "With all his systems down, and the clones without orders, taking him prisoner shouldn't be too hard. In theory."

"I'm sure I can get something running again. Then I can reverse the beam technology and get you up, if you want", Entrapta decided to cut in again.

Glimmer realized then that she really should have spent more time with the woman — she had known she was smart, but she has

clearly had too little an idea just how much she could do. "Great", she just said. "We'll go up and restrain him then."

It had honestly been more of a question that she directed at Bow, who nodded but his face showed that he was just as overwhelmed as she felt.

"Good, I'll prepare the mechanism!", Entrapta called out at the same time and promptly ran off towards the spire, leaving them all to stand there a bit awkwardly.

"I uh … I'll deal with the clones", Hordak said then, slowly backing away too.

Glimmer sighed. So far, Catra had mostly dealt with those two. Were they always this … erratic? "Let's go", she said, even though she would rather lie down.

"Be careful", her parents said at the same time and she rolled her eyes. "We don't know how much of a threat he still is", her dad then added. "Are you sure you two will be okay?"

"Of course", she replied with confidence. "We're a great team."

"The best", Bow added with a nod and a smile.

Her mom smiled back. "I don't doubt it."

She grabbed Bow's hand then and teleported them over to the spire. The rest they would have to walk though, because she had no idea where Entrapta even was.

While they walked, it was oddly silent. She didn't mind because she could really use some quiet to relax after the day they have had, and she also had some things to worry about. Being quiet was just a bit unusual for them, is all.

Still, her thoughts overwhelmed the weirdness of it all.

Mostly she worried about Catra and Adora who she didn't really know if they were doing fine. Assumedly, they have shut down the Heart, but what had happened down there? When would they be back? Unless she saw them safely in front of her again, she didn't think she could relax.

"They'll be fine", Bow ripped her from her thoughts then and she looked at him in confusion. "Adora and Catra. They'll be fine", he repeated with a knowing smile.

She sighed. "I know. They're a great team too, and they'll protect each other", she mumbled. "I just … have a bad feeling."

He hummed. "I'm worried too. But since they clearly succeeded, I think it's safe to assume that they're alive and … hopefully unharmed."

"See?", she said then. "We don't know."

"No, we don't", he agreed. "Maybe they'll be back by the time we come back down."

She scoffed. "They better be", she grumbled. "If I have to go and search for them, wherever they are, I'll be really angry and I'll let them know."

He laughed. "I'm sure you will", he replied with some odd look that made her face heat up a bit.

It hasn't been a new feeling, being attached to Bow, thinking of him as someone special, but somehow she had been starting to think a bit differently about it all. She blamed Catra and Adora.

They haven't really done anything, but after she had told Catra how their close friendship read a lot like a different type of relationship, she had started to notice … parallels. Her and Bow have by no means been as obviously together as these two, but they did occasionally portray a closeness that she only ever saw in couples. And it had made her think.

Not just that maybe she was in love with Bow, but how embarrassing it was that she had made fun of Catra and Adora for being so oblivious when she was clearly not much better.

She shook her head. Right now, they had to deal with Prime. Maybe in a more calmer moment, she could talk to him about it. That shouldn't ruin their friendship, right?

"I think she's over there", Bow interrupted her musings again.

And now that he mentioned it, she could hear some noises from a room not too far from them.

They walked over and peeked inside where they did find Entrapta frantically moving cables around.

"Almost there!", the woman announced without even looking at them. Some connections behind her released sparks, then the lights started to flicker for a minute until it decided to stay on. But as she stepped back, she looked satisfied. "Should work", she said with a shrug.

"Should?", Glimmer asked, a tinge of skepticism to her voice.

"There's always the potential for failure", Entrapta told her matter-of-factly. "And with the hivemind completely destroyed it's debatable if my makeshift override will have any effect at all. Or the right one."

Before she could find the calmness in her to properly answer this, Bow put a hand on her shoulder and smiled comfortingly at her. "That was probably to be expected", he said and nodded encouragingly.

She sighed. "Fine. Just get us up there", she grumbled.

"Will do!", the scientist exclaimed and pushed some buttons on her machinery that controlled whatever was left of Prime's technology. "Ready?", she then asked.

They both nodded, and the woman seemingly put in the last few details before she quickly ran over and squeezed herself between them. Before Glimmer could even get the idea to ask, a beam of green light encased them and next thing she knew, they were back in Prime's throne room.

She shuddered a bit at the sight, but tried to focus on something else quickly. Like Entrapta.

"So… Why are you here?", she asked, trying not to sound rude, hoping it came across as curious.

Luckily, it didn't seem like the woman took any offense. "You have to get down again", was the entire explanation.

Which somehow made sense. They had no way of communicating with Etheria, and therefore no way to tell anyone when they would need to be brought down again. It was … interesting that the woman, who always seemed to not care about anything but her tech, had more foresight than her or Bow.

She didn't dare to respond to that and instead looked around. At the suspiciously empty throne room. Well, apart from the two confused clones that stared at them in shock.

"Don't worry, I'll take care of them", Entrapta volunteered and went over.

Glimmer meanwhile turned to Bow. "So, also not quite unexpected. Prime must be hiding somewhere. Ideas?"

He thought. "Didn't Hordak say that the ship can only be navigated with the hivemind? That would mean that without it, even Prime wouldn't know his ship anymore. He couldn't have gotten far."

"Even without a map, he can just walk wherever", she pointed out, though.

"True", he agreed. "But would he?"

She only shrugged. None of them really knew the guy enough to know what he would do in case of defeat. Considering that he didn't seem to think he could lose, she doubted even Hordak would know.

Then she thought maybe the clones might have some directions for them, but when she looked over, they just listened confusedly to Entrapta explaining to them that they were kind of adopted by her now. They would clearly not be any help.

"Let's get walking", she simply said then and chose a direction at random. She really hoped that Bow was right and that Prime hid out somewhere close, scared to get lost on his own ship or something.

If only she could teleport them around, but after regaining her strength, she already lost her power again since space hated her. And she wasn't sure teleporting wouldn't get them stuck more either.

"Hold on", he stopped her momentarily as he fished out a miniature arrow out of a pocket.

She could help but snort. "What did you built that for?"

He didn't look impressed. "It's a confetti cannon for small occasions of joy", he told her easily. "But right now, it'll be our guide." He proceeded to press the arrow against the wall of the ship and made a line with it.

"Oh, so we'll find our way back", she realized. "That's really smart."

"Thank you", he replied smugly.

They kept walking then. The arrow scratching a line into the wall made an honestly terrible sound, but she'd rather live with that than getting lost.

As they made their way through the corridors, they found several rooms and within them a lot of clones that they told to follow the marks along the wall to get to the throne room. They didn't seem like they really understood, but they did follow the direction, probably for a lack of other orders.

Though, they didn't find nearly as many clones as she had thought they would — it seemed that the majority of them must already be down on Etheria.

What they didn't find however, was Prime.

Glimmer had no idea how long they have been here already, but it was decidedly too long.

"Maybe we should have gotten backup after all", she mumbled after a while. "More people to search this stupid place."

"I don't know", Bow replied though. "This is kind of relaxing. The atmosphere is admittedly a bit creepy, but still. After the last few days and weeks, it's nice to just … stroll a bit."

"I'd prefer a stroll through the woods", she said honestly.

He sighed. "I know, me too. I'd prefer a lot of places over this. I'd even rather brave the Crimson Waste again", he clarified. "What I was trying to say is … that I like just having a moment without anyone attacking us, or having to plan something. Just us. Together."

"Oh." She really didn't expect to have this conversation here. Or for him to start it. Possibly. It kind of sounded like it. "It is nice, yeah. We've been crammed in with everyone lately, it was really hard to just hang out alone."

"Exactly", he exclaimed happily. "I mean, I like the others, and you know I love our Best Friend Squad, but sometimes … I kinda miss the times when it was just us."

She hummed. "Yeah, me too." And Catra had called her crazy for it. Okay, to be fair, she had been freaking out a lot during Princess Prom and may have dramatized everything just a little, leading to Catra telling her to relax and to take it down a notch, but still. Glimmer wasn't crazy and Bow apparently didn't feel all that differently, so … hah!

"Really?", he asked, seeming a bit surprised.

"Yeah! I was even jealous of the others", she blurted out since her brain had already been on the topic, and she has never wanted to see Prime more.

He furrowed his brows as she felt her face heat up. "Why were you jealous?", he then asked, sounding honestly confused.

She knew that he would probably accept it if she tried to change the topic because he was Bow, sweet and supportive and always so understanding. But she didn't want to do that. Well, she did, very much actually, but it didn't feel fair and after all this time, she should probably take her own advice and talk about it.

"Well… I just-" She sighed. Why was this so hard? "Before this entire drama, we met so many people and you made friends so quickly, I was… I might have been a bit nervous that you'd, you know? Find someone better and leave me?" Why did she make it sound like a question?

"Why would you think that?", he asked, his voice taking on a sad tilt. "I would never leave you."

"I know", she groaned. "I know it was stupid. And I don't know why. Maybe because it felt like you got along better with the others, like you had more in common with them. And they are so much more interesting than me, I mean… What do I do? I have to recharge, I can glitter. I have been practically completely useless ever since Prime showed up."

"That's not true", he argued. "You stepped in when Catra had a mental breakdown after Adora got abducted, and even after she

became a workaholic, you still tried to help out wherever and you did great!"

"But I couldn't fight", she pointed out. "You and the others went out almost every other hour, while I was stuck at camp learning the most basic sorcery so I could come with you *occasionally*", she grumbled. "And that's not the point. I… I'm not as cool as Sea Hawk, or as smart as Entrapta, or as strong as Adora, or as quick as Catra."

"No", he agreed softly. "But I haven't met anyone who's as inspiring as you."

She didn't know what to say to that, she could only blink as she tried to understand what that meant.

Bow seemed to know what was going on because he laughed a bit before getting into an explanation. "I started learning archery so I could fight in the Rebellion, but *you* encouraged me to actually got through with it. You trained with me and you inspired me to not give up. You got the alliance back together. You got Catra to open up and managed to integrate her into the group. Not to mention just now! Do you think *Catra* would hand the command to you if she didn't believe in you? Do you think a bunch of Horde soldiers would protect you that fiercely if they didn't care about you at least a bit?"

"Okay, they were Adora's and Catra's old squad, they have to care", she defended sheepishly, not having been ready to hear all of this.

He gave her a funny look. "No, I don't think so. I think they saw that you can be responsible and trusted, and decided to respect that."

She rolled her eyes. "Agree to disagree then."

A laugh burst out of him. "Alright, but you have to agree that you're amazing", he then said, though she wasn't sure she could

do that. "And … you were my first friend too. I'm not ever going to leave you."

"Are you sure?", she had to ask because clearly she was still a bit insecure.

"Of course", he said with enough confidence to convince a rock. "Would you?", he then challenged.

"No!", she replied quickly.

"See?", he laughed. "Nothing to worry about."

That wasn't quite right. There was still one thing to worry about. "I couldn't just leave the person I love anyway", she mumbled, but in the silence of the hallway — safe for Bow's arrow carving a line into the wall — she could have just as well screamed.

Bow stopped, looking at her in shock for a long agonizing second before he smiled and took her hand. "I love you too."

Some part of her hadn't doubted it, but another — probably the same that had been responsible for her freakout at Princess Prom — was greatly relieved. And her bright smile was probably displaying that very obviously.

Bow was right, apparently. Even in the creepiest place imaginable, and at possibly the worst time, they could still manage to have a nice moment. And even if they had to focus on their task again, they could still hold hands and spend their time together.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you could enjoy this many word without our favorite lesbians in it xD

Last chapter will be uploaded in a few days and I'll probably write a cheesy note for it (just warning you now xD)
Until then, stay hydrated <333

Chapter 38: The Heart - Part 4

Chapter Notes

This is it! The last chapter!
I honestly can't believe it, but I'll spare you the sappiness for the end note xD

For now, minor warning for the short description about Prime's face
And apart from that, I hope you enjoy <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After an eternity, they came by the destroyed part of the ship that they had left behind only a few days ago. It didn't feel like days, with their research, mission, more discussions and now this entire disaster, it felt like it had been weeks ago.

Just like it felt like they had already been here for hours.

Glimmer stopped them with a groan. "New plan. We go back, get more people and keep searching", she grumbled. Honestly, she should have expected this, but they have been too worried about Prime to even think about his ship.

"Okay", Bow replied hesitantly and she looked at him expectantly — clearly he had something to say. He sighed. "Look, we can always go back and ask for help, it's not like Prime can go anywhere…"

"But?", she prompted.

"But I think we shouldn't give up this quickly", he finished. "We barely walked as far as we had to last time. I say we give it a few more minutes."

"Really?", she asked in disbelief. "I'm pretty sure we've been here for forever already."

He chuckled. "Yeah, I get it. That's what it felt like when I was stuck in Entrapta's castle, but trust me, the lack of orientation just messes with you."

"Fine", she relented with a groan and a roll of her eyes which he entirely ignored. "But only a few more minutes."

So, they kept walking. She had no idea when a few minutes would be over but considering how long it had felt up until now, it would probably take too long for her liking. She was clearly too impatient for mazes.

But interestingly, it didn't take long for them to hear something odd, maybe a sign they were on the right path. There were some crashing sounds, something shattered, and between the destruction were grunts of exertion — like someone was taking the ship apart.

Instinctively, Bow readied his bow, though without any arrows he could only use it to hit people. And Glimmer, for a lack of powers and her staff, picked up some stone from the debris for the same purpose. It wasn't ideal, but still better than to be completely unarmed.

As they came closer, the more tense they got and when they reached the room that held the source of the noise, they stopped shortly. Carefully they peeked inside. It looked like it must be the server room, seemingly the only thing in this chaos they had actually bothered repairing, though that effort could definitely be called wasted as Prime currently redid all the damage that Entrapta had done just days prior.

She shared a look with Bow, trying to convey her question with her eyes. "What do we do?"

Interrupting felt like a terrible idea, but waiting for him to notice them also didn't sound great. She could just throw her stone at him from a safe distance and hope it would knock him out. It could just as well kill him though, so probably also not the best

since their job was to just take him prisoner. For now. Maybe it wouldn't matter because they would execute him anyway.

Bow seemed just as unsure as he stared at Prime for a while with a contemplative expression. Eventually he shrugged apologetically.

Glimmer sighed. She should probably play it safe, even if she would rather not.

Keeping their distance between each other, she opted for interrupting after all by awkwardly clearing her throat.

He must have heard her because he stopped moving, though he didn't do much else, leaving her to try to come up with something else. But after a minute or so he composed himself, stood up straight and smoothed his hair back into place before he turned to face them.

Glimmer almost threw up then. She knew that Catra had done some damage in her pain-delirious attempt to kill him, but it was still shocking, to say the least, that his face looked like it had half fallen off with the rest covered in some sort of infection. That was barely even a face anymore at all.

Shortly taking her attention off him to look at Bow's reaction, she could see the disgust clearly written all over him as well.

Still, Prime held himself with the confidence of a victorious conquerer. "Princess", he greeted, also sounding like one. "Came to finish me off?"

"No", she mumbled, for some reason feeling a bit of pity for this guy. Just enough to leave out the 'sadly' in her answer. "For now, we'll take you into custody. The Princess Alliance will determine you fate later, but I doubt it'll be death." She once again left out that the chance was still there. Small, but there.

Either that wasn't to his satisfaction or their persistently disgusted expressions were annoying him, either way he frowned angrily and all but growled his response. "You may have humiliated me,

but Prime shall rise again. So it has been and so it always shall be."

And just like that, any amount of pity for him vanished. She just sighed. "Let's get this over with. It's not like you have much of a choice but to comply", she told him lazily. He might be pretty strong on his own, but in his current state, she was sure they could still overwhelm him.

Sadly, he wasn't done yet. And she hasn't had much hope for him to play along anyway. "I have not built an empire to be defeated by children", he spat and visibly tightened his grip on the pipe he had used to demolish his own server. "I am an emperor. I am-"

Glimmer couldn't do this anymore. Throwing her earlier concerns out the window, she threw her stone at the guy before he could get any ideas about attacking them.

It did not kill him, but it did enough damage to shut him up and make him lose his balance.

She then quickly grabbed Bow's bow and went over to use the moment of his confusion to hit him primarily in the neck, but since he didn't seem to have the same weird augmentation as his clones, she also hit him a lot in the head until he passed out.

"Glimmer!", Bow chastised once she was done, looking at her like he had honestly expected her to stay diplomatic here.

"What?", she shot back. "I have had enough of him talking, and he wasn't going to come with us voluntarily."

He sighed. "I know, but did you have to give him a concussion?"

"He'll be fine", she replied with a roll of her eyes. "And if he won't be then he deserved it."

Bow only shook his head, probably because he couldn't really disagree with her but still didn't want to approve of her violent methods. And he did help her drag him back to Entrapta. She

even relented to grabbing him by the arms instead of the legs to not damage his head any further.

The walk was mostly silent, as they had to focus on following the marks, as well as on Prime who could wake up at any moment. And they were both still exhausted, so they didn't have much breath for conversations left anyway.

Ironically, they were also quicker this time. Maybe Bow was right that her worries and lack of orientation made it feel much longer than it actually was.

When they reached the throne room again, they were greeted by the sight of a few dozen clones getting a crash course by Entrapta about what had happened and what would happen now.

It seemed that they already understood that Prime had been defeated and maybe even that he was a terrible person, because as Glimmer and Bow made their way inside and they were spotted, the clones all became a bit uncomfortable with their former leader's presence.

Luckily, Entrapta made quick work with the teleport beam and send them all down in batches.

Once they were back on Etheria, the woman took the new clones over to where Hordak was babysitting the rest, while Glimmer used her returned powers to safe her and Bow the stress, and teleported them and Prime over to the group of princesses, Horde soldiers and sorcerers.

They all made disgusted and concerned faces when they looked over and saw Prime's face. Well, except one.

"Badass", Frosta concluded, just like she had in that one meeting, and nodded approvingly.

It wasn't like everyone disagreed with that, and many clearly thought it was deserved, but most were still incredibly disgusted

by it, which was absolutely fair in Glimmer's opinion who avoided looking at him if possible.

Her mom awkwardly cleared her throat, also tearing her eyes away from Prime to collect herself a little and keep what little food she had eaten inside where it belonged. "Now that that's taken care of, I say we secure everything and rest before we make any further decisions. With the war finally done, there is a lot to discuss and I don't think anyone still has the energy for that."

Everyone agreed with that, some verbally, some could barely manage to nod. They really needed to take a break.

Glimmer didn't really volunteer to 'secure' anything, which at least no one seemed to be mad about. She sat herself on a rock and sighed as the pressure left her body. Bow soon joined her and she didn't hesitate to lean into him.

They watched her dad put a magical barrier around Prime, placing him a bit away from them. She then turned her attention to Entrapta and Hordak explain camping to the clones, while the others checked their surroundings and started to one by one sit down and relax a little.

She couldn't wait to get back to camp, but even if they weren't discussing anything anymore, they still had some things to take care of. And though most weren't able to help much, no one wanted to leave anybody alone right now.

And Catra and Adora were also still missing.

Before she knew her friends were safe, she would not be able to sleep anyway.

***

Adora had never liked the quiet. Growing up in the Fright Zone, she always had noise around her and she had gotten used to it to the point where silence made her incredibly anxious. That had been true her entire life, but especially since she had moved to Brightmoon. It was unsettling how little noise there was.

And yet, as she found herself in the darkness of the Heart's chamber, cuddled close with Catra, deep underground with no sounds but their own breathing, she felt … relaxed.

She couldn't quite explain it, especially since she had no idea how her friends were fairing, but there was something soothing about the knowledge that the Heart was gone, along with Shadow Weaver, and that she was holding her girlfriend safely in her arms.

But still, as her fatigue slowly left her, and her worries marinated in her brain, she felt the urge to move anyway, even if it was much later than usual.

"Catra?", she broke the silence eventually. She had no clue how long they had actually been down here.

The girl only hummed in response.

"I want to go home", she said, feeling a wave of sadness crash over her as she remembered that it has been weeks if not months since she had actually been in Brightmoon.

Catra then carefully extracted herself out of her position and sat up. With her own light still present, Adora could see the solemn expression on the girl's face as she remained silent.

She sat up too then, gently took the other's hand and tried to think of something else to say, but it seemed that she didn't need to worry so much.

"If this is really over", Catra said, clearly in thought. "What are we going to do now?"

That was a good question, but not a hard one. "Whatever you want", she replied with a smile.

The other turned to look at her skeptically. "Whatever *I* want?"

"It's about time, don't you think?" The girl had always had to accept what other people decided for her, including Adora, and something told her than even in her time of power in the Horde, she hadn't been as free as she liked to make it seem.

"What about what you want?", Catra then asked because of course she did.

She sighed. "We can deal with that after we're done with you", she said easily and didn't dare look at the other's face, though she could imagine it — her eyebrows mockingly raised, her eyes rolled with exasperation.

"How about…", the girl started, shifting a bit closer and forcing her to look at her. "We do one thing I want and then one thing you want?", she suggested, though Adora doubted she had any actual say in that.

Especially when Catra cut her off with a kiss, and how was she supposed to argue with that anyway?

"Let's get out of here", the feline all but purred when they separated, and got up, so naturally she followed suit.

They let the silence return as they walked, mostly because Catra was still very tired since she had not received a power boost like Adora. That was fine, and she would offer to carry the girl if she wasn't so sure she would get hissed at.

As it was, they walked side by side, and it felt as dreadful and creepy as it had when they first started wandering through here.

She grabbed Catra's hand. This place would probably always feel a bit disturbing to her, knowing what it was built to do even if it couldn't do it anymore. Knowing how she had hoped that she

would find help here, how she had thought she has had it, how Light Hope had lied to her the entire time.

"I'd be happy to never come back here again", she mumbled eventually, feeling the need to voice her thoughts a little.

The other squeezed her hand in assurance. "You don't have to", she said softly, and while Adora had known that, it was still soothing to hear it from someone else.

Enough so that she was able to walk the rest of the way with a much more relaxed mind. And soon enough they entered the main hall again.

It remained eerily empty and quiet, not that she had expected Light Hope to miraculously show up and say goodbye or something, but … thinking about it, they had never actually said goodbye — in this time, they had never actually met.

So, she slowly came to a stop in the empty place and took one last look around. "Goodbye", she whispered to absolutely no one, but she still hoped it would reach her.

Then she turned back to Catra, who gently tugged her along to finally get outside.

Adora knew she had the option to stay a bit longer if she wanted, but honestly? Despite it being an odd feeling, knowing that she would never have to come back here, she was mostly happy about it.

Presented with the exit, she excitedly let She-Ra slip away, ready to hopefully see their friends again, but as they stepped into the daylight, she had to stop again to process.

The Whispering Woods always had held a lot of magic, moving with a mind of its own, but now it felt more alive than the person standing right next to her. She could feel it pulse and move and breathe — it was honestly a little overwhelming. It was brighter, too, somehow. More colorful.

"That's one thousand years of magic", Catra mumbled, staring with wide eyes and her mouth slightly open.

"Yeah", was all she could say as she processed the beauty in front of her. Adora wondered then if it had looked like this in Mara's time. If it had been so alive and intense, or if that was just the result of the magic returning all at once.

Either way, she somehow knew this was a good thing. She would have to get used to everything being so much now, but she still had to smile seeing that everything the First Ones had stolen was now returned.

And it was so pretty and mesmerizing. So much so that she had to physically shake herself out of her staring. "We should check on the others", she remembered which also seemed to rip Catra out of her trance.

Getting back to the camp was as fast as they could make it with them continuously getting distracted by how the woods looked like now, but when they did make it they found it lacking their friends.

That was nothing to be too worried about. Maybe the others were still busy, they didn't have to be still fighting necessarily, but none of them had really discussed what to do should they actually defeat Prime.

So, they kept making their way through the woods, in the vague direction that the remaining refugees pointed them to. And once they spotted the spire, it was really easy to find the battlefield.

Or the former one as she noticed with relief.

The fighting had clearly ceased a while ago and most of the people had slumped tiredly to the ground, with the exception of the queen and king, as well as some former Horde soldiers.

Adora took a quick look around, and while she had not counted them all before they left, she still felt rather confident that

everyone was still here and alive.

Looking over to Catra, she saw the girl physically relax at the sight. It had really bothered her that she couldn't make a plan for them, that she had absolutely no idea what their chances had been.

This time it was her, who squeezed the other's hand in assurance. She had honestly not spared many thoughts to what the girl might be going through, but she had known that giving up control hadn't been easy for her. And with as much as she had to soothe Adora throughout their mission, she was happy to do the same for her.

"Catra! Adora!", a high pitched voiced cut through her thoughts then, and she spotted Entrapta waving at them from her place in front of a large group a clones, who listened to whatever Hordak had to tell them, looking mostly confused. Meanwhile the woman skipped over to them excitedly as everyone now noticed them as well. "Good, you're still alive. I wasn't sure you would be."

Adora wanted to respond to that, even though she didn't have any response at the ready, but since the scientist kept going anyway, she decided to ignore that comment.

"I can report that I completely destroyed the hivemind, and the war is officially over. And you destroyed the Heart! I can't wait to study the effects on our planet", she cooed. "But the clones will have to be my priority for now. They will need some time adjusting, but they'll be fine, don't worry. Hordak has been explaining things to them already, like thoughts and emotion and food. That was a big one."

"Wait, wait, wait", she interrupted then. "The clones… are…?" She didn't even know how to finish that sentence. She also didn't want to get into the fact that Hordak of all people was teaching them about feelings.

"We're responsible for them now", the woman told her seriously. "We broke them. We can't just leave them to fend for themselves. And they are innocent. I already got everyone's approval."

"Well, not everyone's", Glimmer's voice came out of nowhere, along with some glitter and Bow. "You two are the last two votes missing, because you took ages to come back. Speaking of, where were you? And what happened? You look worse than I feel."

She just shrugged. "Shadow Weaver gave us some trouble", she made it short. "Sorry we took so long."

"No worries", Bow said then. "I mean, it was pretty difficult having to fight with the Heart active so long, but it's fine. We made it."

Adora winced. "I'm so sorry."

"Seriously, it's fine", Glimmer repeated. "I'm honestly too tired to be mad at you. Anyway, Entrapta has volunteered to rehabilitate the clones in Dryl with Hordak, who will also basically be imprisoned there. Yes or no?"

She looked over to Catra who had been oddly silent about everything, but as she looked more tired with each passing second, that made sense. Honestly, they were lucky she was still awake enough to listen.

"Sure, whatever", she grumbled and shrugged. "Why are you still here?", she then asked Glimmer.

"I'm okay with it too", Adora added quickly before she didn't get the chance anymore, with the conversation drifting off already.

Entrapta squealed and ran away again, probably to tell Hordak, but she honestly didn't pay much attention, instead focusing on what was happening around her.

Glimmer sighed. "We're exhausted for one, then the sorcerers are still taking care of everyone's injuries as well as they can, at least enough to transport people as painlessly as possible. And we had

to discuss things since Entrapta's idea kinda needed a more immediate decision. Oh, Bow and I also got Prime down and we still don't quite know what to do with him", she summarized.

"We're also together now!", the boy added excitedly, pointing between him and his friend.

Adora didn't manage much more than to blink. She has had to process too much today for the most predictable development to really sink in.

"I expected you to take longer", Catra responded then, nodding somewhat impressed.

Glimmer scoffed. "Not everyone can be as slow as you two", she grumbled and crossed her arms. "But back to the question of Prime, what do we do with him? I mean, rehabilitation is out of the question."

"Agreed", Adora mumbled, seriously trying to keep up. "What have you done with him already?"

"We imprisoned him", Bow replied and nodded towards a slightly glowing magical prison that stood a good bit away from everyone. Probably smart.

"We'll have to wait and see how much of a threat he'll still be", she said then, not taking her eyes off the glow in the distance. The thought of keeping Prime around was not exactly exciting her, and they were probably well within their rights to just kill him, but … she also didn't want murder to become a habit.

She looked over to Catra again, who only shrugged when she noticed, though as stiff and more awake as she was at the topic, she wasn't all to thrilled about it either.

Well, maybe she could try something. "Be right back", she told them and started to walk in his direction.

Naturally, she could hear Catra follow her and when she looked back, ready to tell the girl that she would be fine, she was unsurprisingly interrupted. "I'm not leaving you alone with him", she other told her, leaving no room for discussions.

Adora only smiled — she had done the same thing earlier after all. "I know", she replied, waiting for the other to catch up.

"Then don't run off, idiot", she grumbled and they kept making their way over.

She got a bit nervous as they got closer, but she reminded herself that he could not do anything anymore. He was behind a barrier, with no army and no power.

And a disturbing face as she noticed when they were right in front of him. Whatever fear she has had subsided to make room for disgust. Despite knowing that Catra had attacked him, she still hadn't quite expected it to become part of her future nightmares.

"She-Ra", he greeted with disdain. "Have you come to boast your victory?", he mocked.

"Not exactly", she replied, somehow managing to calm down again. That face had admittedly thrown her off a bit.

That seemed to offend him, though. Or maybe it was her reaction to his injury that made him angry. Who knew with this guy? "You cannot hold me forever", he spat. "It is my destiny to remake the universe in my image!"

Adora sighed. This was just sad. "No", she said more firmly then, focusing on what she had wanted to do. She took a step forward and saw how Catra quickly got her whip ready, if needed. "No more destinies. I don't want to hear about fate and purpose ever again." She summoned her sword and She-Ra along with it. He looked almost scared, nervous definitely. "You're lucky we believe in second chances."

She didn't wait for a response before she kneeled down, broke through the barrier with one hand to put on his cheek, swallowing her disgust once more, and channeled her powers.

There was only little she could do about the face, but at the very least she could fight off the infection. More importantly though, she tried to reach what may or may not be clouding his mind. Maybe there was nothing to fix there, but maybe she could grant him, and by extension everyone, a bit of peace.

When she pulled away, he slumped to the ground for a moment and she got a bit worried, but he quickly lifted himself up again. "How dare you?", he grumbled weakly. "What did you do?"

"Just giving you a chance", she answered. "You'll probably still spend some time locked away, but someday you might be able to start again. You should want to do that."

That was all she had meant to do and she did not feel like being around the guy any longer. So, she let She-Ra fall away — for hopefully the last time for a while — and turned around to Catra, who stared at her with an odd look, but she too fled Prime's presence with eagerness, so she only really got to ask when they were already halfway back to their friends again.

"What?", she sighed, really not sure what the feline was thinking.

"I just can't believe that after everything, you seriously healed him", the other mumbled like she was trying to solve a difficult puzzle.

"I know, but I didn't do it for him", she told the girl. "I was trying to maybe help him get rid of his delusions. Make him less work for us." It was a hope that most likely wouldn't come true, regardless of how many times she would try to get the evil out of him, but maybe he would prove her wrong.

It at least did seem to clear some things up for her friend. "Still… Sometimes you can be too much of a good person", she

grumbled, a bit of the usual annoyance coming through. "I just hope he really won't make more problems."

"If he does, we can still kill him", she replied sarcastically. She kind of meant it, nevertheless she would like to avoid it.

Catra chuckled a little. "Nevermind, you are actually extremely murderous", she then said, making Adora laugh in turn.

"Not more than you", she pointed out, bumping the other's shoulder and making her roll her eyes.

They were close to their friends again, and now that they weren't standing on the edge of the field anymore, everyone ran over to make sure they were okay, with some of them finding the energy to hug them, though Adora took the brunt of most of it since Catra would rather scratch someone in her current state than endure it.

Even Glimmer and Bow placed themselves protectively in front of the girl, knowing that physical touch wasn't really her thing.

Only Scorpia managed to get to the girl, who could not hold back the shortest hug that Adora had ever seen, but it did keep the feline from murdering the woman.

Eventually the queen made it over to them too, who awkwardly stood before Catra, who just as awkwardly shifted in the tense atmosphere.

"You were right", the woman eventually bit out, leaving the girl to stare in shock. "I did not know what to do and I let you carry the burden that I was supposed to shoulder. I guess at some point that started to bother me and I tried to reestablish myself in a place where I had never belonged", she said solemnly. "I have learned to trust your judgment in spite of what you have revealed to us about your past and I should have been mature enough to let you keep doing what you do best. Save us", she said with greatest sincerity. But the biggest shock were the words that followed. "I am sorry."

Catra only let out a long "uh" at first, clearly a bit stunned to hear that, and from a powerful adult no less. Not that Adora would be faring much better because she too didn't know what to say or think right now.

"Thanks?", the girl settled on eventually. "I shouldn't have yelled at you", she admitted too, though.

But Angella only shook her head. "It seems I needed to hear it. However, I confess that I would appreciate it if you could come to me with your issues next time and we could discuss this privately, with less anger."

"I'm working on it", Catra grumbled honestly. Adora could attest to that, she really did try keeping her anger in check more.

With one last nod, the queen left them alone with their friends again, clearly accepting the words for what they were — an indication of an genuine attempt to be better.

When she was gone, their friend surrounded them again and then they started to enthusiastically tell them all about the battle in great detail while continuously interrupting one another. It was great, but they were all still incredibly tired and the excitement of their reunion soon fizzled out.

She and Catra used that moment to sneak away again, needing another moment of quiet, or at least Adora did.

The walked a bit into the woods again, though not too far as to not worry anyone.

It had gotten dark again, by now, and she stared up at the still starless sky. Somehow, she thinks, she would love to see stars and she was sure she wasn't the only one. Still, she knows they made the right choice in destroying the Heart and stopping Prime.

"It's a nice night", Catra said then, knowingly smirking at her. "Who needs stars anyway?"

She snorted. "Stars would be nice, don't you think?", she asked regardless of her own acceptance of the situation.

The girl looked like she actually thought about it. "I don't really know what that would look like, honestly", she answered eventually. "But yeah, I suppose it would be nice. Not really an option anymore, though."

"It has never been an option", she sighed. "Mara hid us here for a reason." Though, with the First Ones and Prime both gone now, was it really still that dangerous? She shook her head. It didn't matter, they didn't have a way to open a portal anymore anyway.

"I'm sure Entrapta could whip up another portal", Catra pointed out like she could read her mind. "It'll take a while, but maybe… someday."

"Stars, someday." It was a nice thought. "But for now, we should just relax."

The feline downright cackled then. "I wasn't aware you knew how to do that."

Adora pouted a bit. "I was lying in the dark with you earlier, didn't I?" It was a weak argument, and she knew that, but she still made it.

"If you count basically passing out as relaxing, then sure", the girl naturally noticed that flaw.

"Like you're any better", she grumbled.

"Never said I was", Catra replied with a smug grin.

She sighed. "Well … we have time to learn it now", she then said. "I mean, we have to discuss some things, and repair and rebuild, but apart from that I doubt there will be anything happening for a while."

"Sounds dreadful", the other said, but she couldn't completely hide the smile, revealing that she was just as happy about some time off in peace.

Adora moved to sit down then, pulling Catra with her who took advantage of the new position to lean into her, cuddling as well as they could. Yeah, she could probably live like this for a little while.

She was so content for once than she didn't even notice the steps approaching behind them.

"Naww, how cute", Glimmer cooed, startling her, but Catra only rolled her eyes and glared at the princess.

"It's wrong to flirt with a taken woman, Sparkles, especially when you have a boyfriend", the girl teased, making the other blush a deep red.

The princess caught herself relatively quickly though, and pettily pushed herself between them, making them all tumble down the little hill they had been sitting on. Well, all except Bow, who had avoided being part of their pile, though he happily threw himself on top of them once they had come to a stop.

They would surely have some bruises in the morning, but Adora couldn't help but laugh anyway.

"So", Glimmer said through some chuckles. "What now?"

Bow gasped. "Victory sleepover!"

"I'm in!", she agreed quickly and then everyone looked over to Catra, who tried and failed to look grumpy.

The girl rolled her eyes. "Fine, but only because I'm too tired to resist."

"Tell yourself that", Glimmer said with a smirk. "We all know you love us."

"I do not", the feline protested.

The next few minutes were spend on that argument, while both Bow and Adora just stared at their unreasonably angry girlfriends adoringly.

Stars would be nice, sure, but Adora was certain that, right now, she had everything she needed to be happy. And one day, far ahead in the future, she will make sure her people get to see stars, but up until then, she would enjoy every second with the people she loved.

Chapter End Notes

So... this is the end...
I'm pretty sure I said at the very beginning that I had written about 170k words, which was true, but now we end at 230k words, which ... yeah that explains why I'm so tired xD

I honestly have a hard time believing that this is done because it almost marks a year since I first started this fic. That is not the longest I have ever worked on one, but it sure is the longest time that I have consistently worked on one. Apart from the usual day to day life, it often felt like all I did was write this story (which I didn't, but feelings are weird). My point is, I love this story. Enough that I have dedicated so much time to it, even when I sometimes felt like I would rather bury myself than sit down and do this, but you know what? It was absolutely worth it!!

And your support has absolutely carried me through all this and every hard scene or any day that I lacked the motivation. You have made me smile and laugh and I am sooooo unbelievably grateful to everyone who has taken the time to read this!
No matter if you have been here since the beginning, or have discovered this somewhere in the middle. Whether you binged it all or left halfway through. Every single person who has left kudos or took the precious time to comment, I

cannot express how much I appreciate you <33
There were points throughout this when I probably wouldn't have finished editing this if not for your lovely words!!

So, before I turn this into another full length novel, let me quickly summerize: Thank you!!! Thank you all so so so much!!! I hope you enjoyed my silly little fanfction even half as much as I enjoyed all you kind words and kudos <33

And now, one last time: Stay hydrated <333

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!